

CAMBRIDGE ENGLISH CLASSICS



George Crabbe

Poems - Volume I of III

Edited by
ADOLPHUS WILLIAM WARD

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CRABBE: POEMS, VOLUME 1 (OF 3) ***

CAMBRIDGE ENGLISH CLASSICS

POEMS
BY
GEORGE CRABBE

In Three Volumes

GEORGE CRABBE

Born, 1754

Died, 1832

GEORGE CRABBE

POEMS

EDITED BY

ADOLPHUS WILLIAM WARD,

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Master of Peterhouse



Volume I

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PREFATORY NOTE.

IN the present edition of Crabbe's Poems the general arrangement adopted is that of the chronological order of publication. The poem entitled *Midnight* has been inserted at a conjectural date as belonging to the period of the Juvenile Poems (1772-1780); but all other poems contained in this edition which have hitherto remained unpublished will be printed after the published poems, in the sequence of their production so far as this is ascertainable. With the poems hitherto unpublished I have also been fortunate enough to obtain permission to include in a later volume, among other posthumously printed pieces, the *Two Poetical Epistles* by Crabbe, first published, from a manuscript in the collection of Mr Buxton Forman, in Vol. II of *Literary Anecdotes of the Nineteenth Century* edited by W. Robertson Nicoll and Thomas J. Wise (London, 1896). From the second of these *Epistles* were taken, but not in their original order, the ten lines reproduced in the present volume from George Crabbe the younger's 1834 edition of his father's Poems.

The earliest of the Juvenile Poems here printed are taken from *The Lady's Magazine, or Entertaining Companion for the Fair Sex, appropriated solely to their Use and Amusement*, for the year 1772, printed at London for Robinson and Roberts, 25 Paternoster Row. The first volume of this Magazine seems to have been that for the year 1770, and to have comprised the numbers from August to December inclusive; but the earlier portion of this volume had been previously published in the same year 1770 under the same title by J. Wheble at 20 Paternoster Row, 'by whom letters to the Editor are requested and received.' This then must be the 'Wheble's Magazine for 1772,' of which George Crabbe the younger in the Life prefixed to the 1834 edition of his father's Poems (p. 22) states that he had after long search discovered a copy. The Magazine seems itself to have been a revival of an earlier *Lady's Magazine*, of which portions of the volumes for 1760 and 1761 are extant, and which, according to the title-

page of the volume for 1761, was printed for J. Wilkie at the Bible in St Paul's Churchyard.

But the younger Crabbe's account of his father's verses in 'Wheble's Magazine for 1772' does not tally with the actual contents of the volume for 1772 of *The Lady's Magazine* which has been used for the present edition. It is possible, of course, though there is no evidence to support the supposition, that *The Lady's Magazine* published by Wheble was continued at all events till 1772, parallel to *The Lady's Magazine* published by Robinson and Roberts, with which in 1770 it had been in some measure blended. It is equally possible that the younger Crabbe made some mistake or mistakes. In any case, his statement is, that Wheble's Magazine for 1772 'contains besides the prize poem on Hope,' from which he proceeds to quote the concluding six lines, 'four other pieces, signed "G. C., Woodbridge, Suffolk," "To Mira," "The Atheist reclaimed," "The Bee," and "An Allegorical Fable."' The volume published by Robinson and Roberts contains no pieces corresponding to these, except that in its October number there is printed an *Essay on Hope*, in which the lines cited by the younger Crabbe and reprinted, on his authority, in the present edition, do not appear, but of which the concluding lines seem to imply that it was a copy of verses written in competition for a prize. It cannot however be by Crabbe. For it is signed 'C. C., Rotherhithe, 1772'; and the July number of the same volume contains a piece of verse of some length entitled *The Rotherhithe Beauties* and signed 'C. C., Rotherhithe, July 15,' which is certainly not by Crabbe; and later in the volume follows another piece entitled *Night*, signed 'C. C., Rotherhithe, November 19, 1772,' which likewise cannot be attributed to Crabbe.

On the other hand the 1772 volume of *The Lady's Magazine* contains certain pieces of verse which may without hesitation be assigned to him, and which are accordingly reprinted in the present edition. These are, in the September number, *Solitude* and *A Song*, which bear as a signature the quasi-anagram 'G. EBBARE'; in the October number, the lines *To Emma*, with the quasi-anagram 'G. EBBAAC' and the date 'Suffolk'; and, in the November number, *Despair*, *Cupid*, and a *Song*, signed with the earlier form 'G. EBBARE.' This *Song* is followed by some lines in blank verse *On the Wonders of Creation*, and, further on, by some stanzas *To Friendship*,

likewise signed 'C. C.'; but manifestly neither blank verse nor stanzas are by Crabbe.

Finally, it should be noted that in the October number in the same volume the following occurs among the notices *To our Correspondents*: 'The birth of a Maccaroni, by Ebbare, in the style of the Scriptures, seems to be taking too great a liberty with things sacred; and it is our maxim, as far as possible, to abstain from every appearance of evil.' The *Lady's Magazine* continued to be published by Robinson and Roberts for many subsequent years; and it is a curious coincidence that No. 5 of Vol. XLVII (for May, 1816) contains some stanzas entitled *Myra's Wedding-Day*.

The remaining *Juvenilia* printed in the present edition are partly reproduced from the *Fragments of Verse, from Mr Crabbe's early Note-Books* in Vol. II of the 1834 edition, partly from the *Life* in Vol. I of the same. The lines On the Death of William Springall Levett are quoted in the latter from Green's *History of Framlingham*, which has been compared.

Of the poems which follow in the present volume, *Inebriety* is here printed from a copy of the quarto of 1775, which lacks a title-page and which bears on p. 1 the following deprecation in Crabbe's handwriting: 'NB. —pray let not this be seen at [cipher] there is very little of it that I'm not heartily asham'd of.' The imprint of the title-page here given is taken from the *Life* (1834, p. 28).

Midnight, a Poem, is now first printed from the original manuscript which formed part of Dawson Turner's collection, in which it was numbered 121 at the sale of Dawson Turner's manuscripts in June, 1859. Its handwriting, as Professor Dowden points out, is identical with that of a *facsimile* in a passage from the *Two Epistles* mentioned above, given in the *Literary Anecdotes of the Nineteenth Century*.

The Candidate is printed from the edition of 1834 (Vol. II, Appendix). This poem is not included in the edition of 1823, and after a long quest it has proved impossible to obtain a copy of the original edition of 1780 (published in quarto by H. Payne, opposite Marlborough House, Pall Mall). This edition is not in the British Museum. It was only possible to compare the forty-six lines of the poem quoted in *The Monthly Review* for September, 1780; but no variants have been found in these.

The subsequent poems contained in the present volume are all printed from the edition of 1823, the last edition published in England in the poet's lifetime. The *Variants* enumerated at the close of this volume are in each case the readings of the first editions of the several poems, viz., *The Library*, 1781, *The Village*, 1783, *The Newspaper*, 1785, *The Parish Register &c.*, 1807, and *The Borough*, 1810. The address *To the Reader* prefixed to *The Newspaper*, which does not appear in the edition of 1823, has been restored from that of 1785, as it appears in the younger Crabbe's edition of 1834.

The list of *Errata* includes all the misprints, slips of the pen, and unintentional mistakes of spelling or quotation, which have been found in the texts which have been reprinted in this volume. The reading substituted here is in each case enclosed in square brackets. The list is a long one, for Crabbe was a careless writer; and in the matter of quotations (as the concluding sentence of the *Preface* to *The Borough* indicates) was not given to over-conscientiousness. It has seemed permissible, where this could be done, to supplement the poet's statements as to the sources of his quotations; but there are instances in which these statements themselves remain more or less doubtful. Crabbe's interpunctuation is so arbitrary, and, though no doubt largely determined by what might be described as the movement of the writer's mind, so frequently at variance even with the practice (it can hardly be called system) which he more usually follows, that it has been thought right to use as much freedom on this head as seemed consistent with a due respect for the author's intention. No alteration has been made in the matter of interpunctuation which was not warranted either by the poet's ordinary practice, or by the primary necessity of making his meaning clear.

As complete as possible a bibliography of Crabbe's Poems will, it is hoped, be published in the concluding volume of this edition.

There remains the pleasant duty of thanking those whose kindness has been of assistance in the preparation of this volume. The relatives of my dear friend the late Canon AINGER have allowed me to retain for this purpose the first editions of *Inebriety* (with Crabbe's autograph), *The Village* and *The Newspaper* which he had lent me not long before his death. The Vice-Master of Trinity, Mr W. ALDIS WRIGHT, besides enabling me to

borrow from Trinity Library the first edition of *The Library*, kindly lent his own copy of the *Poems* published in 1807. I am indebted to Professor EDWARD DOWDEN, LL.D., of Trinity College, Dublin, for various services generously rendered by him to this edition of Crabbe, which will benefit from them in its concluding as it has in its opening volume. He has readily allowed me to print the whole of the interesting blank verse poem of *Midnight*, which, in his own words, 'unless it be a transcript by Crabbe from some other eighteenth-century poet, of which there is no evidence, may be assumed to be of his authorship.'

To the same kind friend, and to the special courtesy of Mr J. W. LYSTER, Librarian of the National Library of Ireland, Kildare Street, Dublin, I owe the opportunity of tracing *fide oculata*, so far as it seems possible to make sure of it, the elusive volume of *The Lady's Magazine* containing the earliest of Crabbe's printed verse.

Mr A. R. WALLER, of Peterhouse, Assistant Secretary to the Syndics of the University Press, has in many ways facilitated the preparation of this volume. And without the unstinting and unflagging cooperation of another member of my College, Mr A. T. BARTHOLOMEW, of the University Library, who has compiled the list of variants, besides giving me much other assistance, I could not, amidst other engagements, have carried so far the execution of a delightful task.

A. W. WARD.

PETERHOUSE LODGE, CAMBRIDGE.

July 24th, 1905.

CORRIGENDA.

- p. [5](#), *for* Ovid *read* Ovid [?].
- p. [48](#), l. 41, *for* Meonides *read* [Maeonides].
- p. [55](#), l. 297, *for* [threat'ned] *read* [threaten'd].
- p. [232](#), l. 319, *for* Rubens *read* [Rubens].
- p. [252](#), l. 5, *for* dolor *read* [labor].
- p. [256](#), l. 4, *for* deplorant *read* [deplangunt].
- p. [329](#), l. 11, *for* and worship me *read* [and worship me].
- ib. l. 12, *for* Part I *read* Part II.
- p. [364](#), l. 12, *for* [erat] *read* erant.

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JUVENILIA

(1772—1780.)

SOLITUDE.

[September, 1772.]

Free from envy, strife and sorrow,
Jealous doubts, and heart-felt fears;
Free from thoughts of what to-
morrow
May o'er-charge the soul with
cares—

Live I in a peaceful valley,
By a neighbouring lonely wood;
Giving way to melancholy,
(Joy, when better understood).

Near me ancient ruins falling
10
From a worn-out castle's brow;
Once the greatest [chiefs] installing,
Where are all their honours now?

Here in midnight's gloomy terror
I enjoy the silent night;
Darkness shews the soul her error,
Darkness leads to inward light.

Here I walk in meditation,

Pond'ring all sublunar things,
From the silent soft persuasion,
Which from virtue's basis springs.

20

What, says truth, are pomp and
riches?

Guiled baits to folly lent;
Honour, which the soul bewitches,
When obtain'd, we may repent.

By me plays the stream meand'ring
Slowly, as its waters glide;
And, in gentle murmurs wand'ring,
Lulls to downy rest my pride.

Silent as the gloomy graves are
30

Now the mansions once so loud;
Still and quiet as the brave, or
All the horrors of a croud.

This was once the seat of plunder,
Blood of heroes stain'd the floor;
Heroes, nature's pride and wonder,
Heroes heard of now no more.

Owls and ravens haunt the buildings,
Sending gloomy dread to all;
Yellow moss the summit yielding,

40

Pellitory decks the wall.

Time with rapid speed still wanders,
Journies on an even pace;
Fame of greatest actions squanders,
But perpetuates disgrace.

Sigh not then for pomp or glory;
What avails a heroe's name?
Future times may tell your story,
To your then disgrace and shame.

Chuse some humble cot as this is,
50

In sweet philosophic ease;
With dame Nature's frugal blisses
Live in joy, and die in peace.

G. EBBARE.

A SONG.

[September, 1772.]

I.

As Chloe fair, a new-made bride,
Sat knotting in an arbour,
To Colin now the damsel ty'd,
No strange affection harbour.

II.

"How poor," says [she, "'s a] single
life,
A maid's affected carriage;
Spent in sighs and inward strife,
Things unknown in marriage.

III.

"Virgins vainly say they're free,
10
None so much confin'd are;
Lovers kind and good may be,
Husbands may be kinder.

IV.

"Then shun not wedlock's happy
chain,
Nor wantonly still fly man;
A single life is care and pain,
Blessings wait on Hymen."

G. EBBARE.

CONCLUDING LINES OF PRIZE POEM ON HOPE.

[Before October, 1772.]

* * * * *

But, above all, the POET owns thy
powers—
Hope leads him on, and every fear
devours;
He writes, and, unsuccessful, writes
again,
Nor thinks the last laborious work in
vain;
New schemes he forms, and various
plots he tries
To win the laurel, and possess the
PRIZE.

TO EMMA.

View, my fair, the fading flower,
Clad like thee in [beauty's] arms,
Idle pageant of an hour;
Soon shall time its tints devour,
And what are then its charms?

Early pluck'd, it might produce
A remedy to mortal pain,
Afford a balmy cordial juice,
That might celestial ease diffuse,
10

Nor blossom quite in vain.

So 'tis with thee, my Emma fair,
If nature's law's unpaid,
If thou refuse our vows to hear
And steel thy heart to ev'ry pray'r,
A cruel frozen maid.

But yield, my fair one, yield to love,
And joys unnumber'd find,
In Cupid's mystic circle move,
Eternal raptures thou shalt prove,
20

Which leave no pang behind.

G. EBBAAC.

Suffolk, Oct. 15, 1772.

*'Multa cadunt inter calicem
supremaque labra.'*

DESPAIR.

[November, 1772.]

Heu mihi!
Quod nullis amor medicabilis herbis.

OVID.

TYRSIS *and* DAMON.

D. Begin, my Tyrsis; songs shall sooth
our cares,
Allay our sorrows, and dispel our
fears;
Shall glad thy heart, and bring its
native peace,
And bid thy grief its weighty
influence cease.
No more those tears of woe, dear
shepherd, shed,
Nor ever mourn the lov'd Cordelia
dead.

T. In vain, my Damon, urge thy fond
request
To still the troubles of an anxious
breast:
Cordelia's gone! and now what pain
is life
10
Without my fair, my friend, my
lovely wife?
Hope! cheerful hope! to distant
climes is fled,
And Nature mourns the fair Cordelia
dead.

D. But can thy tears re-animate the
earth,
Or give to sordid dust a second birth?
Mistaken mortal! learn to bear the ill,
Nor let that canker, grief, thy
pleasures kill.
No more in Sorrow's sable garb
array'd,
Still [mourn] thy lov'd, thy lost
Cordelia dead.

T. Can I forget the fairest of her kind,
20
Beauteous in person, fairer still in
mind?
Can I forget she sooth'd my heart to
rest,
And still'd the troubl'd motion in my
breast?
Can I, by soothing song or friendship
led,
Forget to mourn my lov'd Cordelia
dead?

D. Another fair may court thee to her
arms,
Display her graces, and reveal her
charms;
May catch thy wand'ring eye, dispel
thy woe,
And give to sorrow final overthrow.
No longer, then, thy heart-felt anguish
shed,
30
Nor mourn, in solitude, Cordelia
dead.

T. Sooner shall lions fierce forget to
roam,
And peaceful walk with gentle lambs
at home;
Sooner shall Discord love her ancient
hate,
And Peace and Love with Rage
incorporate;
Sooner shall turtles with the sparrow
wed,
Than I forget my lov'd Cordelia dead.

- D. Must then Dorintha ever sigh in vain,
And Cælia breathe to echoing groves
her pain?
Must Chloe hope in vain to steel that
heart
40
In which each nymph would gladly
share a part?
Must these, dejected shepherd, be
betray'd.
And victims fall, because Cordelia's
dead?
- T. By those who love, my friend, it
stands confest,
No second flame can fill a lover's
breast:
For me no more the idle scenes of life
Shall vex with envy, hatred, noise, or
strife;
But here, in melancholy form array'd,
I'll ever mourn my lov'd Cordelia
dead.

G. EBBARE.

CUPID.

[November, 1772.]

*Whoe'er thou art, thy master know;
He has been, is, or shall be so.*

What is he, who clad in arms,
Hither seems in haste to move,
Bringing with him soft alarms,
Fears the heart of man to prove;

Yet attended too by charms—
Is he Cupid, God of Love?

Yes, it is, behold him nigh,
Odd compound of ease and smart;
Near him [stands] a nymph, whose
sigh

10

Grief and joy, and love impart;
Pleasure dances in her eye,
Yet she seems to grieve at heart.

Lo! a quiver by his side,
Arm'd with darts, a fatal store!
See him, with a haughty pride,
Ages, sexes, all devour;
Yet, as pleasure is describ'd,
Glad we meet the tyrant's power.

Doubts and cares before him go,

20

Canker'd jealousy behind;
Round about him spells he'll throw,
Scatt'ring with each gust of wind
On the motley crew below,
Who, like him, are render'd blind.

This is love! a tyrant kind,
Giving extacy and pain;
Fond deluder of the mind,
Ever feigning not to feign;
Whom no savage laws can bind,

30

None escape his pleasing chain.

G. EBBARE.

SONG.

[November, 1772.]

Cease to bid me not to sing.
Spite of Fate I'll tune my lyre:
Hither, god of music, bring
Food to feed the gentle fire;
And on Pægasean wing
Mount my soul enraptur'd higher.

Some there are who'd curb the mind,
And would blast the springing
bays;
All essays are vain, they'll find,
10
Nought shall drown the muse's
lays,
Nought shall curb a free-born mind,
Nought shall damp Apollo's praise.

G. EBBARE.

[ON THE DEATH OF WILLIAM SPRINGALL LEVETT.]

[1774.]

What though no trophies peer above
his dust,
Nor sculptured conquests deck his
sober bust;
What though no earthly thunders
sound his name,
Death gives him conquest, and our
sorrows fame:

One sigh reflection heaves, but shuns
excess—
More should we mourn him, did we
love him less.

PARODY ON [BYROM'S] "MY TIME, OH YE MUSES."

[Woodbridge, about 1774.]

My days, oh ye lovers, were happily
sped
Ere you or your whimsies got into my
head;
I could laugh, I could sing, I could
trifle and jest,
And my heart play'd a regular tune in
my breast.
But now, lack-a-day! what a change
for the worse,
'Tis as heavy as lead, yet as wild as a
horse.

My fingers, ere love had tormented
my mind,
Could guide my pen gently to what I
design'd.
I could make an enigma, a rebus, or
riddle,
10
Or tell a short tale of a dog and a
fiddle.
But, since this vile Cupid has got in
my brain,
I beg of the gods to assist in my
strain.

And whatever my subject, the fancy
still roves,
And sings of hearts, raptures, flames,
sorrows, and loves.

* * * * *
* * * *

THE WISH.

[Woodbridge, about 1774.]

My Mira, shepherds, is as fair
As sylvan nymphs who haunt the
vale,
As sylphs who dwell in purest air,
As fays who skim the dusky dale,
As Venus was when Venus fled
From watery Triton's oozy bed.

My Mira, shepherds, has a voice
As soft as Syrinx in her grove,
As sweet as echo makes her choice,
As mild as whispering virgin-love;
As gentle as the winding stream
Or fancy's song when poets dream.

* * * * *

INEBRIETY.

[Inebriety, a Poem, in three Parts. Ipswich, printed and sold by C. Punchard, Bookseller, in the Butter-Market, 1775. Price one shilling and sixpence.]

The PREFACE.

P RESUMPTION or Meanness are but too often the only articles to be discovered in a Preface. Whilst one author haughtily affects to despise the public attention, another timidly courts it. I would no more beg for than disdain applause, and therefore should advance nothing in Favor of the following little *Poem*, did it not appear a Cruelty and disregard to send a first Production naked into the WORLD.

The WORLD!—how pompous, and yet how trifling the sound. Every MAN, Gentle Reader, has a WORLD of his own, & whether it consists of half a score, or half a thousand Friends, 'tis his, and he loves to boast of it. Into my WORLD, therefore, I commit this, my Muse's earliest labor, nothing doubting the Clemency of the Climate, nor fearing the Partiality of the censorious.

Something by way of *Apology* for this trifle, is perhaps necessary; especially for those parts, wherein I have taken such great Liberties with Mr. POPE; that Gentleman, secure in immortal Fame, would forgive me; forgive me too, my friendly Critic; I promise thee, thou wilt find the Extracts from the Swan of Thames the best Parts of the Performance; Few, I dare venture to affirm, will pay me so great a Compliment, as to think I have injured Mr POPE; Fewer, I hope, will think I endeavoured to do it, and Fewest of all will think any thing about it.

The LADIES will doubtless favor my Attempt; for them indeed it was principally composed; I have endeavored to demonstrate that it is their own Faults, if they are not deemed as good MEN, as half the masculine World; that a personal Difference of Sex need not make a real Difference; and that

a tender Languishment, a refin'd Delicacy, and a particular attention to shine in Dress, will render the *Beau-Animal* infinitely more feminine, than the generality of LADIES, whatever arcane Tokens of *Manhood* the said *Animal* may be indued with; and yet, ye FAIR! these creatures pass even in your catalogue for MEN; which I'm afraid is a Demonstration that the real MAN is very scarce.

Some grave *Head* or *other* may possibly tell me, that Vice is to be lash'd, not indulg'd; that true *Poetry* forbids, not encourages, Folly; and such other wise and weighty Sentences, picked from POPE and HORACE, as he shall think most appertaining to his own dignity. But this, my good Reader, is a trifle; *People* now a Days are not to be preach'd into Reflection, or they pay *Parsons*, not *Poets* for it, if they were; they listen indeed to a Discourse from the Pulpit, for MEN are too wise to give away their Money without any consideration; and though they don't mind what is said there, 'tis doubtless a great Satisfaction to think they might if they choose it; but a MAN reads a *Poem* for quite a different purpose: to be lul'd into ease from reflection, to be lul'd into an inclination for pleasure, and (where I confess it comes nearer the Sermon) to be lul'd—asleep.

But lest the *Apology* should have the latter effect in itself, and so take away the merit of the Performance by forestalling that agreeable Event: I without further ceremony bid thee Adieu!

PART THE FIRST.

The mighty Spirit and its power
which stains^[1]
The bloodless cheek, and vivifies the
brains,
I sing. Say ye, its fiery Vot'ries true,
The jovial Curate, and the shrill-
tongu'd Shrew;
Ye, in the floods of limpid poison
nurst,
Where Bowl the second charms like
Bowl the first;

Say, how and why the sparkling ill is
shed,
The Heart which hardens, and which
rules the Head.
When Winter stern his gloomy front
uprears,

10

A sable void the barren earth appears;
The meads no more their former
verdure boast,
Fast bound their streams, and all their
Beauty lost;
The herds, the flocks, their icy
garments mourn,
And wildly murmur for the Spring's
return;
The fallen branches from the sapless
tree
With glittering fragments strow the
glassy way;
From snow-top'd Hills the whirlwinds
keenly blow,
Howl through the Woods, and pierce
the vales below;
Through the sharp air a flaky torrent
flies,

20

Mocks the slow sight, and hides the
gloomy skies;
The fleecy clouds their chilly bosoms
bare,
And shed their substance on the
floating air;
The floating air their downy
substance glides
Through springing Waters, and
prevents their tides;

Seizes the rolling Waves, and, as a
God,
Charms their swift race, and stops the
refl'ent flood;
The opening valves, which fill the
venal road,
Then scarcely urge along the
sanguine flood;
The labouring Pulse a slower motion
rules,

30

The Tendons stiffen, and the Spirit
cools;
Each asks the aid of [Nature's] sister
Art,
To Cher the senses, and to warm the
Heart.

The gentle fair on nervous tea relies,
Whilst gay good-nature sparkles in
her eyes;
An inoffensive Scandal fluttering
round,
Too rough to tickle, and too light to
wound;
Champain the Courtier drinks, the
spleen to chase,
The Colonel burgundy, and port his
Grace;
Turtle and 'rrack the city rulers
charm,

40

Ale and content the labouring
peasants warm;
O'er the dull embers happy Colin sits,
Colin, the prince of joke and rural
wits;

Whilst the wind whistles through the
hollow panes,
He drinks, nor of the rude assault
complains;
And tells the Tale, from sire to son
retold,
Of spirits vanishing near hidden gold;
Of moon-clad Imps, that tremble by
the dew,
Who skim the air, or glide o'er waters
blue.
The throng invisible, that doubtless
float

50

By mould'ring Tombs, and o'er the
stagnant moat;
Fays dimly glancing on the russet
plain,
And all the dreadful nothing of the
Green.
And why not these? Less fictitious is
the tale,
Inspir'd by Hel'con's streams, than
muddy ale?
Peace be to such, the happiest and the
best,
Who with the forms of fancy urge
their jest;
Who wage no war with an Avenger's
Rod,
Nor in the pride of reason curse their
God.

When in the vaulted arch Lucina
gleams,

60

And gaily dances o'er the azure
streams;
When in the wide cerulean space on
high
The vivid stars shoot lustre through
the sky;
On silent Ether when a trembling
sound
Reverberates, and wildly floats
around,
Breaking through trackless space
upon the ear—
Conclude the Bacchanalian Rustic
near;
O'er Hills and vales the jovial Savage
reels,
Fire in his head and Frenzy at his
heels;
From paths direct the bending Hero
swerves,

70

And shapes his way in ill-
proportion'd curves;
Now safe arriv'd, his sleeping Rib he
calls,
And madly thunders on the muddy
walls;
The well-known sounds an equal fury
move,
For rage meets rage, as love
enkindles love;
The buxom Quean }
from bed of }
flocks
descends
With vengeful ire, a civil war
portends,

An oaken plant the Hero's
breast defends.
In vain the 'waken'd infant's accents
shrill
The humble regions of the cottage
fill;

80

In vain the Cricket chirps the
mansion through,
'Tis war, and Blood and Battle must
ensue.

As when, on humble stage, him Satan
hight

Defies the brazen Hero to the fight;
From twanging strokes what dire
misfortunes rise,

What fate to maple arms, and glassen
eyes;

Here lies a leg of elm, and there a
stroke

From ashen neck has whirl'd a Head
of oak.

So drops from either power, with
vengeance big,

A remnant night-cap, and an old cut
wig;

90

Titles unmusical, retorted round,
On either ear with leaden vengeance
sound;

'Till equal Valour equal Wounds
create,

And drowsy peace concludes the fell
debate;

Sleep in her woolen mantle wraps the
pair,

And sheds her poppies on the
 ambient air;
Intoxication flies, as fury fled,
On rocky pinions quits the aching
 head;
Returning Reason cools the fiery
 blood,
And drives from memory's seat the
 rosy God.

100

Yet still he holds o'er some his
 madd'ning rule,
Still sways his Sceptre, and still
 knows his Fool;
Witness the livid lip and fiery front,
With many a smarting trophy plac'd
 upon't;
The hollow Eye, which plays in misty
 springs,
And the hoarse Voice, which rough
 and broken rings.
These are his triumphs, and o'er these
 he reigns,
The blinking Deity of reeling brains.

See Inebriety! her wand she waves,
And lo! her pale, and lo! her purple
 slaves;

110

Sots in embroidery, and sots in crape,
Of every order, station, rank, and
 shape;
The King, who nods upon his rattle-
 throne;
The staggering Peer, to midnight
 revel prone;

The slow-tongu'd Bishop, and the
Deacon sly,
The humble Pensioner, and
Gownsmen dry;
The proud, the mean, the selfish, and
the great,
Swell the dull throng, and stagger
into state.

Lo! proud Flaminus at the
splendid board,
The easy chaplain of an atheist Lord,
120
Quaffs the bright juice, with all the
gust of sense,
And clouds his brain in torpid
elegance;
In china vases see the sparkling ill,
From gay Decanters view the rosy
rill;
The neat-carv'd pipes in silver settle
laid,
The screw by mathematic cunning
made;
The whole a pompous and enticing
scene,
And grandly glaring for the surplic'd
Swain;
Oh! happy Priest whose God like
Egypt's lies,
At once the Deity and sacrifice!
130
But is Flaminus, then, the man alone,
To whom the Joys of swimming
brains are known?
Lo! the poor Toper whose untutor'd
sense^[2]

Sees bliss in ale, and can with wine
dispense;
Whose head proud fancy never taught
to steer
Beyond the muddy extacies of Beer;
But simple nature can her longing
quench
Behind the settle's curve, or humbler
bench;
Some kitchen-fire diffusing warmth
around,
The semi-globe by Hieroglyphics
crown'd;

140

Where canvas purse displays the
brass enroll'd,
Nor Waiters rave, nor Landlords thirst
for gold;
Ale and content his fancy's bounds
confine,
He asks no limpid Punch, no rosy
Wine;
But sees, admitted to an equal share,
Each faithful swain the heady potion
bear.
Go, wiser thou! and in thy scale of
taste
Weigh gout and gravel against ale and
rest.
Call vulgar palates, what thou judgest
so;
Say, beer is heavy, windy, cold and
slow;

150

Laugh at poor sots with insolent
pretence,

Yet cry when tortur'd, where is
Providence?
If thou alone art, head and heel, not
clear,
Alone made steady here, untumour'd
there;
Snatch from the Board the bottle and
the bowl,
Curse the keen pain, and be a mad
proud Fool.

FOOTNOTES:

[1]

"The mighty Mother, and her Son, who
brings
The Smithfield Muses to the ear of
Kings,
I sing. Say ye, her instruments, the
great,
Call'd to this Work by Dulness, Jove,
and Fate;
You by whose care, in vain decry'd, and
curst,
Still Dunce the second reigns like
Dunce the first;
Say, how the Goddess bade Britannia
sleep,
And pour'd her spirit o'er the land and
deep."

POPE'S

DUNCIAD.—

[2]

"Lo, the poor Indian! whose untutor'd
mind
Sees God in Clouds, and hears him in
the wind;
Whose Soul proud science never taught
to stray
Far as the solar walk, or milky way,
Yet simple nature to his hope has given
Behind the cloud-top't hill an humbler
Heaven;

Some safer world, in depth of woods
embrac'd,
Some happier island, in a watry waste:
Where slaves once more their native
land behold,
Nor friends torment, nor Christians
thirst for Gold;
To live, contents his natural desire,
He asks no Seraph's wing, no Angel's
fire,
But thinks admitted to that equal Sky,
His faithful Dog, shall bear him
company:
Go, wiser thou! and in thy scale of sense
Weigh thy opinion against Providence;
Call imperfection what thou fancy'st
such,
Say here he gives too little, here too
much,
Destroy all creatures for thy sport and
gust,
Yet cry, if man's unhappy, God's unjust;
If man alone engross not Heaven's high
care,
Alone made perfect here, immortal
there:
Snatch from his hand the balance and
the rod,
Rejudge his Justice, and be God of
God."

POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

END OF PART THE FIRST.

PART THE SECOND.

In various forms the madd'ning
Spirit moves,
This drinks and fights, another drinks
and loves.

A bastard Zeal of different kinds it
shows,
And now with rage, and now
Religion glows;
The frantic Soul bright reason's path
defies,
Now creeps on Earth, now triumphs
in the Skies;
Swims in the seas of error and
explores,
Through midnight mists, the
fluctuating Shores;
From wave to wave in rocky Channel
glides,

10

And sinks in woe, or on presumption
slides;
In Pride exalted, or by Shame
deprest,
An Angel-Devil, or a human-Beast.
Without a pilot who attempts to steer,
Has small discretion or has little care;
That pilot Reason, in the erring Soul,
Is lost, is blinded in the steaming
Bowl,
Charm'd by its power, we cast our
guide away,
And at the mercy of conjecture lay;
Discretion dies with reason, Revel
wakes!

20

And o'er the head his fiery banners
shakes.
With him come frenzy, folly and
excess,
Blink-ey'd conceit and shallow
emptiness;

At Folly's beck a train of Vices glide,
Murder in madness cloak'd, in choler,
Pride;
Above, Impiety, with curses bound,
Lours at the skies, and whirls
Damnation round.

Some rage, in all the strength of
folly mad,
Some love stupidity, in silence clad,
Are never quarrelsome, are never gay,
30
But sleep and groan and drink the
Night away;
Old Torpio nods, and, as the laugh
goes round,
Grunts through the nasal Duct, and
joins the sound;
Then sleeps again, and, as the liquors
pass,
Wakes at the friendly Jog, and takes
his Glass;
Alike to him who stands, or reels, or
moves;
The elbow chair, good wine and
Sleep he loves;
Nor cares of state disturb his easy
head,
By grosser fumes and calmer follies
fed;
Nor thoughts, of when, or where, or
how to come,
40
The Canvass general, or the general
Doom;
Extremes ne'er reach'd one passion of
his Soul;

A villain tame, and an unmettled fool,
To half his Vices he has but pretence,
For they usurp the place of common
sense;
To half his little Merits has no claim
But very Indolence has rais'd his
name,
Happy in this, that under Satan's sway
His passions humble, but will not
obey.

The Vicar at the table's front
presides,
50
Whose presence a monastic life
derides;
The reverend Wig, in sideways order
plac'd,
The reverend Band, by rubric stains
disgrac'd,
The leering Eye, in wayward circles
roll'd,
Mark him the Pastor of a jovial Fold,
Whose various texts excite a loud
applause,
Favouring the Bottle, and the good
old Cause.
See! the dull smile which fearfully
appears,
When gross Indecency her front
uprears;
The joy conceal'd the fiercer burns
within,
60
As masks afford the keenest gust to
Sin;
Imagination helps the reverend Sire,

And spreads the sails of sub-divine
 desire.
But when the gay immoral joke goes
 round,
When Shame and all her blushing
 train are drown'd,
Rather than hear his God blasphem'd
 he takes
The last lov'd Glass, and then the
 board forsakes:
Not that Religion prompts the sober
 thought,
But slavish Custom has the practice
 taught.
Besides, this zealous son of warm
 devotion

70

Has a true levite Bias for promotion;
Vicars must with discretion go astray,
Whilst Bishops may be d——n'd the
 nearest way;
So puny robbers individuals kill,
When hector-Heroes murder as they
 will.

Good honest Curio elbows the
 [divine,]
And strives, a social sinner, how to
 shine;
The dull quaint tale is his, the
 lengthen'd tale,
That Wilton Farmers give you with
 their ale:
How midnight Ghosts o'er vaults
 terrific pass,

80

Dance o'er the Grave, and slide along
the grass;
How Maids forsaken haunt the lonely
wood,
And tye the Noose, or try the willow
flood;
How rural Heroes overcame the
giants,
And through the ramshorn trumpet
blew defiance;
Or how pale Cicely, within the wood,
Call'd Satan forth and bargain'd with
her blood.
These, honest Curio, are thine, and
these
Are the dull Treasures of a brain at
peace.
No wit intoxicates thy gentle skull,
90
Of heavy, native, [unwrought] folly
full;
Bowl upon Bowl in vain exert their
force;
The breathing Spirit takes a
downward course,
Or, vainly soaring upwards to the
head,
Meets an impenetrable tence of lead.

Hast thou, Oh Reader! search'd o'er
gentle Gay,
Where various animals their powers
display?
In one strange Group, a chattering
race was hurl'd,
Led by the Monkey who had seen the
world.

He, it is said, from woodland
shepherds stole,

100

And went to Court, to greet each
fellow fool.

Like him, Fabricio steals from
guardian's side,

Swims not in [pleasure's] stream, but
sips the tide;

He hates the Bottle, }
yet but thinks it }
right

To boast next day the honours
of the night;

None like your Coward can
describe a fight.

See him, as down the sparkling
potion goes,

Labor to grin away the horrid dose;

In joy-feign'd gaze his misty eye-balls
float,

Th' uncivil Spirit gurgling at his
throat;

110

So looks dim Titan through a wintry
scene,

And faintly cheers the woe-
foreboding swain;

But now, Alas! the hour, th'increasing
flood,

Rolls round and round, and cannot be
withstood;

Thrice he essays to stop the ruby
flow,

To stem its Force, and keep it still
below;

In vain his Art, it comes! at [distance]
gaze,

Ye stancher Sots, and be not near the
place.

As when a flood from Ossa's pendant
brow

Rolls rapid to its fellow streams
below,

120

It moves tempest'ous }
down the
Mountain's sides,

O'er lesser hills and vales like
light'ning glides,

And o'er their beauties fall'n
triumphant rides,

Each verdant spot and sunny bank
defaces,

And forms a minor Ocean at its basis;
So from his rueful lips Fabricio
pours,

With melancholy Force, the tinctur'd
showers;

O'er the embroider'd vest they take
their way,

And in the grave its tinsel honours
lay.

No Nymph was there, to hold the
helpless face,

130

Or save from ruin's spoil the luckless
lace;

No guardian Fair, to turn the head
aside

And to securer paths the torrent glide;
From silk to silk it drove its wayward
Course,

And on the diamond buckle spent its
Force.

Ah! gentle Fop! what luckless fate
was thine

To sin through fashion, and in woe to
shine.

But all our Numbers why should
rascals claim^[3]?

Rise, honest Muse, and sing a nobler
name.

Pleas'd in his Eye good humour
always smiles,

140

And Mirth unbought with strife the
hour beguiles,

Who smoothed the frown on yonder
surly brow?

From the dry Joke who bade gay
Laughter flow?

Not of affected, empty rapture full,
Nor in proud Strain magnificently
dull,

But gay and easy, giving without Art
Joy to each sense, and Solace to the
heart.

Thrice happy Damon, able to pursue
What all so wish, but want the power
to do.

No cares thy Head, no crimes thy
Heart torment,

150

At home thou'rt happy, and abroad
content;

Pleas'd with thyself, and therefore
form'd to please,

With Moderation free, and gay with
Ease,

Wise in a medium, just to an extreme,
"The soul of Humour, and the life of
Whim,"
Plac'd from thy Sphere, amid the sons
of shame,
Proud of thy Jest, but prouder of thy
Name.

Pernicious streams from healthy
fountains rise,
And Wit abus'd degenerates into vice;
Timon, long practic'd in the School of
art,

160

Has lost each finer feeling of the
Heart,
Triumphs o'er shame, and with
delusive whiles,
Laughs at the Idiot he himself
beguiles.

So matrons, past the awe of Censure's
tongue,
Deride the blushes of the fair and
young.

Few with more Fire on every subject
spoke,

But chief he lov'd the gay immoral
joke;

The Words most sacred, stole from
holy writ,

He gave a newer form, and call'd
them Wit;

Could twist a Sentence into various
meaning,

170

And save himself in dubious
explaining;

Could use a manner long taught art
affords,
And hint Impiety in holy words.
Vice never had a more sincere ally,
So bold no Sinner, yet no Saint so sly;
Sophist and Cynic, mystically cool,
And still a very Sceptic at the soul;
Learn'd but not wise, and without
Virtue brave,
A gay, deluding, philosophic Knave.
When Bacchus' joys his airy fancy
fire,

180

They stir a new, but still a false
desire;
The place of malice ridicule then
holds,
And woe to teachers, ministers and
scolds;
And, to the comfort of each untaught
Fool,
Horace in English vindicates the
Bowl.
"The man" (says Timon) "who is
drunk is blest^[4],
No fears [disturb], no cares destroy
his rest;
In thoughtless joy he reels away his
life,
Nor dreads that worst of ills, a noisy
wife.

Of late I sat within the jangling bar,

190

And heard my Rib's hoarse thunder
from afar;
Careless I spoke, and, when she
found me drunk,

She breath'd one Curse, and then
away she slunk,
Oh! place me, Jove, where none but
women come,
And thunders worse than thine afflict
the room;
Where one eternal Nothing flutters
round,
And senseless [titt'rings] sense of
mirth confound;
Or lead me bound to Garret, babel-
high,
Where frantic Poet rolls his crazy
eye;
Tiring the Ear, with oft-repeated
chimes,

200

And smiling at the never ending
rhymes;
E'en here or there, I'll be as blest as
Jove,
Give me tobacco, and the wine I
love."
Applause from Hands the dying
accents break
Of stagg'ring sots, who vainly try to
speak;
From Milo, him who hangs upon
each word,
And in loud praises splits the tortur'd
board,
Collects each sentence, ere it's better
known,
And makes the mutilated joke his
own,
At weekly club to flourish, where he
rules

210

The glorious president of grosser
fools.

But cease, my Muse; of those or
these enough,
The fools who listen, and the knaves
who Scoff;
The jest profane, that mocks th'
offended God,
Defies his power, and [sets] at nought
his rod.
The empty Laugh, discretion's vainest
foe,
From fool to fool re-echo'd to and fro;
The sly Indecency, that slowly
springs
From barren wit, and halts on
trembling wings:
Enough of these, and all the charms
of Wine;

220

Be sober joys and social evenings
mine,
Where peace and Reason unsoil'd
mirth improve,
The powers of friendship and the joys
of love;
Where thought meets thought ere
Words its form array,
And all is sacred, elegant, and gay;
Such pleasure leaves no Sorrow on
the mind,
Too great to [pall], to sicken too
[refin'd],
Too soft for Noise, and too sublime
for art,

The social solace of the feeling Heart,
For sloth too rapid, and for wit too
high,

230

'Tis Virtue's Pleasure, and can never
die.

FOOTNOTES:

[3]

"But all our praises why should Lords
engross?
Rise honest Muse and sing the Man of
Ross.
Pleas'd Vaga echo's, through her
winding bounds,
And rapid Severn hoarse applause
resounds;
Who hung with woods, yon mountain's
sultry brow?
From the dry Rock, who bade the waters
flow?
Not to the skies in useless columns tost,
Nor in proud falls, magnificently lost.
But clear and artless, pouring through
the plain
Health to the Sick, and solace to the
Swain."

POPE.—

[4]

"Integer vitæ, scelerisque [purus]
Non eget &c. &c."

HORACE.

END OF PART THE SECOND.

PART THE THIRD.

Now soar, my Muse! and leave the
meaner crew^[5],

To aim at bliss, and vainly bliss
pursue;
Let us (since Man no privilege can
claim,
Than a contended, half superior
name)
Expatiate o'er the raptures of the Fair,
Vot'ries to stolen joys, but yet sincere;
In secret Haunts, where never day-
light gleams
By bottles, tempting with forbidden
streams,
Together let us search; above, below,
10
Try what the Closets, what the Cellars
show;
The latent vault with piercing view
explore
Of her who hides the all reviving
store.
Eye Beauty's walks, when round the
welkin rolls,
And catch the stumbling Charmer as
she falls;
Laugh where we must, but pity where
we can,
And vindicate the sweet soft souls to
Man.

Pardon, ye Fair, the Poet and his
Muse,
And what ye can't approve, at least
excuse;
Far be from him the iron lash of Wit,
20
The jokes of Humour, and the sneers
that hit;

He speaks of Freedom, and he speaks
to you,
His Verse is simple, but his Subject
new;
And novelty, ye Fair, beyond a doubt,
Is philosophic truth, the World
throughout.

Hard is the lot of Woman, so have
sung
The pensive old, and the presuming
young;
Born without privilege, in bondage
bred,
Slave from the Cradle to the marriage
Bed;
Slave from the hour hymeneal to the
grave,

30

In age, in youth, in infancy a Slave.
Happy the Bard, who, bold in pride of
song
Shall free the chain, by Custom
bound so long,
And show the Fair, to mean tradition
prone,
Though Virtue may have sex, yet
Vice has none.
If Man is licenc'd to confuse his
mind,
Say, why should female Frailty be
confin'd?
Is't right that she who }
dearly bought }
the fruit,
Of all our wayward appetites
the root,

Who first made Man a fool
and then a brute;

40

Who fair in spells of tender kind can
slay,
Like Israel's Judge, her thousands in a
day;

Nay farther, has a far superior Pow'r,
And almost thousands in a day can
cure;

She, the bright cause of fury in Man's
breast;

And brighter cause who bids that fury
rest;

Who raises peace or war at her
command,

And bids a sword destroy a tipsy
Land;

Say, is it right that she who kills and
saves,

Makes wise Men mad, and takes the
veil from Knaves,

50

Should want the pow'r, the magic,
which alone,

Can Conquests boast more fatal than
her own?

For Man alone did earth produce her
fruit,

The sole, as well as the superior,
brute;

Does he alone the glorious licence
claim,

To put the human off, and loose his
Name?

Woman in Knowledge was the earlier
curst,

And tasted of forbidden Fruit the
first;

Prior to Man, the law she disobey'd,
And shall she want the Freedom she
convey'd?

60

By her first Theft each fiery ill we
feel,

And yet compel the gen'rous Fair to
steal;

First made by her for soaring actions
fit,

Woman! the spring of super-human
wit,

Shall we from her each dear bought
bliss withhold,

As Spaniards use the Indians for their
Gold?

Ungrateful Man! in pride so high to
aim,

As to be sole inheritor of shame!

And you, ye Fair! why slumber on
disdain,

Forbear to vindicate, yet can't refrain?

70

Why should Papilla seek the vaulted
hoard,

And but in secret ape her honest
Lord?

Why should'st thou, Celia, to thy
stores repair,

And sip the generous Spirit in such
fear?

Reform the Error, and revoke your
plan,

And as ye dare to imitate, be——
Man.

First know yourselves, and frame
your passions all^[6],
In proper order, how to rise and fall;
Woman's a Being, dubiously great,
Never contented with a passive state;
80
With too much Knowledge to give
Man the sway,
With too much Pride his humours to
obey,
She hangs in doubt, [too] humble or
[too] brave;
In doubt to be a Mistress or a Slave;
In doubt herself or Husband to
controul;
Born to be made a tyrant or a fool;
In one extreme, her Power is always
such
Either to show too little, or too much;
Bred up in Passions, by their sway
abus'd,
The weaker for the stronger still
refus'd;
90
Created oft' to rise, and oft' to fall,
Changing in all things, yet alike in
all;
Soft Judge of right or wrong, or blest
or curst,
The happiest, saddest, holiest, or the
worst.

And why? because your failings ye
suppress,

And what ye dare to act, dare not
confess.

Would you, ye Fair, as Man your
vices boast,

And she be most admir'd, who sins
the most;

Would ye in open revel gaily spring,
And o'er the wanton Banquet
vaunting sing;

100

The doubtful Precedence we then
should own,

And you be first in [Error's] mazes
known.

But why to Vices of the boist'rous
kind

Tye the soft Soul, and urge the gentle
Mind?

Forbid it, Nature! to the Fair I speak,
By her made strong, by Custom
rendered weak;

Whose passions, trembling for
unbounded sway,

Will thank the Bard, who points the
nearest way;

All Vice through Folly's regions first
should pass,

And Folly holds her sceptre o'er the
glass.

110

Drink then, ye Fair! and nature's laws
fulfill;

Be ev'ry thing at once, and all ye will;
Put off the mask that hides the Sex's
claim

And makes Distinction but an empty
name.

Go, wond'rous Creature! where the
potion glides^[7]
From Bowls unmeasured in illumin'd
tides;
Instruct each other, in your due
degrees;
Correct old Rules, and be e'en what
you please;
Go, drink! for who shall jointed
power contest?
Drink to the passable, the good, the
best.

120

And, quitting Custom and her idle
plan,
Call drowning reason imitating Man;
Like lovers' brains in giddy circles
run,
And, all exhausting, imitate the Sun;
Go, and be Man in noise and glorious
strife,
Then drop into his Arms and be a
——Wife.

Ye Gods! what scenes upon my
Fancy press,
The Consequence of unconfin'd
excess;
When Vice in common has one
general name,
And male and female Errors be the
same;

130

For, as the strength of Spirit none
contest,
That daring Ill shall introduce the
rest;
Then, what a field of glory will arise,
What dazzling scenes, ye Fair, before
your eyes:
As female duels, Jockies——what
besides?
Gamblers in petticoats, and booted
brides;
The tender Billet to the gentle swain,
That boldly dares avouch the am'rous
pain;
Soft Beaux intreated, gentle
Coxcombs prest,
And Fops asham'd half blush to be
addrest.

140

Thus to sweet Strephon will his
Chloris say,
One cup of Nectar having pav'd the
way;
"Oh! why so dead to my empling
eyes,
Deaf to my prayer, and speechless to
my sighs?
Sure never Nymph of old, my darling
Boy,
When Men intreated, and when we
were coy,
Was prest so warmly by a bleeding
swain,
Or shot from killing eyes such cold
disdain."
And thus will run wild Flavia's
Billetdoux,

The writing bold, and e'en the
spelling true:

150

"No more, my Belmour, shun these
longing arms,
Thou quintessence of all thy Sex's
charms;
At ten—behind the elm, where
echoes sigh,
Shall, taught [by] me, teach thee my
swain to die;
The conscious Moon shall fill her
lucid horn,
And join thy Blush to mock the
crimson morn;
The limpid Stream shall softly move
along,
And hear its own sweet warble from
thy tongue;
There come, dear boy, or vainly flow
the streams,
There come, or vainly sheds the
moon her beams;

160

Vainly on her my Moments I shall
waste,
She who like thee is cold, and who
like thee is chaste."
But then what tender Stripling shall
escape?
What blushing Boy avoid a Lady-
Rape?
Where shall each lisping creature
hide his head,
To amazonian desires betray'd?
Where from the wily Heroine
remove,

Clad in the fortitude of Wine and
Love?

Oh! hapless Lad, what refuge canst
thou find

Too soft, too mild, too tender to be
kind?

170

Yet this is no objection understood,
"For partial Evil's universal Good."

Nor think of Nature's state I make a
jest^[8]:

The state of Nature is a state undrest;
The love of Pleasure at our birth
began,

Pleasure the aim of all things, and of
Man.

Law then was not, the swelling flame
to kill,

Man walk'd with beast, and—so he
always will;

And Woman too, the same their board
and bed,

And would be now, but Folks are
better bred;

180

In some convenient grot, or tufted
wood,

All human beings Nature's circuit
trod;

The shrine was her's, with no gay
vesture laid;

Unbrib'd, unmarried stood the willing
maid;

Her attribute was universal Love,
And man's prerogative to range and
rove.

But how unlike the Pairs of times to
come,
Wedded, yet separate, abroad at
home,
Who foes to Nature, and to evil
prone,
Despising all, but hating most their
own.

190

A wayward craving this Neglect
succeeds,
As every Monster monst'rous
children breeds;
Strange motly passions from this vice
began,
And Man unnatural turn'd to worship
Man.

For this the Muse now calls the
Fair to rise,
To shew our failings, and to make us
wise;
Be now to Bacchus, now to Venus
prone,
And share each folly Man has
thought his own;
Shame him from Vice, by shewing
him your shame,
And part with yours, to reinstate his
Fame;

200

Be generously vile, and this your
view:
That Man may hate his errors seen in
you.

Say, when the Coxcomb flatters
and adores,
When (taking snuff) your pity he
implores;
With many a gentle Dem'me swears
to die,
And humbly begs Destruction from
your eye;
When your own arts he takes, and
speaks in smiles,
With Softness woos, and with a Voice
beguiles;
Does it not move your pity and
disdain,
Such flow'ry passion, and such
mincing pain;

210

Your various Follies you with anger
scan,
So shewn by one whom Nature meant
for Man.
E'en so do we our faults in you
despise,
And Vice has double malice in those
Eyes.
When Chloe toasts her Beau, or raves
too loud;
When Flavia leaves her home, and
joins a croud;
When Silvia fearless rolls the roguish
eye,
And Damon's want of confidence
supply;
When betts, and duns, and every
rougher name,
Sound in the ear of either Sex the
same;

220

How should we tell, when thus you
love and hate,
Who acts the Man, and who's
effeminate?

Drink, then! disclaim your Sex, be
Man in all,
Shew us at once, distinction ought to
fall;
And from the humble things ye were
of old,
Be reeling Cæsars in a cyprian
mould.

Better for us, 'tis granted, it might
be^[9],
Were you all Softness, and all Honour
we;
That never rougher Passion mov'd
your mind;
That we were all or excellent or
blind;

230

But, as we now subsist by passions
strife,
Which are (POPE writes) the elements
of life,
The general order, since the whole
began,
Should be dissolv'd, and Manners
make the Man.

Nor fear, if once ye break through
general Laws,
To draw in thousands, and gain our
applause;

Nor fear but Fame your merits shall
make known,
And female Bravos trample Hectors
down;
From Man himself you'll learn the art
he boasts,
Rule in his room, and govern in his
posts.

240

Thus does the Muse in vein
didactic speak——^[10]
"Go, from proud Man thy full
instructions take;
Learn from the Law, what gain its
mazes yield;
Learn of the Brave the police of the
field;
Thy arts of shuffling from the
Courtier get;
Learn of his Grace to stare away a
debt;
Learn from the Sot his poison to
caress,
Shake the mad room, and revel in
excess;
From Man all forms of grand
deception find,
And so be tempted to delude
Mankind.

250

Here frantic schemes of wild
Ambition see;
There all the plots, my Fair! he lays
for thee.
Learn each small People's genius,
humours, aims,

The Jocky's dealing, and Newmarket
games;
How there in common wealth in
currents go,
And poverty and riches ebb and flow;
And these for ever, though a Saint
deny'd,
To splendour or contempt their
Masters guide;
Mark the nice rules of modern honour
well,
Rules which the laws of Nature far
excel.

260

In vain thy fancy finer whims shall
draw;
Good-breeding is as difficult as Law,
And, form'd so complex, makes itself
a science,
To bid the Scholar and the Clown
defiance.
Go then, and thus thy present Lords
survey,
And let the Creatures feel they must
obey;
Learn all their Arts, be these thy
choicest hoard,
Be fear'd for these, and be for these
ador'd."

And where are these? within the
Bowl they lie;
Thence spring ambitious thoughts,
there doubtings die;

270

From thence we trace the horrors of a
War,

Chaotic counsel, ministerial jar;
This makes a gambling Lord, a
Patriot vain,
The Soldier's fury, and the Lover's
pain;
Fills Bedlam's wards with souls of
ærial mould;
This makes the Madman, this
supplies the Scold;
Here rules the one grand Passion in
extreme,
A love of lucre, or a love of fame;
The Scholar's boast, the Politician's
plan;
Here shines the Bubble, and here falls
the Man.

280

Oh! happy fall of insolence and
pride,
Which makes the humblest with the
great allied;
Which levels like the Grave all
earthly things,
For drunken Cobblers are as proud as
Kings;
Which plucks the sons of grandeur
from their sphere,
For who is lower than a stagg'ring
Peer?
Yet here, ye Fair, tho' ev'ry Soul's the
same,
And Prince and Pedlar differ but in
name,
Folly with Fashion is discreetly
grac'd,
And, if all sin, not all can sin in taste;

290

For who, ye Gods! would ever go
astray,
If 'twas not something in a modish
way?

Oh! Fashion, caprice, pride—
whate'er we call—
Thou something, nothing, dear
attractive all;
Thou serious trifle of the gentle Soul,
Worship'd, yet changing, varying to
controul;
Sweet Child of wanton fancy, artful
whim,
Bred in an instant, born in an
Extreme;
Folly's best friend, and luxury's ally,
Who, dying always, prov'st thou canst
not die;

300

Attend us here; let us grow mad in
Form,
Rage with an Air, and elegantly
storm;
Invoke destruction with a Grace
divine,
And call for Satan as a child of thine;
Genteely stagger from the common
road;
And ape the brute, but ape him in the
mode;
With a Court-grace make every action
known,
For who'd be d——n'd for sins they
blush to own?

Far as the power of human vice
extends^[11],
Her scale of sensual vanity ascends;
310
Mark how it rises to the gilded
Throne,
From the poor wretch who dully
topes alone.
What modes of folly, each in one
extreme,
The sots dim sense, th' Epicurean's
dream;
Of scent, what difference 'twixt the
pungent rum
And noxious vapours of fermenting
stum;
Of hearing, to Champain's decanted
swell
From the dull gurgle of expiring ale?
The touch, how distant in the mean
and great,
Who feel all roughness, or who feed
from plate;
320
In the nice Lord, behold what arts
produce;
From vases carv'd is quaff'd the
balmy juice;
How palates vary in the poor Divine,
Compar'd, half-reasoning Nobleman!
with thine.

Thus every sense is fill'd in due
degree,
And proper barriers bound his Grace
and me;

Here every Passion is at length
display'd,
Nations are ruin'd, Ministers betray'd;
And what, ye Fair, concerns your
pleasures most,
Intrigues are plan'd, and Reputations
lost:

330

By you persuaded, Man was
overcome,
And conquer'd once, received a
general doom;
Requite the deed, partake a general
Curse;
We fell with you, and you should fall
with us.

FOOTNOTES:

[\[5\]](#)

"Awake, my St. John, leave all meaner
things
To low ambition, and the pride of
Kings;
Let us (since Life can little more supply
Than just to look about us, and to die)
Expatiate free o'er all this scene of Man,
A mighty maze, but not without a plan;
A Wild, where weeds and flowers
promiscuous shoot
Or Garden, tempting with forbidden
fruit.
Together let us beat this ample field,
Try what the open, what the covert
yield;
The latent tracts, the giddy heights
explore,
Of all who blindly creep, or sightless
soar;
Eye Nature's walks, shoot Folly as it
flies,
And catch the Manners, living as they
rise;

Laugh where we must, be candid where
we can,
But vindicate the ways of God to Man."
POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

[6]

"Know then thyself, presume not God to
scan,
The proper study of Mankind is Man.
Plac'd on this isthmus of a middle state,
A Being darkly wise, and rudely great;
With too much knowledge for the
Sceptic side,
With too much weakness for the Stoic's
pride,
He hangs between: in doubt to act, or
rest;
In doubt to deem himself a God, or
Beast;
In doubt his Mind or Body to prefer;
Born but to die, and reas'ning but to err;
Alike in Ignorance, his reason such,
Whether he thinks too little or too
much;
Chaos of Thought and Passion; all
confus'd;
Still by himself abus'd, or disabus'd:
Created half to rise, and half to fall,
Great Lord of all things, yet a prey to
all;
Sole judge of Truth, in endless Error
hurl'd;
The glory, jest, and riddle of the World!"
POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

[7]

"Go, wondrous creature! mount where
Science guides;
Go, measure earth, weigh air, and state
the tides;
Instruct the planets in what orbs to run,
Correct old Time, and regulate the Sun;
Go, soar, with Plato, to th' empyreal
sphere,

To the first Good, first Perfect, and first
Fair;
Or tread the mazy round his foll'wers
trod,
And quitting sense call imitating God;
As eastern Priests in giddy circles run,
And turn their heads to imitate the Sun;
Go, teach Eternal Wisdom how to rule;
Then drop into thyself, and be a Fool."

POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

[8]

"Nor think, in Nature's State they
blindly trod;
The state of Nature was the reign of
God:
Self-love and social at her birth began,
Union the bond of all things, and of
Man.
Pride then was not; nor Arts, that Pride
to aid;
Man walk'd with beast, joint tenant of
the shade;
The same his table, and the same his
bed;
No murder cloath'd him, and no murder
fed.
In the same temple, the resounding
wood,
All vocal beings hymn'd their equal
God;
The shrine with gore unstain'd, with
gold undrest;
Unbrib'd, unbloody, stood the blameless
priest;
Heav'n's attribute was universal care,
And Man's prerogative to rule, but
spare.
Ah! how unlike the man of times to
come!
Of half that live the butcher and the
tomb;
Who, foe to Nature, hears the gen'ral
groan,
Murders their species, and betrays his
own.
But just Disease to luxury succeeds,
And ev'ry death its own avenger breeds;

The Fury-passions from that blood
began,
And turn'd on Man a fiercer savage,
Man."

POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

[9]

"Better for us, I grant, it might appear,
Were there all Harmony, all Virtue here;
That never air or ocean felt the wind,
That never passion discompos'd the
mind;
But all subsists by elemental strife,
And passions are the elements of life;
The general Order, since the whole
began
Is kept in Nature, and is kept in Man."

[10]

"Thus then to Man the voice of Nature
spake——
'Go, from the creatures thy instructions
take:
Learn from the birds what food the
thickets yield;
Learn from the beasts the physic of the
field;
Thy arts of building from the bee
receive;
Learn of the mole to plough, the worm
to weave;
Learn of the little nautilus to sail,
Spread the thin oar, and catch the
driving gale.
Here too all forms of social union find,
And hence let Reason, late, instruct
Mankind;
Here subterranean works and cities see,
There towns aerial on the waving tree.
Learn each small people's genius,
policies,
The ant's republic, and the realm of
bees;
How those in common all their wealth
bestow,
And anarchy without confusion know;

And these for ever, though a monarch
 reign,
Their sep'rate cells and properties
 maintain.
Mark what unvary'd laws preserv'd each
 state,
Laws wise as nature, and as fix'd as
 Fate.
In vain thy Reason finer webs shall
 draw,
Intangle Justice in her net of law,
And right, too rigid, harden into wrong,
Still for the strong too weak, the weak
 too strong.
Yet go! and thus o'er all the creatures
 sway;
Thus let the wiser make the rest obey;
And, for those arts mere Instinct could
 afford,
Be crown'd as Monarchs, or as Gods
 ador'd."

POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

[11]

"Far as Creation's ample range extends,
The scale of sensual, mental pow'rs
 ascends;
Mark how it mounts to Man's imperial
 race,
From the green myriads in the peopled
 grass
What modes of sight, betwixt each wide
 extreme,
The mole's dim curtain, and the lynx's
 beam:
Of smell the head-long lioness between,
And hound sagacious on the tainted
 green.
Of hearing, from the life that fills the
 flood,
To that which warbles thro' the vernal
 wood,
The spider's touch, how exquisitely
 fine!
Feels at each thread, and lives along the
 line;
In the nice bee what art, so subtly true,

From pois'nous herbs extracts the
healing dew;
How Instinct varies in the grov'ling
swine,
Compar'd, half-reasoning elephant, with
thine."

POPE'S ESSAY
ON
MAN.—

FINIS.

JUVENILIA.

[THE LEARNING OF LOVE.]

[About 1776.]

Ah! blest be the days when with Mira
I took
The learning of Love....
When we pluck'd the wild blossoms
that blush'd in the grass,
And I taught my dear maid of their
species and class;
For Conway, the friend of mankind,
had decreed
That Hudson should show us the
wealth of the mead.

YE GENTLE GALES.

Woodbridge, 1776.

Ye gentle Gales, that softly move,
Go whisper to the Fair I love;
Tell her I languish and adore,
And pity in return implore.

But if she's cold to my request,
Ye louder Winds, proclaim the rest—
My sighs, my tears, my griefs
proclaim,

And speak in strongest notes my
flame.

Still, if she rests in mute disdain,
10
And thinks I feel a common pain—
Wing'd with my woes, ye Tempests,
fly,
And tell the haughty Fair I die.

MIRA.

Aldborough, 1777.

A wanton chaos in my breast raged
high,
A wanton transport darted in mine
eye;
False pleasure urged, and ev'ry eager
care,
That swell the soul to guilt and to
despair.
My Mira came! be ever blest the
hour,
That drew my thoughts half way from
folly's power;
She first my soul with loftier notions
fired;
I saw their truth, and as I saw
admired;
With greater force returning reason
moved,
10
And as returning reason urged, I
loved;

Till pain, reflection, hope, and love
allied
My bliss precarious to a surer
guide—
To Him who gives pain, reason, hope,
and love,
Each for that end that angels must
approve.
One beam of light He gave my mind
to see,
And gave that light, my heavenly fair,
by thee;
That beam shall raise my thoughts,
and mend my strain,
Nor shall my vows, nor prayers, nor
verse be vain.

HYMN.

Beccles, 1778.

Oh, Thou! who taught my infant eye
To pierce the air, and view the sky,
To see my God in earth and seas,
To hear him in the vernal breeze,
To know him midnight thoughts
among,
O guide my soul, and aid my song!
Spirit of Light! do thou impart
Majestic truths, and teach my heart;
Teach me to know how weak I am,
10
How vain my powers, how poor my
frame;
Teach me celestial paths untrod—
The ways of glory and of God.

No more let me, in vain surprise,
To heathen art give up my eyes—
To piles laborious science rear'd
For heroes brave, or tyrants fear'd;
But quit Philosophy, and see
The Fountain of her works in Thee.

Fond man! yon glassy mirror eye—
20
Go, pierce the flood, and there descry
The miracles that float between
The rainy leaves of wat'ry green;
Old Ocean's hoary treasures scan;
See nations swimming round a span.

Then wilt thou say—and rear no
more
Thy monuments in mystic lore—
My God! I quit my vain design,
And drop my work to gaze on Thine:
Henceforth I'll frame myself to be,
30
Oh, Lord! a monument of Thee.

THE WISH.

Aldborough, 1778.

Give me, ye Powers that rule in
gentle hearts,
The full design, complete in all its
parts,
Th' enthusiastic glow, that swells the
soul—
When swell'd too much the judgment
to control—

The happy ear that feels the flowing
force
Of the smooth line's uninterrupted
course;
Give me, oh give, if not in vain the
prayer,
That sacred wealth, poetic worth, to
share—
Be it my boast to please and to
improve,
10
To warm the soul to virtue and to
love;
To paint the passions, and to teach
mankind
Our greatest pleasures are the most
refined;
The cheerful tale with fancy to
rehearse,
And gild the moral with the charm of
verse.

THE COMPARISON.

Parham, 1778.

Friendship is like the gold refined,
And all may weigh its worth;
Love like the ore, brought undesign'd
In virgin beauty forth.

Friendship may pass from age to age,
And yet remain the same;
Love must in many a toil engage,
And melt in lambent flame.

GOLDSMITH TO THE AUTHOR.

Aldborough, 1778.

Felix quem faciunt aliena pericula cautum.

You're in love with the Muses? Well,
grant it be true,
When, good Sir, were the Muses
enamour'd of you?
Read first—if my lectures your fancy
delight—
Your taste is diseased, can your cure
be to *write*?

You suppose you're a genius, that
ought to engage
The attention of wits and the smiles
of the age:
Would the wits of the age their
opinion make known,
Why—every man thinks just the
same of his own.

You imagine that Pope—but yourself
you beguile—

10

Would have wrote the same things,
had he chose the same style.
Delude not yourself with so fruitless
a hope—
Had he chose the same style, he had
never been Pope.

You think of *my* muse with a friendly
regard,
And rejoice in her author's esteem
and reward:

But let not his glory your spirits elate,
When pleased with his honours,
remember his fate.

FRAGMENT.

Aldborough, 1778.

Lord, what is man, that thou art mindful of him?

Proud, little Man, opinion's slave.
Error's fond child, too duteous to
be free,
Say, from the cradle to the grave,
Is not the earth thou tread'st too
grand for thee?
This globe that turns thee, on her
agile wheel
Moves by deep springs, which thou
canst never feel;
Her day and night, her centre and her
sun,
Untraced by thee, their annual
courses run.
A busy fly, thou sharest the march
divine,
10
And flattering fancy calls the motion
thine;
Untaught how soon some hanging
grave may burst,
And join thy flimsy substance to the
dust.

THE RESURRECTION.

Aldborough, 1778.

The wintry winds have ceased to
blow,
And trembling leaves appear;
And fairest flowers succeed the snow,
And hail the infant year.

So, when the world and all its woes
Are vanish'd far away,
Fair scenes and wonderful repose
Shall bless the new-born day—

When, from the confines of the grave,
10
The body too shall rise,
No more precarious passion's slave,
Nor error's sacrifice.

'Tis but a sleep—and Sion's king
Will call the many dead;
'Tis but a sleep—and then we sing
O'er dreams of sorrow fled.

Yes!—wintry winds have ceased to
blow,
And trembling leaves appear,
And Nature has her types to show
20
Throughout the varying year.

MY BIRTH-DAY.

Aldborough, December 24, 1778.

Through a dull tract of woe, of dread,

The toiling year has pass'd and fled:
And, lo! in sad and pensive strain,
I sing my birth-day date again.

Trembling and poor, I saw the light,
New waking from unconscious night;
Trembling and poor I still remain,
To meet unconscious night again.

Time in my pathway strews few
flowers,

10

To cheer or cheat the weary hours;
And those few strangers, dear indeed,
Are choked, are check'd, by many a
weed.

TO ELIZA.

Beccles, 1779.

The Hebrew king, with spleen
possest,
By David's harp was soothed to rest;
Yet, when the magic song was o'er,
The soft delusion charm'd no more;
The former fury fired the brain,
And every care return'd again.

But had he known Eliza's skill
To bless the sense and bind the will,
To bid the gloom of care retire,
10
And fan the flame of fond desire,
Remembrance then had kept the
strain,

And not a care return'd again.

LIFE.

Aldborough, 1779.

Think ye, the joys that fill our early
day,

Are the poor prelude to some full
repast?

Think you, they *promise*?—ah!
believe they *pay*;

The purest ever, they are oft the
last.

The jovial swain that yokes the
morning team,

And all the verdure of the field
enjoys,

See him, how languid, when the
noon-tide beam

Plays on his brow, and all his force
destroys.

So 'tis with us, when, love and
pleasure fled,

10

We at the summit of our hill arrive:
Lo! the gay lights of Youth are past—
are dead,

But what still deepening clouds of
Care survive!

THE SACRAMENT.

Aldborough, 1779.

O sacred gift of God to man,
A faith that looks above,
And sees the deep amazing plan
Of sanctifying love.

Thou dear and yet tremendous God,
Whose glory pride reviles;
How did'st thou change thy awful rod
To pard'ning grace and smiles!

Shut up with sin, with shame below,
10

I trust, this bondage past,
A great, a glorious change to know,
And to be bless'd at last.

I *do* believe, that, God of light!
Thou didst to earth descend,
With Satan and with Sin to fight—
Our great, our only friend.

I *know* thou did'st ordain for me,
Thy creature, bread and wine;
The depth of grace I cannot see,
20

But worship the design.

NIGHT.

Aldborough, 1779.

The sober stillness of the night
That fills the silent air,
And all that breathes along the shore,
Invite to solemn prayer.

Vouchsafe to me that spirit, Lord!

Which points the sacred way,
And let thy creatures here below
Instruct me how to pray.

FRAGMENT, WRITTEN AT MIDNIGHT.

Aldborough, 1779.

Oh, great Apollo! by whose equal
aid
The verse is written and the med'cine
made,
Shall thus a boaster, with his fourfold
powers,
In triumph scorn this sacred art of
ours?
Insulting quack! on thy sad business
go,
And land the stranger on this world of
woe.
Still I pass on, and now before me
find
The restless ocean, emblem of my
mind;
There wave on wave, here thought on
thought succeeds,
10
Their produce idle works and idle
weeds.
Dark is the prospect o'er the rolling
sea,
But not more dark than my sad views
to me;
Yet from the rising moon the light
beams dance

In troubled splendour o'er the wide
expanse;
So on my soul, whom cares and
troubles fright,
The Muse pours comfort in a flood of
light.—
Shine out, fair flood! until the day-
star flings
His brighter rays on all sublunar
things.

"Why in such haste? by all the
powers of wit,

20

I have against thee neither bond nor
writ.
If thou'rt a poet, now indulge the
flight
Of thy fine fancy in this dubious
light;
Cold, gloom, and silence shall assist
thy rhyme,
And all things meet to form the true
sublime."—

"Shall I, preserver deem'd around
the place,
With abject rhymes a doctor's name
disgrace?
Nor doctor solely, in the healing art
I'm all in all, and all in every part;
Wise Scotland's boast let that diploma
be

30

Which gave me right to claim the
golden fee.
Praise, then, I claim, to skilful
surgeon due,
For mine th' advice and operation too;

And, fearing all the vile
 compounding tribe,
I make myself the med'cines I
 prescribe.
Mine, too, the chemic art; and not a
 drop
Goes to my patients from a vulgar
 shop.
But chief my fame and fortune I
 command
From the rare skill of this obstetric
 hand:
This our chaste dames and prudent
 wives allow,
40
With her who calls me from thy
 wonder now."

MIDNIGHT.

A POEM.

[About 1779.]

Life is a Dream;—it steals upon the
Man,
He knows not how, but thinks himself
awake;
'Tis like a Bubble dancing on the
Deep,
That turns its glossy surface to the
Sun,
Catches a Rainbow-Vest, and
sparkles, proud
Of momentary Being—then it
breaks—
To some tremendous Billow drops a
prey,
And joins th' eternal Source, from
whence it sprang.

But ah! how dismal are the Dreams of
Care,

10

How much of Care do e'en the
happiest dream,
And some—hard Fortune theirs—of
Care alone.

Forgive me then, ye Wise, who seem
awake,

A Midnight Song, and let your
Censure sleep;
While Sorrow's Theme, and
Contemplation sad,
And Soul-dilating Fancy's pensive
Flight
Through Star-crown'd Gloom, I sing;
inspir'd by her,
Whom Virtue loves, whom Wisdom;
from whose Touch
Grief borrows Charm, and
Expectation sits
On the cold Bosom of the Tomb
serene.

20

Pale Melancholy she; nor softer
shines
The sabled Fair, her Votress, o'er the
Grave
Of the departed Lover; nor more mild
Sits yonder Moon's chaste ray upon
the Rock,
That, rising from the Bosom of the
Wave,
Flings Awe on Night. Thou Grave-
enamour'd Fair,
Attune my Song, and, languid as thou
art,
The Song shall please; and I will
paint the Dream
That Midnight gave thee, when with
wintry Wing
She swept thy Grot, and shook her
grisled Dew

30

Upon the frozen Garment of the pool;

And I will drown mine Eye in Tears
like thine,
And give my hollow Cheek a dewy
pale,
And dress me in the Livery of the
Dead;
And o'er their dreary Mansions walk
with thee;
Bidding a brief Farewell to little
Cares,
And Visionary Honour's frantic Sons,
Who feed on Adulation—let them
feed,
Till the full Soul disdains the
nauseous Trash,
And sickens with Repletion.—

I will
a
s
k
,

40

No Voice of Fame to spread abroad
my Song,
Nor Court Applause—Meonides had
Fame,
And with her poverty and pain and
Care,
Attendants on the Bard-deluding
Nymph,
Who mock the Babbling of her
loudest Note;
From Heaven he stole Description,
Nature's Key,
And loosen'd into Light her
Mysteries;

Ambition started when he sang of
War,
In Language all her own; and o'er his
Lyre
Hung Devastation, glowing at the
Sound,
50
And frantic for the Field; and there
Distress,
As if enamour'd of the Mighty Man,
With cruel Constancy repaid his
Muse;
And chiding Fame, by whispering to
the Soul
Domestic Ills, she [triumph'd] over
praise,
And, through th' untasted Plaudit of a
World,
Led the blind Bard in Sadness to the
Tomb.—

I ask no Mantuan Muse with silver
Wing
To bear me in some rapid even flight
Thro' distant Ages, tho' so sweet her
Bard
60
That yet the Traveller o'er each Hill
he sang,
Transported, [wanders], feeling
power divine
New-rising on his Soul to chain its
Cares.
Imagination turns the Tide of Time,
Unwinds each year, and, thro'
reviving Light,

And thro' the vandal Gloom of
Centuries drear,
And falling Rome works back, till
Nature smiles
And [Tityrus] sings anew; then laughs
each Scene,
And cloudless skies appear, and
Beachen Boughs
That Shade the [Nereids] listning
from their Streams.—

70

Nor Milton's muse I boast, to whom
the Morn
And all her rosy Train, and blazing
Noon,
Dipping his fiery Tresses in the
Stream
Of Pison, bank'd with Gold, and tepid
Eve,
Who in her soft recesses cradles
Thought,
And Worlds unsung pay Homage, and
the Suns,
From which the Light yet wings its
rapid Way,
Nor on the gloomy Bosom of the
Earth,
Sleeps from the Labour of its long
Career.

Nor feels my Bosom that ambiguous
Flame,

80

That now from Skies, and now from
central Gloom,

Shot devious o'er the fervent Page of
Young—
Young, Thought's Economist, who
wove reproof
Her [gloomiest] Vest, and yet a Vest
that shone;
Whose Invitation was assault: he
found
The World asleep and rent its drowsy
Ear.

Nor shares my Soul the soft
enchanting Stream,
The lambent Blaze, that [Thomson]
knew to blend
With his Creation; when he led the
Eye
Through the [year's Verdant] Gate,
the budding Spring;

90

And from the Willow o'er the tuneless
Stream,
And from the [Aspen] Rind, ere yet
her Leaf
Unfolding flicker'd, and from limpid
rills
Unmantled, cull'd Simplicity and
Grace.
Ah! who with mingled Modesty and
Love
So paints the bathing Maid; who so
describes
The new-mown Meadow, and the
new shorn Lamb?
Hard is the Task to strip the Muse's
Wing

Of Learning's plume, yet leave
enough to charm;

But this was thine! Grace beautify'd
thy page,

100

And led thy weary plowman from the
field,

And spread thy simple Foliage on the
Sod,

And hung thy ponderous Treasures on
the Bough,

And rov'd with thy Lavinia where the
Winds,

Rustling along the golden [Valley],
bear

The Grain just dropping from its
withering Glume.

And Winter too was thine! permit me
there

To bear a part, for mine are wintry
Thoughts.—

Nor dare I hope his Dignity and Fire,
Who led the soul thro' Nature, and
display'd

110

Imagination's pleasures to its Eye;

His the blest Task, a [gloomier] task
is mine;

His were the Smiles of Fortune, mine
her Frowns;

And when her Frowns and Smiles
shall charm alike,

At that dread Hour when the officious
Friend,

Stammering his Idiot-Comfort,
soothes amiss,

May Joys he painted dart upon the
Soul,
And, more than Fancy pointing to the
Skies,
Whisper a noble [Challenge] to the
Tomb.—
Tho' far behind my Song, my Hope
the same,

120

And not behind my Song; with
Vulgar souls,
Both sentenc'd to Contempt—
unletter'd pride—
Grins the pale Bard Disgrace alike to
him
Who soars above or labours in the
Clouds,
Who travels the sublime, or dives
profound
In the Wild Chaos of a School-boy's
Dream:
He, tyed to some poor Spot, where
e'en the rill
That owns him Lord untasted steals
away,
Hallows a Clod, and spurns
Immensity.

Ye gentle, nameless Bards, who float
a-down

130

The soft smoothe Stream of silver
poesy
And dream your pretty Dreams,
permit my Song
Cold inspiration from a Winter's
Night.

This is no Stanza'd Birth-Day of his
Grace,
Your patron; no sad Satire of the
Lord,
Your Foe; no Dunciad arm'd with
power,
To dive into the Depths of your
profound,
And with a vile assemblage gather'd
there
Whip the pale Moonshine from your
with'ring Bays.—

Is there, who sick of Pleasure's daily
Draught,

140

In repetition mawkish, or who tir'd
Thinks Life an Idiot's Tale? or whom
the Hand
Of [Disappointment] snatches from
the Vice
That waits on power? or who has lost
a friend,
And mingles with the dew that wets
his Tomb
A frequent Tear? or who by Nature's
mild
And melancholy Bias from the Womb
Was fashioned for the View of serious
Things,
And with the sober chiding of his
eye,
Freezes the [Current] within
Laughter's Cheek,

150

And awes the Voice of loud
Garrulity?

Let him approach, and I will tell my
Soul,
EUGENIO rises from the Grave, and
give
The Living Youth the Manners of my
Friend.
From the Enshrouded Tenant of the
Sod
I'll call the speaking Eye, the open
Heart,
The Tongue belov'd of Knowledge,
and the Form
That, could Deceit put on, Grey-
headed Guile,
That judges from his own embosom'd
Guilt,
Would yet be won, and lend a ductile
Ear.

160

Together, while the [Echo's] feeble
Sound,
Halting in frozen regions of the Air,
Mocks our slow Step, we from the
Mountain's Brow,
Will look around and court the Stars
of Heav'n
For as much Light as guides the
Miser's hand,
To grasp Delusion in her Guise of
Gold.—

The Morn is banish'd now, nor down
the Hill
Slopes the faint Shadow; now in
other Realms

She drinks the Dew that on the Vi'lets
Lip
Slept thro' the Night; and, with her
golden Dart

170

Bays the pale Moon, retiring from the
View.

In other Climates, from the rays of
Noon

Embower'd, Content lies sleeping;
and the palm

Drinking the fiery Stream, plays o'er
the Brow

Of shaded Weariness; and distant
now

Draws meek-ey'd Eve, with even
hand and slow,

The fringed Curtain of the setting
Sun,

Ting'd with the golden Splendour he
bequeaths,

The brief, but beauteous Legacy of
Light.

'Tis Midnight round us, canopied by
Dim

180

And twinkling Orbs that, gleaming
ghastly, gild

The restless Bosom of the briny
Deep.

The fiery Meteor in the foggy Air
Rides emulous of Fame and apes the
Star,

Till, in the Compass of a Maiden's
Wish,

It mocks the Eye, and sheds an
[igneous] Stream,

Within the bosom of Oblivion.

The Sea-Bird sleeps upon yon hoary
Cliff,
Unconscious of the Surge that grates
below
The frozen Shore; and Icy Friendship
binds,

190

As Danger Wretches Destitute of
Soul,
The wave-worn pebbles, which the
ebbing Tide,
Left with the Salt-Flood shining; dark
is now
The awfull Deep, and o'er the
Seaman's Grave
Rolls pouring, and forbids the lucid
Stream,
That silvers oft the way, a shining
Vest,
Sprung from the scaly people's putrid
Dead,
Hanging unheeded upon the Coral
Bough;
Or, as the Sage explains, from Stores
of Light
Imprison'd in the Bowels of the Deep,
200
And now escaping, when the parent
Sun
Flings [out] his fiery Noon with
Beam direct,
Upon the Glossy Surface of the wave.

Cold Vapour, falling on the putrid
Fen,

Condenses grey, and wraps with
glassy net
The wintry Fern, and throws along
the Heath
A Hoary Garment, nor less fair than
Spring
Drops on the Sod, of Texture near as
frail.
The icy Atoms thro' the burden'd Air
Shed Languor, and enwrap with
double Fleece

210

The Slumbering Fold; they cloathe
the knotted oak,
Stretching its naked arms, as if to
chide,
With [age's] stern and touching
Eloquence
The ruthless Skies for Summer's slow
return.
The winds that in converging
Furrows plough
The freezing pool, and shake the
[rattling] Wood,
Are arm'd with pain, and vitrified
their Wings.
In Winter's Livery sleeps this earthly
Scene—
And, save where Ocean rolls his
restless Flood,
The horizontal Eye grasps all things
grey.—

220

Eugenio, see—for thou shalt bear His
Name

Who sleeps beneath yon Sod, and
was my Friend—
The Grave o'er which I weep; and
give not thou
A Glance contemptuous to the grassy
Tomb;
For oft the vaulted Chambers of the
Dead,
Where Vanity amid the Mouldring
Scrolls
Of Genealogy and mingled Bones
Moves in a formal join'd Solemnity,
House wretched Remnants of
degenerate Man;
And oft the Green Turf's temporary
swell,

230

Sepulchring all that Virtue leaves the
Earth,
Stirs busy Memory to con o'er Deeds
Of high Renown in Heaven, the
Deeds of Love;
Which in th' eternal Records of the
Just,
Are written with an Angels pen, and
sung
With [Symphony] of Harp, and there
is Joy
And Gratulation with the Sons of
God.—

Alas! how chang'd the Verdure of this
[Scene],
How lost the Flowers, how winter-
struck the Blade!
No more the wild Thyme wings the
passing Gale

240

With Fragrance, nor invites the
 roving Bee
To taste its Sweets—and why this
 direful waste
Of Verdure? why this Vegetable
 Death?
Did all with Man commit mysterious
 Sin?
All in rebellion rise?—and tepid
 Meads,
And Lawns irriguous, and the
 blooming field,
And Hills, and Vallies, and intangling
 Woods,
Spurn GOD's Command and drink
 forbidden Dew?—

There was a Time, and Poets paint it
 fair,
(A wild, uncertain, musing, madning
 Race)

250

A Golden Age, when wealth was only
 Love:
Not even Fancy dreamt a Dream of
 Care,
The Sward was not—and Desolation
 slept
Till by a Crime awaken'd; not e'en
 Song
Wore Semblatude of War;—Eternal
 Spring
From the unfurrow'd Field the heavy
 Ear
Drew smiling, and the undistinguish'd
 year

Brought willing plenty forth, nor
scorn'd she then
A Common Call, enamour'd of her
plough.
The Clinging Vine prest down the
branching Elm
260
E'en to the Earth, and in her verdant
Lap
The tributary Grape, yet growing,
laid.
The simple Shepherd pip'd a silvan
Lay;
Or, while the Fair who charm'd him
prest beside,
The listning Vale sung hymeneal
Strains,
And woo'd with melting Themes a
ten years' Bride.

Eugenio, thus they taught; and after
this
A silver age arose, and hers the
Scenes
Not Gold could purchase now: when
Vice, afraid,
Hid his pale Visage in the womb of
Night,
270
And blush'd, if but a Moon-beam met
his Eye.
The Seasons alter'd, but the Change
was slow,
And Man forgot they chang'd; then
Care began
To plow his Furrows on the Brow of
Age,

And Falshood from the female Eye to
steal
The silent Tear; then prudence took
her Seat
Within the Soul, and reign'd in
Virtue's room.
Then Vanity, a Child, first learn'd to
bend
The ready Ear to tales of her own
praise;
Nor knew she yet the Gross of
Flattery,

280

But was, as Modesty is now, afraid
The Verse she lov'd should tickle her
too much.
Then young Ambition wore his
Russet Gown
Only in better Form, and Infant pomp
But saw his Garden smile in richer
Bloom,
And propt his Cottage with a taller
pier.—

Since these, dread Sorrow,
consequent of Sin
And foul Deformity, the Breast of
Man
And the Sad Surface of the Earth
enrobes.—

From the Dark Bosom of the Giant
Guilt

290

Leak'd all Things terrible, and Murder
first,

Who proul'd about the Earth and
groan'd for Blood;
And treachery, breaking up the
League of Friends
And rending Nature's Bond, a solemn
writ,
With Heaven's own Seal imprest: and
Avarice pale,
A Woolfish-Visag'd Fiend [and]
fang'd with Care.
Hence War, in all her guilty Majesty
In slow pomp riding o'er a
[threat'ned] Land,
With all the murderous Whispers of
the Camp
And shout of Ambush, castigates the
Night.—

300

And hence the Spirits from th' Abyss
of Hell,
That prey upon Mankind.—Eugenio,
give
Thy Soul's pure Eye, that sees
immortal things,
To the grim Spectres hovering in the
Air,
And we will mark the dreary Train
that vex
The mortal Man, and ride with
ghostly pomp,
Frowning upon the Midnight's murky
Wing.—

And who is he, from yonder antient
roof,

With Horror in his Eye, who steals
around
Each hollow Isle; and with a fierce
Embrace

310

Clasps the encrumbling ruin? 'Tis the
Foe

Of Men and Virtue, Eldest-born of
Night,

And Superstition call'd, a Giant fond
Of Dead-Men's Bones, and vagrant
[Rottenness],

Denied a Tomb; around him turns the
wheel,

And faggots blaze; and prizons, with
a Groan

Resounding loud, affright the Coward
Soul

From Reason's Law, and Nature's.
Hark! he Mourns

The fretted Abby where he reign'd
Secure,

With Indolence and Folly, social pair,

320

Nurses to shrine-enamour'd Zeal, who
built

The Cavern deep and dark, in which
he chain'd

The drowsy Nine; who yet at Morn or
Eve

Hail'd the arising or descending Sun

With gothic Note, harmoniously sad.

But now no more the Votive Maiden
clasps

The clay cold Saint, and mingles with
her Vow

The Heaven-reproaching Sigh; in
these blest realms
No more the power-compelling Bigot
plucks
The robe from Kings, and consecrates
the Tomb
330
That hides a Brother-Saint with Zeal-
enforc'd
And ceremonious Solemnity.—

O'er the Opaque of Nature and of
Night
Fair Truth rose smiling, with the
Heaven-born Art
That shews the Man his Fellow's
Thought imprest
Within the Volumes' varied Character,
Where to the wondering Eye the Soul
reveals
Her Store immortal. Hence a Bacon
shone
And Newton thro' the World, and
Light on Light
Pour'd on the human Breast, as when
of old,
340
From the Eternal Fountains of the
God,
Etherial Streams assail'd the groaning
Mass;
Then Chaos and the Sun's large Eye
survey'd
The first [distinguish'd] Forms of
mortal Things,
Till then in Congregate Confusion
hurl'd

Without a Station, and without a
Name.

Then Wit began, the younger-born of
Light,

To sport in hallow'd Cloysters, where
the arm

Of Superstition, red with slaughter'd
Foes,

Held high the Torch of Discord.
Stroke on Stroke

350

The smiling Boy repeated with his
Sword,

Sharp as the [Whirlwind's] Eye: yet
fear'd the fight,

And oft drew back, his silver wing
born down

By the foul Breath of Malice; till at
length

The Monster, rousing in Collected
Might,

Shook with his Roar the Earth, and at
the Sound

Red Tyranny, and Torture, with his
Limbs

Disjoint, and Ignorance that blows
the blast

For every Fire, prepar'd each bloody
Form

Of Death, and woo'd Destruction for
her Wheel.—

360

Then on the Father dead the dying
Son

Implor'd Heavn's Vengeance.
Execration shrill

Shot from the lurid Flame, and to the
 Skies
Sail'd with the Speed of Light. The
 Virgin's Eye
Met the grey Ruffian's, speaking
 Nature's Fear
Of Death and Pain: the Bigot's stern
 Reply,
Forbidding Hope, on the affrighted
 Soul
Flung Terror; till, in pity to the World,
Came Wisdom, whispering to the Ear
 of power,
And peace arose; and then the
 Brother wept
370
A Brother's Death, for distant seem'd
 his own.

And now the Spirit of uneasy Man,
That weds Extreme, and, ever on the
 Wing
For Wonder, baffles peace, high o'er
 the Cells
Of monkish Zeal, built with the base
 remains
The tow'ring Palace of Impiety.
There Jest profane, and Quibbling
 Mockery
Of all divine grew fast, as from the
 Earth
Enrich'd Ill-Weeds first spring; and
 here the Fools,
Of Laughter vain, [despis'd] the Voice
 of Truth,
380

And labour'd in the ludicrous
obscene.

To these succeed, and ah! with sad
Success,
A Sceptic herd more cool, and fair of
form,
And smoothe of Tongue and apt to
gloss a Lye
With Semblance strong of Nature and
the Truth;
They shine as Serpents, and as
Serpents bite,
With poison'd Tooth. Alas! the State
of Man,
Or doom'd the Victim of ungovern'd
Zeal,
Or led the Captive of unquiet Doubt!

And now, Eugenio, turn thine Eye,
and view

390

Yon Sire bare-headed to the ruthless
Wind,
And heedless of its Force. Upon the
Brow
Of yon huge shapeless Ruin, see, he
kneels,
And urges the departed Saints who
sleep,
To lend a Prayer; Repentance sent
him forth,
Her Son, but late th' adopted of her
dark
And gloomy Train. Ah! heavy weighs
the Crime

Of Murder on his Soul, and haunts
his Bed!

And, shrieking by, unseals the Eye of
Sleep,

Or scatters on the dark and restless
Mind

400

A thousand sooty Images of Death,
All horrible, and making Guilt's
repose

Like to the fearfull rest the Vessel
feels

In the dread Chasm of the
tempestuous Sea,

Arch'd by the Wave that pauses o'er
the Gulph,

While Sea-men urge their momentary
prayer,

And with Heart-shrinking Horror
view their Grave.

But hark, he speaks—attend the
Wretches Tale—

Spreading his Soul upon the Wings of
Night,

And seeking peace by giving Themes
of pain

To the rude Air:

410

"Come, all

ye

little

Ills,

Contempt, and poverty, and pale
Disease

With Dewy Front, and Envy-struck
 applause
That sickens on the World, and all of
 Care
That shed your daily Drops of bitter
 Dew
Upon the Brow of mortal Man, here
 strike,
That I may feel your force, and call it
 Joy,
So made when weigh'd against the
 Load that Guilt,
With leaden Hand, deposits on my
 Heart,
And when a momentary Comfort
 strives,
420
Lifted by hope, to spread her downy
 Wing,
Dispair, with Icy palm, arrests the
 Thought,
And nips the still-born Joy.—

 "To me no
 more
The Good I coveted brings Joy,
 brings peace,
Or stifles Truth's reproof that will be
 heard;
And did I think a base and sordid
 Heap
Had in it the Ability to pluck
The Sting from Guilt, and smother
 how it came
In the vile Knowledge that it came to
 me?

It was a Madman's Dream—O ye
good Gods!

430

If Envy knew her Mark, she would
beset

The poor Man's Table and the
Shepherd's Hut,

Unroof'd to the cold Winter's wildest
Blast,

Or the Embay'd Explorers of the
Deep,

At their still howling North; and
leave the Throne,

The Sceptre and the chested Gold to
plant

The Thorn of Care upon the Brow of
State,

On which Distraction drives his
plow-share deep,

And helps the Scythe of Time to
wrinkle there.—

"When shall I rest—O! let me, Night,
[besiege]

440

Thy drowsy Ear with wailing, but be
thou

[Tenacious] of my Guilt; and with her
Band

Let everlasting Silence Tye thy
Tongue;

The pent-up Woe now struggles to
o'er-leap

Murder's Discretion, and with fearfull
Speech

To free the Heart by telling Deeds of
Death:

[Death, Thought's] repose, whom the
 abhor'd of Man,
The base assassin, gives, and after
 longs
With Lover's Ardour to embrace, be
 mine,
And I will yield all Hope of After-
 Life,

450

All Saints have promis'd, and all
 poets sung—
Elysium water'd with immortal
 Streams,
And gifted with Eternity of peace,
Balm-breathing Fields, and Bowers
 of soft repose,
Walks amaranthine, and the pillowy
 Moss,
On Banks where Harpers, to celestial
 Strings
Attuning Nature, warble Notes of
 Love,
The Anodyne to all-rebellious
 Thought.—

"These, for Oblivion, I forego, with
 these
Foregoing pain eternal. Why then
 strive

460

From off Life's galling Load to elbow
 Care,
When Life and Care may be remov'd
 together?—
If I were not a very Coward Wretch,
A very Shadow of the Man, a thing

Made to feel Burdens of my Fear, and
drag

A hated Being on—'twere but to leap
From this rough [Eminence], and all
is done—

All that is done on this Side of the
Bier.

But there, surrounded with
impervious Fog,
Sits Doubt and Questions of the
Scenes to come;

470

Oh! Death, what moves beyond thee?

Fears and Hopes,
Dread and Confusion, Envy and
Disease,

Sleeping and waking Lusts, War-
moving Pride,

Windy Ambition, and slow Avarice,
Slay in thy path; within thy Sepulchre
Mould Dead Men's Bones, feed
worms, rust Epitaphs,

Sleep brainless Skulls in blest
Vacuity!

But what comes then? O for a
Seraph's Eye

That, piercing thro' the Mask of
Mortal Things,

Might scale the cloudless Battlements
of Light,

480

And in its Immaterial Robe detect
The Spirit, stript of the encumbering
Clay."—

Alas, Eugenio! Life, Deception's
Child,

Gives us her fairer Side, and gives no
more;
The rest we seek in our reflecting
View
Of Self, and Guilt's o'erheard
Soliloquy.
How smiles the World in pain, and
smiles believ'd!
Yon Wretch who, muffled in the Garb
of Night,
Gave her the Tortures of a weary
Soul,
Meets—may he not?—the jovial Eye
of Day,
490
With a depictur'd Laughter in his
Cheek,
Or the smoothe Visage of habitual
Ease?

How have I mourn'd my Lot, as if the
Fates
Cull'd me, the vilest from their pitchy
Stores
That ere in Mortal Bosom planted
Woe,
And pain'd the Care-fraught Soul! I'll
grieve no more,
But, take it patient with a sober hope,
That soon Distress may vary his
assault,
Or soon the Welcome Tomb exclude
Distress.—

But see another Son of Night and
Care,
500

A Shepherd watching o'er his frozen
Fold,
Himself benumb'd and murmuring at
his Fate.
Sigh not, fond Man; thy bosom only
feels
The gentler Blows of Nature, and
receives
The Common Visit of Calamity.

JUVENILIA

[A FAREWELL.]

[1779?]

The hour arrived! I sigh'd and said,
How soon the happiest hours are
fled!

On wings of down they lately flew,
But then their moments pass'd with
you;

And still with you could I but be,
On downy wings they'd always
flee.

Say, did you not, the way you
went,

Feel the soft balm of gay content?

Say, did you not all pleasures find,
10

Of which you left so few behind?

I think you did: for well I know

My parting prayer would make it
so.

"May she," I said, "life's choicest
goods partake;

Those, late in life, for nobler still
forsake—

The bliss of one, th' esteem'd of many
live,

With all that Friendship would, and
all that Love can give!"

TIME.

London, February, 1780.

"The clock struck one! we take no
thought of Time,"

Wrapt up in Night, and meditating
rhyme.

All big with vision, we despise the
powers

That vulgar beings link to days and
hours—

Those vile, mechanic things that rule
our hearts,

And cut our lives in momentary parts.

That speech of Time was Wisdom's
gift, said Young.

Ah, Doctor! better, Time would hold
his tongue:

What serves the clock? "To warn the
careless crew,

10

How much in little space they have to
do;

To bid the busy world resign their
breath,

And beat each moment a soft call for
death—

To give it, then, a tongue, was wise in
man."

Support the assertion, Doctor, if you
can.

It tells the ruffian when his comrades
wait;

It calls the duns to crowd my hapless
gate;

It tells my heart the paralysing tale

Of hours to come, when Misery must
prevail.

THE CHOICE.

London, February, 1780.

What vulgar title thus salutes the eye,
The schoolboy's first attempt at
poesy?
The long-worn theme of every
humbler Muse,
For wits to scorn and nurses to
peruse;
The dull description of a scribbler's
brain,
And sigh'd-for wealth, for which he
sighs in vain;
A glowing chart of fairy-land estate,
Romantic scenes, and visions out of
date,
Clear skies, clear streams, soft banks,
and sober bowers,
10
Deer, whimpering brooks, and wind-
perfuming flowers?

Not thus! too long have I in fancy
wove
My slender webs of wealth, and
peace, and love;
Have dream'd of plenty, in the midst
of want,
And sought, by Hope, what Hope can
never grant;
Been fool'd by wishes, and still
wish'd again,
And loved the flattery, while I knew it
vain!
"Gain by the Muse!"—alas! thou
might'st as soon

Pluck gain (as Percy honour) from
the moon;

As soon grow rich by ministerial
nods,

20

As soon divine by dreaming of the
gods,

As soon succeed by telling ladies
truth,

Or preaching moral documents to
youth;

To as much purpose, mortal! thy
desires,

As Tully's flourishes to country
squires;

As simple truth within St. James's
state,

Or the soft lute in shrill-tongued
Billingsgate.

"Gain by the Muse!" alas,
preposterous hope!

Who ever gain'd by poetry—but
Pope?

And what art thou? No St. John takes
thy part;

30

No potent Dean commends thy head
or heart!

What gain'st thou but the praises of
the poor?

They bribe no milkman to thy lofty
door,

They wipe no scrawl from thy
increasing score.

What did the Muse, or Fame, for
Dryden, say?

What for poor Butler? what for
honest Gay?

For Thomson, what? or what to
Savage give?

Or how did Johnson—how did Otway
live?

Like thee, dependent on to-morrow's
good,

Their thin revénue never understood;

40

Like thee, elate at what thou canst not
know;

Like thee, repining at each puny
blow;

Like thee they lived, each dream of
Hope to mock,

Upon their wits—but with a larger
stock.

No, if for food thy unambitious
pray'r,

With supple acts to supple minds
repair;

Learn of the base in soft grimace to
deal,

And deck thee with the livery
genteel;

Or trim the wherry, or the flail invite,

Draw teeth, or any viler thing but
write.

50

Writers, whom once th' astonish'd
vulgar saw

Give nations language, and great
cities law;

Whom gods, they said—and surely
gods—inspired,

Whom emp'rors honour'd, and the
world admired,
Now common grown, they awe
mankind no more,
But vassals are, who judges were
before.
Blockheads on wits their little talents
waste,
As files gnaw metal that they cannot
taste;
Though still some good the trial may
produce,
To shape the useful to a nobler use.

60

Some few of these a statue and a
stone
Has Fame decreed—but deals out
bread to none.
Unhappy art! decreed thine owner's
curse,
Vile diagnostic of consumptive purse;
Members by bribes, and ministers by
lies,
Gamesters by luck, by courage
soldiers rise:
Beaux by the outside of their heads
may win,
And wily sergeants by the craft
within:
Who but the race, by Fancy's demon
led,
Starve by the means they use to gain
their bread?

70

Oft have I read, and, reading,
mourn'd the fate
Of garret-bard, and his unpitied mate;

Of children stinted in their daily
meal,—
The joke of wealthier wits who could
not feel.
Portentous spoke that pity in my
breast,
And pleaded self—who ever pleads
the best.
No! thank my stars, my misery's all
my own—
To friends, to family, to foes
unknown;
Who hates my verse, and damns the
mean design,
Shall wound no peace—shall grieve
no heart but mine.

80

One trial past, let sober Reason
speak:
Here shall we rest, or shall we further
seek?
Rest here, if our relenting stars ordain
A placid harbour from the stormy
main;
Or, that denied, the fond
remembrance weep,
And sink, forgotten, in the mighty
deep.

[A HUMBLE INVOCATION.]

[1780.]

When summer's tribe, her rosy tribe,
are fled,

And drooping beauty mourns her
blossoms shed,
Some humbler sweet may cheer the
pensive swain,
And simpler beauties deck the
withering plain.
And thus, when Verse her wintry
prospect weeps,
When Pope is gone, and mighty
Milton sleeps,
When Gray in lofty lines has ceased
to soar,
And gentle Goldsmith charms the
town no more,
An humbler Bard the widow'd Muse
invites,
10
Who led by hope and inclination
writes;
With half their art, he tries the soul to
move,
And swell the softer strain with
themes of love.

[FROM AN EPISTLE TO MIRA.]

[April, 1780.]

* * * * *
* * * *

Of substance I've thought, and the
varied disputes
On the nature of man and the notions
of brutes;
Of systems confuted, and systems
explain'd;

Of science disputed, and tenets
 maintain'd.
 These, and such speculations on these
 kind of things,
 Have robb'd my poor Muse of her
 plume and her wings;
 Consumed the phlogiston you used to
 admire,
 The spirit extracted, extinguish'd the
 fire;
 Let out all the ether, so pure and
 refined,
 10
 And left but a mere *caput mortuum*
 behind.

* * * * * * * * *
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**[CONCLUDING LINES OF AN EPISTLE TO PRINCE
 WILLIAM HENRY, AFTERWARDS KING WILLIAM IV.]**

[April, 1780.]

* * * * * * * * *
 * * *

Who thus aspiring sings, would'st
 thou explore?
 A Bard replies, who ne'er assumed
 before—
 One taught in hard affliction's school
 to bear
 Life's ills, where every lesson costs a
 tear;
 Who sees from thence the proper
 point of view,

What the wise heed not, and the weak
pursue.

* * * * *
* * *

"And now farewell," the drooping
Muse exclaims;
She lothly leaves thee to the shock of
war,
And, fondly dwelling on her princely
tar,

10

Wishes the noblest good her Harry's
share,
Without her misery and without her
care.

For, ah! unknown to thee, a rueful
train,
Her hapless children sigh, and sigh in
vain;

A numerous band, denied the boon to
die,
Half-starved, half-fed by fits of
charity.

Unknown to thee! and yet, perhaps,
thy ear

Has chanced each sad, amusing tale
to hear,

How some, like Budgell, madly sank
for ease;

How some, like Savage, sicken'd by
degrees;

20

How a pale crew, like helpless Otway,
shed

The proud, big tear on song-extorted
bread;

Or knew, like Goldsmith, some would
stoop to choose
Contempt, and for the mortar quit the
Muse.

One of this train—and of these
wretches one—
Slave to the Muses, and to Misery
son—

Now prays the Father of all Fates to
shed

On Henry, laurels, on his poet, bread!
Unhappy art! decreed thine owner's
curse;

Vile diagnostic of consumptive purse;
30

Still shall thy fatal force my soul
perplex,

And every friend, and every brother
vex—

Each fond companion?—No, I thank
my God.

There rests my torment—there is
hung the rod.

To friend, to fame, to family
unknown,

Sour disappointments frown on me
alone.

Who hates my song, and damns the
poor design,

Shall wound no peace—shall grieve
no heart but mine!

Pardon, sweet Prince! the thoughts
that will intrude,

For want is absent, and dejection
rude.

40

Methinks I hear, amid the shouts of
Fame,
Each jolly victor hail my Henry's
name;
And Heaven forbid that, in that jovial
day,
One British bard should grieve when
all are gay.
No! let him find his country has
redress,
And bid adieu to every fond distress;
Or, touch'd too near, from joyful
scenes retire,
Scorn to complain, and with one sigh
expire!

[DRIFTING.]

[May, 1780.]

Like some poor bark on the rough
ocean tost,
My rudder broken, and my compass
lost,
My sails the coarsest, and too thin to
last,
Pelted by rains, and bare to many a
blast,
My anchor, Hope, scarce fix'd enough
to stay
Where the strong current Grief
sweeps all away,
I sail along, unknowing how to steer,
Where quicksands lie and frowning
rocks appear.

Life's ocean teems with foes to my
frail bark,

10

The rapid sword-fish, and the
rav'ning shark,

Where torpid things crawl forth in
splendid shell,

And knaves and fools and sycophants
live well.

What have I left in such tempestuous
sea?

No Tritons shield, no Naiads shelter
me!

A gloomy Muse, in Mira's absence,
hears

My plaintive prayer, and sheds
consoling tears—

Some fairer prospect, though at
distance, brings,

Soothes me with song, and flatters as
she sings.

* * * * *
* * *

TO THE RIGHT HONOURABLE THE EARL OF SHELBURNE.

[June, 1780.]

Ah! SHELBURNE, blest with all that's
good or great

T'adorn a rich, or save a sinking,
state—

If public Ills engross not all thy care,
Let private Woe assail a patriot's ear;

Pity confined, but not less warm,
impart,
And unresisted win thy noble heart;
Nor deem I rob thy soul of Britain's
share,
Because I hope to have some interest
there.
Still wilt thou shine on all a fostering
sun,

10

Though with more fav'ring beams
enlight'ning one;
As Heaven will oft make some more
amply blest,
Yet still in general bounty feeds the
rest.
Oh, hear the Virtue thou reverest
plead;
She'll swell thy breast, and there
applaud the deed.
She bids thy thoughts one hour from
greatness stray,
And leads thee on to fame a shorter
way;
Where, if no withering laurel's thy
reward,
There's shouting Conscience, and a
grateful Bard;
A bard untrained in all but misery's
school,

20

Who never bribed a knave or praised
a fool.
'Tis Glory prompts, and, as thou
read'st, attend;
She dictates pity, and becomes my
friend;

She bids each cold and dull reflection
flee,
And yields her Shelburne to distress
and me!

AN EPISTLE TO A FRIEND.

[June, 1780.]

Why, true, thou say'st the fools, at
Court denied,
Growl vengeance—and then take the
other side;
The unfed flatterer borrows satire's
power,
As sweets unshelter'd run to vapid
sour.
But thou, the counsel to my closest
thought,
Beheld'st it ne'er in fulsome stanzas
wrought.
The Muse I court ne'er fawn'd on
venal souls,
Whom suppliants angle, and poor
praise controls;
She, yet unskill'd in all but fancy's
dream,
10
Sang to the woods, and Mira was her
theme.
But, when she sees a titled nothing
stand
The ready cipher of a trembling
land—
Not of that simple kind that, placed
alone,

Are useless, harmless things, and
threaten none;
But those which, join'd to figures,
well express
A strengthen'd tribe that amplify
distress,
Grow in proportion to their number
great,
And help each other in the ranks of
state—
When this and more the pensive
Muses see,

20

They leave the vales and willing
nymphs to thee;
To Court on wings of agile anger
speed,
And paint to freedom's sons each
guileful deed.
Hence rascals teach the virtues they
detest,
And fright base action from sin's
wavering breast;
For, though the Knave may scorn the
Muse's arts,
Her sting may haply pierce more
timid hearts.
Some, though they wish it, are not
steel'd enough,
Nor is each would-be villain
conscience-proof.

And what, my friend, is left my song
besides?

30

No school-day wealth that roll'd in
silver tides,

No dreams of hope that won my early
will,
Nor love, that pain'd in temporary
thrill;
No gold to deck my pleasure-scorn'd
abode,
No friend to whisper peace, to give
me food.
Poor to the World, I'd yet not live in
vain,
But show its lords their hearts, and
my disdain.

Yet shall not Satire all my song
engage
In indiscriminate and idle rage;
True praise, where Virtue prompts,
shall gild each line,

40

And long—if Vanity deceives not—
shine.
For, though in harsher strains, the
strains of woe,
And unadorn'd my heart-felt murmurs
flow,
Yet time shall be when this thine
humbled friend
Shall to more lofty heights his notes
extend.
A Man—for other title were too
poor—
Such as 'twere almost virtue to adore,
He shall the ill that loads my heart
exhale,
As the sun vapours from the dew-
press'd vale;

Himself uninjuring, shall new warmth
infuse,

50

And call to blossom every want-
nipp'd Muse.

Then shall my grateful strains his ear
rejoice,

His name harmonious thrill'd on
Mira's voice;

Round the reviving bays new sweets
shall spring,

And SHELBURNE'S fame through
laughing valleys ring.

THE CANDIDATE;

A POETICAL EPISTLE TO THE AUTHORS OF THE
MONTHLY REVIEW.

*Multa quidem nobis facimus mala
sæpe poetæ,
(Ut vineta egomet cædam mea) cum
tibi librum
Sollicito damus, aut fesso, &c.*
HOR. Lib. ii.
Ep. I.

[London, 1780.]

AN INTRODUCTORY ADDRESS OF THE AUTHOR TO HIS POEMS.

Ye idler things, that soothed my
hours of care,
Where would ye wander, triflers, tell
me where?
As maids neglected, do ye fondly
dote
On the fair type, or the embroider'd
coat;
Detest my modest shelf, and long to
fly,
Where princely POPES and mighty
MILTONS lie?
Taught but to sing, and that in simple
style,

Of Lycia's lip, and Musidora's smile,
Go, then! and taste a yet unfelt
distress,

10

The fear that guards the captivating
press;

Whose maddening region should ye
once explore,

No refuge yields my tongueless
mansion more.

But thus ye'll grieve, Ambition's
plumage stript,

"Ah, would to Heaven, we'd died in
manuscript!"

Your unsoil'd page each yawning wit
shall flee

—For few will read, and none admire
like me.—

Its place, where spiders silent bards
enrobe.

Squeezed betwixt Cibber's Odes and
Blackmore's Job;

Where froth and mud, that varnish
and deform,

20

Feed the lean critic and the fattening
worm;

Then sent disgraced—the unpaid
printer's bane—

To mad Moorfields, or sober
Chancery Lane,

On dirty stalls I see your hopes
expire,

Vex'd by the grin of your unheeded
sire,

Who half reluctant has his care
resign'd,

Like a teased parent, and is rashly
kind.

Yet rush not all, but let some scout
go forth.
View the strange land, and tell us of
its worth;
And, should he there barbarian usage
meet,

30

The patriot scrap shall warn us to
retreat.

And thou, the first of thy eccentric
race,
A forward imp, go, search the
dangerous place,
Where Fame's eternal blossoms tempt
each bard,
Though dragon-wits there keep
eternal guard.
Hope not unhurt the golden spoil to
seize,
The Muses yield, as the Hesperides;
Who bribes the guardian, all his
labour's done,
For every maid is willing to be won.

Before the lords of verse a
suppliant stand,

40

And beg our passage through the
fairy land:
Beg more—to search for sweets each
blooming field,
And crop the blossoms woods and
valleys yield;

To snatch the tints that beam on
Fancy's bow,
And feel the fires on Genius' wings
that glow;
Praise without meanness, without
flattery stoop,
Soothe without fear, and without
trembling hope.

TO THE READER.

THE following Poem being itself of an introductory nature, its author supposes it can require but little preface.

It is published with a view of obtaining the opinion of the candid and judicious reader on the merits of the writer as a poet; very few, he apprehends, being in such cases sufficiently impartial to decide for themselves.

It is addressed to the Authors of the Monthly Review, as to critics of acknowledged merit; an acquaintance with whose labours has afforded the writer of this Epistle a reason for directing it to them in particular, and, he presumes, will yield to others a just and sufficient plea for the preference.

Familiar with disappointment, he shall not be much surprised to find he has mistaken his talent. However, if not egregiously the dupe of his vanity, he promises to his readers some entertainment, and is assured that, however little in the ensuing Poem is worthy of applause, there is yet less that merits contempt.

TO THE AUTHORS OF THE MONTHLY REVIEW.

The pious pilot, whom the Gods
provide,
Through the rough seas the shatter'd
bark to guide,

Trusts not alone his knowledge of the
deep,
Its rocks that threaten, and its sands
that sleep;
But, whilst with nicest skill he steers
his way,
The guardian Tritons hear their
favourite pray.
Hence borne his vows to Neptune's
coral dome,
The God relents, and shuts each gulfy
tomb.

Thus as on fatal floods to fame I
steer,
10
I dread the storm, that ever rattles
here;
Nor think enough, that long my
yielding soul
Has felt the Muse's soft, but strong,
control;
Nor think enough that manly strength
and ease,
Such as have pleased a friend, will
strangers please;
But, suppliant, to the critic's throne I
bow,
Here burn my incense, and here pay
my vow;
That censure hush'd, may every blast
give o'er,
And the lash'd coxcomb hiss
contempt no more.
And ye, whom authors dread or dare
in vain,

Affecting modest hopes or poor
disdain,
Receive a bard, who, neither mad nor
mean,
Despises each extreme, and sails
between;
Who fears; but has, amid his fears
confess'd,
The conscious virtue of a Muse
oppressed;
A Muse in changing times and
stations nursed,
By nature honour'd and by fortune
cursed.

No servile strain of abject hope she
brings,
Nor soars presumptuous, with
unwearied wings;
But, pruned for flight—the future all
her care—

30

Would know her strength, and, if not
strong, forbear.

The supple slave to regal pomp
bows down,
Prostrate to power, and cringing to a
crown;
The bolder villain spurns a decent
awe,
Tramples on rule, and breaks through
every law;
But he whose soul on honest truth
relies,
Nor meanly flatters power, nor madly
flies.

Thus timid authors bear an abject
mind,
And plead for mercy they but seldom
find.

Some, as the desperate to the halter
run,

40

Boldly deride the fate they cannot
shun;

But such there are, whose minds, not
taught to stoop,

Yet hope for fame, and dare avow
their hope;

Who neither brave the judges of their
cause,

Nor beg in soothing strains a brief
applause.

And such I'd be;—and, ere my fate is
past,

Ere clear'd with honour, or with
culprits cast,

Humbly at Learning's bar I'll state my
case,

And welcome then distinction or
disgrace!

When in the man the flights of
fancy reign,

50

Rule in the heart, or revel in the
brain,

As busy Thought her wild creation
apes,

And hangs delighted o'er her varying
shapes,

It asks a judgment, weighty and
discreet,

To know where wisdom prompts, and
where conceit;
Alike their draughts to every
scribbler's mind
(Blind to their faults as to their
danger blind)—
We write enraptured, and we write in
haste,
Dream idle dreams, and call them
things of taste;
Improvement trace in every paltry
line,

60

And see, transported, every dull
design;
Are seldom cautious, all advice
detest,
And ever think our own opinions
best;
Nor shows my Muse a muse-like
spirit here,
Who bids me pause, before I
persevere.

But she—who shrinks, while
meditating flight
In the wide way, whose bounds
delude her sight,
Yet tired in her own mazes still to
roam,
And cull poor banquets for the soul at
home—
Would, ere she ventures, ponder on
the way,

70

Lest dangers yet unthought-of flight
betray;

Lest her Icarian wing, by wits
unplumed,
Be robb'd of all the honours she
assumed,
And Dulness swell—a black and
dismal sea,
Gaping her grave, while censures
madden me.

Such was his fate, who flew too
near the sun,
Shot far beyond his strength, and was
undone;
Such is his fate, who creeping at the
shore
The billow sweeps him, and he's
found no more.
Oh! for some God, to bear my
fortunes fair

80

Midway betwixt presumption and
despair!

"Has then some friendly critic's
former blow
Taught thee a prudence authors
seldom know?"

Not so! their anger and their love
untried,
A wo-taught prudence deigns to tend
my side:
Life's hopes ill-spel'd, the Muse's
hopes grow poor,
And though they flatter, yet they
charm no more;

Experience points where lurking
dangers lay,
And as I run, throws caution in my
way.

There was a night, when wintry
winds did rage,

90

Hard by a ruin'd pile I met a sage;
Resembling him the time-struck place
appear'd,
Hollow its voice, and moss its
spreading beard;
Whose fate-lopp'd brow, the bat's and
beetle's dome,
Shook, as the hunted owl flew
hooting home.
His breast was bronzed by many an
eastern blast,
And fourscore winters seem'd he to
have past;
His thread-bare coat the supple osier
bound,
And with slow feet he press'd the
sodden ground;
Where, as he heard the wild-wing'd
Eurus blow,

100

He shook, from locks as white,
December's snow;
Inured to storm, his soul ne'er bid it
cease,
But lock'd within him meditated
peace.

"Father," I said—for silver hairs
inspire,

And oft I call the bending peasant
Sire—

"Tell me, as here beneath this ivy
bower,

That works fantastic round its
trembling tower,

We hear Heaven's guilt-alarming
thunders roar,

Tell me the pains and pleasures of the
poor;

For Hope, just spent, requires a sad
adieu,

110

And Fear acquaints me I shall live
with you.

"There was a time when, by
Delusion led,

A scene of sacred bliss around me
spread;

On Hope's, as Pisgah's lofty top, I
stood,

And saw my Canaan there, my
promised good.

A thousand scenes of joy the clime
bestow'd,

And wine and oil through vision's
valleys flow'd;

As Moses his, I call'd my prospect
bless'd,

And gazed upon the good I ne'er
possess'd:

On this side Jordan doom'd by fate to
stand,

120

Whilst happier Joshuas win the
promised land."

"Son," said the Sage—"be this thy
care suppressed;
The state the Gods shall choose thee
is the best:
Rich if thou art, they ask thy praises
more,
And would thy patience, when they
make thee poor.
But other thoughts within thy bosom
reign,
And other subjects vex thy busy
brain;
Poetic wreaths thy vainer dreams
excite,
And thy sad stars have destined thee
to write.
Then, since that task the ruthless fates
decree,
130
Take a few precepts from the Gods
and me!

"Be not too eager in the arduous
Chase:
Who pants for triumph seldom wins
the race;
Venture not all, but wisely hoard thy
worth,
And let thy labours one by one go
forth;
Some happier scrap capricious wits
may find
On a fair day, and be profusely kind;
Which, buried in the rubbish of a
throng,
Had pleased as little as a new-year's
song,

Or lover's verse, that cloy'd with
nauseous sweet,

140

Or birth-day ode, that ran on ill-pair'd
feet.

Merit not always—Fortune feeds the
bard,

And, as the whim inclines, bestows
reward;

None without wit, nor with it
numbers gain;

To please is hard, but none shall
please in vain.

As a coy mistress is the humour'd
town,

Loth every lover with success to
crown;

He who would win must every effort
try,

Sail in the mode, and to the fashion
fly;

Must gay or grave to every humour
dress,

150

And watch the lucky Moment of
Success;

That caught, no more his eager hopes
are crost;

But vain are Wit and Love, when that
is lost."

Thus said the God; }
for now a }
God he
grew,

His white locks changing to a
golden hue,

And from his shoulders hung
a mantle azure-blue.
His softening eyes the winning charm
disclosed
Of dove-like Delia, when her doubts
reposed;
Mira's alone a softer lustre bear,
When wo beguiles them of an angel's
tear;

160

Beauteous and young the smiling
phantom stood,
Then sought on airy wing his blest
abode.

Ah! truth distasteful in poetic
theme,
Why is the Muse compell'd to own
her dream?
Whilst forward wits had sworn to
every line,
I only wish to make its moral mine.

Say then, O ye who tell how
authors speed,
May Hope indulge her flight, and I
succeed?
Say, shall my name, to future song
prefix'd,
Be with the meanest of the tuneful
mix'd?

170

Shall my soft strains the modest maid
engage,
My graver numbers move the silver'd
sage,

My tender themes delight the lover's
heart,
And comfort to the poor my solemn
songs impart?

For O! thou, Hope's—thou,
Thought's eternal King,
Who gav'st them power to charm, and
me to sing,
Chief to thy praise my willing
numbers soar,
And in my happier transports I adore;
Mercy thy softest attribute proclaim,
Thyself in abstract, thy more lovely
name;

180

That flings o'er all my grief a
cheering ray,
As the foil moon-beam gilds the
watery way.
And then too, Love, my soul's
resistless lord,
Shall many a gentle, generous strain
afford,
To all the soil of sooty passions blind,
Pure as embracing angels, and as
kind;
Our Mira's name in future times shall
shine,
And—though the harshest—
Shepherds envy mine.

Then let me (pleasing task!)
however hard,
Join, as of old, the prophet and the
bard;

190

If not, ah! shield me from the dire
disgrace
That haunts the wild and visionary
race;
Let me not draw my lengthen'd lines
along,
And tire in untamed infamy of song;
Lest, in some dismal Dunciad's future
page,
I stand the CIBBER of this tuneless
age;
Lest, if another POPE th' indulgent
skies
Should give, inspired by all their
deities,
My luckless name, in his immortal
strain,
Should, blasted, brand me as a second
Cain;
200
Doom'd in that song to live against
my will,
Whom all must scorn, and yet whom
none could kill.

The youth, resisted by the maiden's
art,
Persists, and time subdues her
kindling heart;
To strong entreaty yields the widow's
vow,
As mighty walls to bold besiegers
bow;
Repeated prayers draw bounty from
the sky,
And heaven is won by importunity.

Ours, a projecting tribe, pursue in
vain,
In tedious trials, an uncertain gain;
210
Madly plunge on through every
hope's defeat,
And with our ruin only, find the
cheat.

"And why then seek that luckless
doom to share?"
Who, I?—To shun it is my only care.

I grant it true, that others better tell
Of mighty WOLFE, who conquer'd as
he fell^[12];
Of heroes born their threaten'd realms
to save,
Whom Fame anoints, and Envy tends
whose grave;
Of crimson'd fields, where Fate, in
dire array,
Gives to the breathless the short-
breathing clay;

220
Ours, a young train, by humbler
fountains dream,
Nor taste presumptuous the Pierian
stream;
When Rodney's triumph comes on
eagle-wing,
We hail the victor, whom we fear to
sing;
Nor tell we how each hostile chief
goes on,
The luckless Lee, or wary
Washington;

How Spanish bombast blusters—they
were beat,
And French politeness dulcifies—
defeat.
My modest Muse forbears to speak of
kings,
Lest fainting stanzas blast the name
she sings;

230

For who, the tenant of the beechen
shade,
Dares the big thought in regal breasts
pervade?
Or search his soul, whom each too-
favouring God
Gives to delight in plunder, pomp,
and blood?
No; let me, free from Cupid's frolic
round,
Rejoice, or more rejoice by Cupid
bound;
Of laughing girls in smiling couplets
tell,
And paint the dark-brow'd grove,
where wood-nymphs dwell,
Who bid invading youths their
vengeance feel,
And pierce the votive hearts they
mean to heal.

240

Such were the themes I knew in
school-day ease,
When first the moral magic learn'd to
please;
Ere Judgment told how transports
warm'd the breast,

Transported Fancy there her stores
imprest;
The soul in varied raptures learn'd to
fly,
Felt all their force, and never
question'd why.
No idle doubts could then her peace
molest;
She found delight, and left to heaven
the rest.
Soft joys in Evening's placid shades
were born,
And where sweet fragrance wing'd
the balmy morn.

250

When the wild thought roved vision's
circuit o'er,
And caught the raptures, caught, alas!
no more:
No care did then a dull attention ask,
For study pleased, and that was every
task;
No guilty dreams stalk'd that heaven-
favour'd round,
Heaven-guarded too; no Envy
entrance found;
Nor numerous wants, that vex
advancing age,
Nor Flattery's silver'd tale, nor
Sorrow's sage;
Frugal Affliction kept each growing
dart,
T' o'erwhelm in future days the
bleeding heart.

260

No sceptic art veil'd Pride in Truth's
disguise,

But prayer, unsoil'd of doubt,
besieged the skies;
Ambition, avarice, care, to man
retired,
Nor came desires more quick, than
joys desired.

A summer morn there was, and
passing fair;
Still was the breeze, and health
perfumed the air;
The glowing east in crimson'd
splendour shone,
What time the eye just marks the
pallid moon;
Vi'let-wing'd Zephyr fann'd each
opening flower,
And brush'd from fragrant cups the
limpid shower;

270

A distant huntsman }
fill'd his
cheerful horn,
The vivid dew hung trembling
on the thorn,
And mists, like creeping
rocks, arose to meet the morn.
Huge giant shadows spread along the
plain,
Or shot from towering rocks o'er half
the main.
There to the slumbering bark the
gentle tide
Stole soft, and faintly beat against its
side;
Such is that sound, which fond
designs convey,

When, true to love, the damsel speeds
away;

The sails, unshaken, hung aloft
unfurl'd,

280

And, simpering nigh, the languid
current curl'd;

A crumbling ruin, once a city's pride,
The well-pleased eye through
withering oaks descried,

Where Sadness, gazing on time's
ravage, hung,

And Silence to Destruction's trophy
clung—

Save that, as morning songsters
swell'd their lays,

Awaken'd Echo humm'd repeated
praise.

The lark on quavering }
pinion woo'd }
the day,

Less towering linnets fill'd the
vocal spray,

And song-invited pilgrims
rose to pray.

290

Here at a pine-prest hill's embroider'd
base

I stood, and hail'd the Genius of the
place.

Then was it doom'd by fate, my idle
heart,

Soften'd by Nature, gave access to
Art;

The Muse approach'd, her syren-song
I heard,

Her magic felt, and all her charms
revered:
E'er since she rules in absolute
control,
And Mira only dearer to my soul.
Ah! tell me not these empty joys to
fly;
If they deceive, I would deluded die;
300
To the fond themes my heart so early
wed,
So soon in life to blooming visions
led,
So prone to run the vague uncertain
course—
'Tis more than death to think of a
divorce.

What wills the poet of the
favouring gods,
Led to their shrine, and blest in their
abodes^[13]?
What, when he fills the glass, and to
each youth
Names his loved maid, and glories in
his truth?
Not India's spoils, the splendid
nabob's pride,
Not the full trade of Hermes' own
Cheapside,
310
Nor gold itself, nor all the Ganges
laves,
Or shrouds, well shrouded in his
sacred waves;
Nor gorgeous vessels deck'd in trim
array,

Which the more noble Thames bears
far away.
Let those whose nod makes sooty
subjects flee,
Hack with blunt steel the savory
callipee;
Let those whose ill-used wealth their
country fly,
Virtue-scorn'd wines from hostile
France to buy:
Favour'd by fate, let such in joy
appear,
Their smuggled cargoes landed thrice
a year;
320
Disdaining these, for simpler food I'll
look,
And crop my beverage at the mantled
brook.

O Virtue! brighter than the noon-
tide ray,
My humble prayers with sacred joys
repay!
Health to my limbs may the kind
Gods impart,
And thy fair form delight my yielding
heart!
Grant me to shun each vile inglorious
road,
To see thy way, and trace each moral
good;
If more—let Wisdom's sons my page
peruse,
And decent credit deck my modest
Muse.

330

Nor deem it pride that prophecies,
my song
Shall please the sons of taste, and
please them long.
Say, ye, to whom my Muse
submissive brings
Her first-fruit offering, and on
trembling wings,
May she not hope in future days to
soar,
Where fancy's sons have led the way
before?
Where genius strives in each
ambrosial bower
To snatch with agile hand the opening
flower?
To cull what sweets adorn the
mountain's brow,
What humbler blossoms crown the
vales below?

340

To blend with these the stores by art
refined,
And give the moral Flora to the
mind?

Far other scenes my timid hour
admits,
Relentless critics, and avenging wits;
E'en coxcombs take a licence from
their pen,
And to each "let-him-perish" cry
Amen!
And thus, with wits or fools my heart
shall cry,

For if they please not, let the trifles
die—
Die, and be lost in dark oblivion's
shore,
And never rise to vex their author
more.

350

I would not dream o'er some soft
liquid line,
Amid a thousand blunders form'd to
shine;
Yet rather this, than }
that dull }
scribbler be,
From every fault, and every
beauty free,
Curst with tame thoughts and
mediocrity.
Some have I found so thick beset
with spots,
'Twas hard to trace their beauties
through their blots;
And these, as tapers round a sick-
man's room,
Or passing chimes, but warn'd me of
the tomb!

O! if you blast, at once consume
my bays,

360

And damn me not with mutilated
praise.
With candour judge; and, a young
bard in view.
Allow for that, and judge with
kindness too.

Faults he must own, though hard for
 him to find,
 Not to some happier merits quite so
 blind;
 These if mistaken Fancy only sees,
 Or Hope, that takes Deformity for
 these;
 If Duncce, the crowd-befitting title,
 falls
 His lot, and Dulness her new subject
 calls:
 To the poor bard alone your censures
 give—
 370
 Let his fame die, but let his honour
 live;
 Laugh if you must—be candid as you
 can,
 And when you lash the Poet, spare
 the Man.

FOOTNOTES:

[12]

IMIT.—Scriberis Vario fortis, et hostium
 Victor, Mæonii carminis alite,
 Quam rem cumque ferox navibus aut
 equis
 Miles, te duce, gesserit, &c. &c.
 HOR. Lib. i.
 Od. [6].

[13]

IMIT.—Quid dedicatum poscit Apollinem
 Vates? quid orat, de paterâ novum
 Fundens liquorem? &c. &c.
 HOR. Lib. i.
 Carm.
 xxxii.

POEMS.

Ipse per Ausonias Æneïa carmina
gentes
Qui sonat, ingenti qui nomine pulsat
Olympum,
Mæoniumque senem Romano
provocat ore:
Forsitan illius nemoris latuisset in
umbrâ
Quod canit, et sterili tantum cantâset
avenâ
Ignotus populi, si Mæcenate careret.

Paneg.

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DEDICATION

TO THE
RIGHT HONOURABLE HENRY RICHARD FOX,

LORD HOLLAND,

OF HOLLAND, IN LINCOLNSHIRE; LORD HOLLAND
OF FOXLEY; AND FELLOW OF THE SOCIETY
OF ANTIQUARIES.

MY LORD,

That the longest poem in this collection was honoured by the notice of your Lordship's right honourable and ever-valued relation, Mr. Fox; that it should be the last which engaged his attention; and that some parts of it were marked with his approbation: are circumstances productive of better hopes of ultimate success than I had dared to entertain before I was gratified with a knowledge of them; and the hope thus raised leads me to ask permission that I may dedicate this book to your Lordship, to whom that truly great and greatly lamented personage was so nearly allied in family, so closely bound in affection, and in whose mind presides the same critical taste which he exerted to the delight of all who heard him. He doubtless united with his unequalled abilities a fund of good-nature; and this possibly led him to speak favourably of, and give satisfaction to writers, with whose productions he might not be entirely satisfied; nor must I allow myself to suppose his desire of obliging was withholden, when he honoured any effort of mine with his approbation. But, my Lord, as there was discrimination in the opinion he gave; as he did not veil indifference for insipid mediocrity of composition under any general expression of cool approval: I allow myself to draw a favourable conclusion from the verdict of one who had the superiority of intellect few would dispute, which he made manifest by a force of eloquence peculiar to himself; whose excellent judgment no one of his friends found cause to distrust, and whose acknowledged candour no enemy had the temerity to deny.

With such encouragement, I present my book to your Lordship: the Account of the *Life and Writings of Lopez de Vega* has taught me what I am to expect; I there perceive how your Lordship can write, and am there taught how you can judge of writers: my faults, however numerous, I know will none of them escape through inattention, nor will any merit be lost for want of discernment; my verses are before him who has written elegantly, who has judged with accuracy, and who has given unequivocal proof of abilities in a work of difficulty—a translation of poetry, which few persons in this kingdom are able to read, and in the estimation of talents not hitherto

justly appreciated. In this view, I cannot but feel some apprehension; but I know also, that your Lordship is apprised of the great difficulty of writing well; that you will make much allowance for failures, if not too frequently repeated; and, as you can accurately discern, so you will readily approve, all the better and more happy efforts of one who places the highest value upon your Lordship's approbation, and who has the honour to be,

My LORD,

Your Lordship's most faithful

and obliged humble servant,

GEO. CRABBE.

PREFACE.

ABOUT twenty-five years since was published a poem called "The Library," which, in no long time, was followed by two others, "The Village," and "The Newspaper." These, with a few alterations and additions, are here reprinted; and are accompanied by a poem of greater length, and several shorter attempts, now, for the first time, before the public; whose reception of them creates in their author something more than common solicitude, because he conceives that, with the judgment to be formed of these latter productions, upon whatever may be found intrinsically meritorious or defective, there will be united an inquiry into the relative degree of praise or blame which they may be thought to deserve, when compared with the more early attempts of the same writer.

And certainly, were it the principal employment of a man's life to compose verses, it might seem reasonable to expect that he would continue to improve as long as he continued to live; though, even then, there is some doubt whether such improvement would follow, and perhaps proof might be adduced to show it would not. But when, to this "*idle trade*" is added some "*calling*," with superior claims upon his time and attention, his progress in the art of versification will probably be in proportion neither to the years he has lived, nor even to the attempts he has made.

While composing the first-published of these poems, the author was honoured with the notice and assisted by the advice of the Right Honourable Edmund Burke; part of it was written in his presence, and the whole submitted to his judgment; receiving, in its progress, the benefit of his correction. I hope, therefore, to obtain pardon of the reader, if I eagerly seize the occasion, and, after so long a silence, endeavour to express a grateful sense of the benefits I have received from this gentleman, who was solicitous for my more essential interests, as well as benevolently anxious for my credit as a writer.

I will not enter upon the subject of his extraordinary abilities; it would be vanity, it would be weakness, in me to believe that I could make them better known or more admired than they now are. But of his private worth, of his wishes to do good, of his affability and condescension; his readiness to lend assistance when he knew it was wanted, and his delight to give praise where he thought it was deserved: of these I may write with some propriety. All know that his powers were vast, his acquirements various; and I take leave to add, that he applied them with unremitted attention to those objects which he believed tended to the honour and welfare of his country. But it may not be so generally understood that he was ever assiduous in the more private duties of a benevolent nature; that he delighted to give encouragement to any promise of ability, and assistance to any appearance of desert. To what purposes he employed his pen, and with what eloquence he spake in the senate, will be told by many, who yet may be ignorant of the solid instruction, as well as the fascinating pleasantries, found in his common conversation, amongst his friends, and his affectionate manners, amiable disposition, and zeal for their happiness, which he manifested in the hours of retirement with his family.

To this gentleman I was indebted for my knowledge of Sir Joshua Reynolds, who was as well known to his friends for his perpetual fund of good-humour and his unceasing wishes to oblige, as he was to the public for the extraordinary productions of his pencil and his pen. By him I was favoured with an introduction to Doctor Johnson, who honoured me with his notice, and assisted me, as Mr. Boswell has told, with remarks and emendations for a poem I was about to publish. The doctor had been often wearied by applications, and did not readily comply with requests for his opinion: not from any unwillingness to oblige, but from a painful

contention in his mind between a desire of giving pleasure and a determination to speak truth. No man can, I think, publish a work without some expectation of satisfying those who are to judge of its merit; but I can, with the utmost regard to veracity, speak my fears, as predominating over every pre-indulged thought of a more favourable nature, when I was told that a judge so discerning had consented to read and give his opinion of "The Village," the poem I had prepared for publication. The time of suspense was not long protracted; I was soon favoured with a few words from Sir Joshua, who observed, "If I knew how cautious Doctor Johnson was in giving commendation, I should be well satisfied with the portion dealt to me in his letter." Of that letter the following is a copy:

"SIR,

"I have sent you back Mr. Crabbe's poem, which I read with great delight. It is original, vigorous, and elegant. The alterations which I have made, I do not require him to adopt; for my lines are, perhaps, not often better [than] his own: but he may take mine and his own together, and perhaps, between them, produce something better than either.—He is not to think his copy wantonly defaced; a wet sponge will wash all the red lines away, and leave the pages clean.—His Dedication will be least liked: it were better to contract it into a short sprightly address.—I do not doubt of Mr. Crabbe's success.

"I am, Sir, your most humble servant,

"SAM. JOHNSON."

"*March 4, 1783.*"

That I was fully satisfied, my readers will do me the justice to believe; and I hope they will pardon me, if there should appear to them any impropriety in publishing the favourable opinion expressed in a private letter: they will judge, and truly, that by so doing, I wish to bespeak their good opinion, but have no design of extorting their applause. I would not hazard an appearance so ostentatious to gratify my vanity, but I venture to do it in compliance with my fears.

After these was published "The Newspaper": it had not the advantage of such previous criticism from any friends, nor perhaps so much of my own attention as I ought to have given to it; but the impression was disposed of, and I will not pay so little respect to the judgment of my readers as now to suppress they then approved.

Since the publication of this poem more than twenty years have elapsed, and I am not without apprehension, lest so long a silence should be construed into a blamable neglect of my own interest, which those excellent friends were desirous of promoting; or, what is yet worse, into a want of gratitude for their assistance, since it becomes me to suppose, they considered these first attempts as promises of better things, and their favours as stimulants to future exertion. And here, be the construction put upon my apparent negligence what it *may*, let me not suppress my testimony to the liberality of those who are looked up to as patrons and encouragers of literary merit, or indeed of merit of any kind: their patronage has never been refused, I conceive, when it has been reasonably expected or modestly required; and it would be difficult, probably, to instance, in these times and in this country, any one who merited or was supposed to merit assistance, but who nevertheless languished in obscurity or necessity for want of it; unless in those cases where it was prevented by the resolution of impatient pride, or wearied by the solicitations of determined profligacy. And, while the subject is before me, I am unwilling to pass silently over the debt of gratitude which I owe to the memory of two deceased noblemen, His Grace the late Duke of Rutland, and the Right Honourable the Lord Thurlow: sensible of the honour done me by their notice, and the benefits received from them, I trust this acknowledgment will be imputed to its only motive, a grateful sense of their favours.

Upon this subject I could dwell with much pleasure; but, to give a reason for that appearance of neglect, as it is more difficult, so, happily, it is less required. In truth, I have, for many years, intended a republication of these poems, as soon as I should be able to join with them such other of later date as might not deprive me of the little credit the former had obtained. Long indeed has this purpose been procrastinated; and, if the duties of a profession, not before pressing upon me—if the claims of a situation, at that time untried—if diffidence of my own judgment, and the loss of my earliest friends, will not sufficiently account for my delay, I must rely upon the

good-nature of my reader, that he will let them avail as far as he can, and find an additional apology in my fears of his censure.

These fears being so prevalent with me, I determined not to publish any thing more, unless I could first obtain the sanction of such an opinion as I might with some confidence rely upon. I looked for a friend who, having the discerning taste of Mr. Burke, and the critical sagacity of Doctor Johnson, would bestow upon my MS. the attention requisite to form his opinion, and would then favour me with the result of his observations; and it was my singular good fortune to gain such assistance; the opinion of a critic so qualified, and a friend so disposed to favour me. I had been honoured by an introduction to the Right Honourable Charles James Fox some years before, at the seat of Mr. Burke; and, being again with him, I received a promise that he would peruse any work I might send to him previous to its publication, and would give me his opinion. At that time, I did not think myself sufficiently prepared; and when, afterwards, I had collected some poems for his inspection, I found my right honourable friend engaged by the affairs of a great empire, and struggling with the inveteracy of a fatal disease; at such time, upon such mind, ever disposed to oblige as that mind was, I could not obtrude the petty business of criticising verses; but he remembered the promise he had kindly given, and repeated an offer, which, though I had not presumed to expect, I was happy to receive. A copy of the poems, now first published, was immediately sent to him, and (as I have the information from Lord Holland, and his Lordship's permission to inform my readers) the poem which I have named "The Parish Register" was heard by Mr. Fox, and it excited interest enough, by some of its parts, to gain for me the benefit of his judgment upon the whole. Whatever he approved, the reader will readily believe, I have carefully retained; the parts he disliked are totally expunged, and others are substituted, which I hope resemble those, more conformable to the taste of so admirable a judge. Nor can I deny myself the melancholy satisfaction of adding, that this poem (and more especially the story of Phœbe Dawson, with some parts of the second book), were the last compositions of their kind that engaged and amused the capacious, the candid, the benevolent mind of this great man.

The above information I owe to the favour of the Right Honourable Lord Holland; nor this only, but to his Lordship I am indebted for some excellent remarks upon the other parts of my MS. It was not indeed my good fortune

then to know that my verses were in the hands of a nobleman who had given proof of his accurate judgment as a critic, and his elegance as a writer, by favouring the public with an easy and spirited translation of some interesting scenes of a dramatic poet, not often read in this kingdom. The Life of Lopez de Vega was then unknown to me; I had, in common with many English readers, heard of him, but could not judge whether his far-extended reputation was caused by the sublime efforts of a mighty genius, or the unequalled facility of a rapid composer, aided by peculiar and fortunate circumstances. That any part of my MS. was honoured by the remarks of Lord Holland yields me a high degree of satisfaction, and his Lordship will perceive the use I have made of them; but I must feel some regret when I know to what small portion they were limited; and discerning, as I do, the taste and judgment bestowed upon the verses of Lopez de Vega, I must perceive how much my own needed the assistance afforded to one who cannot be sensible of the benefit he has received.

But how much soever I may lament the advantages lost, let me remember with gratitude the helps I have obtained. With a single exception, every poem in the ensuing collection has been submitted to the critical sagacity of a gentleman, upon whose skill and candour their author could rely. To publish by advice of friends has been severely ridiculed, and that too by a poet, who probably, without such advice, never made public any verses of his own: in fact, it may not be easily determined who acts with less discretion, the writer who is encouraged to publish his works, merely by the advice of friends whom he consulted, or he who, against advice, publishes from the sole encouragement of his own opinion. These are deceptions to be carefully avoided; and I was happy to escape the latter, by the friendly attentions of the Reverend Richard Turner, minister of Great Yarmouth. To this gentleman I am indebted more than I am able to describe, or than he is willing to allow, for the time he has bestowed upon the attempts I have made. He is, indeed, the kind of critic for whom every poet should devoutly wish, and the friend whom every man would be happy to acquire; he has taste to discern all that is meritorious, and sagacity to detect whatsoever should be discarded; he gives just the opinion an author's wisdom should covet, however his vanity might prompt him to reject it; what altogether to expunge and what to improve he has repeatedly taught me, and, could I have obeyed him in the latter direction, as I invariably have in the former,

the public would have found this collection more worthy its attention, and I should have sought the opinion of the critic more void of apprehension.

But whatever I may hope or fear, whatever assistance I have had or have needed, it becomes me to leave my verses to the judgment of the reader, without my endeavour to point out their merit, or an apology for their defects. Yet as, among the poetical attempts of one who has been for many years a priest, it may seem a want of respect for the legitimate objects of his study, that nothing occurs, unless it be incidentally, of the great subjects of religion: so it may appear a kind of ingratitude of a beneficed clergyman, that he has not employed his talent (be it estimated as it may) to some patriotic purpose—as in celebrating the unsubdued spirit of his countrymen in their glorious resistance of those enemies, who would have no peace throughout the world, except that which is dictated to the drooping spirit of suffering humanity by the triumphant insolence of military success.

Credit will be given to me, I hope, when I affirm that subjects so interesting have the due weight with me, which the sacred nature of the one, and the national importance of the other, must impress upon every mind not seduced into carelessness for religion by the lethargic influence of a perverted philosophy, nor into indifference for the cause of our country by hyperbolical or hypocritical professions of universal philanthropy; but, after many efforts to satisfy myself by various trials on these subjects, I declined all further attempt, from a conviction that I should not be able to give satisfaction to my readers. Poetry of religious nature must indeed ever be clogged with almost insuperable difficulty; but there are doubtless to be found poets who are well qualified to celebrate the unanimous and heroic spirit of our countrymen, and to describe in appropriate colours some of those extraordinary scenes, which have been and are shifting in the face of Europe, with such dreadful celerity; and to such I relinquish the duty.

It remains for me to give the reader a brief view of those articles in the following collection, which for the first time solicit his attention.

In the "Parish Register," he will find an endeavour once more to describe village-manners, not by adopting the notion of pastoral simplicity or assuming ideas of rustic barbarity, but by more natural views of the peasantry, considered as a mixed body of persons, sober or profligate, and

hence, in a great measure, contented or miserable. To this more general description are added the various characters which occur in the three parts of a Register: Baptism, Marriages, and Burials.

If the "Birth of Flattery" offer no moral, as an appendage to the fable, it is hoped that nothing of an immoral, nothing of improper, tendency will be imputed to a piece of poetical playfulness. In fact, genuine praise, like all other species of truth, is known by its bearing full investigation: it is what the giver is happy that he can justly bestow, and the receiver conscious that he may boldly accept; but adulation must ever be afraid of inquiry, and must, in proportion to their degrees of moral sensibility,

Be shame "to him that gives and him that takes."

The verses in page[s 234-7] want a title; nor does the motto, although it gave occasion to them, altogether express the sense of the writer, who meant to observe that some of our best acquisitions, and some of our nobler conquests, are rendered ineffectual, by the passing away of opportunity, and the changes made by time: an argument that such acquirements and moral habits are reserved for a state of being in which they have the uses here denied them.

In the story of "Sir Eustace Grey," an attempt is made to describe the wanderings of a mind first irritated by the consequences of error and misfortune, and afterwards soothed by a species of enthusiastic conversion, still keeping him insane: a task very difficult, and, if the presumption of the attempt may find pardon, it will not be refused to the failure of the poet. It is said of our Shakspeare, respecting madness,

"In that circle none dare walk but he."

Yet be it granted to one who dares not to pass the boundary fixed for common minds, at least to step near to the tremendous verge, and form some idea of the terrors that are stalking in the interdicted space.

When first I had written "Aaron, or The Gipsy," I had no unfavourable opinion of it; and, had I been collecting my verses at that time for publication, I should certainly have included this tale. Nine years have since elapsed, and I continue to judge the same of it, thus literally obeying one of the directions given by the prudence of criticism to the eagerness of the

poet; but how far I may have conformed to rules of more importance must be left to the less partial judgment of the readers.

The concluding poem, entitled "Woman!" was written at the time when the quotation from Mr. Ledyard was first made public; the expression has since become hackneyed; but the sentiment is congenial with our feelings, and though somewhat amplified in these verses, it is hoped they are not so far extended as to become tedious.

After this brief account of his subjects, the author leaves them to their fate, not presuming to make any remarks upon the kinds of versification he has chosen, or the merit of the execution. He has indeed brought forward the favourable opinion of his friends, and for that he earnestly hopes his motives will be rightly understood; it was a step of which he felt the advantage while he foresaw the danger; he was aware of the benefit, if his readers would consider him as one who puts on a defensive armour against hasty and determined severity; but he feels also the hazard, lest they should suppose he looks upon himself to be guarded by his friends, and so secure in the defence, that he may defy the fair judgment of legal criticism. It will probably be said, "he has brought with him his testimonials to the bar of the public," and he must admit the truth of the remark; but he begs leave to observe in reply, that of those who bear testimonials of any kind the greater numbers feel apprehension, and not security: they are indeed so far from the enjoyment of victory, of the exultation of triumph, that, with all they can do for themselves, with all their friends have done for them, they are, like him, in dread of examination, and in fear of disappointment.

Muston, Leicestershire,

September, 1807.

THE LIBRARY.

ks afford Consolation to the troubled Mind, by substituting a lighter Kind of Distress for its own—
They are productive of other Advantages—An Author's Hope of being known in distant Times—
Arrangement of the Library—Size and Form of the Volumes—The ancient Folio, clasped and
chained—Fashion prevalent even in this Place—The Mode of publishing in Numbers, Pamphlets,
&c.—Subjects of the different Classes—Divinity—Controversy—The Friends of Religion often
more dangerous than her Foes—Sceptical Authors—Reason too much rejected by the former

Converts; exclusively relied upon by the latter—Philosophy ascending through the Scale of Being to moral Subjects—Books of Medicine: their Variety, Variance, and Proneness to System: the Evil of this, and the Difficulty it causes—Farewell to this Study—Law: the increasing Number of its Volumes—Supposed happy State of Man without Laws—Progress of Society—Historians: their Subjects—Dramatic Authors, Tragic and Comic—Ancient Romances—The Captive Heroine—Happiness in the Perusal of such Books: why—Criticism—Apprehensions of the Author, removed by the Appearance of the Genius of the Place; whose Reasoning and Admonition conclude the Subject.

When the sad soul, by care and grief
oppress'd,
Looks round the world, but looks in
vain for rest;
When every object that appears in
view,
Partakes her gloom and seems
dejected too:
Where shall affliction from itself
retire?
Where fade away and placidly
expire?
Alas! we fly to silent scenes in vain;
Care blasts the honours of the flow'ry
plain:
Care veils in clouds the sun's
meridian beam,
10
Sighs through the grove and murmurs
in the stream.
For, when the soul is labouring in
despair,
In vain the body breathes a purer air:
No storm-toss'd sailor sighs for
slumbering seas—
He dreads the tempest, but invokes
the breeze;
On the smooth mirror }
of the deep }
resides

Reflected wo, and o'er
unruffled tides
The ghost of every former
danger glides.
Thus, in the calms of life, we only see
A steadier image of our misery;
20
But lively gales and gently-clouded
skies
Disperse the sad reflections as they
rise;
And busy thoughts and little cares
avail
To ease the mind, when rest and
reason fail.
When the dull thought, by no designs
employ'd,
Dwells on the past, or suffer'd or
enjoy'd,
We bleed anew in every former grief,
And joys departed furnish no relief.
Not Hope herself, with all her
flattering art,
Can cure this stubborn sickness of the
heart:

30
The soul disdains each comfort she
prepares,
And anxious searches for congenial
cares—
Those lenient cares, }
which, with }
our own
combined,
By mix'd sensations ease th'
afflicted mind.

And steal our grief away and leave
their own behind:
A lighter grief! which feeling hearts
endure
Without regret, nor e'en demand a
cure.

But what strange art, what magic
can dispose
The troubled mind to change its
native woes?
Or lead us willing from ourselves, to
see

40

Others more wretched, more undone
than we?
This, books can do—nor this alone:
they give
New views to life, and teach us how
to live;
They soothe the grieved, the stubborn
they chastise;
Fools they admonish, and confirm the
wise.
Their aid they yield to all: they never
shun
The man of sorrow, nor the wretch
undone;
Unlike the hard, the selfish, and the
proud,
They fly not sullen from the suppliant
crowd;
Nor tell to various people various
things,

50

But show to subjects, what they show
to kings.

Come, Child of Care! to make thy
soul serene,
Approach the treasures of this
tranquil scene;
Survey the dome, and, as the doors
unfold,
The soul's best cure in all her cares
behold!
Where mental wealth the poor in
thought may find,
And mental physic the diseased in
mind.
See here the balms that passion's
wounds assuage;
See coolers here, that damp the fire of
rage;
Here alt'ratives by slow degrees
control

60

The chronic habits of the sickly soul;
And round the heart, and o'er the
aching head,
Mild opiates here their sober
influence shed.
Now bid thy soul man's busy scenes
exclude,
And view composed this silent
multitude:—
Silent they are, but, though deprived
of sound,
Here all the living languages abound,
Here all that live no more; preserved
they lie,
In tombs that open to the curious eye.
Bless'd be the gracious Power, who
taught mankind

70

To stamp a lasting image of the mind!

—

Beasts may convey, and tuneful birds
may sing,

Their mutual feelings in the opening
spring;

But man alone has skill and power to
send

The heart's warm dictates to the
distant friend;

'Tis his alone to please, instruct,
advise

Ages remote, and nations yet to rise.

In sweet repose, when labour's
children sleep,

When joy forgets to smile and care to
weep,

When passion slumbers in the lover's
breast,

80

And fear and guilt partake the balm
of rest—

Why then denies the studious man to
share

Man's common good, who feels his
common care?

Because the hope is his, that bids
him fly

Night's soft repose, and sleep's mild
power defy;

That after-ages may repeat his praise,

And fame's fair meed be his for
length of days.

Delightful prospect! when we leave
behind

A worthy offspring of the fruitful
mind,

Which, born and nursed through
many an anxious day,

90

Shall all our labour, all our care
repay.

Yet all are not these births of noble
kind,

Not all the children of a vigorous
mind;

But, where the wisest should alone
preside,

The weak would rule us, and the
blind would guide;

Nay, man's best efforts taste of man,
and show

The poor and troubled source from
which they flow:

Where most he triumphs, we his
wants perceive,

And for his weakness in his wisdom
grieve.

But, though imperfect all, yet wisdom
loves

100

This seat serene, and virtue's self
approves;

Here come the grieved, a change of
thought to find,

The curious here, to feed a craving
mind;

Here the devout their peaceful temple
choose;

And here the poet meets his
favouring muse.

With awe around these silent walks
I tread:

These are the lasting mansions of the
dead.—

"The dead," methinks, a thousand
tongues reply;

"These are the tombs of such as
cannot die!

Crown'd with eternal fame, they sit
sublime,

110

And laugh at all the little strife of
time."

Hail, then, immortals! ye who
shine above,

Each in his sphere the literary Jove;

And ye, the common people of these
skies,

A humbler crowd of nameless deities:

Whether 'tis yours to lead the willing
mind

Through history's mazes, and the
turnings find;

Or whether, led by science, ye retire,

Lost and bewilder'd in the vast desire;

Whether the Muse invites you to her
bowers,

120

And crowns your placid brows with
living flowers;

Or godlike wisdom teaches you to
show

The noblest road to happiness below;

Or men and manners prompt the easy
page

To mark the flying follies of the age:

Whatever good ye boast, that good
impart;

Inform the head and rectify the heart!

Lo! all in silence, all in order
stand;

And mighty folios first, a lordly band,
Then quartos, their well-order'd ranks
maintain,

130

And light octavos fill a spacious
plain;

See yonder, ranged in more
frequented rows,

A humbler band of duodecimos;

While undistinguished trifles swell
the scene,

The last new play and fritter'd
magazine.

Thus 'tis in life, where first the proud,
the great,

In leagued assembly keep their
cumbrous state;

Heavy and huge, they fill the world
with dread,

Are much admired, and are but little
read:

The commons next, a middle rank,
are found;

140

Professions fruitful pour their
offspring round;

Reasoners and wits are next their
place allow'd,

And last, of vulgar tribes a countless
crowd.

First, let us view the form, the size,
the dress;

For these the manners, nay the mind
express;

That weight of wood, with leathern
coat o'erlaid;
Those ample clasps, of solid metal
made;
The close-press'd leaves, unclosed for
many an age;
The dull red edging of the well-fill'd
page;
On the broad back the stubborn
ridges roll'd,

150

Where yet the title stands in tarnish'd
gold;
These all a sage and labour'd work
proclaim,
A painful candidate for lasting fame:
No idle wit, no trifling verse can lurk
In the deep bosom of that weighty
work;
No playful thoughts degrade the
solemn style,
Nor one light sentence claims a
transient smile.

Hence, in these times, untouch'd
the pages lie,
And slumber out their immortality:
They *had* their day, when, after all his
toil,

160

His morning study, and his midnight
oil,
At length an author's ONE great work
appear'd,
By patient hope, and length of days,
endear'd:
Expecting nations hail'd it from the
press;

Poetic friends prefix'd each kind
address;

Princes and kings received the
pond'rous gift,

And ladies read the work they could
not lift.

Fashion, though Folly's child, and
guide of fools,

Rules e'en the wisest, and in learning
rules;

From crowds and courts to Wisdom's
seat she goes,

170

And reigns triumphant o'er her
mother's foes.

For lo! these fav'rites of the ancient
mode

Lie all neglected like the Birth-day
Ode;

Ah! needless now this weight of
massy chain^[14];

Safe in themselves, the once-loved
works remain;

No readers now invade their still
retreat,

None try to steal them from their
parent-seat;

Like ancient beauties, they may now
discard

Chains, bolts, and locks, and lie
without a guard.

Our patient fathers trifling themes
laid by,

180

And roll'd o'er labour'd works th'
attentive eye;

Page after page, the much-enduring
men
Explored the deeps and shallows of
the pen;
Till, every former note and comment
known,
They mark'd the spacious margin
with their own:
Minute corrections proved their
studious care;
The little index, pointing, told us
where;
And many an emendation show'd the
age
Look'd far beyond the rubric title-
page.
Our nicer palates lighter labours
seek,

190

Cloy'd with a folio-*Number* once a
week;
Bibles, with cuts and comments, thus
go down:
E'en light Voltaire is *number'd*
through the town:
Thus physic flies abroad, and thus the
law,
From men of study, and from men of
straw;
Abstracts, abridgments, please the
fickle times,
Pamphlets and plays, and politics and
rhymes:
But though to write be now a task of
ease,
The task is hard by manly arts to
please,

When all our weakness is exposed to
view,

200

And half our judges are our rivals
too.

Amid these works, on which the
eager eye
Delights to fix, or glides reluctant by,
When all combined, their decent
pomp display,
Where shall we first our early
offering pay?

To thee, DIVINITY! to thee, the light
And guide of mortals through their
mental night;
By whom we learn our hopes and
fears to guide;
To bear with pain, and to contend
with pride;
When grieved, to pray; when injured,
to forgive;

210

And with the world in charity to live.
Not truths like these inspired that
numerous race,
Whose pious labours fill this ample
space;
But questions nice, where doubt on
doubt arose,
Awaked to war the long-contending
foes.
For dubious meanings, learn'd
polemics strove.
And wars on faith prevented works of
love;

The brands of discord far around
 were hurl'd,
And holy wrath inflamed a sinful
 world—
Dull though impatient, peevish
 though devout,
220
With wit disgusting and despised
 without;
Saints in design, in execution men,
Peace in their looks, and vengeance
 in their pen.

 Methinks, I see, and sicken at the
 sight,
Spirits of spleen from yonder pile
 alight:
Spirits who prompted every damning
 page,
With pontiff pride and still-increasing
 rage.
Lo! how they stretch their gloomy
 wings around,
And lash with furious strokes the
 trembling ground!
They pray, they fight, they murder,
 and they weep—
230
Wolves, in their vengeance, in their
 manners sheep;
Too well they act the prophet's fatal
 part,
Denouncing evil with a zealous heart;
And each, like Jonas, is displeased, if
 God
Repent his anger, or withhold his rod.

But here the dormant fury rests
unsought,
And Zeal sleeps soundly by the foes
she fought;
Here all the rage of controversy ends,
And rival zealots rest like bosom-
friends:
An Athanasian here, in deep repose,
240
Sleeps with the fiercest of his Arian
foes;
Socinians here with Calvinists abide,
And thin partitions angry chiefs
divide;
Here wily Jesuits simple Quakers
meet,
And Bellarmine has rest at Luther's
feet.
Great authors, for the church's glory
fired,
Are, for the church's peace, to rest
retired;
And close beside, a mystic, maudlin
race,
Lie, "Crums of Comfort for the Babes
of Grace."

Against her foes Religion well
defends
250
Her sacred truths, but often fears her
friends;
If learn'd, their pride, if weak, their
zeal she dreads,
And their hearts' weakness, who have
soundest heads.
But most she fears the controversial
pen,

The holy strife of disputatious men;
Who the bless'd Gospel's peaceful
page explore,
Only to fight against its precepts
more.

Near to these seats, behold yon
slender frames,
All closely fill'd and mark'd with
modern names;
Where no fair science ever shows her
face,

260

Few sparks of genius, and no spark of
grace.

There sceptics rest, a still-increasing
throng,

And stretch their widening wings ten
thousand strong:

Some in close fight their dubious
claims maintain;

Some skirmish lightly, fly and fight
again;

Coldly profane, and impiously gay;
Their end the same, though various in
their way.

When first Religion came to bless
the land,

Her friends were then a firm
believing band;

To doubt was, then, to plunge in guilt
extreme,

270

And all was gospel that a monk could
dream;

Insulted Reason fled the grov'ling
soul,

For Fear to guide, and visions to
control.

But now, when Reason has assumed
her throne,

She, in her turn, demands to reign
alone;

Rejecting all that lies beyond her
view,

And, being judge, will be a witness
too.

Insulted Faith then leaves the
doubtful mind,

To seek for truth, without a power to
find;

Ah! when will both in friendly beams
unite,

280

And pour on erring man resistless
light?

Next to the seats, well stored with
works divine,

An ample space, PHILOSOPHY! is thine;
Our reason's guide, by whose
assisting light

We trace the moral bounds of wrong
and right;

Our guide through nature, from the
sterile clay,

To the bright orbs of yon celestial
way!

'Tis thine, the great, the golden chain
to trace,

Which runs through all, connecting
race with race;

Save where those puzzling, stubborn
links remain,

290

Which thy inferior light pursues in
vain:—

How vice and virtue in the soul
contend;
How widely differ, yet how nearly
blend!

What various passions war on either
part,

And now confirm, now melt the
yielding heart;

How Fancy loves around the world to
stray,

While Judgment slowly picks his
sober way!

The stores of memory, and the flights
sublime

Of genius, bound by neither space nor
time—

All these divine Philosophy explores,
300

Till, lost in awe, she wonders and
adores.

From these, descending to the earth,
she turns,

And matter, in its various form,
discerns;

She parts the beamy light with skill
profound,

Metes the thin air, and weighs the
flying sound;

'Tis hers the lightning from the clouds
to call,

And teach the fiery mischief where to
fall.

Yet more her volumes teach—on
these we look

As abstracts drawn from Nature's
larger book:

Here, first described, the torpid earth
appears,

310

And next, the vegetable robe it wears:
Where flow'ry tribes, in valleys,
fields and groves,

Nurse the still flame, and feed the
silent loves—

Loves, where no grief, nor joy, nor
bliss, nor pain,

Warm the glad heart or vex the
labouring brain;

But as the green blood moves along
the blade,

The bed of Flora on the branch is
made;

Where, without passion, love
instinctive lives,

And gives new life, unconscious that
it gives.

Advancing still in Nature's maze, we
trace,

320

In dens and burning plains, her
savage race;

With those tame tribes who on their
lord attend,

And find in man, a master and a
friend;

Man crowns the scene, a world of
wonders new,

A moral world, that well demands our
view.

This world is here; for, of more
lofty kind,

These neighbouring volumes reason
on the mind;

They paint the state of man, ere yet
endued

With knowledge—man, poor,
ignorant, and rude;

Then, as his state improves, their
pages swell,

330

And all its cares, and all its comforts,
tell:

Here we behold how inexperience
buys,

At little price, the wisdom of the
wise;

Without the troubles of an active
state,

Without the cares and dangers of the
great,

Without the miseries of the poor, we
know

What wisdom, wealth, and poverty
bestow;

We see how reason calms the raging
mind,

And how contending passions urge
mankind.

Some, won by virtue, glow with
sacred fire;

340

Some, lured by vice, indulge the low
desire;

Whilst others, won by either, now
pursue

The guilty chase, now keep the good
in view;

For ever wretched, with themselves at
 strife,
They lead a puzzled, vex'd, uncertain
 life;
For transient vice bequeaths a
 lingering pain,
Which transient virtue seeks to cure
 in vain.

 Whilst thus engaged, high views
 enlarge the soul,
New interests draw, new principles
 control:
Nor thus the soul alone resigns her
 grief,

350

But here the tortured body finds
 relief;
For see where yonder sage Arachnè
 shapes
Her subtile gin, that not a fly escapes!
There PHYSIC fills the space, and far
 around,
Pile above pile, her learned works
 abound:
Glorious their aim—to ease the
 labouring heart;
To war with death, and stop his flying
 dart;
To trace the source whence the fierce
 contest grew,
And life's short lease on easier terms
 renew;
To calm the frenzy of the burning
 brain;

360

To heal the tortures of imploring pain;

Or, when more }
 powerful ills }
 all efforts
 brave,
To ease the victim no device
 can save,
And smooth the stormy
 passage to the grave.
But man, who knows no good
 unmix'd and pure,

Oft finds a poison where he sought a
 cure;
For grave deceivers lodge their
 labours here,
And cloud the science they pretend to
 clear.
Scourges for sin, the solemn tribe are
 sent;
Like fire and storms, they call us to
 repent;

370

But storms subside, and fires forget to
 rage,
These are eternal scourges of the age.
'Tis not enough that each terrific hand
Spreads desolation round a guilty
 land;
But, train'd to ill, and harden'd by its
 crimes,
Their pen relentless kills through
 future times.
Say ye, who search these records
 of the dead,
Who read huge works, to boast what
 ye have read:

Can all the real knowledge ye
possess,
Or those (if such there are) who more
than guess,

380

Atone for each impostor's wild
mistakes,
And mend the blunders pride or folly
makes?

What thought so wild, what airy
dream so light,
That will not prompt a theorist to
write?

What art so prevalent, what proof so
strong,
That will convince him his attempt is
wrong?

One in the solids finds each lurking
ill,

Nor grants the passive fluids power to
kill;

A learned friend some subtler reason
brings

Absolves the channels, but condemns
their springs;

390

The subtile nerves, that shun the
doctor's eye,

Escape no more his subtler theory;

The vital heat, that warms the
labouring heart,

Lends a fair system to these sons of
art;

The vital air, a pure }
and subtile }
stream,

Serves a foundation for an airy
scheme,
Assists the doctor, and
supports his dream.
Some have their favourite ills, and
each disease
Is but a younger branch that kills
from these.
One to the gout contracts all human
pain;

400

He views it raging in the frantic
brain;
Finds it in fevers all his efforts mar,
And sees it lurking in the cold
catarrh.
Bilious by some, by others nervous
seen,
Rage the fantastic demons of the
spleen;
And every symptom of the strange
disease
With every system of the sage agrees.
Ye frigid tribe, on whom I wasted
long
The tedious hours, and ne'er indulged
in song;

Ye first seducers of my easy heart,

410

Who promised knowledge ye could
not impart;
Ye dull deluders, truth's destructive
foes;
Ye sons of fiction, clad in stupid
prose;
Ye treacherous leaders, who,
yourselves in doubt,

Light up false fires, and send us far
about—
Still may yon spider round your
pages spin,
Subtile and slow, her emblematic gin!
Buried in dust and lost in silence,
dwell;
Most potent, grave, and reverend
friends—farewell!

Near these, and where the setting
sun displays

420

Through the dim window his
departing rays,
And gilds yon columns, there, on
either side,
The huge abridgments of the LAW
abide.
Fruitful as vice the dread correctors
stand,
And spread their guardian terrors
round the land;
Yet, as the best that human care can
do,
Is mix'd with error, oft with evil too,
Skill'd in deceit, and practised to
evade,
Knaves stand secure, for whom these
laws were made;
And justice vainly each expedient
tries,

430

While art eludes it, or while power
defies.
"Ah! happy age," the youthful poet
sings,

"When the free nations knew not laws
nor kings;
When all were bless'd to share a
common store,
And none were proud of wealth, for
none were poor;
No wars nor tumults vex'd each still
domain,
No thirst of empire, no desire of gain;
No proud great man, nor one who
would be great,
Drove modest merit from its proper
state;
Nor into distant climes would avarice
roam,

440

To fetch delights for luxury at home:
Bound by no ties which kept the soul
in awe,
They dwelt at liberty, and love was
law!"

"Mistaken youth! each nation first
was rude,
Each man a cheerless son of solitude,
To whom no joys of social life were
known;
None felt a care that was not all his
own;
Or in some languid clime his abject
soul
Bow'd to a little tyrant's stern control;
A slave, with slaves his monarch's
throne he raised,

450

And in rude song his ruder idol
praised;

The meaner cares of life were all he
knew;
Bounded his pleasures, and his
wishes few.
But when by slow degrees the Arts
arose,
And Science waken'd from her long
repose;
When Commerce, rising from the bed
of ease,
Ran round the land, and pointed to
the seas;
When Emulation, born with jealous
eye,
And Avarice, lent their spurs to
industry;
Then one by one the numerous laws
were made,

460

Those to control, and these to succour
trade;
To curb the insolence of rude
command,
To snatch the victim from the usurer's
hand;
To awe the bold, to yield the wrong'd
redress,
And feed the poor with Luxury's
excess."

Like some vast flood, unbounded,
fierce, and strong,
His nature leads ungovern'd man
along;
Like mighty bulwarks made to stem
that tide,
The laws are form'd and placed on
ev'ry side:

Whene'er it breaks the bounds by
these decreed,

470

New statutes rise, and stronger laws
succeed;

More and more gentle grows the
dying stream,

More and more strong the rising
bulwarks seem;

Till, like a miner working sure and
slow,

Luxury creeps on, and ruins all
below;

The basis sinks, the ample piles
decay;

The stately fabric shakes and falls
away;

Primeval want and ignorance come
on,

But freedom, that exalts the savage
state, is gone.

Next, HISTORY ranks;—there full in
front she lies,

480

And every nation her dread tale
supplies.

Yet History has her doubts, and every
age

With sceptic queries marks the
passing page;

Records of old nor later date are
clear—

Too distant those, and these are
placed too near;

There time conceals the objects from
our view,

Here our own passions and a writer's
too.

Yet, in these volumes, see how states
arose,

Guarded by virtue from surrounding
foes;

Their virtue lost, and of their
triumphs vain,

490

Lo! how they sunk to slavery again!

Satiate with power, of fame and
wealth possess'd,

A nation grows too glorious to be
bless'd;

Conspicuous made, she stands the
mark of all,

And foes join foes to triumph in her
fall.

Thus speaks the page that paints
ambition's race,

The monarch's pride, his glory, his
disgrace;

The headlong course, that madd'ning
heroes run,

How soon triumphant, and how soon
undone;

How slaves, turn'd tyrants, offer
crowns to sale,

500

And each fall'n nation's melancholy
tale.

Lo! where of late the Book of
Martyrs stood,

Old pious tracts, and Bibles bound in
wood:

There, such the taste of our
degenerate age,

Stand the profane delusions of the
STAGE.

Yet virtue owns the TRAGIC MUSE a
friend—

Fable her means, morality her end;
For this she rules all passions in their
turns,

And now the bosom bleeds, and now
it burns;

Pity with weeping eye surveys her
bowl;

510

Her anger swells, her terror chills the
soul;

She makes the vile to virtue yield
applause,

And own her sceptre while they break
her laws;

For vice in others is abhorr'd of all,
And villains triumph when the
worthless fall.

Not thus her sister COMEDY
prevails,

Who shoots at folly, for her arrow
fails:

Folly, by dulness arm'd, eludes the
wound,

And harmless sees the feather'd shafts
rebound;

Unhurt she stands, applauds the
archer's skill,

520

Laughs at her malice, and is folly
still.

Yet well the Muse portrays in fancied
scenes

What pride will stoop to, what
 profession means;
How formal fools the farce of state
 applaud;
How caution watches at the lips of
 fraud;
The wordy variance of domestic life;
The tyrant husband, the retorting
 wife,
The snares for innocence, the lie of
 trade,
And the smooth tongue's habitual
 masquerade.

 With her the virtues too obtain a
 place,

530

Each gentle passion, each becoming
 grace;
The social joy in life's securer road,
Its easy pleasure, its substantial good;
The happy thought that conscious
 virtue gives.
And all that ought to live, and all that
 lives.

 But who are these? Methinks, a
 noble mien
And awful grandeur in their form are
 seen—
Now in disgrace. What, though by
 time is spread
Polluting dust o'er every reverend
 head;
What, though beneath yon gilded
 tribe they lie,

540

And dull observers pass insulting by:

Forbid it shame, forbid it decent awe,
What seems so grave, should no
attention draw!

Come, let us then with [reverent] step
advance,

And greet—the ancient worthies of
ROMANCE.

Hence, ye profane! I feel a former
dread;

A thousand visions float around my
head.

Hark! hollow blasts through empty
courts resound,

And shadowy forms with staring eyes
stalk round;

See! moats and bridges, walls and
castles rise,

550

Ghosts, fairies, demons, dance before
our eyes;

Lo! magic verse inscribed on golden
gate,

And bloody hand that beckons on to
fate:—

"And who art thou, thou little page,
unfold!

Say, doth thy lord my Claribel
withhold?

Go tell him straight, Sir Knight, thou
must resign

The captive queen—for Claribel is
mine."

Away he flies; and now for bloody
deeds,

Black suits of armour, masks, and
foaming steeds;

The giant falls, his recreant throat I
seize,

560

And from his corslet take the massy
keys;

Dukes, lords, and knights in long
procession move,

Released from bondage with my
virgin love;

She comes! she comes! in all the
charms of youth,

Unequall'd love and unsuspected
truth!

Ah! happy he who thus, in magic
themes,

O'er worlds bewitch'd in early rapture
dreams,

Where wild Enchantment waves her
potent wand,

And Fancy's beauties fill her fairy
land;

Where doubtful objects strange
desires excite,

570

And Fear and Ignorance afford
delight.

But lost, for ever lost, to me these
joys,

Which Reason scatters, and which
Time destroys—

Too dearly bought: maturer judgment
calls

My busied mind from tales and
madrigals;

My doughty giants all are slain or
fled,

And all my knights, blue, green, and
yellow, dead!

No more the midnight fairy tribe I
view,

All in the merry moonshine tippling
dew;

E'en the last lingering fiction of the
brain,

580

The church-yard ghost, is now at rest
again;

And all these wayward wanderings of
my youth

Fly Reason's power and shun the light
of truth.

With fiction, then, does real joy
reside,

And is our reason the delusive guide?

Is it, then, right to dream the syrens
sing,

Or mount enraptured on the dragon's
wing?

No, 'tis the infant mind, to care
unknown,

That makes th' imagined paradise its
own;

Soon as reflections in the bosom rise,
590

Light slumbers vanish from the
clouded eyes;

The tear and smile, that once together
rose,

Are then divorced; the head and heart
are foes:

Enchantment bows to Wisdom's
serious plan,

And Pain and Prudence make and
mar the man.

While thus, of power and fancied
empire vain,
With various thoughts my mind I
entertain;

While books, my slaves, with tyrant
hand I seize,
Pleased with the pride that will not let
them please;

Sudden I find terrific thoughts arise,
600

And sympathetic sorrow fills my
eyes;

For, lo! while yet my heart admits the
wound,

I see the CRITIC army ranged around.

Foes to our race! if ever ye have
known

A father's fears for offspring of your
own.—

If ever, smiling o'er a lucky line,

Ye thought the sudden sentiment
divine,

Then paused and doubted, and then,
tired of doubt,

With rage as sudden dash'd the stanza
out—

If, after fearing much and pausing
long,

610

Ye ventured on the world your
labour'd song,

And from the crusty critics of those
days

Implored the feeble tribute of their
praise:
Remember now the fears that moved
you then,
And, spite of truth, let mercy guide
your pen!
What vent'rous race are ours! what
mighty foes
Lie waiting all around them to
oppose!
What treacherous friends betray them
to the fight!
What dangers threaten them—yet still
they write:
A hapless tribe! to every evil born,
620
Whom villains hate, and fools affect
to scorn;
Strangers they come amid a world of
wo,
And taste the largest portion ere they
go.

Pensive I spoke, and cast mine
eyes around;
The roof, methought, return'd a
solemn sound;
Each column seem'd to shake, and
clouds, like smoke,
From dusty piles and ancient volumes
broke;
Gathering above, like mists
condensed they seem,
Exhaled in summer from the rushy
stream;
Like flowing robes they now appear,
and twine

630

Round the large members of a form
divine;

His silver beard, that }
swept his aged }
breast,

His piercing eye, that inward
light express'd,

Were seen—but clouds and
darkness veil'd the rest.

Fear chill'd my heart: to one of mortal
race,

How awful seem'd the Genius of the
place!

So, in Cimmerian shores, Ulysses
saw

His parent-shade, and shrunk in pious
awe;

Like him I stood, and wrapt in
thought profound,

When from the pitying power broke
forth a solemn sound:—

640

"Care lives with all; }
no rules, no
precepts save

The wise from wo, no
fortitude the brave;

Grief is to man as certain as
the grave:

Tempests and storms in life's whole
progress rise,

And hope shines dimly through
o'erclouded skies;

Some drops of comfort on the
favour'd fall,

But showers of sorrow are the lot of
all:

Partial to talents, then, shall Heav'n
withdraw

Th' afflicting rod, or break the general
law?

Shall he who soars, inspired by loftier
views,

650

Life's little cares and little pains
refuse?

Shall he not rather feel a double share
Of mortal wo, when doubly arm'd to
bear?

"Hard is his fate who builds his
peace of mind

On the precarious mercy of mankind;
Who hopes for wild and visionary
things,

And mounts o'er unknown seas with
vent'rous wings:

But as, of various evils that befall
The human race, some portion goes
to all:

To him perhaps the milder lot's
assign'd,

660

Who feels his consolation in his
mind;

And, lock'd within his bosom, bears
about

A mental charm for every care
without.

E'en in the pangs of each domestic
grief,

Or health or vigorous hope affords
relief;

And every wound the tortured bosom
feels,
Or virtue bears, or some preserver
heals;
Some generous friend, of ample
power possess'd;
Some feeling heart that bleeds for the
distress'd;
Some breast that glows with virtues
all divine;

670

Some noble RUTLAND, Misery's
friend and thine.

"Nor say, the Muse's song, the
Poet's pen,
Merit the scorn they meet from little
men.

With cautious freedom if the numbers
flow,

Not wildly high, nor pitifully low;
If vice alone their honest aims
oppose,

Why so ashamed their friends, so
loud their foes?

Happy for men in every age and
clime,

If all the sons of vision dealt in
rhyme!

Go on then, Son of Vision! still
pursue

680

Thy airy dreams; the world is
dreaming too.

Ambition's lofty views, the pomp of
state,

The pride of wealth, the splendour of
the great,

Stripp'd of their mask, their cares and
troubles known,
Are visions far less happy than thy
own:
Go on! and, while the sons of care
complain,
Be wisely gay and innocently vain;
While serious souls are by their fears
undone,
Blow sportive bladders in the beamy
sun,
And call them worlds! and bid the
greatest show
690
More radiant colours in their worlds
below;
Then, as they break, the slaves of care
reprove,
And tell them, Such are all the toys
they love."

FOOTNOTES:

^[14] In the more ancient libraries, works of value and importance were fastened to their places by a length of chain; and might so be perused, but not taken away.

THE VILLAGE.

IN TWO BOOKS.

BOOK I.

Subject proposed—Remarks upon Pastoral Poetry—A Tract of Country near the Coast described—An impoverished Borough—Smugglers and their Assistants—Rude Manners of the Inhabitants—Ruinous Effects of a high Tide—The Village Life more generally considered: Evils of it—The youthful Labourer—The old Man: his Soliloquy—The Parish Workhouse: its Inhabitants—The sick Poor: their Apothecary—The dying Pauper—The Village Priest.

The Village Life, and every care
that reigns
O'er youthful peasants and declining
swains;
What labour yields, and what, that
labour past,
Age, in its hour of languor, finds at
last;
What form the real picture of the
poor,
Demand a song—the Muse can give
no more.

Fled are those times when, in
harmonious strains,
The rustic poet praised his native
plains.
No shepherds now, in smooth
alternate verse,

10

Their country's beauty or their
nymphs' rehearse;
Yet still for these we frame the tender
strain,
Still in our lays fond Corydons
complain,
And shepherds' boys their amorous
pains reveal,
The only pains, alas! they never feel.
On Mincio's banks, in Cæsar's
bounteous reign,
If Tityrus found the Golden Age
again,
Must sleepy bards the flattering
dream prolong,
Mechanic echoes of the Mantuan
song?

From Truth and Nature shall we
widely stray,

20

Where Virgil, not where Fancy, leads
the way?

Yes, thus the Muses sing of happy
swains,
Because the Muses never knew their
pains.

They boast their peasants' pipes; but
peasants now

Resign their pipes and plod behind
the plough;

And few, amid the rural-tribe, have
time

To number syllables, and play with
rhyme;

Save honest Duck, what son of verse
could share

The poet's rapture, and the peasant's
care?

Or the great labours of the field
degrade,

30

With the new peril of a poorer trade?

From this chief cause these idle
praises spring,

That themes so easy few forbear to
sing;

For no deep thought the trifling
subjects ask:

To sing of shepherds is an easy task.

The happy youth assumes the
common strain,

A nymph his mistress, and himself a
swain;

With no sad scenes he clouds his
tuneful prayer,
But all; to look like her, is painted
fair.

I grant indeed that fields and flocks
have charms

40

For him that grazes or for him that
farms;

But, when amid such pleasing scenes
I trace

The poor laborious natives of the
place,

And see the mid-day sun, with fervid
ray,

On their bare heads and dewy
temples play;

While some, with feebler heads and
fainter hearts,

Deplore their fortune, yet sustain
their parts:

Then shall I dare these real ills to
hide

In tinsel trappings of poetic pride?

No; cast by Fortune on a frowning
coast,

50

Which neither groves nor happy
valleys boast;

Where other cares than those the
Muse relates,

And other shepherds dwell with other
mates;

By such examples taught, I paint the
Cot,

As Truth will paint it, and as Bards
will not:

Nor you, ye poor, of letter'd scorn
complain,
To you the smoothest song is smooth
in vain;
O'ercome by labour, and bow'd down
by time,
Feel you the barren flattery of a
rhyme?
Can poets soothe you, when you pine
for bread,

60

By winding myrtles round your ruin'd
shed?
Can their light tales your weighty
griefs o'erpower,
Or glad with airy mirth the toilsome
hour?

Lo! where the heath, with
withering brake grown o'er,
Lends the light turf that warms the
neighbouring poor;
From thence a length of burning sand
appears,
Where the thin harvest waves its
wither'd ears;
Rank weeds, that every art and care
defy,
Reign o'er the land, and rob the
blighted rye:
There thistles stretch their prickly
arms afar,

70

And to the ragged infant threaten
war;
There poppies, nodding, mock the
hope of toil;

There the blue bugloss paints the
sterile soil;
Hardy and high, above the slender
sheaf,
The slimy mallow waves her silky
leaf;
O'er the young shoot the charlock
throws a shade,
And clasping tares cling round the
sickly blade;
With mingled tints the rocky coasts
abound,
And a sad splendour vainly shines
around.
So looks the nymph whom wretched
arts adorn,

80

Betray'd by man, then left for man to
scorn;
Whose cheek in vain assumes the
mimic rose,
While her sad eyes the troubled
breast disclose;
Whose outward splendour is but
folly's dress,
Exposing most, when most it gilds
distress.

Here joyless roam a wild
amphibious race,
With sullen wo display'd in every
face;
Who far from civil arts and social fly,
And scowl at strangers with
suspicious eye.

Here too the lawless merchant of
the main

90

Draws from his plough th' intoxicated
swain;
Want only claim'd the labour of the
day,
But vice now steals his nightly rest
away.

Where are the swains, who, daily
labour done,
With rural games play'd down the
setting sun;
Who struck with matchless force the
bounding ball,
Or made the pond'rous quoit
obliquely fall;
While some huge Ajax, terrible and
strong,
Engaged some artful stripling of the
throng,
And fell beneath him, foil'd, while far
around

100

Hoarse triumph rose, and rocks
return'd the sound?
Where now are these?—Beneath yon
cliff they stand,
To show the freighted pinnace where
to land;
To load the ready steed with guilty
haste;
To fly in terror o'er the pathless
waste;
Or, when detected in their straggling
course,
To foil their foes by cunning or by
force;
Or, yielding part (which equal knaves
demand),

To gain a lawless passport through
the land.

Here, wand'ring long amid these
frowning fields,

110

I sought the simple life that Nature
yields;

Rapine and Wrong and Fear usurp'd
her place,

And a bold, artful, surly, savage race;
Who, only skill'd to take the finny
tribe,

The yearly dinner, or septennial bribe,
Wait on the shore, and, as the waves
run high,

On the tost vessel bend their eager
eye,

Which to their coast directs its
vent'rous way;

[Their], or the ocean's, miserable
prey.

As on their neighbouring beach
yon swallows stand,

120

And wait for favouring winds to
leave the land,

While still for flight the ready wing is
spread:

So waited I the favouring hour, and
fled—

Fled from these shores where guilt
and famine reign,

And cried, Ah! hapless they who still
remain;

Who still remain to hear the ocean
roar,

Whose greedy waves devour the
lessening shore;
Till some fierce tide, with more
imperious sway,
Sweeps the low hut and all it holds
away;
When the sad tenant weeps from door
to door,

130

And begs a poor protection from the
poor!

But these are scenes where
Nature's niggard hand
Gave a spare portion to the famish'd
land;
Hers is the fault, if here mankind
complain
Of fruitless toil and labour spent in
vain.

But yet in other scenes, more fair in
view,

Where Plenty smiles—alas! she
smiles for few—

And those who taste }
not, yet behold }
her store,

Are as the slaves that dig the
golden ore,

The wealth around them
makes them doubly poor

140

Or will you deem them amply paid
in health,
Labour's fair child, that languishes
with wealth?

Go, then! and see them rising with
the sun,

Through a long course of daily toil to
run;
See them beneath the dog-star's
raging heat,
When the knees tremble and the
temples beat;
Behold them, leaning on their
scythes, look o'er
The labour past, and toils to come
explore;
See them alternate suns and showers
engage,
And hoard up aches and anguish for
their age;

150

Through fens and marshy moors their
steps pursue,
When their warm pores imbibe the
evening dew;
Then own that labour may as fatal be
To these thy slaves, as thine excess to
thee.

Amid this tribe too oft a manly
pride
Strives in strong toil the fainting heart
to hide;
There may you see the youth of
slender frame
Contend with weakness, weariness,
and shame;
Yet, urged along, and proudly loth to
yield,
He strives to join his fellows of the
field;

160

Till long-contending nature droops at
last,

Declining health rejects his poor
repast,
His cheerless spouse the coming
danger sees,
And mutual murmurs urge the slow
disease.

Yet grant them health, 'tis not for
us to tell,
Though the head droops not, that the
heart is well;
Or will you praise that homely,
healthy fare,
Plenteous and plain, that happy
peasants share?
Oh! trifle not with wants you cannot
feel,
Nor mock the misery of a stinted
meal—

170

Homely, not wholesome; plain, not
plenteous; such
As you who praise would never deign
to touch.

Ye gentle souls, who dream of rural
ease,
Whom the smooth stream and
smoother sonnet please;
Go! if the peaceful cot your praises
share,
Go, look within, and ask if peace be
there:
If peace be his—that drooping weary
sire,
Or theirs, that offspring round their
feeble fire;
Or hers, that matron pale, whose
trembling hand

Turns on the wretched hearth th'
expiring brand!

180

Nor yet can Time itself obtain for
these
Life's latest comforts, due respect and
ease:
For yonder see that hoary swain,
whose age
Can with no cares except his own
engage;
Who, propp'd on that rude staff, looks
up to see
The bare arms broken from the
withering tree,
On which, a boy, he climb'd the
loftiest bough,
Then his first joy, but his sad emblem
now.

He once was chief in all the rustic
trade;
His steady hand the straightest furrow
made;

190

Full many a prize he won, and still is
proud
To find the triumphs of his youth
allow'd.
A transient pleasure sparkles in his
eyes;
He hears and smiles, then thinks
again and sighs:
For now he journeys to his grave in
pain;
The rich disdain him, nay, the poor
disdain;

Alternate masters now their slave
command,
Urge the weak efforts of his feeble
hand;
And, when his age attempts its task in
vain,
With ruthless taunts, of lazy poor
complain^[15].

200

Oft may you see him, when he
tends the sheep,
His winter-charge, beneath the hillock
weep;
Oft hear him murmur to the winds
that blow
O'er his white locks and bury them in
snow,
When, roused by rage and muttering
in the morn,
He mends the broken hedge with icy
thorn:—

"Why do I live, when I desire to be
At once from life and life's long
labour free?
Like leaves in spring, the young are
blown away,
Without the sorrows of a slow decay;
210

I, like yon wither'd leaf, remain
behind,
Nipp'd by the frost, and shivering in
the wind;
There it abides till younger buds
come on,
As I, now all my fellow-swains are
gone;

Then, from the rising generation
thrust,

It falls, like me, unnoticed to the dust.

"These fruitful fields, these
numerous flocks I see,
Are others' gain, but killing cares to
me:

To me the children of my youth are
lords,

Cool in their looks, but hasty in their
words:

220

Wants of their own demand their
care; and who

Feels his own want and succours
others too?

A lonely, wretched man, in pain I go,
None need my help, and none relieve
my wo;

Then let my bones beneath the turf be
laid,

And men forget the wretch they
would not aid!"

Thus groan the old, till, by disease
oppress'd,

They taste a final wo, and then they
rest.

Theirs is yon house that holds the
parish poor,

Whose walls of mud scarce bear the
broken door;

230

There, where the putrid vapours,
flagging, play,

And the dull wheel hums doleful
through the day—

There children dwell, who know no
parents' care;
Parents, who know no children's love,
dwell there!
Heart-broken matrons on their joyless
bed,
Forsaken wives, and mothers never
wed;
Dejected widows with unheeded
tears,
And crippled age with more than
childhood fears;
The lame, the blind, and, far the
happiest they!
The moping idiot and the madman
gay.

240

Here too the sick their final doom
receive,
Here brought, amid the scenes of
grief, to grieve,
Where the loud groans from some sad
chamber flow,
Mix'd with the clamours of the crowd
below;
Here, sorrowing, they each kindred
sorrow scan,
And the cold charities of man to man:
Whose laws indeed for ruin'd age
provide,
And strong compulsion plucks the
scrap from pride;
But still that scrap is bought with
many a sigh,
And pride embitters what it can't
deny.

250

Say ye, oppress'd by some fantastic
woes,
Some jarring nerve that baffles your
repose;
Who press the downy couch, while
slaves advance
With timid eye to read the distant
glance;
Who with sad prayers the weary
doctor tease,
To name the nameless ever-new
disease;
Who with mock patience dire
complaints endure,
Which real pain, and that alone, can
cure—

How would ye bear in real pain to lie,
Despised, neglected, left alone to die?

260

How would ye bear to draw your
latest breath,
Where all that's wretched paves the
way for death?

Such is that room which one rude
beam divides,
And naked rafters form the sloping
sides;
Where the vile bands that bind the
thatch are seen,
And lath and mud are all that lie
between,
Save one dull pane, that, coarsely
patch'd, gives way
To the rude tempest, yet excludes the
day.

Here, on a matted flock, with dust
o'erspread,

The drooping wretch reclines his
languid head;

270

For him no hand the cordial cup
applies,
Or wipes the tear that stagnates in his
eyes;
No friends with soft discourse his
pain beguile,
Or promise hope till sickness wears a
smile.

But soon a loud and hasty
summons calls,
Shakes the thin roof, and echoes
round the walls.

Anon, a figure enters, quaintly neat,
All pride and business, bustle and
conceit;

With looks unalter'd by these scenes
of wo,

With speed that, entering, speaks his
haste to go,

280

He bids the gazing throng around him
fly,

And carries fate and physic in his
eye:

A potent quack, long versed in human
ills,

Who first insults the victim whom he
kills;

Whose murd'rous hand a drowsy
Bench protect.

And whose most tender mercy is
neglect.

Paid by the parish for attendance
here,

He wears contempt upon his sapient
sneer;
In haste he seeks the bed where
Misery lies,
Impatience mark'd in his averted
eyes;

290

And, some habitual queries hurried
o'er,
Without reply, he rushes on the door.
His drooping patient, long inured to
pain,
And long unheeded, knows
remonstrance vain;
He ceases now the feeble help to
crave
Of man; and silent sinks into the
grave.

But ere his death some pious
doubts arise,
Some simple fears, which "bold bad"
men despise:
Fain would he ask the parish-priest to
prove
His title certain to the joys above;

300

For this he sends the murmuring
nurse, who calls
The holy stranger to these dismal
walls;
And doth not he, the pious man,
appear,
He, "passing rich with forty pounds a
year"?
Ah! no; a shepherd of a different
stock,

And far unlike him, feeds this little
flock:

A jovial youth, who thinks his
Sunday's task

As much as God or man can fairly
ask;

The rest he gives to loves and labours
light,

To fields the morning, and to feasts
the night;

310

None better skill'd the noisy pack to
guide,

To urge their chase, to cheer them or
to chide;

A sportsman keen, he shoots through
half the day,

And, skill'd at whist, devotes the
night to play.

Then, while such honours bloom
around his head,

Shall he sit sadly by the sick man's
bed,

To raise the hope he feels not, or with
zeal

To combat fears that e'en the pious
feel?

Now once again the }
gloomy
scene
explore,

Less gloomy now; the bitter
hour is o'er,

320

The man of many sorrows sighs no
more.—

Up yonder hill, behold how sadly
slow
The bier moves winding from the
vale below;
There lie the happy dead, from
trouble free,
And the glad parish pays the frugal
fee.
No more, O Death! thy victim starts
to hear
Churchwarden stern, or kingly
overseer;
No more the farmer claims his
humble bow,
Thou art his lord, the best of tyrants
thou!

Now to the church behold the
mourners come,

330

Sedately torpid and devoutly dumb;
The village children now their games
suspend,
To see the bier that bears their ancient
friend:
For he was one in all their idle sport,
And like a monarch ruled their little
court;
The pliant bow he form'd, the flying
ball,
The bat, the wicket, were his labours
all;
Him now they follow to his grave,
and stand
Silent and sad, and gazing, hand in
hand;
While bending low, their eager eyes
explore

340

The mingled relics of the parish poor.
The bell tolls late, the moping owl
 flies round,
Fear marks the flight and magnifies
 the sound;
The busy priest, detain'd by weightier
 care,
Defers his duty till the day of prayer;
And, waiting long, the crowd retire
 distress'd,
To think a poor man's bones should
 lie unblest'd^[16].

BOOK II.

re are found, amid the Evils of a laborious Life, some Views of Tranquillity and Happiness—The
Repose and Pleasure of a Summer Sabbath: interrupted by Intoxication and Dispute—Village
Detraction—Complaints of the 'Squire—The Evening Riots—Justice—Reasons for this unpleasant
View of Rustic Life: the Effect it should have upon the Lower Classes; and the Higher—These last
have their peculiar Distresses: Exemplified in the Life and heroic Death of Lord Robert Manners—
Concluding Address to His Grace the Duke of Rutland.

No longer truth, though shown in
 verse, disdain,
But own the Village Life a life of
 pain.
I too must yield, that oft amid these
 woes
Are gleams of transient mirth and
 hours of sweet repose,
Such as you find on yonder sportive
 Green,
The 'squire's tall gate and churchway-
 walk between;
Where loitering stray a little tribe of
 friends,
On a fair Sunday when the sermon
 ends.

Then rural beaux their best attire put
on,

10

To win their nymphs, as other
nymphs are won;

While those long wed go plain, and,
by degrees,

Like other husbands, quit their care to
please.

Some of the sermon talk, a sober
crowd,

And loudly praise, if it were preach'd
aloud;

Some on the labours of the week look
round,

Feel their own worth, and think their
toil renown'd;

While some, whose hopes to no
renown extend,

Are only pleased to find their labours
end.

Thus, as their hours glide on, with
pleasure fraught,

20

Their careful masters brood the
painful thought;

Much in their mind they murmur and
lament,

That one fair day should be so idly
spent;

And think that Heaven deals hard, to
tithe their store

And tax their time for preachers and
the poor.

Yet still, ye humbler friends, enjoy
your hour,

This is your portion, yet unclaim'd of
power;

This is Heaven's gift to weary men
oppress'd,

And seems the type of their expected
rest.

But yours, alas! are joys that soon
decay;

30

Frail joys, begun and ended with the
day;

Or yet, while day permits those joys
to reign,

The village vices drive them from the
plain.

See the stout churl, in drunken fury
great,

Strike the bare bosom of his teeming
mate!

His naked vices, rude and unrefined,
Exert their open empire o'er the mind;
But can we less the senseless rage
despise,

Because the savage acts without
disguise?

Yet here disguise, the city's vice, is
seen,

40

And Slander steals along and taints
the Green:

At her approach domestic peace is
gone,

Domestic broils at her approach come
on;

She to the wife the husband's crime
conveys,

She tells the husband when his
 consort strays,
Her busy tongue through all the little
 state
Diffuses doubt, suspicion, and debate;
Peace, tim'rous goddess! quits her old
 domain,
In sentiment and song content to
 reign.

 Nor are the nymphs that breathe
 the rural air

50

So fair as Cynthia's, nor so chaste as
 fair:
These to the town afford each fresher
 face,
And the clown's trull receives the
 peer's embrace;
From whom, should chance again
 convey her down,
The peer's disease in turn attacks the
 clown.

 Here too the 'squire, or 'squire-like
 farmer, talk,
How round their regions nightly
 pilferers walk;
How from their ponds the fish are
 borne, and all
The rip'ning treasures from their lofty
 wall;
How meaner rivals in their sports
 delight,

60

Just rich enough to claim a doubtful
 right;
Who take a licence round their fields
 to stray,

A mongrel race! the poachers of the
day.

And hark! the riots of the Green
begin,
That sprang at first from yonder noisy
inn;
What time the weekly pay was
vanish'd all,
And the slow hostess scored the
threatening wall;
What time they ask'd, their friendly
feast to close,
A final cup, and that will make them
foes;
When blows ensue that break the arm
of toil,

70

And rustic battle ends the boobies'
broil.

Save when to yonder Hall they
bend their way,
Where the grave justice ends the
grievous fray;
He who recites, to keep the poor in
awe,
The law's vast volume—for he knows
the law:—
To him with anger or with shame
repair
The injured peasant and deluded fair.

Lo! at his throne the silent nymph
appears,
Frail by her shape, but modest in her
tears;
And while she stands abash'd, with
conscious eye,

80

Some favourite female of her judge
glides by,
Who views with scornful glance the
strumpet's fate,
And thanks the stars that made her
keeper great;
Near her the swain, about to bear for
life
One certain evil, doubts 'twixt war
and wife;
But, while the falt'ring damsel takes
her oath,
Consents to wed, and so secures them
both.

Yet, why, you ask, these humble
crimes relate,
Why make the poor as guilty as the
great?
To show the great, those mightier
sons of pride,

90

How near in vice the lowest are
allied;
Such are their natures and their
passions such,
But these disguise too little, those too
much:
So shall the man of power and
pleasure see
In his own slave as vile a wretch as
he;
In his luxurious lord the servant find
His own low pleasures and
degenerate mind:
And each in all the kindred vices
trace

Of a poor, blind, bewilder'd, erring
race;

Who, a short time in varied fortune
past,

100

Die, and are equal in the dust at last.

And you, ye poor, who still lament
your fate,

Forbear to envy those you call the
great;

And know, amid those blessings they
possess,

They are, like you, the victims of
distress;

While sloth with many a pang
torments her slave,

Fear waits on guilt, and danger
shakes the brave.

Oh! if in life one noble chief
appears,

Great in his name, while blooming in
his years;

Born to enjoy whate'er delights
mankind,

110

And yet to all you feel or fear
resign'd;

Who gave up joys and hopes, to you
unknown,

For pains and dangers greater than
your own:

If such there be, then let your
murmurs cease,

Think, think of him, and take your lot
in peace.

And such there was:—Oh! grief,
that checks our pride!

Weeping we say, there was—for
Manners died:
Beloved of Heaven, these humble
lines forgive,
That sing of Thee^[17], and thus aspire
to live.
As the tall oak, whose vigorous
branches form

120

An ample shade and brave the wildest
storm,
High o'er the subject wood is seen to
grow,
The guard and glory of the trees
below;
Till on its head the fiery bolt
descends,
And o'er the plain the shatter'd trunk
extends;
Yet then it lies, all wond'rous as
before,
And still the glory, though the guard
no more:
So THOU, when every virtue,
every grace,
Rose in thy soul, or shone within thy
face;
When, though the son of Granby,
thou wert known

130

Less by thy father's glory than thy
own;
When Honour loved and gave thee
every charm,
Fire to thy eye and vigour to thy arm;
Then from our lofty hopes and
longing eyes,

Fate and thy virtues call'd thee to the
 skies;
Yet still we wonder at thy tow'ring
 fame,
And, losing thee, still dwell upon thy
 name.

 Oh! ever honour'd, ever valued!
 say,
What verse can praise thee, or what
 work repay?
Yet verse (in all we can) thy worth
 repays,

140

Nor trusts the tardy zeal of future
 days;—
Honours for thee thy country shall
 prepare,
Thee in their hearts, the good, the
 brave shall bear;
To deeds like thine shall noblest
 chiefs aspire,
The Muse shall mourn thee, and the
 world admire.

 In future times, when, smit with
 Glory's charms,
The untried youth first quits a father's
 arms;—

"Oh! be like him," the weeping sire
 shall say;

"Like Manners walk, who walk'd in
 Honour's way;

In danger foremost, yet in death
 sedate,

150

Oh! be like him in all things, but his
 fate!"

If for that fate such public tears be
shed,
That Victory seems to die now THOU
art dead;
How shall a friend his nearer hope
resign,
That friend a brother, and whose soul
was thine?
By what bold lines shall we his grief
express,
Or by what soothing numbers make it
less?
'Tis not, I know, the chiming of a
song,
Nor all the powers that to the Muse
belong,
Words aptly cull'd and meanings well
express'd,

160

Can calm the sorrows of a wounded
breast;
But Virtue, soother of the fiercest
pains,
Shall heal that bosom, Rutland, where
she reigns.

Yet hard the task to heal the
bleeding heart,
To bid the still-recurring thoughts
depart,
Tame the fierce grief and stem the
rising sigh,
And curb rebellious passion with
reply;
Calmly to dwell on all that pleased
before,
And yet to know that all shall please
no more—

Oh! glorious labour of the soul, to
save

170

Her captive powers, and bravely
mourn the brave.

To such these thoughts will lasting
comfort give—

Life is not measured by the time we
live:

'Tis not an even course of threescore
years,

A life of narrow views and paltry
fears,

Gray hairs and wrinkles and the cares
they bring,

That take from death the terrors or the
sting;

But 'tis the gen'rous spirit, mounting
high

Above the world, that native of the
sky;

The noble spirit, that, in dangers
brave,

180

Calmly looks on, or looks beyond the
grave:—

Such Manners was, so he resign'd his
breath,

If in a glorious, then a timely death.

Cease then that grief, and let those
tears subside;

If Passion rule us, be that passion
pride;

If Reason, Reason bids us strive to
raise

Our fallen hearts, and be like him we
praise;

Or, if Affection still }
the soul }
subdue,

Bring all his virtues, all his
worth in view,
And let Affection find its
comfort too:

190

For how can Grief so deeply wound
the heart,
When Admiration claims so large a
part?

Grief is a foe; expel him, then, thy
soul;

Let nobler thoughts the nearer views
control!

Oh! make the age to come thy better
care;

See other Rutlands, other Granbys
there!

And, as thy thoughts through
streaming ages glide,

See other heroes die as Manners died:

And, from their fate, thy race shall
nobler grow,

As trees shoot upwards that are
pruned below;

200

Or as old Thames, borne down with
decent pride,

Sees his young streams run warbling
at his side;

Though some, by art cut off, no
longer run,

And some are lost beneath the
summer's sun—

Yet the pure stream moves on, and, as
it moves,
Its power increases and its use
improves;
While plenty round its spacious
waves bestow,
Still it flows on, and shall for ever
flow.

NOTES TO THE VILLAGE.

[15] Note 1, page 125, lines 198 and 199.

*And, when his age attempts its task in
vain,
With ruthless taunts, of lazy poor
complain.*

A pauper who, being nearly past his labour, is employed by different masters for a length of time, proportioned to their occupations.

[16] Note 2, page 128, lines 345 and 346.

*And, waiting long, the crowd retire
distress'd
To think a poor man's bones should lie
unbless'd.*

Some apology is due for the insertion of a circumstance by no means common: that it has been a subject for complaint in any place is a sufficient reason for its being reckoned among the evils which may happen to the poor, and which must happen to them exclusively; nevertheless, it is just to remark, that such neglect is very rare in any part of the kingdom, and in many parts is totally unknown.

[17] Note 3, page 133, lines 117 and 118.

*Beloved of Heaven, these humble lines
forgive,
That sing of Thee, and thus aspire to
live.*

Lord Robert Manners, the youngest son of the Marquis of Granby and the Lady Frances Seymour, daughter of Charles Duke of Somerset, was born the 5th of February, 1758; and was placed with his brother, the late Duke of Rutland, at Eton school, where he acquired, and ever after retained, a considerable knowledge of the classical authors.

Lord Robert, after going through the duties of his profession on board different ships, was made captain of the *Resolution*, and commanded her in nine different actions, besides the last memorable one on the 2nd of April, 1782, when, in breaking the French line of battle, he received the wounds which terminated his life, in the twenty-fourth year of his age.—*See the Annual Register, printed for Mr. Dodsley.*

THE NEWSPAPER.

E quibus, hi vacuas implent
sermonibus aures,
Hi narrata ferunt alio: Mensuraque
ficti
Crescit, et auditis aliquid novus
adjicit auctor:
Illic Credulitas, illic temerarius Error,
Vanaque Lætitia est, consternatique
Timores,
Seditioque recens, dubioque auctore
Susurri.

Ovid.

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DEDICATION

TO THE RIGHT HONOURABLE

EDWARD LORD THURLOW,

LORD HIGH CHANCELLOR OF GREAT BRITAIN; ONE
OF HIS MAJESTY'S MOST HONOURABLE PRIVY
COUNCIL, ETC. ETC.

MY LORD,

My obligations to your Lordship, great as they are, have not induced me to prefix your name to the following Poem; nor is it your Lordship's station, exalted as that is, which prevailed upon me to solicit the honour of your protection for it. But, when I considered your Lordship's great abilities and good taste, so well known and so universally acknowledged, I became anxious for the privilege with which you have indulged me; well knowing that the Public would not be easily persuaded to disregard a performance, marked, in any degree, with your Lordship's approbation.

It is, my Lord, the province of superior rank, in general, to bestow this kind of patronage; but superior talents only can render it valuable. Of the value of your Lordship's I am fully sensible; and, while I make my acknowledgments for that, and for many other favours, I cannot suppress the pride I have in thus publishing my gratitude, and declaring how much I have the honour to be,

MY LORD,

Your Lordship's most obedient

most obliged,

and devoted servant,

GEORGE CRABBE.

*Belvoir Castle,
February 20th, 1785.*

TO THE READER.

THE Poem which I now offer to the Public, is, I believe, the only one written on the subject; at least, it is the only one which I have any knowledge of; and, fearing there may not be found in it many things to

engage the Reader's attention, I am willing to take the strongest hold I can upon him, by offering something which has the claim of novelty.

When the subject first occurred to me, I meant, in a few lines only, to give some description of that variety of dissociating articles which are huddled together in our Daily Papers. As the thought dwelt upon me, I conceived this might be done methodically, and with some connection of parts, by taking a larger scope; which notwithstanding I have done, I must still apologize for a want of union and coherence in my Poem. Subjects like this will not easily admit of them: we cannot slide from theme to theme in an easy and graceful succession; but, on quitting one thought, there will be an unavoidable hiatus, and in general an awkward transition into that which follows.

That, in writing upon the subject of our Newspapers, I have avoided every thing which might appear like the opinion of a party, is to be accounted for from the knowledge I have gained from them; since, the more of these Instructors a man reads, the less he will infallibly understand; nor would it have been very consistent in me, at the same time to censure their temerity and ignorance, and to adopt their rage.

I should have been glad to have made some discrimination in my remarks on these productions. There is, indeed, some difference; and I have observed, that one editor will sometimes convey his abuse with more decency, and colour his falsehood with more appearance of probability, than another: but till I see that paper, wherein no great character is wantonly abused, nor groundless insinuation wilfully disseminated, I shall not make any distinction in my remarks upon them.

It must, however, be confessed, that these things have their use, and are, besides, vehicles of much amusement; but this does not outweigh the evil they do to society, and the irreparable injury they bring upon the characters of individuals. In the following Work I have given those good properties their due weight: they have changed indignation into mirth, and turned, what would otherwise have been abhorrence, into derision.

THE NEWSPAPER.

is not a Time favourable to poetical Composition; and why—Newspapers Enemies to Literature, and their general Influence—Their Numbers—The Sunday Monitor—Their general Character—Their Effect upon Individuals—upon Society—in the Country—The Village Freeholder—What Kind of Composition a Newspaper is; and the Amusement it affords—Of what Parts it is chiefly composed—Articles of Intelligence: Advertisements: The Stage: Quacks: Puffing—The Correspondents to a Newspaper; political and poetical—Advice to the latter—Conclusion.

A time like this, a busy, bustling
time,
Suits ill with writers, very ill with
rhyme:
Unheard we sing, when party-rage
runs strong,
And mightier madness checks the
flowing song:
Or, should we force the peaceful
Muse to wield
Her feeble arms amid the furious
field,
Where party-pens a wordy war
maintain,
Poor is her anger, and her friendship
vain;
And oft the foes who feel her sting,
combine,
10
Till serious vengeance pays an idle
line;
For party-poets are like wasps, who
dart
Death to themselves, and to their foes
but smart.
Hard then our fate: if general
themes we choose,
Neglect awaits the song, and chills
the Muse;
Or, should we sing the subject of the
day,

To-morrow's wonder puffs our praise
away.

More bless'd the bards of that poetic
time,

When all found readers who could
find a rhyme;

Green grew the bays on every
teeming head,

20

And Cibber was enthroned, and Settle
read.

Sing, drooping Muse, the cause of thy
decline;

Why reign no more the once-
triumphant Nine?

Alas! new charms the wavering many
gain,

And rival sheets the reader's eye
detain;

A daily swarm, that banish every
Muse,

Come flying forth, and mortals call
them NEWS:

For these unread the noblest volumes
lie;

For these in sheets unsoil'd the Muses
die;

Unbought, unblest, the virgin
copies wait

30

In vain for fame, and sink, unseen, to
fate.

Since, then, the town forsakes us
for our foes,

The smoothest numbers for the
harshest prose;

Let us, with generous scorn, the taste
deride,

And sing our rivals with a rival's
pride.

Ye gentle poets, who so oft
complain

That foul neglect is all your labours
gain;

That pity only checks your growing
spite

To erring man, and prompts you still
to write;

That your choice works on humble
stalls are laid,

40

Or vainly grace the windows of the
trade;

Be ye my friends, if friendship e'er
can warm

Those rival bosoms whom the Muses
charm:

Think of the common cause wherein
we go,

Like gallant Greeks against the
Trojan foe;

Nor let one peevish chief his leader
blame,

Till, crown'd with conquest, we
regain our fame;

And let us join our forces to subdue
This bold assuming but successful
crew.

I sing of NEWS, and all those vapid
sheets

50

The rattling hawker vends through
 gaping streets;
Whate'er their name, whate'er the
 time they fly,
Damp from the press, to charm the
 reader's eye:
For, soon as morning dawns with
 roseate hue,
The Herald of the morn arises too;
Post after Post succeeds, and, all day
 long,
Gazettes and Ledgers swarm, a noisy
 throng.
When evening comes, she comes
 with all her train
Of Ledgers, Chronicles, and Posts
 again—
Like bats, appearing, when the sun
 goes down,

60

From holes obscure and corners of
 the town.
Of all these triflers, all like these, I
 write;
Oh! like my subject could my song
 delight,
The crowd at Lloyd's one poet's name
 should raise,
And all the Alley echo to his praise.
 In shoals the hours their constant
 numbers bring,
Like insects waking to th' advancing
 spring;
Which take their rise from grubs
 obscene that lie
In shallow pools, or thence ascend the
 sky:

Such are these base ephemeris, so
born

70

To die before the next revolving
morn.

Yet thus they differ: insect-tribes
are lost

In the first visit of a winter's frost;
While these remain, a base but
constant breed,

Whose swarming sons their short-
lived sires succeed:

No changing season makes their
number less,

Nor Sunday shines a sabbath on the
press!

Then, lo! the sainted Monitor is
born,

Whose pious face some sacred texts
adorn:

As artful sinners cloak the secret sin,

80

To veil with seeming grace the guile
within;

So Moral Essays on his front appear,

But all is carnal business in the rear;

The fresh-coin'd lie, the secret
whisper'd last,

And all the gleanings of the six days
past.

With these retired, through half the
Sabbath-day,

The London-lounger yawns his hours
away:

Not so, my little flock! your preacher
fly,

Nor waste the time no worldly wealth
can buy;
But let the decent maid and sober
clown

90

Pray for these idlers of the sinful
town:
This day, at least, on nobler themes
bestow,
Nor give to Woodfall, or the world
below.

But, Sunday pass'd, what numbers
flourish then,
What wond'rous labours of the press
and pen!
Diurnal most, some thrice each week
affords,
Some only once—O avarice of
words!
When thousand starving minds such
manna seek^[18],
To drop the precious food but once a
week.

Endless it were to sing the powers
of all,

100

Their names, their numbers; how they
rise and fall:
Like baneful herbs the gazer's eye
they seize,
Rush to the head, and poison where
they please:
Like idle flies, a busy, buzzing train,
They drop their maggots in the
trifler's brain;

That genial soil receives the fruitful
store,
And there they grow, and breed a
thousand more.

Now be their arts display'd, how
first they choose
A cause and party, as the bard his
muse;
Inspired by these, with clamorous
zeal they cry,

110

And through the town their dreams
and omens fly:
So the Sibylline leaves were blown
about^[19],
Disjointed scraps of fate involved in
doubt;
So idle dreams, the journals of the
night,
Are right and wrong by turns, and
mingle wrong with right.
Some champions for the rights that
prop the crown,
Some sturdy patriots, sworn to pull
them down;
Some neutral powers, with secret
forces fraught,
Wishing for war, but willing to be
bought:
While some to every side and party
go,

120

Shift every friend, and join with
every foe;
Like sturdy rogues in privateers, they
strike

This side and that, the foes of both
alike;

A traitor-crew, who thrive in troubled
times,

Fear'd for their force, and courted for
their crimes.

Chief to the prosperous side the
numbers sail,

Fickle and false, they veer with every
gale;

As birds that migrate from a freezing
shore,

In search of warmer climes, come
skimming o'er,

Some bold adventurers first prepare
to try

130

The doubtful sunshine of the distant
sky;

But soon the growing Summer's
certain sun

Wins more and more, till all at last
are won:

So, on the early prospect of disgrace,
Fly in vast troops this apprehensive
race;

Instinctive tribes! their failing food
they dread,

And buy, with timely change, their
future bread.

Such are our guides; how many a
peaceful head,

Born to be still, have they to
wrangling led!

How many an honest zealot stol'n
from trade,

140

And factious tools of pious pastors
made!

With clews like these they tread the
maze of state,

These oracles explore, to learn our
fate;

Pleased with the guides who can so
well deceive,

Who cannot lie so fast as they
believe.

Oft lend I, loth, to some sage friend
an ear,

(For we who will not speak are
doom'd to hear);

While he, bewilder'd, tells his anxious
thought,

Infectious fear from tainted scribblers
caught,

Or idiot hope; for each his mind
assails,

150

As Lloyd's court-light or Stockdale's
gloom prevails.

Yet stand I patient while but one
declaims,

Or gives dull comments on the
speech he maims:

But oh! ye Muses, keep your votary's
feet

From tavern-haunts where politicians
meet;

Where rector, doctor, and attorney
pause,

First on each parish, then each public
cause:

[Indicted] roads and rates that still
increase;
The murmuring poor, who will not
fast in peace;
Election-zeal and friendship, since
declined;

160

A tax commuted, or a tithe in kind;
The Dutch and Germans kindling into
strife;
Dull port and poachers vile, the
serious ills of life.

Here comes the neighbouring
justice, pleased to guide
His little club, and in the chair
preside.

In private business his commands
prevail,
On public themes his reasoning turns
the scale;
Assenting silence soothes his happy
ear,
And, in or out, his party triumphs
here.

Nor here th' infectious rage for
party stops,

170

But flits along from palaces to shops;
Our weekly journals o'er the land
abound,
And spread their plague and
influenzas round;
The village, too, the peaceful,
pleasant plain,
Breeds the Whig-farmer and the
Tory-swain;

Brookes' and St. Alban's boasts not,
but, instead,
Stares the Red Ram, and swings the
Rodney's Head:—
Hither, with all a patriot's care, comes
he
Who owns the little hut that makes
him free;
Whose yearly forty shillings buy the
smile

180

Of mightier men, and never waste the
while;
Who feels his freehold's worth, and
looks elate,
A little prop and pillar of the state.
Here he delights the weekly news
to con,
And mingle comments as he blunders
on;
To swallow all their varying authors
teach,
To spell a title, and confound a
speech:
Till with a muddled mind he quits the
news,
And claims his nation's licence to
abuse;
Then joins the cry, "That all the
courtly race

190

Are venal candidates for power and
place";
Yet feels some joy, amid the general
vice,
That his own vote will bring its
wonted price.

These are the ills the teeming press
supplies,
The pois'nous springs from learning's
fountain rise;
Not there the wise alone their
entrance find,
Imparting useful light to mortals
blind;
But, blind themselves, these erring
guides hold out
Alluring lights, to lead us far about;
Screen'd by such means, here Scandal
whets her quill,
200
Here Slander shoots unseen, whene'er
she will;
Here Fraud and Falsehood labour to
deceive,
And Folly aids them both, impatient
to believe.

Such, sons of Britain! are the
guides ye trust;
So wise their counsel, their reports so
just:—
Yet, though we cannot call their
morals pure,
Their judgment nice, or their
decisions sure;
Merit they have, to mightier works
unknown,
A style, a manner, and a fate their
own.

We, who for longer fame with
labour strive,

Are pain'd to keep our sickly works
 alive;
Studios we toil, with patient care
 refine,
Nor let our love protect one languid
 line.
Severe ourselves, at last our works
 appear,
When, ah! we find our readers more
 severe;
For after all our care and pains, how
 few
Acquire applause, or keep it if they
 do!—

Not so these sheets, ordain'd to
 happier fate,
Praised through their day, and but that
 day their date;
Their careless authors only strive to
 join

220

As many words as make an even
 line^[20];
As many lines as fill a row complete;
As many rows as furnish up a sheet:
From side to side, with ready types
 they run,
The measure's ended, and the work is
 done;
Oh, born with ease, how envied and
 how blest!
Your fate to-day and your to-
 morrow's rest.
To you all readers turn, and they can
 look
Pleased on a paper, who abhor a
 book;

Those, who ne'er deign'd their Bible
to peruse,

230

Would think it hard to be denied their
news;

Sinners and saints, the wisest with the
weak,

Here mingle tastes, and one
amusement seek;

This, like the public inn, provides a
treat,

Where each promiscuous guest sits
down to eat;

And such this mental food, as we
may call

Something to all men, and to some
men all.

Next, in what rare production shall
we trace

Such various subjects in so small a
space?

As the first ship upon the waters bore

240

Incongruous kinds who never met
before;

Or as some curious virtuoso joins,

In one small room, moths, minerals,
and coins,

Birds, beasts, and fishes; nor refuses
place

To serpents, toads, and all the reptile
race:

So here, compress'd within a single
sheet,

Great things and small, the mean and
mighty meet:

'Tis this which makes all Europe's
business known,
Yet here a private man may place his
own;
And, where he reads of Lords and
Commons, he

250

May tell their honours that he sells
rappee.

Add next th' amusement which the
motley page
Affords to either sex and every age:
Lo! where it comes before the
cheerful fire—

Damps from the press in smoky curls
aspire

(As from the earth the sun exhales the
dew),

Ere we can read the wonders that
ensue:

Then, eager, every eye surveys the
part,

That brings its favourite subject to the
heart;

Grave politicians look for facts alone,
260

And gravely add conjectures of their
own:

The sprightly nymph, who never
broke her rest

For tottering crowns, or mighty lands
oppress'd,

Finds broils and battles, but neglects
them all

For songs and suits, a birth-day, or a
ball;

The keen warm man o'erlooks each
idle tale
For "Money's wanted," and "Estates
on Sale";
While some with equal minds to all
attend,
Pleased with each part, and grieved to
find an end.

So charm the News; but we, who,
far from town,
270
Wait till the postman brings the
packet down,
Once in the week a vacant day
behold,
And stay for tidings, till they're three
days old:
That day arrives; no welcome post
appears,
But the dull morn a sullen aspect
wears;
We meet, but ah! without our wonted
smile,
To talk of headaches, and complain of
bile;
Sullen, we ponder o'er a dull repast,
Nor feast the body while the mind
must fast.

A master-passion is the love of
news,
280
Not music so commands, nor so the
Muse:
Give poets claret, they grow idle
soon;

Feed the musician, and he's out of
tune;
But the sick mind, of this disease
possess'd,
Flies from all cure, and sickens when
at rest.

Now sing, my Muse, what various
parts compose
These rival sheets of politics and
prose.

First, from each brother's hoard a
part they draw,
A mutual theft that never fear'd a law;
Whate'er they gain, to each man's
portion fall,

290

And read it once, you read it through
them all:

For this their runners ramble day and
night,

To drag each lurking deed to open
light;

For daily bread the dirty trade they
ply,

Coin their fresh tales, and live upon
the lie.

Like bees for honey, forth for news
they spring—

Industrious creatures! ever on the
wing;

Home to their several cells they bear
the store,

Cull'd of all kinds, then roam abroad
for more.

No anxious virgin flies to "fair
Tweed-side";

300

No injured husband mourns his
faithless bride;
No duel dooms the fiery youth to
bleed,
But through the town transpires each
vent'rous deed.

Should some fair frail-one drive
her prancing pair,
Where rival peers contend to please
the fair;
When, with new force, she aids her
conquering eyes,
And beauty decks with all that beauty
buys—
Quickly we learn whose heart her
influence feels,
Whose acres melt before her glowing
wheels.

To these a thousand idle themes
succeed,

310

Deeds of all kinds, and comments to
each deed.
Here stocks, the state-barometers, we
view,
That rise or fall, by causes known to
few;
Promotion's ladder who goes up or
down;
Who wed, or who seduced, amuse the
town;
What new-born heir has made his
father blest;

What heir exults, his father now at
rest;
That ample list the Tyburn-herald
gives,
And each known knave, who still for
Tyburn lives.

So grows the work, and now the
printer tries
320
His powers no more, but leans on his
allies.

When, lo! the advertising tribe
succeed,
Pay to be read, yet find but few will
read;
And chief th' illustrious race, whose
drops and pills
Have patent powers to vanquish
human ills:
These, with their cures, a constant aid
remain,
To bless the pale composer's fertile
brain;
Fertile it is, but still the noblest soil
Requires some pause, some intervals
from toil;
And they at least a certain ease obtain
330
From Katterfelto's skill, and
Graham's glowing strain.

I too must aid, and pay to see my
name
Hung in these dirty avenues to fame;

Nor pay in vain, if aught the Muse
has seen
And sung, could make those avenues
more clean;
Could stop one slander ere it found its
way,
And gave to public scorn its helpless
prey.
By the same aid, the Stage invites her
friends,
And kindly tells the banquet she
intends;
Thither from real life the many run,
340
With Siddons weep, or laugh with
Abingdon;
Pleased, in fictitious joy or grief, to
see
The mimic passion with their own
agree;
To steal a few enchanted hours away
From care, and drop the curtain on
the day.
But who can steal from self that
wretched wight,
Whose darling work is tried, some
fatal night?
Most wretched man! when, bane to
every bliss,
He hears the serpent-critic's rising
hiss;
Then groans succeed; not traitors on
the wheel
350
Can feel like him, or have such pangs
to feel.

Nor end they here: next day he reads
his fall
In every paper; critics are they all;
He sees his branded name, with wild
affright,
And hears again the cat-calls of the
night.

Such help the STAGE affords; a
larger space
Is fill'd by PUFFS and all the puffing
race.
Physic had once alone the lofty style,
The well-known boast, that ceased to
raise a smile;
Now all the province of that tribe
invade,
360
And we abound in quacks of every
trade.

The simple barber, once an honest
name—
Cervantes founded, Fielding raised
his fame—
Barber no more, a gay perfumer
comes,
On whose soft cheek his own
cosmetic blooms;
Here he appears, each simple mind to
move,
And advertises beauty, grace, and
love.
—"Come, faded belles, who would
your youth renew,
And learn the wonders of Olympian
dew;

Restore the roses that begin to faint,
370
Nor think celestial washes vulgar
 paint;
Your former features, airs, and arts
 assume,
Circassian virtues, with Circassian
 bloom.
—Come, batter'd beaux, whose locks
 are turn'd to grey,
And crop Discretion's lying badge
 away;
Read where they vend these smart
 engaging things,
These flaxen frontlets with elastic
 springs;
No female eye the fair deception sees,
Not Nature's self so natural as these."
 Such are their arts, but not
 confined to them,

380
The Muse impartial must her sons
 condemn:
For they, degenerate! join the venal
 throng,
And puff a lazy Pegasus along:
More guilty these, by Nature less
 design'd
For little arts that suit the vulgar-kind;
That barbers' boys, who would to
 trade advance,
Wish us to call them, smart Friseurs
 from France;
That he who builds a chop-house, on
 his door
Paints "The true old original Blue
 Boar!"

These are the arts by which a
thousand live,

390

Where Truth may smile, and Justice
may forgive;

But when, amid this rabble-rout, we
find

A puffing poet to his honour blind;

Who [slily] drops quotations all
about,

Packet or Post, and points their merit
out;

Who advertises what reviewers say,

With sham editions every second day;

Who dares not trust his praises out of
sight,

But hurries into fame with all his
might;

Although the verse some transient
praise obtains,

400

Contempt is all the anxious poet
gains.

Now, puffs exhausted,
advertisements past,

Their correspondents stand exposed
at last;

These are a numerous tribe, to fame
unknown,

Who for the public good forego their
own;

Who, volunteers, in paper-war
engage,

With double portion of their party's
rage:

Such are the Bruti, Decii, who appear

Wooing the printer for admission
here;

Whose generous souls can
condescend to pray

410

For leave to throw their precious time
away.

Oh! cruel Woodfall! when a patriot
draws

His grey-goose quill in his dear
country's cause,

To vex and maul a ministerial race,

Can thy stern soul refuse the
champion place?

Alas! thou know'st not with what
anxious heart

He longs his best-loved labours to
impart;

How he has sent them to thy brethren
round,

And still the same unkind reception
found:

At length indignant will he damn the
state,

420

Turn to his trade, and leave us to our
fate.

These Roman souls, like Rome's
great sons, are known
To live in cells on labours of their
own.

Thus Milo, could we see the noble
chief,

Feeds, for his country's good, on legs
of beef;

Camillus copies deeds for sordid pay,

Yet fights the public battles twice a
day;
E'en now the godlike Brutus views
his score
Scroll'd on the bar-board, swinging
with the door;
Where, tippling punch, grave Cato's
self you'll see,
430
And *Amor Patriæ* vending smuggled
tea.

Last in these ranks and least, their
art's disgrace,
Neglected stand the Muse's meanest
race:
Scribblers who court contempt,
whose verse the eye
Disdainful views, and glances swiftly
by:
This Poet's Corner is the place they
choose,
A fatal nursery for an infant Muse;
Unlike that corner where true poets
lie,
These cannot live, and they shall
never die;
Hapless the lad whose mind such
dreams invade,
440
And win to verse the talents due to
trade.

Curb, then, O youth! these raptures
as they rise;
Keep down the evil spirit and be
wise;

Follow your calling, think the Muses
foes,
Nor lean upon the pestle and
compose.

I know your day-dreams, and I
know the snare
Hid in your flow'ry path, and cry
"Beware."

Thoughtless of ill, and to the future
blind,
A sudden couplet rushes on your
mind;
Here you may nameless print your
idle rhymes,

450

And read your first-born work a
thousand times;
Th' infection spreads, your couplet
grows apace—

Stanzas to Delia's dog or Celia's face;
You take a name: Philander's odes are
seen,

Printed, and praised, in every
magazine;

Diarian sages greet their brother sage,
And your dark pages please th'
enlighten'd age.—

Alas! what years you thus consume in
vain,

Ruled by this wretched bias of the
brain!

Go! to your desks and counters all
return;

460

Your sonnets scatter, your acrostics
burn;
Trade, and be rich; or, should your
careful sires
Bequeath you wealth, indulge the
nobler fires;
Should love of fame }
your youthful }
heart betray,
Pursue fair fame, but in a
glorious way,
Nor in the idle scenes of
Fancy's painting stray.

Of all the good that mortal men
pursue,
The Muse has least to give, and gives
to few;
Like some coquettish fair, she leads
us on,
With smiles and hopes, till youth and
peace are gone;

470

Then, wed for life, the restless
wrangling pair
Forget how constant one, and one
how fair:
Meanwhile, Ambition, like a
blooming bride,
Brings power and wealth to grace her
lover's side;
And, though she smiles not with such
flattering charms,
The brave will sooner win her to their
arms.

Then wed to her, if Virtue tie the
bands,

Go spread your country's fame in
 hostile lands;
 Her court, her senate, or her arms
 adorn,
 And let her foes lament that you were
 born:
 480
 Or weigh her laws, their ancient
 rights defend,
 Though hosts oppose, be theirs and
 Reason's friend;
 Arm'd with strong powers, in their
 defence engage,
 And rise the Thurlow of the future
 age!

NOTES TO THE NEWSPAPER.

[18] Note 1, page 144, line 97.

When thousand starving minds such manna seek.

The Manna of the Day. *Green's Spleen.*

[19] Note 2, page 145, line 111.

So the Sibylline leaves were blown about.

. in foliis descripsit carmina
 Virgo;—
 et [teneras] turbavit janua
 frondes.

Virg.

*Æ
 nei
 d.
 lib
 .
 iii.
 [v
 v.
 44
 5,*

[20] Note 3, page 147, lines 220-2.

*As many words as make an even line;
As many lines as fill a row complete;
As many rows as furnish up a sheet.*
How many hours bring about the day;
How many days will furnish up the
year;
How many years a mortal man may live.
&c.

*Shakspear
e's
He
nr
y
VI.
[P
art
III.
Ac
t
II.
Sc.
5.]*

THE PARISH REGISTER.

IN THREE PARTS.

INTRODUCTION.

Village Register considered, as containing principally the Annals of the Poor—State of the Peasantry as meliorated by Frugality and Industry—The Cottage of an industrious Peasant; its Ornaments—Prints and Books—The Garden; its Satisfaction—The State of the Poor, when improvident and vicious—The Row or Street, and its Inhabitants—The Dwelling of one of these—A Public House—Garden and its Appendages—Gamesters; rustic Sharpers, &c.—Conclusion of the Introductory Part.

PART I.

BAPTISMS.

Child of the Miller's Daughter, and Relation of her Misfortune—A frugal Couple: their Kind of Frugality—Plea of the Mother of a natural Child: her Churching—Large Family of Gerard Ablett: his Apprehensions: Comparison between his State and that of the wealthy Farmer his Master: his Consolation—An old Man's Anxiety for an Heir: the Jealousy of another on having many—Characters of the Grocer Dawkins and his Friend: their different Kinds of Disappointment—Three Infants named—An Orphan Girl and Village School-mistress—Gardener's Child: Pedantry and Conceit of the Father: his Botanical Discourse: Method of fixing the Embryo-fruit of Cucumbers—Absurd Effects of Rustic Vanity: observed in the Names of their Children—Relation of the Vestry Debate on a Foundling: Sir Richard Monday—Children of various Inhabitants—The poor Farmer—Children of a Profligate: his Character and Fate—Conclusion.

Tum porro puer (ut sævis projectus ab
undis
Navita) nudus humi jacet, infans, indigus
omni
Vitali auxilio——
Vagituque locum lugubri complet, ut
æquum est,
Cui tantum in vitâ [restet] transire
malorum.

Lucret. de
Nat.
Rer
um,
lib.
v.
[vv.
223
—5,
227
—
8.]

The year revolves, and I again
explore
The simple annals of my parish poor:
What infant-members in my flock
appear;

What pairs I bless'd in the departed
year;
And who, of old or young, or nymphs
or swains,
Are lost to life, its pleasures and its
pains.

No Muse I ask, before my view to
bring
The humble actions of the swains I
sing—
How pass'd the youthful, how the old
their days;

10

Who sank in sloth, and who aspired
to praise;
Their tempers, manners, morals,
customs, arts;
What parts they had, and how they
'mploy'd their parts;
By what elated, soothed, seduced,
depress'd,
Full well I know—these records give
the rest.

Is there a place, save one the poet
sees,
A land of love, of liberty and ease;
Where labour wearies not, nor cares
suppress
Th' eternal flow of rustic happiness;
Where no proud mansion frowns in
awful state,

20

Or keeps the sunshine from the
cottage-gate,
Where young and old, intent on
pleasure, throng,

And half man's life is holiday and
song?

Vain search for scenes like these! no
view appears,

By sighs unruffled or unstain'd by
tears;

Since vice the world subdued and
waters drown'd.

Auburn and Eden can no more be
found.

Hence good and evil mix'd, but
man has skill

And power to part them, when he
feels the will!

Toil, care, and patience bless th'
abstemious few,

30

Fear, shame, and want the thoughtless
herd pursue.

Behold the cot! where thrives th'
industrious swain,

Source of his pride, his pleasure, and
his gain;

Screen'd from the winter's wind, the
sun's last ray

Smiles on the window and prolongs
the day;

Projecting thatch the woodbine's
branches stop,

And turn their blossoms to the
casement's top:

All need requires is in that cot
contain'd,

And much that taste, untaught and
unrestrain'd,

Surveys delighted; there she loves to
trace,

40

In one gay picture, all the royal race;
Around the walls are heroes, lovers,
kings;

The print that shows them and the
verse that sings.

Here the last Lewis on his throne is
seen,

And there he stands imprison'd, and
his queen;

To these the mother takes her child,
and shows

What grateful duty to his God he
owes;

Who gives to him a happy home,
where he

Lives and enjoys his freedom with
the free;

When kings and queens, dethroned,
insulted, tried,

50

Are all these blessings of the poor
denied.

There is King Charles, and all his
Golden Rules,

Who proved Misfortune's was the
best of schools:

And there his son, who, tried by years
of pain,

Proved that misfortunes may be sent
in vain.

The magic-mill that grinds the
gran'nams young,

Close at the side of kind Godiva
hung;

She, of her favourite place the pride
and joy,

Of charms at once most lavish and
most coy,
By wanton act the purest fame could
raise,

60

And give the boldest deed the
chastest praise.

There stands the stoutest Ox in
England fed;
There fights the boldest Jew,
Whitechapel-bred;
And here Saint Monday's worthy
votaries live
In all the joys that ale and skittles
give.

Now, lo! in Egypt's coast that
hostile fleet,
By nations dreaded and by Nelson
beat;
And here shall soon another triumph
come,
A deed of glory in a day of gloom—
Distressing glory! grievous boon of
fate!

70

The proudest conquest, at the dearest
rate.

On shelf of deal, beside the
cuckoo-clock,
Of cottage-reading rests the chosen
stock;
Learning we lack, not books, but
have a kind
For all our wants, a meat for every
mind:
The tale for wonder and the joke for
whim,

The half-sung sermon and the half-
groan'd hymn.

No need of classing; each within
its place,
The feeling finger in the dark can
trace;
"First from the corner, farthest from
the wall":

80

Such all the rules, and they suffice for
all.

There pious works for Sunday's use
are found,
Companions for that Bible newly
bound:
That Bible, bought by sixpence
weekly saved,
Has choicest prints by famous hands
engraved;
Has choicest notes by many a famous
head,
Such as to doubt have rustic readers
led;
Have made them stop to reason, *why?*
and *how?*
And, where they once agreed, to cavil
now.

Oh! rather give me commentators
plain,

90

Who with no deep researches vex the
brain;
Who from the dark and doubtful love
to run,
And hold their glimmering tapers to
the sun;

Who simple truth with nine-fold
reasons back,
And guard the point no enemies
attack.

Bunyan's famed Pilgrim rests that
shelf upon;
A genius rare but rude was honest
John:

Not one who, early by the Muse
beguiled,
Drank from her well the waters
undefiled;
Not one who slowly gain'd the hill
sublime,

100

Then often sipp'd and little at a time;
But one who dabbled in the sacred
springs,
And drank them muddy, mix'd with
baser things.

Here, to interpret dreams we read
the rules—
Science our own, and never taught in
schools;
In moles and specks we Fortune's
gifts discern,
And Fate's fix'd will from Nature's
wanderings learn.

Of Hermit Quarle we read, in
island rare,
Far from mankind and seeming far
from care;
Safe from all want, and sound in
every limb;

110

Yes! there was he, and there was care
with him.

Unbound and heap'd, these valued
works beside,
Lay humbler works the pedler's pack
supplied;
Yet these, long since, have all
acquired a name:
The Wandering Jew has found his
way to fame;
And fame, denied to many a labour'd
song,
Crowns Thumb the great, and
Hickerthrift the strong.

There too is he, by wizard-power
upheld,
Jack, by whose arm the giant-brood
were quell'd:
His shoes of swiftness on his feet he
placed;

120
His coat of darkness on his loins he
braced;
His sword of sharpness in his hand he
took,
And off the heads of doughty giants
stroke:
Their glaring eyes beheld no mortal
near;
No sound of feet alarm'd the drowsy
ear;
No English blood their pagan sense
could smell,
But heads dropp'd headlong,
wondering why they fell.

These are the peasant's joy, when,
placed at ease,
Half his delighted offspring mount
his knees.

To every cot the lord's indulgent
mind

130

Has a small space for garden-ground
assign'd;
Here—till return of morn dismiss'd
the farm—
The careful peasant plies the sinewy
arm,
Warm'd as he works, and casts his
look around
On every foot of that improving
ground:
It is his own he sees; his master's eye
Peers not about, some secret fault to
spy;
Nor voice severe is there, nor censure
known;—
Hope, profit, pleasure,—they are all
his own.

Here grow the humble [chives],
and, hard by them,

140

The leek with crown globose and
reedy stem;
High climb his pulse in many an even
row,
Deep strike the ponderous roots in
soil below;
And herbs of potent smell and
pungent taste
Give a warm relish to the night's
repast;
Apples and cherries grafted by his
hand,
And cluster'd nuts for neighbouring
market stand.

Nor thus concludes his labour: near
the cot,
The reed-fence rises round some
fav'rite spot;
Where rich carnations, }
pinks with }
purple eyes,

150
Proud hyacinths, the least some
florist's prize,
Tulips tall-stemm'd and
pounced auriculas rise.
Here on a Sunday-eve, when
service ends,
Meet and rejoice a family of friends;
All speak aloud, are happy and are
free,
And glad they seem, and gaily they
agree.

What, though fastidious ears may
shun the speech,
Where all are talkers and where none
can teach;
Where still the welcome and the
words are old,
And the same stories are for ever
told—

160
Yet theirs is joy that, bursting from
the heart,
Prompts the glad tongue these
nothings to impart;
That forms these tones of gladness
we despise,
That lifts their steps, that sparkles in
their eyes;

That talks or laughs or runs or shouts
or plays,
And speaks in all their looks and all
their ways.

Fair scenes of peace! ye might
detain us long;
But vice and misery now demand the
song,
And turn our view from dwellings
simply neat,
To this infected row we term our
street.

170

Here, in cabal, a disputatious crew
Each evening meet: the sot, the cheat,
the shrew;
Riots are nightly heard—the curse,
the cries
Of beaten wife, perverse in her
replies;
While shrieking children hold each
threat'ning hand,
And sometimes life, and sometimes
food, demand:
Boys, in their first-stol'n rags, to
swear begin,
And girls, who heed not dress, are
skill'd in gin:
Snarers and smugglers here their
gains divide;
Ensnaring females here their victims
hide;

180

And here is one, the sibyl of the row,
Who knows all secrets, or affects to
know.

Seeking their fate, to her the simple
run,
To her the guilty, theirs awhile to
shun;
Mistress of worthless arts, depraved
in will,
Her care unblest'd and unrepaid her
skill,
Slave to the tribe, to whose command
she stoops,
And poorer than the poorest maid she
dupes.

Between the road-way and the
walls, offence
Invades all eyes and strikes on every
sense:

190

There lie, obscene, at every open
door,
Heaps from the hearth and sweepings
from the floor;
And day by day the mingled masses
grow,
As sinks are disembogued and
kennels flow.

There hungry dogs from hungry
children steal;
There pigs and chickens quarrel for a
meal;
There dropsied infants wail without
redress,
And all is want and wo and
wretchedness:
Yet, should these boys, with bodies
bronzed and bare,
High-swoln and hard, outlive that
lack of care,

200

Forced on some farm, the unexerted
strength,
Though loth to action, is compell'd at
length,
When warm'd by health, as serpents
in the spring
Aside their slough of indolence they
fling.

Yet, ere they go, a greater evil
comes—

See! crowded beds in those
contiguous rooms;
Beds but ill parted by a paltry screen
Of paper'd lath or curtain dropp'd
between;
Daughters and sons to yon
compartments creep,
And parents here beside their children
sleep.

210

Ye who have power, these thoughtless
people part,
Nor let the ear be first to taint the
heart!

Come! search within, nor sight nor
smell regard;

The true physician walks the foulest
ward.

See! on the floor what frouzy patches
rest!

What nauseous fragments on yon
fractured chest!

What downy dust beneath yon
window-seat!

And round these posts that serve this
bed for feet;

This bed, where all those tatter'd
garments lie,
Worn by each sex, and now perforce
thrown by!

220

See! as we gaze, an infant lifts its
head,
Left by neglect and burrow'd in that
bed;
The mother-gossip has the love
suppress'd
An infant's cry once waken'd in her
breast;
And daily prattles, as her round she
takes,
(With strong resentment) of the want
she makes.

Whence all these woes?—From
want of virtuous will,
Of honest shame, of time-improving
skill;
From want of care t'employ the
vacant hour,
And want of ev'ry kind but want of
power.

230

Here are no wheels for either wool
or flax,
But packs of cards—made up of
sundry packs;
Here is no clock, nor will they turn
the glass.
And see how swift th'important
moments pass;
Here are no books, but ballads on the
wall
Are some abusive, and indecent all;

Pistols are here, unpair'd; with nets
and hooks,
Of every kind, for rivers, ponds, and
brooks;
An ample flask, that nightly rovers
fill
With recent poison from the
Dutchman's still;
240
A box of tools, with }
wires of
various size,
Frocks, wigs, and hats, for
night or day disguise,
And bludgeons stout to gain
or guard a prize.

To every house belongs a space of
ground,
Of equal size, once fenced with
paling round;
That paling now by slothful waste
destroy'd,
Dead gorse and stumps of elder fill
the void,
Save in the centre-spot, whose walls
of clay
Hide sots and striplings at their drink
or play.
Within, a board, beneath a tiled
retreat,

250
Allures the bubble and maintains the
cheat;
Where heavy ale in spots like varnish
shows;
Where chalky tallies yet remain in
rows;

Black pipes and broken jugs the seats
defile,
The walls and windows, rhymes and
reck'nings vile;
Prints of the meanest kind disgrace
the door,
And cards, in curses torn, lie
fragments on the floor.

Here his poor bird th'inhuman
cocker brings,
Arms his hard heel and clips his
golden wings;
With spicy food th'impatient spirit
feeds,

260

And shouts and curses as the battle
bleeds.

Struck through the brain, deprived of
both his eyes,

The vanquish'd bird must combat till
he dies;

Must faintly peck at his victorious
foe,

And reel and stagger at each feeble
blow.

When fall'n, the savage grasps his
dabbled plumes,

His blood-stain'd arms, for other
deaths assumes;

And damns the craven-fowl, that lost
his stake,

And only bled and perish'd for his
sake.

Such are our peasants, those to
whom we yield

270

Praise with relief, the fathers of the
field;
And these who take, from our
reluctant hands,
What Burn advises or the Bench
commands.
Our farmers round, well pleased
with constant gain,
Like other farmers, flourish and
complain.—
These are our groups; our portraits
next appear,
And close our exhibition for the year.

With evil omen we that year begin:
A Child of Shame—stern Justice
adds, of Sin—
Is first recorded; I would hide the
deed,
280
But vain the wish; I sigh and I
proceed:
And could I well th' instructive truth
convey,
'Twould warn the giddy and awake
the gay.
Of all the nymphs who gave our
village grace,
The Miller's daughter had the fairest
face.
Proud was the Miller; money was his
pride;
He rode to market, as our farmers
ride;

And 'twas his boast, inspired by
spirits, there,
His favourite Lucy should be rich as
fair;
But she must meek and still obedient
prove,

290

And not presume, without his leave,
to love.

A youthful Sailor heard him;
—"Ha!" quoth he,
"This Miller's maiden is a prize for
me;
Her charms I love, his riches I desire,
And all his threats but fan the
kindling fire;
My ebbing purse no more the foe
shall fill,
But Love's kind act and Lucy at the
mill."

Thus thought the youth, and soon
the chase began,
Stretch'd all his sail, nor thought of
pause or plan:
His trusty staff in his bold hand he
took,

300

Like him and like his frigate, heart of
oak;
Fresh were his features, his attire was
new;
Clean was his linen, and his jacket
blue:
Of finest jean, his trowsers, tight and
trim,
Brush'd the large buckle at the silver
rim.

He soon arrived, he traced the
village-green;
There saw the maid, and was with
pleasure seen;
Then talk'd of love, till Lucy's
yielding heart
Confess'd 'twas painful, though 'twas
right, to part.
"For ah! my father has a haughty
soul;

310

Whom best he loves, he loves but to
control;
Me to some churl in bargain he'll
consign,
And make some tyrant of the parish
mine:
Cold is his heart, and he with looks
severe
Has often forced but never shed the
tear;
Save, when my mother died, some
drops express'd
A kind of sorrow for a wife at rest.—
To me a master's stern regard is
shown,
I'm like his steed, prized highly as his
own;
Stroked but corrected, threaten'd
when supplied,

320

His slave and boast, his victim and
his pride."
"Cheer up, my lass! I'll to thy
father go—
The Miller cannot be the Sailor's foe;

Both live by Heaven's free gale, that
 plays aloud
In the stretch'd canvas and the piping
 shroud;
The rush of winds, the flapping sails
 above,
And rattling planks within, are
 sounds we love;
Calms are our dread; when tempests
 plough the deep,
We take a reef, and to the rocking
 sleep."

"Ha!" quoth the Miller, moved at
 speech so rash,

330

"Art thou like me? then, where thy
 notes and cash?
Away to Wapping, and a wife
 command,
With all thy wealth, a guinea, in thine
 hand;
There with thy messmates quaff the
 muddy cheer,
And leave my Lucy for thy betters
 here."

"Revenge! revenge!" the angry
 lover cried,
Then sought the nymph, and "Be thou
 now my bride."
Bride had she been, but they no priest
 could move
To bind in law the couple bound by
 love.

What sought these lovers then by
 day, by night,

340

But stolen moments of disturb'd
delight—
Soft trembling tumults, terrors dearly
prized,
Transports that pain'd, and joys that
agonized:
Till the fond damsel, pleased with lad
so trim,
Awed by her parent, and enticed by
him,
Her lovely form from savage power
to save,
Gave—not her hand, but ALL she
could, she gave.

Then came the day of shame, the
grievous night,
The varying look, the wandering
appetite;
The joy assumed, while sorrow
dimm'd the eyes;

350

The forced sad smiles that follow'd
sudden sighs;
And every art, long used, but used in
vain,
To hide thy progress, Nature, and thy
pain.

Too eager caution shows some
danger's near,
The bully's bluster proves the
coward's fear;
His sober step the drunkard vainly
tries,
And nymphs expose the failings they
disguise.

First, whispering gossips were in
parties seen;

Then louder Scandal walk'd the
village-green;
Next babbling Folly told the growing
ill,

360

And busy Malice dropp'd it at the
mill.

"Go! to thy curse and mine," the
Father said,
"Strife and confusion stalk around thy
bed;
Want and a wailing brat thy portion
be,
Plague to thy fondness, as thy fault to
me.—

Where skulks the villain?"—"On the
ocean wide
My William seeks a portion for his
bride."—

"Vain be his search! but, till the
traitor come,
The higgler's cottage be thy future
home;
There with his ancient shrew and care
abide,

370

And hide thy head—thy shame thou
canst not hide."

Day after day was pass'd in pains
and grief;
Week follow'd week—and still was
no relief.
Her boy was born—no lads nor lasses
came
To grace the rite or give the child a
name;

Nor grave conceited nurse, of office
proud,
Bore the young Christian roaring
through the crowd:
In a small chamber was my office
done,
Where blinks through paper'd panes
the setting sun;
Where noisy sparrows, perch'd on
penthouse near,

380

Chirp tuneless joy, and mock the
frequent tear;
Bats on their webby wings in
darkness move,
And feebly shriek their melancholy
love.

No Sailor came; the months in
terror fled!

Then news arrived: he fought, and he
was DEAD!

At the lone cottage Lucy lives, and
still

Walks for her weekly pittance to the
mill;

A mean seraglio there her father
keeps,

Whose mirth insults her, as she stands
and weeps,

And sees the plenty, while compell'd
to stay,

390

Her father's pride become his harlot's
prey.

Throughout the lanes she glides, at
evening's close,

And softly lulls her infant to repose;

Then sits and gazes, but with
viewless look,
As gilds the moon the rippling of the
brook;
And sings her vespers, but in voice so
low,
She hears their murmurs as the waters
flow:
And she too murmurs, and begins to
find
The solemn wanderings of a wounded
mind.
Visions of terror, views of wo
succeed,
400
The mind's impatience, to the body's
need;
By turns to that, by turns to this, a
prey,
She knows what reason yields, and
dreads what madness may.

Next, with their boy, a decent
couple came,
And call'd him Robert, 'twas his
father's name;
Three girls preceded, all by time
endear'd,
And future births were neither hoped
nor fear'd.
Bless'd in each other, but to no
excess,
Health, quiet, comfort, form'd their
happiness;
Love, all made up of torture and
delight,

410

Was but mere madness in this
couple's sight:
Susan could think, though not
without a sigh,
If she were gone, who should her
place supply;
And Robert, half in earnest, half in
jest,
Talk of her spouse when he should be
at rest:
Yet strange would either think it to be
told,
Their love was cooling or their hearts
were cold.
Few were their acres,—but, with
these content,
They were, each pay-day, ready with
their rent;
And few their wishes—what their
farm denied,

420

The neighbouring town, at trifling
cost, supplied.
If at the draper's window Susan cast
A longing look, as with her goods she
pass'd,
And, with the produce of the wheel
and churn,
Bought her a Sunday-robe on her
return;
True to her maxim, she would take no
rest,
Till care repaid that portion to the
chest:
Or if, when loitering at the Whitsun-
fair,

Her Robert spent some idle shillings
there;

Up at the barn, before the break of
day,

430

He made his labour for th'indulgence
pay:

Thus both—that waste itself might
work in vain—

Wrought double tides, and all was
well again.

Yet, though so prudent, there were
times of joy,

(The day they wed, the christening of
the boy,)

When to the wealthier farmers there
was shown

Welcome unfeign'd, and plenty like
their own;

For Susan served the great, and had
some pride

Among our topmost people to
preside.

Yet in that plenty, in that welcome
free,

440

There was the guiding nice frugality,
That, in the festal as the frugal day,
Has, in a different mode, a sovereign
sway;

As tides the same attractive influence
know,

In the least ebb and in their proudest
flow:

The wise frugality, that does not give
A life to saving, but that saves to live;

Sparing, not pinching, mindful
though not mean,
O'er all presiding, yet in nothing seen.
Recorded next, a babe of love I
trace,

450

Of many loves the mother's fresh
disgrace.—

"Again, thou harlot! could not all
thy pain,
All my reproof, thy wanton thoughts
restrain?"

"Alas! your reverence, wanton
thoughts, I grant,
Were once my motive, now the
thoughts of want;
Women, like me, as ducks in a decoy,
Swim down a stream, and seem to
swim in joy;
Your sex pursue us, and our own
disdain;
Return is dreadful, and escape is vain.
Would men forsake us, and would
women strive

460

To help the fall'n, their virtue might
revive."

For rite of churching soon she
made her way,
In dread of scandal, should she miss
the day.—

Two matrons came! with them she
humbly knelt,
Their action copied and their
comforts felt,
From that great pain and peril to be
free,

Though still in peril of that pain to
be;
Alas! what numbers, like this
amorous dame,
Are quick to censure, but are dead to
shame!

Twin-infants then appear: a girl, a
boy,

470

Th' o'erflowing cup of Gerard Ablett's
joy.

One had I named in every year that
pass'd

Since Gerard wed, and twins behold
at last!

Well pleased, the bridegroom smiled
to hear—"A vine

Fruitful and spreading round the
walls be thine,

And branch-like be thine
offspring!"—Gerard then

Look'd joyful love, and softly said,
"Amen."

Now of that vine he'd have no more
increase,

Those playful branches now disturb
his peace:

Them he beholds around his table
spread,

480

But finds, the more the branch, the
less the bread;

And while they run his humble walls
about,

They keep the sunshine of good-
humour out.

Cease, man, to grieve! thy master's
lot survey,
Whom wife and children, thou and
thine, obey;
A farmer proud beyond a farmer's
pride,
Of all around the envy or the guide;
Who trots to market on a steed so
fine,
That when I meet him, I'm ashamed
of mine;
Whose board is high }
up-heap'd with }
generous fare,

490

Which five stout sons and three tall
daughters share:
Cease, man, to grieve, and
listen to his care.
A few years fled, and all thy boys
shall be
Lords of a cot, and labourers like
thee:
Thy girls, unportion'd, neighb'ring
youths shall lead
Brides from my church, and
thenceforth thou art freed;
But then thy master shall of cares
complain,
Care after care, a long connected
train;
His sons for farms shall ask a large
supply,
For farmers' sons each gentle miss
shall sigh;

500

Thy mistress, reasoning well of life's
decay,
Shall ask a chaise, and hardly brook
delay;
The smart young cornet who, with so
much grace,
Rode in the ranks and betted at the
race,
While the vex'd parent rails at deeds
so rash,
Shall d—n his luck, and stretch his
hand for cash.
Sad troubles, Gerard! now pertain to
thee,
When thy rich master seems from
trouble free;
But 'tis one fate at different times
assign'd,
And thou shalt lose the cares that he
must find.

510

"Ah!" quoth our village Grocer,
rich and old,
"Would I might one such cause for
care behold!"
To whom his Friend, "Mine greater
bliss would be,
Would Heav'n take those my spouse
assigns to me."

Aged were both, that Dawkins,
Ditchem this,
Who much of marriage thought, and
much amiss;
Both would delay, the one, till, riches
gain'd,

The son he wish'd might be to honour
train'd;
His Friend—lest fierce intruding
heirs should come,
To waste his hoard and vex his quiet
home.

520

Dawkins, a dealer once on
burthen'd back
Bore his whole substance in a pedler's
pack;
To dames discreet, the duties yet
unpaid,
His stores of lace and hyson he
convey'd.
When thus enrich'd, he chose at home
to stop,
And fleece his neighbours in a new-
built shop;
Then woo'd a spinster blithe, and
hoped, when wed,
For love's fair favours and a fruitful
bed.

Not so his Friend;—on widow fair
and staid
He fix'd his eye; but he was much
afraid,

530

Yet woo'd; while she his hair of silver
hue
Demurely noticed, and her eye
withdrew.
Doubtful he paused—"Ah! were I
sure," he cried,
"No craving children would my gains
divide:

Fair as she is, I would my widow
take,
And live more largely for my
partner's sake."
With such their views, some
thoughtful years they
pass'd,
And hoping, dreading, they were
bound at last.
And what their fate? Observe them as
they go,
Comparing fear with fear and wo
with wo.

540

"Humphrey!" said Dawkins, "envy in
my breast
Sickens to see thee in thy children
bless'd;
They are thy joys, while I go grieving
home
To a sad spouse, and our eternal
gloom.
We look despondency; no infant near,
To bless the eye or win the parent's
ear;
Our sudden heats and quarrels to
allay,
And soothe the petty sufferings of the
day.
Alike our want, yet both the want
reprove;
Where are, I cry, these pledges of our
love?

550

When she, like Jacob's wife, makes
fierce reply,

Yet fond—'Oh! give me children, or I
die';
And I return—still childless doom'd
to live,
Like the vex'd patriarch—'Are they
mine to give?'
Ah! much I envy thee thy boys, who
ride
On poplar branch, and canter at thy
side;
And girls, whose cheeks thy chin's
fierce fondness know,
And with fresh beauty at the contact
glow."
"Oh! simple friend," said Ditchem,
"would'st thou gain
A father's pleasure by a husband's
pain?"

560

Alas! what pleasure—when some
vig'rous boy
Should swell thy pride, some rosy girl
thy joy—
Is it to doubt who grafted this sweet
flower,
Or whence arose that spirit and that
power?
"Four years I've wed; not one has
pass'd in vain:
Behold the fifth! behold, a babe
again!
My wife's gay friends th' unwelcome
imp admire,
And fill the room with gratulation
dire.
While I in silence sate, revolving all

That influence ancient men, or that
befall,

570

A gay pert guest—Heav'n knows his
business—came;

'A glorious boy,' he cried, 'and what
the name?'

Angry I growl'd, 'My spirit cease to
tease,

Name it yourselves,—Cain, Judas, if
you please;

His father's give him—should you
that explore,

The devil's or yours,' I said, and
sought the door.

My tender partner not a word or sigh
Gives to my wrath, nor to my speech
reply;

But takes her comforts, triumphs in
my pain,

And looks undaunted for a birth
again."

580

Heirs thus denied afflict the pining
heart,

And, thus afforded, jealous pangs
impart;

Let, therefore, none avoid, and none
demand

These arrows number'd for the giant's
hand.

Then with their infants three, the
parents came,

And each assign'd—'twas all they had
—a name:

Names of no mark or price; of them
not one
Shall court our view on the sepulchral
stone,
Or stop the clerk, th' engraven scrolls
to spell,
Or keep the sexton from the sermon
bell.

590

An orphan-girl succeeds; ere she
was born
Her father died, her mother on that
morn;
The pious mistress of the school
sustains
Her parents' part, nor their affection
feigns,
But pitying feels; with due respect
and joy,
I trace the matron at her loved
employ.
What time the }
striplings, }
wearied e'en
with play,
Part at the closing of the
summer's day,
And each by different path
returns the well-known way—
Then I behold her at her cottage-door,
600
Frugal of light, her Bible laid before,
When on her double duty she
proceeds,
Of time as frugal, knitting as she
reads.

Her idle neighbours, who approach to
tell
Some trifling tale, her serious looks
compel,
To hear reluctant—while the lads
who pass,
In pure respect walk silent on the
grass.
Then sinks the day; but not to rest she
goes,
Till solemn prayers the daily duties
close.
But I digress, and lo! an infant
train

610

Appear, and call me to my task again.
"Why *Lonicera* wilt thou name thy
child?"
I ask'd the Gardener's wife, in accents
mild.
"We have a right," replied the sturdy
dame—
And *Lonicera* was the infant's name.
If next a son shall yield our Gardener
joy,
Then *Hyacinthus* shall be that fair
boy;
And if a girl, they will at length
agree,
That *Belladonna* that fair maid shall
be.
High-sounding words our worthy
Gardener gets,

620

And at his club to wondering swains
repeats;

He then of Rhus and Rhododendron
speaks,
And Allium calls his onions and his
leeks;
Nor weeds are now, for whence arose
the weed,
Scarce plants, fair herbs, and curious
flowers proceed;
Where Cuckoo-pints and Dandelions
sprung,
(Gross names had they our plainer
sires among,)
There Arums, there Leontodons we
view,
And Artemisia grows, where
Wormwood grew.
But though no weed exists his
garden round,

630

From Rumex strong our Gardener
frees his ground;
Takes soft Senicio from the yielding
land,
And grasps the arm'd Urtica in his
hand.
Not Darwin's self had more delight
to sing
Of floral courtship, in th' awaken'd
Spring,
Than Peter Pratt, who, simpering,
loves to tell
How rise the Stamens, as the Pistils
swell;
How bend and curl the moist-top to
the spouse,
And give and take the vegetable
vows;

How those esteem'd of old but tips
and chives,

640

Are tender husbands and obedient
wives;
Who live and love within the sacred
bower—
That bridal bed the vulgar term a
flower.

Hear Peter proudly, to some
humble friend,
A wondrous secret in his science
lend:—

"Would you advance the nuptial hour,
and bring
The fruit of Autumn with the flowers
of Spring:
View that light frame where Cucumis
lies spread,
And trace the husbands in their
golden bed,
Three powder'd Anthers;—then no
more delay,

650

But to the Stigma's tip their dust
convey;
Then by thyself, from prying glance
secure,
Twirl the full tip and make your
purpose sure;
A long-abiding race the deed shall
pay,
Nor one unblest'd abortion pine
away."

T' admire their friend's discourse
our swains agree,
And call it science and philosophy.

'Tis good, 'tis pleasant, through th'
advancing year,
To see unnumber'd growing forms
appear.
What leafy-life from Earth's broad
bosom rise!

660

What insect-myrriads seek the
summer skies!
What scaly tribes in }
every streamlet }
move!

What plummy people sing in
every grove!

All with the year awaked to
life, delight, and love.

Then names are good; for how,
without their aid,

Is knowledge, gain'd by man, to man
convey'd?

But from that source shall all our
pleasures flow?

Shall all our knowledge be those
names to know?

Then he, with memory bless'd, shall
bear away

The palm from Grew, and Middleton,
and Ray.

670

No! let us rather seek, in grove and
field,

What food for wonder, what for use
they yield;

Some just remark from Nature's
people bring,

And some new source of homage for
her King.

Pride lives with all; strange names
our rustics give
To helpless infants, that their own
may live;
Pleased to be known, they'll some
attention claim,
And find some by-way to the house
of fame.

The straightest furrow lifts the
ploughman's art;
The hat he gain'd has warmth for
head and heart;

680

The bowl that beats the greater
number down
Of tottering nine-pins, gives to fame
the clown;
Or, foil'd in these, he opes his ample
jaws,
And lets a frog leap down, to gain
applause;
Or grins for hours, or tipples for a
week;
Or challenges a well-pinch'd pig to
squeak.
Some idle deed, some child's
preposterous name,
Shall make him known, and give his
folly fame.

To name an infant meet our
village-sires,
Assembled all, as such event
requires;

690

Frequent and full, the rural sages sate,
And speakers many urged the long
debate.

Some harden'd knaves, who roved the
country round,
Had left a babe within the parish-
bound.—
First, of the fact they question'd
—"Was it true?"
The child was brought—"What then
remain'd to do?
Was't dead or living?" This was fairly
proved:
'Twas pinch'd, it roar'd, and every
doubt removed.
Then by what name th' unwelcome
guest to call
Was long a question, and it posed
them all;

700

For he who lent it to a babe unknown,
Censorious men might take it for his
own:
They look'd about, they gravely
spoke to all,
And not one Richard answer'd to the
call.
Next they inquired the day, when,
passing by,
Th' unlucky peasant heard the
stranger's cry:
This known, how food and raiment
they might give,
Was next debated—for the rogue
would live;
At last, with all their }
words and }
work content,
Back to their homes the
prudent vestry went,

710

And Richard Monday to the
workhouse sent.
There was he pinch'd and pitied,
thump'd and fed,
And duly took his beatings and his
bread;
Patient in all control, in all abuse,
He found contempt and kicking have
their use—
Sad, silent, supple, bending to the
blow,
A slave of slaves, the lowest of the
low;
His pliant soul gave way to all things
base;
He knew no shame, he dreaded no
disgrace.
It seem'd, so well his passions he
suppressed,

720

No feeling stirr'd his ever-torpid
breast;
Him might the meanest pauper bruise
and cheat,
He was a footstool for the beggar's
feet;
His were the legs that ran at all
commands;
They used on all occasions Richard's
hands.
His very soul was not his own; he
stole
As others order'd, and without a dole;
In all disputes, on either part he lied,
And freely pledged his oath on either
side;

In all rebellions Richard join'd the
rest,

730

In all detections Richard first
confess'd.

Yet, though disgraced, he watch'd his
time so well,

He rose in favour, when in fame he
fell;

Base was his usage, vile his whole
employ,

And all despised and fed the pliant
boy.

At length, "'tis time he should abroad
be sent,"

Was whisper'd near him—and abroad
he went.

One morn they call'd him, Richard
answered not;

They deem'd him hanging, and in
time forgot;

Yet miss'd him long, as each,
throughout the clan,

740

Found he "had better spared a better
man."

Now Richard's talents for the world
were fit,

He'd no small cunning, and had some
small wit;

Had that calm look which seem'd to
all assent,

And that complacent speech which
nothing meant;

He'd but one care, and that he strove
to hide,

How best for Richard Monday to
provide.

Steel, through opposing plates, the
magnet draws,

And steely atoms culls from dust and
straws;

And thus our hero, to his interest true,
750

Gold through all bars and from each
trifle drew;

But, still more surely round the world
to go,

This fortune's child had neither friend
nor foe.

Long lost to us, at last our man we
trace—

Sir Richard Monday died at Monday-
place.

His lady's worth, his daughter's, we
peruse,

And find his grandsons all as rich as
Jews;

He gave reforming charities a sum,
And bought the blessings of the blind
and dumb;

Bequeathed to missions money from
the stocks,

760

And Bibles issued from his private
box;

But, to his native place severely just,
He left a pittance bound in rigid
trust—

Two paltry pounds, on every
quarter's-day,

(At church produced) for forty loaves
should pay:

A stinted gift, that to the parish shows
He kept in mind their bounty and
their blows!

To farmers three, the year has
given a son:
Finch on the Moor, and French, and
Middleton.
Twice in this year a female Giles I
see:

770

A Spalding once, and once a Barnaby

—

A humble man is he, and, when they
meet,
Our farmers find him on a distant
seat;
There for their wit he serves a
constant theme—
They praise his dairy, they extol his
team,
They ask the price of each unrivall'd
steed.
And whence his sheep, that admirable
breed?
His thriving arts they beg he would
explain,
And where he puts the money he
must gain.
They have their daughters, but they
fear their friend

780

Would think his sons too much would
condescend;
They have their sons who would their
fortunes try,
But fear his daughters will their suit
deny.

So runs the joke, while James, with
sigh profound,
And face of care, looks moveless on
the ground;
His cares, his sighs, provoke the
insult more,
And point the jest—for Barnaby is
poor.

Last in my list, five untaught lads
appear;
Their father dead, compassion sent
them here—
For still that rustic infidel denied
790
To have their names with solemn rite
applied.
His, a lone house, by Deadman's
Dyke-way stood;
And his, a nightly haunt, in Lonely-
wood.
Each village inn has heard the ruffian
boast,
That he believed in neither God nor
ghost;
That, when the sod upon the sinner
press'd,
He, like the saint, had everlasting
rest;
That never priest believed his
doctrines true,
But would, for profit, own himself a
Jew,
Or worship wood and stone, as honest
heathen do;

800

That fools alone on future worlds
rely,
And all who die for faith, deserve to
die.

These maxims, part th' attorney's
clerk profess'd;
His own transcendent genius found
the rest.

Our pious matrons heard, and, much
amazed,
Gazed on the man, and trembled as
they gazed;
And now his face explored, and now
his feet,
Man's dreaded foe, in this bad man, to
meet.

But him our drunkards as their
champion raised,
Their bishop call'd, and as their hero
praised;

810

Though most, when sober, and the
rest, when sick,
Had little question whence his
bishopric.

But he, triumphant spirit! all things
dared,
He poach'd the wood, and on the
warren snared;
'Twas his, at cards, each novice to
trepan,
And call the wants of rogues the
rights of man;
Wild as the winds, he let his offspring
rove,
And deem'd the marriage-bond the
bane of love.

What age and sickness, for a man
so bold,
Had done, we know not—none
beheld him old.

820

By night, as business urged, he
sought the wood—
The ditch was deep—the rain had
caused a flood—
The foot-bridge fail'd—he plunged
beneath the deep,
And slept, if truth were his, th' eternal
sleep.

These have we named; on life's
rough sea they sail,
With many a prosperous, many an
adverse gale!
Where passion soon, like powerful
winds, will rage,
And prudence, wearied, with their
strength engage.
Then each, in aid, shall some
companion ask,
For help or comfort in the tedious
task;

830

And what that help—what joys from
union flow,
What good or ill, we next prepare to
show;
And row, meantime, our weary bark
ashore,
As Spenser his—but not with
Spenser's oar^[21].

FOOTNOTES:

[21] Allusions of this kind are to be found in the Fairy Queen. See the end of the First Book, and other places.

PART II.

MARRIAGES.

ious Consideration necessary: yet not too long Delay—Imprudent Marriage of old Kirk and his Servant—Comparison between an ancient and youthful Partner to a young Man—Prudence of Donald the Gardener—Parish Wedding: the compelled Bridegroom; Day of Marriage, how spent—Relation of the Accomplishments of Phœbe Dawson, a rustic Beauty; her Lover: his Courtship; their Marriage—Misery of Precipitation—The wealthy Couple: Reluctance in the Husband; why?—Unusually fair Signatures in the Register: the common Kind—Seduction of Lucy Collins by Footman Daniel: her rustic Lover; her Return to him—An ancient Couple: Comparisons on the Occasion—More pleasant View of Village Matrimony: Farmers celebrating the Day of Marriage; their Wives—Reuben and Rachel, a happy Pair: an Example of prudent Delay—Reflections on their State who were not so prudent, and its Improvement towards the Termination of Life; an old Man so circumstanced—Attempt to seduce a Village Beauty: Persuasion and Reply; the Event.

Nubere si quæ voles, quamvis
properabitis ambo,
Differ; habent parvæ commoda magna
moræ.

Ovid. Fast.
lib.
iii.
[vv.
393
-4.]

"Disposed to wed, e'en while you
hasten, stay;
There's great advantage in a small
delay:"—
Thus Ovid sang, and much the wise
approve
This prudent maxim of the priest of
Love.

If poor, delay for future want
prepares,
And eases humble life of half its
cares;
If rich, delay shall brace the
thoughtful mind,
T' endure the ills that e'en the
happiest find:
Delay shall knowledge yield on either
part,

10

And show the value of the
vanquished heart;
The humours, passions, merits,
failings prove,
And gently raise the veil that's worn
by Love;
Love, that impatient guide—too
proud to think
Of vulgar wants, of clothing, meat
and drink—
Urges our amorous swains their joys
to seize,
And then, at rags and hunger
frighten'd, flees.—
Yet not too long in cold debate
remain:
Till age, refrain not—but if old,
refrain.

By no such rule }
would }
Gaffer Kirk
be tried;

20

First in the year he led a blooming
bride,

And stood a withered elder at her
side.

Oh! Nathan! Nathan! at thy years,
trepann'd

To take a wanton harlot by the hand!
Thou, who wert used so tartly to
express

Thy sense of matrimonial happiness,
Till every youth, whose bans at
church were read,

Strove not to meet, or meeting, hung
his head;

And every lass forbore at thee to
look,

A sly old fish, too cunning for the
hook;—

30

And now at sixty, that pert dame to
see

Of all thy savings mistress, and of
thee;

Now will the lads, rememb'ring
insults past,

Cry, "What, the wise-one in the trap
at last!"

Fie! Nathan! fie! to let an artful
jade

The close recesses of thine heart
invade;

What grievous pangs, what suffering,
she'll impart,

And fill with anguish that rebellious
heart;

For thou wilt strive incessantly, in
vain,

By threatening speech, thy freedom
to regain:

40

But she for conquest married, nor will
prove

A dupe to thee, thine anger, or thy
love.

Clamorous her tongue will be;—of
either sex,

She'll gather friends around thee, and
perplex

Thy doubtful soul; thy money she
will waste

In the vain ramblings of a vulgar
taste;

And will be happy to exert her power,
In every eye, in thine, at every hour.

Then wilt thou bluster—"No! I will
not rest,

And see consumed each shilling of
my chest":

50

Thou wilt be valiant—"When thy
cousins call,

I will abuse and shut my door on all";

Thou wilt be cruel—"What the law
allows,

That be thy portion, my ungrateful
spouse!

Nor other shillings }
shalt thou then }
receive,

And when I die—What! may I
this believe?

Are these true tender tears?
and does my Kitty grieve?

Ah! crafty vixen, thine old man has
fears;

But weep no more! I'm melted by thy
tears;

Spare but my money; thou shalt rule
ME still,

60

And see thy cousins—there! I burn
the will."—

Thus, with example sad, our year
began,

A wanton vixen and a weary man;
But had this tale in other guise been
told,

Young let the lover be, the lady old,
And that disparity of years shall
prove

No bane of peace, although some bar
to love:

'Tis not the worst, our nuptial ties
among,

That joins the ancient bride and
bridegroom young;—

Young wives, like changing winds,
their power display,

70

By shifting points and varying day by
day;

Now zephyrs mild, now whirlwinds
in their force,

They sometimes speed, but often
thwart our course;

And much experienced should that
pilot be,

Who sails with them on life's
tempestuous sea.

But like a trade-wind is the ancient
dame,

Mild to your wish, and every day the
same;
Steady as time, no sudden squalls you
fear,
But set full sail and with assurance
steer;
Till every danger in your way be
pass'd,

80

And then she gently, mildly breathes
her last;
Rich you arrive, in port awhile
remain,
And for a second venture sail again.

For this, blithe Donald southward
made his way,
And left the lasses on the banks of
Tay;
Him to a neighbouring garden fortune
sent,
Whom we beheld, aspiringly content:
Patient and mild, he sought the dame
to please,
Who ruled the kitchen and who bore
the keys.
Fair Lucy first, the laundry's grace
and pride,

90

With smiles and gracious looks, her
fortune tried;
But all in vain she praised his "pawky
eyne,"
Where never fondness was for Lucy
seen:
Him the mild Susan, boast of dairies,
loved,

And found him civil, cautious, and
unmoved:
From many a fragrant simple,
Catharine's skill
Drew oil and essence from the
boiling still;
But not her warmth, nor all her
winning ways,
From his cool phlegm could Donald's
spirit raise:
Of beauty heedless, with the merry
mute,
100
To Mistress Dobson he preferr'd his
suit;
There proved his service, there
address'd his vows,
And saw her mistress—friend—
protectress—spouse;
A butler now, he thanks his powerful
bride,
And, like her keys, keeps constant at
her side.

Next at our altar stood a luckless
pair,
Brought by strong passions and a
warrant there;
By long rent cloak, hung loosely,
strove the bride,
From ev'ry eye what all perceived to
hide;
While the boy-bridegroom, shuffling
in his pace,
110
Now hid awhile and then exposed his
face;

As shame alternately with anger
 strove
The brain confused with muddy ale to
 move.
In haste and stammering he perform'd
 his part,
And look'd the rage that rankled in
 his heart;
(So will each lover inly curse his fate,
Too soon made happy and made wise
 too late;)
I saw his features take a savage
 gloom,
And deeply threaten for the days to
 come.
Low spake the lass, and lisp'd and
 minced the while,
120
Look'd on the lad, and faintly tried to
 smile;
With soften'd speech and humbled
 tone she strove
To stir the embers of departed love:
While he, a tyrant, frowning walk'd
 before,
Felt the poor purse and sought the
 public door,
She, sadly following, in submission
 went,
And saw the final shilling foully
 spent;
Then to her father's hut the pair
 withdrew,
And bade to love and comfort long
 adieu!
Ah! fly temptation, youth, refrain!
 refrain!

130

I preach for ever; but I preach in
vain!

Two summers since, I saw, at
Lammas Fair,
The sweetest flower that ever
blossom'd there,
When Phœbe Dawson gaily cross'd
the Green,
In haste to see and happy to be seen:
Her air, her manners, all who saw
admired,
Courteous though coy, and gentle
though retired;
The joy of youth and health her eyes
display'd,
And ease of heart her every look
convey'd;
A native skill her simple robes
express'd,

140

As with untutor'd elegance she
dress'd;
The lads around admired so fair a
sight,
And Phœbe felt, and felt she gave,
delight.
Admirers soon of every age she
gain'd,
Her beauty won them and her worth
retain'd;
Envy itself could no contempt
display,
They wish'd her well, whom yet they
wish'd away.

Correct in thought, she judged a
servant's place
Preserved a rustic beauty from
disgrace;
But yet on Sunday-eve, in freedom's
hour,

150

With secret joy she felt that beauty's
power,
When some proud bliss upon the
heart would steal,
That, poor or rich, a beauty still must
feel.—

At length, the youth, ordain'd to
move her breast,
Before the swains with bolder spirit
press'd;
With looks less timid made his
passion known,
And pleased by manners most unlike
her own;
Loud though in love, and confident
though young;
Fierce in his air, and voluble of
tongue;
By trade a tailor, though, in scorn of
trade,

160

He served the 'Squire, and brush'd the
coat he made:
Yet now, would Phœbe her consent
afford,
Her slave alone, again he'd mount the
board;
With her should years of growing
love be spent,

And growing wealth—she sigh'd and
look'd consent.

Now, through the lane, up hill, and
'cross the green,
(Seen by but few, and blushing to be
seen—

Dejected, thoughtful, anxious, and
afraid,)

Led by the lover, walk'd the silent
maid.

Slow through the meadows roved
they many a mile,

170

Toy'd by each bank and trifled at each
stile;

Where, as he painted every blissful
view,

And highly colour'd what he strongly
drew,

The pensive damsel, prone to tender
fears,

Dimm'd the false prospect with
prophetic tears.—

Thus pass'd th' allotted hours, till,
lingering late,

The lover loiter'd at the master's gate;
There he pronounced adieu! and yet
would stay,

Till chidden—soothed—entreated—
forced away,

He would of coldness, though
indulged, complain,

180

And oft retire and oft return again;
When, if his teasing vex'd her gentle
mind,

The grief assumed, compell'd her to
be kind!

For he would proof of plighted
kindness crave,

That she resented first and then
forgave,

And to his grief and penance yielded
more

Than his presumption had required
before.—

Ah! fly temptation, youth; refrain!
refrain,

Each yielding maid and each
presuming swain!

Lo! now with red rent cloak and
bonnet black,

190

And torn green gown loose hanging
at her back,

One who an infant in her arms
sustains,

And seems in patience striving with
her pains;

Pinch'd are her looks, as one who
pines for bread,

Whose cares are growing and whose
hopes are fled;

Pale her parch'd lips, her heavy eyes
sunk low,

And tears unnoticed from their
channels flow;

Serene her manner, till some sudden
pain

Frets the meek soul, and then she's
calm again.—

Her broken pitcher to the pool she
takes,

200

And every step with cautious terror
makes;

For not alone that infant in her arms,
But nearer cause, her anxious soul
alarms.

With water burthen'd, then she picks
her way,

Slowly and cautious, in the clinging
clay;

Till, in mid-green, she trusts a place
unsound,

And deeply plunges in th' adhesive
ground;

Thence, but with pain, her slender
foot she takes,

While hope the mind, as strength the
frame, forsakes:

For, when so full the cup of sorrow
grows,

210

Add but a drop, it instantly o'erflows.

And now her path, but not her peace,
she gains,

Safe from her task, but shivering with
her pains;

Her home she reaches, open leaves
the door,

And, placing first her infant on the
floor,

She bares her bosom to the wind, and
sits,

And sobbing struggles with the rising
fits.

In vain, they come; she feels
th'inflating grief,
That shuts the swelling bosom from
relief;
That speaks in feeble cries a soul
distressed,

220

Or the sad laugh that cannot be
repress'd.
The neighbour-matron leaves her
wheel and flies
With all the aid her poverty supplies;
Unfee'd, the calls of Nature she
obeys,
Not led by profit, nor allured by
praise;
And, waiting long, till these
contentions cease,
She speaks of comfort, and departs in
peace.

Friend of distress! the mourner
feels thy aid,
She cannot pay thee, but thou wilt be
paid.

But who this child of weakness,
want, and care?

230

'Tis Phœbe Dawson, pride of Lamma
Fair;
Who took her lover for his sparkling
eyes,
Expressions warm, and love-inspiring
lies.
Compassion first assail'd her gentle
heart,

For all his suffering, all his bosom's
smart:

And then his prayers! they would a
savage move,

And win the coldest of the sex to
love.

But ah! too soon his looks success
declared,

Too late her loss the marriage-rite
repaired;

The faithless flatterer then his vows
forgot,

240

A captious tyrant or a noisy sot:

If present, railing, till he saw her
pain'd;

If absent, spending what their labours
gain'd;

Till that fair form in want and
sickness pined,

And hope and comfort fled that
gentle mind.

Then fly temptation, youth; resist,
refrain!

Nor let me preach for ever and in
vain!

Next came a well-dress'd pair, who
left their coach,

And made, in long procession, slow
approach;

For this gay bride had many a female
friend,

250

And youths were there, this favoured
youth t' attend.

Silent, nor wanting due respect, the
crowd
Stood humbly round, and gratulation
bow'd;
But not that silent crowd, in wonder
fix'd,
Not numerous friends, who praise
and envy mix'd,
Nor nymphs attending near to swell
the pride
Of one more fair, the ever-smiling
bride;
Nor that gay bride, }
adorn'd with }
every grace,
Nor love nor joy triumphant
in her face,
Could from the youth's sad
signs of sorrow chase.

260

Why didst thou grieve? wealth,
pleasure, freedom thine;
Vex'd it thy soul, that freedom to
resign?
Spake Scandal truth? "Thou didst not
then intend
So soon to bring thy wooing to an
end"?
Or, was it, as our prating rustics say,
To end as soon, but in a different
way?
'Tis told, thy Phillis is a skilful dame,
Who play'd uninjured with the
dangerous flame:
That, while, like Lovelace, thou thy
coat display'd,

And hid the snare for her affection
laid,

270

Thee, with her net, she found the
means to catch,
And, at the amorous see-saw, won the
match^[22].

Yet others tell, the Captain fix'd thy
doubt,
He'd call thee brother, or he'd call
thee out.—

But rest the motive—all retreat too
late,

Joy like thy bride's should on thy
brow have sate;

The deed had then }
appear'd thine }
own intent,

A glorious day, by gracious
fortune sent,

In each revolving year to be in
triumph spent.

Then in few weeks that cloudy brow
had been

280

Without a wonder or a whisper seen;
And none had been so weak as to
inquire,

"Why pouts my Lady?" or "why
frowns the Squire?"

How fair these names, how much
unlike they look

To all the blurr'd subscriptions in my
book:

The bridegroom's letters stand in row
above.

Tapering yet stout, like pine-trees in
his grove;
While free and fine the bride's appear
below,
As light and slender as her jasmines
grow.
Mark now in what confusion, stoop
or stand,

290

The crooked scrawls of many a
clownish hand;
Now out, now in, they droop, they
fall, they rise,
Like raw recruits drawn forth for
exercise;
Ere yet reform'd and modell'd by the
drill,
The free-born legs stand striding as
they will.

Much have I tried to guide the fist
along,
But still the blunderers placed their
blottings wrong:
Behold these marks uncouth! how
strange that men,
Who guide the plough, should fail to
guide the pen.

For half a mile the furrows even lie;

300

For half an inch the letters stand
awry;—
Our peasants, strong and sturdy in the
field,
Cannot these arms of idle students
wield;
Like them, in feudal days, their
valiant lords

Resign'd the pen and grasp'd their
conqu'ring swords;
They to robed clerks and poor
dependent men
Left the light duties of the peaceful
pen;
Nor to their ladies wrote, but sought
to prove,
By deeds of death, their hearts were
fill'd with love.
But yet, small arts have charms for
female eyes;

310

Our rustic nymphs the beau and
scholar prize;
Unletter'd swains and ploughmen
coarse they slight,
For those who dress, and amorous
scrolls indite.

For Lucy Collins happier days had
been,
Had Footman Daniel scorn'd his
native green;
Or when he came an idle coxcomb
down,
Had he his love reserved for lass in
town;
To Stephen Hill she then had pledged
her truth,—
A sturdy, sober, kind, unpolish'd
youth;
But from the day, that fatal day she
spied

320

The pride of Daniel, Daniel was her
pride.

In all concerns was }
 Stephen just }
 and true;
 But coarse his doublet was
 and patch'd in view,
 And felt his stockings were,
 and blacker than his shoe;
 While Daniel's linen all was fine and
 fair—
 His master wore it, and he deign'd to
 wear;
 (To wear his livery, some respect
 might prove;
 To wear his linen, must be sign of
 love:)
 Blue was his coat, unsoil'd by spot or
 stain;
 His hose were silk, his shoes of
 Spanish-grain;
 330
 A silver knot his }
 breadth of
 shoulder bore;
 A diamond buckle blazed his
 breast before—
 Diamond he swore it was! and
 show'd it as he swore;
 Rings on his fingers shone; his milk-
 white hand
 Could pick-tooth case and box for
 snuff command:
 And thus, with clouded cane, a fop
 complete,
 He stalk'd, the jest and glory of the
 street.
 Join'd with these powers, he could so
 sweetly sing,

Talk with such toss, and saunter with
such swing;
Laugh with such glee, and trifle with
such art,

340

That Lucy's promise fail'd to shield
her heart.

Stephen, meantime, to ease his
amorous cares,
Fix'd his full mind upon his farm's
affairs;
Two pigs, a cow, and wethers half a
score,
Increased his stock, and still he look'd
for more.

He, for his acres few, so duly paid,
That yet more acres to his lot were
laid;

Till our chaste nymphs no longer felt
disdain,

And prudent matrons praised the
frugal swain;

Who, thriving well, through many a
fruitful year,

350

Now clothed himself anew, and acted
overseer.

Just then poor Lucy, from her
friend in town,
Fled in pure fear, and came a beggar
down;

Trembling, at }
Stephen's door }
she knock'd for
bread—

Was chidden first, next pitied,
and then fed;

Then sat at Stephen's board,
 then shared in Stephen's bed
All hope of marriage lost in her
 disgrace,
He mourns a flame revived, and she a
 love of lace.

Now to be wed a well-match'd
 couple came;
Twice had old Lodge been tied, and
 twice the dame;

360

Tottering they came and toying,
 (odious scene!)
And fond and simple, as they'd
 always been.

Children from wedlock we by laws
 restrain;

Why not prevent them, when they're
 such again?

Why not forbid the doting souls, to
 prove

Th' indecent fondling of preposterous
 love?

In spite of prudence, uncontroll'd by
 shame,

The amorous senior woos the
 toothless dame,

Relating idly, at the closing eve,

The youthful follies he disdains to
 leave;

370

Till youthful follies wake a transient
 fire,

When arm in arm they totter and
 retire.

So a fond pair of solemn birds, all
day,
Blink in their seat and doze the hours
away;
Then, by the moon awaken'd, forth
they move,
And fright the songsters with their
cheerless love.

So two sear trees, dry, stunted, and
unsound,
Each other catch, when dropping to
the ground;
Entwine their wither'd arms 'gainst
wind and weather,
And shake their leafless heads, and
drop together.

380

So two cold limbs, touch'd by
Galvani's wire,
Move with new life, and feel
awaken'd fire;
Quivering awhile, their flaccid forms
remain,
Then turn to cold torpidity again.

"But ever frowns your Hymen?
man and maid,
Are all repenting, suffering, or
betray'd?"
Forbid it, Love! we have our couples
here
Who hail the day in each revolving
year:
These are with us, as in the world
around;
They are not frequent, but they may
be found.

390

Our farmers, too; what, though
they fail to prove,
In Hymen's bonds, the tenderest
slaves of love,
(Nor, like those pairs whom
sentiment unites,
Feel they the fervour of the mind's
delights:)
Yet, coarsely kind and comfortably
gay,
They heap the board and hail the
happy day:
And, though the bride, now freed
from school, admits
Of pride implanted there some
transient fits;
Yet soon she casts her girlish flights
aside,
And in substantial blessings rests her
pride.

400

No more she moves in measured
steps, no more
Runs, with bewilder'd ear, her music
o'er;
No more recites her French the hinds
among,
But chides her maidens in her
mother-tongue;
Her tambour-frame she leaves and
diet spare,
Plain work and plenty with her house
to share;
Till, all her varnish lost, in few short
years,

In all her worth, the farmer's wife
appears.

Yet not the ancient kind; nor she
who gave
Her soul to gain—a mistress and a
slave:

410

Who not to sleep allow'd the needful
time;

To whom repose was loss, and sport a
crime;

Who, in her meanest room (and all
were mean),

A noisy drudge, from morn till night
was seen;—

But she, the daughter, boasts a decent
room,

Adorn'd with carpet, form'd in
Wilton's loom;

Fair prints along the }
paper'd wall }
are spread

There, Werter sees the
sportive children fed,

And Charlotte, here, bewails
her lover dead.

'Tis here, assembled, while in
space apart

420

Their husbands, drinking, warm the
opening heart,

Our neighbouring dames, on festal
days, unite

With tongues more fluent and with
hearts as light;

Theirs is that art, which English
wives alone

Profess—a boast and privilege their
own;
An art it is, where each at once
attends
To all, and claims attention from her
friends,
When they engage the tongue, the
eye, the ear,
Reply when list'ning, and when
speaking hear:
The ready converse knows no dull
delays,
430
"But double are the pains, and double
be the praise^[23]."

Yet not to those alone who bear
command
Heaven gives a heart to hail the
marriage band;
Among their servants, we the pairs
can show,
Who much to love and more to
prudence owe.
Reuben and Rachel, though as fond
as doves,
Were yet discreet and cautious in
their loves;
Nor would attend to Cupid's wild
commands,
Till cool reflection bade them join
their hands.
When both were poor, they thought it
argued ill
440
Of hasty love to make them poorer
still;

Year after year, with savings long laid
by,
They bought the future dwelling's full
supply;
Her frugal fancy cull'd the smaller
ware,
The weightier purchase ask'd her
Reuben's care;
Together then their last year's gain
they threw,
And lo! an auction'd bed, with
curtains neat and new.
Thus both, as prudence counsell'd,
wisely stay'd,
And cheerful then the calls of Love
obey'd:
What if, when Rachel gave her hand,
'twas one

450

Embrown'd by Winter's ice and
Summer's sun?
What if, in Reuben's hair, the female
eye
Usurping grey among the black could
spy?
What if, in both, life's bloomy flush
was lost,
And their full autumn felt the
mellowing frost?
Yet time, who blow'd the rose of
youth away,
Had left the vigorous stem without
decay;
Like those tall elms, in Farmer
Frankford's ground,
They'll grow no more—but all their
growth is sound;

By time confirm'd and rooted in the
land,

460

The storms they've stood, still
promise they shall stand.

These are the happier pairs: their
life has rest,
Their hopes are strong, their humble
portion bless'd;
While those, more rash, to hasty
marriage led,
Lament th' impatience which now
stints their bread.

When such their union, years their
cares increase;
Their love grows colder, and their
pleasures cease;
In health just fed, in sickness just
relieved;
By hardships harass'd and by children
grieved;

In petty quarrels and in peevish strife
470

The once fond couple waste the
spring of life;
But, when to age mature those
children grown,
Find hopes and homes and hardships
of their own,
The harass'd couple feel their
lingering woes
Receding slowly, till they find repose.
Complaints and murmurs then are
laid aside,
(By reason these subdued, and those
by pride;)

And, taught by care, the patient man
and wife

Agree to share the bitter-sweet of life;
(Life that has sorrow much and
sorrow's cure,

480

Where they who most enjoy shall
much endure;)

Their rest, their labours, duties,
sufferings, prayers,

Compose the soul, and fit it for its
cares;

Their graves before them, and their
griefs behind,

Have each a med'cine for the rustic
mind;

Nor has he care to whom his wealth
shall go,

Or who shall labour with his spade
and hoe;

But, as he lends the strength that yet
remains,

And some dead neighbour on his bier
sustains,

(One with whom oft he whirl'd the
bounding flail,

490

Toss'd the broad coit, or took th'
inspiring ale,)

"For me," (he meditates,) "shall soon
be done

This friendly duty, when my race be
run;

'Twas first in trouble }
as in error }
pass'd,

Dark clouds and stormy cares whole
 years o'ercast,
But calm my setting day, and
 sunshine smiles at last:
My vices punish'd and my follies
 spent,
Not loth to die, but yet to live
 content,
I rest";—then, casting on the grave
 his eye,
His friend compels a tear, and his
 own griefs a sigh.

500

 Last on my list appears a match of
 love,
And one of virtue—happy may it
 prove!—
Sir Edward Archer is an amorous
 knight,
And maidens chaste and lovely shun
 his sight;
His bailiff's daughter suited much his
 taste,
For Fanny Price was lovely and was
 chaste;
To her the Knight with gentle looks
 drew near,
And timid voice assumed, to banish
 fear.—

 "Hope of my life, dear sovereign of
 my breast,
Which, since I knew thee, knows not
 joy nor rest;

510

Know, thou art all that my delighted
 eyes,

My fondest thoughts, my proudest
wishes prize;
And is that bosom—(what on earth so
fair!)
To cradle some coarse peasant's
sprawling heir?
To be that pillow which some surly
swain
May treat with scorn and agonize
with pain?
Art thou, sweet maid, a ploughman's
wants to share,
To dread his insult, to support his
care;
To hear his follies, his contempt to
prove,
And (oh! the torment!) to endure his
love;

520

Till want and deep regret those
charms destroy,
That time would spare, if time were
pass'd in joy?
With him, in varied pains, from morn
till night,
Your hours shall pass, yourself a
ruffian's right;
Your softest bed shall be the knotted
wool;
Your purest drink the waters of the
pool;
Your sweetest food will but your life
sustain,
And your best pleasure be a rest from
pain;
While, through each year, as health
and strength abate,

You'll weep your woes and wonder at
your fate;

530

And cry, 'Behold, as life's last cares
come on,

My burthens growing when my
strength is gone!'

"Now turn with me, and all the
young desire,

That taste can form, that fancy can
require;

All that excites enjoyment, or
procures

Wealth, health, respect, delight, and
love, are yours:

Sparkling, in cups of gold, your
wines shall flow,

Grace that fair hand, in that dear
bosom glow;

Fruits of each clime, and flowers,
through all the year,

Shall on your walls and in your walks
appear;

540

Where all, beholding, shall your
praise repeat,

No fruit so tempting and no flower so
sweet.

The softest carpets in your rooms
shall lie,

Pictures of happiest loves shall meet
your eye,

And tallest mirrors, reaching to the
floor,

Shall show you all the object I adore;

Who, by the hands of wealth and
fashion dress'd,

By slaves attended and by friends
caress'd,
Shall move, a wonder, through the
public ways,
And hear the whispers of adoring
praise.

550

Your female friends, though gayest of
the gay,
Shall see you happy, and shall,
sighing, say,
While smother'd envy rises in the
breast—

'Oh! that we lived so beauteous and
so bless'd!'

"Come then, my mistress, and my
wife; for she
Who trusts my honour is the wife for
me;
Your slave, your husband, and your
friend employ,
In search of pleasures we may both
enjoy."

To this the damsel, meekly firm,
replied:
"My mother loved, was married,
toil'd, and died;

560

With joys, she'd griefs, had troubles
in her course,
But not one grief was pointed by
remorse;
My mind is fix'd, to Heaven I resign,
And be her love, her life, her
comforts mine."

Tyrants have wept; and those with
hearts of steel,

Unused the anguish of the heart to
 heal,
 Have yet the transient power of virtue
 known,
 And felt th' imparted joy promote
 their own.
 Our Knight, relenting, now
 befriends a youth,
 Who to the yielding maid had vow'd
 his truth;
 570
 And finds in that fair deed a sacred
 joy,
 That will not perish, and that cannot
 cloy—
 A living joy, that shall its spirit keep,
 When every beauty fades, and all the
 passions sleep.

FOOTNOTES:

[22] Clarissa, vol. vii. Lovelace's Letter.

[23] Spenser[, *The Faerie Queene*, Bk. II. c. ii. st. xxv.]

PART III.

BURIALS.

æ Christian Resignation not frequently to be seen—The Register a melancholy Record—A dying Man, who at length sends for a Priest: for what Purpose? answered—Old Collett of the Inn, an Instance of Dr. Young's slow-sudden Death: his Character and Conduct—The Manners and Management of the Widow Goe: her successful Attention to Business; her Decease unexpected—The Infant-Boy of Gerard Ablett dies: Reflections on his Death, and the Survivor his Sister-Twin—The Funeral of the deceased Lady of the Manor described: her neglected Mansion; Undertaker and Train; the Character which her Monument will hereafter display—Burial of an ancient Maiden: some former Drawback on her Virgin-fame; Description of her House and Household; Her Manners, Apprehensions, Death—Isaac Ashford, a virtuous Peasant, dies: his manly Character; Reluctance to enter the Poor-House; and why—Misfortune and Derangement of Intellect in Robin Dingley: whence they proceeded: he is not restrained by Misery from a wandering Life; his various Returns

to his Parish; his final Return—Wife of Farmer Frankford dies in Prime of Life; Affliction in Consequence of such Death; melancholy View of her House, &c. on her Family's Return from her Funeral: Address to Sorrow—Leah Cousins, a Midwife: her Character; and successful Practice; at length opposed by Doctor Glibb; Opposition in the Parish: Argument of the Doctor; of Leah: her Failure and Decease—Burial of Roger Cuff, a Sailor: his Enmity to his Family; how it originated: his Experiment and its Consequence—The Register terminates—A Bell heard: Inquiry, for whom? The Sexton—Character of old Dibble, and the five Rectors whom he served—Reflections—Conclusion.

Qui vultus Acherontis atri,
Qui Stygia tristem, non tristis, videt,—

.....

Par ille Regi, par Superis erit.

Seneca *in*
Agamem.
[Act III.
vv. 606-
8.]

There was, 'tis said, and I believe, a
time,
When humble Christians died with
views sublime;
When all were ready for their faith to
bleed,
But few to write or wrangle for their
creed;
When lively Faith upheld the sinking
heart,
And friends, assured to meet,
prepared to part;
When Love felt hope, when Sorrow
grew serene,
And all was comfort in the death-bed
scene.

Alas! when now the gloomy king
they wait,

'Tis weakness yielding to resistless
fate;
Like wretched men upon the ocean
cast,
They labour hard and struggle to the
last,
"Hope against hope," and wildly gaze
around,
In search of help that never shall be
found:
Nor, till the last strong billow stops
the breath,
Will they believe them in the jaws of
Death!

When these my records I reflecting
read,
And find what ills these numerous
births succeed;
What powerful griefs these nuptial
ties attend,

20

With what regret these painful
journeys end;
When from the cradle to the grave I
look,
Mine I conceive a melancholy book.
Where now is perfect resignation
seen?

Alas! it is not on the village-green:—
I've seldom known, though I have
often read,
Of happy peasants on their dying-
bed;
Whose looks proclaim'd that sunshine
of the breast,

That more than hope, that Heaven
itself express'd.

What I behold are feverish fits of
strife,

30

'Twixt fears of dying and desire of
life:

Those earthly hopes, that to the last
endure;

Those fears, that hopes superior fail
to cure;

At best a sad submission to the doom,
Which, turning from the danger, lets
it come.

Sick lies the man, bewilder'd, lost,
afraid,

His spirits vanquish'd and his strength
decay'd;

No hope the friend, the nurse, the
doctor lend—

"Call then a priest, and fit him for his
end."

A priest is call'd; 'tis now, alas! too
late,

40

Death enters with him at the cottage-
gate;

Or, time allow'd, he goes, assured to
find

The self-commending, all-confiding
mind;

And sighs to hear, what we may
justly call

Death's common-place, the train of
thought in all.

"True, I'm a sinner," feebly he
begins,
"But trust in Mercy to forgive my
sins";
(Such cool confession no past crimes
excite;
Such claim on Mercy seems the
sinner's right!)

"I know, mankind are frail, that God
is just,

50

And pardons those who in his mercy
trust;
We're sorely tempted in a world like
this;
All men have done, and I like all,
amiss;
But now, if spared, it is my full intent
On all the past to ponder and repent:
Wrongs against me I pardon great and
small,
And if I die, I die in peace with all."
His merits thus and not his sins
confess'd,
He speaks his hopes, and leaves to
Heaven the rest.
Alas! are these the prospects, dull and
cold,

60

That dying Christians to their priests
unfold?
Or mends the prospect when th'
enthusiast cries,
"I die assured!" and in a rapture dies?
Ah, where that humble, self-
abasing mind,

With that confiding spirit, shall we
find—
The mind that, feeling what
repentance brings,
Dejection's terrors and Contrition's
stings,
Feels then the hope, that mounts all
care above,
And the pure joy that flows from
pardoning love?
Such have I seen in death, and
much deplore,

70

So many dying, that I see no more.
Lo! now my records, where I grieve
to trace,
How Death has triumph'd in so short
a space;
Who are the dead, how died they, I
relate,
And snatch some portion of their acts
from fate.

With Andrew Collett we the year
begin,
The blind, fat landlord of the Old
Crown Inn—
Big as his butt, and, for the self-same
use,
To take in stores of strong fermenting
juice.
On his huge chair beside the fire he
sate,

80

In revel chief, and umpire in debate;
Each night his string of vulgar tales
he told,

When ale was cheap and bachelors
were bold:
His heroes all were famous in their
days,
Cheats were his boast and drunkards
had his praise;
"One, in three draughts, three mugs
of ale took down,
As mugs were then—the champion of
the Crown;
For thrice three days another lived on
ale,
And knew no change but that of mild
and stale;
Two thirsty soakers watch'd a vessel's
side,

90

When he the tap, with dexterous
hand, applied;
Nor from their seats departed, till
they found
That butt was out and heard the
mournful sound."

He praised a poacher, precious
child of fun!
Who shot the keeper with his own
spring-gun;
Nor less the smuggler who the
exciseman tied,
And left him hanging at the birch-
wood side,
There to expire; but one who saw him
hang
Cut the good cord—a traitor of the
gang.

His own exploits with boastful glee
he told,

100

What ponds he emptied and what
pikes he sold;
And how, when bless'd with sight
alert and gay,
The night's amusements kept him
through the day.

He sang the praises of those times,
when all
"For cards and dice, as for their drink,
might call;
When justice wink'd on every jovial
crew,
And ten-pins tumbled in the parson's
view."

He told, when angry wives,
provoked to rail,
Or drive a third-day drunkard from
his ale,
What were his triumphs, and how
great the skill

110

That won the vex'd virago to his will:
Who raving came—then talk'd in
milder strain—
Then wept, then drank, and pledged
her spouse again.
Such were his themes: how knaves
o'er laws prevail,
Or, when made captives, how they fly
from jail;
The young how brave, how subtle
were the old;
And oaths attested all that Folly told.
On death like his what name shall
we bestow,
So very sudden! yet so very slow?

'Twas slow:—Disease, augmenting
year by year,

120

Show'd the grim king by gradual
steps brought near.

'Twas not less sudden: in the night he
died,

He drank, he swore, he jested, and he
lied;

Thus aiding folly with departing
breath.—

"Beware, Lorenzo, the slow-sudden
death^[24]."

Next died the Widow Goe, an
active dame,

Famed ten miles round, and worthy
all her fame;

She lost her husband when their loves
were young,

But kept her farm, her credit, and her
tongue:

Full thirty years she ruled, with
matchless skill,

130

With guiding judgment and resistless
will;

Advice she scorn'd, rebellions she
suppress'd,

And sons and servants bow'd at her
behest.

Like that great man's, who to his
Saviour came,

Were the strong words of this
commanding dame:—

"Come," if she said, they came; if
"go," were gone;

And if "do this,"—that instant it was
done.

Her maidens told she was all eye and
ear,

In darkness saw and could at distance
hear;—

No parish-business in the place could
stir,

140

Without direction or assent from her;
In turn she took each office as it fell,
Knew all their duties, and discharged
them well;

The lazy vagrants in her presence
shook,

And pregnant damsels fear'd her stern
rebuke;

She look'd on want with judgment
clear and cool,

And felt with reason and bestow'd by
rule;

She match'd both sons and daughters
to her mind,

And lent them eyes—for Love, she
heard, was blind;

Yet ceaseless still she throve, alert,
alive,

150

The working bee, in full or empty
hive;

Busy and careful, like that working
bee,

No time for love nor tender cares had
she;

But when our farmers made their
amorous vows,

She talk'd of market-steeds and
patent-ploughs.

Not unemploy'd her evenings pass'd
away,

Amusement closed, as business
waked the day;

When to her toilet's brief concern she
ran,

And conversation with her friends
began,

Who all were welcome, what they
saw, to share;

160

And joyous neighbours praised her
Christmas fare,

That none around might, in their
scorn, complain

Of Gossip Goe as greedy in her gain.

Thus long she reign'd, admired, if
not approved;

Praised, if not honour'd; fear'd, if not
beloved;—

When, as the busy days of Spring
drew near,

That call'd for all the forecast of the
year;

When lively hope the rising crops
survey'd,

And April promised what September
paid;

When stray'd her lambs where gorse
and greenweed grow;

170

When rose her grass in richer vales
below;

When pleased she look'd on all the
smiling land,

And view'd the hinds who wrought at
her command;
(Poultry in groups still follow'd where
she went;)
Then dread o'ercame her—that her
days were spent.
"Bless me! I die, and not a warning
giv'n,—
With *much* to do on Earth, and ALL
for Heav'n!—
No reparation for my soul's affairs,
No leave petition'd for the barn's
repairs;
Accounts perplex'd, my interest yet
unpaid,

180

My mind unsettled, and my will
unmade;
A lawyer, haste, and, in your way, a
priest;
And let me die in one good work at
least."
She spake, and, trembling, dropp'd
upon her knees,
Heaven in her eye, and in her hand
her keys;
And still the more she found her life
decay,
With greater force she grasp'd those
signs of sway:
Then fell and died!—In haste her
sons drew near,
And dropp'd, in haste, the tributary
tear;
Then from th' adhering clasp the keys
unbound,

190

And consolation for their sorrows
found.

Death has his infant-train; his bony
arm
Strikes from the baby-cheek the rosy
charm;
The brightest eye his glazing film
makes dim,
And his cold touch sets fast the lithest
limb:
He seized the sick'ning boy to Gerard
lent^[25],
When three days' life, in feeble cries,
were spent;
In pain brought forth, those painful
hours to stay,
To breathe in pain and sigh its soul
away!
"But why thus lent, if thus recall'd
again,

200

To cause and feel, to live and die, in
pain?"
Or rather say, Why grievous these
appear,
If all it pays for Heaven's eternal
year;
If these sad sobs and piteous sighs
secure
Delights that live, when worlds no
more endure?
The sister-spirit long may lodge
below,
And pains from nature, pains from
reason, know;

Through all the common ills of life
may run,
By hope perverted and by love
undone;
A wife's distress, a mother's pangs,
may dread,

210

And widow-tears, in bitter anguish,
shed;
May at old age arrive through
numerous harms,
With children's children in those
feeble arms:
Nor, till by years of want and grief
oppress'd,
Shall the sad spirit flee and be at rest!
Yet happier therefore shall we
deem the boy,
Secured from anxious care and
dangerous joy?

Not so! for then would Love
Divine in vain
Send all the burthens weary men
sustain;
All that now curb the passions when
they rage,

220

The checks of youth and the regrets
of age;
All that now bid us hope, believe,
endure,
Our sorrow's comfort and our vice's
cure;
All that for Heaven's high joys the
spirits train,
And charity, the crown of all, were
vain.

Say, will you call the breathless
 infant bless'd,
Because no cares the silent grave
 molest?
So would you deem the nursling from
 the wing
Untimely thrust and never train'd to
 sing;
But far more bless'd the bird whose
 grateful voice

230

Sings its own joy and makes the
 woods rejoice,
Though, while untaught, ere yet he
 charm'd the ear,
Hard were his trials and his pains
 severe!

Next died the Lady who yon Hall
 possess'd;
And here they brought her noble
 bones to rest.
In Town she dwelt;—forsaken stood
 the Hall:
Worms ate the floors, the tap'stry fled
 the wall;
No fire the kitchen's cheerless grate
 display'd;
No cheerful light the long-closed sash
 convey'd;
The crawling worm, that turns a
 summer-fly,

240

Here spun his shroud and laid him up
 to die
The winter-death:—upon the bed of
 state,

The bat shrill-shrieking woo'd his
flickering mate;
To empty rooms the }
curious came }
no more,
From empty cellars turn'd the
angry poor,
And surly beggars cursed the
ever-bolted door.
To one small room the steward found
his way,
Where tenants follow'd to complain
and pay;
Yet no complaint before the Lady
came,
The feeling servant spared the feeble
dame;

250

Who saw her farms with his
observing eyes,
And answer'd all requests with his
replies.
She came not down, her falling
groves to view;
Why should she know, what one so
faithful knew?
Why come, from many clamorous
tongues to hear,
What one so just might whisper in her
ear?
Her oaks or acres why with care
explore;
Why learn the wants, the sufferings
of the poor;
When one so knowing all their worth
could trace,

And one so piteous govern'd in her
place?

260

Lo! now, what dismal sons of
Darkness come,
To bear this daughter of Indulgence
home;
Tragedians all, and well arranged in
black!
Who nature, feeling, force,
expression lack;
Who cause no tear, but gloomily pass
by,
And shake their sables in the wearied
eye,
That turns disgusted from the
pompous scene,
Proud without grandeur, with
profusion, mean!
The tear for kindness past affection
owes;
For worth deceased the sigh from
reason flows;

270

E'en well-feign'd passion[s] for our
sorrows call,
And real tears for mimic miseries
fall—
But this poor farce has neither truth
nor art,
To please the fancy or to touch the
heart;
Unlike the darkness of the sky, that
pours
On the dry ground its fertilizing
showers;

Unlike to that which strikes the soul
with dread,
When thunders roar and forky fires
are shed;
Dark but not awful, dismal but yet
mean,
With anxious bustle moves the
cumbrous scene;

280

Presents no objects tender or
profound,
But spreads its cold unmeaning
gloom around.

When woes are feign'd, how ill
such forms appear;
And oh! how needless, when the wo's
sincere.

Slow to the vault they come, with
heavy tread,
Bending beneath the Lady and her
lead;

A case of elm surrounds that
ponderous chest,
Close on that case the crimson
velvet's press'd;

Ungenerous this, that to the worm
denies,
With niggard-caution, his appointed
prize;

290

For now, ere yet he works his tedious
way,
Through cloth and wood and metal to
his prey,
That prey dissolving shall a mass
remain,

That fancy loathes and worms
themselves disdain.

But see! the master-mourner makes
his way,
To end his office for the coffin'd clay;
Pleased that our rustic men and maids
behold
His plate like silver, and his studs like
gold,
As they approach to spell the age, the
name,
And all the titles of th' illustrious
dame.—

300

This as (my duty done) some scholar
read,
A village-father look'd disdain and
said:
"Away, my friends! why take such
pains to know
What some brave marble soon in
church shall show?
Where not alone her gracious name
shall stand,
But how she lived—the blessing of
the land;
How much we all deplored the noble
dead,
What groans we utter'd and what
tears we shed;
Tears, true as those, which in the
sleepy eyes
Of weeping cherubs on the stone
shall rise;

310

Tears, true as those, which, ere she
found her grave,

The noble Lady to our sorrows gave."

Down by the church-way walk,
and where the brook
Winds round the chancel like a
shepherd's crook,
In that small house, with those green
pales before,
Where jasmine trails on either side
the door;
Where those dark shrubs that now
grow wild at will,
Were clipp'd in form and tantalized
with skill;
Where cockles blanch'd and pebbles
neatly spread,
Form'd shining borders for the
larkspurs' bed—

320

There lived a Lady, wise, austere, and
nice,
Who show'd her virtue by her scorn
of vice.
In the dear fashions of her youth she
dress'd,
A pea-green Joseph was her favourite
vest;
Erect she stood, she walk'd with
stately mien,
Tight was her length of stays, and she
was tall and lean.

There long she lived in maiden-
state immured,
From looks of love and treacherous
man secured;
Though evil fame (but that was long
before)

Had blown her dubious blast at
Catherine's door.

330

A Captain thither, rich from India,
came,
And though a cousin call'd, it touch'd
her fame:
Her annual stipend rose from his
behest,
And all the long-prized treasures she
possess'd:—
If aught like joy awhile appear'd to
stay
In that stern face, and chase those
frowns away,
'Twas when her treasures she
disposed for view,
And heard the praises to their
splendour due;
Silks beyond price, so rich, they'd
stand alone,
And diamonds blazing on the buckled
zone;

340

Rows of rare pearls by curious
workmen set,
And bracelets fair in box of glossy
jet;
Bright polish'd amber precious from
its size,
Or forms the fairest fancy could
devise.
Her drawers of cedar, shut with secret
springs,
Conceal'd the watch of gold and
rubied rings;

Letters, long proofs of love, and
verses fine

Round the pink'd rims of crisped
Valentine.

Her china-closet, cause of daily care,
For woman's wonder held her
pencill'd ware;

350

That pictured wealth of China and
Japan,

Like its cold mistress, shunn'd the eye
of man.

Her neat small room, adorn'd with
maiden-taste,

A clipp'd French puppy, first of
favourites, graced;

A parrot next, but dead and stuff'd
with art;

(For Poll, when living, lost the Lady's
heart,

And then his life; for he was heard to
speak

Such frightful words as tinged his
Lady's cheek;)

Unhappy bird! who had no power to
prove,

Save by such speech, his gratitude
and love.

360

A grey old cat his whiskers lick'd
beside;

A type of sadness in the house of
pride.

The polish'd surface of an India chest,
A glassy globe, in frame of ivory,
press'd;

Where swam two finny creatures: one
of gold,
Of silver one, both beauteous to
behold.

All these were form'd the guiding
taste to suit;
The beasts well-manner'd and the
fishes mute.

A widow'd Aunt was there, compelled
by need
The nymph to flatter and her tribe to
feed;

370

Who, veiling well her scorn, endured
the clog,
Mute as the fish and fawning as the
dog.

As years increased, these treasures,
her delight,
Arose in value in their owner's sight:
A miser knows that, view it as he
will,

A guinea kept is but a guinea still;
And so he puts it to its proper use,
That something more this guinea may
produce:

But silks and rings, in the possessor's
eyes,
The oft'ner seen, the more in value
rise,

380

And thus are wisely hoarded to
bestow
The kind of pleasure that with years
will grow.

But what avail'd their worth—if
worth had they—

In the sad summer of her slow decay?
 Then we beheld her turn an
 anxious look
 From trunks and chests, and fix it on
 her book—
 A rich-bound Book of Prayer the
 Captain gave,
 (Some Princess had it, or was said to
 have;)
 And then once more, on all her stores,
 look round,
 And draw a sigh so piteous and
 profound,
 390
 That told, "Alas! how hard from these
 to part,
 And for new hopes and habits form
 the heart!
 What shall I do," (she cried,) "my
 peace of mind
 To gain in dying, and to die resign'd?"
 "Hear," we return'd;—"these
 baubles cast aside,
 Nor give thy God a rival in thy pride;
 Thy closets shut, and ope thy
 kitchen's door;
There own thy failings, *here* invite
 the poor;
 A friend of Mammon }
 let thy bounty }
 make;
 For widows' prayers thy
 vanities forsake;
 400
 And let the hungry of thy pride
 partake:

Then shall thy inward eye with joy
survey

The angel Mercy tempering Death's
delay!"

Alas! 'twas hard; the treasures still
had charms,
Hope still its flattery, sickness its
alarms;

Still was the same unsettled, clouded
view,

And the same plaintive cry, "What
shall I do?"

Nor change appear'd: for when her
race was run,

Doubtful we all exclaim'd, "What has
been done?"

Apart she lived, and still she lies
alone;

410

Yon earthy heap awaits the flattering
stone,

On which invention shall be long
employ'd,

To show the various worth of
Catherine Lloyd.

Next to these ladies, but in nought
allied,

A noble Peasant, Isaac Ashford, died.
Noble he was, contemning all things
mean,

His truth unquesti'd and his soul
serene;

Of no man's presence Isaac felt
afraid;

At no man's question Isaac look'd
dismay'd:

Shame knew him not, he dreaded no
disgrace;

420

Truth, simple truth, was written in his
face;

Yet while the serious thought his soul
approved,

Cheerful he seem'd, and gentleness he
loved.

To bliss domestic he his heart
resign'd,

And, with the firmest, had the fondest
mind.

Were others joyful, he look'd smiling
on,

And gave allowance where he needed
none;

Good he refused with future ill to
buy,

Nor knew a joy that caused
reflection's sigh;

A friend to virtue, his unclouded
breast

430

No envy stung, no jealousy distress'd;
(Bane of the poor! it wounds their
weaker mind,

To miss one favour which their
neighbours find.)

Yet far was he from stoic pride
removed;

He felt humanely, and he warmly
loved.

I mark'd his action, when his infant
died,

And his old neighbour for offence
was tried;

The still tears, stealing down that
furrow'd cheek,
Spoke pity, plainer than the tongue
can speak.

If pride were his, 'twas not their
vulgar pride,

440

Who, in their base contempt, the
great deride;

Nor pride in learning,—though my
clerk agreed,

If fate should call him, Ashford might
succeed;

Nor pride in rustic skill, although we
knew

None his superior, and his equals
few:—

But, if that spirit in his soul had
place,

It was the jealous pride that shuns
disgrace:

A pride in honest fame, by virtue
gain'd,

In sturdy boys to virtuous labours
train'd;

Pride in the power that guards his
country's coast,

450

And all that Englishmen enjoy and
boast;

Pride in a life that slander's tongue
defied,—

In fact, a noble passion, misnamed
pride.

He had no party's rage, no sect'ry's
whim;

Christian and countryman was all
with him.

True to his church he came; no
Sunday-shower

Kept him at home in that important
hour;

Nor his firm feet could one
persuading sect,

By the strong glare of their new light,
direct;—

"On hope, in mine own sober light, I
gaze,

460

But should be blind and lose it, in
your blaze."

In times severe, when many a
sturdy swain

Felt it his pride, his comfort, to
complain,

Isaac their wants would soothe, his
own would hide,

And feel in that his comfort and his
pride.

At length he found, when seventy
years were run,

His strength departed, and his labour
done;

When he, save honest fame, retain'd
no more,

But lost his wife and saw his children
poor:

'Twas then, a spark of—say not,
discontent—

470

Struck on his mind, and thus he gave
it vent:

"Kind are your laws, ('tis not to be
denied,)
That in yon house for ruin'd age
provide,
And they are just;—when young, we
give you all,
And for assistance in our weakness
call.—
Why then this proud reluctance to be
fed,
To join your poor, and eat the parish-
bread?
But yet I linger, loth with him to feed,
Who gains his plenty by the sons of
need;
He who, by contract, all your paupers
took,
480
And gauges stomachs with an
anxious look.
On some old master I could well
depend;
See him with joy and thank him as a
friend;
But ill on him, who doles the day's
supply,
And counts our chances, who at night
may die:
Yet help me, Heav'n! and let me not
complain
Of what I suffer, but my fate sustain."
Such were his thoughts, and so
resign'd he grew;
Daily he placed the workhouse in his
view!
But came not there, for sudden was
his fate:

490

He dropp'd, expiring, at his cottage-
gate.

I feel his absence in the hours of
prayer,
And view his seat and sigh for Isaac
there:

I see no more those white locks thinly
spread

Round the bald polish of that
honoured head;

No more that awful glance on playful
wight,

Compell'd to kneel and tremble at the
sight,

To fold his fingers, all in dread the
while,

Till Mister Ashford soften'd to a
smile;

No more that meek and suppliant
look in prayer,

500

Nor the pure faith (to give it force),
are there;—

But he is bless'd, and I lament no
more

A wise good man, contented to be
poor.

Then died a Rambler: not the one
who sails

And trucks, for female favours, beads
and nails;

Not one, who posts from place to
place—of men

And manners treating with a flying
pen;

Not he, who climbs, for prospects,
Snowd[o]n's height,
And chides the clouds that intercept
the sight;
No curious shell, rare plant, or
brilliant spar,

500

Enticed our traveller from his home
so far;
But all the reason, by himself assign'd
For so much rambling, was, a restless
mind;
As on, from place to place, without
intent,
Without reflection, Robin Dingley
went.

Not thus by nature;—never man
was found
Less prone to wander from his parish-
bound:
Claudian's old Man, to whom all
scenes were new,
Save those where he and where his
apples grew,
Resembled Robin, who around would
look,

520

And his horizon for the earth's
mistook.

To this poor swain a keen Attorney
came:—
"I give thee joy, good fellow! on thy
name;
The rich old Dingley's dead;—no
child has he,
Nor wife, nor will; his ALL is left for
thee:

To be his fortune's heir thy claim is
good;

Thou hast the name, and we will
prove the blood."

The claim was made; 'twas tried—
it would not stand;
They proved the blood, but were
refused the land.

Assured of wealth, this man of
simple heart,

530

To every friend had predisposed a
part:

His wife had hopes indulged of
various kind;

The three Miss Dingleys had their
school assign'd,

Masters were sought for what they
each required,

And books were bought and
harpsichords were hired:

So high was hope;—the failure
touch'd his brain,

And Robin never was himself again.

Yet he no wrath, no angry wish
express'd,

But tried, in vain, to labour or to rest;
Then cast his bundle on his back, and
went

540

He knew not whither, nor for what
intent.

Years fled;—of Robin all
remembrance past,
When home he wander'd in his rags at
last.

A sailor's jacket on his limbs was
thrown,
A sailor's story he had made his own;
Had suffer'd battles, prisons,
tempests, storms,
Encountering death in all his ugliest
forms.
His cheeks were haggard, hollow was
his eye,
Where madness lurk'd, conceal'd in
misery;
Want, and th' ungentle world, had
taught a part,

550

And prompted cunning to that simple
heart:
He now bethought him, he would
roam no more,
But live at home and labour as
before.

Here clothed and fed, no sooner he
began
To round and redden, than away he
ran;
His wife was dead, their children past
his aid:
So, unmolested, from his home he
stray'd.

Six years elapsed, when, worn with
want and pain,
Came Robin, wrapt in all his rags,
again.—

We chide, we pity;—placed among
our poor,

560

He fed again, and was a man once
more.

As when a gaunt and hungry fox is
found,
Entrapp'd alive in some rich hunter's
ground;
Fed for the field, although each day's
a feast,
Fatten you may, but never *tame* the
beast;
A house protects him, savoury viands
sustain;
But loose his neck and off he goes
again:
So stole our vagrant from his warm
retreat,
To rove a prowler and be deem'd a
cheat.

Hard was his fare; for, him at
length we saw,

570

In cart convey'd and laid supine on
straw.
His feeble voice now spoke a sinking
heart;
His groans now told the motions of
the cart;
And when it stopp'd, he tried in vain
to stand;
Closed was his eye, and clench'd his
clammy hand;
Life ebb'd apace, and our best aid no
more
Could his weak sense or dying heart
restore:
But now he fell, a victim to the snare,
That vile attorneys for the weak
prepare—

They who, when profit or resentment
call,

580

Heed not the groaning victim they
enthrall.

Then died lamented, in the strength
of life,
A valued Mother and a faithful Wife;
Call'd not away, when time had
loosed each hold
On the fond heart, and each desire
grew cold;
But when, to all that knit us to our
kind,
She felt fast-bound, as charity can
bind—
Not, when the ills of age, its pain, its
care,
The drooping spirit for its fate
prepare;
And each affection, failing, leaves the
heart

590

Loosed from life's charm and willing
to depart—
But all her ties the strong invader
broke,
In all their strength, by one
tremendous stroke!
Sudden and swift the eager pest came
on,
And terror grew, till every hope was
gone;
Still those around appear'd for hope
to seek!

But view'd the sick, and were afraid
to speak.—

Slowly they bore, with solemn
step, the dead;
When grief grew loud and bitter tears
were shed,
My part began; a crowd drew near the
place,

600

Awe in each eye, alarm in every face:
So swift the ill, and of so fierce a
kind,
That fear with pity mingled in each
mind;
Friends with the husband came their
griefs to blend;
For good-man Frankford was to all a
friend.

The last-born boy they held above the
bier;

He knew not grief, but cries express'd
his fear;

Each different age and sex reveal'd its
pain,

In now a louder, now a lower strain;
While the meek father, listening to
their tones,

610

Swell'd the full cadence of the grief
by groans.

The elder sister strove her pangs to
hide,

And soothing words to younger
minds applied

"Be still, be patient," oft she strove to
say;

But fail'd as oft, and weeping turn'd
away.

Curious and sad, upon the fresh-
dug hill,
The village-lads stood melancholy
still;
And idle children, wandering to-and-
fro,
As Nature guided, took the tone of
wo.

Arrived at home, how then they
gazed around,

620

In every place—where she no more
was found;
The seat at table she was wont to fill;
The fire-side chair, still set, but
vacant still;
The garden-walks, a labour all her
own,
The latticed bower, with trailing
shrubs o'ergrown;
The Sunday-pew she fill'd with all
her race—
Each place of hers, was now a sacred
place,
That, while it call'd up sorrows in the
eyes,
Pierced the full heart and forced them
still to rise.

Oh sacred sorrow! by whom souls
are tried,

630

Sent not to punish mortals, but to
guide;
If thou art mine, (and who shall
proudly dare

To tell his Maker, he has had his
share?)
Still let me feel for what thy pangs
are sent,
And be my guide and not my
punishment!

Of Leah Cousins next the name
appears,
With honours crown'd and bless'd
with length of years,
Save that she lived to feel, in life's
decay,
The pleasure die, the honours drop
away.
A matron she, whom every village-
wife

640

View'd as the help and guardian of
her life;
Fathers and sons, indebted to her aid,
Respect to her and her profession
paid;
Who in the house of plenty largely
fed,
Yet took her station at the pauper's
bed;
Nor from that duty could be bribed
again,
While fear or danger urged her to
remain.
In her experience all her friends
relied;
Heaven was her help and nature was
her guide.
Thus Leah lived, long trusted,
much caress'd,

650

Till a Town-Dame a youthful Farmer
bless'd;

A gay vain bride, who would example
give

To that poor village where she
deign'd to live;

Some few months past, she sent, in
hour of need,

For Doctor Glibb, who came with
wond'rous speed:

Two days he waited, all his art
applied,

To save the mother when her infant
died:—

""Twas well I came," at last he deign'd
to say;

""Twas wondrous well"—and proudly
rode away.

The news ran round:—"How vast
the Doctor's pow'r!

660

He saved the Lady in the trying hour;
Saved her from death, when she was
dead to hope,

And her fond husband had resign'd
her up:

So all, like her, may evil fate defy,
If Doctor Glibb, with saving hand, be
nigh."

Fame (now his friend), fear,
novelty, and whim,
And fashion, sent the varying sex to
him:

From this, contention in the village
rose,

And *these* the Dame espoused, the
Doctor *those*:

The wealthier part, to him and
science went;

670

With luck and her the poor remain'd
content.

The matron sigh'd; for she was
vex'd at heart,
With so much profit, so much fame,
to part:

"So long successful in my art," she
cried,

"And this proud man, so young and
so untried!"

"Nay," said the Doctor, "dare you
trust your wives,
The joy, the pride, the solace of your
lives,

To one who acts and knows no reason
why,

But trusts, poor hag! to luck for an
ally?—

Who, on experience, can her claims
advance,

680

And own the powers of accident and
chance?

A whining dame, who prays in
danger's view,

(A proof she knows not what beside
to do;)

What's her experience? In the time
that's gone,

Blundering she wrought, and still she
blunders on:—

What is Nature? One who acts in aid

Of gossips half asleep, and half
afraid.

With such allies I scorn my fame to
blend,

Skill is my luck and courage is my
friend;

No slave to Nature, 'tis my chief
delight

690

To win my way and act in her despite:

—

"Trust then my art, that, in itself
complete,

Needs no assistance and fears no
defeat."

Warm'd by her well-spiced ale and
aiding pipe,

The angry matron grew for contest
ripe.

"Can you," she said, "ungrateful
and unjust,

Before experience, ostentation trust!

What is your hazard, foolish
daughters, tell?

If safe, you're certain; if secure,
you're well:

That I have luck must friend and foe
confess,

700

And what's good judgment but a
lucky guess?

He boasts but what he *can* do:—will
you run

From me, your friend! who, all *he*
boasts, *have* done?

By proud and learned words his
powers are known;

By healthy boys and handsome girls
my own.

Wives! fathers! children! by my help
you live;

Has this pale Doctor more than life to
give?

No stunted cripple hops the village
round;

Your hands are active and your heads
are sound:

My lads are all your fields and flocks
require;

710

My lasses all those sturdy lads
admire.

Can this proud leech, with all his
boasted skill,

Amend the soul or body, wit or will?

Does he for courts the sons of farmers
frame,

Or make the daughter differ from the
dame?

Or, whom he brings into this world of
wo,

Prepares he them their part to
undergo?

If not, this stranger from your doors
repel,

And be content to *be*, and to be *well*."

She spake; but, ah! with words too
strong and plain;

720

Her warmth offended, and her truth
was vain:

The *many* left her, and the friendly
few,

If never colder, yet they older grew;

Till, unemploy'd, she felt her spirits
 droop,
And took, insidious aid! th' inspiring
 cup;
Grew poor and peevish as her powers
 decay'd,
And propp'd the tottering frame with
 stronger aid;—
Then died!—I saw our careful swains
 convey,
From this our changeful world, the
 matron's clay,
Who to this world, at least, with equal
 care,

730

Brought them its changes, good and
 ill to share.

 Now to his grave was Roger Cuff
 convey'd,
And strong resentment's lingering
 spirit laid.

Shipwreck'd in youth, he home
 return'd, and found
His brethren three—and thrice they
 wish'd him drown'd.

"Is this a landman's love? Be certain
 then,

We part for ever!"—and they cried,
 "Amen!"

 His words were truth's.—Some
 forty summers fled;
His brethren died; his kin supposed
 him dead:

Three nephews these, one sprightly
 niece, and one,

740

Less near in blood—they call'd him
surly John;

He work'd in woods apart from all his
kind.

Fierce were his looks and moody was
his mind.

For home the Sailor now began to
sigh:—

"The dogs are dead, and I'll return
and die;

When all I have, my gains, in years of
care,

The younger Cuffs with kinder souls
shall share.—

Yet hold! I'm rich;—with one consent
they'll say,

'You're welcome, Uncle, as the
flowers in May.'

No; I'll disguise me, be in tatters
dress'd,

750

And best befriend the lads who treat
me best."

Now all his kindred,—neither rich
nor poor—

Kept the wolf want some distance
from the door.

In piteous plight he knock'd at
George's gate,

And begg'd for aid, as he described
his state;—

But stern was George:—"Let them
who had thee strong,

Help thee to drag thy weaken'd frame
along;

To us a stranger, while your limbs
would move,

From us depart and try a stranger's
love:—

Ha! dost thou murmur?"—for, in
Roger's throat,

760

Was "Rascal!" rising with disdainful
note.

To pious James he then his prayer
address'd;—

"Good lack," quoth James, "thy
sorrows pierce my breast;

And, had I wealth, as have my
brethren twain,

One board should feed us and one
roof contain.

But plead I will thy cause and I will
pray;

And so farewell! Heaven help thee on
thy way!"

"Scoundrel!" said Roger, (but
apart;)—and told

His case to Peter;—Peter too was
cold;—

"The rates are high; we have a-many
poor;

770

But I will think,"—he said, and shut
the door.

Then the gay Niece the seeming
pauper press'd;—

"Turn, Nancy, turn, and view this
form distress'd;

Akin to thine is this declining frame,
And this poor beggar claims an
Uncle's name."

"Avaunt! begone!" the courteous
maiden said,

"Thou vile impostor! Uncle Roger's
dead:

I hate thee, beast; thy look my spirit
shocks!

Oh! that I saw thee starving in the
stocks!"

"My gentle niece!" he said—and
sought the wood.—

780

"I hunger, fellow; prithee, give me
food!"

"Give! am I rich? This hatchet
take, and try

Thy proper strength, nor give those
limbs the lie;

Work, feed thyself, to thine own
powers appeal,

Nor whine out woes, thine own right-
hand can heal:

And while that hand is thine and thine
a leg,

Scorn of the proud or of the base to
beg."

"Come, surly John, thy wealthy
kinsman view,"

Old Roger said:—"thy words are
brave and true;

Come, live with me: we'll vex those
scoundrel-boys,

790

And that prim shrew shall, envying,
hear our joys.—

Tobacco's glorious fume all day we'll
share,

With beef and brandy kill all kinds of
care;

We'll beer and biscuit on our table
heap,
And rail at rascals, till we fall asleep."
Such was their life; but when the
woodman died,
His grieving kin for Roger's smiles
applied—
In vain; he shut, with stern rebuke,
the door,
And dying, built a refuge for the
poor:
With this restriction, That no Cuff
should share
800
One meal, or shelter for one moment
there.

My record ends:—But hark! e'en
now I hear
The bell of death, and know not
whose to fear.
Our farmers all, and all our hinds
were well;
In no man's cottage danger seem'd to
dwell;—
Yet death of man proclaim these
heavy chimes,
For thrice they sound, with pausing
space, three times.
"Go; of my sexton seek, Whose
days are sped?—
"What! he, himself!—and is old
Dibble dead?"
His eightieth year he reach'd, still
undecay'd,

And rectors five to one close vault
convey'd:—
But he is gone; his care and skill I
lose,
And gain a mournful subject for my
Muse:
His masters lost, he'd oft in turn
deplore,
And kindly add,—"Heaven grant, I
lose no more!"
Yet, while he spake, a sly and
pleasant glance
Appear'd at variance with his
complaisance:
For, as he told their fate and varying
worth,
He archly look'd,—"I yet may bear
thee forth."
"When first"—(he so began)—"my
trade I plied,

820

Good master Addle was the parish-
guide;
His clerk and sexton, I beheld with
fear
His stride majestic, and his frown
severe;
A noble pillar of the church he stood,
Adorn'd with college-gown and
parish-hood.
Then as he paced the hallow'd aisles
about,
He fill'd the sevenfold surplice fairly
out!
But in his pulpit, wearied down with
prayer,

He sat and seem'd as in his study's
chair;

For while the anthem swell'd, and
when it ceased,

830

Th' expecting people view'd their
slumbering priest:

Who, dozing, died.—Our Parson
Peele was next;

'I will not spare you,' was his
favourite text;

Nor did he spare, but raised them
many a pound;

Ev'n me he mulct for my poor rood of
ground;

Yet cared he nought, but with a
gibing speech,

'What should I do,' quoth he, 'but
what *I* preach?'

His piercing jokes (and he'd a
plenteous store)

Were daily offer'd both to rich and
poor;

His scorn, his love, in playful words
he spoke;

840

His pity, praise, and promise, were a
joke:

But though so young and bless'd with
spirits high,

He died as grave as any judge could
die:

The strong attack subdued his lively
powers,—

His was the grave, and Doctor
Grandspear ours.

Then were there golden times the
village round;
In his abundance all appear'd t'
abound;
Liberal and rich, a plenteous board he
spread,
E'en cool Dissenters at his table fed,
Who wish'd, and hoped,—and
thought a man so kind

850

A way to Heaven, though not their
own, might find;
To them, to all, he was polite and
free,
Kind to the poor, and, ah! most kind
to me:
'Ralph,' would he say, 'Ralph Dibble,
thou art old;
That doublet fit, 'twill keep thee from
the cold.
How does my sexton?—What! the
times are hard;
Drive that stout pig, and pen him in
thy yard.'
But most, his rev'rence loved a
mirthful jest:—
'Thy coat is thin; why, man, thou'rt
barely dress'd;
It's worn to th' thread; but I have
nappy beer;

860

Clap that within, and see how they
will wear!'
"Gay days were these; but they
were quickly past:
When first he came, we found he
cou'dn't last:

A whoreson cough (and at the fall of
leaf)

Upset him quite;—but what's the gain
of grief?

"Then came the Author-Rector; his
delight
Was all in books; to read them, or to
write:

Women and men he strove alike to
shun,

And hurried homeward when his
tasks were done,

Courteous enough, but careless what
he said,

870

For points of learning he reserved his
head;

And, when addressing either poor or
rich,

He knew no better than his cassock
which.

He, like an osier, was of pliant kind,
Erect by nature, but to bend inclined;
Not like a creeper falling to the
ground,

Or meanly catching on the
neighbours round.—

Careless was he of surplice, hood,
and band—

And kindly took them as they came to
hand;

Nor, like the doctor, wore a world of
hat,

880

As if he sought for dignity in that.

He talk'd, he gave, but not with
cautious rules,

Nor turn'd from gipsies, vagabonds,
or fools;
It was his nature, but they thought it
whim,
And so our beaux and beauties turn'd
from him.
Of questions much he wrote,
profound and dark—
How spake the serpent, and where
stopp'd the ark;
From what far land the Queen of
Sheba came;
Who Salem's priest, and what his
father's name;
He made the Song of Songs its
mysteries yield,
890
And Revelations, to the world,
reveal'd.
He sleeps i' the aisle—but not a stone
records
His name or fame, his actions or his
words:
And, truth, your reverence, when I
look around,
And mark the tombs in our sepulchral
ground,
(Though dare I not of one man's hope
to doubt),
I'd join the party who repose without,
"Next came a youth from
Cambridge, and, in truth,
He was a sober and a comely youth;
He blush'd in meekness as a modest
man,

900

And gain'd attention ere his task
began;
When preaching, seldom ventured on
reproof,
But touch'd his neighbours tenderly
enough.
Him, in his youth, a clamorous sect
assail'd,
Advised and censured, flatter'd,—and
prevail'd.—
Then did he much his sober hearers
vex,
Confound the simple, and the sad
perplex;
To a new style his reverence rashly
took;
Loud grew his voice, to threat'ning
swell'd his look;
Above, below, on either side, he
gazed,

910

Amazing all, and most himself
amazed:
No more he read his preachments
pure and plain,
But launch'd outright, and rose and
sank again:
At times he smiled in }
scorn, at times }
he wept,
And such sad coil with words
of vengeance kept,
That our best sleepers started
as they slept.
"Conviction comes like lightning,"
he would cry;

'In vain you seek it, and in vain you
fly;

'Tis like the rushing of the mighty
wind,

Unseen its progress, but its power
you find;

920

It strikes the child ere yet its reason
wakes;

His reason fled, the ancient sire it
shakes.

The proud, learn'd man, and him who
loves to know

How and from whence these gusts of
grace will blow,

It shuns,—but sinners in their way
impedes,

And sots and harlots visits in their
deeds:

Of faith and penance it }
supplies the }
place;

Assures the vilest that they
live by grace,

And, without running, makes
them win the race.'

"Such was the doctrine our young
prophet taught;

930

And here conviction, there confusion
wrought;

When his thin cheek assumed a
deadly hue,

And all the rose to one small spot
withdrew:

They call'd it hectic; 'twas a fiery
flush,

More fix'd and deeper than the
maiden blush;
His paler lips the pearly teeth
disclosed,
And lab'ring lungs the length'ning
speech opposed.
No more his span-girth shanks and
quiv'ring thighs
Upheld a body of the smaller size;
But down he sank upon his dying
bed,

940

And gloomy crotchets fill'd his
wandering head.—
"Spite of my faith, all-saving
faith,' he cried,
'I fear of worldly works the wicked
pride;
Poor as I am, degraded, abject, blind,
The good I've wrought still rankles in
my mind;
My alms-deeds all, and every deed
I've done,
My moral-rags defile me, every one;
It should not be—what say'st thou?
tell me, Ralph.'
Quoth I, 'Your reverence, I believe,
you're safe;
Your faith's your prop, nor have you
pass'd such time

950

In life's good-works as swell them to
a crime.
If I of pardon for my sins were sure,
About my goodness I would rest
secure.'

"Such was his end; and mine
approaches fast;
I've seen my best of preachers—and
my last."—

He bow'd, and archly smiled at
what he said,
Civil but sly:—"And is old Dibble
dead?"

Yes! he is gone: and we are going
all;
Like flowers we wither, and like
leaves we fall;—
Here, with an infant, joyful sponsors
come,

960

Then bear the new-made Christian to
its home;
A few short years, and we behold him
stand,
To ask a blessing, with his bride in
hand:

A few, still seeming shorter, and we
hear

His widow weeping at her husband's
bier:—

Thus, as the months succeed, shall
infants take

Their names; thus parents shall the
child forsake;

Thus brides again and bridegrooms
blithe shall kneel,

By love or law compell'd their vows
to seal,

Ere I again, or one like me, explore

970

These simple annals of the VILLAGE
POOR.

FOOTNOTES:

[24] Young's *The Complaint, or Night Thoughts, Night I.*

[25] See p. 170.

THE BIRTH OF FLATTERY.

Subject—Poverty and Cunning described—When united, a jarring Couple—Mutual Reproof—The Wife consoled by a Dream—Birth of a Daughter—Description and Prediction of Envy—How to be rendered ineffectual, explained in a Vision—Simulation foretells the future Success and Triumphs of Flattery—Her Power over various Characters and different Minds; over certain Classes of Men; over Envy himself—Her successful Art of softening the Evils of Life; of changing Characters; of meliorating Prospects, and affixing Value to Possessions, Pictures, &c.—Conclusion.

Omnia habeo, nec quicquam habeo [...]
Quidquid dicunt, laudo; id rursum si
negant, laudo id quoque.
Negat quis, nego; ait, aio. Postremò
imperavi egomet mihi
Omnia assentari.

Terent. in
Eun
uch.
[Act
II.
Sc.
2.]

It has been held in ancient rules,
That flattery is the food of fools;
Yet now and then your men of wit
Will condescend to taste a bit.

Swift[,
Cad
enu
s
and
Van
essa
.]

Muse of my Spenser, who so well
could sing
The passions all, their bearings and
their ties;
Who could in view those shadowy
beings bring,
And with bold hand remove each
dark disguise,
Wherein love, hatred, scorn, or anger
lies:
Guide him to Fairy-land, who now
intends
That way his flight; assist him as he
flies,
To mark those passions, Virtue's foes
and friends,
By whom when led she droops, when
leading she ascends.

10

Yes! they appear, I see the fairy-train!
And who that modest nymph of
meek address?
Not Vanity, though loved by all the
vain;
Not Hope, though promising to all
success;

Nor Mirth, nor Joy, though foe to
all distress;
Thee, sprightly syren, from this train
I choose,
Thy birth relate, thy soothing arts
confess;
'Tis not in thy mild nature to refuse,
When poets ask thine aid, so oft their
need and muse.

In Fairy-land, on wide and
cheerless plain,
20
Dwelt, in the house of Care, a sturdy
swain;
A hireling he, who, when he till'd the
soil,
Look'd to the pittance that repaid his
toil;
And to a master left the mingled joy
And anxious care that follow'd his
employ.
Sullen and patient he at once
appear'd,
As one who murmur'd, yet as one
who fear'd;
Th' attire was coarse that clothed his
sinewy frame,
Rude his address, and Poverty his
name.

In that same plain a nymph, of
curious taste,
30

A cottage (plann'd with all her skill)
 had placed;
Strange the materials, and for what
 design'd
The various parts, no simple man
 might find;
What seem'd the door, each entering
 guest withstood,
What seem'd a window was but
 painted wood;
But by a secret spring the wall would
 move,
And day-light drop through glassy
 door above.
'Twas all her pride, new traps for
 praise to lay,
And all her wisdom was to hide her
 way;
In small attempts incessant were her
 pains,
40
And Cunning was her name among
 the swains.

Now, whether fate decreed this pair
 should wed,
And blindly drove them to the
 marriage-bed;
Or whether love in some soft hour
 inclined
The damsel's heart, and won her to be
 kind,
Is yet unsung: they were an ill-
 match'd pair,
But both disposed to wed—and wed
 they were.

Yet, though united in their fortune,
still
Their ways were diverse; varying was
their will;
Nor long the maid had bless'd the
simple man,
50
Before dissensions rose, and she
began:—

"Wretch that I am! since to thy
fortune bound,
What plan, what project, with success
is crown'd?
I, who a thousand secret arts possess,
Who every rank approach with right
address;
Who've loosed a guinea from a
miser's chest,
And worm'd his secret from a traitor's
breast;
Thence gifts and gains collecting,
great and small,
Have brought to thee, and thou
consum'st them all:
For want like thine—a bog without a
base—

60
Ingulfs all gains I gather for the
place;
Feeding, unfill'd; destroying,
undestroy'd;
It craves for ever, and is ever void:—
Wretch that I am! what misery have I
found,
Since my sure craft was to thy calling
bound!"

"Oh! vaunt of worthless art," the
swain replied,
Scowling contempt, "how pitiful this
pride!
What are these specious gifts, these
paltry gains,
But base rewards for ignominious
pains?
With all thy tricking, still for bread
we strive;

70

Thine is, proud wretch! the care that
cannot thrive;
By all thy boasted skill and baffled
hooks
Thou gain'st no more than students by
their books;
No more than I for my poor deeds am
paid,
Whom none can blame, will help, or
dare upbraid.

"Call this our need, a bog that all
devours—
Then what thy petty arts but summer-
flowers,
Gaudy and mean, and serving to
betray
The place they make unprofitably
gay?
Who know it not, some useless
beauties see—

80

But ah! to prove it, was reserved for
me."

Unhappy state! that, in decay of
love,

Permits harsh truth his errors to
disprove;
While he remains, to wrangle and to
jar
Is friendly tournament, not fatal war;
Love in his play will borrow arms of
hate,
Anger and rage, upbraiding and
debate;
And by his power the desperate
weapons thrown,
Become as safe and pleasant as his
own;
But left by him, their natures they
assume,
90
And fatal, in their poisoning force,
become.

Time fled, and now the swain
compell'd to see
New cause for fear—"Is this thy
thrift?" quoth he.
To whom the wife with cheerful voice
replied:—
"Thou moody man, lay all thy fears
aside,
I've seen a vision;—they, from whom
I came,
A daughter promise, promise wealth
and fame;
Born with my features, }
with my arts, }
yet she
Shall patient, pliant,
persevering be,

And in thy better ways resemble thee.
100

The fairies round shall at her birth
attend;
The friend of all in all shall find a
friend;
And, save that one sad star that hour
must gleam
On our fair child, how glorious were
my dream!"

This heard the husband, and, in
surly smile,
Aim'd at contempt, but yet he hoped
the while:
For as, when sinking, wretched men
are found
To catch at rushes rather than be
drown'd;
So on a dream our peasant placed his
hope,
And found that rush as valid as a
rope.

110

Swift fled the days, for now in
hope they fled,
When a fair daughter bless'd the
nuptial bed;
Her infant-face the mother's pains
beguiled,
She look'd so pleasing, and so softly
smiled;
Those smiles, those looks, with sweet
sensations moved
The gazer's soul, and, as he look'd, he
loved.

And now the fairies came, with
 gifts, to grace
So mild a nature and so fair a face.
 They gave, with beauty, that
 bewitching art,
That holds in easy chains the human
 heart;

120

They gave her skill to win the
 stubborn mind,
To make the suffering to their
 sorrows blind,
To bring on pensive looks the
 pleasing smile,
And Care's stern brow of every frown
 beguile.

 These magic favours graced the
 infant-maid,
Those more enlivening smile the
 charming gifts repaid.

Now Fortune changed, who, were
 she constant long,
Would leave us few adventures for
 our song.

 A wicked elfin roved this land
 around,
Whose joys proceeded from the griefs
 he found;

130

Envy his name:—his fascinating eye
From the light bosom drew the
 sudden sigh;
Unsocial he, but with malignant
 mind,
He dwelt with man, that he might
 curse mankind;

Like the first foe, he sought th' abode
of Joy,
Grieved to behold, but eager to
destroy;
Round blooming beauty, like the
wasp, he flew,
Soil'd the fresh sweet, and changed
the rosy hue;
The wise, the good, with anxious
heart, he saw,
And here a failing found, and there a
flaw;

140

Discord in families 'twas his to move,
Distrust in friendship, jealousy in
love;
He told the poor, what joys the great
possess'd,
The great—what calm content the
cottage bless'd;
To part the learned and the rich he
tried,
Till their slow friendship perish'd in
their pride.
Such was the fiend, and so secure of
prey,
That only Misery pass'd unstung
away.

Soon as he heard the fairy-babe
was born,
Scornful he smiled, but felt no more
than scorn;

150

For why, when Fortune placed her
state so low,

In useless spite his lofty malice
show?

Why, in a mischief of the meaner
kind,

Exhaust the vigour of a ranc'rous
mind?

But, soon as Fame the fairy-gifts
proclaim'd,

Quick-rising wrath his ready soul
inflamed,

To swear, by vows that e'en the
wicked tie,

The nymph should weep her varied
destiny;

That every gift, that now appear'd to
shine

In her fair face, and make her smiles
divine,

160

Should all the poison of his magic
prove,

And they should scorn her, whom she
sought for love.

His spell prepared, in form an
ancient dame,

A fiend in spirit, to the cot he came;

There gain'd admittance, and the
infant press'd

(Muttering his wicked magic) to his
breast;

And thus he said:—"Of all the
powers, who wait

On Jove's decrees, and do the work of
fate,

Was I alone, despised or worthless,
found,

Weak to protect, or impotent to
wound?

170

See then thy foe, regret the friendship
lost,
And learn my skill, but learn it at
your cost.

"Know then, O child! devote to
fates severe,
The good shall hate thy name, the
wise shall fear;
Wit shall deride, and no protecting
friend
Thy shame shall cover, or thy name
defend.
Thy gentle sex, who, more than ours,
should spare
A humble foe, will greater scorn
declare;
The base alone thy advocates shall
be,
Or boast alliance with a wretch like
thee."

180

He spake and vanish'd, other prey
to find,
And waste in slow disease the
conquer'd mind.

Awed by the elfin's threats, and
fill'd with dread,
The parents wept, and sought their
infant's bed:
Despair alone the father's soul
possess'd,

But hope rose gently in the mother's
breast;
For well she knew that neither grief
nor joy
Pain'd without hope, or pleased
without alloy;
And while these hopes and fears her
heart divide,
A cheerful vision bade the fears
subside.

190

She saw descending to the world
below
An ancient form, with solemn pace
and slow.

"Daughter, no more be sad," (the
phantom cried,)
"Success is seldom to the wise
denied;
In idle wishes fools supinely stay—
Be there a will, and wisdom finds a
way:
Why art thou grieved? Be rather glad,
that he,
Who hates the happy, aims his darts
at thee,
But aims in vain; thy favour'd
daughter lies,
Serenely blest, and shall to joy arise.

200

For, grant that curses on her name
shall wait,
(So envy wills and such the voice of
fate,)

Yet, if that name be prudently
suppress'd,
She shall be courted, favour'd, and
caress'd.

"For what are names? and where
agree mankind
In those to persons or to acts
assign'd?
Brave, learn'd, or wise, if some their
favourites call,
Have they the titles or the praise from
all?
Not so, but others will the brave
disdain
As rash, and deem the sons of
wisdom vain;

210

The self-same mind shall scorn or
kindness move,
And the same deed attract contempt
and love.

"So all the powers who move the
human soul,
With all the passions who the will
control,
Have various names—[one] giv'n by
Truth Divine,
(As Simulation thus was fix'd for
mine,)
The rest by man, who now, as
wisdom's, prize
My secret counsels, now as art
despise;
One hour, as just, those counsels they
embrace,
And spurn, the next, as pitiful and
base.

220

"Thee, too, my child, those fools as
Cunning fly,
Who on thy counsel and thy craft
rely;
That worthy craft in others they
condemn,
But 'tis their prudence, while
conducting them.

"Be FLATTERY, then, thy happy
infant's name,
Let Honour scorn her and let Wit
defame;
Let all be true that Envy dooms, yet
all,
Not on herself, but on her name, shall
fall;
While she thy fortune and her own
shall raise,
And decent Truth be call'd, and loved
as modest Praise.

230

"O happy child! the }
glorious day
shall shine,
When every ear shall to thy
speech incline,
Thy words alluring and thy
voice divine.
The sullen pedant and the sprightly
wit,
To hear thy soothing eloquence, shall
sit;
And both, abjuring Flattery, will
agree
That truth inspires, and they must
honour thee.

"Envy himself shall }
to thy }
accents
bend,
Force a faint smile and
sullenly attend,
When thou shalt call him
Virtue's jealous friend,

240

Whose bosom glows with generous
rage to find
How fools and knaves are flatter'd by
mankind.

"The sage retired, who spends
alone his days,
And flies th' obstreperous voice of
public praise;
The vain, the vulgar cry shall gladly
meet,
And bid thee welcome to his still
retreat;
Much will he wonder, how thou
cam'st to find
A man to glory dead, to peace
consign'd.
'O Fame!' he'll cry, (for he will call
thee Fame,)
'From thee I fly, from thee conceal
my name.'

250

But thou shalt say, 'Though Genius
takes his flight,
He leaves behind a glorious train of
light,
And hides in vain;—yet prudent he
that flies

The flatterer's art, and for himself is
wise.'

"Yes, happy child! I mark th'
approaching day,
When warring natures will confess
thy sway;
When thou shalt Saturn's golden reign
restore,
And vice and folly shall be known no
more.

"Pride shall not then in human-kind
have place,
Changed, by thy skill, to Dignity and
Grace;

260

While Shame, who now betrays the
inward sense
Of secret ill, shall be thy Diffidence;
Avarice shall thenceforth prudent
Forecast be,
And bloody Vengeance,
Magnanimity;
The lavish tongue }
shall honest }
truths impart,
The lavish hand shall show
the generous heart,
And Indiscretion be contempt
of art:
Folly and Vice shall then, no longer
known,
Be, this as Virtue, that as Wisdom,
shown.

"Then shall the Robber, as the
Hero, rise

270

To seize the good that churlish law
denies;
Throughout the world shall rove the
generous band,
And deal the gifts of Heaven from
hand to hand.

"In thy blest days no tyrant shall be
seen,
Thy gracious king shall rule
contented men;
In thy blest days shall not a rebel be,
But patriots all and well approved of
thee.

"Such powers are thine, that man,
by thee, shall wrest
The gainful secret from the cautious
breast;
Nor then, with all his care, the good
retain,

280

But yield to thee the secret and the
gain.
In vain shall much experience guard
the heart
Against the charm of thy prevailing
art;
Admitted once, so soothing is thy
strain,
It comes the sweeter, when it comes
again;
And when confess'd as thine, what
mind so strong
Forbears the pleasure it indulged so
long?
"Soft'ner of every ill! of all our
woes

The balmy solace! friend of fiercest
foes!

Begin thy reign, and like the morning
rise!

290

Bring joy, bring beauty, to our eager
eyes;

Break on the drowsy }
world like }
opening day,

While grace and gladness join
thy flow'ry way;

While every voice is praise,
while every heart is gay.

"From thee all prospects shall new
beauties take,

'Tis thine to seek them and 'tis thine
to make;

On the cold fen I see thee turn thine
eyes,

Its mists recede, its chilling vapour
flies;

Th' enraptured lord th' improving
ground surveys,

And for his Eden asks the traveller's
praise,

300

Which yet, unview'd of thee, a bog
had been,

Where spongy rushes hide the plashy
green.

"I see thee breathing on the barren
moor,

That seems to bloom although so
bleak before;

There, if beneath the gorse the
primrose spring,

Or the pied daisy smile below the
ling,
They shall new charms, at thy
command, disclose,
And none shall miss the myrtle or the
rose.

The wiry moss, that whitens all the
hill,
Shall live a beauty by thy matchless
skill;

310

Gale^[26] from the bog shall yield
Arabian balm,
And the grey willow wave a golden
palm.

"I see thee smiling in the pictured
room,
Now breathing beauty, now reviving
bloom;
There, each immortal name 'tis thine
to give
To graceless forms, and bid the
lumber live.

Should'st thou coarse boors or
gloomy martyrs see,
These shall thy Guidos those thy
Teniers' be;

There shalt thou }
Raphael's
saints and
angels trace,

There make for Rubens and
for Reynolds place,

320

And all the pride of art [shalt] find in
her disgrace.

"Delight of either }
sex! thy }
reign
commence;
With balmy sweetness soothe
the weary sense,
And to the sickening soul thy
cheering aid dispense.
Queen of the mind! }
thy golden age }
begin;
In mortal bosoms varnish
shame and sin;
Let all be fair without, let all
be calm within."

The Vision fled; the happy mother
rose,
Kiss'd the fair infant, smiled at all her
foes,
And FLATTERY made her name:—her
reign began,
330
Her own dear sex she ruled, then
vanquish'd man;
A smiling friend, to every class, she
spoke,
Assumed their manners, and their
habits took;
Her, for her humble mien, the modest
loved;
Her cheerful looks the light and gay
approved;
The just beheld her, firm; the valiant,
brave;
Her mirth the free, her silence pleased
the grave;

Zeal heard her voice, and, as he
 preach'd aloud,
Well-pleased he caught her whispers
 from the crowd—
(Those whispers, soothing-sweet to
 every ear,

340

Which some refuse to pay, but none
 to hear);
Shame fled her presence; at her
 gentle strain,
Care softly smiled, and guilt forgot its
 pain;
The wretched thought, the happy
 found her true;
The learn'd confess'd that she their
 merits knew;
The rich—could they a constant
 friend condemn?
The poor believed—for who should
 flatter them?

 Thus on her name though all
 disgrace attend,
In every creature she beholds a
 friend.

FOOTNOTES:

^[26] "Myrica gale," a shrub growing in boggy and fenny grounds.

REFLECTIONS

UPON THE SUBJECT——

Quid juvat errores, mersâ jam puppe,
fateri?

Quid lacrymæ delicta juvant commissa
secutæ?

Claudian.

in

Eutr

op.

lib.

ii.

lin.

7

What avails it, when shipwrecked, that
error appears?

Are the crimes we commit wash'd away
by our tears?

When all the fiercer passions cease
(The glory and disgrace of youth);
When the deluded soul, in peace,
Can listen to the voice of truth;
When we are taught in whom to trust,
And how to spare, to spend, to
give,
(Our prudence kind, our pity just)—
'Tis then we rightly learn to live.

Its weakness when the body feels,
10

Nor danger in contempt defies;
To reason when desire appeals,
When on experience hope relies;
When every passing hour we prize,
Nor rashly on our follies spend;
But use it, as it quickly flies,

With sober aim to serious end;
When prudence bounds our utmost
views,
And bids us wrath and wrong
forgive;
When we can calmly gain or lose—
20

'Tis then we rightly learn to live.
Yet thus, when we our way discern,
And can upon our care depend,
To travel safely when we learn,
Behold! we're near our journey's
end.

We've trod the maze of error round,
Long wand'ring in the winding
glade;
And now the torch of truth is found,
It only shows us where we stray'd:
Light for ourselves, what is it worth,
30

When we no more our way can
choose?
For others when we hold it forth,
They, in their pride, the boon
refuse.

By long experience taught, we now
Can rightly judge of friends and
foes,
Can all the worth of these allow,
And all their faults discern in
those;
Relentless hatred, erring love,
We can for sacred truth forego;
We can the warmest friend reprove,
40

And bear to praise the fiercest foe:

To what effect? Our friends are gone,
Beyond reproof, regard, or care;
And of our foes remains there one,
The mild relenting thoughts to
share?

Now 'tis our boast that we can quell
The wildest passions in their rage;
Can their destructive force repel,
And their impetuous wrath
assuage:

Ah! Virtue, dost thou arm, when now
50

This bold rebellious race are fled;
When all these tyrants rest, and thou
Art warring with the mighty dead?
Revenge, ambition, scorn, and pride,
And strong desire and fierce
disdain,
The giant-brood, by thee defied,
Lo! Time's resistless strokes have
slain.

Yet Time, who could that race
subdue,
(O'erpow'ring strength, appeasing
rage,)

Leaves yet a persevering crew,
60

To try the failing powers of age.
Vex'd by the constant call of these,
Virtue awhile for conquest tries,
But weary grown and fond of ease,
She makes with them a
compromise:

Av'rice himself she gives to rest,
But rules him with her strict
commands;

Bids Pity touch his torpid breast,
And Justice hold his eager hands.

Yet is there nothing men can do,
70

When chilling Age comes creeping
on?

Cannot we yet some good pursue?
Are talents buried? genius gone?
If passions slumber in the breast,
If follies from the heart be fled:
Of laurels let us go in quest,
And place them on the poet's head.

Yes, we'll redeem the wasted time,
And to neglected studies flee;
We'll build again the lofty rhyme,
80

Or live, Philosophy, with thee;
For reasoning clear, for flight
sublime,
Eternal fame reward shall be;
And to what glorious heights we'll
climb,
Th' admiring crowd shall envying
see.

Begin the song! begin the theme!—
Alas! and is Invention dead?
Dream we no more the golden
dream?

Is Mem'ry with her treasures fled?
Yes, 'tis too late—now Reason guides
90

The mind, sole judge in all debate;
And thus th' important point decides,
For laurels, 'tis, alas! too late.

What is possess'd we may retain,
But for new conquests strive in
vain.
Beware then, Age, that what was
won,
[In] life's past labours, studies,
views,
Be lost not, now the labour's done,
When all thy part is—not to lose:
When thou canst toil or gain no
more,
100
Destroy not what was gain'd
before.

For, all that's gain'd of all that's good,
When time shall his weak frame
destroy,
(Their use then rightly understood,)
Shall man, in happier state, enjoy.
Oh! argument for truth divine,
For study's cares, for virtue's strife:
To know th' enjoyment will be thine,
In that renew'd, that endless life!

SIR EUSTACE GREY.

SCENE—A MAD-HOUSE.

PERSONS—VISITOR, PHYSICIAN, AND PATIENT.

Veris miscens falsa.—

Seneca in Herc. furente
[Act IV. V. 1070].

VISITOR.

I'll know no more;—the heart is torn
By views of wo we cannot heal;
Long shall I see these things forlorn,
And oft again their griefs shall feel,
As each upon the mind shall steal;
That wan projector's mystic style,
That lumpish idiot leering by,
That peevish idler's ceaseless wile,
And that poor maiden's half-form'd
smile,

10

While struggling for the full-drawn
sigh!—
I'll know no more.

PHYSICIAN.

—Yes, turn
again
;

Then speed to happier scenes thy
way,
When thou hast view'd, what yet
remain,
The ruins of Sir Eustace Grey,
The sport of madness, misery's
prey.
But he will no historian need;
His cares, his crimes, will he
display,
And show (as one from frenzy freed)
The proud-lost mind, the rash-done
deed.

20

That cell to him is Greyling Hall:—

Approach; he'll bid thee welcome
there;
Will sometimes for his servant call,
And sometimes point the vacant
chair:
He can, with free and easy air,
Appear attentive and polite;
Can veil his woes in manners fair,
And pity with respect excite.

PATIENT.

Who comes?—Approach!—'tis
kindly done:—
My learn'd physician, and a friend,
30
Their pleasures quit, to visit one
Who cannot to their ease attend,
Nor joys bestow, nor comforts lend,
As when I lived so bless'd, so well,
And dreamt not I must soon contend
With those malignant powers of
hell.

PHYSICIAN.

Less warmth, Sir Eustace, or we
go.—

PATIENT.

See! I am calm as infant-love,
A very child, but one of wo,
Whom you should pity, not
reprove:—
40
But men at ease, who never strove

With passions wild, will calmly
show
How soon we may their ills remove,
And masters of their madness
grow.

Some twenty years I think are
gone;—
(Time flies, I know not how,
away;)—
The sun upon no happier shone,
Nor prouder man, than Eustace
Grey.
Ask where you would, and all would
say,
The man admired and praised of
all,

50

By rich and poor, by grave and gay.
Was the young lord of Greyling
Hall.
Yes! I had youth and rosy health;
Was nobly form'd, as man might
be;
For sickness then, of all my wealth,
I never gave a single fee:
The ladies fair, the maidens free,
Were all accustom'd then to say,
Who would a handsome figure see
Should look upon Sir Eustace
Grey.

60

He had a frank and pleasant look,
A cheerful eye and accent bland;
His very speech and manner spoke
The generous heart, the open hand;

About him all was gay or grand,
He had the praise of great and
small;
He bought, improved, projected,
plann'd,
And reign'd a prince at Greyling
Hall.

My lady!—she was all we love;
All praise (to speak her worth) is
faint;

70

Her manners show'd the yielding
dove,
Her morals, the seraphic saint;
She never breathed nor look'd
complaint;
No equal upon earth had she:—
Now, what is this fair thing I paint?
Alas! as all that live shall be.

There was, beside, a gallant youth,
And him my bosom's friend I
had:—

Oh! I was rich in very truth,
It made me proud—it made me
mad!—

80

Yes, I was lost—but there was cause!

—

Where stood my tale?—I cannot
find—
But I had all mankind's applause,
And all the smiles of womankind.

There were two cherub-things beside,
A gracious girl, a glorious boy;

Yet more to swell my full-blown
pride,

To varnish higher my fading joy,
Pleasures were ours without alloy,

Nay, Paradise,—till my frail Eve
90

Our bliss was tempted to destroy,
Deceived and fated to deceive.

But I deserved; for all that time,
When I was loved, admired,
caress'd,

There was within each secret crime,
Unfelt, uncancell'd, unconfess'd:

I never then my God address'd,
In grateful praise or humble prayer;
And, if His Word was not my jest,
(Dread thought!) it never was my
care.

100

I doubted—fool I was to doubt!—

If that all-piercing eye could see;
If He who looks all worlds
throughout,

Would so minute and careful be,
As to perceive and punish me:—
With man I would be great and
high,

But with my God so lost, that He,
In his large view, should pass me
by.

Thus bless'd with children, friend,
and wife,

Bless'd far beyond the vulgar lot;

110

Of all that gladdens human life,
Where was the good, that I had
not?
But my vile heart had sinful spot,
And Heaven beheld its deep'ning
stain;
Eternal justice I forgot,
And mercy sought not to obtain.

Come near—I'll softly speak the rest!

—
Alas! 'tis known to all the crowd,
Her guilty love was all confess'd,
And his, who so much truth
avow'd,

120

My faithless friend's.—In pleasure
proud
I sat, when these cursed tidings
came;
Their guilt, their flight was told
aloud,
And Envy smiled to hear my
shame!

I call'd on Vengeance; at the word
She came:—Can I the deed forget?
I held the sword, th' accursed sword,
The blood of his false heart made
wet;
And that fair victim paid her debt;
She pined, she died, she loath'd to
live;—

130

I saw her dying—see her yet:
Fair fallen thing! my rage forgive!

Those cherubs still, my life to bless,
Were left; could I my fears remove,
Sad fears that checked each fond
caress,
And poison'd all parental love?
Yet that with jealous feelings strove,
And would at last have won my
will,
Had I not, wretch! been doom'd to
prove
Th' extremes of mortal good and
ill.

140

In youth! health! joy! in beauty's
pride!
They droop'd: as flowers when
blighted bow,
The dire infection came.—They died,
And I was cursed—as I am now.—
Nay, frown not, angry friend—allow
That I was deeply, sorely tried;
Hear then, and you must wonder how
I could such storms and strifes
abide.

Storms!—not that clouds embattled
make,
When they afflict this earthly
globe;

150

But such as with their terrors shake
Man's breast, and to the bottom
probe:
They make the hypocrite disrobe,
They try us all, if false or true;
For this, one devil had pow'r on Job;

And I was long the slave of two.

PHYSICIAN.

Peace, peace, my friend; these
subjects fly;
Collect thy thoughts—go calmly
on.—

PATIENT.

And shall I then the fact deny?
I was,—thou know'st—I was
begone,

160

Like him who fill'd the eastern
throne,

To whom the Watcher cried
aloud^[27];

That royal wretch of Babylon,
Who was so guilty and so proud.

Like him, with haughty, stubborn
mind,

I, in my state, my comforts sought;
Delight and praise I hoped to find,

In what I builded, planted, bought!
Oh! arrogance! by misery taught—

Soon came a voice! I felt it come:

170

"Full be his cup, with evil fraught,

"Demons his guides, and death his
doom!"

Then was I cast from out my state;

Two fiends of darkness led my
way;

They waked me early, watch'd me
late,
My dread by night, my plague by
day!
Oh! I was made their sport, their play,
Through many a stormy troubled
year;
And how they used their passive prey
Is sad to tell;—but you shall hear.

180
And first, before they sent me forth,
Through this unpitying world to
run,
They robb'd Sir Eustace of his worth,
Lands, manors, lordships, every
one;
So was that gracious man undone,
Was spurn'd as vile, was scorn'd as
poor,
Whom every former friend would
shun,
And menials drove from every
door.

Then those ill-favour'd Ones^[28],
whom none
But my unhappy eyes could view,
190
Led me, with wild emotion, on,
And, with resistless terror, drew.
Through lands we fled, o'er seas we
flew,
And halted on a boundless plain;
Where nothing fed, nor breathed, nor
grew,
But silence ruled the still domain.

Upon that boundless plain, below,
The setting sun's last rays were
shed,
And gave a mild and sober glow,
Where all were still, asleep, or
dead;

200

Vast ruins in the midst were spread,
Pillars and pediments sublime,
Where the grey moss had form'd a
bed,
And clothed the crumbling spoils
of time.

There was I fix'd, I know not how,
Condemn'd for untold years to
stay:

Yet years were not;—one dreadful
now

Endured no change of night or day;
The same mild evening's sleeping ray
Shone softly-solemn and serene,

210

And all that time I gazed away,
The setting sun's sad rays were
seen.

At length a moment's sleep stole on—
Again came my commission'd
foes;

Again through sea and land we're
gone,

No peace, no respite, no repose:
Above the dark broad sea we rose,
We ran through bleak and frozen
land;

I had no strength their strength t'
oppose,
An infant in a giant's hand.

220

They placed me where those
streamers play,
Those nimble beams of brilliant
light;
It would the stoutest heart dismay,
To see, to feel, that dreadful sight:
So swift, so pure, so cold, so bright,
They pierced my frame with icy
wound,
And, all that half-year's polar night,
Those dancing streamers wrapp'd
me round.

Slowly that darkness pass'd away,
When down upon the earth I
fell;—

230

Some hurried sleep was mine by day;
But, soon as toll'd the evening bell,
They forced me on, where ever dwell
Far-distant men in cities fair,
Cities of whom no trav'lers tell,
Nor feet but mine were wanderers
there.

Their watchmen stare, and stand
aghast,
As on we hurry through the dark;
The watch-light blinks as we go past,
The watch-dog shrinks and fears to
bark;

240

The watch-tower's bell sounds shrill;
and, hark!
The free wind blows—we've left
the town—
A wide sepulchral ground I mark,
And on a tombstone place me
down.

What monuments of mighty dead!
What tombs of various kinds are
found!
And stones erect their shadows shed
On humble graves, with wickers
bound;
Some risen fresh, above the ground,
Some level with the native clay,
250
What sleeping millions wait the
sound,
"Arise, ye dead, and come away!"

Alas! they stay not for that call;
Spare me this wo! ye demons,
spare!—
They come! the shrouded shadows
all—
'Tis more than mortal brain can
bear;
Rustling they rise, they sternly glare
At man, upheld by vital breath;
Who, led by wicked fiends, should
dare
To join the shadowy troops of
death!

260
Yes, I have felt all man can feel,

Till he shall pay his nature's debt:
Ills that no hope has strength to heal,
No mind the comfort to forget:
Whatever cares the heart can fret,
The spirits wear, the temper gall,
Wo, want, dread, anguish, all beset
My sinful soul!—together all!

Those fiends upon a shaking fen
Fix'd me, in dark tempestuous
night;

270

There never trod the foot of men;
There flock'd the fowl in wint'ry
flight;
There danced the moor's deceitful
light
Above the pool where sedges
grow;
And, when the morning-sun shone
bright,
It shone upon a field of snow.

They hung me on a bough so small.
The rook could build her nest no
higher;
They fix'd me on the trembling ball
That crowns the steeple's quiv'ring
spire;

280

They set me where the seas retire,
But drown with their returning
tide;
And made me flee the mountain's
fire,
When rolling from its burning side.

I've hung upon the ridgy steep
Of cliffs, and held the rambling
brier;
I've plunged below the billowy deep,
Where air was sent me to respire;
I've been where hungry wolves retire;
And (to complete my woes) I've
ran

290

Where Bedlam's crazy crew conspire
Against the life of reasoning man.

I've furl'd in storms the flapping sail,
By hanging from the topmast-head;
I've served the vilest slaves in jail,
And pick'd the dunghill's spoil for
bread;
I've made the badger's hole my bed,
I've wander'd with a gipsy crew;
I've dreaded all the guilty dread,
And done what they would fear to
do.

300

On sand, where ebbs and flows the
flood,
Midway they placed and bade me
die;
Propp'd on my staff, I stoutly stood,
When the swift waves came rolling
by;
And high they rose, and still more
high,
Till my lips drank the bitter brine;
I sobb'd convulsed, then cast mine
eye,
And saw the tide's re-flowing sign.

And then, my dreams were such as
nought

Could yield but my unhappy case;
310

I've been of thousand devils caught,
And thrust into that horrid place,
Where reign dismay, despair,
disgrace;

Furies with iron fangs were there,
To torture that accursed race,
Doomed to dismay, disgrace,
despair.

Harmless I was, yet hunted down
For treasons, to my soul unfit;
I've been pursued through many a
town,
For crimes that petty knaves
commit;

320
I've been adjudged t' have lost my
wit,
Because I preach'd so loud and
well;
And thrown into the dungeon's pit,
For trampling on the pit of hell.

Such were the evils, man of sin.
That I was fated to sustain;
And add to all, without—within,
A soul defiled with every stain
That man's reflecting mind can pain;
That pride, wrong, rage, despair,
can make;

330
In fact, they'd nearly touch'd my
brain,

And reason on her throne would
shake.

But pity will the vilest seek,
If punish'd guilt will not repine;—
I heard a heavenly teacher speak,
And felt the SUN OF MERCY shine:
I hail'd the light! the birth divine!
And then was seal'd among the
few;
Those angry fiends beheld the sign,
And from me in an instant flew.

340

Come, hear how thus the charmers
cry
To wandering sheep, the strays of
sin,
While some the wicket-gate pass by,
And some will knock and enter in:
Full joyful 'tis a soul to win,
For he that winneth souls is wise;
Now, hark! the holy strains begin,
And thus the sainted preacher
cries^[29]:—

"Pilgrim, burthen'd with thy sin,
Come the way to Zion's gate,

350

There, till Mercy let thee in,
Knock and weep, and watch and
wait.
Knock!—He knows the
sinner's cry;
Weep!—He loves the
mourner's tears;

Watch!—for saving grace is
nigh;
Wait!—till heavenly light
appears.

"Hark! it is the Bridegroom's
voice;
Welcome, pilgrim, to thy rest;
Now within the gate rejoice,
Safe and seal'd, and bought and
bless'd!

360

Safe—from all the lures of
vice;
Seal'd—by signs the chosen
know;
Bought—by love and life the
price;
Bless'd—the mighty debt to
owe.

"Holy Pilgrim! what for thee
In a world like this remain?
From thy guarded breast shall
flee
Fear and shame, and doubt and
pain.

Fear—the hope of Heaven
shall fly;
Shame—from glory's view
retire;

370

Doubt—in certain rapture die;
Pain—in endless bliss expire."

But though my day of grace was
come,

Yet still my days of grief I find;
The former clouds' collected gloom
Still sadden the reflecting mind;
The soul, to evil things consign'd.
Will of their evil some retain;
The man will seem to earth inclined,
And will not look erect again.

380

Thus, though elect, I feel it hard
To lose what I possess'd before,
To be from all my wealth debarr'd:—
The brave Sir Eustace is no more.
But old I wax and passing poor,
Stern, rugged men my conduct
view;
They chide my wish, they bar my
door,
'Tis hard—I weep—you see I do.—

Must you, my friends, no longer stay?
Thus quickly all my pleasures end;

390

But I'll remember, when I pray,
My kind physician and his friend;
And those sad hours you deign to
spend
With me, I shall requite them all;
Sir Eustace for his friends shall send,
And thank their love at Greyling
Hall.

VISITOR.

The poor Sir Eustace!—Yet his hope
Leads him to think of joys again;
And when his earthly visions droop,

His views of heavenly kind
remain.—

400

But whence that meek and humbled
strain,
That spirit wounded, lost, resign'd?
Would not so proud a soul disdain
The madness of the poorest mind?

PHYSICIAN.

No! for the more he swell'd with
pride,
The more he felt misfortune's
blow;
Disgrace and grief he could not hide,
And poverty had laid him low:
Thus shame and sorrow working
slow,
At length this humble spirit gave;

410

Madness on these began to grow,
And bound him to his fiends a
slave.

Though the wild thoughts had touch'd
his brain,
Then was he free.—So, forth he
ran;
To soothe or threat, alike were vain:
He spake of fiends; look'd wild and
wan;
Year after year, the hurried man
Obey'd those fiends from place to
place;
Till his religious change began
To form a frenzied child of grace.

420

For, as the fury lost its strength,
The mind reposed; by slow degrees
Came lingering hope, and brought at
length,

To the tormented spirit ease:
This slave of sin, whom fiends could
seize,

Felt or believed their power had
end;—

"'Tis faith," he cried, "my bosom
frees,

And now my SAVIOUR is my
friend."

But ah! though time can yield relief,
And soften woes it cannot cure,

430

Would we not suffer pain and grief,
To have our reason sound and
sure?

Then let us keep our bosoms pure,
Our fancy's favourite flights
suppress;

Prepare the body to endure,
And bend the mind to meet
distress;

And then HIS guardian care implore,
Whom demons dread and men adore.

NOTES TO SIR EUSTACE GREY.

[27] Note 1, p. 243, line 161.

To whom the Watcher cried aloud.

Prophecy of Daniel, chap. iv. 22 [and 23].

[28] Note 2, page 243, line 188.

Then those ill-favour'd Ones, &c.

Vide Bunyan's Pilgrim's Progress [Part II.].

[29] Note 3, page 248, line 347.

And thus the sainted preacher cries.

It has been suggested to me, that this change from restlessness to repose, in the mind of Sir Eustace, is wrought by a methodistic call; and it is admitted to be such: a sober and rational conversion could not have happened while the disorder of the brain continued. Yet the verses which follow, in a different measure, are not intended to make any religious persuasion appear ridiculous; they are to be supposed as the effect of memory in the disordered mind of the speaker, and, though evidently enthusiastic in respect to language, are not meant to convey any impropriety of sentiment.

THE HALL OF JUSTICE.

IN TWO PARTS.

PART I.

Confiteor facere hoc annos; sed et altera
causa est,

Anxietas animi, continuusque dolor.

Ovid [Epp. ex
Ponto
Lib. I.
Ep. iv.
vv. 7-8].

MAGISTRATE, VAGRANT, CONSTABLE, &c.

VAGRANT.

Take, take away thy barbarous hand,
And let me to thy master speak;
Remit awhile the harsh command,

And hear me, or my heart will
break.

MAGISTRATE.

Fond wretch! and what canst thou
relate,
But deeds of sorrow, shame, and
sin?
Thy crime is proved, thou know'st thy
fate;
But come, thy tale!—begin, begin!

VAGRANT.

My crime!—This sick'ning child to
feed,
10
I seized the food your witness saw;
I knew your laws forbade the deed,
But yielded to a stronger law.
Know'st thou, to Nature's great
command
All human laws are frail and weak?
Nay! frown not—stay his eager hand,
And hear me, or my heart will
break.

In this, th' adopted babe I hold
With anxious fondness to my
breast,
My heart's sole comfort I behold,
20
More dear than life, when life was
bless'd;
I saw her pining, fainting, cold,
I begg'd—but vain was my request.

I saw the tempting food, and seized—
My infant-sufferer found relief;
And, in the pilfer'd treasure pleased,
Smiled on my guilt, and hush'd my
grief.

But I have griefs of other kind,
Troubles and sorrows more severe;
Give me to ease my tortured mind,
30

Lend to my woes a patient ear;
And let me—if I may not find
A friend to help—find one to hear.

Yet nameless let me plead—my name
Would only wake the cry of scorn;
A child of sin, conceived in shame,
Brought forth in wo, to misery
born.

My mother dead, my father lost,
I wander'd with a vagrant crew;
A common care, a common cost,
40

Their sorrows and their sins I
knew;
With them, by want on error forced,
Like them, I base and guilty grew.

Few are my years, not so my crimes;
The age, which these sad looks
declare,
Is Sorrow's work, it is not Time's,
And I am old in shame and care.

Taught to believe the world a place
Where every stranger was a foe,
Train'd in the arts that mark our race,

50

To what new people could I go?
Could I a better life embrace,
Or live as virtue dictates? No!—

So through the land I wandering
went,
And little found of grief or joy;
But lost my bosom's sweet content
When first I loved—the Gipsy-
Boy.

A sturdy youth he was and tall,
His looks would all his soul
declare;
His piercing eyes were deep and
small,

60

And strongly curl'd his raven-hair.

Yes, Aaron had each manly charm,
All in the May of youthful pride;
He scarcely fear'd his father's arm,
And every other arm defied.—
Oft, when they grew in anger warm,
(Whom will not love and power
divide?)
I rose, their wrathful souls to calm,
Not yet in sinful combat tried.

His father was our party's chief,

70

And dark and dreadful was his
look;
His presence fill'd my heart with
grief;
Although to me he kindly spoke.

With Aaron I delighted went,
His favour was my bliss and pride;
In growing hope our days we spent,
Love growing charms in either
spied;
It saw them, all which Nature lent,
It lent them all which she denied.

Could I the father's kindness prize,
80
Or grateful looks on him bestow,
Whom I beheld in wrath arise,
When Aaron sunk beneath his
blow?

He drove him down with wicked
hand,—
It was a dreadful sight to see;
Then vex'd him, till he left the land,
And told his cruel love to me;—
The clan were all at his command,
Whatever his command might be.

The night was dark, the lanes were
deep,
90

And one by one they took their
way;
He bade me lay me down and sleep,
I only wept and wish'd for day.

Accursèd be the love he bore.
Accursèd was the force he used;
So let him of his God implore
For mercy, and be so refused!

You frown again;—to show my
wrong,

Can I in gentle language speak?
My woes are deep, my words are
strong;—

100

And hear me, or my heart will
break.

MAGISTRATE.

I hear thy words, I feel thy pain;
Forbear awhile to speak thy woes;
Receive our aid, and then again
The story of thy life disclose.
For, though seduced and led astray,
Thou'st travell'd far and wander'd
long;
Thy God hath seen thee all the way,
And all the turns that led thee
wrong.

PART II.

Quondam ridentes oculi, nunc fonte
perenni
Deplorant pœnas nocte dieque suas.

Corn. Galli
[Maximi
niani
(Pseudo-
Galli)]
Eleg. [I.
vv. 137-
8.]

MAGISTRATE.

Come, now again thy woes impart,
Tell all thy sorrows, all thy sin;
We cannot heal the throbbing heart
Till we discern the wounds within.

Compunction weeps our guilt away,
The sinner's safety is his pain;
Such pangs for our offences pay,
And these severer griefs are gain.

VAGRANT.

The son came back—he found us
wed;

10

Then dreadful was the oath he
swore;—
His way through Blackburn Forest
led;—
His father we beheld no more.

Of all our daring clan not one
Would on the doubtful subject
dwell;
For all esteem'd the injured son,
And fear'd the tale which he could
tell.

But I had mightier cause for fear;
For slow and mournful round my
bed

I saw a dreadful form appear—

20

It came when I and Aaron wed.

(Yes! we were wed, I know my
crime,—

We slept beneath the [elmen] tree;
But I was grieving all the time,

And Aaron frown'd my tears to see.

For he not yet had felt the pain
That rankles in a wounded breast;
He waked to sin, then slept again,
Forsook his God, yet took his
rest.—

But I was forced to feign delight,

30

And joy in mirth and music sought;
And mem'ry now recalls the night,
With such surprise and horror
fraught,
That reason felt a moment's flight,
And left a mind to madness
wrought.)

When waking, on my heaving breast
I felt a hand as cold as death;
A sudden fear my voice suppress'd,
A chilling terror stopp'd my
breath.—

I seem'd—no words can utter how!

40

For there my father-husband stood

—

And thus he said:—"Will God allow,
"The great avenger, just and good,
A wife to break her marriage vow,
A son to shed his father's blood?"

I trembled at the dismal sounds,
But vainly strove a word to say;
So, pointing to his bleeding wounds,
The threat'ning spectre stalk'd
away^[30].

I brought a lovely daughter forth,
50

His father's child, in Aaron's bed;
He took her from me in his wrath;—
"Where is my child?"—"Thy child
is dead."

'Twas false—we wander'd far and
wide,
Through town and country, field
and fen,
Till Aaron, fighting, fell and died,
And I became a wife again.

I then was young:—my husband sold
My fancied charms for wicked
price;
He gave me oft, for sinful gold,
60

The slave, but not the friend, of
vice—
Behold me, Heaven! my pains
behold,
And let them for my sins suffice!

The wretch, who lent me thus for
gain,
Despised me when my youth was
fled;
Then came disease, and brought me
pain—
Come, death, and bear me to the
dead!
For, though I grieve, my grief is vain,
And fruitless all the tears I shed.

True, I was not to virtue train'd;
70

Yet well I knew my deeds were ill;
By each offence my heart was
pain'd—

I wept, but I offended still;
My better thoughts my life disdain'd,
But yet the viler led my will.

My husband died, and now no more
My smile was sought, or ask'd my
hand—

A widow'd vagrant, vile and poor,
Beneath a vagrant's vile command.

Ceaseless I roved the country round,
80

To win my bread by fraudulent arts,
And long a poor subsistence found,
By spreading nets for simple
hearts.

Though poor, and abject, and
despised,

Their fortunes to the crowd I told;
I gave the young the love they prized,
And promised wealth to bless the
old;

Schemes for the doubtful I devised,
And charms for the forsaken sold.

At length for arts like these confined
90

In prison with a lawless crew,
I soon perceived a kindred mind,
And there my long-lost daughter
knew:

His father's child, whom Aaron gave
To wander with a distant clan,

The miseries of the world to brave,
And be the slave of vice and man.

She knew my name—we met in pain;
Our parting pangs can I express?
She sail'd a convict o'er the main,
100
And left an heir to her distress.

This is that heir to shame and pain,
For whom I only could descry
A world of trouble and disdain—
Yet, could I bear to see her die,
Or stretch her feeble hand in vain,
And, weeping, beg of me supply?

No! though the fate thy mother knew
Was shameful! shameful though
thy race
Have wander'd all, a lawless crew,
110
Outcasts, despised in every place:

Yet, as the dark and muddy tide,
When far from its polluted source,
Becomes more pure, and, purified,
Flows in a clear and happy
course—
In thee, dear infant! so may end
Our shame, in thee our sorrows
cease!

And thy pure course will then extend,
In floods of joy, o'er vales of peace.
Oh! by the God who loves to spare,
120

Deny me not the boon I crave;
Let this loved child your mercy share,
And let me find a peaceful grave;

Make her yet spotless soul your care,
And let my sins their portion have;
Her for a better fate prepare,
And punish whom 'twere sin to
save!

MAGISTRATE.

Recall the word, renounce the
thought,
Command thy heart and bend thy
knee.

There is to all a pardon brought,

130

A ransom rich, assured and free;
'Tis full when found, 'tis found if
sought,
Oh! seek it, till 'tis seal'd to thee.

VAGRANT.

But how my pardon shall I know?

MAGISTRATE.

By feeling dread that 'tis not sent;
By tears, for sin that freely flow;
By grief, that all thy tears are
spent;

By thoughts on that great debt we
owe,

With all the mercy God has lent;
By suffering what thou canst not
show,

140

Yet showing how thine heart is
rent:

Till thou canst feel thy bosom glow,

And say, "MY SAVIOUR, I REPENT!"

FOOTNOTES:

^[30] The state of mind here described will account for a vision of this nature, without having recourse to any supernatural appearance.

WOMAN!

MR. LEDYARD, AS QUOTED BY M. PARKE IN HIS TRAVELS INTO AFRIC:

a Woman I never addressed myself in the language of decency and friendship, without receiving a decent and friendly answer. If I was hungry or thirsty, wet or sick, they did not hesitate, like Men, to perform a generous action: in so free and kind a manner did they contribute to my relief, that if I was dry, I drank the sweetest draught; and if hungry, I ate the coarsest morsel with a double relish."

Place the white man on Afric's coast,
Whose swarthy sons in blood
delight,
Who of their scorn to Europe boast,
And paint their very demons white:
There, while the sterner sex disdains
To soothe the woes they cannot
feel,
Woman will strive to heal his pains,
And weep for those she cannot
heal.
Hers is warm pity's sacred glow;
10
From all her stores she bears a part,
And bids the spring of hope re-flow,
That languish'd in the fainting
heart.

"What, though so pale his haggard
face,

So sunk and sad his looks,"—she
cries—
"And far unlike our nobler race,
With crisped locks and rolling
eyes:
Yet misery marks him of our kind;
We see him lost, alone, afraid;
And pangs of body, griefs in mind,
20
Pronounce him man, and ask our
aid.

"Perhaps, in some far-distant shore,
There are who in these forms
delight;
Whose milky features please them
more,
Than ours of jet thus burnish'd
bright.
Of such may be his weeping wife,
Such children for their sire may
call;
And, if we spare his ebbing life,
Our kindness may preserve them
all."

Thus her compassion woman shows,
30
Beneath the line her acts are these;
Nor the wide waste of Lapland-snows
Can her warm flow of pity
freeze:—
"From some sad land the stranger
comes,
Where joys, like ours, are never
found;
Let's soothe him in our happy homes,

Where freedom sits, with plenty
crown'd.

"'Tis good the fainting soul to cheer,
To see the famish'd stranger fed;
To milk for him the mother-deer,
40

To smooth for him the furry bed.
The powers above our Lapland bless
With good no other people know,
T' enlarge the joys that we possess,
By feeling those that we bestow!"

Thus, in extremes of cold and heat,
Where wandering man may trace
his kind;
Wherever grief and want retreat,
In Woman they compassion find;
She makes the female breast her seat,
50

And dictates mercy to the mind.

Man may the sterner virtues know,
Determined justice, truth severe;
But female hearts with pity glow,
And Woman holds affliction dear.
For guiltless woes her sorrows flow,
And suffering vice compels her
tear;

'Tis hers to soothe the ills below,
And bid life's fairer views appear.
To Woman's gentle kind we owe
60

What comforts and delights us
here;
They its gay hopes on youth bestow,

And care they soothe, and age they
cheer.

THE BOROUGH.

Paulo majora canamus.—VIRGIL. [*Ecl.* IV. v. 1.]

TO
HIS GRACE

THE DUKE OF RUTLAND,

MARQUIS OF GRANBY;

RECORDER OF CAMBRIDGE AND SCARBOROUGH;
LORD-LIEUTENANT AND CUSTOS-ROTULORUM OF THE
COUNTY OF LEICESTER; K.G. & LL.D.

MY LORD,

The poem, for which I have ventured to solicit your Grace's attention, was composed in a situation so near to Belvoir Castle, that the author had all the advantage to be derived from prospects extensive and beautiful, and from works of grandeur and sublimity: and, though nothing of the influence arising from such situation should be discernible in these verses, either from want of adequate powers in the writer, or because his subjects do not assimilate with such views, yet would it be natural for him to indulge a wish, that he might inscribe his labours to the lord of a scene which perpetually excited his admiration, and he would plead the propriety of placing the titles of the House of Rutland at the entrance of a volume written in the Vale of Belvoir.

But, my Lord, a motive much more powerful than a sense of propriety, a grateful remembrance of benefits conferred by the noble family in which you preside, has been the great inducement for me to wish that I might be permitted to inscribe this work to your Grace. The honours of that time were to me unexpected, they were unmerited, and they were transitory; but

since I am thus allowed to make public my gratitude, I am in some degree restored to the honour of that period; I have again the happiness to find myself favoured, and my exertions stimulated, by the condescension of the Duke of Rutland.

It was my fortune, in a poem which yet circulates, to write of the virtues, talents, and heroic death of Lord Robert Manners, and to bear witness to the affection of a brother whose grief was poignant, and to be soothed only by remembrance of his worth whom he so deeply deplored. In a patron thus favourably predisposed, my Lord, I might look for much lenity, and could not fear the severity of critical examination: from your Grace, who, happily, have no such impediment to justice, I must not look for the same kind of indulgence. I am assured, by those whose situation gave them opportunity for knowledge, and whose abilities and attention guarded them from error, that I must not expect my failings will escape detection from want of discernment, neither am I to fear that any merit will be undistinguished through deficiency of taste. It is from this information, my Lord, and a consciousness of much which needs forgiveness, that I entreat your Grace to read my verses, with a wish, I had almost added, with a purpose, to be pleased, and to make every possible allowance for subjects not always pleasing, for manners sometimes gross, and for language too frequently incorrect.

With the fullest confidence in your Grace's ability and favour, in the accuracy of your judgment, and the lenity of your decision; with grateful remembrance of benefits received, and due consciousness of the little I could merit; with prayers that your Grace may long enjoy the dignities of the House of Rutland, and continue to dictate improvement for the surrounding country—I terminate an address, in which a fear of offending your Grace has made me so cautious in my expressions, that I may justly fear to offend many of my readers, who will think that something more of animation should have been excited by the objects I view, the benevolence I honour, and the gratitude I profess.

I have the honour to be,

My Lord,

Your Grace's

Most obliged
and obedient humble servant,
GEORGE CRABBE.

PREFACE.

WHETHER, if I had not been encouraged by some proofs of public favour, I should have written the Poem now before the reader, is a question which I cannot positively determine; but I will venture to assert, that I should not, in that case, have committed the work to the press; I should not have allowed my own opinion of it to have led me into further disappointment, against the voice of judges impartial and indifferent, from whose sentence it had been fruitless to appeal. The success of a late publication, therefore, may be fairly assigned as the principal cause for the appearance of this.

When the ensuing Letters were so far written, that I could form an opinion of them, and when I began to conceive that they might not be unacceptable to the public, I felt myself prompted by duty, as well as interest, to put them to the press; I considered myself bound by gratitude for the favourable treatment I had already received, to show that I was not unmindful of it; and, however this might be mixed with other motives, it operated with considerable force upon my mind, acting as a stimulus to exertions naturally tardy, and to expectations easily checked.

It must nevertheless be acknowledged that, although such favourable opinion had been formed, I was not able, with the requisite impartiality, to determine the comparative value of an unpublished manuscript, and a work sent into the world. Books, like children, when established, have doubtless our parental affection and good wishes; we rejoice to hear that they are doing well, and are received and respected in good company: but it is to manuscripts in the study, as to children in the nursery, that our care, our anxiety, and our tenderness are principally directed: they are fondled as our endearing companions, their faults are corrected with the lenity of partial love, and their good parts are exaggerated by the strength of parental

imagination; nor is it easy even for the more cool and reasonable among parents, thus circumstanced, to decide upon the comparative merits of their offspring, whether they be children of the bed or issue of the brain.

But, however favourable my own opinion may have been, or may still be, I could not venture to commit so long a Poem to the press without some endeavour to obtain the more valuable opinion of less partial judges. At the same time, I am willing to confess that I have lost some portion of the timidity once so painful, and that I am encouraged to take upon myself the decision of various points, which heretofore I entreated my friends to decide. Those friends were then my council, whose opinion I was implicitly to follow; they are now advisers, whose ideas I am at liberty to reject. This will not, I hope, seem like arrogance: it would be more safe, it would be more pleasant, still to have that reliance on the judgment of others; but it cannot always be obtained; nor are they, however friendly disposed, ever ready to lend a helping hand to him whom they consider as one who ought by this time to have cast away the timidity of inexperience, and to have acquired the courage that would enable him to decide for himself.

When it is confessed that I have less assistance from my friends, and that the appearance of this work is, in a great measure, occasioned by the success of a former, some readers will, I fear, entertain the opinion that the book before them was written in haste, and published without due examination and revisal. Should this opinion be formed, there will doubtless occur many faults which may appear as originating in neglect. Now, readers are, I believe, disposed to treat with more than common severity those writers who have been led into presumption by the approbation bestowed on their diffidence, and into idleness and unconcern, by the praises given to their attention. I am therefore even anxious it should be generally known that sufficient time and application were bestowed upon this work, and by this I mean that no material alteration would be effected by delay; it is true that this confession removes one plea for the errors of the book—want of time, but, in my opinion, there is not much consolation to be drawn by reasonable minds from this resource: if a work fails, it appears to be poor satisfaction when it is observed, that if the author had taken more care, the event had been less disgraceful.

When the reader enters into the Poem, he will find the author retired from view, and an imaginary personage brought forward to describe his Borough for him. To him it seemed convenient to speak in the first person; but the inhabitant of a village, in the centre of the kingdom, could not appear in the character of a residing burgess in a large sea-port; and when, with this point, was considered what relations were to be given, what manners delineated, and what situations described, no method appeared to be so convenient as that of borrowing the assistance of an ideal friend. By this means the reader is in some degree kept from view of any particular place; nor will he perhaps be so likely to determine where those persons reside, and what their connexions, who are so intimately known to this man of straw.

From the title of this Poem, some persons will, I fear, expect a political satire,—an attack upon corrupt principles in a general view, or upon the customs and manners of some particular place; of these they will find nothing satirized, nothing related. It may be that graver readers would have preferred a more historical account of so considerable a Borough—its charter, privileges, trade, public structures, and subjects of this kind; but I have an apology for the omission of these things, in the difficulty of describing them, and in the utter repugnancy which subsists between the studies and objects of topography and poetry. What I thought I could best describe, that I attempted:—the sea, and the country in the immediate vicinity; the dwellings, and the inhabitants; some incidents and characters, with an exhibition of morals and manners, offensive perhaps to those of extremely delicate feelings, but sometimes, I hope, neither unamiable nor unaffecting. An Election indeed forms a part of one Letter, but the evil there described is one not greatly nor generally deplored, and there are probably many places of this kind where it is not felt.

From the variety of relations, characters, and descriptions which a BOROUGH affords, several were rejected which a reader might reasonably expect to have met with: in this case he is entreated to believe that these, if they occurred to the author, were considered by him as beyond his ability, as subjects which he could not treat in a manner satisfactory to himself. Possibly the admission of some will be thought to require more apology than the rejection of others. In such variety, it is to be apprehended, that almost every reader will find something not according with his ideas of

propriety, or something repulsive to the tone of his feelings; nor could this be avoided but by the sacrifice of every event, opinion, and even expression, which could be thought liable to produce such effect; and this casting away so largely of our cargo, through fears of danger, though it might help us to clear it, would render our vessel of little worth when she came into port. I may likewise entertain a hope, that this very variety, which gives scope to objection and censure, will also afford a better chance for approval and satisfaction.

Of these objectionable parts many must be to me unknown; of others some opinion may be formed, and for their admission some plea may be stated.

In the first Letter is nothing which particularly calls for remark, except possibly the last line—giving a promise to the reader that he should both smile and sigh in the perusal of the following Letters. This may appear vain, and more than an author ought to promise; but let it be considered that the character assumed is that of a friend, who gives an account of objects, persons, and events to his correspondent, and who was therefore at liberty, without any imputation of this kind, to suppose in what manner he would be affected by such descriptions.

Nothing, I trust, in the second Letter, which relates to the imitation of what are called weather-stains on buildings, will seem to any invidious or offensive. I wished to make a comparison between those minute and curious bodies which cover the surface of some edifices, and those kinds of stain which are formed of boles and ochres, and laid on with a brush. Now, as the work of time cannot be anticipated in such cases, it may be very judicious to have recourse to such expedients as will give to a recent structure the venerable appearance of antiquity; and in this case, though I might still observe the vast difference between the living varieties of nature, and the distant imitation of the artist, yet I would not forbear to make use of his dexterity, because he could not clothe my freestone with *mucor*, *lichen*, and *byssus*.

The wants and mortifications of a poor Clergyman are the subjects of one portion of the third Letter; and, he being represented as a stranger in the Borough, it may be necessary to make some apology for his appearance in

the Poem. Previous to a late meeting of a literary society, whose benevolent purpose is well known to the public, I was induced by a friend to compose a few verses, in which, with the general commendation of the design, should be introduced a hint that the bounty might be farther extended; these verses a gentleman did me the honour to recite at the meeting, and they were printed as an extract from the Poem, to which in fact they may be called an appendage.

I am now arrived at that part of my work, which I may expect will bring upon me some animadversion. Religion is a subject deeply interesting to the minds of many; and, when these minds are weak, they are often led by a warmth of feeling into the violence of causeless resentment. I am therefore anxious that my purpose should be understood; and I wish to point out what things they are which an author may hold up to ridicule and be blameless. In referring to the two principal divisions of enthusiastical teachers, I have denominated them, as I conceive they are generally called, *Calvinistic* and *Arminian* Methodists. The *Arminians*, though divided and perhaps subdivided, are still, when particular accuracy is not intended, considered as one body, having had, for many years, one head, who is yet held in high respect by the varying members of the present day. But the Calvinistic societies are to be looked upon rather as separate and independent congregations; and it is to one of these (unconnected, as is supposed, with any other) I more particularly allude. But while I am making use of this division, I must entreat that I may not be considered as one who takes upon him to censure the religious opinions of any society or individual: the reader will find that the spirit of the enthusiast, and not his opinions, his manners, and not his creed, have engaged my attention. I have nothing to observe of the Calvinist and Arminian, considered as such; but my remarks are pointed at the enthusiast and the bigot, at their folly and their craft.

To those readers who have seen the journals of the first Methodists, or the extracts quoted from them by their opposers^[31] in the early times of this spiritual influenza, are sufficiently known all their leading notions and peculiarities; so that I have no need to enter into such unpleasant inquiries in this place. I have only to observe that their tenets remain the same, and have still the former effect on the minds of the converted. There is yet that imagined contention with the powers of darkness, that is at once so lamentable and so ludicrous; there is the same offensive familiarity with the

Deity, with a full trust and confidence both in the immediate efficacy of their miserably delivered supplications, and in the reality of numberless small miracles wrought at their request and for their convenience; there still exists that delusion, by which some of the most common diseases of the body are regarded as proofs of the malignity of Satan contending for dominion over the soul; and there still remains the same wretched jargon, composed of scriptural language, debased by vulgar expressions, which has a kind of mystic influence on the minds of the ignorant. It will be recollected that it is the abuse of those scriptural terms which I conceive to be improper: they are doubtless most significant and efficacious when used with propriety; but it is painful to the mind of a soberly devout person, when he hears every rise and fall of the animal spirits, every whim and notion of enthusiastic ignorance, expressed in the venerable language of the Apostles and Evangelists.

The success of these people is great, but not surprising: as the powers they claim are given, and come not of education, many may, and therefore do, fancy they are endowed with them; so that they who do not venture to become preachers, yet exert the minor gifts, and gain reputation for the faculty of prayer, as soon as they can address the Creator in daring flights of unpremeditated absurdity. The less indigent gain the praise of hospitality, and the more harmonious become distinguished in their choirs; curiosity is kept alive by succession of ministers, and self-love is flattered by the consideration that they are the persons at whom the world wonders; add to this, that, in many of them, pride is gratified by their consequence as new members of a sect whom their conversion pleases, and by the liberty, which as seceders they take, of speaking contemptuously of the Church and ministers, whom they have relinquished.

Of those denominated *Calvinistic Methodists* I had principally one sect in view, or, to adopt the term of its founder, *a church*. This *church* consists of several congregations in town and country, unknown perhaps in many parts of the kingdom, but, where known, the cause of much curiosity and some amusement. To such of my readers as may judge an enthusiastic teacher and his peculiarities to be unworthy any serious attention, I would observe that there is something unusually daring in the boast of this man, who claims the authority of a messenger sent from God, and declares without hesitation that his call was immediate; that he is assisted by the sensible influence of

the Spirit, and that miracles are perpetually wrought in his favour and for his convenience.

As it was and continues to be my desire to give proof that I had advanced nothing respecting this extraordinary person, his operations or assertions, which might not be readily justified by quotations from his own writings, I had collected several of these and disposed them under certain heads. But I found that by this means a very disproportioned share of attention must be given to the subject, and after some consideration, I have determined to relinquish the design; and, should any have curiosity to search whether my representation of the temper and disposition, the spirit and manners, the knowledge and capacity, of a very popular teacher be correct, he is referred to about fourscore pamphlets, whose titles will be found on the covers of the late editions of the *Bank of Faith*, itself a wonderful performance, which (according to the turn of mind in the reader) will either highly excite, or totally extinguish, curiosity. In these works will be abundantly seen, abuse and contempt of the Church of England and its ministers; vengeance and virulent denunciation against all offenders; scorn for morality and heathen virtue, with that kind of learning which the author possesses, and his peculiar style of composition. A few of the titles placed below will give some information to the reader respecting the merit and design of those performances^[32].

As many of the preacher's subjects are controverted and nice questions in divinity, he has sometimes allowed himself relaxation from the severity of study, and favoured his admirers with the effects of an humbler kind of inspiration, viz. that of the Muse. It must be confessed that these flights of fancy are very humble, and have nothing of that daring and mysterious nature which the prose of the author leads us to expect. *The Dimensions of eternal LOVE* is a title of one of his more learned productions, with which might have been expected (as a fit companion) *The Bounds of infinite Grace*; but no such work appears, and possibly the author considered one attempt of this kind was sufficient to prove the extent and direction of his abilities.

Of the whole of this mass of inquiry and decision, of denunciation and instruction (could we suppose it read by intelligent persons), different opinions would probably be formed; the more indignant and severe would

condemn the whole as the produce of craft and hypocrisy, while the more lenient would allow that such things might originate in the wandering imagination of a dreaming enthusiast.

None of my readers will, I trust, do me so much injustice as to suppose I have here any other motive than a vindication of what I have advanced in the verses which describe this kind of character, or that I had there any other purpose than to express (what I conceive to be) justifiable indignation against the assurance, the malignity, and (what is of more importance) the pernicious influence of such sentiments on the minds of the simple and ignorant, who, if they give credit to his relations, must be no more than tools and instruments under the control and management of one *called to be their Apostle*.

Nothing would be more easy for me, as I have observed, than to bring forward quotations such as would justify all I have advanced; but, even had I room, I cannot tell whether there be not something degrading in such kind of attack: the reader might smile at those miraculous accounts, but he would consider them and the language of the author as beneath his further attention: I therefore once more refer him to those pamphlets, which will afford matter for pity and for contempt by which some would be amused and others astonished—not without sorrow, when they reflect that thousands look up to the writer as a man literally inspired, to whose wants they administer with their substance, and to whose guidance they prostrate their spirit and understanding.

Having been so long detained by this Letter, I must not permit my desire of elucidating what may seem obscure, or of defending what is liable to misconstruction, any further to prevail over a wish for brevity, and the fear of giving an air of importance to subjects which have perhaps little in themselves.

The circumstance recorded in the fifth Letter is a fact; although it may appear to many almost incredible, that, in this country, and but few years since, a close and successful man should be a stranger to the method of increasing money by the loan of it. The Minister of the place where the honest Fisherman resided has related to me the apprehension and suspicion he witnessed. With trembling hand and dubious look, the careful man

received and surveyed the bond given to him; and, after a sigh or two of lingering mistrust, he placed it in the coffer whence he had just before taken his cash; for which, and for whose increase, he now indulged a belief that it was indeed both promise and security.

If the Letter which treats of Inns should be found to contain nothing interesting or uncommon; if it describe things which we behold every day, and some which we do not wish to behold at any time: let it be considered that this Letter is one of the shortest, and that from a Poem whose subject was a Borough, populous and wealthy, these places of public accommodation could not, without some impropriety, be excluded.

I entertain the strongest, because the most reasonable, hope that no liberal practitioner in the Law will be offended by the notice taken of dishonourable and crafty attorneys. The increased difficulty of entering into the profession will in time render it much more free than it now is from those who disgrace it; at present such persons remain, and it would not be difficult to give instances of neglect, ignorance, cruelty, oppression, and chicanery; nor are they by any means confined to one part of the country: quacks and impostors are indeed in every profession, as well with a licence as without one. The character and actions of *Swallow* might doubtless be contrasted by the delineation of an able and upright Solicitor; but this Letter is of sufficient length, and such persons, without question, are already known to my readers.

When I observe, under the article Physic, that the young and less experienced physician will write rather with a view of making himself known, than to investigate and publish some useful fact, I would not be thought to extend this remark to all the publications of such men. I could point out a work, containing experiments the most judicious, and conclusions the most interesting, made by a gentleman, then young, which would have given just celebrity to a man after long practice. The observation is nevertheless generally true: many opinions have been adopted and many books written, not that the theory might be well defended, but that a young physician might be better known.

If I have in one Letter praised the good-humour of a man confessedly too inattentive to business, and, in another, if I have written somewhat

sarcastically of "the brick-floored parlour which the butcher lets:" be credit given to me, that in the one case I had no intention to apologize for idleness, nor any design in the other to treat with contempt the resources of the poor. The good-humour is considered as the consolation of disappointment, and the room is so mentioned because the lodger is vain. Most of my readers will perceive this; but I shall be sorry if by any I am supposed to make pleas for the vices of men, or treat their wants and infirmities with derision or with disdain.

It is probable, that really polite people, with cultivated minds and harmonious tempers, may judge my description of a Card-club conversation to be highly exaggerated, if not totally fictitious; and I acknowledge that the club must admit a particular kind of members to afford such specimens of acrimony and objurgation. Yet, that such language is spoken, and such manners exhibited, is most certain, chiefly among those who, being successful in life, without previous education, not very nice in their feelings, or very attentive to improprieties, sit down to game with no other view than that of adding the gain of the evening to the profits of the day; whom therefore disappointment itself makes angry, and, when caused by another; resentful and vindictive.

The Letter on Itinerant Players will to some appear too harshly written, their profligacy exaggerated, and their distresses magnified; but, though the respectability of a part of these people may give us a more favourable view of the whole body, though some actors be sober, and some managers prudent: still there is vice and misery left, more than sufficient to justify my description. But, if I could find only one woman who (passing forty years on many stages, and sustaining many principal characters) laments in her unrespected old age, that there was no workhouse to which she could legally sue for admission; if I could produce only one female, seduced upon the boards, and starved in her lodging, compelled by her poverty to sing, and by her sufferings to weep, without any prospect but misery, or any consolation but death; if I could exhibit only one youth who sought refuge from parental authority in the licentious freedom of a wandering company: yet, with three such examples, I should feel myself justified in the account I have given.—But such characters and sufferings are common, and there are few of these societies which could not show members of this description. To some, indeed, the life has its satisfactions: they never expected to be free

from labour, and their present kind, they think, is light; they have no delicate ideas of shame, and therefore duns and hisses give them no other pain than what arises from the fear of not being trusted, joined with the apprehension that they may have nothing to subsist upon except their credit.

For the Alms-House itself, its Governors and Inhabitants, I have not much to offer, in favour of the subject or of the characters. One of these, *Sir Denys Brand*, may be considered as too highly placed for an author (who seldom ventures above middle-life) to delineate; and indeed I had some idea of reserving him for another occasion, where he might have appeared with those in his own rank; but then it is most uncertain whether he would ever appear, and he has been so many years prepared for the public whenever opportunity might offer, that I have at length given him place, and though with his inferiors, yet as a ruler over them. Of these, one (*Benbow*) may be thought too low and despicable to be admitted here; but he is a Borough-character, and, however disgusting in some respects a picture may be, it will please some, and be tolerated by many, if it can boast that one merit of being a faithful likeness.

Blaney and *Clelia*, a male and female inhabitant of this mansion, are drawn at some length; and I may be thought to have given them attention which they do not merit. I plead not for the originality, but for the truth, of the character; and, though it may not be very pleasing, it may be useful to delineate (for certain minds) these mixtures of levity and vice; people who are thus incurably vain and determinately worldly; thus devoted to enjoyment and insensible of shame, and so miserably fond of their pleasures, that they court even the remembrance with eager solicitation, by conjuring up the ghosts of departed indulgences with all the aid that memory can afford them. These characters demand some attention, because they hold out a warning to that numerous class of young people who are too lively to be discreet; to whom the purpose of life is amusement, and who are always in danger of falling into vicious habits, because they have too much activity to be quiet, and too little strength to be steady.

The characters of the Hospital-Directors were written many years since, and, so far as I was capable of judging, are drawn with *fidelity*. I mention this circumstance, that, if any reader should find a difference in the versification or expression, he will be thus enabled to account for it.

The Poor are here almost of necessity introduced, for they must be considered, in every place, as a large and interesting portion of its inhabitants. I am aware of the great difficulty of acquiring just notions on the maintenance and management of this class of our fellow-subjects, and I forbear to express any opinion of the various modes which have been discussed or adopted: of one method only I venture to give my sentiments, that of collecting the poor of a hundred into one building. This admission of a vast number of persons, of all ages and both sexes, of very different inclinations, habits, and capacities, into a society, must, at a first view, I conceive, be looked upon as a cause of both vice and misery; nor does anything which I have heard or read invalidate the opinion; happily, it is not a prevailing one, as these houses are, I believe, still confined to that part of the kingdom where they originated.

To this subject follow several Letters describing the follies, and crimes of persons in lower life, with one relation of a happier and more consolatory kind. It has been a subject of greater vexation to me than such trifle ought to be, that I could not, without destroying all appearance of arrangement, separate these melancholy narratives, and place the fallen Clerk in Office at a greater distance from the Clerk of the Parish, especially as they resembled each other in several particulars; both being tempted, seduced, and wretched. Yet are there, I conceive, considerable marks of distinction: their guilt is of different kind; nor would either have committed the offence of the other. The Clerk of the Parish could break the commandment, but he could not have been induced to have disowned an article of that creed for which he had so bravely contended, and on which he fully relied; and the upright mind of the Clerk in Office would have secured him from being guilty of wrong and robbery, though his weak and vacillating intellect could not preserve him from infidelity and profaneness. Their melancholy is nearly alike, but not its consequences. *Jachin* retained his belief, and though he hated life, he could never be induced to quit it voluntarily; but *Abel* was driven to terminate his misery in a way which the unfixedness of his religious opinions rather accelerated than retarded. I am therefore not without hope that the more observant of my readers will perceive many marks of discrimination in these characters.

The Life of *Ellen Orford*, though sufficiently burthened with error and misfortune, has in it little besides, which resembles those of the above

unhappy men, and is still more unlike that of *Grimes*, in a subsequent Letter. There is in this character cheerfulness and resignation, a more uniform piety, and an immovable trust in the aid of religion: this, with the light texture of the introductory part, will, I hope, take off from that idea of sameness which the repetition of crimes and distresses is likely to create. The character of *Grimes*, his obduracy and apparent want of feeling, his gloomy kind of misanthropy, the progress of his madness, and the horrors of his imagination, I must leave to the judgment and observation of my readers. The mind here exhibited is one untouched by pity, unstung by remorse, and uncorrected by shame: yet is this hardihood of temper and spirit broken by want, disease, solitude, and disappointment; and he becomes the victim of a distempered and horror-stricken fancy. It is evident, therefore, that no feeble vision, no half-visible ghost, not the momentary glance of an unbodied being, nor the half-audible voice of an invisible one, would be created by the continual workings of distress on a mind so depraved and flinty. The ruffian of Mr Scott^[33] has a mind of this nature: he has no shame or remorse: but the corrosion of hopeless want, the wasting of unabating disease, and the gloom of unvaried solitude, will have their effect on every nature; and, the harder that nature is, and the longer time required to work upon it, so much the more strong and indelible is the impression. This is all the reason I am able to give, why a man of feeling so dull should yet become insane, should be of so horrible a nature.

That a Letter on Prisons should follow those narratives is unfortunate, but not to be easily avoided. I confess it is not pleasant to be detained so long by subjects so repulsive to the feelings of many as the sufferings of mankind; but, though I assuredly would have altered this arrangement, had I been able to have done it by substituting a better, yet am I not of opinion that my verses, or indeed the verses of any other person, can so represent the evils and distresses of life as to make any material impression on the mind, and much less any of injurious nature. Alas! sufferings real, evident, continually before us, have not effects very serious or lasting, even in the minds of the more reflecting and compassionate; nor indeed does it seem right that the pain caused by sympathy should serve for more than a stimulus to benevolence. If, then, the strength and solidity of truth placed before our eyes have effect so feeble and transitory, I need not be very apprehensive that my representations of Poor-houses and Prisons, of wants

and sufferings, however faithfully taken, will excite any feelings which can be seriously lamented. It has always been held as a salutary exercise of the mind, to contemplate the evils and miseries of our nature. I am not, therefore, without hope, that even this gloomy subject of Imprisonment, and more especially the Dream of the condemned Highwayman, will excite in some minds that mingled pity and abhorrence, which, while it is not unpleasant to the feelings, is useful in its operation: it ties and binds us to all mankind by sensations common to us all, and in some degree connects us, without degradation, even to the most miserable and guilty of our fellow-men.

Our concluding subject is Education; and some attempt is made to describe its various seminaries, from that of the Poor Widow, who pronounces the alphabet for infants, to seats whence the light of learning is shed abroad on the world. If, in this Letter, I describe the lives of literary men as embittered by much evil; if they be often disappointed, and sometimes unfitted for the world they improve: let it be considered that they are described as men who possess that great pleasure, the exercise of their own talents, and the delight which flows from their own exertions; they have joy in their pursuits, and glory in their acquirements of knowledge. Their victory over difficulties affords the most rational cause of triumph, and the attainment of new ideas leads to incalculable riches, such as gratify the glorious avarice of aspiring and comprehensive minds. Here, then, I place the reward of learning.—Our Universities produce men of the first scholastic attainments, who are heirs to large possessions, or descendants from noble families. Now, to those so favoured, talents and acquirements are, unquestionably, means of arriving at the most elevated and important situations; but these must be the lot of a few. In general, the diligence, acuteness, and perseverance of a youth at the University, have no other reward than some College honours and emoluments, which they desire to exchange, many of them, for very moderate incomes in the obscurity of some distant village: so that, in stating the reward of an ardent and powerful mind to consist principally (I might have said entirely) in its own views, efforts, and excursions, I place it upon a sure foundation, though not one so elevated as the more ambitious aspire to. It is surely some encouragement to a studious man to reflect, that if he be disappointed, he cannot be without gratification; and that, if he gets but a very humble portion of what the

world can give, he has a continual fruition of unwearying enjoyment, of which it has not power to deprive him.

Long as I have detained the reader, I take leave to add a few words on the subject of imitation, or, more plainly speaking, borrowing. In the course of a long Poem, and more especially of two long ones, it is very difficult to avoid a recurrence of the same thoughts, and of similar expressions; and, however careful I have been myself in detecting and removing these kinds of repetitions, my readers, I question not, would, if disposed to seek them, find many remaining. For these I can only plead that common excuse—they are the offences of a bad memory, and not of voluntary inattention; to which I must add the difficulty (I have already mentioned) of avoiding the error. This kind of plagiarism will therefore, I conceive, be treated with lenity; and of the more criminal kind, borrowing from others, I plead, with much confidence, "not guilty." But while I claim exemption from guilt, I do not affirm that much of sentiment and much of expression may not be detected in the vast collection of English poetry: it is sufficient for an author, that he uses not the words or ideas of another without acknowledgment; and this, and no more than this, I mean, by disclaiming debts of the kind. Yet resemblances are sometimes so very striking, that it requires faith in a reader to admit they were undesigned. A line in the second Letter,

"And monuments themselves memorials need,"

was written long before the author, in an accidental recourse to Juvenal, read—

"Quandoquidem data sunt ipsis quoque fata sepulchris."

Sat. x. l. 146.

and for this I believe the reader will readily give me credit. But there is another apparent imitation in the life of *Blaney* (Letter xiv), a simile of so particular a kind, that its occurrence to two writers at the same time must appear as an extraordinary event. For this reason I once determined to exclude it from the relation, but, as it was truly unborrowed, and suited the place in which it stood, this seemed, on after-consideration, to be an act of cowardice, and the lines are therefore printed as they were written about two months before the very same thought (prosaically drest) appeared in a periodical work of the last summer. It is highly probable, in these cases, that

both may derive the idea from a forgotten but common source; and in this way I must entreat the reader to do me justice, by accounting for other such resemblances, should any be detected.

I know not whether to some readers the placing two or three Latin quotations to a Letter may not appear pedantic and ostentatious, while both they and the English ones may be thought unnecessary. For the necessity I have not much to advance; but if they be allowable (and certainly the best writers have adopted them), then, where two or three different subjects occur, so many of these mottoes seem to be required: nor will a charge of pedantry remain, when it is considered that these things are generally taken from some books familiar to the school-boy, and the selecting them is facilitated by the use of a book of common-place. Yet, with this help, the task of motto-hunting has been so unpleasant to me, that I have in various instances given up the quotation I was in pursuit of, and substituted such English verse or prose as I could find or invent for my purpose.

FOOTNOTES:

[31] Methodists and Papists compared; Treatise on Grace, by Bishop Warburton, &c.

[32] Barbar, in two Parts; Bond-Child; Cry of Little Faith; Satan's Lawsuit; Forty Stripes for Satan; Myrrh and Odour of Saints; the Naked Bow of God: Rule and Riddle; Way and Fare for Wayfaring Men; Utility of the Books and Excellency of the Parchments; Correspondence between *Noctua*, *Aurita* (the words so separated), and *Philomela*, &c.

[33] Marmion.

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LETTER I.

GENERAL DESCRIPTION.

These did the ruler of the deep ordain,
To build proud navies, and to rule the
main.

*Pope's Homer's
Iliad,
book vi.*

line 45.
[?]

Such [place hath] Deptford, navy-
building town,
 Woolwich and Wapping, smelling
 strong of pitch;
Such Lambeth, envy of each band and
 gown,
And Twickenham such, which fairer
 scenes enrich.

*Pope's Imitation
of
Spenser.*

Et cum cœlestibus
 undis
Æquoreæ miscentur aquæ; caret ignibus
 æther,
Cæaque nox premitur tenebris
 hiemisque suisque;
[Discutiunt] tamen has, præbentque
 micantia lumen
Fulmina; fulmineis ardescunt ignibus
 undæ.

*Ovid.
Metamor
ph. lib.
xi. [vv.
519-
523].*

Difficulty of describing Town Scenery—A Comparison with certain Views in the Country—The River and Quay—The Shipping and Business—Ship-Building—Sea-Boys and Port-Views—Village and Town Scenery again compared—Walks from Town—Cottage and adjoining Heath, &c.—House of Sunday Entertainment—The Sea: a Summer and Winter View—A Shipwreck at

Night, and its Effects on Shore—Evening Amusements in the Borough—An Apology for the imperfect View which can be given of these Subjects.

LETTER I.

GENERAL DESCRIPTION.

"Describe the Borough."—Though
our idle tribe
May love description, can we so
describe,
That you shall fairly streets and
buildings trace,
And all that gives distinction to a
place?
This cannot be; yet, moved by your
request,
A part I paint—let fancy form the
rest.

Cities and towns, the various
haunts of men,
Require the pencil; they defy the pen.
Could he, who sang so well the
Grecian fleet,

10
So well have sung of alley, lane, or
street?
Can measured lines these various
buildings show,
The Town-Hall Turning, or the
Prospect Row?
Can I the seats of wealth and want
explore,
And lengthen out my lays from door
to door?

Then, let thy fancy aid me.—I
repair

From this tall mansion of our last-
year's mayor,
Till we the outskirts of the Borough
reach,
And these half-buried buildings next
the beach;
Where hang at open doors the net and
cork,

20

While squalid sea-dames mend the
meshy work;
Till comes the hour, when, fishing
through the tide,
The weary husband throws his freight
aside—
A living mass, which now demands
the wife,
Th' alternate labours of their humble
life.

Can scenes like these withdraw
thee from thy wood,
Thy upland forest or thy valley's
flood?
Seek, then, thy garden's shrubby
bound, and look,
As it steals by, upon the bordering
brook:
That winding streamlet, limpid,
lingering, slow,

30

Where the reeds whisper when the
zephyrs blow;
Where in the midst, upon her throne
of green,
Sits the large lily^[34] as the water's
queen;

And makes the current, forced awhile
to stay,
Murmur and bubble as it shoots
away;
Draw then the strongest contrast to
that stream,
And our broad river will before thee
seem.

With ceaseless motion comes and
goes the tide,
Flowing, it fills the channel vast and
wide;
Then back to sea, with strong
majestic sweep

40

It rolls, in ebb yet terrible and deep;
Here sampire-banks^[35] and salt-
wort^[36] bound the flood;
There stakes and sea-weeds,
withering on the mud;
And, higher up, a ridge of all things
base,
Which some strong tide has roll'd
upon the place.

Thy gentle river boasts its pigmy
boat,
Urged on by pains, half grounded,
half afloat;
While at her stern an angler takes his
stand,
And marks the fish he purposes to
land;
From that clear space, where, in the
cheerful ray

50

Of the warm sun, the scaly people
play.

Far other craft our prouder river
shows,
Hoys, pinks and sloops; brigs,
brigantines and snows:
Nor angler we on our wide stream
descry,
But one poor dredger where his
oysters lie:
He, cold and wet, and driving with
the tide,
Beats his weak arms against his tarry
side,
Then drains the remnant of diluted
gin,
To aid the warmth that languishes
within;
Renewing oft his poor attempts to
beat

60

His tingling fingers into gathering
heat.
He shall again be seen when
evening comes,
And social parties crowd their
favourite rooms;
Where on the table pipes and papers
lie,
The steaming bowl or foaming
tankard by.
'Tis then, with all these comforts
spread around,
They hear the painful dredger's
welcome sound;
And few themselves the savoury
boon deny,
The food that feeds, the living luxury.

Yon is our quay! those smaller
hoys from town.

70

Its various wares, for country-use,
bring down;
Those laden waggons, in return,
impart
The country-produce to the city mart;
Hark to the clamour in that miry road,
Bounded and narrow'd by yon
vessels' load;
The lumbering wealth she empties
round the place,
Package, and parcel, hogshead, chest,
and case;
While the loud seaman and the angry
hind,
Mingling in business, bellow to the
wind.

Near these a crew amphibious, in
the docks,

80

Rear, for the sea, those castles on the
stocks:
See the long keel, which soon the
waves must hide;
See the strong ribs which form the
roomy side;
Bolts yielding slowly to the sturdiest
stroke,
And planks^[32] which curve and
crackle in the smoke.
Around the whole rise cloudy
wreaths, and far
Bear the warm pungence of o'er-
boiling tar.

Dabbling on shore half-naked sea-
boys crowd,
Swim round a ship, or swing upon the
shroud;
Or, in a boat purloin'd, with paddles
play,

90

And grow familiar with the watery
way.
Young though they be, they feel
whose sons they are;
They know what British seamen do
and dare;
Proud of that fame, they raise and
they enjoy
The rustic wonder of the village-boy.

Before you bid these busy scenes
adieu,
Behold the wealth that lies in public
view,
Those far-extended heaps of coal and
coke,
Where fresh-fill'd lime-kilns breathe
their stifling smoke.
This shall pass off, and you behold,
instead,

100

The night-fire gleaming on its chalky
bed;
When from the light-house brighter
beams will rise,
To show the shipman where the
shallow lies.

Thy walks are ever pleasant; every
scene
Is rich in beauty, lively, or serene:

Rich—is that varied view with woods
 around,
Seen from the seat, within the
 shrubb'ry bound;
Where shines the distant lake, and
 where appear
From ruins bolting, unmolested deer;
Lively—the village-green, the inn,
 the place

110

Where the good widow schools her
 infant race;
Shops, whence are heard the hammer
 and the saw,
And village-pleasures unreprieved by
 law.
Then, how serene—when in your
 favourite room,
Gales from your jasmines soothe the
 evening gloom;
When from your upland paddock you
 look down,
And just perceive the smoke which
 hides the town;
When weary peasants at the close of
 day
Walk to their cots, and part upon the
 way;
When cattle slowly cross the shallow
 brook,

120

And shepherds pen their folds, and
 rest upon their crook.
 We prune our hedges, prime our
 slender trees,
And nothing looks untutor'd and at
 ease;

On the wide heath, or in the flow'ry
vale,
We scent the vapours of the sea-born
gale;
Broad-beaten paths lead on from stile
to stile,
And sewers from streets the road-side
banks defile;
Our guarded fields a sense of danger
show,
Where garden-crops with corn and
clover grow;
Fences are form'd of wreck and
placed around
130
(With tenters tipp'd), a strong
repulsive bound;
Wide and deep ditches by the gardens
run,
And there in ambush lie the trap and
gun;
Or yon broad board, which guards
each tempting prize,
"Like a tall bully, lifts its head and
lies."

There stands a cottage with an
open door,
Its garden undefended blooms before;
Her wheel is still, and overturn'd her
stool,
While the lone widow seeks the
neighb'ring pool.
This gives us hope all views of town
to shun—

140
No! here are tokens of the sailor-son:

That old blue jacket, and that shirt of
check,
And silken kerchief for the seaman's
neck;
Sea-spoils and shells from many a
distant shore,
And furry robe from frozen Labrador.
Our busy streets and sylvan-walks
between,
Fen, marshes, bog and heath all
intervene;
Here pits of crag, with spongy, plashy
base,
To some enrich th' uncultivated
space:
For there are blossoms rare, and
curious rush,
150
The gale's rich balm, and sun-dew's
crimson blush,
Whose velvet leaf, with radiant
beauty dress'd,
Forms a gay pillow for the plover's
breast.
Not distant far, a house,
commodious made,
Lonely yet public stands, for Sunday-
trade;
Thither, for this day free, gay parties
go,
Their tea-house walk, their tippling
rendezvous;
There humble couples sit in corner-
bowers,
Or gaily ramble for th' allotted hours;
Sailors and lasses from the town
attend,

160

The servant-lover, the apprentice-
friend;
With all the idle social tribes who
seek
And find their humble pleasures once
a week.

Turn to the watery world!—but
who to thee
(A wonder yet unview'd) shall paint
—the sea?

Various and vast, sublime in all its
forms,
When lull'd by zephyrs, or when
roused by storms;
Its colours changing, when from
clouds and sun
Shades after shades upon the surface
run;
Embrown'd and horrid now, and now
serene,

170

In limpid blue, and evanescent green;
And oft the foggy banks on ocean lie,
Lift the fair sail, and cheat th'
experienced eye^[38].

Be it the summer-noon: a sandy
space
The ebbing tide has left upon its
place;
Then, just the hot and stony beach
above,
Light twinkling streams in bright
confusion move
(For heated thus, the warmer air
ascends,

Th' unwieldy porpoise through the
day before
Had roll'd in view of boding men on
shore;
And sometimes hid, and sometimes
show'd, his form,
Dark as the cloud, and furious as the
storm.

200

All where the eye delights, yet
dreads, to roam,
The breaking billows cast the flying
foam
Upon the billows rising—all the deep
Is restless change; the waves so
swell'd and steep,
Breaking and sinking, and the sunken
swells,
Nor one, one moment, in its station
dwells.
But, nearer land, you may the billows
trace,
As if contending in their watery
chase;
May watch the mightiest till the shoal
they reach,
Then break and hurry to their utmost
stretch;

210

Curl'd as they come, they strike with
furious force,
And then, re-flowing, take their
grating course,
Raking the rounded flints, which ages
past
Roll'd by their rage, and shall to ages
last.

Far off, the petrel in the troubled
way
Swims with her brood, or flutters in
the spray;
She rises often, often drops again,
And sports at ease on the
tempestuous main.

High o'er the restless deep, above
the reach
Of gunner's hope, vast flights of wild-
ducks stretch;

220

Far as the eye can glance on either
side,
In a broad space and level line they
glide;
All in their wedge-like figures from
the north,
Day after day, flight after flight, go
forth.

In-shore their passage tribes of sea-
gulls urge,
And drop for prey within the
sweeping surge;
Oft in the rough }
opposing blast }
they fly

Far back, then turn, and all
their force apply,
While to the storm they give
their weak complaining cry;
Or clap the sleek white pinion to the
breast,

230

And in the restless ocean dip for rest.
Darkness begins to reign; the
louder wind

Appals the weak and awes the firmer
mind;
But frights not him, whom evening
and the spray
In part conceal—yon prowler on his
way.
Lo! he has something seen; he runs
apace,
As if he fear'd companion in the
chase;
He sees his prize, and now he turns
again,
Slowly and sorrowing—"Was your
search in vain?"
Gruffly he answers, "'Tis a sorry
sight!

240

A seaman's body; there'll be more to-
night!"
Hark to those sounds! they're from
distress at sea:
How quick they come! What terrors
may there be!
Yes, 'tis a driven vessel: I discern
Lights, signs of terror, gleaming from
the stern;
Others behold them too, and from the
town
In various parties seamen hurry
down;
Their wives pursue, and damsels
urged by dread,
Lest men so dear be into danger led;
Their head the gown has hooded, and
their call

250

In this sad night is piercing like the
squall;
They feel their kinds of power, and
when they meet,
Chide, fondle, weep, dare, threaten,
or entreat.

See one poor girl, all terror and
alarm,
Has fondly seized upon her lover's
arm;
"Thou shalt not venture;" and he
answers "No!
I will not"—still she cries, "Thou
shalt not go."

No need of this; not here the
stoutest boat
Can through such breakers, o'er such
billows float;
Yet may they view these lights upon
the beach,

260

Which yield them hope, whom help
can never reach.

From parted clouds the moon her
radiance throws
On the wild waves, and all the danger
shows;
But shows them beaming in her
shining vest,
Terrific splendour! gloom in glory
dress'd!

This for a moment, and then clouds
again
Hide every beam, and fear and
darkness reign.

But hear we now those sounds? Do
lights appear?

I see them not! the storm alone I hear:
And lo! the sailors homeward take
their way;

270

Man must endure—let us submit and
pray.

Such are our winter-views; but
night comes on—
Now business sleeps, and daily cares
are gone;
Now parties form, and some their
friends assist
To waste the idle hours at sober
whist;
The tavern's pleasure or the concert's
charm
Unnumber'd moments of their sting
disarm;
Play-bills and open doors a crowd
invite,
To pass off one dread portion of the
night;
And show and song and luxury
combined

280

Lift off from man this burthen of
mankind.

Others advent'rous walk abroad
and meet
Returning parties pacing through the
street;
When various voices, in the dying
day,
Hum in our walks, and greet us in our
way;
When tavern-lights flit on from room
to room,

And guide the tippling sailor,
staggering home:

There as we pass, the jingling bells
betray

How business rises with the closing
day:

Now walking silent, by the river's
side,

290

The ear perceives the rippling of the
tide;

Or measured cadence of the lads who
tow

Some enter'd hoy, to fix her in her
row;

Or hollow sound, which from the
parish-bell

To some departed spirit bids farewell!

Thus shall you something of our
BOROUGH know,

Far as a verse, with Fancy's aid, can
show;

Of sea or river, of a quay or street,

The best description must be
incomplete;

But when a happier theme [succeeds],
and when

300

Men are our subjects and the deeds of
men;

Then may we find the Muse in
happier style,

And we may sometimes sigh and
sometimes smile.

NOTES TO LETTER I.

[34] Note 1, page 286, line 32.

Sits the large lily as the water's queen.

The white water-lily. *Nymphæa alba*.

[35] Note 2, page 286, line 41.

Sampire-banks.

The jointed glasswort *Salicornia* is here meant, not the true sampire, the *crithmum maritimum*.

[36] Note 3, page 286, line 41.

Salt-wort.

The salsola of botanists.

[37] Note 4, page 287, line 84.

*And planks which curve and crackle in
the smoke.*

The curvature of planks for the sides of a ship, &c. is, I am informed, now generally made by the power of steam. Fire is nevertheless still used for boats and vessels of the smaller kind.

[38] Note 5, page 289, lines 171 and 172.

*And oft the foggy banks on ocean lie,
Lift the fair sail, and cheat th'
experienced eye.*

Of the effect of these mists, known by the name of fog-banks, wonderful and indeed incredible relations are given; but their property of appearing to elevate ships at sea, and to bring them in view, is, I believe, generally acknowledged.

LETTER II.

THE CHURCH.

... Festinat enim decurrere velox
Flosculus angustæ miseræque brevissima
vitæ
Portio! dum bibimus, dumserta,
unguenta, puellas
Poscimus, obrepit non intellecta senectus.
Juvenal.

Sati
r.
ix.
lin.
126.

And when at last thy love shall die,
Wilt thou receive his parting breath?
Wilt thou repress each struggling sigh,
And cheer with smiles the bed of
death?
Percy [?].

eral Meanings of the word *Church*—The Building so called, here intended—Its Antiquity and Grandeur—Columns and Ailes—The Tower: the Stains made by Time compared with the mock Antiquity of the Artist—Progress of Vegetation on such Buildings—Bells—Tombs: one in decay—Mural Monuments, and the Nature of their Inscriptions—An Instance in a departed Burgess—Churchyard Graves—Mourners for the Dead—A Story of a betrothed Pair in humble Life, and Effects of Grief in the Survivor.

LETTER II.

THE CHURCH.

"What is a Church?"—Let Truth
and Reason speak,
They would reply, "The faithful, pure,
and meek;

From Christian folds the one selected
race,
Of all professions, and in every
place."

"What is a Church?"—"A flock,"
our vicar cries,
"Whom bishops govern and whom
priests advise;
Wherein are various states and due
degrees,
The bench for honour, and the stall
for ease;
That ease be mine, which, after all his
cares,

10
The pious, peaceful prebendary
shares."

"What is a Church?"—Our honest
sexton tells,
"'Tis a tall building, with a tower and
bells;
Where priest and clerk with joint
exertion strive
To keep the ardour of their flock
alive:
That, by his periods eloquent and
grave;
This, by responses, and a well-set
stave.
These for the living; but, when life be
fled,
I toll myself the requiem for the
dead."

'Tis to this Church I call thee, and
that place

Where slept our fathers, when they'd
run their race.

We too shall rest, and then our
children keep

Their road in life, and then, forgotten,
sleep;

Meanwhile the building slowly falls
away,

And, like the builders, will in time
decay.

The old foundation—but it is not
clear

When it was laid—you care not for
the year:

On this, as parts decay'd by time and
storms,

Arose these various disproportion'd
forms;

Yet Gothic, all the learn'd who visit
us

30

(And our small wonders) have
decided thus:

"Yon noble Gothic arch;" "That
Gothic door;"

So have they said; of proof you'll
need no more.

Here large plain columns rise in
solemn style:

You'd love the gloom they make in
either aisle,

When the sun's rays, enfeebled as
they pass

(And shorn of splendour) through the
storied glass,

Faintly display the figures on the
floor,

Which pleased distinctly in their
place before.

But, ere you enter, yon bold tower
survey,

40

Tall and entire, and venerably gray;
For time has soften'd what was harsh
when new,

And now the stains are all of sober
hue—

The living stains which Nature's hand
alone,

Profuse of life, pours forth upon the
stone,

For ever growing; where the common
eye

Can but the bare and rocky bed
descry,

There Science loves to trace her
tribes minute,

The juiceless foliage, and the
tasteless fruit;

There she perceives them round the
surface creep,

50

And, while they meet, their due
distinction keep,

Mix'd but not blended; each its name
retains,

And these are Nature's ever-during
stains.

And would'st thou, artist, with thy
tints and brush,

Form shades like these? Pretender,
where thy blush?

In three short hours shall thy
presuming hand

Th' effect of three slow centuries
command^[39]?

Thou may'st thy various greens and
grays contrive:

They are not lichens, nor like aught
alive.—

But yet proceed, and when thy tints
are lost,

60

Fled in the shower, or crumbled by
the frost;

When all thy work is done away as
clean

As if thou never spread'st thy gray
and green:

Then may'st thou see how Nature's
work is done,

How slowly true she lays her colours
on;

When her least speck upon the
hardest flint

Has mark and form and is a living
tint,

And so embodied with the rock, that
few

Can the small germ upon the
substance view^[40].

Seeds, to our eye invisible, will
find

70

On the rude rock the bed that fits
their kind;

There, in the rugged soil, they safely
dwell,

Till showers and snows the subtle
atoms swell,

And spread th' enduring foliage;—
 then we trace
The freckled flower upon the flinty
 base;
These all increase, till in unnoticed
 years
The stony tower as gray with age
 appears;
With coats of vegetation, thinly
 spread,
Coat above coat, the living on the
 dead.
These then dissolve to dust, and make
 a way

80

For bolder foliage, nursed by their
 decay;
The long-enduring ferns in time will
 all
Die and depose their dust upon the
 wall,
Where the wing'd seed may rest, till
 many a flower
Show Flora's triumph o'er the falling
 tower.

 But ours yet stands, and has its
 bells renown'd
For size magnificent and solemn
 sound.
Each has its motto: some contrived to
 tell,
In monkish rhyme, the uses of a
 bell^[41]—
Such wond'rous good, as few
 conceive could spring

90

From ten loud coppers when their
clappers swing.
Enter'd the Church, we to a tomb
proceed,
Whose names and titles few attempt
to read;
Old English letters, and those half
pick'd out,
Leave us, unskilful readers, much in
doubt.
Our sons shall see its more degraded
state;
The tomb of grandeur hastens to its
fate;
That marble arch, our sexton's
favourite show,
With all those ruff'd and painted pairs
below—
The noble lady and the lord who rest
100
Supine, as courtly dame and warrior
dress'd—
All are departed from their state
sublime,
Mangled and wounded in their war
with time,
Colleagued with mischief; here a leg
is fled,
And lo! the baron with but half a
head;
Midway is cleft the arch; the very
base
Is batter'd round and shifted from its
place.
Wonder not, mortal, at thy quick
decay—

See! men of marble piece-meal melt
away;
When whose the image we no longer
read,

110

But monuments themselves
memorials need^[42].

With few such stately proofs of
grief or pride,
By wealth erected, is our Church
supplied;

But we have mural tablets, every size,
That wo could wish, or vanity devise.

Death levels man,—the wicked and
the just,
The wise, the weak, lie blended in the
dust;

And by the honours dealt to every
name,
The king of terrors seems to level
fame.

—See here lamented wives, and
every wife

120

The pride and comfort of her
husband's life;

Here to her spouse, with every virtue
graced,

His mournful widow has a trophy
placed;

And here 'tis doubtful if the duteous
son,

Or the good father, be in praise
outdone.

This may be nature; when our
friends we lose,

Our alter'd feelings alter too our
views;
What in their tempers teased us or
distress'd,
Is, with our anger and the dead, at
rest;
And much we grieve, no longer trial
made,

130

For that impatience which we then
display'd;
Now to their love and worth of every
kind
A soft compunction turns th' afflicted
mind;
Virtues, neglected then, adored
become,
And graces slighted blossom on the
tomb.

'Tis well; but let not love nor grief
believe
That we assent (who neither loved
nor grieve)
To all that praise which on the tomb
is read,
To all that passion dictates for the
dead;
But, more indignant, we the tomb
deride,

140

Whose bold inscription flattery sells
to pride.
Read of this Burgess—on the stone
appear,
How worthy he! how virtuous! and
how dear!

What wailing was }
there when his }
spirit fled,
How mourn'd his lady for her
lord when dead,
And tears abundant through
the town were shed;
See! he was liberal, kind, religious,
wise,
And free from all disgrace and all
disguise;
His sterling worth, which words
cannot express,
Lives with his friends, their pride and
their distress.

150

All this of Jacob Holmes? for his
the name,
He thus kind, liberal, just, religious?
—shame!
What is the truth? Old Jacob married
thrice;
He dealt in coals, and av'rice was his
vice;
He ruled the Borough when his year
came on,
And some forget, and some are glad
he's gone;
For never yet with shilling could he
part,
But when it left his hand, it struck his
heart.

Yet, here will love its last
attentions pay,
And place memorials on these beds
of clay.

160

Large level stones lie flat upon the
grave,
And half a century's sun and tempest
brave;
But many an honest tear and heart-
felt sigh
Have follow'd those who now
unnoticed lie;
Of these what numbers rest on every
side!
Without one token left by grief or
pride;
Their graves soon levell'd to the
earth, and then
Will other hillocks rise o'er other
men;
Daily the dead on the decay'd are
thrust,
And generations follow, "dust to
dust."

170

Yes! there are real mourners—I
have seen
A fair, sad girl, mild, suffering, and
serene;
Attention (through the day) her duties
claim'd,
And to be useful as resign'd she
aim'd;
Neatly she dress'd, nor vainly seem'd
t' expect
Pity for grief, or pardon for neglect.
But, when her wearied parents sunk
to sleep,
She sought her place to meditate and
weep:

Then to her mind was all the past
display'd,
That faithful memory brings to
sorrow's aid:

180

For then she thought on one regretted
youth,
Her tender trust, and his unquestion'd
truth;
In ev'ry place she wander'd where
they'd been,
And sadly-sacred held the parting-
scene,
Where last for sea he took his leave—
that place
With double interest would she
nightly trace;
For long the courtship was, and he
would say,
Each time he sail'd,—"This once, and
then the day."
Yet prudence tarried; but, when last
he went,
He drew from pitying love a full
consent.

190

Happy he sail'd, and great the care
she took,
That he should softly sleep, and
smartly look;
White was his better linen, and his
check
Was made more trim than any on the
deck;
And every comfort men at sea can
know

Was hers to buy, to make, and to
bestow:
For he to Greenland sail'd, and much
she told,
How he should guard against the
climate's cold;
Yet saw not danger; dangers he'd
withstood,
Nor could she trace the fever in his
blood.

200

His messmates smiled at flushings in
his cheek,
And he too smiled, but seldom would
he speak;
For now he found the danger, felt the
pain,
With grievous symptoms he could not
explain;
Hope was awaken'd, as for home he
sail'd,
But quickly sank, and never more
prevail'd.

He call'd his friend, and prefaced
with a sigh
A lover's message—"Thomas, I must
die.

Would I could see my Sally, and
could rest
My throbbing temples on her faithful
breast,

210

And gazing go!—if not, this trifle
take,
And say, till death I wore it for her
sake.

Yes! I must die—blow on, sweet
breeze, blow on!
Give me one look, before my life be
gone,
Oh! give me that, and let me not
despair,
One last fond look—and now repeat
the prayer."

He had his wish, had more; I will
not paint
The lovers' meeting: she beheld him
faint—
With tender fears she took a nearer
view,
Her terrors doubling as her hopes
withdrew;

220

He tried to smile, and, half
succeeding, said,
"Yes! I must die;" and hope for ever
fled.

Still long she nursed him: tender
thoughts meantime
Were interchanged, and hopes and
views sublime.
To her he came to die, and every day
She took some portion of the dread
away;
With him she pray'd, to him his Bible
read,
Soothed the faint heart, and held the
aching head.
She came with smiles the hour of
pain to cheer;
Apart, she sigh'd; alone, she shed the
tear;

230

Then, as if breaking from a cloud, she
gave

Fresh light, and gilt the prospect of
the grave.

One day he lighter seem'd, and
they forgot

The care, the dread, the anguish of
their lot;

They spoke with cheerfulness, and
seem'd to think,

Yet said not so—"Perhaps he will not
sink."

A sudden brightness in his look
appear'd,

A sudden vigour in his voice was
heard;—

She had been reading in the Book of
Prayer,

And led him forth, and placed him in
his chair;

240

Lively he seem'd, and spoke of all he
knew,

The friendly many, and the favourite
few;

Nor one that day did he to mind recall
But she has treasured, and she loves
them all;

When in her way she meets them,
they appear

Peculiar people—death has made
them dear.

He named his friend, but then his
hand she press'd,

And fondly whisper'd, "Thou must go
to rest;"

"I go," he said; but, as he spoke, she
found
His hand more cold, and fluttering
was the sound!

250

Then gazed affrighten'd; but she
caught a last,
A dying look of love—and all was
past!

She placed a decent stone his grave
above,
Neatly engraved—an offering of her
love;
For that she wrought, for that forsook
her bed,
Awake alike to duty and the dead;
She would have grieved, had friends
presumed to spare
The least assistance—'twas her
proper care.

Here will she come, and on the
grave will sit,
Folding her arms, in long abstracted
fit;

260

But if observer pass, will take her
round,
And careless seem, for she would not
be found;
Then go again, and thus her hour
employ,
While visions please her, and while
woes destroy.

Forbear, sweet maid! nor be by
fancy led
To hold mysterious converse with the
dead;

For sure at length thy [thoughts'], thy
[spirit's] pain
In this sad conflict will disturb thy
brain.
All have their tasks and trials; thine
are hard,
But short the time, and glorious the
reward:
270
Thy patient spirit to thy duties give;
Regard the dead, but to the living
live^[43].

NOTES TO LETTER II.

^[39] Note 1, page 296, lines 55 and 56.

*In three short hours shall thy presuming
hand
Th' effect of three slow centuries
command?*

If it should be objected, that centuries are not slower than hours, because the speed of time must be uniform, I would answer, that I understand so much, and mean that they are slower in no other sense, than because they are not finished so soon.

^[40] Note 2, page 296, line 68.

*Can the small germ upon the substance
view.*

This kind of vegetation, as it begins upon siliceous stones, is very thin, and frequently not to be distinguished from the surface of the flint. The byssus jolithus of Linnæus (lepraria jolithus of the present system), an adhesive carmine crust on rocks and old buildings, was, even by scientific persons, taken for the substance on which it spread. A great variety of these minute vegetables are to be found in some parts of the coast, where the beach, formed of stones of various kinds, is undisturbed, and exposed to every change of weather; in this situation the different species of lichen, in their different stages of growth, have an appearance interesting and agreeable even to those who are ignorant of, and indifferent to, the cause.

^[41] Note 3, page 297, lines 87 and 88.

*Each has its motto: some contrived to
tell,
In monkish rhyme, the uses of a bell.*

The several purposes for which bells are used are expressed in two Latin verses of this kind.

[42] Note 4, page 297, line 110.

*But monuments themselves memorials
need.*

Quandoquidem data sunt ipsis quoque fata sepulchris.

Juvenal. Sat. x. I. 146.

[43] Note 5, page 301, last line.

Regard the dead, but to the living live.

It has been observed to me, that in the first part of the story I have represented this young woman as resigned and attentive to her duties; from which it should appear that the concluding advice is unnecessary; but if the reader will construe the expression "to the living live," into the sense—"live entirely for them, attend to duties only which are real, and not those imposed by the imagination," I shall have no need to alter the line which terminates the story.

LETTER III.

THE VICAR—THE CURATE, &c.

And telling me the sov'reign'st thing on
earth

Was parmacity for an inward bruise.

Shakspeare

.-
Hen
ry
IV.
Part
I.
Act
1

[Sc.
3, v.
58].

So gentle, yet so brisk, so wond'rous
sweet,
So fit to prattle at a lady's feet.

Churchill[,
The
Aut
hor]

.

Much are the precious hours of youth
mispent
In climbing learning's rugged, steep
ascent:

When to the top the bold adventurer's got,
He reigns, vain monarch[, o'er] a barren
spot;

[Whilst] in the vale of ignorance below
Folly and vice to rank luxuriance grow;
Honours and wealth pour in on every
side,

And proud preferment rolls her golden
tide.

Churchill[,
The
Aut
hor]

.

VICAR.

lately departed Minister of the Borough—His soothing and supplicatory Manners—His cool and
timid Affections—No Praise due to such negative Virtue—Address to Characters of this Kind—

The Vicar's Employments—His Talents and moderate Ambition—His Dislike of Innovation—His mild but ineffectual Benevolence—A Summary of his Character.

CURATE.

le of paying the Borough-Minister—The Curate has no such Resources—His Learning and Poverty—Erroneous Idea of his Parent—His Feelings as a Husband and Father—The dutiful Regard of his numerous Family—His Pleasure as a Writer, how interrupted—No Resource in the Press—Vulgar Insult—His Account of a Literary Society, and a Fund for the Relief of indigent Authors, &c.

LETTER III.

THE VICAR—THE CURATE, &c.

Where ends our chancel in a
vaulted space,
Sleep the departed vicars of the place;
Of most, all mention, memory,
thought are past—
But take a slight memorial of the last.
To what famed college we our
Vicar owe,
To what fair county, let historians
show.
Few now remember when the mild
young man,
Ruddy and fair, his Sunday-task
began;
Few live to speak of that soft
soothing look
10
He cast around, as he prepared his
book;
It was a kind of supplicating smile,
But nothing hopeless of applause, the
while;
And when he finish'd, his corrected
pride

Felt the desert, and yet the praise
denied.

Thus he his race began, and to the
end

His constant care was, no man to
offend;

No haughty virtues stirr'd his peaceful
mind,

Nor urged the priest to leave the flock
behind;

He was his Master's soldier, but not
one

20

To lead an army of his martyrs on:

Fear was his ruling passion; yet was
love,

Of timid kind, once known his heart
to move;

It led his patient spirit where it paid

Its languid offerings to a listening
maid;

She, with her widow'd mother, heard
him speak,

And sought awhile to find what he
would seek.

Smiling he came, he smiled when he
withdrew,

And paid the same attention to the
two;

Meeting and parting without joy or
pain,

30

He seem'd to come that he might go
again.

The wondering girl, no prude, but
something nice,

At length was chill'd by his unmelting
ice;
She found her tortoise held such
sluggish pace,
That she must turn and meet him in
the chase.
This not approving, she withdrew till
one
Came who appeared with livelier
hope to run;
Who sought a readier way the heart to
move,
Than by faint dalliance of unfixing
love.
Accuse me not that I approving
paint

40

Impatient hope or love without
restraint;
Or think the passions, a tumultuous
throng,
Strong as they are, ungovernably
strong:
But is the laurel to the soldier due,
Who cautious comes not into danger's
view?
What worth has virtue by desire
untried,
When Nature's self enlists on duty's
side?

The married dame in vain assail'd
the truth
And guarded bosom of the Hebrew
youth;
But with the daughter of the Priest of
On

50

The love was lawful, and the guard
was gone;
But Joseph's fame had lessen'd in our
view,
Had he, refusing, fled the maiden too.
Yet our good priest to Joseph's
praise aspired,
As once rejecting what his heart
desired;
"I am escaped," he said, when none
pursued;
When none attack'd him, "I am
unsubdued;"
"Oh pleasing pangs of love," he sang
again,
Cold to the joy, and stranger to the
pain.
Ev'n in his age would he address the
young,

60

"I too have felt these fires, and they
are strong;"
But from the time he left his favourite
maid,
To ancient females his devoirs were
paid;
And still they miss him after morning
prayer;
Nor yet successor fills the Vicar's
chair,
Where kindred spirits in his praise
agree,
A happy few, as mild and cool as
he—
The easy followers in the female
train,

Led without love, and captives
without chain.

Ye lilies male! think (as your tea
you sip,

70

While the town small-talk flows from
lip to lip;

Intrigues half-gather'd, conversation-
scraps,

Kitchen-cabals, and nursery-mishaps)

If the vast world may not some scene
produce,

Some state, where your small talents
might have use.

Within seraglios you might harmless
move,

'Mid ranks of beauty, and in haunts of
love;

There from too daring man the
treasures guard,

An easy duty, and its own reward;

Nature's soft substitutes, you there
might save

80

From crime the tyrant, and from
wrong the slave.

But let applause be dealt in all we
may:

Our priest was cheerful, and in season
gay;

His frequent visits seldom fail'd to
please;

Easy himself, he sought his
neighbour's ease.

To a small garden with delight he
came,

And gave successive flowers a
summer's fame;
These he presented with a grace his
own
To his fair friends, and made their
beauties known,
Not without moral compliment: how
they

90

"Like flowers were sweet, and must
like flowers decay."

Simple he was, and loved the
simple truth,
Yet had some useful cunning from his
youth;
A cunning never to dishonour lent,
And rather for defence than conquest
meant;
'Twas fear of power, with some desire
to rise,
But not enough to make him enemies;
He ever aim'd to please; and to offend
Was ever cautious; for he sought a
friend;
Yet for the friendship }
never much }
would pay,

100

Content to bow, be silent, and
obey,
And by a soothing suff'rance
find his way.
Fiddling and fishing were his arts;
at times
He alter'd sermons, and he aim'd at
rhymes;

And his fair friends, not yet intent on
cards,

Oft he amused with riddles and
charades.

Mild were his doctrines, and not
one discourse

But gain'd in softness what it lost in
force:

Kind his opinions; he would not
receive

An ill report, nor evil act believe;

110

"If true, 'twas wrong; but blemish
great or small

Have all mankind; yea, sinners are we
all."

If ever fretful thought disturbed his
breast,

If aught of gloom that cheerful mind
oppress'd,

It sprang from innovation; it was then

He spake of mischief made by
restless men,

Not by new doctrines: never in his
life

Would he attend to controversial
strife;

For sects he cared not; "They are not
of us,

Nor need we, brethren, their concerns
discuss;

120

But 'tis the change, the schism at
home I feel;

Ills few perceive, and none have skill
to heal:

Not at the altar our young brethren
read
(Facing their flock) the decalogue and
creed;
But at their duty, in their desks they
stand,
With naked surplice, lacking hood
and band:
Churches are now of holy song
bereft,
And half our ancient customs
changed or left;
Few sprigs of ivy are at Christmas
seen,
Nor crimson berry tips the holly's
green;

130

Mistaken choirs refuse the solemn
strain
Of ancient Sternhold, which from
ours amain
[Comes] flying forth, from aile to aile
about,
Sweet links of harmony and long
drawn out."

These were to him essentials, all
things new
He deem'd superfluous, useless, or
untrue;
To all beside indifferent, easy, cold,
Here the fire kindled, and the wo was
told.

Habit with him was all the test of
truth,
"It must be right: I've done it from my
youth."

140

Questions he answer'd in as brief a
way,
"It must be wrong—it was of
yesterday."
Though mild benevolence our
priest possess'd,
'Twas but by wishes or by words
express'd:
Circles in water, as they wider flow,
The less conspicuous, in their
progress grow;
And when at last they touch upon the
shore,
Distinction ceases, and they're view'd
no more.
His love, like that last circle, all
embraced,
But with effect that never could be
traced.

150

Now rests our Vicar. They who
knew him best
Proclaim his life t' have been entirely
rest—
Free from all evils which disturb his
mind
Whom studies vex and controversies
blind.
The rich approved—of them in
awe he stood;
The poor admired—they all believed
him good;
The old and serious of his habits
spoke;
The frank and youthful loved his
pleasant joke;

Mothers approved a safe contented
guest,
And daughters one who back'd each
small request:

160

In him his flock found nothing to
condemn;
Him sectaries liked—he never
troubled them;
No trifles fail'd his yielding mind to
please,
And all his passions sunk in early
ease;
Nor one so old has left this world of
sin,
More like the being that he entered
in.

THE CURATE.

Ask you what lands our pastor tithes?
—Alas!

But few our acres, and but short our
grass:

In some fat pastures of the rich,
indeed,

May roll the single cow or favourite
steed,

170

Who, stable-fed, is here for pleasure
seen,

His sleek sides bathing in the dewy
green:

But these, our hilly heath and
common wide,

Yield a slight portion for the parish-
guide;

No crops luxuriant in our borders
stand,
For here we plough the ocean, not the
land;
Still reason wills that we our pastor
pay,
And custom does it on a certain day.
Much is the duty, small the legal due,
And this with grateful minds we keep
in view;

180

Each makes his off'ring, some by
habit led,
Some by the thought, that all men
must be fed;
Duty and love, and piety and pride,
have each their force, and for the
priest provide.

Not thus our Curate, one whom all
believe
Pious and just, and for whose fate
they grieve;
All see him poor, but ev'n the vulgar
know
He merits love, and their respect
bestow.
A man so learn'd you shall but seldom
see,
Nor one so honour'd, so aggrieved as
he—

190

Not grieved by years alone; though
his appear
Dark and more dark, severer on
severe:
Not in his need,—and yet we all must
grant

How painful 'tis for feeling age to
want;
Nor in his body's sufferings—yet we
know
Where time has plough'd, there
misery loves to sow:
But in the wearied mind, that all in
vain
Wars with distress, and struggles with
its pain.

His father saw his powers—"I'll
give," quoth he,
"My first-born learning; 'twill a
portion be."

200

Unhappy gift! a portion for a son!
But all he had:—he learn'd, and was
undone!

Better, apprenticed to an humble
trade,
Had he the cassock for the priesthood
made,
Or thrown the shuttle, or the saddle
shaped,
And all these pangs of feeling souls
escaped.

He once had hope—hope ardent,
lively, light;
His feelings pleasant, and his
prospects bright:
Eager of fame, he read, he thought,
he wrote,
Weigh'd the Greek page, and added
note on note;

210

At morn, at evening at his work was
he,

And dream'd what his Euripides
would be.

Then care began;—he loved, he
woo'd, he wed;
Hope cheer'd him still, and Hymen
bless'd his bed—

A Curate's bed! then came the woful
years,

The husband's terrors, and the father's
tears;

A wife grown feeble, mourning,
pining, vex'd,

With wants and woes—by daily cares
perplex'd;

No more a help, a smiling, soothing
aid,

But boding, drooping, sickly, and
afraid.

220

A kind physician and without a fee,
Gave his opinion—"Send her to the
sea."

"Alas!" the good man answer'd, "can
I send

A friendless woman? Can I find a
friend?

No; I must with her, in her need,
repair

To that new place; the poor lie
everywhere;—

Some priest will pay me for my pious
pains:"—

He said, he came, and here he yet
remains.

Behold his dwelling; this poor hut
he hires,

Where he from view, though not from
want, retires;

230

Where four fair daughters, and five
sorrowing sons,
Partake his sufferings, and dismiss his
duns.

All join their efforts, and in patience
learn

To want the comforts they aspire to
earn;

For the sick mother something they'd
obtain,

To soothe her grief and mitigate her
pain;

For the sad father something they'd
procure,

To ease the burthen they themselves
endure.

Virtues like these at once delight
and press

On the fond father with a proud
distress;

240

On all around he looks with care and
love,

Grieved to behold, but happy to
approve.

Then from his care, his love, his
grief he steals,

And by himself an author's pleasure
feels;

Each line detains him, he omits not
one,

And all the sorrows of his state are
gone.—

Alas! ev'n then, in that delicious hour,

He feels his fortune, and laments its
power.

Some tradesman's bill his
wandering eyes engage,
Some scrawl for payment, thrust
'twixt page and page;

250
Some bold, loud }
rapping at his
humble door,

Some surly message he has
heard before,

Awake, alarm, and tell him he
is poor.

An angry dealer, vulgar, rich, and
proud,
Thinks of his bill, and passing, raps
aloud;

The elder daughter meekly makes
him way—

"I want my money, and I cannot stay:
My mill is stopp'd; what, Miss! I
cannot grind;

Go tell your father he must raise the
wind."

Still trembling, troubled, the dejected
maid

260
Says, "Sir! my father!—" and then
steps afraid:

Ev'n his hard heart is soften'd, and he
hears

Her voice with pity; he respects her
tears;

His stubborn features half admit a
smile,

And his tone softens—"Well! I'll wait
awhile."

Pity, a man so good, so mild, so
meek,
At such an age, should have his bread
to seek;
And all those rude and fierce attacks
to dread,
That are more harrowing than the
want of bread;
Ah! who shall whisper to that misery
peace,

270

And say that want and insolence shall
cease?

"But why not publish?"—those
who know too well,
Dealers in Greek, are fearful 'twill not
sell;
Then he himself is timid, troubled,
slow,
Nor likes his labours nor his griefs to
show;
The hope of fame may in his heart
have place,
But he has dread and horror of
disgrace;
Nor has he that confiding, easy way,
That might his learning and himself
display;
But to his work he from the world
retreats,

280

And frets and glories o'er the
favourite sheets.

But see the man himself; and sure I
trace

Signs of new joy exulting in that face
O'er care that sleeps—we err, or we
discern

Life in thy looks—the reason may we
learn?

"Yes," he replied, "I'm happy, I
confess,

To learn that some are pleased with
happiness

Which others feel— }
there are who }
now combine

The worthiest natures in the
best design,

To aid the letter'd poor, and
soothe such ills as mine:

290

We who more keenly feel the world's
contempt,

And from its miseries are the least
exempt;

Now hope shall whisper to the
wounded breast,

And grief, in soothing expectation,
rest.

Yes, I am taught that men who
think, who feel,

Unite the pains of thoughtful men to
heal;

Not with disdainful pride, whose
bounties make

The needy curse the benefits they
take;

Not with the idle vanity that knows
Only a selfish joy when it bestows;

300

Not with o'erbearing wealth, that, in
disdain,
Hurls the superfluous bliss at
groaning pain;
But these are men who yield such
bless'd relief
That with the grievance they destroy
the grief;
Their timely aid the needy sufferers
find,
Their generous manner soothes the
suffering mind;
Theirs is a gracious bounty, form'd to
raise
Him whom it aids; their charity is
praise;
A common bounty may relieve
distress,
But whom the vulgar succour, they
oppress;

310

This, though a favour, is an honour
too;
Though mercy's duty, yet 'tis merit's
due:
When our relief from such resources
rise,
All painful sense of obligation dies;
And grateful feelings in the bosom
wake,
For 'tis their offerings, not their alms,
we take.

Long may these founts of charity
remain,
And never shrink but to be fill'd
again;

True! to the author }
they are now }
confined,

To him who gave the treasure
of his mind,

320

His time, his health, and thankless
found mankind:

But there is hope that from these
founts may flow

A sideways stream, and equal good
bestow—

Good that may reach us, whom the
day's distress

Keeps from the fame and perils of the
press;

Whom study beckons from the ills of
life,

And they from study—melancholy
strife!

Who then can say but bounty now so
free,

And so diffused, may find its way to
me?

Yes! I may see my decent table yet
330

Cheer'd with the meal that adds not to
my debt;

May talk of those to whom so much
we owe,

And guess their names whom yet we
may not know;

Bless'd we shall say are those who
thus can give,

And next who thus upon the bounty
live;

Then shall I close with thanks my
humble meal,
And feel so well—Oh! God! how I
shall feel!"

LETTER IV.

SECTS AND PROFESSIONS IN RELIGION.

... But cast your eyes again,
And view those errors which new sects
maintain,
Or which of old disturb'd the [Church's]
peaceful reign:
And we can point each period of the time
When they began and who begat the
crime;
Can calculate how long th' eclipse
endured;
Who interposed; what digits were
obscured;
Of all which are already pass'd away,
We [know] the rise, the progress, and
decay.

Dryden.—
Hin
d
and
Pan
ther
,
Part
II.

[Ah!] said the Hind, how many sons have
you
Who call you mother, whom you never
knew?
But most of them who that relation plead
Are such ungracious youths as wish you
dead;
They gape at rich revenues which you
hold,
And fain would nibble at your grandame
gold.

*Hind and
Pan
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[Par
t
III].*

is and Professions in Religion are numerous and successive—General Effect of false Zeal—Deists—
Fanatical Idea of Church Reformers—The Church of Rome—Baptists—Swedenborgians—
Universalists—Jews.

hodists of two Kinds; Calvinistic and Arminian.

Preaching of a Calvinistic Enthusiast—His Contempt of Learning—Dislike to sound Morality: why—
His Idea of Conversion—His Success and Pretensions to Humility.

Arminian Teacher of the older Flock—Their Notions of the Operations and Power of Satan—
Description of his Devices—Their Opinion of regular Ministers—Comparison of these with the
Preacher himself—A Rebuke to his Hearers; introduces a Description of the powerful Effects of
the Word in the early and awakening Days of Methodism.

LETTER IV.

SECTS AND PROFESSIONS IN RELIGION.

"Sects in Religion?"—Yes, of every
race
We nurse some portion in our
favoured place;

Not one warm preacher of one
growing sect
Can say our Borough treats him with
neglect;
Frequent as fashions they with us
appear,
And you might ask, "how think we
for the year?"
They come to us as riders in a trade,
And with much art exhibit and
persuade.
Minds are for sects of various
kinds decreed,

10

As different soils are form'd for
diff'rent seed;
Some, when converted, sigh in sore
amaze,
And some are wrapt in joy's ecstatic
blaze;
Others again will change to each
extreme,
They know not why—as hurried in a
dream;
Unstable they, like water, take all
forms,
Are quick and stagnant, have their
calms and storms;
High on the hills, they }
in the }
sunbeams
glow;
Then muddily they move
debased and slow,
Or cold and frozen rest, and
neither rise nor flow.

20

Yet none the cool and prudent
teacher prize;
On him they dote who wakes their
ecstasies;
With passions ready primed such
guide they meet,
And warm and kindle with th'
imparted heat;
'Tis he who wakes the nameless
strong desire,
The melting rapture, and the glowing
fire;
'Tis he who pierces deep the tortured
breast,
And stirs the terrors, never more to
rest.

Opposed to these we have a
prouder kind,
Rash without heat, and without
raptures blind;

30

These our *Glad Tidings* unconcern'd
peruse,
Search without awe, and without fear
refuse;
The truths, the blessings found in
Sacred Writ,
Call forth their spleen, and exercise
their wit;
Respect from these nor saints nor
martyrs gain;
The zeal they scorn, and they deride
the pain;
And take their transient, cool,
contemptuous view,
Of that which must be tried, and
doubtless—*may be true*.

Friends of our faith we have,
whom doubts like these,
And keen remarks, and bold
objections please;

40

They grant such doubts have weaker
minds oppress'd,
Till sound conviction gave the
troubled rest.

"But still," they cry, "let none their
censures spare;
They but confirm the glorious hopes
we share;
From doubt, disdain, derision, scorn,
and lies,
With five-fold triumph sacred truth
shall rise."

Yes! I allow, so truth shall stand at
last,
And gain fresh glory by the conflict
past—
As Solway-Moss (a barren mass and
cold,
Death to the seed, and poison to the
fold,)

50

The smiling plain and fertile vale
o'erlaid,
Choked the green sod, and kill'd the
springing blade;
That, changed by culture, may in time
be seen,
Enrich'd by golden grain, and pasture
green;
And these fair acres, rented and
enjoy'd,

May those excel by Solway-Moss
destroyed^[44].

Still must have mourn'd the tenant
of the day,
For hopes destroy'd and harvests
swept away;
To him the gain of future years
unknown,
The instant grief and suffering were
his own.

60

So must I grieve for many a wounded
heart,
Chill'd by those doubts which bolder
minds impart:
Truth in the end shall shine divinely
clear,
But sad the darkness till those times
appear;
Contests for truth, as wars for
freedom, yield
Glory and joy to those who gain the
field;
But still the Christian must in pity
sigh
For all who suffer, and uncertain die.

Here are, who all the Church
maintains approve,
But yet the Church herself they will
not love;

70

In angry speech, they blame the
carnal tie,
Which pure Religion lost her spirit
by;
What time from prisons, flames, and
tortures led,

She slumber'd careless in a royal bed;
To make, they add, the Churches'
glory shine.

Should Diocletian reign, not
Constantine.

"In pomp," they cry, "is England's
Church array'd;
Her cool reformers wrought like men
afraid.

We would have pull'd her gorgeous
temples down,
And spurn'd her mitre, and defiled her
gown;

80

We would have trodden low both
bench and stall,
Nor left a tithe remaining, great or
small."

Let us be serious.—Should such
trials come,
Are they themselves prepared for
martyrdom?

It seems to us that our reformers
knew

Th' important work they undertook to
do;

An equal priesthood they were loth to
try,

Lest zeal and care should with
ambition die;

To them it seem'd that, take the tenth
away,

Yet priests must eat, and you must
feed or pay:

90

Would they indeed, who hold such
pay in scorn,

Put on the muzzle when they tread
the corn?

Would they, all gratis, watch and tend
the fold,

Nor take one fleece to keep them
from the cold?

Men are not equal, and 'tis meet
and right

That robes and titles our respect
excite;

Order requires it; 'tis by vulgar pride
That such regard is censured and
denied,

Or by that false enthusiastic zeal,
That thinks the spirit will the priest
reveal,

100

And show to all men, by their
powerful speech,

Who are appointed and inspired to
teach.

Alas! could we the dangerous rule
believe,

Whom for their teacher should the
crowd receive?

Since all the varying kinds demand
respect,

All press you on to join their chosen
sect,

Although but in this single point
agreed,

"Desert your churches and adopt our
creed."

We know full well how much our
forms offend

The burthen'd Papist and the simple
Friend—

110

Him who new robes for every service
takes,
And who in drab and beaver sighs
and shakes.
He on the priest, whom hood and
band adorn,
Looks with the sleepy eye of silent
scorn;
But him I would not for my friend
and guide,
Who views such things with spleen,
or wears with pride.

See next our several sects—but
first behold
The Church of Rome, who here is
poor and old:
Use not triumphant rail'ry, or, at least,
Let not thy mother be a whore and
beast.

120

Great was her pride indeed in ancient
times;
Yet shall we think of nothing but her
crimes?
Exalted high above all earthly things,
She placed her foot upon the neck of
kings;
But some have deeply since avenged
the crown,
And thrown her glory and her
honours down;
Nor neck nor ear can she of kings
command,
Nor place a foot upon her own fair
land.

Among her sons, with us a quiet
few,
Obscure themselves, her ancient state
review;

130

And fond and melancholy glances
cast

On power insulted, and on triumph
pass'd:

They look, they can but look, with
many a sigh,

On sacred buildings doom'd in dust to
lie;

"On seats," they tell, "where priests
'mid tapers dim

Breathed the warm prayer, or tuned
the midnight hymn;

Where trembling penitents their guilt
confess'd;

Where want had succour, and
contrition rest.

There weary men from trouble found
relief,

There men in sorrow found repose
from grief;

140

To scenes like these the fainting soul
retired;

Revenge and anger in these cells
expired;

By pity soothed, remorse lost half her
fears,

And soften'd pride dropp'd penitential
tears.

Then convent-walls and nunnery-
spires arose,

In pleasant spots which monk or
 abbot chose;
When counts and barons saints
 devoted fed,
And, making cheap exchange, had
 pray'r for bread.

Now all is lost; the earth where
 abbeys stood
Is layman's land, the glebe, the
 stream, the wood;

150

His oxen low where monks retired to
 eat;
His cows repose upon the prior's seat;
And wanton doves within the
 cloisters bill,
Where the chaste votary warr'd with
 wanton will."

Such is the change they mourn, but
 they restrain
The rage of grief, and passively
 complain.

We've Baptists old and new;
 forbear to ask
What the distinction—I decline the
 task.

This I perceive, that, when a sect
 grows old,
Converts are few, and the converted
 cold:

160

First comes the hot-bed heat, and,
 while it glows,
The plants spring up, and each with
 vigour grows;
Then comes the cooler day, and,
 though awhile

The verdure prospers and the
blossoms smile,
Yet poor the fruit, and form'd by long
delay,
Nor will the profits for the culture
pay;
The skilful gard'ner then no longer
stops,
But turns to other beds for bearing
crops.

Some Swedenborgians in our
streets are found,
Those wandering walkers on
enchanted ground;

170

Who in our world can other worlds
survey,
And speak with spirits, though
confined in clay:
Of Bible-mysteries they the keys
possess,
Assured themselves, where wiser
men but guess:
'Tis theirs to see—around, about,
above—
How spirits mingle thoughts, and
angels move;
Those whom our grosser views from
us exclude,
To them appear a heavenly multitude;
While the dark sayings, seal'd to men
like us,
Their priests interpret, and their
flocks discuss.

180

But while these gifted men, a
favoured fold,

New powers exhibit and new worlds
 behold;
Is there not danger lest their minds
 confound
The pure above them with the gross
 around?
May not these Phaetons, who thus
 contrive
'Twixt heaven above and earth
 beneath to drive,
When from their flaming chariots
 they descend,
The worlds they visit in their fancies
 blend?
Alas! too sure on both they bring
 disgrace;
Their earth is crazy, and their heav'n
 is base.

190

 We have, it seems, who treat, and
 doubtless well,
Of a chastising, not awarding hell;
Who are assured that an offended
 God
Will cease to use the thunder and the
 rod;
A soul on earth, by crime and folly
 stain'd,
When here corrected, has
 improvement gain'd—
In other state still more improved to
 grow,
And nobler powers in happier world
 to know;
New strength to use in each divine
 employ,

And, more enjoying, looking to more
joy.

200

A pleasing vision! could we thus
be sure
Polluted souls would be at length so
pure;
The view is happy, we may think it
just,
It may be true—but who shall add it
must?
To the plain words and sense of
sacred writ,
With all my heart I reverently submit;
But, where it leaves me doubtful, I'm
afraid
To call conjecture to my reason's aid;
Thy thoughts, thy ways, great God!
are not as mine,
And to thy mercy I my soul resign.

210

Jews are with us, but far unlike to
those,
Who, led by David, warr'd with
Israel's foes;
Unlike to those whom his imperial
son
Taught truths divine—the preacher
Solomon:
Nor war nor wisdom yield our Jews
delight;
They will not study, and they dare not
fight^[45].
These are, with us, a slavish,
knaveish crew,
Shame and dishonour to the name of
Jew;

The poorest masters of the meanest
arts,
With cunning heads, and cold and
cautious hearts;

220

They grope their dirty way to petty
gains,
While poorly paid for their nefarious
pains.

Amazing race! deprived of land
and laws,
A general language, and a public
cause;
With a religion none can now obey,
With a reproach that none can take
away:
A people still, whose common ties are
gone;
Who, mix'd with every race, are lost
in none.

What said their prophet?
—"Shouldst thou disobey,
The Lord shall take thee from thy
land away;

230

Thou shalt a by-word and a proverb
be,
And all shall wonder at thy woes and
thee;
Daughter and son shalt thou, while
captive, have,
And see them made the bond-maid
and the slave;
He, whom thou leav'st, the Lord thy
God, shall bring
War to thy country on an eagle-wing:

A people strong and dreadful to
 behold,
Stern to the young, remorseless to the
 old;
Masters, whose speech thou canst not
 understand,
By cruel signs shall give the harsh
 command;

240

Doubtful of life shalt thou by night,
 by day,
For grief, and dread, and trouble pine
 away;
Thy evening-wish,—'Would God I
 saw the sun!'
Thy morning-sigh,—'Would God the
 day were done!'
Thus shalt thou suffer, and to distant
 times
Regret thy misery, and lament thy
 crimes^[46]."

A part there are, whom doubtless
 man might trust,
Worthy as wealthy, pure, religious,
 just;
They who with patience, yet with
 rapture look
On the strong promise of the sacred
 book:

250

As unfulfilled th' endearing words
 they view,
And blind to truth, yet own their
 prophets true;
Well pleased they look for Sion's
 coming state,

Nor think of Julian's boast and
Julian's fate^[47].

More might I add; I might describe
the flocks
Made by seceders from the ancient
stocks;
Those who will not to any guide
submit,
Nor find one creed to their
conceptions fit,
Each sect, they judge, in something
goes astray,
And every church has lost the certain
way;

260

Then for themselves they carve out
creed and laws,
And weigh their atoms, and divide
their straws.

A sect remains, }
which }
though }
divided long }

In hostile parties, both are
fierce and strong,
And into each enlists a warm
and zealous throng.

Soon as they rose in }
fame, the strife }
arose, }

The Calvinistic these, th'
Arminian those;

With Wesley some remained,
the remnant Whitfield chose.

Now various leaders both the parties
take,

And the divided hosts their new
divisions make.

270

See yonder preacher to his people
pass,
Borne up and swell'd by tabernacle-
gas;
Much he discourses, and of various
points,
All unconnected, void of limbs and
joints;
He rails, persuades, explains, and
moves the will,
By fierce bold words, and strong
mechanic skill.

"That Gospel Paul with zeal and
love maintain'd,
To others lost, to you is now
explain'd;
No worldly learning can these points
discuss,
Books teach them not as they are
taught to us.

280

Illiterate call us! let their wisest man
Draw forth his thousands as your
teacher can:
They give their moral precepts; so,
they say,
Did Epictetus once, and Seneca;
One was a slave, and slaves we all
must be,
Until the Spirit comes and sets us
free,
Yet hear you nothing from such men
but works;

They make the Christian service like
the Turks'.

"Hark to the churchman: day by
day he cries,—
'Children of men, be virtuous and be
wise;

290

Seek patience, justice, temp'rance,
meekness, truth;
In age be courteous, be sedate in
youth.'—

So they advise, and when such things
be read,
How can we wonder that their flocks
are dead?

"The heathens wrote of virtue, they
could dwell
On such light points—in them it
might be well,
They might for virtue strive; but I
maintain,
Our strife for virtue would be proud
and vain.

When Samson carried Gaza's gates so
far,
Lack'd he a helping hand to bear the
bar?

300

Thus the most virtuous must in
bondage groan:
Samson is grace, and carries all
alone^[48].

"Hear you not priests their feeble
spirits spend
In bidding sinners turn to God, and
mend;

To check their passions, and to walk
aright;

To run the race, and fight the glorious
fight?

Nay more—to pray, to study, to
improve,

To grow in goodness, to advance in
love?

"Oh! babes and sucklings, dull of
heart and slow,

Can grace be gradual? Can
conversion grow?

310

The work is done by instantaneous
call;

Converts at once are made, or not at
all;

Nothing is left to grow, reform,
amend;

The first emotion is the movement's
end:

If once forgiven, debt can be no
more;

If once adopted, will the heir be
poor?

The man who gains the twenty-
thousand prize,

Does he by little and by little rise?

There can no fortune for the soul be
made

By peddling cares and savings in her
trade.

320

"Why are our sins forgiven?—
Priests reply,

—'Because by faith on mercy we
rely;

Because, believing, we repent and
pray,'—
Is this their doctrine?—then, they go
astray:
We're pardon'd neither for belief nor
deed,
For faith nor practice, principle nor
creed;
Nor for our sorrow for our former sin,
Nor for our fears when better
thoughts begin;
Nor prayers nor penance in the cause
avail;
All strong remorse, all soft contrition
fail:—

330

It is the *call!* till that proclaims us
free,
In darkness, doubt, and bondage we
must be;
Till that *assures* us, we've in vain
endured,
And all is over when we're once
assured.

"This is conversion:—First, there
comes a cry
Which utters, 'Sinner, thou'rt
condemned to die;'
Then the struck soul to every aid
repairs,
To church and altar, ministers and
prayers;
In vain she strives—involved,
ingulf'd in sin,
She looks for hell, and seems already
in:

340

When in this travail, the new birth
comes on,
And in an instant every pang is gone;
The mighty work is done without our
pains—
Claim but a part, and not a part
remains.

"All this experience }
tells the }
soul, and yet
These moral men their pence
and farthings set
Against the terrors of the
countless debt.
But such compounders, when they
come to jail,
Will find that virtues never serve as
bail.

"So much to duties; now to
learning look,
350
And see their priesthood piling book
on book;
Yea, books of infidels, we're told, and
plays,
Put out by heathens in the wink'd-on
days;
The very letters are of crooked kind,
And show the strange perverseness of
their mind.
Have I this learning? When the Lord
would speak,
Think ye he needs the Latin or the
Greek?
And lo! with all their learning, when
they rise

To preach, in view the ready sermon
lies;

Some low-prized stuff they purchased
at the stalls,

360

And more like Seneca's than mine or
Paul's.

Children of bondage, how should
they explain

The spirit's freedom, while they wear
a chain?

They study words, for meanings grow
perplex'd,

And slowly hunt for truth, from text
to text,

Through Greek and Hebrew—we the
meaning seek

Of that within, who every tongue can
speak.

This all can witness; yet the more I
know,

The more a meek and humble mind I
show.

"No; let the Pope, the high and
mighty priest,

370

Lord to the poor, and servant to the
Beast,

Let bishops, deans, and prebendaries
swell

With pride and fatness till their hearts
rebel:

I'm meek and modest.—If I could be
proud,

This crowded meeting, lo! th'
amazing crowd!

Your mute attention, and your meek
respect,
My spirit's fervour, and my words'
effect:
Might stir th' unguarded soul; and oft
to me
The tempter speaks, whom I compel
to flee;
He goes in fear, for he my force has
tried—

380

Such is my power! but can you call it
pride?

"No, fellow-pilgrims! of the things
I've shown
I might be proud, were they indeed
my own!

But they are lent; and well you know
the source

Of all that's mine, and must confide
of course;

Mine! no, I err; 'tis but consign'd to
me,

And I am nought but steward and
trustee."

FAR other doctrines yon Arminian
speaks;

"Seek grace," he cries; "for he shall
find who seeks."

This is the ancient stock by Wesley
led—

390

They the pure body, he the reverend
head;

All innovation they with dread
decline;

Their John the elder was the John
divine.

Hence still their moving prayer, the
melting hymn,

The varied accent, and the active
limb;

Hence that implicit faith in Satan's
might,

And their own matchless prowess in
the fight.

In every act they see that lurking foe,
Let loose awhile, about the world to
go:—

A dragon, flying round the earth, to
kill

400

The heavenly hope, and prompt the
carnal will;

Whom sainted knights attack in
sinners' cause,

And force the wounded victim from
his paws;

Who but for them would man's whole
race subdue;

For not a hireling will the foe pursue.

"Show me one }
Churchman }
who will rise
and pray

Through half the night,
though lab'ring all the day,

Always abounding—show me
him, I say."—

Thus cries the preacher, and he adds,
"their sheep

Satan devours at leisure as they sleep.

410

Not so with us; we drive him from
the fold,
For ever barking and for ever bold;
While they securely slumber, all his
schemes
Take full effect—the devil never
dreams:
Watchful and changeful through the
world he goes,
And few can trace this deadliest of
their foes;
But I detect, and at his work surprise,
The subtle serpent under all disguise.

"Thus to man's soul the foe of
souls will speak,
—'A saint elect, you can have nought
to seek;

420

Why all this labour in so plain a case
—

Such care to run, when certain of the
race?'

All this he urges to the carnal will;
He knows you're slothful, and would
have you still.

Be this your answer,—'Satan, I will
keep

Still on the watch till you are laid
asleep.'

Thus too the Christian's progress he'll
retard:—

'The gates of mercy are for ever
barr'd,

And that with bolts so driven and so
stout,

Ten thousand workmen cannot
wrench them out,'

430

To this deceit you have but one reply

—

Give to the father of all lies, the lie.

"A sister's weakness he'll by fits
surprise—

His her wild laughter, his her piteous
cries;

And, should a pastor at her side
attend,

He'll use her organs to abuse her
friend.

These are possessions—unbelieving
wits

Impute them all to nature: 'They're
her fits,

Caused by commotions in the nerves
and brains.'—

Vain talk! but they'll be fitted for their
pains.

440

"These are in part the ills the foe
has wrought,

And these the churchman thinks not
worth his thought;

They bid the troubled try for peace
and rest,

Compose their minds, and be no more
distress'd;

As well might they command the
passive shore

To keep secure, and be o'erflow'd no
more;

To the wrong subject is their skill
applied—

To act like workmen, they should
stem the tide.

"These are the church-physicians;
they are paid
With noble fees for their advice and
aid;

450

Yet know they not the inward pulse to
feel,
To ease the anguish, or the wound to
heal.

With the sick sinner thus their work
begins:

'Do you repent you of your former
sins?

Will you amend if you revive and
live,

And, pardon seeking, will you pardon
give?

Have you belief in what your Lord
has done,

And are you thankful?—all is well,
my son.'

"A way far different ours—we thus
surprise

A soul with questions, and demand
replies;

460

"'How dropp'd you first,' I ask, 'the
legal yoke?

What the first word the living
Witness spoke?

Perceived you thunders roar and
lightnings shine,

And tempests gathering ere the birth
divine?

Did fire, and storm, and earthquake
all appear

Before that still small voice, *What
dost thou here?*

Hast thou by day and night, and soon
and late,

Waited and watch'd before
Admission-gate;

And so, a pilgrim and a soldier, pass'd
To Sion's hill through battle and
through blast?

470

Then, in thy way didst thou thy foe
attack,

And mad'st thou proud Apollyon turn
his back?

"Heart-searching things are these,
and shake the mind,

Yea, like the rustling of a mighty
wind.

"Thus would I ask:—'Nay, let me
question now,

How sink my sayings in your
bosoms? how?

Feel you a quickening? drops the
subject deep?

Stupid and stony, no! you're all
asleep;

Listless and lazy, waiting for a close,
As if at church—Do I allow repose?

480

Am I a legal minister? do I

With form or rubrick, rule or rite,
comply?

Then, whence this quiet, tell me, I
beseech?

One might believe you heard your
rector preach,

Or his assistant dreamer;—Oh!
return,
Ye times of burning, when the heart
would burn.
Now hearts are ice, and you, my
freezing fold,
Have spirits sunk and sad, and
bosoms stony-cold,'
"Oh! now again for those
prevailing powers,
Which once began this mighty work
of ours;

490

When the wide field, God's temple,
was the place,
And birds flew by to catch a breath of
grace;
When 'mid his timid friends and
threat'ning foes,
Our zealous chief as Paul at Athens
rose:
When with infernal spite and knotty
clubs
The ill-one arm'd his scoundrels and
his scrubs;
And there were flying all around the
spot
Brands at the preacher, but they
touch'd him not;
Stakes brought to smite him,
threaten'd in his cause,
And tongues, attuned to curses, roar'd
applause;

500

Louder and louder grew his awful
tones,

Sobbing and sighs were heard, and
rueful groans;
Soft women fainted, prouder man
express'd
Wonder and wo, and butchers smote
the breast;
Eyes wept, ears tingled; stiff'ning on
each head,
The hair drew back, and Satan howl'd
and fled.

"In that soft season, when the
gentle breeze
Rises all round, and swells by slow
degrees;
Till tempests gather, when through all
the sky
The thunders rattle, and the lightnings
fly;

510

When rain in torrents wood and vale
deform,
And all is horror, hurricane, and
storm:
So, when the preacher in that glorious
time,
Than clouds more melting, more than
storm sublime,
Dropp'd the new word, there came a
charm around;
Tremors and terrors rose upon the
sound;
The stubborn spirits by his force he
broke,
As the fork'd lightning rives the
knotted oak.
Fear, hope, dismay, all signs of shame
or grace,

Chain'd every foot, or featured every
face;

520

Then took his sacred trump a louder
swell,

And now they groan'd they sicken'd,
and they fell;

Again he sounded, and we heard the
cry

Of the word-wounded, as about to
die;

Further and further spread the
conquering word,

As loud he cried—"the battle of the
Lord."

Ev'n those apart who were the sound
denied,

Fell down instinctive, and in spirit
died.

Nor [stay'd] he yet—his eye, his
frown, his speech,

His very gesture had a power to
teach;

530

With outstretch'd arms, strong voice
and piercing call,

He won the field, and made the
Dagons fall;

And thus in triumph took his glorious
way,

Through scenes of horror, terror, and
dismay."

NOTES TO LETTER IV.

[44] Note 1, page 315, line 55.

*May those excel by Solway-Moss
destroy'd.*

For an account of this extraordinary and interesting event, I refer my readers to the Journals of the year 1772.

[45] Note 2, page 319, line 315.

*They will not study, and they dare not
fight.*

Some may object to this assertion; to whom I beg leave to answer, that I do not use the word *fight* in the sense of the Jew Mendoza.

[46] Note 3, page 320, line 245.

*Regret thy misery, and lament thy
crimes.*

See the Book of Deuteronomy, chapter [xxviii.] and various other places.

[47] Note 4, page 320, line 253.

*Nor think of Julian's boast and Julian's
fate.*

His boast, that he would rebuild the Temple at Jerusalem; his fate (whatever becomes of the miraculous part of the story), that he died before the foundation was laid.

[48] Note 5, page 331, line 301

Samson is grace, and carries all alone.

Whoever has attended to the books or preaching of these enthusiastic people, must have observed much of this kind of absurd and foolish application of scripture history; it seems to them as reasoning.

LETTER V.

ELECTIONS.

Say then which class to greater folly
stoop,
The great in promise, or the poor in
hope?

brave, for your [captain] is brave, and vows reformation; there shall be in England seven halfpenny loaves sold for a penny; the three-hooped pot shall have ten hoops[; and] I will make it felony to drink small beer[...] all shall eat and drink on my score, and I will apparel them all in one livery, that they may agree like brothers, and worship me their lord.

Shakspeare's Henry
VI. [Part I. Act IV. Sc.
2.]

Evils of the Contest, and how in part to be avoided—The Miseries endured by a Friend of the Candidate—The various Liberties taken with him, who has no personal Interest in the Success—The unreasonable Expectations of Voters—The Censures of the opposing Party—The Vices as well as Follies shown in such Time of Contest—Plans and Cunning of Electors—Evils which remain after the Decision, opposed in vain by the Efforts of the Friendly, and of the Successful; among whom is the Mayor—Story of his Advancement till he was raised to the Government of the Borough—These Evils not to be placed in Balance with the Liberty of the People, but are yet Subjects of just Complaint.

LETTER V.

THE ELECTION.

Yes, our Election's past, and we've
 been free,
Somewhat as madmen without
 keepers be;
And such desire of freedom has been
 shown,
That both the parties wish'd her all
 their own:
All our free smiths and cobblers in
 the town
Were loth to lay such pleasant
 freedom down—
To put the bludgeon and cockade
 aside,
And let us pass unhurt and undefied.
 True! you might then your party's
 sign produce,

And so escape with only half th'
abuse—
With half the danger as you walk'd
along,
With rage and threat'ning but from
half the throng.
This you might do, and not your
fortune mend;
For where you lost a foe, you gain'd a
friend;
And, to distress you, vex you, and
expose,
Election-friends are worse than any
foes;
The party-curse is with the canvass
past,
But party-friendship, for your grief,
will last.
Friends of all kinds, the civil and
the rude,

20

Who humbly wish, or boldly dare t'
intrude:
These beg or take a liberty to come
(Friends should be free), and make
your house their home;
They know that warmly you their
cause espouse,
And come to make their boastings
and their bows.
You scorn their manners, you their
words mistrust;
But you must hear them, and they
know you must.
One plainly sees a friendship firm
and true
Between the noble candidate and you;

So humbly begs (and states at large
the case),

30

"You'll think of Bobby and the little
place."

Stifling his shame by drink, a
wretch will come,
And prate your wife and daughter
from the room:

In pain you hear him, and at heart
despise,

Yet with heroic mind your pangs
disguise;

And still in patience to the sot attend,
To show what man can bear to serve a
friend.

One enters hungry—not to be
denied,
And takes his place and jokes
—"We're of a side."

Yet worse, the proser who, upon the
strength

40

Of his one vote, has tales of three
hours' length—

This sorry rogue you bear, yet with
surprise

Start at his oaths, and sicken at his
lies.

Then comes there one, and tells in
friendly way,
What the opponents in their anger
say;

All that through life has vex'd you, all
abuse,

Will this kind friend in pure regard
produce;

And, having through your own
offences run,
Adds (as appendage) what your
friends have done.

Has any female cousin made a trip
50
To Gretna-Green, or more vexatious
slip?

Has your wife's brother, or your
uncle's son,
Done aught amiss, or is he thought t'
have done?

Is there of all your kindred some who
lack

Vision direct, or have a gibbous
back?

From your unlucky name may quips
and puns

Be made by these upbraiding Goths
and Huns?

To some great public character have
you

Assign'd the fame to worth and
talents due,

Proud of your praise?—In this, in any
case,

60
Where the brute-spirit may affix
disgrace,

These friends will smiling bring it,
and the while

You silent sit, and practise for a
smile.

Vain of their power, and of their
value sure,
They nearly guess the tortures you
endure;

Nor spare one pang—for they
perceive your heart
Goes with the cause; you'd die before
you'd start;
Do what they may, they're sure you'll
not offend
Men who have pledged their honours
to your friend.

Those friends indeed, who start as
in a race,

70

May love the sport, and laugh at this
disgrace;
They have in view the glory and the
prize,
Nor heed the dirty steps by which
they rise:
But we, their poor associates, lose the
fame,
Though more than partners in the toil
and shame.

Were this the whole, and did the
time produce
But shame and toil, but riot and
abuse:
We might be then from serious griefs
exempt,
And view the whole with pity and
contempt,
Alas! but here the vilest passions
rule;

80

It is Seduction's, is Temptation's
school:
Where vices mingle in the oddest
ways,

The grossest slander and the dirtiest
praise;
Flattery enough to make the vainest
sick,
And clumsy stratagem, and scoundrel
trick.
Nay more, your anger and contempt
to cause,
These, while they fish for profit,
claim applause;
Bribed, bought and bound, they
banish shame and fear;
Tell you they're stanch, and have a
soul sincere;
Then talk of honour, and, if doubt's
express'd,

90

Show where it lies, and smite upon
the breast.

Among these worthies, some at
first declare
For whom they vote; he then has
most to spare.
Others hang off—when coming to the
post
Is spurring time, and then he'll spare
the most;
While some, demurring, wait, and
find at last
The bidding languish, and the market
pass'd;
These will affect all bribery to
condemn,
And, be it Satan laughs, he laughs at
them.

Some too are pious—one desired
the Lord

100

To teach him where "to drop his little
word;
To lend his vote, where it will profit
best;
Promotion came not from the east or
west;
But as their freedom had promoted
some,
He should be glad to know which
way 'twould come,
It was a naughty world, and, where to
sell
His precious charge, was more than
he could tell."

"But you succeeded?"—true, at
mighty cost;
And our good friend, I fear, will think
he's lost.
Inns, horses, chaises, dinners, balls
and notes;

110

What fill'd their purses, and what
drench'd their throats;
The private pension, and indulgent
lease,
Have all been granted to these friends
who fleece—
Friends who will hang like burs upon
his coat,
And boundless judge the value of a
vote.

And, though the terrors of the time
be pass'd,
There still remain the scatterings of
the blast.

The boughs are parted that entwined
before,

And ancient harmony exists no more;
The gusts of wrath our peaceful seats
deform,

120

And sadly flows the sighing of the
storm:

Those who have gain'd are sorry for
the gloom,

But they who lost unwilling peace
should come;

There open envy, here suppress'd
delight,

Yet live till time shall better thoughts
excite,

And so prepare us, by a six-years'
truce,

Again for riot, insult, and abuse.

Our worthy mayor, on the
victorious part,

Cries out for peace, and cries with all
his heart;

He, civil creature! ever does his best,

130

To banish wrath from every voter's
breast;

"For where," says he, with reason
strong and plain,

"Where is the profit? what will anger
gain?"

His short stout person he is wont to
brace

In good brown broad-cloth, edged
with two-inch lace,

When in his seat; and still the coat
seems new,

Preserved by common use of
seaman's blue.

He was a fisher from his earliest
day,
And placed his nets within the
Borough's bay;
Where by his skates, his herrings, and
his soles,

140

He lived, nor dream'd of corporation-
doles^[49];

But, toiling, saved and, saving, never
ceased

Till he had box'd up twelve score
pounds at least.

He knew not money's power, but
judged it best

Safe in his trunk to let his treasure
rest;

Yet to a friend complain'd: "Sad
charge, to keep

So many pounds, and then I cannot
sleep."

"Then put it out," replied the friend.
—"What, give

My money up? why, then I could not
live."—

"Nay, but for interest place it in his
hands,

150

Who'll give you mortgage on his
house or lands."—

"Oh but," said Daniel, "that's a
dangerous plan;

He may be robb'd like any other
man."—

"Still he is bound, and you may be at
rest,
More safe the money than within
your chest;
And you'll receive, from all
deductions clear,
Five pounds for every hundred, every
year."—

"What good in that?" quoth Daniel,
"for 'tis plain,
If part I take, there can but part
remain."—

"What! you, my friend, so skill'd in
gainful things,

160

Have you to learn what interest
money brings?"—

"Not so," said Daniel, "perfectly I
know,

He's the most interest who has most
to show."—

"True! and he'll show the more, the
more he lends;

Thus he his weight and consequence
extends;

For they who borrow must restore
each sum,

And pay for use—What, Daniel, art
thou dumb?"

For much amazed was that good man
—"Indeed!"

Said he, with glad'ning eye, "will
money breed?

How have I lived? I grieve, with all
my heart,

170

For my late knowledge in this
precious art:—

Five pounds for every hundred will
he give?

And then the hundred?——I begin to
live."—

So he began, and other means he
found,

As he went on, to multiply a pound:
Though blind so long to interest, all
allow

That no man better understands it
now.

Him in our body-corporate we chose,
And, once among us, he above us
rose;

Stepping from post to post, he reach'd
the chair,

180

And there he now reposes—that's the
mayor.

But 'tis not he, 'tis not the kinder
few,

The mild, the good, who can our
peace renew;

A peevish humour swells in every
eye,

The warm are angry, and the cool are
shy;

There is no more the social board at
whist.

The good old partners are with scorn
dismiss'd;

No more with dog and lantern comes
the maid,

To guide the mistress when the
rubber's play'd;

Sad shifts are made, lest ribbons blue
and green

190

Should at one table, at one time be
seen.

On care and merit none will now rely,
'Tis party sells what party-friends
must buy;

The warmest burgess wears a
bodger's coat,

And fashion gains less int'rest than a
vote;

Uncheck'd, the vintner still his poison
vends;

For he too votes, and can command
his friends.

But, this admitted, be it still
agreed,

These ill effects from noble cause
proceed;

Though like some vile }
excrescences }
they be,

200

The tree they spring from is a sacred
tree,

And its true produce, strength
and liberty.

Yet if we could th' attendant ills
suppress;

If we could make the sum of mischief
less;

If we could warm and angry men
persuade

No more man's common comforts to
invade;

And that old ease and harmony re-
seat
In all our meetings, so in joy to meet:
Much would of glory to the Muse
ensue,
And our good vicar would have less
to do.

NOTE TO LETTER V.

[49] Note 1, page 333, line 140.

*He lived, nor dreamed of corporation-
doles.*

I am informed that some explanation is here necessary, though I am ignorant for what class of my readers it can be required. Some corporate bodies have actual property, as appears by their receiving rents; and they obtain money on the admission of members into their society: this they may lawfully share perhaps. There are, moreover, other doles, of still greater value, of which it is not necessary for me to explain the nature, or to inquire into the legality.

LETTER VI.

PROFESSIONS—LAW.

Quid leges sine
moribus
Vanæ proficiunt?

Horace

[Lib
. III.
Od.
XXI
V.
vv.
35-
6].

Væ misero
mih
i!

Mea nunc facinora aperiuntur, clam quæ
speravi fore.

[Plaut.

*Tru
cul.
Act
IV.
Sc.
3,
vv.
20-
1].*

les and Professions of every Kind to be found in the Borough—Its Seamen and Soldiers—Law, the Danger of the Subject—Coddington's Offence—Attorneys increased; their splendid Appearance, how supported—Some worthy Exceptions—Spirit of Litigation, how stirred up—A Boy articled as a Clerk; his Ideas—How this Profession perverts the Judgment—Actions appear through this Medium in a false Light—Success from honest Application—Archer a worthy Character—Swallow a Character of different Kind—His Origin, Progress, Success, &c.

LETTER VI.

PROFESSIONS—LAW.

"Trades and Professions"—these
are themes the Muse,
Left to her freedom, would forbear to
choose;
But to our Borough they in truth
belong,
And we, perforce, must take them in
our song.
Be it then known that we can boast
of these

In all denominations, ranks, degrees;
All who our numerous }
 wants through }
 life supply,
Who soothe us sick, attend us
 when we die,
Or for the dead their various
 talents try.

10

Then have we those who live by
 secret arts,
By hunting fortunes, and by stealing
 hearts;
Or who by nobler means themselves
 advance;
Or who subsist by charity and chance.
Say, of our native heroes shall I
 boast,
Born in our streets, to thunder on our
 coast—
Our Borough-seamen? Could the
 timid Muse
More patriot-ardour in their breasts
 infuse;
Or could she paint their merit or their
 skill,
She wants not love, alacrity, or will;

20

But needless all: that ardour is their
 own,
And, for their deeds, themselves have
 made them known.
Soldiers in arms! }
 Defenders of }
 our soil!
Who from destruction save
 us; who from spoil

Protect the sons of peace who
 traffic, or who toil:
Would I could duly praise you; that
 each deed
Your foes might honour, and your
 friends might read:
This too is needless; you've imprinted
 well
Your powers, and told what I should
 feebly tell.
Beside, a Muse like mine, to satire
 prone,

30

Would fail in themes where there is
 praise alone.

—Law shall I sing, or what to Law
 belongs?

Alas! there may be danger in such
 songs;

A foolish rhyme, 'tis said, a trifling
 thing,

The law found treason, for it touch'd
 the king.

But kings have mercy in these happy
 times,

Or surely *one* had suffer'd for his
 rhymes;

Our glorious Edwards and our Henrys
 bold,

So touch'd, had kept the reprobate in
 hold;

But he escaped—nor fear, thank
 Heav'n, have I,

40

Who love my king, for such offence
 to die.

But I am taught the danger would be
much,
If these poor lines should one
attorney touch—
(One of those *limbs* of law who're
always here;
The *heads* come down to guide them
twice a year.)
I might not swing indeed; but he in
sport
Would whip a rhymers on from court
to court;
Stop him in each, and make him pay
for all
The long proceedings in that dreaded
Hall.—
Then let my numbers flow discreetly
on,

50

Warn'd by the fate of luckless
Coddington^[50];
Lest some *attorney* (pardon me the
name)
Should wound a poor *solicitor* for
fame.

One man of law in George the
Second's reign
Was all our frugal fathers would
maintain;
He too was kept for forms; a man of
peace,
To frame a contract, or to draw a
lease:
He had a clerk, with whom he used to
write
All the day long, with whom he drank
at night;

Spare was his visage, moderate his
bill,

60

And he so kind, men doubted of his
skill.

Who thinks of this, with some
amazement sees,
For one so poor, three flourishing at
ease—

Nay, one in splendour!—See that
mansion tall,

That lofty door, the far-resounding
hall;

Well-furnish'd rooms, plate shining
on the board,

Gay liveried lads, and cellar proudly
stored:

Then say how comes it that such
fortunes crown

These sons of strife, these terrors of
the town?

Lo! that small office! there th'
incautious guest

70

Goes blindfold in, and that maintains
the rest;

There in his web th' observant spider
lies,

And peers about for fat intruding
flies;

Doubtful at first, he hears the distant
hum,

And feels them flutt'ring as they
nearer come.

They buzz and blink, and doubtfully
they tread

On the strong birdlime of the utmost
thread;
But, when they're once entangled by
the gin,
With what an eager clasp he draws
them in;
Nor shall they 'scape till after long
delay,

80

And all that sweetens life is drawn
away.

"Nay, this," you cry, "is common-
place, the tale
Of petty tradesmen o'er their evening-
ale.

There are who, living by the legal
pen,
Are held in honour—'honourable
men.'"

Doubtless—there are, who hold
manorial courts,
Or whom the trust of powerful
friends supports;
Or who, by labouring through a
length of time,
Have pick'd their way, unsullied by a
crime.

These are the few—in this, in every
place,

90

Fix the litigious rupture-stirring race:
Who to contention as to trade are led,
To whom dispute and strife are bliss
and bread.

There is a doubtful pauper, and we
think

'Tis with us to give him meat and
drink;
There is a child, and 'tis not mighty
clear
Whether the mother lived with us a
year;
A road's indicted, and our seniors
doubt
If in our proper boundary or without:
But what says our attorney? He our
friend

100

Tells us 'tis just and manly to
contend.

"What! to a neighbouring parish
yield your cause,
While you have money, and the
nation laws?
What! lose without a trial, that which
tried,
May—nay it must—be given on our
side?
All men of spirit would contend; such
men
Than lose a pound would rather
hazard ten.

What! be imposed on? No! a British
soul
Despises imposition, hates control;
The law is open; let them, if they
dare,

110

Support their cause; the Borough
need not spare.
All I advise is vigour and good-will:
Is it agreed then?—Shall I file a bill?"

The trader, grazier, merchant,
priest, and all
Whose sons aspiring to [professions']
call,
Choose from their lads some bold and
subtle boy,
And judge him fitted for this grave
employ.
Him a keen old practitioner admits,
To write five years and exercise his
wits:
The youth has heard—it is in fact his
creed—

120

Mankind dispute, that lawyers may
be fee'd:
Jails, bailiffs, writs, all terms and
threats of law,
Grow now familiar as once top and
taw;
Rage, hatred, fear, the mind's severer
ills,
All bring employment, all augment
his bills;
As feels the surgeon for the mangled
limb,
The mangled mind is but a job for
him;
Thus taught to think, these legal
reasoners draw
Morals and maxims from their views
of law;
They cease to judge by precepts
taught in schools,

130

By man's plain sense, or by religious
rules;

No! nor by law itself, in truth
discern'd,
But as its statutes may be warp'd and
turn'd.
How they should judge of man, his
word and deed,
They in their books and not their
bosoms read:
Of some good act you speak with just
applause,
"No! no!" says he, "'twould be a
losing cause."
Blame you some tyrant's deed?—he
answers, "Nay,
He'll get a verdict; heed you what you
say."
Thus, to conclusions from examples
led,

140

The heart resigns all judgment to the
head;
Law, law alone, for ever kept in view,
His measures guides, and rules his
conscience too;
Of ten commandments, he confesses
three
Are yet in force, and tells you which
they be,
As law instructs him, thus: "Your
neighbour's wife
You must not take, his chattels, nor
his life;
Break these decrees, for damage you
must pay;
These you must reverence, and the
rest—you may."

Law was design'd to keep a state in
peace;

150

To punish robbery, that wrong might
cease;
To be impregnable—a constant fort,
To which the weak and injured might
resort.

But these perverted minds its force
employ,
Not to protect mankind, but to annoy;
And, long as ammunition can be
found,
Its lightning flashes and its thunders
sound.

Or, law with lawyers is an ample
still,
Wrought by the passions' heat with
chymic sill;
While the fire burns, the gains are
quickly made,

160

And freely flow the profits of the
trade;
Nay, when the }
fierceness fails, }
these artists
blow

The dying fire, and make the
embers glow,
As long as they can make the
smaller profits flow;
At length the process of itself will
stop,
When they perceive they've drawn
out every drop.

Yet, I repeat, there are, who nobly
strive
To keep the sense of moral worth
alive:
Men who would starve, ere meanly
deign to live
On what deception and chican'ry
give;

170

And these at length succeed: they
have their strife,
Their apprehensions, stops, and rubs
in life;
But honour, application, care, and
skill,
Shall bend opposing fortune to their
will.

Of such is Archer, he who keeps in
awe
Contending parties by his threats of
law.
He, roughly honest, has been long a
guide
In Borough-business, on the
conquering side;
And seen so much of both sides, and
so long,
He thinks the bias of man's mind goes
wrong.

180

Thus, though he's friendly, he is still
severe,
Surly though kind, suspiciously
sincere:
So much he's seen of baseness in the
mind,

That, while a friend to man, he scorns
mankind;
He knows the human heart, and sees
with dread,
By slight temptation, how the strong
are led;
He knows how interest can asunder
rend
The bond of parent, master, guardian,
friend,
To form a new and a degrading tie
'Twixt needy vice and tempting
villany.

190

Sound in himself, yet, when such
flaws appear,
He doubts of all, and learns that self
to fear:
For, where so dark the moral view is
grown,
A timid conscience trembles for her
own;
The pitchy taint of general vice is
such
As daubs the fancy, and you dread the
touch.

Far unlike him was one in former
times,
Famed for the spoil he gather'd by his
crimes;
Who, while his brethren nibbling held
their prey,
He like an eagle seized and bore the
whole away.

200

Swallow, a poor attorney, brought
his boy

Up at his desk, and gave him his
employ;
He would have bound him to an
honest trade,
Could preparations have been duly
made.
The clerkship ended, both the sire and
son
Together did what business could be
done;
Sometimes they'd luck to stir up
small disputes
Among their friends, and raise them
into suits.
Though close and hard, the father was
content
With this resource, now old and
indolent;

210

But his young Swallow, gaping and
alive
To fiercer feelings, was resolved to
thrive:—
"Father," he said, "but little can they
win
Who hunt in couples, where the game
is thin;
Let's part in peace, and each pursue
his gain
Where it may start—our love may yet
remain."
The parent growl'd, he couldn't think
that love
Made the young cockatrice his den
remove;
But, taught by habit, he the truth
suppress'd,

Forced a frank look, and said he
"thought it best."

220

Not long they'd parted ere dispute
arose;
The game they hunted quickly made
them foes.

Some house the father by his art had
won

Seem'd a fit cause of contest to the
son:

Who raised a claimant, and then
found a way

By a stanch witness to secure his
prey.

The people cursed him, but in times
of need

Trusted in one so certain to succeed:
By law's dark by-ways he had stored
his mind

With wicked knowledge, how to
cheat mankind.

230

Few are the freeholds in our ancient
town;

A copy-right from heir to heir came
down.

From whence some heat arose, when
there was doubt

In point of heirship; but the fire went
out,

Till our attorney had the art to raise
The dying spark, and blow it to a
blaze.

For this he now began his friends to
treat;

His way to starve them was to make
 them eat,
And drink oblivious draughts—to his
 applause
It must be said, he never starved a
 cause;

240

He'd roast and boil'd upon his board
 —the boast
Of half his victims was his boil'd and
 roast—
And these at every hour: he seldom
 took
Aside his client, till he'd praised his
 cook;
Nor to an office led him, there in pain
To give his story and go out again,
But first the brandy and the chine
 were seen.
And then the business came by starts
 between.

 "Well, if 'tis so, the house to you
 belongs;
But have you money to redress these
 wrongs?

250

Nay, look not sad, my friend; if you're
 correct,
You'll find the friendship that you'd
 not expect."

 If right the man, the house was
 Swallow's own;
If wrong, his kindness and good-will
 were shown.
"Rogue!" "Villain!" "Scoundrel!"
 cried the losers all;

He let them cry, for what would that
recall?

At length he left us, took a village
seat,

And like a vulture look'd abroad for
meat;

The Borough-booty, give it all its
praise,

Had only served the appetite to raise;

260

But, if from simple heirs he drew
their land,

He might a noble feast at will
command;

Still he proceeded by his former
rules,

His bait their pleasures, when he
fish'd for fools;—

Flagons and haunches on his board
were placed,

And subtle avarice look'd like
thoughtless waste.

Most of his friends, though youth
from him had fled,

Were young, were minors, of their
sires in dread;

Or those whom widow'd mothers kept
in bounds,

And check'd their generous rage for
steeds and hounds;

270

Or such as travell'd 'cross the land to
view

A Christian's conflict with a boxing
Jew.

Some too had run upon Newmarket
heath

With so much speed that they were
out of breath;
Others had tasted claret, till they now
To humbler port would turn, and
knew not how.
All these for favours would to
Swallow run,
Who never sought their thanks for all
he'd done;
He kindly took them by the hand,
then bow'd
Politely low, and thus his love
avow'd—

280

(For he'd a way that many judged
polite;
A cunning dog, he'd fawn before he'd
bite):—

"Observe, my friends, the frailty of
our race
When age unmans us—let me state a
case:
There's our friend Rupert; we shall
soon redress
His present evil—drink to our
success—
I flatter not, but did you ever see
Limbs better turn'd? a prettier boy
than he?
His senses all acute, his passions such
As nature gave—she never does too
much;

290

His the bold wish the cup of joy to
drain,
And strength to bear it without qualm
or pain.

"Now view his father as he dozing
lies,
Whose senses wake not when he opes
his eyes;
Who slips and shuffles when he
means to walk,
And lisps and gabbles if he tries to
talk;
Feeling he's none: he could as soon
destroy
The earth itself, as aught it holds
enjoy;
A nurse attends him to lay straight his
limbs,
Present his gruel, and respect his
whims.

300

Now, shall this dotard from our hero
hold
His lands and lordships? Shall he
hide his gold?
That which he cannot use, and dare
not show,
And will not give—why longer
should he owe?
Yet, 'twould be murder should we
snap the locks,
And take the thing he worships from
the box;
So let him dote and dream: but, till he
die,
Shall not our generous heir receive
supply?
For ever sitting on the river's brink,
And ever thirsty, shall he fear to
drink?

310

The means are simple: let him only
wish,
Then say he's willing, and I'll fill his
dish."

They all applauded, and not least
the boy,
Who now replied, "It fill'd his heart
with joy
To find he needed not deliv'rance
crave
Of death, or wish the justice in the
grave;
Who, while he spent, would every art
retain,
Of luring home the scatter'd gold
again;
Just as a fountain gaily spirts and
plays
With what returns in still and secret
ways."

320

Short was the dream of bliss; he
quickly found,
His father's acres all were Swallow's
ground.
Yet to those arts would other heroes
lend
A willing ear, and Swallow was their
friend;
Ever successful, some began to think
That Satan help'd him to his pen and
ink;
And shrewd suspicions ran about the
place,
"There was a compact"—I must leave
the case.

But of the parties, had the fiend been
one,
The business could not have been
speedier done.

330

Still, when a man has angled day and
night,
The silliest gudgeons will refuse to
bite:

So Swallow tried no more; but if they
came

To seek his friendship, that remain'd
the same.

Thus he retired in peace, and some
would say,

He balk'd his partner, and had learn'd
to pray.

To this some zealots lent an ear, and
sought

How Swallow felt, then said "a
change is wrought."

'Twas true there wanted all the signs
of grace,

But there were strong professions in
their place;

340

Then, too, the less that men from him
expect,

The more the praise to the converting
sect;

He had not yet subscribed to all their
creed,

Nor own'd a call; but he confess'd the
need.

His acquiescent speech, his gracious
look,

That pure attention, when the
brethren spoke,
Was all contrition,—he had felt the
wound,
And with confession would again be
sound.

True, Swallow's board had still the
sumptuous treat;
But could they blame? the warmest
zealots eat.

350

He drank—'twas needful his poor
nerves to brace;
He swore—'twas habit; he was
grieved—'twas grace.

What could they do a new-born zeal
to nurse?

"His wealth's undoubted—let him
hold our purse;

He'll add his bounty, and the house
we'll raise

Hard by the church, and gather all her
strays;

We'll watch her sinners as they home
retire,

And pluck the brands from the
devouring fire."

Alas! such speech was but an
empty boast;

The good men reckon'd, but without
their host;

360

Swallow, delighted, took the trusted
store,

And own'd the sum: they did not ask
for more,

Till more was needed; when they
call'd for aid—

And had it?—No, their agent was
afraid;

"Could he but know to whom he
should refund,

He would most gladly—nay, he'd go
beyond;

But, when such numbers claim'd,
when some were gone,

And others going—he must hold it
on;

The Lord would help }
them,"—Loud }
their anger
grew,

And while they threat'ning
from his door withdrew,

370

He bow'd politely low, and bade them
all adieu.

But lives the man by whom such
deeds are done?

Yes, many such—but Swallow's race
is run;

His name is lost;—for, though his
sons have name,

It is not his, they all escape the
shame;

Nor is there vestige now of all he had,
His means are wasted, for his heir
was mad.

Still we of Swallow as a monster
speak,

A hard, bad man, who prey'd upon the
weak.

FOOTNOTES:

^[50] The account of Coddington [Collingbourne] occurs in "*The Mirrour for Magistrates*"; he suffered in the reign of Richard III.

LETTER VII.

PROFESSIONS—PHYSIC.

[Jam mala finissem letho; sed credula
vitam
Spes fovet, et fore cras semper ait
melius.]

Tibullus

[Lib
. II.
vi.
vv.
19-
20].

He fell to juggle, cant, and cheat——
For as those fowls that live in water
Are never wet, he did but smatter;
Whate'er he labour'd to appear,
His understanding still was clear.
A paltry wretch he had, half-starved,
That him in place of zany served.

Butler's

*Hud
ibra
s
[Par
t II.
Can*

to
iii].

Worth and Excellence of the true Physician—Merit not the sole Cause of Success—Modes of advancing Reputation—Motives of medical Men for publishing their Works—The great Evil of Quackery—Present State of advertising Quacks—Their Hazard—Some fail, and why—Causes of Success—How Men of Understanding are prevailed upon to have Recourse to Empirics, and to permit their Names to be advertised—Evils of Quackery: to nervous Females; to Youth; to Infants—History of an advertising Empiric, &c.

LETTER VII.

PROFESSIONS—PHYSIC.

Next, to a graver tribe we turn our
view,
And yield the praise to worth and
science due;
But this with serious words and sober
style,
For these are friends with whom we
seldom smile:
Helpers of men^[51] they're call'd, and
we confess
Theirs the deep study, theirs the lucky
guess.
We own that numbers join with care
and skill
A temperate judgment, a devoted
will:
Men who suppress their feelings, but
who feel
10
The painful symptoms they delight to
heal;
Patient in all their trials, they sustain

The starts of passion, the reproach of
pain;
With hearts affected, but with looks
serene,
Intent they wait through all the
solemn scene;
Glad, if a hope should rise from
nature's strife,
To aid their skill and save the
lingering life.
But this must virtue's generous effort
be,
And spring from nobler motives than
a fee:
To the physicians of the soul, and
these,

20

Turn the distress'd for safety, hope,
and ease.

But as physicians of that nobler
kind
Have their warm zealots, and their
sectaries blind;
So among these for knowledge most
renown'd,
Are dreamers strange, and stubborn
bigots found.
Some, too, admitted to this honour'd
name,
Have, without learning, found a way
to fame;
And some by learning:—young
physicians write,
To set their merit in the fairest light;
With them a treatise is a bait that
draws

30

Approving voices; 'tis to gain
applause,

And to exalt them in the public view,
More than a life of worthy toil could
do.

When 'tis proposed to make the man
renown'd,

In every age convenient doubts
abound;

Convenient themes in every period
start,

Which he may treat with all the pomp
of art;

Curious conjectures he may always
make,

And either side of dubious questions
take.

He may a system broach, or, if he
please,

40

Start new opinions of an old disease;
Or may some simple in the woodland
trace,

And be its patron, till it runs its race;
As rustic damsels from their woods
are won,

And live in splendour till their race be
run;

It weighs not much on what their
powers be shown,

When all his purpose is to make them
known.

To show the world what long
experience gains,

Requires not courage, though it calls
for pains;

But, at life's outset to inform
mankind,

50

Is a bold effort of a valiant mind.

The great good man, for noblest
cause, displays

What many labours taught, and many
days;

These sound instruction from
experience give,

The others show us how they mean to
live;

That they have genius, and they hope
mankind

Will to its efforts be no longer blind.

There are, beside, whom powerful
friends advance,

Whom fashion favours, person,
patrons, chance;

And merit sighs to see a fortune made

60

By daring rashness or by dull parade.

But these are trifling evils; there is
one

Which walks uncheck'd, and triumphs
in the sun:

There was a time, when we beheld
the quack,

On public stage, the licensed trade
attack;

He made his labour'd speech with
poor parade;

And then a laughing zany lent him
aid.

Smiling we pass'd him, but we felt
the while

Pity so much, that soon we ceased to
smile;

Assured that fluent speech and
flow'ry vest

70

Disguised the troubles of a man
distress'd.

But now our quacks are gamesters,
and they play
With craft and skill to ruin and
betray;

With monstrous promise they delude
the mind,

And thrive on all that tortures human-
kind.

Void of all honour, avaricious,
rash,

The daring tribe compound their
boasted trash—

Tincture or syrup, lotion, drop or pill;
All tempt the sick to trust the lying
bill;

And twenty names of cobblers turn'd
to squires,

80

Aid the bold language of these
blushless liars.

There are among them those who
cannot read,

And yet they'll buy a patent, and
succeed;

Will dare to promise dying sufferers
aid,—

For who, when dead, can threaten or
upbraid?

With cruel avarice still they
recommend

More draughts, more syrup, to the
journey's end:

"I feel it not;"—"Then take it every
hour."—

"It makes me worse;"—"Why, then it
shows its power."—

"I fear to die;"—"Let not your spirits
sink,

90

You're always safe, while you believe
and drink."

How strange to add, in this
nefarious trade,
That men of parts are dupes by
dunces made:

That creatures nature meant should
clean our streets

Have purchased lands and mansions,
parks and seats;

Wretches with conscience so obtuse,
they leave

Their untaught sons their parents to
deceive;

And, when they're laid upon their
dying-bed,

No thought of murder comes into
their head,

Nor one revengeful ghost to them
appears,

100

To fill the soul with penitential fears.

Yet not the whole of this imposing
train

Their gardens, seats, and carriages
obtain;

Chiefly, indeed, they to the robbers
fall,

Who are most fitted to disgrace them
all.

But there is hazard—patents must be
bought,

Venders and puffers for the poison
sought;

And then in many a paper through the
year

Must cures and cases, oaths and
proofs appear;

Men snatch'd from graves, as they
were dropping in,

110

Their lungs cough'd up, their bones
pierced through their skin;

Their liver all one scirrhus, and the
frame

Poison'd with evils which they dare
not name;

Men who spent all }
upon
physicians'
fees,

Who never slept, nor had a
moment's ease,

Are now as roaches sound,
and all as brisk as bees.

If the sick gudgeons to the bait
attend,

And come in shoals, the angler gains
his end;

But, should the advertising cash be
spent,

Ere yet the town has due attention
lent,

120

Then bursts the bubble, and the
hungry cheat
Pines for the bread he ill deserves to
eat:

It is a lottery, and he shares perhaps
The rich man's feast, or begs the
pauper's scraps.

From powerful causes spring th'
empiric's gains,
Man's love of life, his weakness, and
his pains;
These first induce him the vile trash
to try,
Then lend his name, that other men
may buy.

This love of life, which in our nature
rules,
To vile imposture makes us dupes and
tools;

130

Then pain compels th' impatient soul
to seize
On promised hopes of instantaneous
ease;
And weakness too with every wish
complies,
Worn out and won by importunities.

Troubled with something in your
bile or blood,
You think your doctor does you little
good;
And, grown impatient, you require in
haste
The nervous cordial, nor dislike the
taste;
It comforts, heals, and strengthens;
nay, you think

It makes you better every time you
drink;

140

"Then lend your name"—you're loth,
but yet confess

Its powers are great, and so you
acquiesce.

Yet, think a moment, ere your name
you lend,

With whose 'tis placed, and what you
recommend;

Who tipples brandy will some
comfort feel,

But will he to the med'cine set his
seal?

Wait, and you'll find the cordial you
admire

Has added fuel to your fever's fire.

Say, should a robber chance your
purse to spare,

Would you the honour of the man
declare?

150

Would you assist his purpose? swell
his crime?

Besides, he might not spare a second
time.

Compassion sometimes sets the
fatal sign,

The man was poor, and humbly
begg'd a line;

Else how should noble names and
titles back

The spreading praise of some
advent'rous quack?

But he the moment watches, and
entreats

Your honour's name—your honour
joins the cheats;
You judged the med'cine harmless,
and you lent
What help you could, and with the
best intent;

160

But can it please you, thus to league
with all
Whom he can beg or bribe to swell
the scrawl?
Would you these wrappers with your
name adorn,
Which hold the poison for the yet
unborn?

No class escapes them—from the
poor man's pay
The nostrum takes no trifling part
away;
See! those square patent bottles from
the shop,
Now decoration to the cupboard's top;
And there a favourite hoard you'll
find within,
Companions meet! the julep and the
gin.

170

Time too with cash is wasted; 'tis
the fate
Of real helpers to be call'd too late;
This find the sick, when (time and
patience gone)
Death with a tenfold terror hurries on.
Suppose the case surpasses human
skill,
There comes a quack to flatter
weakness still;

What greater evil can a flatterer do,
Than from himself to take the
sufferer's view?

To turn from sacred thoughts his
reasoning powers,
And rob a sinner of his dying hours?

180

Yet this they, dare and craving to the
last,

In hope's strong bondage hold their
victim fast:

For soul or body no }
concern have }
they,

All their inquiry, "Can the
patient pay?

And will he swallow draughts
until his dying day?"

Observe what ills to nervous
females flow,

When the heart flutters, and the pulse
is low;

If once induced these cordial sips to
try,

All feel the ease, and few the danger
fly;

For, while obtain'd, of drams they've
all the force,

190

And when denied, then drams are the
resource.

Nor these the only evils—there are
those

Who for the troubled mind prepare
repose;

They write: the young are tenderly
address'd,

Much danger hinted, much concern
express'd;
They dwell on freedoms lads are
prone to take,
Which makes the doctor tremble for
their sake;
Still, if the youthful patient will but
trust
In one so kind, so pitiful, and just;
If he will take the tonic all the time,
200
And hold but moderate intercourse
with crime:
The sage will gravely give his honest
word,
That strength and spirits shall be both
restored;
In plainer English—if you mean to
sin,
Fly to the drops, and instantly begin.
Who would not lend a
sympathizing sigh,
To hear yon infant's pity-moving cry?
That feeble sob, unlike the new-born
note,
Which came with vigour from the
op'ning throat;
When air and light first rush'd on
lungs and eyes,
210
And there was life and spirit in the
cries;
Now an abortive, faint attempt to
weep
Is all we hear; sensation is asleep.
The boy was healthy, and at first
express'd

His feelings loudly, when he fail'd to
rest;
When cramm'd with food, and
tighten'd every limb,
To cry aloud, was what pertain'd to
him;
Then the good nurse, (who, had she
borne a brain,
Had sought the cause that made her
babe complain,)
Has all her efforts, loving soul!
applied,

220

To set the cry, and not the cause,
aside;
She gave her powerful sweet without
remorse,
The sleeping cordial—she had tried
its force,
Repeating oft; the infant, freed from
pain,
Rejected food, but took the dose
again,
Sinking to sleep; while she her joy
express'd,
That her dear charge could sweetly
take his rest:
Soon may she spare her cordial; not a
doubt
Remains but quickly he will rest
without.

This moves our grief and pity, and
we sigh

230

To think what numbers from these
causes die;

But what contempt and anger should
we show,
Did we the lives of these impostors
know!

Ere for the world's I left the cares
of school,
One I remember who assumed the
fool:

A part well suited—when the idler
boys

Would shout around him, and he
loved the noise;

They call'd him Neddy;—Neddy had
the art

To play with skill his ignominious
part;

When he his trifles would for sale
display,

240

And act the mimic for a schoolboy's
pay.

For many years he plied his humble
trade,

And used his tricks and talents to
persuade;

The fellow barely read, but chanced
to look

Among the fragments of a tatter'd
book,

Where, after many efforts made to
spell

One puzzling word, he found it
oxymel:

A potent thing, 'twas said, to cure the
ills

Of ailing lungs—the *oxymel of*
squills.

Squills he procured, but found the
bitter strong,

250

And most unpleasant; none would
take it long;

But the pure acid and the sweet
would make

A med'cine numbers would for
pleasure take.

There was a fellow near, an artful
knave,

Who knew the plan, and much
assistance gave;

He wrote the puffs, and every talent
plied

To make it sell: it sold, and then he
died.

Now all the profit fell to Ned's
control,

And Pride and Avarice quarrell'd for
his soul;

When mighty profits by the trash
were made,

260

Pride built a palace, Avarice groan'd
and paid;

Pride placed the signs of grandeur all
about,

And Avarice barr'd his friends and
children out.

Now see him doctor! yes, the idle
fool,

The butt, the robber of the lads at
school;

Who then knew nothing, nothing
since acquired,

Became a doctor, honour'd and
admired;
His dress, his frown, his dignity were
such,
Some who had known him thought
his knowledge much;
Nay, men of skill, of apprehension
quick,

270

Spite of their knowledge, trusted him
when sick.

Though he could never }
reason, write, }
nor spell,

They yet had hope his trash
would make them well;
And while they scorn'd his
parts, they took his oxymel.
Oh! when his nerves had once
received a shock,

Sir Isaac Newton might have gone to
Rock^[52]:

Hence impositions of the grossest
kind;

Hence thought is feeble,
understanding blind;

Hence sums enormous by those
cheats are made,

And deaths unnumber'd by their
dreadful trade.

280

Alas! in vain is my contempt
express'd;

To stronger passions are their words
address'd:

To pain, to fear, to terror their appeal,

What then our hopes?—perhaps
 there may by law
 Be method found, these pests to curb
 and awe;
 Yet in this land of freedom, law is
 slack
 With any being to commence attack;
 Then let us trust to }
 science—there }
 are those
 Who can their falsehoods and
 their frauds disclose,
 290
 All their vile trash detect, and their
 low tricks expose.
 Perhaps their numbers may in time
 confound
 Their arts—as scorpions give
 themselves the wound:
 For, when these curers dwell in every
 place,
 While of the cured we not a man can
 trace,
 Strong truth may then the public
 mind persuade,
 And spoil the fruits of this nefarious
 trade.

[51]

[Ovid, *Metam.* Lib.
I. vv. 521-2.]

[52] An empiric who *flourished* at the same time with this great man.

LETTER VIII.

TRADES.

Non possidentem multa vocaveris
Recte beatum: rectius occupat
Nomen Beati, qui Deorum
Muneribus sapienter uti,
Duramque callet pauperiem pati.

Hor. lib. iv.
od.
9
[vv.
45-
9].

Non uxor saluum te vult, non filius:
omnes
Vicini oderunt; noti, pueri atque puellæ.
Miraris, cum tu argento post omnia
ponas,
Si nemo præstet, quem non merearis,
amorem?

Hor. Sat.
lib.
1.
[Sat
. 1.
vv.
84-
7].

Non propter vitam faciunt patrimonia
quidam,
Sed vitio cæci propter patrimonia vivunt.

Juvenal.

Sat.
12.
[vv.
50-
1].

extensive Manufactories in the Borough: yet considerable Fortunes made there—Ill Judgment of Parents in disposing of their Sons—The best educated not the most likely to succeed—Instance—Want of Success compensated by the lenient Power of some Avocations—The Naturalist—The Weaver an Entomologist, &c.—A Prize-Flower—Story of Walter and William.

LETTER VIII.

TRADES.

Of manufactures, trade, inventions
rare,
Steam-towers and looms, you'd know
our Borough's share—
'Tis small: we boast not these rich
subjects here,
Who hazard thrice ten thousand
pounds a year,
We've no huge buildings, where
incessant noise
Is made by springs and spindles, girls
and boys;
Where, 'mid such thundering sounds,
the maiden's song
Is "Harmony in Uproar"^[53] all day
long.
Still, common minds with us, in
common trade,

10

Have gain'd more wealth than ever
student made;

And yet a merchant, when he gives
his son

His college-learning, thinks his duty
done;

A way to wealth he leaves his boy to
find,

Just when he's made for the discovery
blind.

Jones and his wife perceived their
elder boy

Took to his learning, and it gave them
joy;

This they encouraged, and were
bless'd to see

Their son a Fellow with a high
degree;

A living fell, he married, and his sire

20

Declared 'twas all a father could
require;

Children then bless'd them, and when
letters came,

The parents proudly told each
grandchild's name.

Meantime the sons at home in
trade were placed,

Money their object—just the father's
taste;

Saving he lived and long, and when
he died,

He gave them all his fortune to
divide.

"Martin," said he, "at vast expense
was taught;

He gain'd his wish, and has the ease
he sought."

Thus the good priest (the Christian-
scholar!) finds

30

What estimate is made by vulgar
minds;

He sees his brothers, who had every
gift

Of thriving, now assisted in their
thrift;

While he whom learning, habits, all
prevent,

Is largely mulct for each impediment.

Yet, let us own that trade has much
of chance:

Not all the careful by their care
advance;

With the same parts and prospects,
one a seat

Builds for himself; one finds it in the
Fleet.

Then, to the wealthy you will see
denied

40

Comforts and joys that with the poor
abide:

There are who labour through the
year, and yet

No more have gain'd than—not to be
in debt;

Who still maintain the same laborious
course,

Yet pleasure hails them from some
favourite source;

And health, amusements, children,
wife or friend,

With life's dull views their
consolations blend.

Nor these alone possess the lenient
power
Of soothing life in the desponding
hour;
Some favourite studies, some
delightful care,

50

The mind with trouble and distresses
share;
And by a coin, a flower, a verse, a
boat,
The stagnant spirits have been set
afloat;
They pleased at first, and then the
habit grew,
Till the fond heart no higher pleasure
knew;
Till, from all cares and other comforts
freed,
Th' important nothing took in life the
lead.

With all his phlegm, it broke a
Dutchman's heart,
At a vast price with one loved root to
part;
And toys like these fill many a British
mind,

60

Although their hearts are found of
firmer kind.

Oft have I smiled the happy pride
to see
Of humble tradesmen, in their
evening glee;

When, of some pleasing, fancied
good possess'd,
Each grew alert, was busy, and was
bless'd;
Whether the call-bird yield the hour's
delight,
Or, magnified in microscope, the
mite;
Or whether tumblers, croppers,
carriers seize
The gentle mind, they rule it and they
please.

There is my friend the Weaver;
strong desires

70

Reign in his breast; 'tis beauty he
admires:

See! to the shady grove he wings his
way,

And feels in hope the raptures of the
day—

Eager he looks; and }
soon, to glad }
his eyes,

From the sweet bower, by
nature form'd, arise

Bright troops of virgin moths
and fresh-born butterflies;

Who broke that morning from their
half-year's sleep,

To fly o'er flow'rs where they were
wont to creep.

Above the sovereign oak a
sovereign skims,
The purple Emp'ror, strong in wing
and limbs:

80

There fair Camilla takes her flight
serene,
Adonis blue, and Paphia, silver-
queen;
With every filmy fly from mead or
bower,
And hungry Sphinx, who threads the
honey'd flower;
She o'er the Larkspur's bed, where
sweets abound,
Views ev'ry bell, and hums th'
approving sound;
Poised on her busy plumes, with
feeling nice
She draws from every flower, nor
tries a floret twice.

He fears no bailiff's wrath, no
baron's blame,
His is untax'd and undisputed game;
90
Nor less the place of curious plant he
knows^[54];
He both his Flora and his Fauna
shows;
For him is blooming in its rich array
The glorious flower which bore the
palm away;
In vain a rival tried his utmost art,
His was the prize, and joy o'erflow'd
his heart.

"This, this is beauty! cast, I pray,
your eyes
On this my glory! see the grace! the
size!
Was ever stem so tall, so stout, so
strong,

Exact in breadth, in just proportion,
long!

100

These brilliant hues are all distinct
and clean,
No kindred tint, no blending streaks
between;
This is no shaded, run-off^[55], pin-
eyed^[56] thing,
A king of flowers, a flower for
England's king:
I own my pride, and thank the
favouring star,
Which shed such beauty on my fair
Bizarre^[57]."

Thus may the poor the cheap
indulgence seize,
While the most wealthy pine and pray
for ease;
Content not always waits upon
success,
And more may he enjoy who profits
less.

110

Walter and William took (their
father dead)
Jointly the trade to which they both
were bred;
When fix'd, they married, and they
quickly found
With due success their honest labours
crown'd:
Few were their losses, but, although a
few,
Walter was vex'd, and somewhat
peevish grew:

"You put your trust in every pleading
fool,"

Said he to William, and grew strange
and cool.

"Brother, forbear," he answer'd; "take
your due,
Nor let my lack of caution injure
you."

120

Half friends they parted,—better so to
close,

Than longer wait to part entirely foes.

Walter had knowledge, prudence,
jealous care;

He let no idle views his bosom share;

He never thought nor felt for other
men—

"Let one mind one, and all are
minded then."

Friends he respected, and believed
them just;

But they were men, and he would no
man trust;

He tried and watch'd his people day
and night,—

The good it harm'd not; for the bad
'twas right:

130

He could their humours bear, nay
disrespect,

But he could yield no pardon to
neglect;

That all about him were of him
afraid,

"Was right," he said—"so should we
be obey'd."

These merchant- }
maxims, }
much good-
fortune too,
And ever keeping one grand
point in view,
To vast amount his once small
portion drew.
William was kind and easy; he
complied
With all requests, or grieved when he
denied;
To please his wife he made a costly
trip,
140
To please his child he let a bargain
slip;
Prone to compassion, }
mild with the }
distress'd,
He bore with all who poverty
profess'd,
And some would he assist,
nor one would he arrest.
He had some loss at }
sea, bad debts }
at land,
His clerk absconded with
some bills in hand,
And plans so often fail'd that
he no longer plann'd.
To a small house (his brother's) he
withdrew,
At easy rent—the man was not a Jew;
And there his losses and his cares he
bore,

Nor found that want of wealth could
make him poor.

No, he in fact was rich; nor could
he move,
But he was follow'd by the looks of
love;
All he had suffer'd, every former
grief,
Made those around more studious in
relief;
He saw a cheerful smile in every
face,
And lost all thoughts of error and
disgrace.

Pleasant it was to see them in their
walk
Round their small garden, and to hear
them talk;
Free are their children, but their love
refrains

160

From all offence—none murmurs,
none complains;
Whether a book amused them, speech
or play,
Their looks were lively, and their
hearts were gay;
There no forced efforts for delight
were made,
Joy came with prudence, and without
parade;
Their common comforts they had all
in view,
Light were their troubles, and their
wishes few;
Thrift made them easy for the coming
day;

Religion took the dread of death
away;

A cheerful spirit still insured content,
170

And love smiled round them
wheresoe'er they went.

Walter, meantime, with all his
wealth's increase,
Gain'd many points, but could not
purchase peace;

When he withdrew from business for
an hour,

Some fled his presence, all confess'd
his power;

He sought affection, but received
instead

Fear undisguised, and love-repelling
dread;

He look'd around him—"Harriet, dost
thou love?"—

"I do my duty," said the timid
dove;—

"Good Heav'n, your duty! prithee, tell
me now—

180

To love and honour—was not that
your vow?

Come, my good Harriet, I would
gladly seek

Your inmost thought—Why can't the
woman speak?

Have you not all things?"—"Sir, do I
complain?"—

"No, that's my part, which I perform
in vain;

I want a simple answer, and direct—
But you evade; yes! 'tis as I suspect.

Come then, my children! Watt! upon
your knees
Vow that you love me."—"Yes, sir, if
you please."—
"Again! by Heav'n, it mads me; I
require

190

Love, and they'll do whatever I
desire.
Thus too my people shun me; I would
spend
A thousand pounds to get a single
friend;
I would be happy—I have means to
pay
For love and friendship, and you run
away;
Ungrateful creatures! why, you seem
to dread
My very looks; I know you wish me
dead.
Come hither, Nancy! you must hold
me dear;
Hither, I say; why! what have you to
fear?
You see I'm gentle—Come, you
trifler, come;

200

My God! she trembles! Idiot, leave
the room!
Madam! your children hate me; I
suppose
They know their cue; you make them
all my foes;
I've not a friend in all the world—not
one:

I'd be a bankrupt sooner; nay, 'tis
done;
In every better hope of life I fail;
You're all tormentors, and my house a
jail;
Out of my sight! I'll sit and make my
will—
What, glad to go? stay, devils, and be
still;
'Tis to your uncle's cot you wish to
run,

210

To learn to live at ease and be
undone;
Him you can love, who lost his whole
estate,
And I, who gain you fortunes, have
your hate;
'Tis in my absence you yourselves
enjoy:
Tom! are you glad to lose me? tell
me, boy:
'Yes!' does he answer?"—"Yes!' upon
my soul;"
"No awe, no fear, no duty, no control!
Away! away! ten thousand devils
seize
All I possess, and plunder where they
please!
What's wealth to me?—yes, yes! it
gives me sway,

220

And you shall feel it—Go! begone, I
say."

NOTES TO LETTER VIII.

[53] Note 1, page 358, line 8.

Is "Harmony in Uproar" all day long.

The title of a short piece of humour by Arbuthnot.

[54] Note 2, page 360, line 90.

*Nor less the place of curious plant he
knows.*

In botanical language, "*the habitat*," the favourite soil or situation of the more scarce species.

[55] Note 3, page 360, line 102.

*This is no shaded, run-off, pin-eyed
thing.*

This, it must be acknowledged, is contrary to the opinion of Thomson, and I believe of some other poets, who, in describing the varying hues of our most beautiful flowers, have considered them as lost and blended with each other; whereas their beauty, in the eye of a florist (and I conceive in that of the uninitiated also), depends upon the distinctness of their colours: the stronger the bounding line, and the less they break into the neighbouring tint, so much the richer and more valuable is the flower esteemed.

[56] Note 4, page 360, line 102.

Pin-eyed.

An auricle, or any other single flower, is so called when the *stigma* (the part which arises from the seed-vessel) is protruded beyond the tube of the flower, and becomes visible.

[57] Note 5, page 360, line 105.

*Which shed such beauty on my faire
Bizarre.*

This word, so far as it relates to flowers, means those variegated with three or more colours irregularly and indeterminately.

LETTER IX.

AMUSEMENTS.

Interpone tuis interdum gaudia curis,
Ut possis animo quemvis sufferre
laborem.

[(*Dionys.*)

Cat

o de

Mor

ibus

. III.

7.]

... nostra [fatiscit]

Laxaturque chelys; vires instigat alitque
Tempestiva quies, major post otia virtus.

Statius,

Sylv

.

lib.

IV.

[4,

vv.

32-

3].

Jamque mare et tellus nullum discrimen
habebant;

Omnia pontus [erat]: deerant quoque
littora ponto.

Ovid.

Met

amo

rph.

lib.

Common Amusements of a Bathing-place—Morning Rides, Walks, &c.—Company resorting to the Town
—Different Choice of Lodgings—Cheap Indulgences—Sea-side Walks—Wealthy Invalid—
Summer-Evening on the Sands—Sea Productions—"Water parted from the Sea"—Winter Views
serene—In what Cases to be avoided—Sailing upon the River—A small Islet of Sand off the Coast
—Visited by Company—Covered by the Flowing of the Tide—Adventure in that Place.

LETTER IX.

AMUSEMENTS.

Of our amusements }
ask you?— }
We amuse
Ourselves and friends with
sea-side walks and views,
Or take a morning ride, a
novel, or the news;
Or, seeking nothing, glide about the
street,
And, so engaged, with various parties
meet;
Awhile we stop, discourse of wind
and tide,
Bathing and books, the raffle, and the
ride:
Thus, with the aid which shops and
sailing give,
Life passes on; 'tis labour, but we
live.

10

When evening comes, our invalids
awake,

Nerves cease to tremble, heads
forbear to ache;
Then cheerful meals the sunken
spirits raise,
Cards or the dance, wine, visiting, or
plays.

Soon as the season comes, and
crowds arrive,
To their superior rooms the wealthy
drive;
Others look round for lodging snug
and small,
Such is their taste—they've hatred to
a hall;
Hence one his fav'rite habitation gets,
The brick-floor'd parlour which the
butcher lets;

20

Where, through his single light, he
may regard
The various business of a common
yard,
Bounded by backs of buildings
form'd of clay,
By stable, sties, and coops, et-cætera.
The needy-vain, themselves awhile
to shun,
For dissipation to these dog-holes
run;
Where each (assuming petty pomp)
appears,
And quite forgets the shopboard and
the shears.

For them are cheap amusements:
they may slip
Beyond the town and take a private
dip;

30

When they may urge that to be safe
they mean:
They've heard there's danger in a light
machine;
They too can gratis move the quays
about,
And gather kind replies to every
doubt;
There they a pacing, lounging tribe
may view,
The stranger's guides, who've little
else to do;
The Borough's placemen, where no
more they gain
Than keeps them idle, civil, poor, and
vain.
Then may the poorest with the
wealthy look
On ocean, glorious page of Nature's
book!

40

May see its varying }
views in every
hour,
All softness now, then rising
with all power,
As sleeping to invite, or
threat'ning to devour:
'Tis this which gives us all our
choicest views;
Its waters heal us, and its shores
amuse.
See those fair nymphs upon that
rising strand,
Yon long salt lake has parted from the
land;

Well pleased to press that path, so
clean, so pure,
To seem in danger, yet to feel secure;
Trifling with terror, while they strive
to shun

50

The curling billows; laughing as they
run;
They know the neck that joins the
shore and sea,
Or, ah! how changed that fearless
laugh would be.

Observe how various parties take
their way,
By sea-side walks, or make the sand-
hills gay;
There group'd are laughing maids and
sighing swains,
And some apart who feel unpitied
pains:
Pains from diseases, pains which
those who feel
To the physician, not the fair, reveal;
For nymphs (propitious to the lover's
sigh)

60

Leave these poor patients to complain
and die.
Lo! where on that huge anchor
sadly leans
That sick tall figure, lost in other
scenes;
He late from India's clime impatient
sail'd,
There, as his fortune grew, his spirits
fail'd;

For each delight, in search of wealth
he went,
For ease alone, the wealth acquired is
spent—
And spent in vain; enrich'd, aggriev'd,
he sees
The envied poor possess'd of joy and
ease;
And now he flies from place to place,
to gain

70

Strength for enjoyment, and still flies
in vain.
Mark, with what sadness, of that
pleasant crew,
Boist'rous in mirth, he takes a
transient view,
And, fixing then his eye upon the sea,
Thinks what has been and what must
shortly be:
Is it not strange that man should
health destroy,
For joys that come when he is dead to
joy?

Now is it pleasant in the summer-
eve,
When a broad shore retiring waters
leave,
Awhile to wait upon the firm fair
sand,

80

When all is calm at sea, all still at
land;
And there the ocean's produce to
explore,
As floating by, or rolling on the
shore;

Those living jellies^[58] which the flesh
inflame,
Fierce as a nettle, and from that its
name;
Some in huge masses, some that you
may bring
In the small compass of a lady's ring;
Figured by hand divine—there's not a
gem
Wrought by man's art to be compared
to them;
Soft, brilliant, tender, through the
wave they glow,

90

And make the moon-beam brighter
where they flow.
Involved in sea-wrack, here you find
a race,
Which science, doubting, knows not
where to place;
On shell or stone is dropp'd the
embryo-seed,
And quickly vegetates a vital
breed^[59].

While thus with pleasing wonder
you inspect
Treasures the vulgar in their scorn
reject,
See as they float along th' entangled
weeds
Slowly approach, upborne on
bladdery beads;
Wait till they land, and you shall then
behold

100

The fiery sparks those tangled frons'
infold,

Myriads of living points^[60]; th'
 unaided eye
Can but the fire and not the form
 descry.
And now your view upon the ocean
 turn,
And there the splendour of the waves
 discern;
Cast but a stone, or strike them with
 an oar,
And you shall flames within the deep
 explore;
Or scoop the stream phosphoric as
 you stand,
And the cold flames shall flash along
 your hand;
When, lost in wonder, you shall walk
 and gaze

110

On weeds that sparkle, and on waves
 that blaze^[61].
 The ocean too has winter-views
 serene,
When all you see through densest fog
 is seen;
When you can hear the fishers near at
 hand
Distinctly speak, yet see not where
 they stand;
Or sometimes them and not their boat
 discern,
Or half-conceal'd some figure at the
 stern;
The view's all bounded, and from side
 to side
Your utmost prospect but a few ells
 wide;

Boys who, on shore, to sea the pebble
cast,

120

Will hear it strike against the viewless
mast;

While the stern boatman growls his
fierce disdain,

At whom he knows not, whom he
threats in vain.

'Tis pleasant then to view the nets
float past,

Net after net till you have seen the
last;

And as you wait till all beyond you
slip,

A boat comes gliding from an
anchor'd ship,

Breaking the silence with the dipping
oar

And their own tones, as labouring for
the shore—

Those measured tones which with the
scene agree,

130

And give a sadness to serenity.

All scenes like these the tender
maid should shun,

Nor to a misty beach in autumn run;

Much should she guard against the
evening cold,

And her slight shape with fleecy
warmth infold;

This she admits, but not with so much
ease

Gives up the night-walk when th'
attendants please.

Her have I seen, pale, vapour'd
through the day,
With crowded parties at the midnight
play;
Faint in the morn, no powers could
she exert;

140

At night with Pam delighted and
alert;
In a small shop she's raffled with a
crowd,
Breathed the thick air, and cough'd
and laugh'd aloud;
She, who will tremble if her eye
explore
"The smallest monstrous mouse that
creeps on floor;"
Whom the kind doctor charged, with
shaking head,
At early hour to quit the beaux for
bed:
She has, contemning fear, gone down
the dance,
Till she perceived the rosy morn
advance;
Then has she wonder'd, fainting o'er
her tea,

150

Her drops and juleps should so
useless be:
Ah! sure her joys must ravish every
sense,
Who buys a portion at so vast
expense.
Among those joys, 'tis one at eve to
sail

On the broad river with a favourite
gale;
When no rough waves upon the
bosom ride,
But the keel cuts, nor rises on the
tide;
Safe from the stream the nearer
gunwale stands,
Where playful children trail their idle
hands,
Or strive to catch long grassy leaves
that float

160

On either side of the impeded boat:
What time the moon, arising, shows
the mud
A shining border to the silver flood;
When, by her dubious light, the
meanest views,
Chalk, stones, and stakes, obtain the
richest hues;
And when the cattle, as they gazing
stand,
Seem nobler objects than when
view'd from land.
Then anchor'd vessels in the way
appear,
And sea-boys greet them as they pass
—"What cheer?"
The sleeping shell-ducks at the sound
arise,

170

And utter loud their unharmonious
cries;
Fluttering, they move their weedy
beds among,

Or, instant diving, hide their
plumeless young.

Along the wall, returning from the
town,

The weary rustic homeward wanders
down;

Who stops and gazes at such joyous
crew,

And feels his envy rising at the view;

He the light speech and laugh
indignant hears,

And feels more press'd by want, more
vex'd by fears.

Ah! go in peace, good fellow, to
thine home,

180

Nor fancy these escape the general
doom;

Gay as they seem, be sure with them
are hearts

With sorrow tried; there's sadness in
their parts.

If thou couldst see them when they
think alone,

Mirth, music, friends, and these
amusements gone;

Couldst thou discover every secret ill
That pains their spirit, or resists their
will;

Couldst thou behold forsaken Love's
distress,

Or Envy's pang at glory and success,

Or Beauty, conscious of the spoils of
Time,

190

Or Guilt, alarm'd when Memory
shows the crime—

All that gives sorrow, terror, grief,
and gloom:

Content would cheer thee, trudging to
thine home^[62].

There are, 'tis true, who lay their
cares aside,

And bid some hours in calm
enjoyment glide;

Perchance some fair-one to the sober
night

Adds (by the sweetness of her song)
delight;

And, as the music on the water floats,
Some bolder shore returns the
soften'd notes;

Then, youth, beware, for all around
conspire

200

To banish caution and to wake desire;

The day's amusement, }
feasting, }

beauty, wine,

These accents sweet and this
soft hour combine,

When most unguarded, then
to win that heart of thine:

But see, they land! the fond
enchantment flies,

And in its place life's common views
arise.

Sometimes a party, row'd from
town, will land

On a small islet form'd of shelly sand,
Left by the water when the tides are
low,

But which the floods in their return
o'erflow:

210

There will they anchor, pleased
 awhile to view
The watery waste, a prospect wild
 and new;
The now receding billows give them
 space
On either side the growing shores to
 pace;
And then, returning, they contract the
 scene,
Till small and smaller grows the walk
 between,
As sea to sea approaches, shore to
 shores,
Till the next ebb the sandy isle
 restores.

 Then what alarm! what danger and
 dismay,
If all their trust, their boat should drift
 away;

220

And once it happen'd—gay the
 friends advanced;
They walk'd, they ran, they play'd,
 they sang, they danced;
The urns were boiling, and the cups
 went round,
And not a grave or thoughtful face
 was found;
On the bright sand they trod with
 nimble feet,
Dry shelly sand that made the
 summer-seat;
The wondering mews flew fluttering
 o'er the head,

And waves ran softly up their shining
bed.

Some form'd a party from the rest
to stray,
Pleased to collect the trifles in their
way;

230

These to behold, they call their
friends around—

No friends can hear, or hear another
sound;

Alarm'd, they hasten, yet perceive not
why,

But catch the fear that quickens as
they fly.

For lo! a lady sage, who paced the
sand

With her fair children, one in either
hand,

Intent on home, had turn'd, and saw
the boat

Slipp'd from her moorings, and now
far afloat;

She gazed, she trembled, and though
faint her call,

It seem'd, like thunder, to confound
them all.

240

Their sailor-guides, the boatman and
his mate,

Had drank, and slept regardless of
their state;

"Awake!" they cried aloud; "Alarm
the shore!

"Shout all, or never shall we reach it
more!"

Alas! no shout the distant land can
reach,
Nor eye behold them from the foggy
beach.
Again they join in one }
loud, powerful }
cry,
Then cease, and eager listen
for reply;
None came—the rising wind
blew sadly by.
They shout once more, and then they
turn aside,

250

To see how quickly flow'd the
coming tide;
Between each cry they find the
waters steal
On their strange prison, and new
horrors feel;
Foot after foot on the contracted
ground
The billows fall, and dreadful is the
sound;
Less and yet less the sinking isle
became,
And there was wailing, weeping,
wrath, and blame.

Had one been there, with spirit
strong and high,
Who could observe, as he prepared to
die:
He might have seen of hearts the
varying kind,

260

And traced the movement of each
different mind;

He might have seen, that not the
gentle maid
Was more than stern and haughty
man afraid;
Such calmly grieving, will their fears
suppress,
And silent prayers to Mercy's throne
address;
While fiercer minds, impatient, angry,
loud,
Force their vain grief on the reluctant
crowd.
The party's patron, sorely sighing,
cried,
"Why would you urge me? I at first
denied."
Fiercely they answer'd, "Why will
you complain,

270

"Who saw no danger, or was warn'd
in vain?"
A few essay'd the troubled soul to
calm;
But dread prevail'd, and anguish and
alarm.

Now rose the water through the
lessening sand,
And they seem'd sinking while they
yet could stand;
The sun went down, they look'd from
side to side,
Nor aught except the gathering sea
descried;
Dark and more dark, more wet, more
cold it grew,
And the most lively bade to hope
adieu;

Children, by love then lifted from the
seas,

280

Felt not the waters at the parents'
knees,
But wept aloud; the wind increased
the sound,
And the cold billows as they broke
around.

"Once more, yet once again, with
all our strength,
Cry to the land—we may be heard at
length."
Vain hope, if yet unseen! but hark! an
oar,
That sound of bliss! comes dashing to
their shore;
Still, still the water rises; "Haste!"
they cry,
"Oh! hurry, seamen; in delay we die;"
(Seamen were these, who in their ship
perceived

290

The drifted boat, and thus her crew
relieved.)
And now the keel just cuts the cover'd
sand,
Now to the gunwale stretches every
hand;
With trembling pleasure all confused
embark,
And kiss the tackling of their
welcome ark;
While the most giddy, as they reach
the shore,
Think of their danger, and their God
adore.

NOTES TO LETTER IX.

[58] Note 1, page 368, line 83.

*Those living jellies which the flesh
inflame.*

Some of the smaller species of the Medusa (sea-nettle) are exquisitely beautiful: their form is nearly oval, varied with serrated longitudinal lines; they are extremely tender, and by no means which I am acquainted with can be preserved, for they soon dissolve in either spirit of wine or water, and lose every vestige of their shape, and indeed of their substance: the larger species are found in mis-shapen masses of many pounds weight; these, when handled, have the effect of the nettle, and the stinging is often accompanied or succeeded by the more unpleasant feeling, perhaps in a slight degree resembling that caused by the torpedo.

[59] Note 2, page 368, line 94.

And quickly vegetates a vital breed.

Various tribes and species of marine vermes are here meant: that which so nearly resembles a vegetable in its form, and perhaps, in some degree, manner of growth, is the coralline called by naturalists Sertularia, of which there are many species in almost every part of the coast. The animal protrudes its many claws (apparently in search of prey) from certain pellucid vesicles which proceed from a horny, tenacious, branchy stem.

[60] Note 3, page 368, line 101.

*Myriads of living points; th' unaided eye
Can but the fire and not the form descry.*

These are said to be a minute kind of animal of the same class; when it does not shine, it is invisible to the naked eye.

[61] Note 4, page 369, line 110.

*On weeds that sparkle, and on waves
that blaze.*

For the cause or causes of this phenomenon, which is sometimes, though rarely, observed on our coasts, I must refer the reader to the writers on natural philosophy and natural history.

[62] Note 5, page 371, line 192.

*Content would
cheer thee, trudging to thine home.*

This is not offered as a reasonable source of contentment, but as one motive for resignation: there would not be so much envy if there were more discernment.

LETTER X.

CLUBS AND SOCIAL MEETINGS.

Non inter lances mensasque
nitentes,
Cum stupet insanis acies fulgoribus, et
cum
Acclinis falsis animus meliora recusat;
Verum hîc impransi mecum disquirite.

Hor. Sat.
lib.
ii.
[Sat
. 2.
vv.
4-
7].

O prodiga rerum
Luxuries, nunquam parvo contenta
paratu,
Et quæditorum terrâ pelagoque ciborum
Ambitiosa fames et lautæ gloria mensæ.

Lucan. lib.
iv.
[vv.
373
-6].

[Sed] quæ non prosunt singula, [multa]
juvant.

[Ovid.

*Rem
ed.
Am
or.
v.
420.
]*

Rusticus agricolam, miles fera bella
gerentem,

Rectorem dubiæ navita puppis amat.

Ovid. Pont.

*lib.
ii.
[Ep.
2.
vv.
61-
2].*

ire of Country Gentlemen for Town Associations—Book-clubs—Too much of literary Character expected from them—Literary Conversation prevented: by Feasting: by Cards—Good, notwithstanding, results—Card-club with Eagerness resorted to—Players—Umpires at the Whist Table—Petulances of Temper there discovered—Free-and-easy Club: not perfectly easy or free—Freedom, how interrupted—The superior Member—Termination of the Evening—Drinking and Smoking Clubs—The Midnight Conversation of the Delaying Members—Society of the poorer Inhabitants: its Use: gives Pride and Consequence to the humble Character—Pleasant Habitations of the frugal Poor—Sailor returning to his Family—Freemasons' Club—The Mystery—What its Origin—Its professed Advantages—Griggs and Gregorians—A Kind of Masons—Reflections on these various Societies.

LETTER X.

CLUBS AND SOCIAL MEETINGS.

You say you envy in your calm retreat
Our social meetings;—'tis with joy
we meet.

In these our parties you are pleased to
find

Good sense and wit, with intercourse
of mind;

Composed of men, who read, reflect,
and write;

Who, when they meet, must yield and
share delight.

To you our Book-club has peculiar
charm,

For which you sicken in your quiet
farm;

Here you suppose us at our leisure
placed,

10

Enjoying freedom, and displaying
taste;

With wisdom cheerful, temperately
gay,

Pleased to enjoy, and willing to
display.

If thus your envy gives your ease
its gloom,

Give wings to fancy, and among us
come.

We're now assembled; you may soon
attend—

I'll introduce you—"Gentlemen, my
friend."—

"Now are you happy? you have
pass'd a night

In gay discourse, and rational
delight."—

"Alas! not so; for how can mortals
think,

20

Or thoughts exchange, if thus they eat
and drink?

No! I confess, when we had fairly
dined,

That was no time for intercourse of
mind;

There was each dish prepared with
skill t' invite,

And to detain the struggling appetite;

On such occasions minds with one
consent

Are to the comforts of the body lent;

There was no pause—the wine went
quickly round,

Till struggling Fancy was by Bacchus
bound;

Wine is to wit as water thrown on
fire:

30

By duly sprinkling, both are raised
the higher;

Thus largely dealt, the vivid blaze
they choke,

And all the genial flame goes off in
smoke."—

"But when no more your boards
these loads contain,

When wine no more o'erwhelms the
labouring brain,

But serves, a gentle stimulus: we
know

How wit must sparkle, and how fancy
flow."—

It might be so, but no such club-
days come;
We always find these dampers in the
room.

If to converse were all that brought us
here,

40

A few odd members would in turn
appear;

Who, dwelling nigh, would saunter in
and out,

O'erlook the list, and toss the books
about;

Or, yawning, read them, walking up
and down,

Just as the loungers in the shops in
town;

Till, fancying nothing would their
minds amuse,

They'd push them by, and go in
search of news.

But our attractions are a stronger
sort,

The earliest dainties and the oldest
port;

All enter then with glee in every look,
50

And not a member thinks about a
book.

Still let me own, there are some
vacant hours,

When minds might work, and men
exert their powers:

Ere wine to folly spurs the giddy
guest,

But gives to wit its vigour and its
zest;

Then might we reason, might in turn
display
Our several talents, and be wisely
gay;
We might—but who a tame discourse
regards,
When whist is named, and we behold
the cards?
We from that time are neither grave
nor gay;

60

Our thought, our care, our business is
to play:
Fix'd on these spots and figures, each
attends
Much to his partners, nothing to his
friends.
Our public cares, the long, the
warm debate,
That kept our patriots from their beds
so late;
War, peace, invasion, all we hope or
dread,
Vanish like dreams when men forsake
their bed;
And groaning nations and contending
kings
Are all forgotten for these painted
things:
Paper and paste, vile figures and poor
spots,

70

Level all minds, philosophers and
sots;
And give an equal spirit, pause, and
force,

Join'd with peculiar diction, to
discourse:

"Who deals?—you led—we're three
by cards—had you

Honour in hand?"—"Upon my
honour, two."

Hour after hour, men thus contending
sit,

Grave without sense, and pointed
without wit.

Thus it appears these envied clubs
possess

No certain means of social happiness;
Yet there's a good that flows from
scenes like these—

80

Man meets with man at leisure and at
ease;

We to our neighbours and our equals
come,

And rub off pride that man contracts
at home;

For there, admitted master, he is
prone

To claim attention and to talk alone:

But here he meets with neither son
nor spouse;

No humble cousin to his bidding
bows;

To his raised voice his neighbours'
voices rise;

To his high look as lofty look replies;

When much he speaks, he finds that
ears are closed,

90

And certain signs inform him when
he's prosed;

Here all the value of a listener know,
And claim, in turn, the favour they
bestow.

No pleasure gives the speech,
when all would speak,
And all in vain a civil hearer seek.
To chance alone we owe the free
discourse,

In vain you purpose what you cannot
force;

'Tis when the favourite themes
unbidden spring,

That fancy soars with such unwearied
wing;

Then may you call in aid the
moderate glass,

100

But let it slowly and unprompted
pass;

So shall there all things for the end
unite,

And give that hour of rational delight.

Men to their clubs repair,
themselves to please,

To care for nothing, and to take their
ease;

In fact, for play, for wine, for news
they come;

Discourse is shared with friends, or
found at home.

But cards with books are incidental
things;

We've nights devoted to these queens
and kings.

Then, if we choose the social game,
we may;

110

Now, 'tis a duty, and we're bound to
play;

Nor ever meeting of the social kind
Was more engaging, yet had less of
mind.

Our eager parties, when the lunar
light

Throws its full radiance on the festive
night,

Of either sex, with punctual hurry
come,

And fill, with one accord, an ample
room.

Pleased, the fresh packs on cloth of
green they see,

And, seizing, handle with preluding
glee;

They draw, they sit, they shuffle, cut
and deal;

120

Like friends assembled, but like foes
to feel:

But yet not all—a happier few have
joys

Of mere amusement, and their cards
are toys;

No skill nor art, nor fretful hopes
have they,

But while their friends are gaming,
laugh and play.

Others there are, the veterans of the
game,

Who owe their pleasure to their
envied fame;
Through many a year, with hard-
contested strife,
Have they attain'd this glory of their
life.
Such is that ancient burgess, whom in
vain

130

Would gout and fever on his couch
detain;
And that large lady, who resolves to
come,
Though a first fit has warn'd her of
her doom!
These are as oracles: in every cause
They settle doubts, and their decrees
are laws;
But all are troubled, when, with
dubious look,
Diana questions what Apollo spoke.
Here avarice first, the keen desire
of gain,
Rules in each heart, and works in
every brain;
Alike the veteran-dames and virgins
feel,

140

Nor care what gray-beards or what
striplings deal;
Sex, age, and station, vanish from
their view,
And gold, their sov'reign good, the
mingled crowd pursue.
Hence they are jealous, and as
rivals, keep
A watchful eye on the beloved heap;

Meantime discretion bids the tongue
be still,
And mild good-humour strives with
strong ill-will;
Till prudence fails; when, all
impatient grown,
They make their grief, by their
suspensions, known.

"Sir, I protest, were Job himself at
play,

150

He'd rave to see you throw your cards
away;
Not that I care a button—not a pin
For what I lose; but we had cards to
win:

A saint in heaven would grieve to see
such hand

Cut up by one who will not
understand."—

"Complain of me! and so you
might indeed,
If I had ventured on that foolish lead,
That fatal heart—but I forgot your
play—

Some folk have ever thrown their
hearts away."—

"Yes, and their diamonds; I have
heard of one

160

Who made a beggar of an only
son."—

"Better a beggar, than to see him
tied
To art and spite, to insolence and
pride."—

"Sir, were I you, I'd strive to be
polite,
Against my nature, for a single
night."—

"So did you strive, and, madam!
with success;
I knew no being we could censure
less!"—

Is this too much? alas! my peaceful
muse
Cannot with half their virulence
abuse.
And hark! at other tables discord
reigns,

170

With feign'd contempt for losses and
for gains;
Passions awhile are bridled; then they
rage,
In waspish youth, and in resentful
age;
With scraps of insult—"Sir, when
next you play,
Reflect whose money 'tis you throw
away.

No one on earth can less such things
regard,
But when one's partner doesn't know
a card——"

"I scorn suspicion, ma'am, but
while you stand
Behind that lady, pray keep down
your hand."—

"Good heav'n, revoke! remember,
if the set

180

Be lost, in honour you should pay the
debt."—

"There, there's your money; but,
while I have life,
I'll never more sit down with man and
wife;
They snap and snarl indeed, but in the
heat
Of all their spleen, their
understandings meet;
They are Freemasons, and have many
a sign,
That we, poor devils! never can
divine:
May it be told, do ye divide th'
amount,
Or goes it all to family account?"

Next is the club, where to their
friends in town

190

Our country neighbours once a month
come down;
We term it Free-and-easy, and yet we
Find it no easy matter to be free:
Ev'n in our small assembly, friends
among,
Are minds perverse, there's
something will be wrong;
Men are not equal; some will claim a
right
To be the kings and heroes of the
night;

Will their own favourite themes and
notions start,
And you must hear, offend them, or
depart.

There comes Sir Thomas from his
village-seat,

200

Happy, he tells us, all his friends to
meet;

He brings the ruin'd brother of his
wife,

Whom he supports, and makes him
sick of life:

A ready witness whom he can
produce

Of all his deeds—a butt for his abuse.

Soon as he enters, has the guests
espied,

Drawn to the fire, and to the glass
applied—

"Well, what's the subject?—what are
you about?

The news, I take it—come, I'll help
you out;"—

And then, without one answer, he
bestows

210

Freely upon us all he hears and
knows;

Gives us opinions, }
tells us how he }
votes,

Recites the speeches, adds to
them his notes,

And gives old ill-told tales for
new-born anecdotes;

Yet cares he nothing what we judge
or think,
Our only duty's to attend and drink.
At length, admonish'd by his gout, he
ends
The various speech, and leaves at
peace his friends;
But now, alas! we've lost the pleasant
hour,
And wisdom flies from wine's
superior power.

220

Wine, like the rising sun,
possession gains,
And drives the mist of dulness from
the brains;
The gloomy vapour from the spirit
flies,
And views of gaiety and gladness
rise.
Still it proceeds, till from the glowing
heat,
The prudent calmly to their shades
retreat;—
Then is the mind o'ercast—in wordy
rage
And loud contention angry men
engage;
Then spleen and pique, like fire-
works thrown in spite,
To mischief turn the pleasures of the
night;

230

Anger abuses, Malice loudly rails,
Revenge awakes, and Anarchy
prevails:

Till wine, that raised the tempest,
 makes it cease,
And maudlin Love insists on instant
 peace;
He noisy mirth and roaring song
 commands,
Gives idle toasts, and joins unfriendly
 hands;
Till fuddled Friendship vows esteem
 and weeps,
And jovial Folly drinks and sings and
 sleeps.

A club there is of Smokers.—Dare
 you come
To that close, clouded, hot, narcotic
 room?

240

When, midnight past, the very
 candles seem
Dying for air, and give a ghastly
 gleam;
When curling fumes in lazy wreaths
 arise,
And prosing toppers rub their winking
 eyes;
When the long tale, renew'd when last
 they met,
Is spliced anew, and is unfinish'd yet;
When but a few are left the house to
 tire,
And they half-sleeping by the sleepy
 fire;

Ev'n the poor ventilating vane, that
flew
Of late so fast, is now grown drowsy
too;

250

When sweet, cold, clammy punch its
aid bestows,
Then thus the midnight conversation
flows:—

"Then, as I said, and—mind me—
as I say,
At our last meeting—you
remember"—"Ay;"

"Well, very well—then freely as I
drink

I spoke my thought—you take me—
what I think:

And sir, said I, if I a freeman be,
It is my bounden duty to be free."—

"Ay, there you posed him; I respect
the chair,

But man is man, although the man's a
mayor.

260

If Muggins live—no, no!—if
Muggins die,

He'll quit his office—neighbour, shall
I try?"—

"I'll speak my mind, for here are
none but friends:

They're all contending for their
private ends;

No public spirit, once }
a vote would }
bring;

I say a vote was then a pretty
thing;

It made a man to serve his
country and his king.
But for that place, that Muggins must
resign,
You've my advice—'tis no affair of
mine."

The poor man has his club; he
comes and spends
270
His hoarded pittance with his chosen
friends;
Nor this alone—a monthly dole he
pays,
To be assisted when his health
decays;
Some part his prudence, from the
day's supply,
For cares and troubles in his age, lays
by;
The printed rules he guards with
painted frame,
And shows his children where to read
his name:
Those simple words his honest nature
move,
That bond of union tied by laws of
love.
This is his pride, it gives to his
employ
280
New value, to his home another joy;
While a religious hope its balm
applies

For all his fate inflicts and all his
state denies.

Much would it please you,
sometimes to explore
The peaceful dwellings of our
borough poor;
To view a sailor just return'd from
sea;
His wife beside; a child on either
knee,
And others crowding near, that none
may lose
The smallest portion of the welcome
news:

What dangers pass'd, "when seas ran
mountains high,

290

When tempests raved, and horrors
veil'd the sky;

When prudence fail'd, when courage
grew dismay'd

When the strong fainted, and the
wicked pray'd,—

Then in the yawning gulf far down
we drove,

And gazed upon the billowy mount
above;

Till up that mountain, swinging with
the gale,

We view'd the horrors of the watery
vale."

The trembling children look with
stedfast eyes,

And panting, sob involuntary sighs:
Soft sleep awhile his torpid touch
delays,

300

And all is joy and piety and praise.

Masons are ours. Freemasons—
but, alas!
To their own bards I leave the mystic
class;
In vain shall one, and not a gifted
man,
Attempt to sing of this enlighten'd
clan:
I know no word, boast no directing
sign,
And not one token of the race is
mine;
Whether with Hiram, that wise
widow's son,
They came from Tyre to royal
Solomon,
Two pillars raising by their skill
profound,
310
Boaz and Jachin through the East
renown'd:
Whether the sacred books their rise
express,
Or books profane, 'tis vain for me to
guess.
It may be, lost in date remote and
high,
They know not what their own
antiquity;
It may be too, derived from cause so
low,

They have no wish their origin to
show.

If, as crusaders, they combined to
wrest

From heathen lords the land they long
possess'd,

Or were at first some harmless club,
who made

320

Their idle meetings solemn by
parade,

Is but conjecture—for the task unfit,
Awe-struck and mute, the puzzling
theme I quit.

Yet, if such blessings from their order
flow,

We should be glad their moral code to
know;

Trowels of silver are but simple
things,

And aprons worthless as their apron-
strings;

But, if indeed you have the skill to
teach

A social spirit, now beyond our reach;
If man's warm passions you can guide
and bind,

330

And plant the virtues in the wayward
mind;

If you can wake to christian-love the
heart—

In mercy, something of your powers
impart.

But, as it seems, we Masons must
become

To know the secret, and must then be
dumb;

And, as we venture for uncertain
gains,

Perhaps the profit is not worth the
pains.

When Bruce, the dauntless
traveller, thought he stood
On Nile's first rise, the fountain of the
flood,

And drank exulting in the sacred
spring,

340

The critics told him, it was no such
thing;

That springs unnumber'd round the
country ran,

But none could show him where they
first began:

So might we feel, should we our time
bestow

To gain these secrets and these signs
to know;

Might question still if all the truth we
found,

And firmly stood upon the certain
ground;

We might our title to the mystery
dread,

And fear we drank not at the river-
head.

Griggs and Gregorians here their
meetings hold,

350

Convivial sects, and Bucks alert and
bold:

A kind of Masons, but without their
sign;

The bonds of union—pleasure, song,
and wine.

Man, a gregarious creature, loves to
fly

Where he the trackings of the herd
can spy;

Still to be one with many he desires,
Although it leads him through the
thorns and briers.

A few—but few—there are, who in
the mind

Perpetual source of consolation find;
The weaker many to the world will
come,

360

For comforts seldom to be found
from home.

When the faint }
hands no }
more a
brimmer hold;

When flannel-wreaths the
useless limbs infold,

The breath impeded, and the
bosom cold;

When half the pillow'd man the palsy
chains,

And the blood falters in the bloated
veins—

Then, as our friends no further aid
supply

Than hope's cold phrase and
courtesy's soft sigh,
We should that comfort for ourselves
ensure,
Which friends could not, if we could
friends procure.

370

Early in life, when we can laugh
aloud,
There's something pleasant in a social
crowd,
Who laugh with us—but will such
joy remain,
When we lie struggling on the bed of
pain?
When our physician tells us with a
sigh,
No more on hope and science to rely,
Life's staff is useless then; with
labouring breath
We pray for hope divine—the staff of
death.
This is a scene which few
companions grace,
And where the heart's first favourites
yield their place.

380

Here all the aid of man to man
must end,
Here mounts the soul to her eternal
Friend;
The tenderest love must here its tie
resign,
And give th' aspiring heart to love
divine.
Men feel their weakness, and to
numbers run,

Themselves to strengthen, or
themselves to shun;
But though to this our weakness may
be prone,
Let's learn to live, for we must die,
alone.

LETTER XI.

INNS.

All the comforts of life in a tavern are
known,
'Tis his home who possesses not one of
his own;
And to him who has rather too much of
that one,
'Tis the house of a friend where he's
welcome to run:
The instant you enter my door you're my
lord,
With whose taste and whose pleasure I'm
proud to accord;
And the louder you call and the longer
you stay,
The more I am happy to serve and obey.

To the house of a friend if you're pleased
to retire,
You must all things admit, you must all
things admire;
You must pay with observance the price
of your treat,
You must eat what is praised, and must
praise what you eat:

But here you may come, and no tax we
require,
You may loudly condemn what you
greatly admire;
You may growl at our wishes and pains to
excel,
And may snarl at the rascals who please
you so well.

At your wish we attend, and confess that
your speech
On the nation's affairs might the minister
teach;
His views you may blame, and his
measures oppose,
There's no tavern-treason—you're under
the Rose:
Should rebellions arise in your own little
state,
With me you may safely their
consequence wait;
To recruit your lost spirits 'tis prudent to
come,
And to fly to a friend when the devil's at
home.

That I've faults is confess'd; but it won't
be denied,
'Tis my interest the faults of my
neighbours to hide;
If I've sometimes lent Scandal occasion
to prate,
I've often conceal'd what she'd love to
relate;
If to Justice's bar some have wander'd
from mine,

'Twas because the dull rogues wouldn't
stay by their wine;
And for brawls at my house, well the
poet explains,
That men drink *shallow draughts*, and so
madden their brains.

Difficult Subject for Poetry—Invocation of the Muse—Description of the principal Inn and those of the first Class—The large deserted Tavern—Those of a second Order—Their Company—One of particular Description—A lower Kind of Public-Houses; yet distinguished among themselves—Houses on the Quays for Sailors—The Green-Man: its Landlord, and the Adventure of his Marriage, &c.

LETTER XI.

INNS.

Much do I need, and therefore will
I ask,
A Muse to aid me in my present task;
For then with special cause we beg
for aid,
When of our subject we are most
afraid:
Inns are this subject—'tis an ill-drawn
lot;
So, thou who gravely triflest, fail me
not.
Fail not, but haste, and to my memory
bring
Scenes yet unsung, which few would
choose to sing:
Thou mad'st a Shilling splendid; thou
hast thrown
10
On humble themes the graces all
thine own;

By thee the Mistress of a village-
school
Became a queen, enthroned upon her
stool;
And far beyond the rest thou gav'st to
shine
Belinda's Lock—that deathless work
was thine.

Come, lend thy cheerful light, and
give to please
These seats of revelry, these scenes of
ease;
Who sings of Inns much danger has
to dread,
And needs assistance from the
fountain-head.

High in the street, o'erlooking all
the place,

20

The rampant Lion shows his kingly
face;
His ample jaws extend from side to
side,
His eyes are glaring, and his nostrils
wide;
In silver shag the sovereign form is
dress'd;
A mane horrific sweeps his ample
chest;
Elate with pride, he seems t' assert his
reign,
And stands, the glory of his wide
domain.

Yet nothing dreadful to his friends
the sight,
But sign and pledge of welcome and
delight:

To him the noblest guest the town
detains

30

Flies for repast, and in his court
remains;

Him too the crowd with longing
looks admire,

Sigh for his joys, and modestly retire;
Here not a comfort shall to them be
lost

Who never ask or never feel the cost.

The ample yards on either side
contain

Buildings where order and distinction
reign;—

The splendid carriage of the wealthier
guest,

The ready chaise and driver smartly
dress'd;

Whiskeys and gigs and curricles are
there,

40

And high-fed prancers, many a raw-
boned pair.

On all without a lordly host sustains
The care of empire, and observant
reigns;

The parting guest beholds him at his
side,

With pomp obsequious, bending in
his pride;

Round all the place his eyes all
objects meet,

Attentive, silent, civil, and discreet.

O'er all within the lady-hostess rules,
Her bar she governs, and her kitchen
schools;

To every guest th' appropriate speech
is made,

50

And every duty with distinction paid:
Respectful, easy, pleasant, or polite—
"Your honour's servant—Mister
Smith, good night."

Next, but not near, yet honour'd
through the town,
There swing, incongruous pair! the
Bear and Crown;
That Crown suspended gems and
ribands deck,
A golden chain hangs o'er that furry
neck.

Unlike the nobler beast, the Bear is
bound,
And with the Crown so near him,
scowls uncrown'd;
Less his dominion, but alert are all

60

Without, within, and ready for the
call;
Smart lads and light run nimbly here
and there,
Nor for neglected duties mourns the
Bear.

To his retreats, on the election-day,
The losing party found their silent
way;
There they partook of each consoling
good,
Like him uncrown'd, like him in
sullen mood—
Threat'ning, but bound.—Here meet a
social kind,

Our various clubs, for various cause
combined;
Nor has he pride, but thankful takes
as gain

70

The dew-drops shaken from the
Lion's mane:
A thriving couple here their skill
display,
And share the profits of no vulgar
sway.

Third in our Borough's list appears
the sign
Of a fair queen—the gracious
Caroline;
But in decay—each feature in the
face
Has stain of Time, and token of
disgrace.
The storm of winter, and the summer-
sun,
Have on that form their equal
mischief done;
The features now are all disfigured
seen,

80

And not one charm adorns th' insulted
queen:
To this poor face was never paint
applied,
Th' unseemly work of cruel Time to
hide;
Here we may rightly such neglect
upbraid;
Paint on such faces is by prudence
laid.

Large the domain, but all within
combine
To correspond with the dishonour'd
sign;
And all around dilapidates; you
call—
But none replies—they're inattentive
all.
At length a ruin'd stable holds your
steed,

90

While you through large and dirty
rooms proceed,
Spacious and cold; a proof they once
had been
In honour—now magnificently mean;
Till in some small half-furnish'd room
you rest,
Whose dying fire denotes it had a
guest.
In those you pass'd where former
splendour reign'd,
You saw the carpets torn, the paper
stain'd;
Squares of discordant glass in
windows fix'd,
And paper oil'd in many a space
betwixt;
A soil'd and broken sconce; a mirror
crack'd,

100

With table underpropp'd, and chairs
new-back'd;
A marble side-slab with ten thousand
stains,
And all an ancient tavern's poor
remains.

With much entreaty, they your food
prepare,
And acid wine afford, with meagre
fare;
Heartless you sup; and when a dozen
times
You've read the fractured window's
senseless rhymes;
Have been assured that Phœbe Green
was fair,
And Peter Jackson took his supper
there:
You reach a chilling chamber, where
you dread

110

Damps, hot or cold, from a
tremendous bed;
Late comes your sleep, and you are
waken'd soon
By rustling tatters of the old festoon.
O'er this large building, thus by
time defaced,
A servile couple has its owner placed,
Who, not unmindful that its style is
large,
To lost magnificence adapt their
charge.
Thus an old beauty, who has long
declined,
Keeps former dues and dignity in
mind;
And wills that all attention should be
paid

120

For graces vanish'd and for charms
decay'd.

Few years have pass'd, since
 brightly 'cross the way
Lights from each window shot the
 lengthen'd ray,
And busy looks in every face were
 seen,
Through the warm precincts of the
 reigning Queen.
There fires inviting blazed, and all
 around
Was heard the tinkling bells' seducing
 sound;
The nimble waiters to that sound
 from far
Sprang to the call, then hasten'd to the
 bar;
Where a glad priestess of the temple
 sway'd,

130

The most obedient, and the most
 obey'd;
Rosy and round, adorn'd in crimson
 vest,
And flaming ribands at her ample
 breast,
She, skill'd like Circe, tried her guests
 to move
With looks of welcome and with
 words of love;
And such her potent charms, that men
 unwise
Were soon transform'd and fitted for
 the sties.

Her port in bottles stood, a well-
 stain'd row,
Drawn for the evening from the pipe
 below;

Three powerful spirits fill'd a parted
case;

140

Some cordial-bottles stood in secret
place;

Fair acid fruits in nets above were
seen;

Her plate was splendid, and her
glasses clean;

Basins and bowls were ready on the
stand,

And measures clatter'd in her
powerful hand.

Inferior houses now our notice
claim,

But who shall deal them their
appropriate fame?

Who shall the nice, yet known
distinction, tell,

Between the peal complete and single
bell?

Determine, ye, who on your
shining nags

150

Wear oil-skin beavers and bear seal-
skin bags;

Or ye, grave toppers, who with coy
delight

Snugly enjoy the sweetness of the
night;

Ye travellers all, superior inns denied
By moderate purse, the low by decent
pride:

Come and determine,—will ye take
your place

At the *full* orb, or *half* the lunar face?

With the Black-Boy or Angel will ye
dine?

Will ye approve the Fountain or the
Vine?

Horses the *white* or *black* will ye
prefer?

160

The Silver-Swan, or swan opposed to
her—

Rare bird! whose form the raven-
plumage decks,

And graceful curve her three alluring
necks?

All these a decent entertainment
give,

And by their comforts comfortably
live.

Shall I pass by the Boar?—there
are who cry,

"Beware the Boar," and pass
determined by:

Those dreadful tusks, those little
peering eyes

And churning chaps, are tokens to the
wise.

There dwells a kind old aunt, and
there you see

170

Some kind young nieces in her
company—

Poor village nieces, whom the tender
dame

Invites to town, and gives their
beauty fame;

The grateful sisters feel th' important
aid,

And the good aunt is flatter'd and
repaid.

What though it may some cool
observers strike,
That such fair sisters should be so
unlike;
That still another and another comes,
And at the matron's table smiles and
blooms;
That all appear as if they meant to
stay

180

Time undefined, nor name a parting
day;
And yet, though all are valued, all are
dear,

Causeless, they go, and seldom more
appear:

Yet—let Suspicion hide her odious
head,

And Scandal vengeance from a
burgess dread—

A pious friend, who with the ancient
dame

At sober cribbage takes an evening
game;

His cup beside him, through their
play he quaffs,

And oft renews, and innocently
laughs;

Or, growing serious, to the text
resorts,

190

And from the Sunday-sermon makes
reports;

While all, with grateful glee, his wish
attend,

A grave protector and a powerful
friend.

But Slander says, who indistinctly
sees,

Once he was caught with Silvia on
his knees—

A cautious burgess with a careful
wife

To be so caught!—'tis false, upon my
life.

Next are a lower kind, yet not so
low

But they, among them, their
distinctions know;

And, when a thriving landlord aims
so high

200

As to exchange the Chequer for the
Pye,

Or from Duke William to the Dog
repairs,

He takes a finer coat and fiercer airs.

Pleased with his power, the poor
man loves to say

What favourite inn shall share his
evening's pay;

Where he shall sit the social hour, and
lose

His past day's labours and his next
day's views.

Our seamen too have choice: one
takes a trip

In the warm cabin of his favourite
ship;

And on the morrow in the humbler
boat

210

He rows, till fancy feels herself
afloat;
Can he the sign—Three Jolly Sailors
pass,
Who hears a fiddle and who sees a
lass?
The Anchor too affords the seaman
joys,
In small smoked room, all clamour,
crowd, and noise;
Where a curved settle half surrounds
the fire,
Where fifty voices purl and punch
require.
They come for pleasure in their
leisure hour,
And they enjoy it to their utmost
power;
Standing they drink, they swearing
smoke, while all

220

Call or make ready for a second call:
There is no time for trifling—"Do ye
see?
We drink and drub the French
extempore."
See! round the room, on every
beam and balk,
Are mingled scrolls of hieroglyphic
chalk;
Yet nothing heeded—would one
stroke suffice
To blot out all, here honour is too
nice—
"Let knavish landsmen think such
dirty things,

We're British tars, and British tars are
kings."

But the Green-Man shall I pass by
unsung,

230

Which mine own James upon his
sign-post hung?

His sign, his image,—for he once was
seen

A squire's attendant, clad in keeper's
green;

Ere yet, with wages more, and honour
less,

He stood behind me in a graver dress.

James in an evil hour went forth to
woo

Young Juliet Hart, and was her
Romeo:

They'd seen the play, and thought it
vastly sweet

For two young lovers by the moon to
meet;

The nymph was gentle, of her favours
free,

240

Ev'n at a word—no Rosalind was she;
Nor, like that other Juliet, tried his
truth

With—"Be thy purpose marriage,
gentle youth?"

But him received, and heard his
tender tale,

When sang the lark, and when the
nightingale:

So in few months the generous lass
was seen

I' the way that all the Capulets had
been.

Then first repentance seized the
amorous man,
And—shame on love—he reason'd
and he ran;
The thoughtful Romeo trembled for
his purse,

250

And the sad sounds, "for better and
for worse."

Yet could the lover not so far
withdraw,
But he was haunted both by love and
law:
Now law dismay'd him as he view'd
its fangs,
Now pity seized him for his Juliet's
pangs;
Then thoughts of justice and some
dread of jail,
Where all would blame him and
where none might bail;
These drew him back, till Juliet's hut
appear'd,
Where love had drawn him when he
should have fear'd.

There sat the father in his wicker
throne,

260

Uttering his curses in tremendous
tone;
With foulest names his daughter he
reviled,
And look'd a very Herod at the child:
Nor was she patient, but with equal
scorn,

Bade him remember when his Joe
was born:

Then rose the mother, eager to begin
Her plea for frailty, when the swain
came in.

To him she turn'd, and other theme
began,
Show'd him his boy, and bade him be
a man—

"An honest man, who, when he
breaks the laws,

270

Will make a woman honest if there's
cause."

With lengthened speech she proved
what came to pass

Was no reflection on a loving lass:

"If she your love as wife and mother
claim,

What can it matter which was first the
name?

But 'tis most base, 'tis perjury and
theft,

When a lost girl is like a widow left;

The rogue who ruins"—here the
father found

His spouse was treading on forbidden
ground.

"That's not the point," quoth he,
—"I don't suppose

280

My good friend Fletcher to be one of
those;

What's done amiss he'll mend in
proper time—

I hate to hear of villany and crime.

'Twas my misfortune, in the days of
youth,
To find two lasses pleading for my
truth;
The case was hard, I would with all
my soul
Have wedded both, but law is our
control;
So one I took, and when we gain'd a
home,
Her friend agreed—what could she
more?—to come;
And when she found that I'd a
widow'd bed,

290

Me she desired—what could I less?—
to wed.
An easier case is yours: you've not
the smart
That two fond pleaders cause in one
man's heart;
You've not to wait from year to year
distress'd,
Before your conscience can be laid at
rest;
There smiles your bride, there
sprawls your new-born son,
—A ring, a licence, and the thing is
done."

"My loving James,"—the lass
began her plea,
"I'll make thy reason take a part with
me.
Had I been froward, skittish, or
unkind,

300

Or to thy person or thy passion blind;

Had I refused, when 'twas thy part to
prayer,
Or put thee off with promise and
delay;
Thou might'st in justice and in
conscience fly,
Denying her who taught thee to deny:
But, James, with me thou hadst an
easier task,
Bonds and conditions I forbore to
ask;
"I laid no traps for thee, no plots or
plans,
Nor marriage named by licence or by
banns;
Nor would I now the parson's aid
employ,

310

But for this cause"—and up she held
her boy.

Motives like these could heart of
flesh resist?
James took the infant and in triumph
kiss'd;
Then to his mother's arms the child
restored,
Made his proud speech, and pledged
his worthy word.

"Three times at church our banns
shall publish'd be,
Thy health be drunk in bumpers three
times three;
And thou shalt grace (bedeck'd in
garments gay)
The christening-dinner on the
wedding day."

James at my door then made his
parting bow,
320
Took the Green-Man, and is a master
now.

LETTER XII.

PLAYERS.

These are monarchs none respect;
Heroes, yet an humbled crew;
Nobles, whom the crowd correct;
Wealthy men, whom duns pursue;
Beauties, shrinking from the view
Of the day's detecting eye;
Lovers, who with much ado
Long-forsaken damsels woo,
And heave the ill-feign'd sigh.

These are misers, craving means
Of existence through the day;
Famous scholars, conning scenes
Of a dull bewildering play;
Ragged beaux and misses grey,
Whom the rabble praise and blame;
Proud and mean, and sad and gay,
Toiling after ease, are they,
Infamous^[63], and boasting fame.

ers arrive in the Borough—Welcomed by their former Friends—Are better fitted for Comic than Tragic Scenes: yet better approved in the latter by one Part of their Audience—Their general Character and Pleasantry—Particular Distresses and Labours—Their Fortitude and Patience—A private Rehearsal—The Vanity of the aged Actress—A Heroine from the Milliner's Shop—A deluded Tradesman—Of what Persons the Company is composed—Character and Adventures of Frederick Thompson.

LETTER XII.

PLAYERS.

Drawn by the annual }
call, we now }
behold
Our troop dramatic, heroes
known of old,
And those, since last they
march'd, inlisted and enroll'd:
Mounted on hacks or borne in
waggon some,
The rest on foot (the humbler
brethren) come.
Three favour'd places, an unequal
time,
Join to support this company sublime:
Ours for the longer }
period—see }
how light
Yon parties move, their
former friends in sight,
10
Whose claims are all allow'd, and
friendship glads the night.
Now public rooms shall sound with
words divine,
And private lodgings hear how heroes
shine;
No talk of pay shall yet on pleasure
steal,
But kindest welcome bless the
friendly meal;
While o'er the social jug and decent
cheer,

Shall be described the fortunes of the
year.

Peruse these bills, and see what
each can do,—
Behold! the prince, the slave, the
monk, the Jew;
Change but the garment, and they'll
all engage

20

To take each part, and act in every
age.

Cull'd from all houses, what a house
are they!

Swept from all barns, our borough-
critics say;

But with some portion of a critic's ire,
We all endure them; there are some
admire:

They might have praise, confined to
farce alone;

Full well they grin—they should not
try to groan;

But then our servants' and our
seamen's wives

Love all that rant and rapture as their
lives;

He who 'Squire Richard's part could
well sustain,

30

Finds as King Richard he must roar
amain,

"My horse! my horse!"—Lo! now to
their abodes,

Come lords and lovers, empresses
and gods.

The master-mover of these scenes has
made

No trifling gain in this adventurous
trade;—

Trade we may term it, for he duly
buys

Arms out of use and undirected eyes;
These he instructs, and guides them
as he can,

And vends each night the
manufactured man.

Long as our custom lasts, they gladly
stay,

40

Then strike their tents, like Tartars!
and away!

The place grows bare where they too
long remain,

But grass will rise ere they return
again.

Children of Thespis, welcome!
knights and queens!

Counts! barons! beauties! when
before your scenes,

And mighty monarchs thund'ring
from your throne;

Then step behind, and all your glory's
gone:

Of crown and palace, throne and
guards bereft,

The pomp is vanish'd, and the care is
left.

Yet strong and lively is the joy they
feel,

50

When the full house secures the
plenteous meal;

Flatt'ring and flatter'd, each attempts
to raise

A brother's merits for a brother's
praise:

For never hero shows a prouder heart,
Than he who proudly acts a hero's
part—

Nor without cause; the boards, we
know, can yield

Place for fierce contest, like the
tented field.

Graceful to tread the stage, to be in
turn

The prince we honour, and the knave
we spurn;

Bravely to bear the tumult of the
crowd,

60

The hiss tremendous, and the censure
loud:

These are their parts—and he who
these sustains

Deserves some praise and profit for
his pains.

Heroes at least of }
gentler kind }
are they,

Against whose swords no
weeping widows pray,

No blood their fury sheds, nor
havoc marks their way.

Sad happy race! soon raised and
soon depress'd;

Your days all pass'd in jeopardy and
jest;

Poor without prudence, with
afflictions vain,

Not warn'd by misery, not enrich'd by
gain;

70

Whom justice pitying, chides from
place to place,
A wandering, careless, wretched,
merry race;
Who cheerful looks assume, and play
the parts
Of happy rovers with repining hearts;
Then cast off care, and in the mimic
pain
Of tragic wo, feel spirits light and
vain,
Distress and hope—the mind's, the
body's wear,
The man's affliction, and the actor's
tear:
Alternate times of fasting and excess
Are yours, ye smiling children of
distress.

80

Slaves though ye }
be, your
wandering freedom seems,
And with your varying views
and restless schemes,
Your griefs are transient, as
your joys are dreams.
Yet keen those griefs—ah! what
avail thy charms,
Fair Juliet! what that infant in thine
arms;
What those heroic lines thy patience
learns,
What all the aid thy present Romeo
earns,
Whilst thou art crowded in that
lumbering wain,

With all thy plaintive sisters to
complain?

Nor is there lack of labour.—To
rehearse,

90

Day after day, poor scraps of prose
and verse;

To bear each other's spirit, pride, and
spite;

To hide in rant the heart-ache of the
night;

To dress in gaudy patch-work, and to
force

The mind to think on the appointed
course:

This is laborious, and may be defined
The bootless labour of the thriftless
mind.

There is a veteran dame—I see her
stand

Intent and pensive with her book in
hand;

Awhile her thoughts she forces on her
part,

100

Then dwells on objects nearer to the
heart;

Across the room she paces, gets her
tone,

And fits her features for the Danish
throne;

To-night a queen—I mark her motion
slow,

I hear her speech, and Hamlet's
mother know.

Methinks 'tis pitiful to see her try

For strength of arms and energy of
eye;
With vigour lost, and spirits worn
away,
Her pomp and pride she labours to
display;
And when awhile she's tried her part
to act,

110

To find her thoughts arrested by some
fact;
When struggles more and more
severe are seen
In the plain actress than the Danish
queen;—
At length she feels her part, she finds
delight,
And fancies all the plaudits of the
night:
Old as she is, she smiles at every
speech,
And thinks no youthful part beyond
her reach.

But, as the mist of vanity again
Is blown away by press of present
pain,
Sad and in doubt she to her purse
applies

120

For cause of comfort, where no
comfort lies;
Then to her task she sighing turns
again,—
"Oh! Hamlet, thou hast cleft my heart
in twain!"
And who that poor, consumptive,
wither'd thing,

Who strains her slender throat and
 strives to sing?
Panting for breath, and forced her
 voice to drop,
And far unlike the inmate of the shop,
Where she, in youth and health, alert
 and gay,
Laugh'd off at night the labours of the
 day;
With novels, verses, fancy's fertile
 powers,

130

And sister-converse pass'd the
 evening-hours;
But Cynthia's soul was soft, her
 wishes strong,
Her judgment weak, and her
 conclusions wrong.
The morning-call and counter were
 her dread,
And her contempt the needle and the
 thread;
But, when she read a gentle damsel's
 part,
Her wo, her wish—she had them all
 by heart.

At length the hero of the boards
 drew nigh,
Who spake of love till sigh re-echo'd
 sigh;
He told in honey'd words his
 deathless flame,

140

And she his own by tender vows
 became;
Nor ring nor licence needed souls so
 fond,

Alphonso's passion was his Cynthia's
bond:

And thus the simple girl, to shame
betray'd,

Sinks to the grave forsaken and
dismay'd.

Sick without pity, sorrowing
without hope,

See her, the grief and scandal of the
troop;

A wretched martyr to a childish pride,
Her wo insulted, and her praise
denied;

Her humble talents, though derided,
used,

150

Her prospects lost, her confidence
abused;

All that remains—for she not long
can brave

Increase of evils—is an early grave,
Ye gentle Cynthias of the shop,
take heed

What dreams ye cherish, and what
books ye read.

A decent sum had Peter Nottage
made,

By joining bricks—to him a thriving
trade.

Of his employment master and his
wife,

This humble tradesman led a lordly
life;

The house of kings and heroes lack'd
repairs,

160

And Peter, though reluctant, served
the players:
Connected thus, he heard in way
polite,—
"Come, Master Nottage, see us play
to-night."
At first 'twas folly, nonsense, idle
stuff,
But seen for nothing it grew well
enough;
And better now—now best, and every
night
In this fool's paradise he drank
delight;
And, as he felt the bliss, he wish'd to
know
Whence all this rapture and these joys
could flow;
For, if the seeing could such pleasure
bring,

170

What must the feeling?—feeling like
a king?
In vain his wife, his uncle, and his
friend,
Cried—"Peter! Peter! let such follies
end;
'Tis well enough these vagabonds to
see,
But would you partner with a
showman be?"
"Showman!" said Peter, "did not
Quin and Clive,
And Roscius-Garrick, by the science
thrive?
Showman!—'tis scandal; I'm by
genius led

To join a class who've Shakspeare at
their head."

Poor Peter thus by easy steps
became

180

A dreaming candidate for scenic
fame;

And, after years consumed, infirm
and poor,

He sits and takes the tickets at the
door.

Of various men these marching
troops are made—

Pen-spurning clerks, and lads
contemning trade;

Waiters and servants by confinement
teased,

And youths of wealth by dissipation
eased;

With feeling nymphs, who, such
resource at hand,

Scorn to obey the rigour of
command;

Some, who from higher views by vice
are won,

190

And some of either sex by love
undone;

The greater part lamenting as their
fall

What some an honour and
advancement call.

There are who names in shame or
fear assume,

And hence our Bevilles and our
Savilles come:

It honours him, from tailor's board
kick'd down,
As Mister Dormer to amuse the town;
Falling, he rises: but a kind there are
Who dwell on former prospects, and
despair;
Justly, but vainly, they their fate
deplore,

200

And mourn their fall who fell to rise
no more.

Our merchant Thompson, with his
sons around,
Most mind and talent in his Frederick
found:
He was so lively, that his mother
knew,
If he were taught, that honour must
ensue;
The father's views were in a different
line;
But if at college he were sure to
shine,
Then should he go—to prosper, who
could doubt—
When school-boy stigmas would be
all wash'd out;
For there were marks upon his
youthful face,

210

'Twixt vice and error—a neglected
case:
These would submit to skill; a little
time,
And none could trace the error or the
crime;

Then let him go, and once at college,
he

Might choose his station—what
would Frederick be?

'Twas soon determined.—He could
not descend
To pedant-laws and lectures without
end;

And then the chapel—night and morn
to pray,

Or mulct and threaten'd if he kept
away;

No! not to be a bishop—so he swore,
220

And at his college he was seen no
more.

His debts all paid, the father with a
sigh,

Placed him in office—"Do, my
Frederick, try;

"Confine thyself a few short months,
and then——"

He tried a fortnight, and threw down
the pen.

Again demands were hush'd: "My
son, you're free,

But you're unsettled; take your
chance at sea:"

So in few days the midshipman
equipp'd,

Received the mother's blessing and
was shipp'd.

Hard was her fortune! soon
compell'd to meet

230

The wretched stripling staggering
through the street;

For, rash, impetuous, insolent and
vain,
The captain sent him to his friends
again.
About the borough roved th' unhappy
boy,
And ate the bread of every chance-
employ;
Of friends he borrow'd, and the
parents yet
In secret fondness authorised the
debt;
The younger sister, still a child, was
taught
To give with feign'd affright the
pittance sought;
For now the father cried—"It is too
late

240

For trial more—I leave him to his
fate"—
Yet left him not; and with a kind of
joy
The mother heard of her desponding
boy:
At length he sicken'd, and he found,
when sick,
All aid was ready, all attendance
quick;
A fever seized him, and at once was
lost
The thought of trespass, error, crime
and cost;
Th' indulgent parents knelt beside the
youth;
They heard his promise and believed
his truth;

And, when the danger lessen'd on
their view,

250

They cast off doubt, and hope
assurance grew;—

Nursed by his sisters, cherish'd by his
sire,

Begg'd to be glad, encouraged to
aspire,

His life, they said, would now all care
repay,

And he might date his prospects from
that day;

A son, a brother to his home received,
They hoped for all things, and in all
believed.

And now will pardon, comfort,
kindness, draw

The youth from vice? will honour,
duty, law?

Alas! not all: the more the trials lent,
260

The less he seem'd to ponder and
repent;

Headstrong, determined in his own
career,

He thought reproof unjust and truth
severe;

The soul's disease was to its crisis
come,

He first abused and then abjured his
home;

And when he chose a vagabond to be,
He made his shame his glory—"I'll be
free."

Friends, parents, relatives, hope,
reason, love,

With anxious ardour for that empire
strove;

In vain their strife, in vain the means
applied,

270

They had no comfort, but that all
were tried;

One strong vain trial made, the mind
to move,

Was the last effort of parental love.

Ev'n then he watch'd his father
from his home,

And to his mother would for pity
come,

Where, as he made her tender terrors
rise,

He talk'd of death, and threaten'd for
supplies.

Against a youth so vicious and
undone

All hearts were closed, and every
door but one:

The players received him; they with
open heart

280

Gave him his portion and assign'd his
part;

And ere three days were added to his
life,

He found a home, a duty, and a wife.

His present friends, though they
were nothing nice,

Nor ask'd how vicious he, or what his
vice,

Still they expected he should now
attend

To the joint duty as an useful friend;

The leader too declared, with frown
severe,
That none should pawn a robe that
kings might wear;
And much it moved him, when he
Hamlet play'd,

290

To see his Father's Ghost so drunken
made.

Then too the temper, the unbending
pride

Of this ally would no reproof
abide:—

So, leaving these, he march'd away
and join'd

Another troop, and other goods
purloin'd;

And other characters, both gay and
sage,

Sober and sad, made stagger on the
stage;

Then to rebuke, with arrogant
disdain,

He gave abuse, and sought a home
again.

Thus changing scenes, but with
unchanging vice,

300

Engaged by many, but with no one
twice:

Of this, a last and poor resource,
bereft,

He to himself, unhappy guide! was
left—

And who shall say where guided? to
what seats

Of starving villany? of thieves and
cheats?

In that sad time, of many a dismal
scene

Had he a witness (not inactive) been;
Had leagued with petty pilferers, and
had crept,

Where of each sex degraded numbers
slept.

With such associates }
he was long }
allied,

310

Where his capacity for ill was tried,
And, that once lost, the wretch
was cast aside;

For now, though willing with the
worst to act,

He wanted powers for an important
fact;

And, while he felt as lawless spirits
feel,

His hand was palsied, and he couldn't
steal.

By these rejected, is there lot so
strange,

So low, that he could suffer by the
change?

Yes! the new station as a fall we
judge—

He now became the harlot's humble
drudge,

320

Their drudge in common: they
combined to save

Awhile from starving their
submissive slave;

For now his spirit left him, and his
pride,
His scorn, his rancour, and
resentment died;
Few were his feelings—but the
keenest these,
The rage of hunger, and the sigh for
ease;
He who abused indulgence, now
became
By want subservient and by misery
tame;
A slave, he begg'd forbearance; bent
with pain,
He shunn'd the blow—"Ah! strike me
not again."

330

Thus was he found: the master of a
hoy
Saw the sad wretch, whom he had
known a boy
At first in doubt; but Frederick laid
aside
All shame, and humbly for his aid
applied.
He, tamed and smitten with the
storms gone by,
Look'd for compassion through one
living eye,
And stretch'd th' }
unpalsied }
hand; the
seaman felt
His honest heart with gentle
pity melt,
And his small boon with
cheerful frankness dealt;

Then made inquiries of th' unhappy
youth,

340

Who told, nor shame forbade him, all
the truth.

"Young Frederick Thompson to a
chandler's shop
By harlots order'd and afraid to stop!

—

What! our good merchant's favourite
to be seen

In state so loathsome and in dress so
mean?"—

So thought the seaman as he bade
adieu,
And, when in port, related all he
knew.

But time was lost, inquiry came too
late,
Those whom he served knew nothing
of his fate;
No! they had seized on what the
sailor gave,

350

Nor bore resistance from their abject
slave;

The spoil obtain'd, they cast him from
the door,

Robb'd, beaten, hungry, pain'd,
diseased and poor.

Then nature (pointing to the only
spot
Which still had comfort for so dire a
lot,)
Although so feeble, led him on the
way,

And hope look'd forward to a happier
day.

He thought, poor prodigal! a father
yet

His woes would pity and his crimes
forget;

Nor had he brother who with speech
severe

360

Would check the pity or refrain the
tear:

A lighter spirit in his bosom rose,

As near the road he sought an hour's
repose.

And there he found it: he had left
the town,

But buildings yet were scatter'd up
and down;

To one of these, half-ruin'd and half-
built,

Was traced this child of wretchedness
and guilt;

There on the remnant of a beggar's
vest,

Thrown by in scorn, the sufferer
sought for rest;

There was this scene of vice and wo
to close,

370

And there the wretched body found
repose.

FOOTNOTES:

^[63] Strolling players are thus held in a legal sense.

LETTER XIII.

THE ALMS-HOUSE AND TRUSTEES.

Do good by stealth, and blush to find it
fame.

[*Pope,*
Epil
ogu
e to
the
Sati
res,
Dial
ogu
e I.,
v.
136.
]

There are a sort of men whose visages
Do cream and mantle like a standing
[pond,]
And do a wilful stillness entertain,
With purpose to be dress'd in an
opinion[...]
As who should say, "I am Sir Oracle,
And when I ope my lips, let no dog
bark!"

Merchant
of
Veni
ce
[*Act*
I.

Sc.
1.
vv.
88-
94].

Sum felix; quis enim neget? felixque
manebo;
Hoc quoque quis dubitet? Tutum me
copia fecit.

frugal Merchant—Rivalship in Modes of Frugality—Private Exceptions to the general Manners—
Alms-House built—Its Description—Founder dies—Six Trustees—Sir Denys Brand, a Principal—
His Eulogium in the Chronicles of the Day—Truth reckoned invidious on these Occasions—An
Explanation of the Magnanimity and Wisdom of Sir Denys—His Kinds of Moderation and
Humility—Laughton, his Successor, a planning, ambitious, wealthy Man—Advancement in Life
his perpetual Object, and all Things made the Means of it—His Idea of Falsehood—His
Resentment dangerous: how removed—Success produces Love of Flattery: his daily Gratification
—His Merits and Acts of Kindness—His proper Choice of Alms-Men—In this Respect
meritorious—His Predecessor not so cautious.

LETTER XIII.

THE ALMS-HOUSE AND TRUSTEES.

Leave now our streets, and in yon
plain behold
Those pleasant seats for the reduced
and old;
A merchant's gift, whose wife and
children died,
When he to saving all his powers
applied;
He wore his coat till bare was every
thread,
And with the meanest fare his body
fed.

He had a female cousin, who with
care
Walk'd in his steps and learn'd of him
to spare;
With emulation and success they
strove,

10

Improving still, still seeking to
improve,
As if that useful knowledge they
would gain—
How little food would human life
sustain:

No pauper came their table's crumbs to
crave;

Scraping they lived, but not a scrap
they gave:

When beggars saw the frugal
merchant pass,

It moved their pity, and they said,
"Alas!

Hard is thy fate, my brother," and
they felt

A beggar's pride as they that pity
dealt:

The dogs, who learn of man to scorn
the poor,

20

Bark'd him away from ev'ry decent
door;

While they who saw him bare, but
thought him rich,

To show respect or scorn, they knew
not which.

But while our merchant seem'd so
base and mean,

He had his wanderings, sometimes,
"not unseen;"

To give in secret was a favourite act,
Yet more than once they took him in
the fact.

To scenes of various wo he nightly
went,

And serious sums in healing misery
spent;

Oft has he cheer'd the wretched, at a
rate

30

For which he daily might have dined
on plate;

He has been seen—his }
hair all silver- }
white,

Shaking and shining—as he
stole by night,

To feed unenvied on his still
delight.

A two-fold taste he had: to give and
spare,

Both were his duties, and had equal
care;

It was his joy, to sit alone and fast,
Then send a widow and her boys
repast.

Tears in his eyes would, spite of him,
appear,

But he from other eyes has kept the
tear:

40

All in a wint'ry night from far he
came,

To soothe the sorrows of a suff'ring
dame;

Whose husband robb'd him, and to
whom he meant
A ling'ring, but reforming
punishment.
Home then he walk'd, and found his
anger rise,
When fire and rush-light met his
troubled eyes;
But, these extinguish'd, and his prayer
address'd
To Heaven in hope, he calmly sank to
rest.

His seventieth year was pass'd, and
then was seen
A building rising on the northern
green;

50

There was no blinding all his
neighbours' eyes,
Or surely no one would have seen it
rise.

Twelve rooms contiguous stood, and
six were near;

There men were placed, and sober
matrons here;

There were behind small useful
gardens made,

Benches before, and trees to give
them shade;

In the first room were seen, above,
below,

Some marks of taste, a few attempts
at show;

The founder's picture and his arms
were there

(Not till he left us), and an elbow'd
chair;

60

There, 'mid these signs of his superior
place,
Sat the mild ruler of this humble race.
Within the row are men who strove
in vain,
Through years of trouble, wealth and
ease to gain;
Less must they have than an
appointed sum,
And freemen been, or hither must not
come;
They should be decent and command
respect
(Though needing fortune,) whom
these doors protect,
And should for thirty dismal years
have tried
For peace unfelt and competence
denied.

70

Strange, that o'er men thus train'd
in sorrow's school,
Power must be held, and they must
live by rule!
Infirm, corrected by misfortunes, old,
Their habits settled and their passions
cold;
Of health, wealth, power, and worldly
cares, bereft,
Still must they not at liberty be left;
There must be one to rule them, to
restrain
And guide the movements of his
erring train.
If then control imperious, check
severe,

Be needed where such reverend men
appear;

80

To what would youth, without such
checks, aspire,
Free the wild wish, uncurb'd the
strong desire?

And where (in college or in camp)
they found

The heart ungovern'd and the hand
unbound?

His house endow'd, the generous
man resign'd

All power to rule, nay power of
choice declined;

He and the female saint survived to
view

Their work complete, and bade the
world adieu!

Six are the guardians of this happy
seat,

And one presides when they on
business meet;

90

As each expires, the five a brother
choose;

Nor would Sir Denys Brand the
charge refuse;

True, 'twas beneath him, "but to do
men good

Was motive never by his heart
withstood."

He too is gone, and they again must
strive

To find a man in whom his gifts
survive.

Now, in the various records of the
dead,
Thy worth, Sir Denys, shall be
weigh'd and read;
There we the glory of thy house shall
trace,
With each alliance of thy noble race.
100

Yes! here we have him!—"Came in
William's reign
The Norman-Brand, the blood
without a stain;
From the fierce Dane and ruder
Saxon clear,
Pict, Irish, Scot, or Cambrian
mountaineer;
But the pure Norman was the sacred
spring,
And he, Sir Denys, was in heart a
king:
Erect in person and so firm in soul,
Fortune he seem'd to govern and
control;
"Generous as he who gives his all
away,
Prudent as one who toils for weekly
pay;

110
In him all merits were decreed to
meet—
Sincere though cautious, frank and
yet discreet;
Just all his dealings, faithful every
word;
His passions' master, and his temper's
lord."

Yet more, kind dealers in decaying
fame?
His magnanimity you next proclaim;
You give him learning, join'd with
sound good sense,
And match his wealth with his
benevolence;
What hides the multitude of sins, you
add—
Yet seem to doubt if sins he ever had.
120

Poor honest Truth! thou writ'st of
living men,
And art a railer and detractor then;
They die, again to be described, and
now
A foe to merit and mankind art thou!
Why banish truth? it injures not the
dead;
It aids not them with flattery to be
fed;
And, when mankind such perfect
pictures view,
They copy less, the more they think
them true.
Let us a mortal as he was behold,
And see the dross adhering to the
gold;

130
When we the errors of the virtuous
state,
Then erring men their worth may
emulate.
View then this picture of a noble
mind:
Let him be wise, magnanimous, and
kind;

What was the wisdom? Was it not the
frown
That keeps all question, all inquiry
down?
His words were powerful and
decisive all;
But his slow reasons came for no
man's call.
"'Tis thus," he cried, no doubt with
kind intent,
To give results and spare all
argument.—

140

"Let it be spared—all men at least
agree
Sir Denys Brand had magnanimity:
His were no vulgar charities; none
saw
Him like the merchant to the hut
withdraw;
He left to meaner minds the simple
deed,
By which the houseless rest, the
hungry feed;
His was a public bounty vast and
grand;
'Twas not in him to work with
viewless hand;
He raised the room that towers above
the street,
A public room where grateful parties
meet;

150

He first the life-boat plann'd; to him
the place
Is deep in debt—'twas he reviv'd the
race;

To every public act this hearty friend
Would give with freedom or with
frankness lend;
His money built the jail, nor prisoner
yet
Sits at his ease, but he must feel the
debt;
To these let candour }
add his vast }
display—
Around his mansion all is
grand and gay,
And this is bounty with the
name of pay."

I grant the whole, nor from one
deed retract,

160

But wish recorded too the private act;
All these were great, but still our
hearts approve
Those simpler tokens of the Christian
love;
'Twould give me joy some gracious
deed to meet,
That has not call'd for glory through
the street.
Who felt for many, could not always
shun,
In some soft moment, to be kind to
one;
And yet they tell us, when Sir Denys
died,
That not a widow in the Borough
sigh'd;
Great were his gifts, his mighty heart
I own,

170

But why describe what all the world
has known?

The rest is petty pride, the useless
art

Of a vain mind to hide a swelling
heart.

Small was his private room; men
found him there

By a plain table, on a paltry chair;
A wretched floor-cloth, and some
prints around,

The easy purchase of a single pound:
These humble trifles and that study
small

Make a strong contrast with the
servants' hall;

There barely comfort, here a proud
excess,

180

The pompous seat of pamper'd
idleness,

Where the sleek rogues with one
consent declare,

They would not live upon his
honour's fare.

He daily took but one half-hour to
dine,

On one poor dish and some three sips
of wine;

Then he'd abuse them for their
sumptuous feasts,

And say, "My friends! you make
yourselves like beasts;

One dish suffices any man to dine,

But you are greedy as a herd of
swine;

Learn to be temperate."—Had they
dared t' obey,

190

He would have praised and turn'd
them all away.

Friends met Sir Denys riding in his
ground,
And there the meekness of his spirit
found:

For that grey coat, not new for many
a year,

Hides all that would like decent dress
appear;

An old brown pony 'twas his will to
ride,

Who shuffled onward, and from side
to side;

A five-pound purchase, but so fat and
sleek,

His very plenty made the creature
weak.

"Sir Denys Brand! and on so poor a
steed!"—

200

"Poor! it may be—such things I never
heed:"

And who that youth behind, of
pleasant mien,

Equipp'd as one who wishes to be
seen,

Upon a horse, twice victor for a plate,
A noble hunter, bought at dearest
rate?—

Him the lad, fearing, yet resolved to
guide,

He curbs his spirit, while he strokes
his pride.

"A handsome youth, Sir Denys;
and a horse
Of finer figure never trod the
course—
Yours, without question?"—"Yes! I
think, a groom

210

Bought me the beast; I cannot say the
sum:
I ride him not, it is a foolish pride
Men have in cattle—but my people
ride;
The boy is—hark ye, sirrah! what's
your name?
Ay, Jacob, yes! I recollect—the same,
As I bethink me now, a tenant's son—
I think a tenant—is your father one?"

There was an idle boy who ran
about,
And found his master's humble spirit
out;
He would at awful distance snatch a
look,

220

Then run away and hide him in some
nook;
"For oh!" quoth he, "I dare not fix my
sight
On him, his grandeur puts me in a
fright;
Oh! Mister Jacob, when you wait on
him,
Do you not quake and tremble every
limb?"
The steward soon had orders
—"Summers, see

That Sam be clothed, and let him wait
on me."

Sir Denys died, bequeathing all
affairs
In trust to Laughton's long
experienced cares,
Before a guardian; and, Sir Denys
dead,

230

All rule and power devolved upon his
head.

Numbers are call'd to govern, but in
fact

Only the powerful and assuming act.

Laughton, too wise to be a dupe to
fame,

Cared not a whit of what descent he
came,

Till he was rich; he then conceived
the thought

To fish for pedigree, but never
caught.

All his desire, when he was young
and poor,

Was to advance; he never cared for
more:

"Let me buy, sell, be factor, take a
wife,

240

Take any road to get along in life."

Was he a miser then? a robber? foe
To those who trusted? a deceiver?—
No!

He was ambitious; all his powers of
mind
Were to one end controll'd, improved,
combined;
Wit, learning, judgment, were, by his
account,
Steps for the ladder he design'd to
mount.
Such step was money: wealth was but
his slave,
For power he gain'd it, and for power
he gave;
Full well the Borough knows that
he'd the art

250

Of bringing money to the surest mart;
Friends too were aids, they led to
certain ends,
Increase of power and claim on other
friends.
A favourite step was marriage: then
he gain'd
Seat in our hall, and o'er his party
reign'd;
Houses and lands he bought, and
long'd to buy,
But never drew the springs of
purchase dry;
And thus at last they answer'd every
call,
The failing found him ready for their
fall.
He walks along the street, the mart,
the quay,

260

And looks and mutters, "This belongs
to me."

His passions all }
partook the }
general bent;
Interest inform'd him when he
should resent,
How long resist, and on what
terms relent.
In points where he determined to
succeed,
In vain might reason or compassion
plead;
But gain'd his point, he was the best
of men,
'Twas loss of time to be vexatious
then:
Hence he was mild to all men whom
he led,
Of all who dared resist the scourge
and dread.

270

Falsehood in him was not the
useless lie
Of boasting pride or laughing vanity;
It was the gainful, the persuading art,
That made its way and won the
doubting heart,
Which argued, soften'd, humbled, and
prevail'd;
Nor was it tried till ev'ry truth had
fail'd;
No sage on earth could more than he
despise
Degrading, poor, unprofitable lies.
Though fond of gain, and grieved
by wanton waste,
To social parties he had no distaste;

280

With one presiding purpose in his
view,

He sometimes could descend to trifle
too!

Yet, in these moments, he had still the
art

To ope the looks and close the
guarded heart;

And, like the public host, has
sometimes made

A grand repast, for which the guests
have paid.

At length, with power endued and
wealthy grown,

Frailties and passions, long
suppressed, were shown;

Then, to provoke him was a
dangerous thing;

His pride would punish, and his
temper sting;

290

His powerful hatred sought th'
avenging hour,

And his proud vengeance struck with
all his power—

Save when th' offender took a prudent
way

The rising storm of fury to allay.

This might he do, and so in safety
sleep,

By largely casting to the angry deep;
Or, better yet (its swelling force t'
assuage,)

By pouring oil of flattery on its rage.

And now, of all the heart approved,
possess'd,

Fear'd, favour'd, follow'd, dreaded,
and caress'd,

300

He gently yields to one mellifluous
joy,

The only sweet that is not found to
cloy,

Bland adulation! Other pleasures pall
On the sick taste, and transient are
they all;

But this one sweet has such
enchancing power,

The more we take, the faster we
devour;

Nauseous to those who must the dose
apply,

And most disgusting to the standers-
by;

Yet in all companies will Laughton
feed,

Nor care how grossly men perform
the deed.

310

As gapes the nursling, or, what
comes more near,

Some Friendly-island chief, for
hourly cheer—

When wives and slaves, attending
round his seat,

Prepare by turns the masticated meat:
So for this master, husband, parent,
friend,

His ready slaves their various efforts
blend,

And, to their lord still eagerly
inclined,

Pour the crude trash of a dependent
mind.

But let the muse assign the man his
due;

Worth he possess'd, nor were his
virtues few;—

320

He sometimes help'd the injured in
their cause;

His power and purse have back'd the
failing laws;

He for religion has a due respect,
And all his serious notions are
correct;

Although he pray'd and languished
for a son,

He grew resigned when Heaven
denied him one;

He never to this quiet mansion sends
Subject unfit, in compliment to
friends.

Not so Sir Denys, who would yet
protest

He always chose the worthiest and
the best:

330

Not men in trade by various loss
brought down,

But those whose glory once amazed
the town;

Who their last guinea in their
pleasures spent,

Yet never fell so low as to repent;
To these his pity he could largely
deal,

Wealth they had known, and therefore
want could feel.

Three seats were vacant while Sir
Denys reign'd,
And three such favourites their
admission gain'd;
These let us view, still more to
understand
The moral feelings of Sir Denys
Brand.

LETTER XIV.

INHABITANTS OF THE ALMS-HOUSE.

BLANEY.

Sed [quam] cæcus inest vitiis amor, omne
futurum
Despicitur; suadent brevem præsentia
fructum,
Et ruit in vetitum damni secura libido.

Claudian.

in
Eutr
op.
[Lib
. II.
vv.
50-
2].

Nunquam parvo contenta
peracta
Et quæditorum terrâ pelagoque ciborum
Ambitiosa fames et lautæ gloria mensæ.

Et Luxus, populator Opum, [cui] semper
adhærens,
Infelix humili gressu comitatur Egestas.

Claudian.

in
Rufi
num
[Lib
. I.
vv.
35-
6].

Behold what blessing[s] wealth to life
can lend!

Pope

[Mo
ral
Ess
ays,
Ep.
III.
v.
297
].

ney, a wealthy Heir, dissipated, and reduced to Poverty—His Fortune restored by Marriage: again consumed—His Manner of living in the West Indies—Recalled to a larger Inheritance—His more refined and expensive Luxuries—His Method of quieting Conscience—Death of his Wife—Again become poor—His Method of supporting Existence—His Ideas of Religion—His Habits and Connexions when old—Admitted into the Alms-House.

LETTER XIV.

LIFE OF BLANEY.

Observe that tall pale veteran! what a
look
Of shame and guilt! who cannot read
that book?
Misery and mirth are blended in his
face,
Much innate vileness and some
outward grace;
There wishes strong and stronger
griefs are seen,
Looks ever changed, and never one
serene:
Show not that manner, and these
features all,
The serpent's cunning and the sinner's
fall?

Hark to that laughter!—'tis the way
he takes

10

To force applause for each vile jest he
makes;
Such is yon man, by partial favour
sent
To these calm seats to ponder and
repent.

Blaney, a wealthy heir at twenty-
one,
At twenty-five was ruin'd and
undone:
These years with grievous crimes we
need not load,
He found his ruin in the common
road;—
Gamed without skill, without inquiry
bought,
Lent without love, and borrowed
without thought.

But, gay and handsome, he had soon
the dower

20

Of a kind wealthy widow in his
power;

Then he aspired to loftier flights of
vice,

To singing harlots of enormous price;

He took a jockey in his gig to buy

A horse, so valued that a duke was
shy;

To gain the plaudits of the knowing
few,

Gamblers and grooms, what would
not Blaney do?

His dearest friend, at that improving
age,

Was Hounslow Dick, who drove the
western stage.

Cruel he was not.—If he left his
wife,

30

He left her to her own pursuits in life;

Deaf to reports, to all expenses blind;

Profuse, not just, and careless, but not
kind.

Yet, thus assisted, ten long winters
pass'd

In wasting guineas ere he saw his
last;

Then he began to reason, and to feel

He could not dig, nor had he learn'd
to steal;

And should he beg as long as he
might live,

He justly fear'd that nobody would
give.

But he could charge a pistol, and, at
will,

40

All that was mortal by a bullet kill:
And he was taught, by those whom
he would call
Man's surest guides—that he was
mortal all.

While thus he thought, still waiting
for the day,
When he should dare to blow his
brains away,
A place for him a kind relation found,
Where England's monarch ruled, but
far from English ground;
He gave employ that might for bread
suffice,
Correct his habits and restrain his
vice.

Here Blaney tried (what such man's
miseries teach)

50

To find what pleasures were within
his reach;
These he enjoy'd, though not in just
the style
He once possess'd them in his native
isle;
Congenial souls he found in every
place,
Vice in all soils, and charms in every
race:
His lady took the same amusing way,
And laugh'd at Time till he had turn'd
them grey:
At length for England once again
they steer'd,

By ancient views and new designs
 endear'd;
His kindred died, and Blaney now
 became

60

An heir to one who never heard his
 name.

 What could he now?—The man
 had tried before
The joys of youth, and they were joys
 no more;
To vicious pleasure he was still
 inclined,
But vice must now be season'd and
 refined;
Then as a swine he would on pleasure
 seize,
Now common pleasures had no
 power to please:
Beauty alone has for the vulgar
 charms,
He wanted beauty trembling with
 alarms;
His was no more a youthful dream of
 joy,

70

The wretch desired to ruin and
 destroy;
He bought indulgence with a
 boundless price,
Most pleased when decency bow'd
 down to vice,
When a fair dame her husband's
 honour sold,
And a frail Countess play'd for
 Blaney's gold.

"But did not conscience in her
anger rise?"
Yes! and he learn'd her terrors to
despise;
When stung by thought, to soothing
books he fled,
And grew composed and hardened as
he read;
Tales of Voltaire, and essays gay and
slight,

80

Pleased him and shone with their
phosphoric light;
Which, though it rose from objects
vile and base,
Where'er it came threw splendour on
the place,
And was that light which the deluded
youth,
And this grey sinner, deem'd the light
of truth.

He different works for different
cause admired—
Some fix'd his judgment, some his
passions fired;
To cheer the mind and }
raise a dormant }
flame,
He had the books, decreed to
lasting shame,
Which those who read are
careful not to name:

90

These won to vicious act the yielding
heart,
And then the cooler reasoners
soothed the smart.

He heard of Blount, and
Mandeville, and Chubb,
How they the doctors of their day
would drub;
How Hume had dwelt on miracles so
well,
That none would now believe a
miracle;
And though he cared not works so
grave to read,
He caught their faith and sign'd the
sinner's creed.

Thus was he pleased to join the
laughing side;
Nor ceased the laughter when his
lady died.

100

Yet was he kind and careful of her
fame,
And on her tomb inscribed a virtuous
name:

"A tender wife, respected, and so
forth."—

The marble still bears witness to the
worth.

He has some children, but he
knows not where;
Something they cost, but neither love
nor care;

A father's feelings he has never
known,

His joys, his sorrows, have been all
his own.

He now would build—and lofty
seat he built,
And sought, in various ways, relief
from guilt.

110

Restless, for ever anxious to obtain
Ease for the heart by ramblings of the
 brain,
He would have pictures, and of
 course a taste,
And found a thousand means his
 wealth to waste.
Newmarket steeds he bought at
 mighty cost;
They sometimes won, but Blaney
 always lost.
 Quick came his ruin, came when
 he had still
For life a relish, and in pleasure skill:
By his own idle reckoning he
 supposed
His wealth would last him till his life
 was closed;

120

But no! he found his final hoard was
 spent,
While he had years to suffer and
 repent.
Yet at the last, his noble mind to
 show,
And in his misery how he bore the
 blow,
He view'd his only guinea, then
 suppress'd
For a short time, the tumults in his
 breast,
And, moved by pride, by habit and
 despair,
Gave it an opera-bird to hum an air.
 Come ye! who live for pleasure,
 come, behold

A man of pleasure when he's poor and
old;

130

When he looks back through life, and
cannot find

A single action to relieve his mind;

When he looks forward, striving still
to keep

A steady prospect of eternal sleep;

When not one friend is left, of all the
train

Whom 'twas his pride and boast to
entertain—

Friends now employ'd from house to
house to run

And say, "Alas! poor Blaney is
undone!"—

Those whom he shook with ardour by
the hand,

By whom he stood as long as he
could stand,

140

Who seem'd to him from all
deception clear,

And who, more strange! might think
themselves sincere.

Lo! now the hero shuffling through
the town,

To hunt a dinner and to beg a crown;

To tell an idle tale, that boys may
smile;

To bear a strumpet's billet-doux a
mile;

To cull a wanton for a youth of
wealth,

(With [reverent] view to both his taste
and health);

To be a useful, needy thing between
Fear and desire—the pander and the
screen;

150

To flatter pictures, houses, horses,
dress,
The wildest fashion or the worst
excess;

To be the grey seducer, and entice
Unbearded folly into acts of vice;
And then, to level every fence which
law

And virtue fix to keep the mind in
awe,

He first inveigles }
youth to walk }
astray,

Next prompts and soothes
them in their fatal way,

Then vindicates the deed, and
makes the mind his prey.

Unhappy man! what pains he takes
to state

160

(Proof of his fear!) that all below is
fate;

That all proceed in one appointed
track,

Where none can stop, or take their
journey back!

Then what is vice or virtue?—Yet
he'll rail

At priests till memory and quotation
fail;

He reads, to learn the various ills
they've done,

And calls them vipers, every mother's
son.

He is the harlot's aid, who
wheedling tries
To move her friend for vanity's
supplies;
To weak indulgence he allures the
mind,

170

Loth to be duped, but willing to be
kind;

And if successful—what the labour
pays?

He gets the friend's contempt and
Chloe's praise,
Who, in her triumph, condescends to
say,

"What a good creature Blaney was to-
day!"

Hear the poor dæmon when the
young attend,

And willing ear to vile experience
lend;

When he relates (with laughing,
leering eye)

The tale licentious, mix'd with
blasphemy:

No genuine gladness his narrations
cause,

180

The frailest heart denies sincere
applause;

And many a youth has turn'd him half
aside,

And laugh'd aloud, the sign of shame
to hide.

Blaney, no aid in his vile cause to
lose,
Buys pictures, prints, and a licentious
muse;
He borrows every help from every
art,
To stir the passions and mislead the
heart.
But from the subject let us soon
escape,
Nor give this feature all its ugly
shape:
Some to their crimes escape from
satire owe;

190

Who shall describe what Blaney
dares to show?

While thus the man, to vice and
passion slave,
Was, with his follies, moving to the
grave,
The ancient ruler of this mansion
died,
And Blaney boldly for the seat
applied.

Sir Denys Brand, then guardian,
join'd his suit;

"'Tis true," said he, "the fellow's quite
a brute—

A very beast; but yet, with all his sin,
He has a manner—let the devil in."

They half complied, they gave the
wish'd retreat,

200

But raised a worthier to the vacant
seat.

Thus forced on ways unlike each
former way,
Thus led to prayer without a heart to
pray,
He quits the gay and rich, the young
and free,
Among the badge-men with a badge
to be.
He sees an humble tradesman raised
to rule
The grey-beard pupils of this moral
school;
Where he himself, an old licentious
boy,
Will nothing learn, and nothing can
enjoy;
In temp'rate measures he must eat and
drink,

210

And, pain of pains! must live alone
and think.

In vain, by fortune's smiles, thrice
affluent made,
Still has he debts of ancient date
unpaid;
Thrice into penury by error thrown,
Not one right maxim has he made his
own;
The old men shun him—some his
vices hate,
And all abhor his principles and
prate;
Nor love nor care for him will mortal
show,
Save a frail sister in the female row.

LETTER XV.

INHABITANTS OF THE ALMS-HOUSE.

CLELIA.

She early found herself mistress of herself. All she did was right: all she said was admired. Early, very early, did she dismiss blushes from her cheek: she could not blush, because she could not doubt; and silence, whatever was the subject, was as much a stranger to her as diffidence.

Richardson.

Quo fugit Venus? heu! Quove color?
decens

Quo motus? Quid habes illius, illius,

Quæ spirabat amores,

Quæ me surpuerat mihi?

Horatius,

lib.

iv,

od.

13

[vv.

17-

20].

lively and pleasant Manners—Her Reading and Decision—Her Intercourse with different Classes of Society—Her Kind of Character—The favoured Lover—Her Management of him: his of her—After one Period, Clelia with an Attorney: her Manner and Situation there—Another such Period, when her Fortune still declines—Mistress of an Inn—A Widow—Another such Interval: she becomes poor and infirm, but still vain and frivolous—The fallen Vanity—Admitted into the House; meets Blaney.

LETTER XV.

CLELIA.

We had a sprightly nymph—in every
town

Are some such sprights, who wander
up and down;

She had her useful arts, and could
contrive,

In time's despite, to stay at twenty-
five;—

"Here will I rest; move on, thou lying
year,

This is mine age, and I will rest me
here."

Arch was her look, and she had
pleasant ways

Your good opinion of her heart to
raise;

Her speech was lively, and with ease
express'd,

10

And well she judged the tempers she
address'd:

If some soft stripling had her
keenness felt,

She knew the way to make his anger
melt;

Wit was allow'd her, though but few
could bring

Direct example of a witty thing;

'Twas that gay, pleasant, smart,
engaging speech,

Her beaux admired, and just within
their reach;

Not indiscreet, perhaps, but yet more
free

Than prudish nymphs allow their wit
to be.

Novels and plays, with poems, old
and new,

20

Were all the books our nymph
attended to;
Yet from the press no treatise issued
forth,
But she would speak precisely of its
worth.

She with the London stage familiar
grew,
And every actor's name and merit
knew;
She told how this or that their part
mistook,
And of the rival Romeos gave the
look;
Of either house 'twas hers the
strength to see,
Then judge with candour—"Drury-
Lane for me."

What made this knowledge, what
this skill complete?

30

A fortnight's visit in Whitechapel-
street.

Her place in life was rich and poor
between,
With those a favourite, and with these
a queen;
She could her parts assume, and
condescend
To friends more humble while an
humble friend;
And thus a welcome, lively guest
could pass,

Threading her pleasant way from
class to class.

"Her reputation?"—That was like
her wit,
And seem'd her manner and her state
to fit;
Something there was—what, none
presumed to say:

40

Clouds lightly passing on a smiling
day—

Whispers and hints which went from
ear to ear,
And mix'd reports no judge on earth
could clear.

But of each sex a friendly number
press'd
To joyous banquets this alluring
guest.

There, if, indulging mirth and freed
from awe,

If, pleasing all and pleased with all
she saw,

Her speech were free, and such as
freely dwelt

On the same feelings all around her
felt;

Or if some fond presuming favourite
tried

50

To come so near as once to be denied;
Yet not with brow so stern or speech
so nice,

But that he ventured on denial
twice:—

If these have been, and so has scandal
taught,

Yet malice never found the proof she
sought.

But then came one, the Lovelace of
his day,
Rich, proud, and crafty, handsome,
brave, and gay;
Yet loved he not those labour'd plans
and arts,
But left the business to the ladies'
hearts,
And, when he found them in a proper
train,

60

He thought all else superfluous and
vain.

But in that training he was deeply
taught,

And rarely fail'd of gaining all he
sought;

He knew how far directly on to go;

How to recede and dally to and fro;

How to make all the }
passions his }
allies,

And, when he saw them in
contention rise,

To watch the wrought-up
heart, and conquer by
surprise.

Our heroine fear'd him not; it was
her part,

To make sure conquest of such gentle
heart—

70

Of one so mild and humble; for she
saw

In Henry's eye a love chastised by
awe.

Her thoughts of virtue were not all
sublime,

Nor virtuous all her thoughts; 'twas
now her time

To bait each hook, in every way to
please,

And the rich prize with dext'rous
hand to seize.

She had no virgin-terrors; she could
stray

In all love's maze, nor fear to lose her
way;

Nay, could go near the precipice, nor
dread

A failing caution or a giddy head;

80

She'd fix her eyes upon the roaring
flood,

And dance upon the brink where
danger stood.

'Twas nature all, she judged, in one
so young,

To drop the eye and falter in the
tongue;

To be about to take, and then
command

His daring wish, and only view the
hand:

Yes! all was nature; it became a maid
Of gentle soul t' encourage love
afraid.—

He, so unlike the confident and bold,
Would fly in mute despair to find her
cold:

90

The young and tender germ requires
the sun
To make it spread; it must be smiled
upon.
Thus the kind virgin gentle means
devised
To gain a heart so fond, a hand so
prized;
More gentle still she grew; to change
her way
Would cause confusion, danger and
delay:
Thus, (an increase of gentleness her
mode,)
She took a plain, unvaried, certain
road,
And every hour believed success was
near,
Till there was nothing left to hope or
fear.

100

It must be own'd that in this strife
of hearts,
Man has advantage—has superior
arts.
The lover's aim is to the nymph
unknown,
Nor is she always certain of her own;
Or has her fears, nor }
these can so }
disguise,
But he who searches, reads
them in her eyes,
In the avenging frown, in the
regretting sighs:
These are his signals, and he learns to
steer

The straighter course whenever they
appear.

"Pass we ten years, and what was
Clelia's fate?"

110

At an attorney's board alert she sate,
Not legal mistress: he with other men
Once sought her hand, but other
views were then;
And when he knew he might the bliss
command,
He other [blessing] sought, without
the hand;
For still he felt alive the lambent
flame,
And offer'd her a home—and home
she came.

There, though her higher
friendships lived no more,
She loved to speak of what she shared
before—

"Of the dear Lucy, }
heirress of the }
hall—

120

Of good Sir Peter—of their annual
ball,
And the fair countess!—Oh!
she loved them all!"
The humbler clients of her friend
would stare,
The knowing smile—but neither
caused her care;

She brought her spirits to her humble
state,
And soothed with idle dreams her
frowning fate.

"Ten summers pass'd, and how was
Clelia then?"
Alas! she suffer'd in this trying ten;
The pair had parted: who to him
attend,
Must judge the nymph unfaithful to
her friend;

130

But who on her would equal faith
bestow,
Would think him rash—and surely
she must know.

Then as a matron Clelia taught a
school,
But nature gave not talents fit for
rule.

Yet now, though marks of wasting
years were seen,
Some touch of sorrow, some attack of
spleen;
Still there was life, a spirit quick and
gay,
And lively speech and elegant array.

The Griffin's landlord these allured
so far,
He made her mistress of his heart and
bar;

140

He had no idle retrospective whim,

Till she was his, her deeds concern'd
not him.
So far was well,—but Clelia thought
not fit
(In all the Griffin needed) to submit:
Gaily to dress and in the bar preside,
Soothed the poor spirit of degraded
pride;
But cooking, waiting, welcoming a
crew
Of noisy guests, were arts she never
knew:
Hence daily wars, with temporary
truce,
His vulgar insult, and her keen abuse;
150
And as their spirits wasted in the
strife,
Both took the Griffin's ready aid of
life;
But she with greater prudence—
Harry tried
More powerful aid, and in the trial
died;
Yet drew down vengeance: in no
distant time,
Th' insolvent Griffin struck his wings
sublime;—
Forth from her palace walk'd th'
ejected queen,
And show'd to frowning fate a look
serene;
Gay spite of time, though poor, yet
well attired,
Kind without love, and vain if not
admired.

160

Another term is past; ten other
years
In various trials, troubles, views, and
fears.
Of these some pass'd in small
attempts at trade;
Houses she kept for widowers lately
made;
For now she said, "They'll miss th'
endearing friend,
And I'll be there the soften'd heart to
bend."
And true a part was done as Clelia
plann'd—
The heart was soften'd, but she miss'd
the hand.
She wrote a novel, and Sir Denys
said,
The dedication was the best he read;
170
But Edgeworths, Smiths, and
Radcliffes so engross'd
The public ear, that all her pains were
lost.
To keep a toy-shop was attempt the
last,
There too she fail'd, and schemes and
hopes were past.
Now friendless, sick and old, and
wanting bread,
The first-born tears of fallen pride
were shed—
True, bitter tears; and yet that
wounded pride,

Among the poor, for poor distinctions
sigh'd.

Though now her tales were to her
audience fit;

Though loud her tones, and vulgar
grown her wit;

180

Though now her dress—(but let me
not explain

The piteous patch-work of the needy-
vain,

The flirtish form to coarse materials
lent,

And one poor robe through fifty
fashions sent;)

Though all within was sad, without
was mean—

Still 'twas her wish, her comfort to be
seen:

She would to plays on lowest terms
resort,

Where once her box was to the beaux
a court;

And, strange delight! to that same
house where she

Join'd in the dance, all gaiety and
glee,

190

Now, with the menials crowding to
the wall,

She'd see, not share, the pleasures of
the ball,

And with degraded vanity unfold,
How she too triumphed in the years
of old.

To her poor friends 'tis now her pride
to tell

On what a height she stood before she
fell;

At church she points to one tall seat,
and "There

We sat," she cries, "when my papa
was mayor."

Not quite correct in what she now
relates,

She alters persons, and she forges
dates;

200

And, finding memory's weaker help
decay'd,

She boldly calls invention to her aid.

Touch'd by the pity he had felt
before,

For her Sir Denys op'd the alms-
house door.

"With all her faults," he said, "the
woman knew

How to distinguish—had a manner
too;

And, as they say she is allied to some
In decent station—let the creature
come."

Here she and Blaney meet, and
take their view

Of all the pleasures they would still
pursue.

210

Hour after hour they sit, and nothing
hide

Of vices past; their follies are their
pride;

What to the sober and the cool are
crimes,

They boast—exulting in those happy
times;
The darkest deeds no indignation
raise,
The purest virtue never wins their
praise;
But still they on their }
ancient joys }
dilate,
Still with regret departed
glories state,
And mourn their grievous fall,
and curse their rigorous fate.

LETTER XVI.

INHABITANTS OF THE ALMS-HOUSE.

BENBOW.

Thou art the Knight of the Burning Lamp[....] ... If thou [wert] any way
given to virtue, I would swear by thy face; my oath should be by this fire.
[....] a perpetual triumph, [...] Thou hast saved me a thousand marks in
links and torches, walking [with thee in the] night betwixt tavern and tavern
...

Shakspeare [Henry IV. Part
I. Act III. Sc. 3].

Ebrietas tibi fida comes, tibi Luxus, et
atris

Circa te semper volitans Infamia pennis.

Silius

Itali

cus

[Pu

nica

,

Lib,

V.

vv.

96-

7].

bow, an improper Companion for the Badgemen of the Alms-house—He resembles Bardolph—Left in Trade by his Father—Contracts useless Friendships—His Friends drink with him, and employ others—Called worthy and honest! Why—Effect of Wine on the Mind of Man—Benbow's common Subject—the Praise of departed Friends and Patrons—'Squire Asgill, at the Grange: his Manners, Servants, Friends—True to his Church: ought therefore to be spared—His Son's different Conduct—Vexation of the Father's Spirit if admitted to see the Alteration—Captain Dowling, a boon Companion, ready to drink at all Times, and with any Company; famous in his Club-room—His easy Departure—Dolley Murrey, a Maiden advanced in Years: abides by Ratafia and Cards—Her free Manners—Her Skill in the Game—Her Preparation and Death—Benbow, how interrupted; his Submission.

LETTER XVI.

BENBOW.

See yonder badgeman, with that
glowing face,
A meteor shining in this sober place!
Vast sums were paid, and many years
were past,

Ere gems so rich around their
radiances cast!
Such was the fiery front that
Bardolph wore,
Guiding his master to the tavern-
door;
There first that meteor rose, and there
alone,
In its due place, the rich effulgence
shone.
But this strange fire the seat of peace
invades,

10

And shines portentous in these
solemn shades.

Benbow, a boon companion, long
approved
By jovial sets, and (as he thought)
beloved,
Was judged as one to joy and
friendship prone,
And deem'd injurious to himself
alone;
Gen'rous and free, he paid but small
regard
To trade, and fail'd; and some
declared "'twas hard."
These were his friends—his foes
conceived the case
Of common kind; he sought and
found disgrace;
The reasoning few, who neither
scorn'd nor loved,

20

His feelings pitied and his faults
reproved.

Benbow, the father, left
possessions fair,
A worthy name and business to his
heir;
Benbow, the son, those fair
possessions sold,
And lost his credit, while he spent the
gold.
He was a jovial trader: men enjoy'd
The night with him; his day was
unemploy'd;
So, when his credit and his cash were
spent,
Here, by mistaken pity, he was sent;
Of late he came, with }
passions }
unsubdued,

30

And shared and cursed the hated
solitude,
Where gloomy thoughts arise,
where grievous cares intrude.
Known but in drink—he found an
easy friend,
Well pleased his worth and honour to
commend;
And, thus inform'd, the guardian of
the trust
Heard the applause and said the claim
was just;
A worthy soul! unfitted for the strife,
Care and contention of a busy life;—
Worthy, and why?—that o'er the
midnight bowl
He made his friend the partner of his
soul,

40

And any man his friend;—then thus
in glee,
"I speak my mind; I love the truth,"
quoth he;
Till 'twas his fate that useful truth to
find,
'Tis sometimes prudent not to speak
the mind.

With wine inflated, man is all
upblown,
And feels a power which he believes
his own;
With fancy soaring to the skies, he
thinks
His all the virtues all the while he
drinks;
But when the gas from the balloon is
gone,
When sober thoughts and serious
cares come on,

50

Where then the worth that in himself
he found?—
Vanish'd—and he sank grov'ling on
the ground.

Still some conceit }
will
Benbow's
mind inflate;

Poor as he is—'tis pleasant to
relate
The joys he once possess'd: it
soothes his present state.
Seated with some grey beadsman,
he regrets
His former feasting, though it swell'd
his debts;

Topers once famed, his friends in
earlier days,
Well he describes, and thinks
description praise:
Each hero's worth with much delight
he paints;

60

Martyrs they were, and he would
make them saints.

"Alas! alas!" Old England now
may say,

"My glory withers; it has had its day:
We're fallen on evil times; men read
and think;

Our bold forefathers loved to fight
and drink.

"Then lived the good 'Squire Asgill
—what a change

Has death and fashion shown us at
the Grange!

He bravely thought it best became his
rank,

That all his tenants and his tradesmen
drank;

He was delighted from his favourite
room

70

To see them 'cross the park go daily
home,

Praising aloud the liquor and the host,
And striving who should venerate
him most.

"No pride had he, }
and there }
was
difference small

Between the master's and the
servants' hall;
And here or there the guests
were welcome all.
Of Heaven's free gifts he took no
special care;
He never quarrel'd for a simple hare;
But sought, by giving sport, a
sportsman's name,
Himself a poacher, though at other
game.

80

He never planted nor inclosed—his
trees
Grew like himself, untroubled and at
ease;
Bounds of all kinds he hated, and had
felt
Choked and imprison'd in a modern
belt,
Which some rare genius now has
twined about
The good old house, to keep old
neighbours out;
Along his valleys, in the evening
hours,
The borough-damsels stray'd to
gather flowers,
Or by the brakes and brushwood of
the park,
To take their pleasant rambles in the
dark.

90

"Some prudes, of rigid kind,
forbore to call
On the kind females—favourites at
the hall;

But better natures saw, with much
delight,
The different orders of mankind
unite;
'Twas schooling pride to see the
footman wait,
Smile on his sister and receive her
plate.

"His worship ever was a
churchman true,
He held in scorn the methodistic
crew;
'May God defend the Church, and
save the King,'
He'd pray devoutly and divinely sing.
100

Admit that he the holy day would
spend
As priests approved not—still he was
a friend.
Much then I blame the preacher, as
too nice,
To call such trifles by the name of
vice,
Hinting, though gently and with
cautious speech,
Of good example—'tis their trade to
preach;
But still 'twas pity, when the worthy
'squire
Stuck to the church: what more could
they require?
'Twas almost joining that fanatic
crew,
To throw such morals at his honour's
pew;

A weaker man, had he been so
reviled,
Had left the place—he only swore
and smiled.

"But think, ye rectors and ye
curates, think,
Who are your friends, and at their
frailties wink;
Conceive not—mounted on your
Sunday-throne,
Your fire-brands fall upon your foes
alone;
They strike your patrons—and,
should all withdraw
In whom your wisdoms may discern
a flaw,
You would the flower of all your
audience lose,
And spend your crackers on their
empty pews,

120

"The father dead, the son has found
a wife,
And lives a formal, proud, unsocial
life;—
The lands are now enclosed; the
tenants all,
Save at a rent-day, never see the hall;
No lass is suffer'd o'er the walks to
come,
And, if there's love, they have it all at
home.

"Oh! could the ghost of our good
'squire arise,
And see such change, would it
believe its eyes?

Would it not glide about from place
to place,
And mourn the manners of a feeble
race?

130

At that long table, where the servants
found
Mirth and abundance while the year
went round;
Where a huge pollard on the winter-
fire
At a huge distance made them all
retire;
Where not a measure in the room was
kept,
And but one rule—they tipp'd till
they slept:
There would it see a pale old hag
preside,
A thing made up of stinginess and
pride;
Who carves the meat, as if the flesh
could feel,
Careless whose flesh must miss the
plenteous meal.

140

Here would the ghost a small coal-
fire behold,
Not fit to keep one body from the
cold;
Then would it flit to higher rooms,
and stay
To view a dull, dress'd company at
play;
All the old comfort, all the genial fare
For ever gone! how sternly would it
stare;

And, though it might not to their view
appear,
'Twould cause among them lassitude
and fear;
Then wait to see—where he delight
has seen—
The dire effect of fretfulness and
spleen.

150

"Such were the worthies of these
better days;
We had their blessings—they shall
have our praise.—
"Of Captain Dowling would you
hear me speak?
I'd sit and sing his praises for a week:
He was a man, and man-like all his
joy,—
I'm led to question, was he ever boy?
Beef was his breakfast;—if from sea
and salt,
It relish'd better with his wine of
malt;
Then, till he dined, if walking in or
out,
Whether the gravel teased him or the
gout,

160

Though short in wind and flannel'd
every limb,
He drank with all who had concerns
with him:
Whatever trader, agent, merchant,
came,
They found him ready, every hour the
same;

Whatever liquors might between
 them pass,
He took them all, and never balk'd his
 glass;
Nay, with the seamen working in the
 ship,
At their request, he'd share the grog
 and flip.
But in the club-room was his chief
 delight,
And punch the favourite liquor of the
 night;

170

Man after man they from the trial
 shrank,
And Dowling ever was the last who
 drank.
Arrived at home, he, ere he sought his
 bed,
With pipe and brandy would compose
 his head;
Then half an hour was o'er the news
 beguiled,
When he retired as harmless as a
 child.
Set but aside the gravel and the gout,
And breathing short—his sand ran
 fairly out.

"At fifty-five we lost him—after
 that

Life grows insipid and its pleasures
 flat;

180

He had indulged in all that man can
 have,
He did not drop a dotard to his grave;

Still to the last, his feet upon the
chair,
With rattling lungs now gone beyond
repair;
When on each feature death had fix'd
his stamp,
And not a doctor could the body
vamp;
Still at the last, to his beloved bowl
He clung, and cheer'd the sadness of
his soul;
For, though a man may not have
much to fear,
Yet death looks ugly, when the view
is near.

190

—'I go,' he said, 'but still my friends
shall say,
'Twas as a man—I did not sneak
away;
An honest life with worthy souls I've
spent—
Come, fill my glass;'—he took it, and
he went.—

"Poor Dolly Murrey!—I might live
to see
My hundredth year, but no such lass
as she.

Easy by nature, in her humour gay,
She chose her comforts, ratafia and
play:
She loved the social game, the decent
glass;
And was a jovial, friendly, laughing
lass.

200

We sat not then at Whist demure and
still,
But pass'd the pleasant hours at gay
Quadrille;
Lame in her side, we placed her in
her seat,
Her hands were free, she cared not
for her feet;
As the game ended, came the glass
around,
(So was the loser cheer'd, the winner
crown'd.)
Mistress of secrets, both the young
and old
In her confided—not a tale she told;
Love never made impression on her
mind,
She held him weak, and all his
captives blind;

210

She suffered no man her free soul to
vex,
Free from the weakness of her gentle
sex;
One with whom ours unmoved
conversing sate,
In cool discussion or in free debate.
"Once in her chair we'd placed the
good old lass,
Where first she took her preparation
glass;
By lucky thought she'd been that day
at prayers,
And long before had fix'd her small
affairs;
So all was easy—on her cards she
cast

A smiling look; I saw the thought that
pass'd:

220

'A king,' she call'd;—though
conscious of her skill,

'Do more,' I answer'd—'More?' she
said; 'I will;'

And more she did—cards answer'd to
her call,

She saw the mighty to her mightier
fall:

'A vole! a vole!' she cried, 'tis fairly
won,

My game is ended and my work is
done.'—

This said, she gently, with a single
sigh,

Died as one taught and practised how
to die.

"Such were the dead-departed; I
survive,

To breathe in pain among the dead-
alive."

230

The bell then call'd }
these ancient
men to pray;

"Again!" said Benbow—"tolls
it every day?

Where is the life I led?"—He
sigh'd, and walk'd his way.

LETTER XVII.

THE HOSPITAL AND GOVERNORS.

Blessed be the man [that] provideth for the sick and needy: the Lord shall deliver him in [the] time of trouble.

[Communion Service, [Ps.
xli. v. Prayer Book Version].]

Quas dederis, solas semper habebis opes.

Martial

[Lib
. v.
Epi
gr.
xliii
].

Nil negat, et sese vel non poscentibus
offert.

Claudian

[in
Eutr
op.
Lib.
i. v.
365
].

Decipias alios verbis voltuque benigno;
Nam mihi jam notus dissimulator eris.

Martial

[Lib
. iv.
Epi
gr.
lxxx
ix.].

istian Charity anxious to provide for future as well as present Miseries—Hence the Hospital for the Diseased—Description of a recovered Patient—The Building: how erected—The Patrons and Governors—Eusebius—The more active Manager of Business a moral and correct Contributor—One of different Description—Good the Result, however intermixed with Imperfection.

LETTER XVII.

THE HOSPITAL AND GOVERNORS.

An ardent spirit dwells with
Christian love,
The eagle's vigour in the pitying
dove;
'Tis not enough that we with sorrow
sigh,
That we the wants of pleading man
supply;
That we in sympathy with sufferers
feel,
Nor hear a grief without a wish to
heal.
Not these suffice—to sickness, pain,
and wo,
The Christian spirit loves with aid to
go;
Will not be sought, waits not for want
to plead,
10
But seeks the duty—nay, prevents the
need;
Her utmost aid to every ill applies,
And plans relief for coming miseries.
Hence yonder building rose: on
either side
Far stretch'd the wards, all airy,
warm, and wide;

And every ward has beds by comfort
spread,

And smooth'd for him who suffers on
the bed.

There have all kindness, most relief
—for some

Is cure complete—it is the sufferer's
home:

Fevers and chronic ills, corroding
pains,

20

Each accidental mischief man
sustains;

Fractures and wounds, and wither'd
limbs and lame,

With all that, slow or sudden, vex our
frame,

Have here attendance }
—here the }
sufferers lie

(Where love and science
every aid apply),

And heal'd with rapture live,
or soothed by comfort die.

See one relieved from anguish, and
to-day

Allow'd to walk and look an hour
away;

Two months confined by fever,
frenzy, pain,

He comes abroad and is himself
again:

30

'Twas in the spring, when carried to
the place,

The snow fell down and melted in his
face.

'Tis summer now; all objects gay
and new;
Smiling alike the viewer and the
view:

He stops as one unwilling to advance,
Without another and another glance;
With what a pure and simple joy he
sees

Those sheep and cattle browsing at
their ease;

Easy himself, there's nothing breathes
or moves

But he would cherish—all that lives
he loves:

40

Observing every ward as round he
goes,

He thinks what pain, what danger
they enclose;

Warm in his wish for all who suffer
there,

At every view he meditates a prayer:
No evil counsels in his breast abide,
There joy, and love, and gratitude
reside.

The wish that Roman necks in one
were found,

That he who form'd the wish might
deal the wound,

This man had never heard; but of the
kind,

Is that desire which rises in his mind;

50

He'd have all English hands (for
further he

Cannot conceive extends our charity),

All but his own, in one right-hand to
grow,
And then what hearty shake would he
bestow!
"How rose the building?"—Piety
first laid
A strong foundation, but she wanted
aid;
To Wealth unwieldy was her prayer
address'd,
Who largely gave, and she the donor
bless'd.
Unwieldy Wealth then to his couch
withdrew,
And took the sweetest sleep he ever
knew.

60

Then busy Vanity sustain'd her
part,
"And much," she said, "it moved her
tender heart;
To her all kinds of man's distress
were known,
And all her heart adopted as its own."
Then Science came—his talents he
display'd,
And Charity with joy the dome
survey'd;
Skill, Wealth, and Vanity, obtain the
fame,
And Piety, the joy that makes no
claim.

Patrons there are, and governors,
from whom
The greater aid and guiding orders
come;

70

Who voluntary cares and labours
take,
The sufferers' servants for the service'
sake.
Of these a part I give you—but a
part—
Some hearts are hidden; some have
not a heart.
First let me praise—for so I best
shall paint—
That pious moralist, that reasoning
saint!
Can I of worth like thine, Eusebius,
speak?
The man is willing, but the muse is
weak;—
'Tis thine to wait on wo! to soothe! to
heal!
With learning social, and polite with
zeal:

80

In thy pure breast although the
passions dwell,
They're train'd by virtue and no more
rebel;
But have so long been active on her
side,
That passion now might be itself the
guide.
Law, conscience, honour, all
obey'd; all give
Th' approving voice, and make it bliss
to live;
While faith, when life can nothing
more supply,
Shall strengthen hope, and make it
bliss to die.

He preaches, speaks and writes
with manly sense—
No weak neglect, no laboured
eloquence;

90

Goodness and wisdom are in all his
ways,
The rude revere him and the wicked
praise.

Upon humility his virtues grow,
And tower so high because so fix'd
below;
As wider spreads the oak his boughs
around,
When deeper with his roots he digs
the solid ground.

By him, from ward to ward, is
every aid
The sufferer needs with every care
convey'd.
Like the good tree he brings his
treasure forth,
And, like the tree, unconscious of his
worth;

100

Meek as the poorest Publican is he,
And strict as lives the straitest
Pharisee;
Of both, in him unite the better part—
The blameless conduct and the
humble heart.

Yet he escapes not; he, with some,
is wise
In carnal things, and loves to
moralize;
Others can doubt, if all that Christian
care

Has not its price—there's something
he may share.

But this, and ill severer, he sustains,
As gold the fire, and as unhurt
remains;

110

When most reviled, although he feels
the smart,

It wakes to nobler deeds the wounded
heart,

As the rich olive, beaten for its fruit,
Puts forth at every bruise a bearing
shoot.

A second friend we have, whose
care and zeal

But few can equal—few indeed can
feel.

He lived a life obscure, and profits
made

In the coarse habits of a vulgar trade.

His brother, master of a hoy, he loved

So well, that he the calling
disapproved:

120

"Alas! poor Tom!" the landman oft
would sigh,

When the gale freshen'd and the
waves ran high;

And when they parted, with a tear
he'd say,

"No more adventure!—here in safety
stay."

Nor did he feign; with more than half
he had,

He would have kept the seaman, and
been glad.

Alas! how few resist, when
strongly tried!—
A rich relation's nearer kinsman died;
He sicken'd, and to him the landman
went,
And all his hours with cousin
Ephraim spent.

130
This Thomas heard, and cared not:
"I," quoth he,
"Have one in port upon the watch for
me."
So Ephraim died, and, when the will
was shown,
Isaac, the landman, had the whole his
own:
Who to his brother sent a moderate
purse,
Which he return'd, in anger, with his
curse;
Then went to sea, and made his grog
so strong,
He died before he could forgive the
wrong.

The rich man built a house, both
large and high,
He enter'd in and set him down to
sigh;

140
He planted ample woods and gardens
fair,
And walk'd with anguish and
compunction there:
The rich man's pines, to every friend
a treat,
He saw with pain, and he refused to
eat;

His daintiest food, his richest wines,
were all
Turn'd by remorse to vinegar and
gall:
The softest down, by living body
press'd,
The rich man bought, and tried to
take his rest;
But care had thorns upon his pillow
spread,
And scatter'd sand and nettles in his
bed.

150

Nervous he grew—would often sigh
and groan,
He talk'd but little, and he walk'd
alone;
Till by his priest convinced, that from
one deed
Of genuine love would joy and health
proceed;
He from that time with care and zeal
began
To seek and soothe the grievous ills
of man;
And, as his hands their aid to grief
apply,
He learns to smile and he forgets to
sigh.

Now he can drink his wine and
taste his food.
And feel the blessings Heav'n has
dealt are good;

160

And, since the suffering seek the rich
man's door,

He sleeps as soundly as when young
and poor.

Here much he gives—is urgent
more to gain;
He begs—rich beggars seldom sue in
vain;
Preachers most famed he moves, the
crowd to move,
And never wearies in the work of
love;
He rules all business, settles all
affairs,
He makes collections, he directs
repairs;
And if he wrong'd one brother—
Heav'n forgive
The man by whom so many brethren
live!

170

Then, 'mid our signatures, a name
appears
Of one for wisdom famed above his
years;
And these were forty: he was from
his youth
A patient searcher after useful truth:
To language little of his time he gave,
To science less, nor was the muse's
slave;
Sober and grave, his college sent him
down,
A fair example for his native town.

Slowly he speaks, and with such
solemn air,
You'd think a Socrates or Solon there,
180
For though a Christian, he's disposed
to draw
His rules from reason's and from
nature's law.
"Know," he exclaims, "my fellow
mortals, know,
Virtue alone is happiness below;
And what is virtue? Prudence, first to
choose
Life's real good—the evil to refuse;
Add justice then, the eager hand to
hold,
To curb the lust of power and thirst of
gold;
Join temp'rance next, that cheerful
health insures,
And fortitude unmoved, that conquers
or endures."

190

He speaks, and lo!—the very man
you see:
Prudent and temperate, just and
patient he;
By prudence taught his worldly
wealth to keep,
No folly wastes, no avarice swells the
heap:
He no man's debtor, no man's patron
lives;
Save sound advice, he neither asks
nor gives;
By no vain thoughts or erring fancy
sway'd,

His words are weighty, or at least are
weigh'd;
Temp'rate in every place—abroad, at
home,
Thence will applause, and hence will
profit come;

200

And health from either he in time
prepares
For sickness, age, and their attendant
cares,
But not for fancy's ills;—he never
grieves
For love that wounds or friendship
that deceives;
His patient soul endures what Heav'n
ordains,
But neither feels nor fears ideal pains.

"Is aught then wanted in a man so
wise?"—

Alas!—I think he wants infirmities;
He wants the ties that knit us to our
kind—
The cheerful, tender, soft, complacent
mind,

210

That would the feelings, which he
dreads, excite,
And make the virtues he approves
delight;
What dying martyrs, saints, and
patriots feel—
The strength of action and the
warmth of zeal.
Again attend!—and see a man
whose cares

Are nicely placed on either world's
affairs.—

Merchant and saint, 'tis doubtful if he
knows

To which account he most regard
bestows;

Of both he keeps his ledger:—there
he reads

Of gainful ventures and of godly
deeds;

220

There all he gets or loses find a place
—

A lucky bargain and a lack of grace.

The joys above this prudent man
invite

To pay his tax—devotion!—day and
night;

The pains of hell his timid bosom
awe,

And force obedience to the church's
law:

Hence that continual thought, that
solemn air,

Those sad good works, and that
laborious prayer.

All these (when conscience,
waken'd and afraid

To think how avarice calls and is
obey'd)

230

He in his journal finds, and for his
grief

Obtains the transient opium of relief.

"Sink not, my soul!—my spirit,
rise and look

O'er the fair entries of this precious
book:

Here are the sins, our debts;—this
fairer side

Has what to carnal wish our strength
denied;

Has those religious duties every day
Paid—which so few upon the sabbath
pay;

Here too are conquests over frail
desires,

Attendance due on all the church
requires;

240

Then alms I give—for I believe the
word

Of holy writ, and lend unto the
Lord—

And, if not all th' importunate
demand,

The fear of want restrains my ready
hand;

—Behold what sums I to the poor
resign,

Sums placed in Heaven's own book,
as well as mine!

Rest, then, my spirit!—fastings,
prayers, and alms,

Will soon suppress these idly-raised
alarms,

And, weigh'd against our frailties, set
in view

A noble balance in our favour due.

250

Add that I yearly here affix my name,
Pledge for large payment—not from
love of fame,

But to make peace within;—that
peace to make,
What sums I lavish! and what gains
forsake!
Cheer up, my heart!—let's cast off
every doubt,
Pray without dread, and place our
money out."

Such the religion of a mind that
steers
Its way to bliss, between its hopes
and fears;
Whose passions in due bounds each
other keep,
And, thus subdued, they murmur till
they sleep;

260

Whose virtues all their certain limits
know,
Like well-dried herbs that neither
fade nor grow;
Who for success and safety ever tries,
And with both worlds alternately
complies.

Such are the guardians of this
bless'd estate;
Whate'er without, they're praised
within the gate;
That they are men, and have their
faults, is true,
But here their worth alone appears in
view:
The Muse indeed, who reads the very
breast,
Has something of the secrets there
express'd,

270

But yet in charity;—and, when she
sees
Such means for joy or comfort, health
or ease,
And knows how much united minds
effect,
She almost dreads their failings to
detect;
But truth commands:—in man's
erroneous kind,
Virtues and frailties mingle in the
mind;
Happy, when fears to public spirit
move,
And even vices to the work of love!

LETTER XVIII.

THE POOR AND THEIR DWELLINGS.

Bene paupertas
Humili tecto contenta latet.

Seneca [Octavia,
Act V.
vv. 895-
6].

Omnes quibu' res sunt minu' secundæ,
magi' sunt, nescio quo modo,
Suspiciosi; ad contumeliam omnia
accipiunt magis;
Propter suam impotentiam se semper
credunt negligi.

Terent. in
Ade
lph.
Act
4.
Sc.
3
[vv.
12-
4].

Show not to the poor thy pride,
Let their home a cottage be;
Nor the feeble body hide
In a palace fit for thee;
Let him not about him see
Lofty ceilings, ample halls,
Or a gate his boundary be,
Where nor friend or kinsman calls.

Let him not one walk behold,
That only one which he must tread,
Nor a chamber large and cold,
Better far his humble shed,
Where the aged and sick are led;
Humble sheds of neighbours by,
And the old and tatter'd bed,
Where he sleeps and hopes to die.

To quit of torpid sluggishness the [lair],
And from the pow'rful arms of sloth [get]
free,
'Tis rising from the dead—Alas! it cannot
be.

Thomson's
Cas

Method of treating the Borough Paupers—Many maintained at their own Dwellings—Some Characters of the Poor—The School-mistress, when aged—The Idiot—The poor Sailor—The declined Tradesman and his Companion—This contrasted with the Maintenance of the Poor in a common Mansion erected by the Hundred—The Objections to this Method: not Want, nor Cruelty, but the necessary Evils of this Mode—What they are—Instances of the Evil—A Return to the Borough Poor—The Dwellings of these—The Lanes and By-ways—No Attention here paid to Convenience—The Pools in the Path-ways—Amusements of Sea-port Children—The Town-Flora—Herbs on Walls and vacant Spaces—A female Inhabitant of an Alley—A large Building let to several poor Inhabitants—Their Manners and Habits.

LETTER XVIII.

THE POOR AND THEIR DWELLINGS.

Yes! we've our Borough-vices, and
I know
How far they spread, how rapidly
they grow;
Yet think not virtue quits the busy
place,
Nor charity, the virtues' crown and
grace.
"Our poor how feed we?"—To the
most we give
A weekly dole, and at their homes
they live;—

Others together dwell—but when
they come
To the low roof, they see a kind of
home,
A social people whom they've ever
known,

10

With their own thoughts and manners
like their own.

At her old house, her dress, her air
the same,

I see mine ancient letter-loving dame:
"Learning, my child," said she, "shall
fame command;

Learning is better worth than house
or land—

For houses perish, lands are gone and
spent;

In learning then excel, for that's most
excellent."

"And what her learning?"—"Tis
with awe to look

In every verse throughout one sacred
book;

From this her joy, her hope, her peace
is sought:

20

This she has learn'd, and she is nobly
taught.

If aught of mine have gain'd the
public ear;

If RUTLAND deigns these humble Tales
to hear;

If critics pardon what my friends
approved,

Can I mine ancient widow pass
unmoved?

Shall I not think what pains the
matron took,
When first I trembled o'er the gilded
book?
How she, all patient, both at eve and
morn,
Her needle pointed at the guarding
horn;
And how she soothed me, when, with
study sad,

30

I labour'd on to reach the final zad?
Shall I not grateful still the dame
survey,
And ask the muse the poet's debt to
pay?

Nor I alone, who hold a trifler's
pen,
But half our bench of wealthy,
weighty men,
Who rule our }
Borough, who }
enforce our
laws,

They own the matron as the
leading cause,
And feel the pleasing debt,
and pay the just applause:
To her own house is borne the week's
supply;
There she in credit lives, there hopes
in peace to die.

40

With her a harmless idiot we
behold,
Who hoards up silver shells for
shining gold;

These he preserves, with unremitted
care,
To buy a seat, and reign the
Borough's mayor:
Alas!—who could th' ambitious
changeling tell,
That what he sought our rulers dared
to sell?

Near these a sailor in that hut of
thatch
(A fish-boat's cabin is its nearest
match)
Dwells, and the dungeon is to him a
seat,
Large as he wishes—in his view
complete.

50
A lockless coffer and a lidless hutch
That hold his stores, have room for
twice as much;
His one spare shirt, long glass, and
iron box,
Lie all in view; no need has he for
locks.
Here he abides, and, as our strangers
pass,
He shows the shipping, he presents
the glass;
He makes (unask'd) their ports and
business known,
And (kindly heard) turns quickly to
his own.
Of noble captains—heroes every
one—
You might as soon have made the
steeple run:

60

And then his messmates, if you're
pleased to stay,
He'll one by one the gallant souls
display;
And as the story verges to an end,
He'll wind from deed to deed, from
friend to friend;
He'll speak of those long lost, the
brave of old,
As princes gen'rous and as heroes
bold;
Then will his feelings rise, till you
may trace
Gloom, like a cloud, frown o'er his
manly face—
And then a tear or two, which sting
his pride,
These he will dash indignantly aside,
70
And splice his tale;—now take him
from his cot,
And for some cleaner [berth]
exchange his lot,
How will he all that cruel aid
deplore?
His heart will break, and he will fight
no more.

Here is the poor old merchant: he
declined,
And, as they say, is not in perfect
mind;
In his poor house, with one poor
maiden friend,
Quiet he paces to his journey's end.
Rich in his youth, he traded and he
fail'd;

Again he tried, again his fate
prevail'd;

80

His spirits low and his exertions
small,
He fell perforce, he seem'd decreed to
fall:

Like the gay knight, unapt to rise was
he,

But downward sank with sad alacrity.
A borough-place we gain'd him—in
disgrace

For gross neglect, he quickly lost the
place;

But still he kept a kind of sullen
pride,

Striving his wants to hinder or to
hide.

At length, compell'd by very need, in
grief

He wrote a proud petition for relief.

90

"He did suppose a fall, like his,
would prove

Of force to wake their sympathy and
love;

Would make them feel the changes all
may know,

And stir them up a new regard to
show."

His suit was granted;—to an
ancient maid,

Relieved herself, relief for him was
paid.

Here they together (meet
companions) dwell,

And dismal tales of man's
misfortunes tell:

"'Twas not a world for them, God
help them! they
Could not deceive, nor flatter, nor
betray;

100

But there's a happy change, a scene to
come,
And they, God help them! shall be
soon at home."

If these no pleasures }
nor
enjoyments
gain,

Still none their spirits nor
their speech restrain;

They sigh at ease, 'mid
comforts they complain.

The poor will grieve, the poor will
weep and sigh,

Both when they know, and when they
know not why;

But we our bounty with such care
bestow,

That cause for grieving they shall
seldom know.

Your plan I love not;—with a
number you

110

Have placed your poor, your pitiable
few;

There, in one house, throughout their
lives to be—

The pauper-palace which they hate to
see;

That giant-building, that high-
bounding wall,
Those bare-worn walks, that lofty
thund'ring hall!
That large loud clock, which tolls
each dreaded hour;
Those gates and locks, and all those
signs of power:
It is a prison, with a milder name,
Which few inhabit without dread or
shame.

Be it agreed—the poor who hither
come

120

Partake of plenty, seldom found at
home;
That airy rooms and decent beds are
meant
To give the poor by day, by night,
content;
That none are frighten'd, once
admitted here,
By the stern looks of lordly overseer;
Grant that the guardians of the place
attend,
And ready ear to each petition lend;
That they desire the grieving poor to
show
What ills they feel, what partial acts
they know,
Not without promise, nay desire to
heal

130

Each wrong they suffer and each wo
they feel.—
Alas! their sorrows in their bosoms
dwell;

They've much to suffer, but have
nought to tell;
They have no evil in the place to
state,
And dare not say, it is the house they
hate:
They own, there's granted all such
place can give,
But live repining, for 'tis there they
live.

Grandsires are }
 there, who }
 now no
 more must see,
No more must nurse upon the
trembling knee,
The lost loved daughter's
infant progeny:

140

Like death's dread mansion, this
allows not place
For joyful meetings of a kindred race.
Is not the matron there, to whom
the son
Was wont at each declining day to
run;
He (when his toil was over) gave
delight,
By lifting up the latch, and one "good
night"?
Yes, she is here; but nightly to her
door
The son, still lab'ring, can return no
more.
Widows are here, who in their huts
were left,

Of husbands, children, plenty, ease
bereft;

150

Yet all that grief within the humble
shed

Was soften'd, soften'd in the humble
bed;—

But here, in all its force, remains the
grief,

And not one soft'ning object for
relief.

Who can, when here, the social
neighbour meet?

Who learn the story current in the
street?

Who to the long-known intimate
impart

Facts they have learn'd or feelings of
the heart?—

They talk indeed; but who can choose
a friend,

Or seek companions at their journey's
end?

160

Here are not those whom they,
when infants, knew;

Who, with like fortune, up to
manhood grew;

Who, with like troubles, at old age
arrived;

Who, like themselves, the joy of life
survived;

Whom time and custom so familiar
made,

That looks the meaning in the mind
convey'd:

But here, to strangers, words nor
looks impart
The various movements of the
suffering heart;
Nor will that heart with those alliance
own,
To whom its views and hopes are all
unknown.

170

What, if no grievous fears their
lives annoy,
Is it not worse no prospects to enjoy?
'Tis cheerless living in such bounded
view,
With nothing dreadful, but with
nothing new;
Nothing to bring them joy, to make
them weep—
The day itself is, like the night,
asleep;
Or, on the sameness if a break be
made,
'Tis by some pauper to his grave
convey'd;
By smuggled news from neighb'ring
village told,
News never true, or truth a
twelvemonth old;

180

By some new inmate doom'd with
them to dwell,
Or justice come to see that all goes
well;
Or change of room, or }
hour of leave }
to crawl

On the black footway winding with
the wall,
Till the stern bell forbids, or
master's sterner call.

Here too the mother sees her
children train'd,
Her voice excluded and her feelings
pain'd.

Who govern here, by general rules
must move,

Where ruthless custom rends the
bond of love.

Nations, we know, have nature's law
transgressed.

190

And snatch'd the infant from the
parent's breast;

But still for public good the boy was
train'd,

The mother suffer'd, but the matron
gain'd:

Here nature's outrage serves no cause
to aid;

The ill is felt, but not the Spartan
made.

Then too, I own, it grieves me to
behold

Those ever virtuous, helpless now
and old,

By all for care and industry approved,
For truth respected, and for temper
loved;

And who, by sickness and misfortune
tried,

200

Gave want its worth and poverty its
pride:

I own it grieves me to behold them
sent
From their old home; 'tis pain, 'tis
punishment,
To leave each scene familiar, every
face,
For a new people and a stranger race;
For those who, sunk in sloth and dead
to shame,
From scenes of guilt with daring
spirits came;
Men, just and guileless, at such
manners start,
And bless their God that time has
fenced their heart,
Confirm'd their virtue, and expell'd
the fear

210

Of vice in minds so simple and
sincere.

Here the good pauper, losing all the
praise
By worthy deeds acquired in better
days,
Breathes a few months; then, to his
chamber led,
Expires, while strangers prattle round
his bed.

The grateful hunter, when his horse
is old,
Wills not the useless favourite to be
sold;
He knows his former worth, and
gives him place
In some fair pasture, till he runs his
race.

But has the labourer, has the seaman
done

220

Less worthy service, thought not
dealt to one?

Shall we not, then, contribute to their
ease,

In their old haunts, where ancient
objects please;

That, till their sight shall fail them,
they may trace

The well-known prospect and the
long-loved face?

The noble oak, in distant ages seen,
With far-stretch'd boughs and foliage
fresh and green,

Though now its bare and forky
branches show

How much it lacks the vital warmth
below—

The stately ruin yet our wonder gains,
230

Nay, moves our pity, without thought
of pains;

Much more shall real wants and cares
of age

Our gentler passions in their cause
engage.—

Drooping and burthen'd with a weight
of years,

What venerable ruin man appears!

How worthy pity, love, respect, and
grief—

He claims protection—he compels
relief;—

And shall we send him }
from our view, }

to brave
The storms abroad, whom we
at home might save,
And let a stranger dig our
ancient brother's grave?

240

No!—we will shield him from the
storm he fears,
And when he falls, embalm him with
our tears.

Farewell to these; but all our poor
to know,
Let's seek the winding lane, the
narrow row—
Suburban prospects, }
where the }
traveller stops
To see the sloping tenement
on props,
With building yards immix'd,
and humble sheds and shops;
Where the Cross-Keys and
Plumber's-Arms invite
Laborious men to taste their coarse
delight;
Where the low porches, stretching
from the door,

250

Gave some distinction in the days of
yore—
Yet now, neglected, more offend the
eye

By gloom and ruin than the cottage
by.

Places like these the noblest town
endures,

The gayest palace has its sinks and
sewers.

Here is no pavement, no inviting
shop,

To give us shelter when compell'd to
stop;

But plashy puddles stand along the
way,

Fill'd by the rain of one tempestuous
day;

And these so closely to the buildings
run,

260

That you must ford them, for you
cannot shun;

Though here and there convenient
bricks are laid,

And door-side heaps afford their
dubious aid.

Lo! yonder shed; observe its
garden-ground,

With the low paling, form'd of wreck,
around:

There dwells a fisher; if you view his
boat,

With bed and barrel—'tis his house
afloat;

Look at his house, where ropes, nets,
blocks, abound,

Tar, pitch, and oakum—'tis his boat
aground:

That space enclosed but little he
regards,

270

Spread o'er with relics of masts, sails,
and yards;

Fish by the wall on }
spit of elder }
rest,

Of all his food the cheapest
and the best,

By his own labour caught, for
his own hunger dress'd.

Here our reformers come not; none
object

To paths polluted, or upbraid neglect;
None care that ashy heaps at doors
are cast,

That coal-dust flies along the blinding
blast;

None heed the stagnant pools on
either side,

Where new-launch'd ships of infant
sailors ride:

280

Rodneys in rags here British valour
boast,

And lisp'ing Nelsons fright the Gallic
coast.

They fix the rudder, set the swelling
sail,

They point the bowsprit, and they
blow the gale.

True to her port, the frigate scuds
away,

And o'er that frowning ocean finds
her bay:

Her owner rigg'd her, and he knows
her worth,

And sees her, fearless, gunwale-deep
go forth;
Dreadless he views his sea, by
breezes curl'd,
When inch-high billows vex the
watery world.

290

There, fed by food they love, to
rankest size
Around the dwellings docks and
wormwood rise;
Here the strong mallow strikes her
slimy root,
Here the dull night-shade hangs her
deadly fruit;
On hills of dust the henbane's faded
green,
And pencil'd flower of sickly scent is
seen;
At the wall's base the fiery nettle
springs,
With fruit globose and fierce with
poison'd stings;
Above (the growth of many a year) is
spread
The yellow level of the stone-crop's
bed;

300

In every chink delights the fern to
grow,
With glossy leaf and tawny bloom
below^[64]:
These, with our sea-weeds, rolling up
and down,
Form the contracted Flora^[65] of the
town.

Say, wilt thou more of scenes so
sordid know?
Then will I lead thee down the dusty
row,
By the warm alley and the long close
lane—
There mark the fractured door and
paper'd pane,
Where flags the noon-tide air, and, as
we pass,
We fear to breathe the putrefying
mass.

310

But fearless yonder matron; she
disdains
To sigh for zephyrs from ambrosial
plains;
But mends her meshes torn, and
pours her lay
All in the stifling fervour of the day.
Her naked children round the alley
run,
And, roll'd in dust, are bronzed
beneath the sun;
Or gambol round the dame, who,
loosely dress'd,
Woos the coy breeze, to fan the open
breast.
She, once a handmaid, strove by
decent art
To charm her sailor's eye and touch
his heart;

320

Her bosom then was veil'd in kerchief
clean,
And fancy left to form the charms
unseen.

But, when a wife, she lost her
former care,
Nor thought on charms, nor time for
dress could spare;
Careless she found her friends who
dwelt beside;
No rival beauty kept alive her pride:
Still in her bosom virtue keeps her
place;
But decency is gone, the virtues'
guard and grace.

See that long boarded building!—
By these stairs
Each humble tenant to that home
repairs—

330

By one large window lighted; it was
made
For some bold project, some design
in trade.

This fail'd—and one, a humorist in
his way,

(Ill was the humour), bought it in
decay;

Nor will he sell, repair, or take it
down;

'Tis his—what cares he for the talk of
town?

"No! he will let it to the poor—a
home

Where he delights to see the creatures
come."

"They may be thieves;"—"Well, so
are richer men;"—

"Or idlers, cheats, or
prostitutes;"—"What then?"—

340

"Outcasts pursued by justice, vile and
base;"—

"They need the more his pity and the
place,"

Convert to system his vain mind has
built,

He gives asylum to deceit and guilt.

In this vast room, each place by
habit fix'd,

Are sexes, families, and ages mix'd—
To union forced by crime, by fear, by
need,

And all in morals and in modes
agreed:

Some ruin'd men, who from mankind
remove;

Some ruin'd females, who yet talk of
love;

350

And some grown old in idleness—the
prey

To vicious spleen, still railing through
the day;

And need and misery, vice and
danger bind

In sad alliance each degraded mind.

That window view!—oil'd paper
and old glass

Stain the strong rays, which, though
impeded, pass,

And give a dusty warmth to that huge
room,

The conquer'd sunshine's melancholy
gloom;

When all those western rays, without
so bright,

Within become a ghastly glimmering
light,

360

As pale and faint upon the floor they
fall,
Or feebly gleam on the opposing
wall.

That floor, once oak, now pieced with
fir unplaned

Or, where not pieced, in places bored
and stain'd;

That wall, once whiten'd, now an
odious sight,

Stain'd with all hues, except its
ancient white;

The only door is fastened by a pin

Or stubborn bar, that none may hurry
in:

For this poor room, like rooms of
greater pride,

At times contains what prudent men
would hide.

370

Where'er the floor allows an even
space,

Chalking and marks of various games
have place;

Boys, without foresight, pleased in
halters swing,

On a fix'd hook men cast a flying
ring;

While gin and snuff their female
neighbours share,

And the black beverage in the
fractured ware.

On swinging shelf are things
incongruous stored—

Scraps of their food; the cards and
cribbage-board,
With pipes and pouches; while on peg
below
Hang a lost member's fiddle and its
bow,

380

That still reminds them how he'd
dance and play,
Ere sent untimely to the convicts' bay.
Here by a curtain, by a blanket
there,

Are various beds conceal'd, but none
with care;

Where some by day and some by
night, as best

Suit their employments, seek
uncertain rest;

The drowsy children at their pleasure
creep

To the known crib, and there securely
sleep.

Each end contains a grate, and
these beside

Are hung utensils for their boil'd and
fried—

390

All used at any hour, by night, by day,
As suit the purse, the person, or the
prey.

Above the fire, the mantel-shelf
contains

Of china-ware some poor unmatch'd
remains;

There many a tea-cup's gaudy
fragment stands,

All placed by vanity's unwearied
 hands;
 For here she lives, e'en here she looks
 about,
 To find some small consoling objects
 out.
 Nor heed these Spartan dames their
 house, nor sit
 'Mid cares domestic—they nor sew
 nor knit;
 400
 But of their fate discourse, their
 ways, their wars,
 With arm'd authorities, their 'scapes
 and scars:
 These lead to present evils, and a cup,
 If fortune grant it, winds description
 up.
 High hung at either end, and next
 the wall,
 Two ancient mirrors show the forms
 of all,
 In all their force;— }
 these aid them }
 in their dress,
 But, with the good, the evils
 too express,
 Doubling each look of care,
 each token of distress.

NOTES TO LETTER XVIII.

^[64] Note 1, p. 456, line 301.

With glossy leaf and tawny bloom below.

This scenery is, I must acknowledge, in a certain degree like that heretofore described in the Village; but that also was a maritime country:—if the objects be

similar, the pictures must (in their principal features) be alike, or be bad pictures. I have varied them as much as I could, consistently with my wish to be accurate.

[65] Note 2, page 456, line 303.

Form the contracted Flora of the town.

The reader unacquainted with the language of botany is informed, that the Flora of a place means the vegetable species it contains, and is the title of a book which describes them.

LETTER XIX.

THE POOR OF THE BOROUGH.

THE PARISH-CLERK.

Nam dives qui fieri vult,
Et citò vult fieri; sed quæ reverentia
legum,
Quis metus aut pudor est unquam
properantis avari?

Juvenal.

Sat.

14

[vv.

176

-8].

Nocte brevem si forte indulsit cura
soporem,
Et toto versata thoro jam membra
quiescunt,
Continuò templum et violati Numinis
aras,
Et, quod præcipuis mentem sudoribus
urget,

Te videt in somnis; tua sacra et major
imago

Humanâ turbat pavidum, cogitque fateri.

Juvenal.

Sat.

13

[vv.

217

-22]

.

Parish-Clerk began his Duties with the late Vicar, a grave and austere Man; one fully orthodox; a Detector and Opposer of the Wiles of Satan—His Opinion of his own Fortitude—The more frail offended by these Professions—His good Advice gives further Provocation—They invent Stratagems to overcome his Virtue—His Triumph—He is yet not invulnerable: is assaulted by Fear of Want, and Avarice—He gradually yields to the Seduction—He reasons with himself and is persuaded—He offends, but with Terror; repeats his Offence; grows familiar with Crime; is detected—His Sufferings and Death.

LETTER XIX.

THE PARISH-CLERK.

With our late vicar, }
and his age the }
same,

His clerk, hight Jachin, to his
office came:

The like slow speech was his,
the like tall slender frame.

But Jachin was the gravest man on
ground,

And heard his master's jokes with
look profound;

For worldly wealth this man of letters
sigh'd,

And had a sprinkling of the spirit's
pride;

But he was sober, chaste, devout, and
just,

One whom his neighbours could
believe and trust:

10

Of none suspected, neither man nor
maid

By him were wrong'd, or were of him
afraid.

There was indeed a frown, a trick
of state

In Jachin;—formal was his air and
gait;

But if he seem'd more solemn and
less kind

Than some light men to light affairs
confined,

Still 'twas allow'd that he should so
behave

As in high seat, and be severely
grave.

This book-taught man to man's first
foe profess'd

Defiance stern, and hate that knew
not rest;

20

He held that Satan, since the world
began,

In every act had strife with every
man;

That never evil deed on earth was
done,

But of the acting parties he was one:

The flattering guide to make ill
prosper clear;

To smooth rough ways the constant
pioneer;
The ever-tempting, soothing,
softening power,
Ready to cheat, seduce, deceive,
devour.

"Me has the sly seducer oft
withstood,"
Said pious Jachin,— "but he gets no
good;

30

I pass the house where swings the
tempting sign,
And, pointing, tell him, 'Satan, that is
thine;'
I pass the damsels pacing down the
street,
And look more grave and solemn
when we meet;
Nor doth it irk me to rebuke their
smiles,
Their wanton ambling and their
watchful wiles.
Nay, like the good John Bunyan,
when I view
Those forms, I'm angry at the ills they
do;
That I could pinch and spoil, in sin's
despite,
Beauties, which frail and evil
thoughts excite^[66]!

40

"At feasts and banquets seldom am
I found,
And (save at church) abhor a tuneful
sound;

To plays and shows I run not to and
fro,
And where my master goes forbear to
go."

No wonder Satan took the thing
amiss,
To be opposed by such a man as
this—

A man so grave, important, cautious,
wise,
Who dared not trust his feeling or his
eyes;

No wonder he should lurk and lie in
wait,
Should fit his hooks and ponder on
his bait;

50
Should on his movements keep a
watchful eye;

For he pursued a fish who led the fry.
With his own peace our clerk was
not content;

He tried, good man! to make his
friends repent.

"Nay, nay, my friends, from inns
and taverns fly;

You may suppress your thirst, but not
supply.

A foolish proverb says, 'the devil's at
home;'

But he is there, and tempts in every
room:

Men feel, they know not why, such
places please;

His are the spells—they're idleness
and ease;

60

Magic of fatal kind he throws around,
Where care is banish'd but the heart is
bound.

"Think not of beauty; when a maid
you meet,
Turn from her view, and step across
the street;
Dread all the sex: their looks create a
charm,
A smile should fright you and a word
alarm.

E'en I myself, with all }
my watchful }
care,

Have for an instant felt th'
insidious snare,
And caught my sinful eyes at
th' endangering stare;
Till I was forced to smite my
bounding breast

70

With forceful blow and bid the bold-
one rest.

"Go not with crowds when they to
pleasure run,
But public joy in private safety shun.
When bells, diverted }
from their true }
intent,

Ring loud for some deluded
mortal sent

To hear or make long speech
in parliament;

What time the many, that unruly
beast,

Roars its rough joy and shares the
final feast:

Then heed my counsel, shut thine
ears and eyes;
A few will hear me—for the few are
wise."

80

Not Satan's friends, nor Satan's self
could bear
The cautious man who took of souls
such care:
An interloper—one who, out of place,
Had volunteer'd upon the side of
grace.
There was his master ready once a
week
To give advice; what further need he
seek?
"Amen, so be it:"—what had he to do
With more than this?—'twas insolent
and new;
And some determined on a way to see
How frail he was, that so it might not
be.

90

First they essay'd to tempt our saint
to sin,
By points of doctrine argued at an
inn;
Where he might warmly reason,
deeply drink,
Then lose all power to argue and to
think.
In vain they tried; he took the
question up,
Clear'd every doubt, and barely
touch'd the cup;
By many a text he proved his doctrine
sound,

And look'd in triumph on the
tempters round.

Next 'twas their care an artful lass
to find,
Who might consult him, as perplex'd
in mind;

100

She, they conceived, might put her
case with fears,
With tender tremblings and seducing
tears;
She might such charms of various
kind display,
That he would feel their force and
melt away:
For why of nymphs such caution and
such dread,
Unless he felt and fear'd to be misled?
She came, she spake: he calmly
heard her case,
And plainly told her 'twas a want of
grace;
Bade her "such fancies and affections
check,
And wear a thicker muslin on her
neck."

110

Abased, his human foes the combat
fled,
And the stern clerk yet higher held
his head.
They were indeed a weak, impatient
set;
But their shrewd prompter had his
engines yet;
Had various means to make a mortal
trip,

Who shunn'd a flowing bowl and rosy
lip;
And knew a thousand ways his heart
to move,
Who flies from banquets and who
laughs at love.

Thus far the playful Muse has lent
her aid,
But now departs, of graver theme
afraid;

120

Her may we seek in more appropriate
time—
There is no jesting with distress and
crime.

Our worthy clerk had now arrived
at fame,
Such as but few in his degree might
claim;
But he was poor, and wanted not the
sense

That lowly rates the praise without
the pence:

He saw the common herd with
reverence treat

The weakest burgess whom they
chanced to meet;

While few respected his exalted
views,

And all beheld his doublet and his
shoes;

130

None, when they meet, would to his
parts allow
(Save his poor boys) a hearing or a
bow.

To this false judgment of the vulgar
mind

He was not fully, as a saint, resign'd;
He found it much his jealous soul
affect,

To fear derision and to find neglect.

The year was bad, the christening-
fees were small,

The weddings few, the parties
paupers all:

Desire of gain, with fear of want
combined,

Raised sad commotion in his
wounded mind;

140

Wealth was in all his thoughts, his
views, his dreams,

And prompted base desires and
baseless schemes.

Alas! how often erring mortals
keep

The strongest watch against the foes
who sleep;

While the more wakeful, bold and
artful foe

Is suffer'd guardless and unmark'd to
go.

Once in a month the sacramental
bread

Our clerk with wine upon the table
spread;

The custom this, that, as the vicar
reads,

He for our off'rings round the church
proceeds.

150

Tall, spacious seats the wealthier
people hid,
And none had view of what his
neighbour did;
Laid on the box and mingled when
they fell,
Who should the worth of each
oblation tell?
Now as poor Jachin took the usual
round,
And saw the alms and heard the metal
sound,
He had a thought;—at first it was no
more
Than—"these have cash and give it to
the poor."
A second thought from this to work
began—
"And can they give it to a poorer
man?"

160

Proceeding thus—"My merit could
they know,
And knew my need, how freely they'd
bestow;
But though they know not, these
remain the same;
And are a strong, although a secret
claim:
To me, alas! the want and worth are
known;—
Why then, in fact, 'tis but to take my
own."
Thought after thought pour'd in, a
tempting train—
"Suppose it done, who is it could
complain?"

How could the poor? for they such
trifles share
As add no comfort, as suppress no
care;

170

But many a pittance makes a worthy
heap—
What says the law? that silence puts
to sleep;—
Nought then forbids, the danger could
we shun;
And sure the business may be safely
done.

"But am I earnest?—earnest? No.
—I say,
If such my mind, that I could plan a
way;
Let me reflect;—I've not allow'd me
time
To purse the pieces, and if dropp'd
they'd chime."
Fertile is evil in the soul of man—
He paused—said Jachin, "They may
drop on bran.

180

Why then 'tis safe and (all consider'd)
just;
The poor receive it—'tis no breach of
trust;
The old and widows may their trifles
miss,
There must be evil in a good like this.
But I'll be kind—the sick I'll visit
twice,
When now but once, and freely give
advice.

Yet let me think again,"—Again he
tried
For stronger reasons on his passion's
side;
And quickly these were found, yet
slowly he complied.
The morning came: the common
service done—

190

Shut every door—the solemn rite
begun;
And, as the priest the sacred sayings
read,
The clerk went forward, trembling as
he tread;
O'er the tall pew he held the box, and
heard
The offer'd piece, rejoicing as he
fear'd.
Just by the pillar, as he cautious
tripp'd,
And turn'd the aile, he then a portion
slipp'd
From the full store, and to the pocket
sent,
But held a moment—and then down
it went.
The priest read on; on walk'd the
man afraid,

200

Till a gold offering in the plate was
laid;
Trembling he took it, for a moment
stopp'd,
Then down it fell, and sounded as it
dropp'd;

Amazed he started, for th' affrighted
man,
Lost and bewildered, thought not of
the bran;
But all were silent, all on things
intent
Of high concern; none ear to money
lent;
So on he walk'd, more cautious than
before,
And gain'd the purposed sum, and
one piece more.

Practice makes perfect;—when the
month came round,

210

He dropp'd the cash, nor listen'd for a
sound;
But yet, when, last of all th'
assembled flock,
He ate and drank—it gave th' electric
shock.
Oft was he forced his reasons to
repeat,
Ere he could kneel in quiet at his seat;
But custom soothed him.—Ere a
single year
All this was done without restraint or
fear:
Cool and collected, easy and
composed,
He was correct till all the service
closed;
Then to his home, without a groan or
sigh,

220

Gravely he went, and laid his treasure
by.

Want will complain: some widows
 had express'd
A doubt if they were favour'd like the
 rest;
The rest described with like regret
 their dole,
And thus from parts they reason'd to
 the whole;
When all agreed some evil must be
 done,
Or rich men's hearts grew harder than
 a stone.

Our easy vicar cut the matter short;
He would not listen to such vile
 report.

All were not thus— }
 there
 govern'd in
 that year

230

A stern stout churl, an angry overseer;
A tyrant fond of power, loud,
 lewd, and most severe.
Him the mild vicar, him the graver
 clerk,
Advised, reproved, but nothing would
 he mark,
Save the disgrace; "and that, my
 friends," said he,
"Will I avenge, whenever time may
 be."
And now, alas! 'twas time;—from
 man to man
Doubt and alarm and shrewd
 suspicions ran.
With angry spirit and with sly
 intent,

This parish ruler to the altar went;

240

A private mark he fix'd on shillings
three,

And but one mark could in the money
see;

Besides, in peering round, he chanced
to note

A sprinkling slight on Jachin's
Sunday-coat.

All doubt was over:—when the flock
were bless'd,

In wrath he rose, and thus his mind
express'd,

"Foul deeds are here!" and, saying
this, he took

The clerk, whose conscience, in her
cold-fit, shook.

His pocket then was emptied on the
place;

All saw his guilt; all witness'd his
disgrace:

250

He fell, he fainted; not a groan, a
look,

Escaped the culprit; 'twas a final
stroke—

A death-wound never to be heal'd—a
fall

That all had witness'd, and amazed
were all.

As he recover'd, to his mind it
came,

"I owe to Satan this disgrace and
shame."

All the seduction now appear'd in
view;

"Let me withdraw," he said, and he
withdrew;

No one withheld him, all in union
cried,

E'en the avenger—"We are satisfied;"

260

For what has death in any form to
give,

Equal to that man's terrors, if he live?

He lived in freedom, but he hourly
saw

How much more fatal justice is than
law;

He saw another in his office reign,

And his mild master treat him with
disdain;

He saw that all men shunn'd him,
some reviled;

The harsh pass'd frowning, and the
simple smiled;

The town maintain'd him, but with
some reproof;

"And clerks and scholars proudly
kept aloof."

270

In each lone place, dejected and
dismay'd,

Shrinking from view, his wasting
form he laid;

Or to the restless sea and roaring
wind

Gave the strong yearnings of a ruin'd
mind.

On the broad beach, the silent
summer day,

Stretch'd on some wreck, he wore his
life away;

Or where the river }
mingles with }
the sea,
Or on the mud-bank by the
elder-tree,
Or by the bounding marsh-
dyke, there was he;
And when unable to forsake the town,
280
In the blind courts he sate desponding
down—
Always alone; then feebly would he
crawl
The church-way walk, and lean upon
the wall.
Too ill for this, he lay beside the door,
Compell'd to hear the reasoning of
the poor:
He look'd so pale, so weak, the
pitying crowd
Their firm belief of his repentance
vow'd;
They saw him then so ghastly and so
thin,
That they exclaim'd, "Is this the work
of sin?"
"Yes," in his better moments, he
replied,
290
"Of sinful avarice and the spirit's
pride;—
While yet untempted, I was safe and
well;
Temptation came; I reason'd, and I
fell.
To be man's guide and glory I
design'd,

A rare example for our sinful kind;
 But now my weakness and my guilt I
 see,
 And am a warning—man, be warn'd
 by me!"

He said, and saw no more the
 human face;
 To a lone loft he went, his dying
 place,
 And, as the vicar of his state inquired,
 300
 Turn'd to the wall and silently
 expired!

FOOTNOTES:

^[66] John Bunyan, in one of the many productions of his zeal, has ventured to make public this extraordinary sentiment, which the frigid piety of our clerk so readily adopted.

LETTER XX.

THE POOR OF THE BOROUGH.

ELLEN ORFORD.

Patience and sorrow strove
 Who should express her goodliest.

Shakspeare

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r
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 iv.
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 3,

"No charms she now can boast,"—'tis
true,
But other charmers wither too:
"And she is old,"—the fact I know,
And old will other heroines grow;
But not like them has she been laid,
In ruin'd castle, sore dismay'd;
Where naughty man and ghostly spright
Fill'd her pure mind with awe and
dread,
Stalk'd round the room, put out the light,
And shook the curtains round the bed.
No cruel uncle kept her land;
No tyrant father forced her hand;
She had no vixen virgin-aunt,
Without whose aid she could not eat,
And yet who poison'd all her meat,
With gibe and sneer and taunt.
Yet of the heroine she'd a share:
She saved a lover from despair,
And granted all his wish, in spite
Of what she knew and felt was right;
But heroine then no more,
She own'd the fault, and wept and pray'd,
And humbly took the parish aid,
And dwelt among the poor.

Widow's Cottage—Blind Ellen one—Hers not the Sorrows or Adventures of Heroines—What these
are, first described—Deserted Wives; rash Lovers; courageous Damsels: in desolated Mansions; in
grievous Perplexity—These Evils, however severe, of short Duration—Ellen's Story—Her
Employment in Childhood—First Love; first Adventure; its miserable Termination—An idiot
Daughter—A Husband—Care in Business without Success—The Man's Despondency and its

Effect—Their Children: how disposed of—One particularly unfortunate—Fate of the Daughter—
Ellen keeps a School and is happy—Becomes blind; loses her School—Her Consolations.

LETTER XX.

ELLEN ORFORD.

Observe yon tenement, apart and
small,
Where the wet pebbles shine upon the
wall;
Where the low benches lean beside
the door,
And the red paling bounds the space
before;
Where thrift and lavender and lad's-
love^[67] bloom—
That humble dwelling is the widow's
home.
There live a pair, for various fortunes
known,
But the Blind Ellen will relate her
own;—
Yet, ere we hear the story she can tell,
10
On prouder sorrows let us briefly
dwell.
I've often marvel'd, when by night,
by day,
I've mark'd the manners moving in
my way,
And heard the language and beheld
the lives
Of lass and lover, goddesses and
wives:
That books, which promise much of
life to give,

Should show so little how we truly
live.

To me it seems, their females and
their men
Are but the creatures of the author's
pen;
Nay, creatures borrow'd and again
convey'd

20

From book to book—the shadows of
a shade.

Life, if they'd search, would show
them many a change,
The ruin sudden and the misery
strange!

With more of grievous, base, and
dreadful things,

Than novelists relate or poet sings.

But they, who ought to look the world
around,

Spy out a single spot in fairy-ground;
Where all, in turn, ideal forms
behold,

And plots are laid and histories are
told.

Time have I lent—I would their
debt were less—

30

To flow'ry pages of sublime distress;
And to the heroine's soul-distracting
fears

I early gave my sixpences and tears:
Oft have I travell'd in these tender
tales,

To Darnley-Cottages and Maple-
Vales,

And watch'd the fair-one from the
first-born sigh,
When Henry pass'd and gazed in
passing by;
Till I beheld them pacing in the park,
Close by a coppice where 'twas cold
and dark;
When such affection with such fate
appear'd,

40

Want and a father to be shunn'd and
fear'd,
Without employment, prospect, cot,
or cash,
That I have judged th' heroic souls
were rash.

Now shifts the scene—the fair, in
tower confined,
In all things suffers but in change of
mind;
Now woo'd by greatness to a bed of
state,
Now deeply threaten'd with a
dungeon's grate;
Till, suffering much and being tried
enough,
She shines, triumphant maid!—
temptation-proof.

Then was I led to vengeful monks,
who mix

50

With nymphs and swains, and play
unpriestly tricks;
Then view'd banditti, who in forest
wide,
And cavern vast, indignant virgins
hide;

Who, hemm'd with bands of sturdiest
 rogues about,
Find some strange succour, and come
 virgins out.

I've watch'd a wint'ry night on
 castle-walls;
I've stalk'd by moonlight through
 deserted halls;
And, when the weary world was sunk
 to rest,
I've had such sights as—may not be
 express'd.

Lo! that chateau, the western tower
 decay'd,

60

The peasants shun it—they are all
 afraid;
For there was done a deed!—could
 walls reveal,
Or timbers tell it, how the heart
 would feel!
Most horrid was it:—for, behold, the
 floor
Has stain of blood, and will be clean
 no more.
Hark to the winds! which through the
 wide saloon
And the long passage send a dismal
 tune—
Music that ghosts delight in;—and
 now heed
Yon beauteous nymph, who must
 unmask the deed.
See! with majestic sweep she swims
 alone

70

Through rooms, all dreary, guided by
a groan;
Though windows rattle, and though
tap'stries shake,
And the feet falter every step they
take,
'Mid groans and gibing }
sprights she }
silent goes,
To find a something, which
will soon expose
The villanies and wiles of her
determined foes;
And, having thus adventured, thus
endured,
Fame, wealth, and lover, are for life
secured.

Much have I fear'd, but am no
more afraid,
When some chaste beauty, by some
wretch betray'd,

80

Is drawn away with such distracted
speed,
That she anticipates a dreadful
deed;—
Not so do I.—Let solid walls
impound
The captive fair, and dig a moat
around;
Let there be brazen locks and bars of
steel,
And keepers cruel, such as never feel;
With not a single note the purse
supply,
And when she begs, let men and
maids deny;

Be windows those from which she
dares not fall,
And help so distant, 'tis in vain to
call;

90

Still means of freedom will some
power devise,
And from the baffled ruffian snatch
his prize.

To Northern Wales, in some
sequester'd spot,
I've followed fair Louisa to her cot;
Where, then a wretched and deserted
bride,
The injured fair-one wish'd from man
to hide;
Till by her fond repenting Belville
found,
By some kind chance—the straying
of a hound—
He at her feet craved mercy, nor in
vain;
For the relenting dove flew back
again.

100

There's something }
rapturous in
distress, or, oh!
Could Clementina bear her lot
of wo?
Or what she underwent could
maiden undergo?
The day was fix'd; for so the lover
sigh'd,
So knelt and craved, he couldn't be
denied;

When, tale most dreadful! every hope
adieu—

For the fond lover is the brother too:
All other griefs abate; this monstrous
grief
Has no remission, comfort, or relief;
Four ample volumes, through each
page disclose—

110

Good Heaven protect us!—only woes
on woes;

Till some strange means afford a
sudden view

Of some vile plot, and every wo
adieu!^[68]

Now, should we grant these
beauties all endure
Severest pangs, they've still the
speediest cure,
Before one charm be }
wither'd from }
the face,

Except the bloom, which shall
again have place,

In wedlock ends each wish, in
triumph all disgrace;

And life to come we fairly may
suppose

One light, bright contrast to these
wild dark woes.

120

These let us leave, and at her
sorrows look,

Too often seen, but seldom in a book;
Let her who felt, relate them.—On
her chair

The heroine sits—in former years the
fair,
Now aged and poor; but Ellen Orford
knows,
That we should humbly take what
Heav'n bestows.

"My father died—again my mother
wed,
And found the comforts of her life
were fled;
Her angry husband, vex'd through
half his years
By loss and troubles, fill'd her soul
with fears;

130

Their children many, and 'twas my
poor place
To nurse and wait on all the infant-
race;
Labour and hunger were indeed my
part,
And should have strengthen'd an
erroneous heart.

"Sore was the grief to see him
angry come,
And, teased with business, make
distress at home;
The father's fury and the children's
cries
I soon could bear, but not my
mother's sighs;
For she look'd back on comforts, and
would say,
'I wrong'd thee, Ellen,' and then turn
away.

140

Thus for my age's good, my youth
was tried,
And this my fortune till my mother
died.

"So, amid sorrow much and little
cheer—

A common case—I pass'd my
twentieth year;
For these are frequent evils;
thousands share
An equal grief—the like domestic
care.

"Then in my days of bloom, of
health and youth,
One, much above me, vow'd his love
and truth.

We often met, he dreading to be seen,
And much I question'd what such
dread might mean;

150

Yet I believed him true; my simple
heart

And undirected reason took his part.

"Can he who loves }
me, whom I }
love,
deceive?

Can I such wrong of one so
kind believe,

Who lives but in my smile,
who trembles when I grieve?

"He dared not marry, but we met to
prove

What sad encroachments and deceits
has love:

Weak that I was, when he, rebuked,
withdrew,

I let him see that I was wretched too;
When less my caution, I had still the
pain

160

Of his or mine own weakness to
complain.

"Happy the lovers class'd alike in
life,

Or happier yet the rich endowing
wife;

But most aggrieved the fond
believing maid,

Of her rich lover tenderly afraid.

You judge th' event; for grievous was
my fate,

Painful to feel, and shameful to
relate:

Ah! sad it was my burthen to sustain,
When the least misery was the dread
of pain;

When I have grieving told him my
disgrace,

170

And plainly mark'd indifference in his
face.

"Hard! with these fears and terrors
to behold

The cause of all, the faithless lover
cold;

Impatient grown at every wish
denied,

And barely civil, soothed and
gratified;

Peevish when urged to think of vows
so strong,

And angry when I spake of crime and
wrong.

"All this I felt, and still the sorrow
grew,
Because I felt that I deserved it too,
And begg'd my infant stranger to
forgive

180

The mother's shame, which in herself
must live.

"When known that shame, I, soon
expell'd from home,
With a frail sister shared a hovel's
gloom;
There barely fed—(what could I more
request?)—
My infant slumberer sleeping at my
breast;
I from my window saw his blooming
bride,
And my seducer smiling at her side;
Hope lived till then; I sank upon the
floor,
And grief and thought and feeling
were no more.
Although revived, I judged that life
would close,

190

And went to rest, to wonder that I
rose:
My dreams were dismal; wheresoe'er
I stray'd,
I seem'd ashamed, alarm'd, despised,
betray'd;
Always in grief, in guilt, disgraced,
forlorn,
Mourning that one so weak, so vile,
was born;
The earth a desert, tumult in the sea,

The birds }
affrighted fled }
from tree to
tree,
Obscured the setting sun, and
every thing like me;
But Heav'n had mercy, and my need
at length
Urged me to labour and renew'd my
strength.

200

"I strove for patience as a sinner
must,
Yet felt th' opinion of the world
unjust:
There was my lover, in his joy,
esteem'd,
And I, in my distress, as guilty
deem'd;
Yet sure, not all the guilt and shame
belong
To her who feels and suffers for the
wrong.
The cheat at play may use the wealth
he's won,
But is not honour'd for the mischief
done;
The cheat in love may use each
villain-art,
And boast the deed that breaks the
victim's heart.

210

"Four years were past; I might
again have found
Some erring wish, but for another
wound:

Lovely my daughter grew, her face
was fair;

But no expression ever brighten'd
there.

I doubted long, and vainly strove to
make

Some certain meaning of the words
she spake;

But meaning there was none, and I
survey'd

With dread the beauties of my idiot-
maid.

"Still I submitted;—Oh! 'tis meet
and fit

In all we feel to make the heart
submit;

220

Gloomy and calm my days, but I had
then,

It seem'd, attractions for the eyes of
men.

The sober master of a decent trade
O'erlook'd my errors, and his offer
made;

Reason assented;—true, my heart
denied,

'But thou,' I said, 'shalt be no more
my guide.'

"When wed, our toil and trouble,
pains and care,

Of means to live procured us humble
share;

Five were our sons,—and we, though
careful, found

Our hopes declining as the year came
round;

230

For I perceived, yet would not soon
perceive,
My husband stealing from my view
to grieve;
Silent he grew, and when he spoke he
sigh'd,
And surly look'd and peevishly
replied.
Pensive by nature, he had gone of late
To those who preach'd of destiny and
fate,
Of things fore-doom'd, and of
election-grace,
And how in vain we strive to run our
race;
That all by works and }
moral worth }
we gain
Is to perceive our care and
labour vain;

240

That still the more we pay, our debts
the more remain;
That he who feels not the mysterious
call,
Lies bound in sin, still grov'ling from
the fall.
My husband felt not;—our
persuasion, prayer,
And our best reason darken'd his
despair;
His very nature changed; he now
reviled
My former conduct—he reproach'd
my child;
He talk'd of bastard slips, and cursed
his bed,

And from our kindness to
concealment fled;

For ever to some evil }
change
inclined,

250

To every gloomy thought he lent his
mind,

Nor rest would give to us, nor
rest himself could find;

His son suspended saw him, long
bereft

Of life, nor prospect of revival left.

"With him died all our prospects,
and once more

I shared th' allotments of the parish
poor;

They took my children too, and this I
know

Was just and lawful, but I felt the
blow;

My idiot-maid and one unhealthy boy
Were left, a mother's misery and her
joy.

260

"Three sons I follow'd to the grave,
and one—

Oh! can I speak of that unhappy son?

Would all the memory of that time
were fled,

And all those horrors, with my child,
were dead!

Before the world seduced him, what a
grace

And smile of gladness shone upon his
face!

Then he had knowledge; finely would
he write;
Study to him was pleasure and
delight;
Great was his courage, and but few
could stand
Against the sleight and vigour of his
hand;

270

The maidens loved him;—when he
came to die,
No, not the coldest could suppress a
sigh.
Here I must cease—how can I say,
my child
Was by the bad of either sex
beguiled?
Worst of the bad—they taught him
that the laws
Made wrong and right; there was no
other cause;
That all religion was the trade of
priests,
And men, when dead, must perish
like the beasts;—
And he, so lively and so gay before—
Ah! spare a mother—I can tell no
more.

280

"Int'rest was made that they should
not destroy
The comely form of my deluded
boy—
But pardon came not; damp the place
and deep
Where he was kept, as they'd a tiger
keep;

For he, unhappy! had before them all
Vow'd he'd escape, whatever might
 befall.

 "He'd means of dress, and dress'd
 beyond his means,
And, so to see him in such dismal
 scenes,
I cannot speak it—cannot bear to tell
Of that sad hour—I heard the
 passing-bell!

290

 "Slowly they went; he smiled and
 look'd so smart,
Yet sure he shudder'd when he saw
 the cart,
And gave a look—until my dying-
 day,
That look will never from my mind
 away;
Oft as I sit, and ever in my dreams,
I see that look, and they have heard
 my screams.

 "Now let me speak no more—yet
 all declared
That one so young, in pity should be
 spared,
And one so manly;—on his graceful
 neck,
That chains of jewels may be proud
 to deck,

300

To a small mole a mother's lips have
 press'd—
And there the cord—my breath is
 sore oppress'd.

 "I now can speak again:—my elder
 boy

Was that year drown'd—a seaman in
a hoy.

He left a numerous race; of these
would some

In their young troubles to my cottage
come;

And these I taught—an humble
teacher I—

Upon their heavenly Parent to rely.

"Alas! I needed such reliance
more:—

My idiot-girl, so simply gay before,
310

Now wept in pain; some wretch had
found a time,

Depraved and wicked, for that
coward-crime;

I had indeed my doubt, but I
suppress'd

The thought that day and night
disturb'd my rest;

She and that sick-pale brother—but
why strive

To keep the terrors of that time alive?

"The hour arrived, the new, th'
undreaded pain,

That came with violence and yet
came in vain.

I saw her die; her brother too is dead,
Nor own'd such crime—what is it that
I dread?

320

"The parish-aid withdrawn, I
look'd around,

And in my school a bless'd
subsistence found—

My winter-calm of life: to be of use

Would pleasant thoughts and
 heavenly hopes produce;
 I loved them all; it soothed me to
 presage
 The various trials of their riper age,
 Then dwell on mine, and bless the
 Power who gave
 Pains to correct us, and remorse to
 save.
 "Yes! these were days of peace, but
 they are past—
 A trial came, I will believe, a last;
 330
 I lost my sight, and my employment
 gone,
 Useless I live, but to the day live on;
 Those eyes, which long the light of
 heaven enjoy'd,
 Were not by pain, by agony destroy'd;
 My senses fail not all; I speak, I pray;
 By night my rest, my food I take by
 day;
 And as my mind looks cheerful to my
 end,
 I love mankind and call my God my
 friend."

NOTES TO LETTER XX.

[67] Note 1, page 470, line 5.

*Where thrift and lavender and
 lad's-love bloom.*

The lad's or boy's love of some counties is the plant
 southernwood, the *artemisia abrotanum* of botanists.

[68] Note 2, page 473, line 112.

*Of some vile plot, and every wo
 adieu!*

As this incident points out the work alluded to, I wish it to be remembered, that the gloomy tenour, the querulous melancholy of the story, is all I censure. The language of the writer is often animated, and is, I believe, correct; the characters well drawn, and the manners described from real life; but the perpetual occurrence of sad events, the protracted list of teasing and perplexing mischances, joined with much waspish invective, unallayed by pleasantry or sprightliness, and these continued through many hundred pages, render publications, intended for amusement and executed with ability, heavy and displeasing;—you find your favourite persons happy in the end; but they have teased you so much with their perplexities by the way, that you were frequently disposed to quit them in their distresses.

LETTER XXI.

THE POOR OF THE BOROUGH.

ABEL KEENE.

[Cœpisti] melius quam [desinis]: ultima
primis

Cedunt. Dissimiles: hic vir et ille puer.

Ovid.

*Dei
anir
a
Her
culi
[He
roid
.
VIII
. vv.
23-
4].*

Now the Spirit speaketh expressly, that, in the latter times, some shall depart from the faith, giving heed to seducing spirits and doctrines of devils.

[I] *Epistle to Timothy*, [ch. IV. v. 1].

1. a poor Man, Teacher of a School of the lower Order; is placed in the Office of a Merchant; is alarmed by Discourses of the Clerks; unable to reply; becomes a Convert; dresses, drinks, and ridicules his former Conduct—The Remonstrance of his Sister, a devout Maiden—Its Effect—The Merchant dies—Abel returns to Poverty unpitied; but relieved—His abject Condition—His Melancholy—He wanders about: is found—His own Account of himself, and the Revolutions in his Mind.

LETTER XXI.

ABEL KEENE.

A quiet simple man was Abel
Keene;
He meant no harm, nor did he often
mean.
He kept a school of loud rebellious
boys,
And growing old, grew nervous with
the noise;
When a kind merchant hired his
useful pen,
And made him happiest of
accompting men;
With glee he rose to every easy day,
When half the labour brought him
twice the pay.
There were young clerks, and there
the merchant's son,
10
Choice spirits all, who wish'd him to
be one;

It must, no question, give them lively
joy,
Hopes long indulged, to combat and
destroy;
At these they level'd all their skill and
strength—
He fell not quickly, but he fell at
length.
They quoted books, to him both bold
and new,
And scorn'd as fables all he held as
true—
"Such monkish stories and such
nursery lies,"
That he was struck with terror and
surprise.
"What! all his life had he the laws
obey'd,

20

Which they broke through and were
not once afraid?
Had he so long his evil passions
check'd,
And yet at last had nothing to expect?
While they their lives in joy and
pleasure led,
And then had nothing, at the end, to
dread?
Was all his priest with so much zeal
convey'd,
A part! a speech! for which the man
was paid?
And were his pious books, his solemn
prayers,
Not worth one tale of the admired
Voltaire's?

Then was it time, while yet some
years remain'd,

30

To drink untroubled and to think
unchain'd,
And on all pleasures, which his purse
could give,
Freely to seize, and while he lived, to
live."

Much time he passed in this
important strife,
The bliss or bane of his remaining
life;
For converts all are made with care
and grief,
And pangs attend the birth of
unbelief;
Nor pass they soon;—with awe and
fear he took
The flow'ry way, and cast back many
a look.

The youths applauded much his
wise design,

40

With weighty reasoning o'er their
evening wine;
And much in private 'twould their
mirth improve,
To hear how Abel spake of life and
love;
To hear him own what grievous pains
it cost,
Ere the old saint was in the sinner
lost;
Ere his poor mind with every deed
alarm'd,

By wit was settled, and by vice was
charm'd.

For Abel enter'd in his bold career,
Like boys on ice, with pleasure and
with fear;
Lingering, yet longing for the joy, he
went,

50

Repenting now, now dreading to
repent;
With awkward pace, and with himself
at war,
Far gone, yet frighten'd that he went
so far;
Oft for his efforts he'd solicit praise,
And then proceed with blunders and
delays.

The young more aptly }
passion's calls }
pursue,

But age and weakness start at
scenes so new,
And tremble when they've
done, for all they dared to do.
At length example Abel's dread
removed;

With small concern he sought the
joys he loved;

60

Not resting here, he claim'd his share
of fame,
And first their votary, then their wit
became;
His jest was bitter and his satire bold,
When he his tales of formal brethren
told,

What time with pious neighbours he
discuss'd,

Their boasted treasure and their
boundless trust:

"Such were our dreams," the jovial
elder cried;

"Awake and live," his youthful
friends replied.

Now the gay clerk a modest drab
despised,

And clad him smartly as his friends
advised;

70

So fine a coat upon his back he threw,
That not an alley-boy old Abel knew;
Broad polish'd buttons blazed that
coat upon,

And just beneath the watch's trinkets
shone—

A splendid watch, that pointed out the
time,

To fly from business and make free
with crime.

The crimson waistcoat and the silken
hose

Rank'd the lean man among the
Borough beaux;

His raven hair he cropp'd with fierce
disdain,

And light elastic locks encased his
brain:

80

More pliant pupil who could hope to
find,

So deck'd in person and so changed in
mind?

When Abel walk'd the streets, with
pleasant mien
He met his friends, delighted to be
seen;
And, when he rode along the public
way,
No beau so gaudy and no youth so
gay.
His pious sister, }
now an }
ancient
maid,
For Abel fearing, first in
secret pray'd;
Then thus in love and scorn
her notions she convey'd:
"Alas! my brother! }
can I see }
thee pace

90

Hoodwink'd to hell, and not lament
thy case,
Nor stretch my feeble hand to
stop thy headlong race?
Lo! thou art bound; a slave in Satan's
chain,
The righteous Abel turn'd the
wretched Cain;
His brother's blood against the
murderer cried;
Against thee thine, unhappy suicide!
Are all our pious nights and peaceful
days,
Our evening readings and our
morning praise,
Our spirits' comfort in the trials sent,

Our hearts' rejoicings in the blessings
lent,

100

All that o'er grief a cheering influence
shed—

Are these for ever and for ever fled?

"When in the years gone by, the
trying years,

When faith and hope had strife with
wants and fears,

Thy nerves have trembled till thou
couldst not eat

(Dress'd by this hand) thy mess of
simple meat;

When, grieved by fastings, gall'd by
fates severe,

Slow pass'd the days of the
successless year;

Still in these gloomy hours, my
brother then

Had glorious views, unseen by
prosperous men:

110

And when thy heart has felt its wish
denied,

What gracious texts hast thou to grief
applied;

Till thou hast enter'd in thine humble
bed,

By lofty hopes and heavenly musings
fed;

Then I have seen thy lively looks
express

The spirit's comforts in the man's
distress.

"Then didst thou cry, exulting,
'Yes, 'tis fit,

'Tis meet and right, my heart! that we
submit;
And wilt thou, Abel, thy new
pleasures weigh
Against such triumphs?—Oh! repent
and pray.

120

"What are thy pleasures?—with the
gay to sit,
And thy poor brain torment for
awkward wit;
All thy good thoughts (thou hat'st
them) to restrain,
And give a wicked pleasure to the
vain;
Thy long lean frame by fashion to
attire,
That lads may laugh and wantons
may admire;
To raise the mirth of boys, and not to
see,
Unhappy maniac! that they laugh at
thee.

"These boyish follies, which alone
the boy
Can idly act or gracefully enjoy,

130

Add new reproaches to thy fallen
state,
And make men scorn what they
would only hate.

"What pains, my brother, dost thou
take to prove
A taste for follies which thou canst
not love!
Why do thy stiffening limbs the steed
bestride—

That lads may laugh to see thou canst
not ride?

And why (I feel the crimson tinge my
cheek)

Dost thou by night in Diamond-Alley
sneak?

"Farewell! the }
 parish will }
 thy sister
 keep,

Where she in peace shall pray
and sing and sleep,

140

Save when for thee she mourns, thou
wicked, wandering sheep!

When youth is fall'n, there's hope the
young may rise,

But fallen age for ever hopeless lies:

Torn up by storms and placed in earth
once more,

The younger tree may sun and soil
restore;

But when the old and sapless trunk
lies low,

No care or soil can former life
bestow;

Reserved for burning is the worthless
tree;

And what, O Abel! is reserved for
thee?"

These angry words our hero deeply
felt,

150

Though hard his heart, and
indisposed to melt!

To gain relief he took a glass the
more,

And, then went on as careless as
before;
Thenceforth, uncheck'd, amusements
he partook,
And (save his ledger) saw no decent
book;
Him found the merchant punctual at
his task,
And, that perform'd, he'd nothing
more to ask;
He cared not how old Abel play'd the
fool,
No master he, beyond the hours of
school:
Thus they, proceeding, had their wine
and joke,

160

Till merchant Dixon felt a warning
stroke,
And, after struggling half a gloomy
week,
Left his poor clerk another friend to
seek.

Alas! the son, who led the saint
astray,
Forgot the man whose follies made
him gay;
He cared no more for Abel in his
need,
[Than] Abel cared about his hackney
steed;
He now, alas! had all his earnings
spent,
And thus was left to languish and
repent;
No school nor clerkship found he in
the place,

170

Now lost to fortune, as before to
grace.

For town-relief the grieving man
applied,
And begg'd with tears what some
with scorn denied;
Others look'd down upon the glowing
vest,
And, frowning, ask'd him at what
price he dress'd?
Happy for him his country's laws are
mild,
They must support him, though they
still reviled;
Grieved, abject, scorn'd, insulted, and
betray'd,
Of God unmindful, and of man
afraid—
No more he talk'd; 'twas pain, 'twas
shame to speak,

180

His heart was sinking and his frame
was weak.
His sister died with such serene
delight,
He once again began to think her
right;
Poor like himself, the happy spinster
lay,
And sweet assurance bless'd her
dying-day;
Poor like the spinster, he, when death
was nigh,
Assured of nothing, felt afraid to die.
The cheerful clerks who sometimes
pass'd the door,

Just mention'd "Abel!" and then
thought no more.

So Abel, pondering on his state
forlorn,

190

Look'd round for comfort, and was
chased by scorn.

And now we saw him on the beach
reclined,

Or causeless walking in the wint'ry
wind;

And, when it raised a loud and angry
sea,

He stood and gazed, in wretched
reverie;

He heeded not the frost, the rain, the
snow;

Close by the sea he walk'd alone and
slow.

Sometimes his frame through many
an hour he spread

Upon a tombstone, moveless as the
dead;

And, was there found a sad and silent
place,

200

There would he creep with slow and
measured pace.

Then would he wander by the river's
side,

And fix his eyes upon the falling tide;
The deep dry ditch, the rushes in the
fen,

And mossy crag-pits were his
lodgings then:

There, to his discontented thoughts a
prey,

The melancholy mortal pined away.
The neighb'ring poor at length
began to speak
Of Abel's ramblings—he'd been gone
a week,
They knew not where; and little care
they took

210

For one so friendless and so poor to
look;
At last a stranger, in a pedler's shed,
Beheld him hanging—he had long
been dead.
He left a paper, penn'd at sundry
times,
Intitled thus—"My Groanings and my
Crimes!"

"I was a christian man, and none
could lay
Aught to my charge; I walk'd the
narrow way:
All then was simple faith, serene and
pure,
My hope was steadfast and my
prospects sure;
Then was I tried by }
want and }
sickness sore,

220

But these I clapp'd my shield of faith
before,
And cares and wants and
man's rebukes I bore.
Alas! new foes assail'd me; I was
vain,
They stung my pride and they
confused my brain:

Oh! these deluders! with what glee
they saw
Their simple dupe transgress the
righteous law;
'Twas joy to them to view that
dreadful strife,
When faith and frailty warr'd for
more than life;
So with their pleasures they beguiled
the heart,
Then with their logic they allay'd the
smart;

230

They proved (so thought I then) with
reasons strong,
That no man's feelings ever led him
wrong;
And thus I went, as on the varnish'd
ice,
The smooth career of unbelief and
vice.
Oft would the youths, with sprightly
speech and bold,
Their witty tales of naughty priests
unfold;
"Twas all a craft,' they said, 'a
cunning trade,
Not she the priests, but priests
religion made:'
So I believed;"—No, Abel! to thy
grief,
So thou relinquish'dst all that was
belief;—

240

"I grew as very flint, and when the
rest

Laugh'd at devotion, I enjoy'd the
 jest;
But this all vanish'd }
 like the }
 morning-dew,
When unemploy'd, and poor
 again I grew;
Yea! I was doubly poor, for I
 was wicked too.

 "The mouse that trespass'd and the
 treasure stole,
Found his lean body fitted to the hole;
Till, having fattened, he was forced to
 stay,
And, fasting, starve his stolen bulk
 away.
Ah! worse for me—grown poor, I yet
 remain

250

In sinful bonds, and pray and fast in
 vain.

 "At length I thought: although
 these friends of sin
Have spread their net and caught their
 prey therein;
Though my hard heart could not for
 mercy call,
Because, though great my grief, my
 faith was small;
Yet, as the sick on skilful men rely,
The soul diseased may to a doctor fly.

 "A famous one there was, whose
 skill had wrought
Cures past relief, and him the sinners
 sought;
Numbers there were denied by mire
 and filth,

260

Whom he recover'd by his goodly
tilth:—

'Come then,' I said, 'let me the man
behold,

And tell my case;'—I saw him and I
told.

"With trembling voice, 'Oh!
reverend sir,' I said,

'I once believed, and I was then
misled;

And now such doubts my sinful soul
beset,

I dare not say that I'm a Christian yet;
Canst thou, good sir, by thy superior
skill,

Inform my judgment and direct my
will?

Ah! give thy cordial; let my soul have
rest,

270

And be the outward man alone
distress'd;

For at my state I tremble.'—"Tremble
more,'

Said the good man, 'and then rejoice
therefore;

'Tis good to tremble; prospects then
are fair,

When the lost soul is plunged in deep
despair.

Once thou wert simply honest, just
and pure,

Whole, as thou thought'st, and never
wish'd a cure;

Now thou hast plunged in folly,
shame, disgrace;

Now thou'rt an object meet for
healing grace;

No merit thine, no }
virtue, hope, }
belief;

280

Nothing hast thou, but misery, sin,
and grief,

The best, the only titles to
relief.'

"What must I do,' I said, 'my soul
to free?'

'—Do nothing, man; it will be done
for thee.'

'But must I not, my reverend guide,
believe?'

'—If thou art call'd, thou wilt the faith
receive;—

'But I repent not.'—Angry he replied,
'If thou art call'd, thou needest nought
beside;

Attend on us, and if 'tis Heaven's
decree,

The call will come—if not, ah! wo
for thee.'

290

"There then I waited, ever on the
watch,

A spark of hope, a ray of light to
catch;

His words fell softly like the flakes of
snow,

But I could never find my heart
o'erflow.

He cried aloud, till in the flock began
The sigh, the tear, as caught from
man to man;

They wept and they rejoiced, and
there was I,
Hard as a flint, and as the desert dry.
To me no tokens of the call would
come,
I felt my sentence and received my
doom;

300
But I complain'd; }
—'Let thy
repinings cease,
Oh! man of sin, for they thy
guilt increase;
It bloweth where it listeth,—
die in peace.'
—'In peace, and perish?' I replied;
'impart
Some better comfort to a burthen'd
heart.'—
'Alas!' the priest return'd, 'can I direct
The heavenly call?—Do I proclaim
th' elect?
Raise not thy voice against th' Eternal
will,
But take thy part with sinners and be
still^[69].'

"Alas! for me, no more the times of
peace

310
Are mine on earth—in death my
pains may cease.

"Foes to my soul! ye young
seducers, know,
What serious ills from your
amusements flow;
Opinions you with so much ease
profess

O'erwhelm the simple and their minds
oppress:
Let such be happy, nor with reasons
strong,
That make them wretched, prove
their notions wrong;
Let them proceed in that they deem
the way,
Fast when they will, and at their
pleasure pray.
Yes, I have pity for my brethren's lot;
320
And so had Dives, but it help'd him
not.
And is it thus?—I'm full of doubts:—
Adieu!
Perhaps his reverence is mistaken
too."

NOTE TO LETTER XXI.

[69] Note 1, page 489, line 308.

*But take thy part with sinners and be
still.*

In a periodical work for the month of June last, the preceding dialogue is pronounced to be a most abominable caricature, if meant to be applied to Calvinists in general, and greatly distorted, if designed for an individual. Now, the author in his preface has declared, that he takes not upon him the censure of any sect or society for their opinions; and the lines themselves evidently point to an individual, whose sentiments they very fairly represent, without any distortion whatsoever. In a pamphlet entitled "A Cordial for a Sin-despairing Soul," originally written by a teacher of religion, and lately re-published by another teacher of greater notoriety, the reader is informed that after he had full assurance of his salvation, the Spirit entered particularly into the subject with him; and, among many other matters of like nature, assured him that "his sins were fully and freely forgiven, as if they had never been committed: not for any act done by him, whether believing in Christ, or repenting of sin; nor yet for the sorrows and miseries he endured, nor for any service he should be called upon in his militant state, but for his own name and for his glory's sake^[70]," &c. And the whole drift and tenour of the book is to the same purpose, viz. the uselessness of all religious duties, such as prayer, contrition, fasting, and good works: he shows

the evil done by reading such books as the Whole Duty of Man, and the Practice of Piety; and complains heavily of his relation, an Irish bishop, who wanted him to join with the household in family prayer: in fact, the whole work inculcates that sort of quietism which this dialogue alludes to, and that without any recommendation of attendance on the teachers of the Gospel, but rather holding forth encouragement to the supineness of man's nature; by the information that he in vain looks for acceptance by the employment of his talents, and that his hopes of glory are rather extinguished than raised by any application to the means of grace.

[70] Cordial, &c. page 87.

LETTER XXII.

THE POOR OF THE BOROUGH.

PETER GRIMES.

——Was a sordid soul,
Such as does murder for a meed;
Who but for fear knows no control,
Because his conscience, sear'd and foul,
Feels not the import of the deed;
One whose brute feeling ne'er aspires
Beyond his own more brute desires.

Scott,

*Mar
mio
n
[Ca
nto
II.].*

Methought the souls of all that I had
murder'd
Came to my tent, and every one did
threat——

Shakspeare

.
*Ric
har
d
III.
[Act
V.
Sc.
3,
vv.
204
-5].*

The times have been,
That, when the brains were out, the man
would die,
And there an end; but now they rise
again,
With twenty mortal murders on their
crowns,
And push us from our stools.

Macbeth

[Act
III.
Sc.
4.
vv.
78-
82].

Father of Peter a Fisherman—Peter's early Conduct—His Grief for the old Man—He takes an Apprentice—The Boy's Suffering and Fate—A second Boy: how he died—Peter acquitted—A third Apprentice—A Voyage by Sea: the Boy does not return—Evil Report on Peter: he is tried and threatened—Lives alone—His Melancholy and incipient Madness—Is observed and visited—He escapes and is taken: is lodged in a Parish-house: Women attend and watch him—He speaks in a

Delirium: grows more collected—His Account of his Feelings and visionary Terrors previous to his Death.

LETTER XXII.

PETER GRIMES.

Old Peter Grimes }
made fishing }
his employ;
His wife he cabin'd with him
and his boy,
And seem'd that life laborious
to enjoy.
To town came quiet Peter with his
fish,
And had of all a civil word and wish.
He left his trade upon the sabbath-
day,
And took young Peter in his hand to
pray;
But soon the stubborn boy from care
broke loose,
At first refused, then added his abuse;
10
His father's love he scorn'd, his power
defied,
But, being drunk, wept sorely when
he died.
Yes! then he wept, and to his mind
there came
Much of his conduct, and he felt the
shame:—
How he had oft the good old man
reviled,
And never paid the duty of a child;

How, when the father in his Bible
read,
He in contempt and anger left the
shed;
"It is the word of life," the parent
cried;
—"This is the life itself," the boy
replied;

20

And while old Peter in amazement
stood,
Gave the hot spirit to his boiling
blood;—
How he, with oath and furious
speech, began
To prove his freedom and assert the
man;
And when the parent check'd his
impious rage,
How he had cursed the tyranny of
age;—
Nay, once had dealt the sacrilegious
blow
On his bare head, and laid his parent
low;
The father groan'd—"If thou art old,"
said he,
"And hast a son—thou wilt remember
me;

30

Thy mother left me in a happy time,
Thou kill'dst not her—Heav'n spares
the double crime."
On an inn-settle, in his maudlin
grief,
This he revolved, and drank for his
relief.

Now lived the youth in freedom,
but debarr'd
From constant pleasure, and he
thought it hard;
Hard that he could not every wish
obey,
But must awhile relinquish ale and
play;
Hard! that he could not to his cards
attend,
But must acquire the money he would
spend.

40

With greedy eye he look'd on all he
saw;
He knew not justice, and he laugh'd at
law;
On all he mark'd he stretch'd his
ready hand;
He fish'd by water, and he filch'd by
land.
Oft in the night has Peter dropp'd his
oar,
Fled from his boat and sought for
prey on shore;
Oft up the hedge-row }
glided, on his }
back
Bearing the orchard's produce
in a sack,
Or farm-yard load, tugg'd
fiercely from the stack;
And as these wrongs to greater
numbers rose,

50

The more he look'd on all men as his
foes.

He built a mud-wall'd hovel, where
 he kept
His various wealth, and there he oft-
 times slept;
But no success could please his cruel
 soul,
He wish'd for one to trouble and
 control;
He wanted some obedient boy to
 stand
And bear the blow of his outrageous
 hand;
And hoped to find in some propitious
 hour
A feeling creature subject to his
 power.

Peter had heard there were in
 London then—

60

Still have they being!—workhouse-
 clearing men,
Who, undisturb'd by feelings just or
 kind,
Would parish-boys to needy
 tradesmen bind;
They in their want a trifling sum
 would take,
And toiling slaves of piteous orphans
 make.

Such Peter sought, and, when a lad
 was found,
The sum was dealt him, and the slave
 was bound.
Some few in town observed in Peter's
 trap
A boy, with jacket blue and woollen
 cap;

But none inquired how Peter used the
rope,

70

Or what the bruise, that made the
stripling stoop;

None could the ridges on his back
behold,

None sought him shiv'ring in the
winter's cold;

None put the question—"Peter, dost
thou give

The boy his food?—What, man! the
lad must live:

Consider, Peter, let the child have
bread,

He'll serve thee better if he's stroked
and fed."

None reason'd thus—and some, on
hearing cries,

Said calmly, "Grimes is at his
exercise."

Pinn'd, beaten, cold, pinch'd,
threaten'd, and abused—

80

His efforts punish'd and his food
refused—

Awake tormented—soon aroused
from sleep—

Struck if he wept, and yet compell'd
to weep:

The trembling boy dropp'd down and
strove to pray,

Received a blow, and trembling turn'd
away,

Or sobb'd and hid his piteous face;—
while he,

The savage master, grinn'd in horrid
glee:

He'd now the power he ever loved to
show,

A feeling being subject to his blow.

Thus lived the lad, in hunger, peril,
pain,

90

His tears despised, his supplications
vain.

Compell'd by fear to lie, by need to
steal,

His bed uneasy and unblest'd his
meal,

For three sad years the boy his
tortures bore;

And then his pains and trials were no
more.

"How died he, }
Peter?" }
when the
people said,

He growl'd—"I found him
lifeless in his bed;"

Then tried for softer tone, and
sigh'd, "Poor Sam is dead."

Yet murmurs were there, and some
questions ask'd—

How he was fed, how punish'd, and
how task'd?

100

Much they suspected, but they little
proved,

And Peter pass'd untroubled and
unmoved.

Another boy with equal ease was
found,

The money granted, and the victim
bound;
And what his fate?—One night, it
chanced he fell
From the boat's mast and perish'd in
her well,
Where fish were living kept, and
where the boy
(So reason'd men) could not himself
destroy.

0.5

(For he was idle both by night and
day,)

110

He climb'd the main-mast and then
fell below;"—

Then show'd his corpse and pointed
to the blow;—

"What said the jury?"—They were
long in doubt;

But sturdy Peter faced the matter out:
So they dismiss'd him, saying at the
time,

"Keep fast your hatchway, when
you've boys who climb."

This hit the conscience, and he
colour'd more

Than for the closest questions put
before.

Thus all his fears the verdict set
aside,

And at the slave-shop Peter still
applied.

120

Then came a boy, of manners soft
and mild—

Our seamen's wives with grief beheld
the child;
All thought (the poor themselves) that
he was one
Of gentle blood, some noble sinner's
son,
Who had, belike, deceived some
humble maid,
Whom he had first seduced and then
betray'd.—
However this, he seem'd a gracious
lad,
In grief submissive and with patience
sad.

Passive he labour'd, till his slender
frame
Bent with his loads, and he at length
was lame;—

130

Strange that a frame so weak could
bear so long
The grossest insult and the foulest
wrong;
But there were causes—in the town
they gave
Fire, food, and comfort, to the gentle
slave;
And though stern Peter, with a cruel
hand,
And knotted rope, enforced the rude
command,
Yet he consider'd what he'd lately felt,
And his vile blows with selfish pity
dealt.

One day such draughts the cruel
fisher made

He could not vend them in his
borough-trade,

140

But sail'd for London-mart; the boy
was ill,

But ever humbled to his master's will;
And on the river, where they
smoothly sail'd,

He strove with terror and awhile
prevail'd;

But, new to danger on the angry sea,
He clung affrighten'd to his master's
knee.

The boat grew leaky and the wind
was strong,

Rough was the passage and the time
was long;

His liquor fail'd, and Peter's wrath
arose—

No more is known—the rest we must
suppose,

150

Or learn of Peter;— }
Peter says, he
"spied

The stripling's danger and for
harbour tried;

Meantime the fish, and then
th' apprentice died."

The pitying women raised a
clamour round,

And weeping said, "Thou hast thy
'prentice drown'd."

Now the stern man was summon'd
to the hall,

To tell his tale before the burghers all.

He gave th' account; profess'd the lad
 he loved,
And kept his brazen features all
 unmoved.

The mayor himself with tone
 severe replied,—

160

"Henceforth with thee shall never boy
 abide;

Hire thee a freeman, whom thou durst
 not beat,

But who, in thy despite, will sleep
 and eat.

Free thou art now!—again shouldst
 thou appear,

Thou'lt find thy sentence, like thy
 soul, severe."

Alas! for Peter not a helping hand,
So was he hated, could he now
 command;

Alone he row'd his boat; alone he cast
His nets beside, or made his anchor
 fast;

To hold a rope or hear a curse was
 none—

170

He toil'd and rail'd; he groan'd and
 swore alone.

Thus by himself compell'd to live
 each day,

To wait for certain hours the tide's
 delay;

At the same times the same dull
 views to see,

The bounding marsh-bank and the
 blighted tree;

The water only when the tides were
high;
When low, the mud half-cover'd and
half-dry;
The sun-burnt tar that blisters on the
planks,
And bank-side stakes in their uneven
ranks;
Heaps of entangled weeds that slowly
float,

180

As the tide rolls by the impeded boat.
When tides were neap, and, in the
sultry day,
Through the tall bounding mud-banks
made their way,
Which on each side rose swelling,
and below
The dark warm flood ran silently and
slow:
There anchoring, Peter }
chose from }
man to hide,
There hang his head, and view
the lazy tide
In its hot slimy channel
slowly glide;
Where the small eels that left the
deeper way
For the warm shore, within the
shallows play;

190

Where gaping muscles, left upon the
mud,
Slope their slow passage to the fallen
flood:—

Here dull and hopeless he'd lie down
and trace

How sidelong crabs had scrawl'd their
crooked race;

Or sadly listen to the tuneless cry
Of fishing gull or clanging golden-
eye;

What time the sea- }
birds to the }
marsh would
come,

And the loud bittern, from the
bull-rush home,

Gave from the salt-ditch side
the bellowing boom.

He nursed the feelings these dull
scenes produce,

200

And loved to stop beside the opening
sluice;

Where the small stream, confined in
narrow bound,

Ran with a dull, unvaried, sadd'ning
sound;

Where all presented to the eye or ear
Oppress'd the soul with misery, grief,
and fear.

Besides these objects, there were
places three,

Which Peter seem'd with certain
dread to see;

When he drew near them he would
turn from each,

And loudly whistle till he pass'd the
reach^[71].

A change of scene to him brought
no relief;

210

In town, 'twas plain, men took him
for a thief:

The sailors' wives would stop him in
the street,

And say, "Now, Peter, thou'st no boy
to beat;"

Infants at play, when they perceived
him, ran,

Warning each other—"That's the
wicked man;"

He growl'd an oath, and in an angry
tone

Cursed the whole place and wish'd to
be alone.

Alone he was, the same dull scenes
in view,

And still more gloomy in his sight
they grew.

Though man he hated, yet employ'd
alone

220

At bootless labour, he would swear
and groan,

Cursing the shoals that glided by the
spot,

And gulls that caught them when his
arts could not.

Cold nervous tremblings shook his
sturdy frame,

And strange disease—he couldn't say
the name;

Wild were his dreams, and oft he rose
in fright,

Waked by his view of horrors in the
night—

Horrors that would the sternest minds
 amaze,
Horrors that demons might be proud
 to raise;
And, though he felt }
 forsaken, }
 grieved at
 heart,

230

To think he lived from all mankind
 apart;
Yet, if a man approach'd, in
 terrors he would start.

 A winter pass'd since Peter saw the
 town,
And summer-lodgers were again
 come down;
These, idly curious, with their glasses
 spied
The ships in bay as anchored for the
 tide—
The river's craft—the bustle of the
 quay—
And sea-port views, which landmen
 love to see.

 One, up the river, had a man and
 boat
Seen day by day, now anchor'd, now
 afloat;

240

Fisher he seem'd, yet }
 used no net nor
 hook;
Of sea-fowl swimming by no
 heed he took,
But on the gliding waves still
 fix'd his lazy look;

At certain stations he would view the
stream,
As if he stood bewilder'd in a dream,
Or that some power had chain'd him
for a time,
To feel a curse or meditate on crime.
This known, some curious, some in
pity went,
And others question'd—"Wretch, dost
thou repent?"
He heard, he trembled, and in fear
resign'd

250

His boat; new terror fill'd his restless
mind;
Furious he grew, and up the country
ran,
And there they seized him—a
distemper'd man.—
Him we received; and to a parish-bed,
Follow'd and cursed, the groaning
man was led.

Here when they saw him, whom
they used to shun,
A lost, lone man, so harass'd and
undone,
Our gentle females, ever prompt to
feel,
Perceived compassion on their anger
steal;
His crimes they could not from their
memories blot;

260

But they were grieved, and trembled
at his lot.
A priest too came, to whom his
words are told;

And all the signs they shudder'd to
behold.

"Look! look!" they }
cried; "his }
limbs with
horror shake,
And as he grinds his teeth,
what noise they make!
How glare his angry eyes, and
yet he's not awake.
See! what cold drops upon his
forehead stand,
And how he clenches that broad bony
hand."

The priest, attending, found he
spoke at times
As one alluding to his fears and
crimes:

270

"It was the fall," he mutter'd, "I can
show
The manner how—I never struck a
blow;"—
And then aloud—"Unhand me, free
my chain;
On oath, he fell—it struck him to the
brain;—
Why ask my father?—that old man
will swear
Against my life; besides, he wasn't
there;—
What, all agreed?—Am I to die to-
day?—
My Lord, in mercy, give me time to
pray."

Then, as they watch'd him, calmer
he became,

And grew so weak he couldn't move
his frame,

280

But murmuring spake—while they
could see and hear

The start of terror and the groan of
fear;

See the large dew-beads on his
forehead rise,

And the cold death-drop glaze his
sunken eyes;

Nor yet he died, but with unwonted
force

Seem'd with some fancied being to
discourse.

He knew not us, or with accustom'd
art

He hid the knowledge, yet exposed
his heart;

'Twas part confession and the rest
defence,

A madman's tale, with gleams of
waking sense.

290

"I'll tell you all," he said; "the very
day

When the old man first placed them
in my way:

My father's spirit—he who always
tried

To give me trouble, when he lived
and died—

When he was gone, he could not be
content

To see my days in painful labour
spent,

But would appoint his meetings, and
he made
Me watch at these, and so neglect my
trade.

"'Twas one hot noon, all silent,
still, serene;
No living being had I lately seen;
300

I paddled up and down and dipp'd my
net,
But (such his pleasure) I could
nothing get—

A father's pleasure, when his toil was
done,
To plague and torture thus an only
son!

And so I sat and look'd upon the
stream,
How it ran on, and felt as in a
dream—

But dream it was not; no!—I fix'd my
eyes
On the mid stream and saw the spirits
rise;

I saw my father on the water stand,
And held a thin pale boy in either
hand;

310
And there they glided ghastly on the
top
Of the salt flood, and never touch'd a
drop.

I would have struck them, but they
knew th' intent,
And smiled upon the oar, and down
they went.

"Now, from that day, whenever I
began
To dip my net, there stood the hard
old man—
He and those boys; I humbled me and
pray'd
They would be gone;—they heeded
not, but stay'd.
Nor could I turn, nor }
would the boat }
go by,
But gazing on the spirits,
there was I;

320

They bade me leap to death, but I was
loth to die.
And every day, as sure as day arose,
Would these three spirits meet me ere
the close;
To hear and mark them daily was my
doom,
And 'Come,' they said, with weak,
sad voices, 'come.'
To row away with all }
my strength I }
try'd;
But there were they, hard by
me in the tide,
The three unbodied forms—
and 'Come,' still 'come,' they
cried.

"Fathers should pity—but this old
man shook
His hoary locks, and froze me by a
look.

330

Thrice, when I struck them, through
the water came
A hollow groan that weakened all my
frame;
'Father!' said I, 'have mercy!'—He
replied,
I know not what—the angry spirit
lied,—
'Didst thou not draw thy knife?' said
he;—'Twas true,
But I had pity and my arm withdrew;
He cried for mercy which I kindly
gave,
But he has no compassion in his
grave.

"There were three places, where
they ever rose;—
The whole long river has not such as
those—

340

Places accursed, where, if a man
remain,
He'll see the things which strike him
to the brain;
And there they made me on my
paddle lean,
And look at them for hours—
accursed scene!
When they would glide to that
smooth eddy-space,
Then bid me leap and join them in the
place;
And at my groans each little villain
sprite
Enjoy'd my pains and vanish'd in
delight.

"In one fierce summer-day, when
my poor brain
Was burning hot and cruel was my
pain,

350

Then came this father-foe; and there
he stood
With his two boys again upon the
flood;
There was more mischief in their
eyes, more glee
In their pale faces when they glared at
me.

Still did they force me on the oar to
rest,
And when they saw me fainting and
oppress'd,
He, with his hand, the old man,
scoop'd the flood,
And there came flame about him,
mix'd with blood;
He bade me stoop and look upon the
place,
Then flung the hot-red liquor in my
face;

360

Burning it blazed, and then I roar'd
for pain,
I thought the demons would have
turn'd my brain.

"Still there they stood, and forced
me to behold
A place of horrors—they cannot be
told—
Where the flood open'd, there I heard
the shriek

Of tortured guilt no earthly tongue
can speak:

'All days alike! for ever!' did they say,
'And unremitted torments every
day!'—

Yes, so they said;"—but here he
ceased and gazed

On all around, affrighten'd and
amazed;

370

And still he tried to speak, and look'd
in dread

Of frighten'd females gathering round
his bed;

Then dropp'd exhausted and appear'd
at rest,

Till the strong foe the vital powers
possess'd;

Then with an inward, broken voice he
cried,

"Again they come," and mutter'd as
he died.

FOOTNOTES:

[71] The reaches in a river are those parts which extend from point to point. Johnson has not the word precisely in this sense; but it is very common, and I believe used wheresoever a navigable river can be found in this country.

LETTER XXIII.

PRISONS.

Pœna autem vehemens ac multò sævior
 illis,
Quas et Cæditius gravis invenit aut
 Rhadamanthus,
Nocte dieque suum gestare in pectore
 testem.

Juvenal.

Sat.

13.

ll.

197

-9.

Think [our] former state a happy
 dream,
From which awaked, the truth of what we
 are
Shows us but this,—I am sworn brother
 now
To grim Necessity, and he and I
Will keep a league till death.

Richard II.

[Act

V.

Sc.
1,
ll.
18-
22].

Mind of Man accommodates itself to all Situations; Prisons otherwise would be intolerable—Debtors; their different Kinds: three particularly described; others more briefly—An arrested Prisoner: his Account of his Feelings and his Situation—The Alleviations of a Prison—Prisoners for Crimes—Two condemned: a vindictive Female: a Highwayman—The Interval between Condemnation and Execution—His Feelings as the Time approaches—His Dream.

LETTER XXIII.

PRISONS.

'Tis well that man to all the varying
states
Of good and ill his mind
accommodates;
He not alone progressive grief
sustains,
But soon submits to unexperienced
pains.
Change after change, all climes his
body bears,
His mind repeated shocks of
changing cares;
Faith and fair virtue arm the nobler
breast;
Hope and mere want of feeling aid
the rest.
Or who could bear to lose the
balmy air
10
Of summer's breath, from all things
fresh and fair,

With all that man }
 admires or }
 loves below;
All earth and water, wood and
 vale bestow,
Where rosy pleasures smile,
 whence real blessings flow;
With sight and sound of every kind
 that lives,
And crowning all with joy that
 freedom gives?
Who could from these, in some
 unhappy day,
Bear to be drawn by ruthless arms
 away
To the vile nuisance of a noisome
 room,
Where only insolence and misery
 come?

20

(Save that the curious will by chance
 appear,
Or some in pity drop a fruitless tear,)
To a damp prison, where the very
 sight
Of the warm sun is favour and not
 right;
Where all we hear or see the feelings
 shock,
The oath and groan, the fetter and the
 lock?
Who could bear this and live?—
 Oh! many a year
All this is borne, and miseries more
 severe;
And some there are, familiar with the
 scene,

Who live in mirth, though few
become serene.

30

Far as I might the inward man
perceive,
There was a constant effort—not to
grieve;
Not to despair, for better days would
come,
And the freed debtor smile again at
home;
Subdued his habits, he may peace
regain,
And bless the woes that were not sent
in vain.

Thus might we class the debtors
here confined,
The more deceived, the more
deceitful kind;
Here are the guilty race, who mean to
live
On credit, that credulity will give;

40

Who purchase, conscious they can
never pay;
Who know their fate, and traffic to
betray;
On whom no pity, fear, remorse,
prevail,
Their aim a statute, their resource a
jail;—
These as the public spoilers we
regard;
No dun so harsh, no creditor so hard.
A second kind are they, who truly
strive

To keep their sinking credit long
 alive;
Success, nay prudence, they may
 want, but yet
They would be solvent, and deplore a
 debt;

50

All means they use, to all expedients
 run,
And are by slow, sad steps, at last
 undone.
Justly, perhaps, you blame their want
 of skill,
But mourn their feelings and absolve
 their will.

 There is a debtor, who his trifling
 all
Spreads in a shop; it would not fill a
 stall:
There at one window his temptation
 lays,
And in new modes disposes and
 displays.
Above the door you shall his name
 behold,
And what he vends in ample letters
 told,

60

The words *repository*, *warehouse*, all
He uses to enlarge concerns so small.
He to his goods assigns some beauty's
 name,
Then in her reign, and hopes they'll
 share her fame;
And talks of credit, commerce,
 traffic, trade,

As one important by their profit
made;
But who can paint the vacancy, the
gloom,
And spare dimensions of one
backward room?
Wherein he dines, if so 'tis fit to
speak,
Of one day's herring and the
morrow's steak;

70

An anchorite in diet, all his care
Is to display his stock and vend his
ware.

Long waiting hopeless, then he
tries to meet
A kinder fortune in a distant street;
There he again displays, increasing
yet
Corroding sorrow and consuming
debt:
Alas! he wants the requisites to rise—
The true connexions, the availing
ties;
They who proceed on certainties
advance;
These are not times when men prevail
by chance.

80

But still he tries, till, after years of
pain,
He finds, with anguish, he has tried in
vain.
Debtors are these on whom 'tis hard
to press,
'Tis base, impolitic, and merciless.

To these we add a miscellaneous
kind,
By pleasure, pride, and indolence
confined;
Those whom no calls, no warnings
could divert,
The unexperienced and the inexperienced;
The builder, idler, schemer, gamester,
sot—
The follies different, but the same
their lot;

90

Victims of horses, lasses, drinking,
dice,
Of every passion, humour, whim, and
vice.

See that sad merchant, who but
yesterday
Had a vast household in command
and pay;
He now entreats permission to
employ
A boy he needs, and then entreats the
boy.

And there sits one, improvident but
kind,
Bound for a friend, whom honour
could not bind;
Sighing, he speaks to any who
appear,
"A treach'rous friend—'twas that
which sent me here:

100

I was too kind—I thought I could
depend
On his bare word—he was a
treach'rous friend."

A female too!—it is to her a home;
She came before—and she again will
come.

Her friends have pity; when their
anger drops,

They take her home;—she's tried her
schools and shops—

Plan after plan;—but }
fortune would }
not mend,

She to herself was still the
treach'rous friend;

And wheresoe'er began, all
here was sure to end.

And there she sits as }
thoughtless and }
as gay,

110

As if she'd means, or not a debt to
pay—

Or knew to-morrow she'd be
call'd away—

Or felt a shilling and could
dine to-day.

While thus observing, I began to
trace

The sober'd features of a well-known
face—

Looks once familiar, manners form'd
to please,

And all illumined by a heart at ease.

But fraud and flattery ever claim'd a
part

(Still unresisted) of that easy heart;

But he at length beholds me—"Ah!
my friend!

120

And have thy pleasures this unlucky
end?"

"Too sure," he said, and, smiling as
he sigh'd:

"I went astray, though prudence
seem'd my guide;

All she proposed I in my heart
approved,

And she was honour'd, but my
pleasure loved—

Pleasure, the mistress to whose arms I
fled,

From wife-like lectures angry
prudence read.

"Why speak the madness of a life
like mine,

The powers of beauty, novelty, and
wine?

Why paint the wanton smile, the
venal vow,

130

Or friends whose worth I can
appreciate now?

"Oft I perceived my fate, and then
would say,

'I'll think to-morrow, I must live to-
day:'

So am I here—I own the laws are
just—

And here, where thought is painful,
think I must.

But speech is pleasant; this discourse
with thee

Brings to my mind the sweets of
liberty;

Breaks on the sameness of the place,
and gives

The doubtful heart conviction that it
lives,

"Let me describe my anguish in the
hour

140

When law detained me and I felt its
power.

"When in that shipwreck, this I
found my shore,
And join'd the wretched, who were
wreck'd before;

When I perceived each feature in the
face

Pinch'd through neglect or turbid by
disgrace;

When in these wasting forms
affliction stood

In my afflicted view, it chill'd my
blood;—

And forth I rush'd, a quick retreat to
make,

Till a loud laugh proclaim'd the dire
mistake.

But when the groan had settled to a
sigh;

150

When gloom became familiar to the
eye;

When I perceive how others seem to
rest,

With every evil rankling in my
breast—

Led by example, I put on the man,
Sing off my sighs, and trifle as I can.

"Homer! nay, Pope! (for never will
I seek

Applause for learning—nought have I
with Greek—)

Gives us the secrets of his pagan hell,
Where ghost with ghost in sad
communion dwell;
Where shade meets shade, and round
the gloomy meads

160

They glide and speak of old heroic
deeds—

What fields they conquer'd, and what
foes they slew

And sent to join the melancholy crew.

"When a new spirit in that world
was found,

A thousand shadowy forms came
flitting round;

Those who had known him, fond
inquiries made:—

'Of all we left, inform us, gentle
shade,

Now as we lead thee in our realms to
dwell,

Our twilight groves, and meads of
asphodel.'

"What paints the poet, is our
station here,

170

Where we like ghosts and flitting
shades appear:

This is the hell he sings, and here we
meet,

And former deeds to new-made
friends repeat;

Heroic deeds, which here obtain us
fame,

And are in fact the causes why we
came.

Yes! this dim region is old Homer's
hell,

Abate but groves and meads of
asphodel.

"Here, when a stranger from your
world we spy,

We gather round him and for news
apply;

He hears unheeding, nor can speech
endure,

180

But shivering gazes on the vast
obscure.

We, smiling, pity, and by kindness
show

We felt his feelings and his terrors
know;

Then speak of comfort—time will
give him sight,

Where now 'tis dark; where now 'tis
wo, delight.

"'Have hope,' we say, 'and soon the
place to thee

Shall not a prison but a castle be;

When to the wretch whom care and
guilt confound,

The world's a prison, with a wider
bound;

Go where he may, he feels himself
confined,

190

And wears the fetters of an abject
mind.'

"But now adieu! those giant keys
appear,

Thou art not worthy to be inmate
here;
Go to thy world, and to the young
declare
What we, our spirits and
employments, are;
Tell them how we the ills of life
endure,
Our empire stable, and our state
secure;
Our dress, our diet, for their use
describe,
And bid them haste to join the
gen'rous tribe:
Go to thy world, and leave us here to
dwell,

200

Who to its joys and comforts bid
farewell."

Farewell to these; but other scenes
I view,
And other griefs, and guilt of deeper
hue;
Where conscience gives to outward
ills her pain,
Gloom to the night, and pressure to
the chain.
Here separate cells awhile in misery
keep
Two doom'd to suffer; there they
strive for sleep;
By day indulged, in larger space they
range,
Their bondage certain, but their
bounds have change.

One was a female, who had
grievous ill

210

Wrought in revenge, and she enjoy'd
it still.

With death before her, and her fate in
view,

Unsated vengeance in her bosom
grew;

Sullen she was and threat'ning; in her
eye

Glared the stern triumph that she
dared to die;

But first a being in the world must
leave—

'Twas once reproach; 'twas now a
short reprieve.

She was a pauper bound, who early
gave

Her mind to vice, and doubly was a
slave;

Upbraided, beaten, held by rough
control,

220

Revenge sustain'd, inspired, and fill'd
her soul.

She fired a full-stored barn, confess'd
the fact,

And laugh'd at law and justified the
act.

Our gentle vicar tried his powers in
vain,

She answer'd not, or answer'd with
disdain;

Th' approaching fate she heard
without a sigh,

And neither cared to live nor fear'd to
die.

Not so he felt, who with her was to
pay
The forfeit, life—with dread he
view'd the day,
And that short space which yet for
him remain'd,

230

Till with his limbs his faculties were
chain'd.

He paced his narrow bounds some
ease to find,

But found it not,—no comfort
reached his mind.

Each sense was palsied; when he
tasted food,

He sigh'd and said, "Enough—'tis
very good."

Since his dread sentence, nothing
seem'd to be

As once it was—he seeing could not
see,

Nor hearing, hear aright;—when first,
I came

Within his view, I fancied there was
shame,

I judged, resentment; I mistook the
air—

240

These fainter passions live not with
despair,

Or but exist and die;—Hope, fear,
and love,

Joy, doubt, and hate, may other spirits
move,

But touch not his, who every waking
hour

Has one fix'd dread, and always feels
its power.

"But will not mercy?"—No! she
cannot plead
For such an outrage;—'twas a cruel
deed:

He stopp'd a timid traveller;—to his
breast,
With oaths and curses, was the danger
press'd:—

No! he must suffer; pity we may find
250

For one man's pangs, but must not
wrong mankind.

Still I behold him, every thought
employ'd
On one dire view!—all others are
destroy'd;

This makes his features ghastly, gives
the tone

Of his few words resemblance to a
groan.

He takes his tasteless food, and, when
'tis done,

Counts up his meals, now lessen'd by
that one;

For expectation is on time intent,
Whether he brings us joy or
punishment.

Yes! e'en in sleep the impressions
all remain;

260

He hears the sentence and he feels the
chain;

He sees the judge and jury, when he
shakes,

And loudly cries, "Not guilty," and
awakes.

Then chilling tremblings o'er his body
creep,

Till worn-out nature is compell'd to
sleep.

Now comes the dream again; it
shows each scene,

With each small circumstance that
comes between—

The call to suffering and the very
deed—

There crowds go with him, follow,
and precede;

Some heartless shout, some pity, all
condemn,

270

While he in fancied envy looks at
them.

He seems the place for that sad act to
see,

And dreams the very thirst which
then will be;

A priest attends—it seems, the one he
knew

In his best days, beneath whose care
he grew.

At this his terrors take a sudden
flight,

He sees his native village with
delight;

The house, the chamber, where he
once array'd

His youthful person; where he knelt
and pray'd.

Then too the comforts he enjoy'd at
home,

280

The days of joy; the joys themselves
are come—

The hours of innocence—the timid
look

Of his loved maid, when first her
hand he took

And told his hope; her trembling joy
appears,

Her forced reserve and his retreating
fears.

All now is present;—'tis a
moment's gleam

Of former sunshine—stay, delightful
dream!

Let him within his pleasant garden
walk,

Give him her arm, of blessings let
them talk.

Yes! all are with him now, and all
the while

290

Life's early prospects and his Fanny's
smile:

Then come his sister and his village-
friend,

And he will now the sweetest
moments spend

Life has to yield;—no! never will he
find

Again on earth such pleasure in his
mind:

He goes through shrubby walks these
friends among,

Love in their looks and honour on the
tongue;

Nay, there's a charm beyond what
nature shows,
The bloom is softer and more sweetly
grows;—
Pierced by no crime, and urged by no
desire

300

For more than true and honest hearts
require,
They feel the calm delight, and thus
proceed
Through the green lane—then linger
in the mead—
Stray o'er the heath in all its purple
bloom—
And pluck the blossom where the
wild bees hum;
Then through the broomy bound with
ease they pass,
And press the sandy sheep-walk's
slender grass,
Where dwarfish flowers among the
gorse are spread,
And the lamb browses by the linnet's
bed;
Then 'cross the bounding brook they
make their way

310

O'er its rough bridge—and there
behold the bay!—
The ocean smiling to the fervid sun—
The waves that faintly fall and slowly
run—
The ships at distance and the boats at
hand;
And now they walk upon the sea-side
sand,

Counting the number and what kind
they be,
Ships softly sinking in the sleepy sea;
Now arm in arm, now parted, they
behold
The glitt'ring waters on the shingles
roll'd;
The timid girls, half dreading their
design,

320

Dip the small foot in the retarded
brine,
And search for crimson weeds, which
spreading flow,
Or lie like pictures on the sand below;
With all those bright red pebbles that
the sun
Through the small waves so softly
shines upon;
And those live lucid jellies which the
eye
Delights to trace as they swim
glitt'ring by:
Pearl-shells and rubied star-fish they
admire,
And will arrange above the parlour-
fire,—
Tokens of bliss!—"Oh! horrible! a
wave

330

Roars as it rises—save me, Edward!
save!"
She cries—Alas! the watchman on
his way
Calls and lets in—truth, terror, and
the day!

LETTER XXIV.

SCHOOLS.

Tu quoque ne metuas, quamvis schola
verbere multo
Increpet et truculenta senex geret ora
magister;
Degeneres animos timor arguit; at tibi
consta
Intrepidus, nec te clamor, plagæque
sonantes,
Nec matutinis agitet formido sub horis,
Quod sceptrum vibrat ferulæ, quod multa
supellex
Virgea, quod molis scuticam prætexit
aluta,
Quod fervent trepido subsellia vestra
tumultu;
Pompa loci, et vani fugiatur scena
timoris.

*Ausonius in
Prot
rept
ico
ad
Nep
ote
m
[vv.
24-
33].*

Be it a weakness, it deserves some
praise,—

We love the play-place of our early days;
 The scene is touching, and the heart is
 stone
 That feels not at that sight—and feels at
 none.
 The wall on which we tried our graving
 skill;
 The very name we carved subsisting still;
 The bench on which we sat while deep
 employ'd,
 Though mangled, hack'd, and hew'd, yet
 not destroy'd.
 The little ones unbutton'd, glowing hot,
 Playing our games, and on the very spot;
 As happy as we once to kneel and draw
 The chalky ring and knuckle down at taw.

.
 .

This fond attachment to the well-known
 place,
 When first we started into life's long race,
 Maintains its hold with such unfailing
 sway,
 We feel it e'en in age, and at our latest
 day.

Cowper

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 ocin
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 296
 -31
 7].

ools of every Kind to be found in the Borough—The School for Infants—The School Preparatory: the
 Sagacity of the Mistress in foreseeing Character—Day-Schools of the lower Kind—A Master with
 Talents adapted to such Pupils; one of superior Qualifications—Boarding-Schools: that for young

Ladies: one going first to the Governess, one finally returning Home—School for Youth; Master and Teacher; various Dispositions and Capacities—The Miser-Boy—The Boy-Bully—Sons of Farmers: how amused—What Study will effect, examined—A College Life: one sent from his College to a Benefice; one retained there in Dignity—The Advantages in either Case not considerable—Where then the Good of a literary Life?—Answered—Conclusion.

LETTER XXIV.

SCHOOLS.

To every class we have a school
assign'd,
Rules for all ranks and food for every
mind;
Yet one there is, that small regard to
rule
Or study pays, and still is deem'd a
school:
That, where a deaf, poor, patient
widow sits,
And awes some thirty infants as she
knits;
Infants of humble, busy wives, who
pay
Some trifling price for freedom
through the day.
At this good matron's hut the children
meet,
10
Who thus becomes the mother of the
street.
Her room is small, they cannot
widely stray—
Her threshold high, they cannot run
away;
Though deaf, she sees the rebel-
heroes shout;—

Though lame, her white rod nimbly
walks about;
With band of yarn she keeps
offenders in,
And to her gown the sturdiest rogue
can pin.
Aided by these, and spells, and tell-
tale birds,
Her power they dread and reverence
her words.

To learning's second seats we now
proceed,

20

Where humming students gilded
primers read;
Or books with letters large and
pictures gay,
To make their reading but a kind of
play—
"Reading made Easy," so the titles
tell;
But they who read must first begin to
spell.

There may be profit in these arts, but
still

Learning is labour, call it what you
will—

Upon the youthful mind a heavy load;
Nor must we hope to find the royal
road.

Some will their easy steps to science
show,

30

And some to heav'n itself their by-
way know;
Ah! trust them not;—who fame or
bliss would share,

Must learn by labour, and must live
by care.

Another matron of superior kind
For higher schools prepares the rising
mind;
Preparatory she her learning calls,
The step first made to colleges and
halls.

She early sees to what the mind
will grow,
Nor abler judge of infant-powers I
know;
She sees what soon the lively will
impede,

40

And how the steadier will in turn
succeed;
Observes the dawn of wisdom, fancy,
taste,
And knows what parts will wear and
what will waste:
She marks the mind too lively, and at
once
Sees the gay coxcomb and the rattling
dunce.

Long has she lived, and much she
loves to trace
Her former pupils, now a lordly race;
Whom when she sees rich robes and
furs bedeck,
She marks the pride which once she
strove to check.

A burgess comes, and she remembers
well

50

How hard her task to make his
worship spell;

Cold, selfish, dull, inanimate, unkind,
'Twas but by anger he display'd a
mind;
Now civil, smiling, complaisant, and
gay,
The world has worn th' unsocial crust
away;
That sullen spirit now a softness
wears,
And, save by fits, e'en dulness
disappears:
But still the matron can the man
behold,
Dull, selfish, hard, inanimate, and
cold.
A merchant passes;—"probity and
truth,

60

Prudence and patience, mark'd thee
from thy youth."
Thus she observes, but oft retains her
fears
For him, who now with name
unstain'd appears;
Nor hope relinquishes for one who
yet
Is lost in error and involved in debt;
For latent evil in that heart she found,
More open here, but here the core
was sound.

Various our day-schools: here
behold we one
Empty and still;—the morning duties
done,
Soil'd, tatter'd, worn, and thrown in
various heaps,

70

Appear their books, and there
 confusion sleeps;
The workmen all are from the Babel
 fled,
And lost their tools, till the return
 they dread.
Meantime the master, with his wig
 awry,
Prepares his books for business by-
 and-by.
Now all th' insignia of the monarch
 laid
Beside him rest, and none stand by
 afraid;
He, while his troop light-hearted leap
 and play,
Is all intent on duties of the day;
No more the tyrant stern or judge
 severe,

80

He feels the father's and the husband's
 fear.
 Ah! little think the timid trembling
 crowd,
That one so wise, so powerful, and so
 proud,
Should feel himself, and dread the
 humble ills
Of rent-day charges and of coalman's
 bills;
That, while they mercy from their
 judge implore,
He fears himself—a knocking at the
 door;
And feels the burthen as his
 neighbour states

His humble portion to the parish-
rates.

They sit th' allotted hours, then
eager run,

90

Rushing to pleasure when the duty's
done;

His hour of leisure is of different
kind,

Then cares domestic rush upon his
mind;

And half the ease and comfort he
enjoys,

Is when surrounded by slates, books,
and boys.

Poor Reuben Dixon has the
noisiest school

Of ragged lads, who ever bow'd to
rule;

Low in his price—the men who
heave our coals,

And clean our causeways, send him
boys in shoals.

To see poor Reuben, with his fry
beside—

100

Their half-check'd rudeness and his
half-scorn'd pride—

Their room, the sty in which th'
assembly meet,

In the close lane behind the
Northgate-street;

T' observe his vain attempts to keep
the peace,

Till tolls the bell, and strife and
troubles cease,

Calls for our praise; his labour praise
deserves,

But not our pity; Reuben has no
nerves.

'Mid noise and dirt, and stench, and
play, and prate,

He calmly cuts the pen or views the
slate.

But Leonard!—yes, for Leonard's
fate I grieve,

110

Who loathes the station which he
dares not leave;

He cannot dig, he will not beg his
bread;

All his dependence rests upon his
head;

And, deeply skill'd in sciences and
arts,

On vulgar lads he wastes superior
parts.

Alas! what grief that feeling mind
sustains,

In guiding hands and stirring torpid
brains;

He whose proud mind from pole to
pole will move,

And view the wonders of the worlds
above;

Who thinks and reasons strongly—
hard his fate,

120

Confined for ever to the pen and
slate.

True, he submits, and when the long
dull day

Has slowly pass'd, in weary tasks,
away,
To other worlds with cheerful view he
looks,
And parts the night between repose
and books.

Amid his labours, he has
sometimes tried
To turn a little from his cares aside;
Pope, Milton, Dryden, with delight
has seized,
His soul engaged and of his trouble
eased.

When, with a heavy eye and ill-done
sum,

130

No part conceived, a stupid boy will
come;

Then Leonard first subdues the rising
frown,

And bids the blockhead lay his
blunders down;

O'er which disgusted }
he will turn his }
eye,

To his sad duty his sound
mind apply,

And, vex'd in spirit, throw his
pleasures by.

Turn we to schools which more
than these afford—

The sound instruction and the
wholesome board;

And first our school for ladies:—pity
calls

For one soft sigh, when we behold
these walls,

140

Placed near the town, and where,
from window high,
The fair, confined, may our free
crowds espy,
With many a stranger gazing up and
down,
And all the envied tumult of the
town;
May, in the smiling summer-eve,
when they
Are sent to sleep the pleasant hours
away,
Behold the poor (whom they
conceive the bless'd)
Employ'd for hours, and grieved they
cannot rest.

Here the fond girl, whose days are
sad and few
Since dear mamma pronounced the
last adieu,

150

Looks to the road, and fondly thinks
she hears
The carriage-wheels, and struggles
with her tears.
All yet is new, the misses great and
small,
Madam herself, and teachers, odious
all;
From laughter, pity, nay command,
she turns,
But melts in softness, or with anger
burns;
Nauseates her food, and wonders who
can sleep

On such mean beds, where she can
only weep.

She scorns condolence—but to all she
hates

Slowly at length her mind
accommodates;

160

Then looks on bondage with the same
concern

As others felt, and finds that she must
learn

As others learn'd—the common lot to
share,

To search for comfort and submit to
care.

There are, 'tis said, who on these
seats attend,

And to these ductile minds
destruction vend;

Wretches (to virtue, peace, and
nature, foes)

To these soft minds, their wicked
trash expose;

Seize on the soul, ere passions take
the sway,

And lead the heart, ere yet it feels,
astray:

170

Smugglers obscene!—and can there
be who take

Infernal pains, the sleeping vice to
wake?

Can there be those, by whom the
thought defiled

Enters the spotless bosom of a child?

By whom the ill is to }
the heart }

convey'd,
Who lend the foe, not yet in
arms, their aid,
And sap the city-walls before
the siege be laid?
Oh! rather skulking in the by-ways
steal,
And rob the poorest traveller of his
meal;
Burst through the humblest trader's
bolted door;

180

Bear from the widow's hut her winter-
store;
With stolen steed on highways take
your stand,
Your lips with curses arm'd, with
death your hand;—
Take all but life—the }
virtuous more }
would say,
Take life itself, dear as it is,
away,
Rather than guilty thus the
guileless soul betray.

Years, pass away—let us suppose
them past,
Th' accomplish'd nymph for freedom
looks at last;
All hardships over, which a school
contains,
The spirit's bondage and the body's
pains;

190

Where teachers make the heartless,
trembling set
Of pupils suffer for their own regret;

Where winter's cold, attack'd by one
 poor fire,
Chills the fair child, commanded to
 retire;
She felt it keenly in the morning air,
Keenly she felt it at the evening
 prayer.
More pleasant summer; but then
 walks were made
Not a sweet ramble, but a slow
 parade;
They moved by pairs beside the
 hawthorn-hedge,
Only to set their feelings on an edge;
200
And now at eve, when all their spirits
 rise,
Are sent to rest, and all their pleasure
 dies;
Where yet they all the town alert can
 see,
And distant plough-boys pacing o'er
 the lea.

 These and the tasks successive
 masters brought—
The French they conn'd, the curious
 works they wrought,
The hours they made their taper
 fingers strike,
Note after note, all dull to them alike;
Their drawings, dancings on
 appointed days,
Playing with globes, and getting parts
 of plays;

210

The tender friendships made 'twixt
 heart and heart,

When the dear friends had nothing to
impart:—

All! all! are over;—now th'
accomplished maid
Longs for the world, of nothing there
afraid.

Dreams of delight invade her gentle
breast,
And fancied lovers rob the heart of
rest;

At the paternal door a carriage stands,
Love knits their hearts, and Hymen
joins their hands.

Ah!—world unknown! how
charming is thy view,
Thy pleasures many, and each
pleasure new!

220

Ah!—world experienced! what of
thee is told?

How few thy pleasures, and those few
how old!

Within a silent street, and far apart
From noise of business, from a quay
or mart,
Stands an old spacious building, and
the din

You hear without, explains the work
within;

Unlike the whispering of the nymphs,
this noise

Loudly proclaims a "boarding-school
for boys."

The master heeds it not, for thirty
years

Have render'd all familiar to his ears;

230

He sits in comfort, 'mid the various
 sound
Of mingled tones for ever flowing
 round;
Day after day he to his task attends—
Unvaried toil, and care that never
 ends.
Boys in their works proceed; while
 his employ
Admits no change, or changes but the
 boy;
Yet time has made it easy;—he beside
Has power supreme, and power is
 sweet to pride.
But grant him pleasure;—what can
 teachers feel,
Dependent helpers always at the
 wheel?

240

Their power despised, their
 compensation small,
Their labour dull, their life laborious
 all;
Set after set, the lower lads to make
Fit for the class which their superiors
 take;
The road of learning for a time to
 track
In roughest state, and then again go
 back;
Just the same way on other troops to
 wait—
Attendants fix'd at learning's lower
 gate.
The day-tasks now are over;—to
 their ground

Rush the gay crowd with joy-
compelling sound;

250

Glad to [elude] the burthens of the
day,

The eager parties hurry to their play.
Then in these hours of liberty we find
The native bias of the opening mind;
They yet possess not skill the mask to
place,

And hide the passions glowing in the
face;

Yet some are found—the close, the
sly, the mean,

Who know already all must not be
seen.

Lo! one who walks apart, although
so young,

He lays restraint upon his eye and
tongue;

260

Nor will he into scrapes or dangers
get,

And half the school are in the
stripling's debt.

Suspicious, timid, he is much afraid
Of trick and plot—he dreads to be
betray'd;

He shuns all friendship, for he finds
they lend,

When lads begin to call each other
friend.

Yet self with self has war; the
tempting sight

Of fruit on sale provokes his
appetite;—

See! how, he walks the }
sweet
seduction by;
That he is tempted, costs him
first a sigh—

270

'Tis dangerous to indulge, 'tis
grievous to deny!
This he will choose, and whispering
asks the price.
The purchase dreadful, but the
portion nice;
Within the pocket he explores the
pence;
Without, temptation strikes on either
sense,
The sight, the smell;—but then he
thinks again
Of money gone! while fruit nor taste
remain.
Meantime there comes an eager
thoughtless boy,
Who gives the price and only feels
the joy:
Example dire! the youthful miser
stops,

280

And slowly back the treasured
coinage drops.
Heroic deed! for should he now
comply,
Can he to-morrow's appetite deny?
Beside, these spendthrifts who so
friendly live,
Cloy'd with their purchase, will a
portion give.—

Here ends debate, he buttons up his
store,
And feels the comfort that it burns no
more,
Unlike to him the tyrant-boy,
whose sway
All hearts acknowledge; him the
crowds obey:
At his command they break through
every rule;

290

Whoever governs, he controls the
school;
'Tis not the distant emperor moves
their fear,
But the proud viceroy who is ever
near.

Verres could do that mischief in a
day,
For which not Rome, in all its power,
could pay;
And these boy-tyrants will their
slaves distress,
And do the wrongs no master can
redress.

The mind they load }
with fear; it }
feels disdain

For its own baseness; yet it
tries in vain
To shake th' admitted power;
—the coward comes again.

300

'Tis more than present pain these
tyrants give,
Long as we've life some strong
impressions live;

And these young ruffians in the soul
will sow
Seeds of all vices that on weakness
grow.

Hark! at his word the trembling
younglings flee;
Where he is walking none must walk
but he;
See! from the winter-fire the weak
retreat;
His the warm corner, his the favourite
seat,
Save when he yields it to some slave
to keep
Awhile, then back, at his return, to
creep.

310

At his command his poor dependents
fly,
And humbly bribe him as a proud
ally;
Flatter'd by all, the notice he bestows
Is gross abuse, and bantering and
blows;
Yet he's a dunce, and, spite of all his
fame
Without the desk, within he feels his
shame:
For there the weaker boy, who felt his
scorn,
For him corrects the blunders of the
morn;
And he is taught, unpleasant truth! to
find
The trembling body has the prouder
mind.

320

Hark to that shout, that burst of
empty noise,
From a rude set of bluff, obstreperous
boys;
They who, like colts let loose, with
vigour bound,
And thoughtless spirit, o'er the beaten
ground;
Fearless they leap, and every
youngster feels
His Alma active in his hands and
heels.

These are the sons of farmers, and
they come
With partial fondness for the joys of
home;
Their minds are coursing in their
fathers' fields,
And e'en the dream a lively pleasure
yields;

330

They, much enduring, sit th' allotted
hours,
And o'er a grammar waste their
sprightly powers;
They dance; but them can measured
steps delight,
Whom horse and hounds to daring
deeds excite?
Nor could they bare to wait from
meal to meal,
Did they not slyly to the chamber
steal,
And there the produce of the basket
seize,
The mother's gift! still studious of
their ease.

Poor Alma, thus oppress'd, forbears to
rise,
But rests or revels in the arms and
thighs^[72].

340

"But is it sure that study will repay
The more attentive and
forbearing?"—Nay!
The farm, the ship, the humble shop
have each
Gains which severest studies seldom
reach.

At college place a youth, who
means to raise
His state by merit and his name by
praise;
Still much he hazards; there is serious
strife
In the contentions of a scholar's life.
Not all the mind's attention, care,
distress,

Nor diligence itself, ensure success;

350

His jealous heart a rival's power may
dread,
Till its strong feelings have confused
his head,
And, after days and months, nay,
years of pain,
He finds just lost the object he would
gain.

But, grant him this and all such life
can give,
For other prospects he begins to live;
Begins to feel that man was form'd to
look

And long for other objects than a
book.

In his mind's eye his house and glebe
he sees,

And farms and talks with farmers at
his ease;

360

And time is lost, till fortune sends
him forth

To a rude world unconscious of his
worth;

There in some petty parish to reside,
The college-boast, then turn'd the
village-guide;

And, though awhile his flock and
dairy please,

He soon reverts to former joys and
ease:

Glad when a friend shall come to
break his rest,

And speak of all the pleasures they
possess'd—

Of masters, fellows, tutors, all with
whom

They shared those pleasures, never
more to come;

370

Till both conceive the times by bliss
endear'd,

Which once so dismal and so dull
appear'd.

But fix our scholar, and suppose
him crown'd

With all the glory gain'd on classic
ground;

Suppose the world without a sigh
resign'd,

And to his college all his care
confined;
Give him all honours that such states
allow,
The freshman's terror and the
tradesman's bow;
Let his apartments with his taste
agree,
And all his views be those he loves to
see;

380

Let him each day behold the savoury
treat,
For which he pays not, but is paid to
eat;
These joys and glories soon delight
no more,
Although, withheld, the mind is vex'd
and sore;
The honour too is to the place
confined;
Abroad they know not each superior
mind:
Strangers no *wrangers* in these
figures see,
Nor give they worship to a high
degree.

Unlike the prophet's is the scholar's
case,
His honour all is in his dwelling-
place;

390

And there such honours are familiar
things;
What is a monarch in a crowd of
kings?

Like other sovereigns he's by forms
address'd,
By statutes govern'd and with rules
oppress'd.

When all these forms and duties
die away,
And the day passes like the former
day,
Then, of exterior things at once
bereft,
He's to himself and one attendant left;
Nay, John too goes; nor aught of
service more
Remains for him; he gladly quits the
door,

400

And, as he whistles to the college-
gate,
He kindly pities his poor master's
fate.

Books cannot always please,
however good;
Minds are not ever craving for their
food;
But sleep will soon the weary soul
prepare
For cares to-morrow that were this
day's care;
For forms, for feasts, that sundry
times have past,
And formal feasts that will for ever
last.

"But then from study will no
comforts rise?"
Yes! such as studious minds alone
can prize;

410

Comforts, yea! joys ineffable they
find,
Who seek the prouder pleasures of
the mind:
The soul, collected in those happy
hours,
Then makes her efforts, then enjoys
her powers;
And in those seasons feels herself
repaid,
For labours past and honours long
delay'd.

No! 'tis not worldly gain, although
by chance
The sons of learning may to wealth
advance;
Nor station high, though in some
favouring hour
The sons of learning may arrive at
power;

420

Nor is it glory, though the public
voice
Of honest praise will make the heart
rejoice;
But 'tis the mind's own feelings give
the joy,
Pleasures she gathers in her own
employ—
Pleasures that gain or praise cannot
bestow,
Yet can dilate and raise them when
they flow.

For this the poet looks the world
around,
Where form and life and reasoning
man are found.

He loves the mind in all its modes to
trace,
And all the manners of the changing
race;

430

Silent he walks the road of life along,
And views the aims of its tumultuous
throng;

He finds what shapes the Proteus-
passions take,

And what strange waste of life and
joy they make,

And loves to show them in their
varied ways,

With honest blame or with
unflattering praise.

'Tis good to know, 'tis pleasant to
impart,

These turns and movements of the
human heart;

The stronger features of the soul to
paint,

And make distinct the latent and the
faint;

440

Man as he is, to place in all men's
view,

Yet none with rancour, none with
scorn pursue;

Nor be it ever of my portraits told,—

"Here the strong lines of malice we
behold."—

This let me hope, that when in
public view
I bring my pictures, men may feel
them true;
"This is a likeness," may they all
declare,
"And I have seen him, but I know not
where;"
For I should mourn the mischief I had
done,
If as the likeness all would fix on one.
450

Man's vice and crime I combat as I
can,
But to his GOD and conscience leave
the man;
I search (a [Quixote!]) all the land
about,
To find its giants and enchanters out,
(The giant-folly, the enchanter-vice,
Whom doubtless I shall vanquish in a
trice;)
But is there man whom I would
injure?—no!
I am to him a fellow, not a foe—
A fellow-sinner, who must rather
dread
The bolt, than hurl it at another's
head.
460

No! let the guiltless, if there such
be found,
Launch forth the spear, and deal the
deadly wound;
How can I so the cause of virtue aid,
Who am myself attainted and afraid?

Yet, as I can, I point the powers of
rhyme,
And, sparing criminals, attack the
crime.

FOOTNOTES:

^[72] Should any of my readers find themselves at a loss in this place, I beg leave to refer them to a poem of Prior, called Alma, or the Progress of the Mind.

ERRATA

cept in the case of short poems with unnumbered lines, or in that of prefaces, mottos, notes &c. the line of the poem, not the line of the page, is cited.]

- PAGE [1](#) l. 11 for *chests* read *chiefs*.
p. [3](#) l. 5 for *she's a* read *she, "'s a*.
p. [4](#) l. 2 for *beaut'y* read *beauty's*.
p. [5](#) l. 18 for *moans* read *mourn*.
p. [7](#) l. 9 for *stand* read *stands*.
p. [9](#) l. 1 for *Shenstone's* read *Byrom's*.
p. [14](#) l. 31 for *nature* read *Nature's*.
p. [20](#) l. 75 for *devine* read *divine*.
 ib. l. 90 for *unwraught* read *unwrought*.
 ib. l. 102 for *pleasures* read *pleasure's*.
p. [21](#) l. 116 for *distant* read *distance*.
p. [23](#) l. 186 for *desturb* read *disturb*.
 ib. l. 196 for *titt'ring* read *titt'rings*.
 ib. note for *puris* read *purus*.
p. [24](#) l. 214 for *sits* read *sets*.
 ib. l. 226 for *fall* read *pall*.
 ib. for *refind* read *refin'd*.
p. [27](#) l. 82 for *to humble or to brave* read *too humble or too brave*.
p. [28](#) l. 101 for *Errors* read *Error's*.
p. [30](#) l. 153 for *be* read *by*.
p. [48](#) l. 41 for *Meonides* read *Mæonides*.
 ib. l. 54 for *triump'd* read *triumph'd*.
 ib. l. 61 for *Wonders* read *wanders*.
p. [49](#) l. 67 for *Titerus* read *Tityrus*.
 ib. l. 69 for *Neareds* read *Nereids*.
 ib. l. 83 for *glomiest* read *gloomiest*.
 ib. l. 87 for *Thompson* read *Thomson*.
 ib. l. 89 for *years Verdent* read *year's Verdant*.
 ib. l. 91 for *Aspin* read *Aspen*.

- p. [50](#) l. 104 for *Vally* read *Valley*.
 ib. l. 111 for *glomier* read *gloomier*.
 ib. l. 118 for *Challange* read *Challenge*.
- p. [51](#) l. 142 for *Disapointment* read *Disappointment*.
 ib. l. 149 for *Currant* read *Current*.
 ib. l. 160 for *Eccho's* read *Echo's*.
- p. [52](#) l. 185 for *ignious* read *igneous*.
 ib. l. 201 for *not* read *out*.
 ib. l. 212 for *ages* read *age's*.
 ib. l. 215 for *ratling* read *rattling*.
- p. [53](#) l. 235 for *Simphony* read *Symphony*.
 ib. l. 237 for *Scence* read *Scene*.
- p. [55](#) l. 295 for *Fiend, fang'd* read *Fiend and fang'd*.
 ib. l. 297 for *thretned* read *threaten'd*.
 ib. l. 313 for *Rotteness* read *Rottenness*.
- p. [56](#) l. 343 for *distinguis'd* read *distinguish'd*.
 ib. l. 351 for *Worldwind's* read *Whirlwind's*.
- p. [57](#) l. 379 for *dispis'd* read *despis'd*.
- p. [59](#) l. 439 for *beseige* read *besiege*.
 ib. l. 441 for *tenaceous* read *tenacious*.
 ib. l. 446 for *Death Thoughts* read *Death, Thought's*.
 ib. l. 466 for *Emminence* read *Eminence*.
- p. [82](#) note for *Od. 8* read *Od. 6*.
- p. [87](#) l. 8 for *Paneg. ad Pisones, Lucan* read *Paneg. ad Pisones*.
- p. [115](#) l. 543 for *reverend* read *reverent*.
- p. [123](#) l. 118 for *Theirs* read *Their*.
- p. [146](#) l. 157 for *Indited* read *Indicted*.
- p. [152](#) l. 393 for *silly* read *slily*.
- p. [155](#) l. 8 for *teneres* read *teneras*.
 ib. l. 15. The reading in Shakspeare is not *furnish up*, but *finish up*.
- p. [158](#) l. 8 for *restat* read *restet*.
- p. [161](#) l. 139 for *cives* read *chives*.
- p. [182](#) l. 63 not in inverted commas.
- p. [187](#) ll. 235-6 not in inverted commas.
- p. [205](#) l. 270 for *passion* read *passions*.
- p. [211](#) l. 507 for *Snowden's* read *Snowdon's*.
- p. [212](#) ll. 551-2 not in inverted commas.

- p. [230](#) l. 214 for *One* read *one*.
- p. [232](#) l. 319 for *Reubens* read *Rubens*.
ib. l. 320 for *shall* read *shalt*.
- p. [237](#) l. 96 for *If* read *In*.
- p. [238](#) l. 11. *I'll know no more*, not printed as beginning of new stanza.
- p. [239](#) l. 36 not printed as beginning of new stanza.
ib. not in inverted commas.
- p. [251](#) l. 4 for 22 read 22 *and* 23.
- p. [252](#) l. 5 for *dolor* read *labor*.
- p. [256](#) l. 4 for *deplorant* read *deplangunt*.
- p. [257](#) l. 22 for *elmin* read *elmen*.
- p. [284](#) l. 7 for *scenes* read *place hath*.
ib. l. 15 for *discutient* read *discutiunt*.
ib. l. 17 for *ver. 520* read *vv. 519-523*.
- p. [289](#) l. 154 (Lonely yet public stands) not enclosed *sic* in brackets.
- p. [292](#) l. 299 for *suceeds* read *succeeds*.
- p. [301](#) l. 266 for *thoughts* and *spirits* read *thoughts'* and *spirit's*.
- p. [303](#) l. 13 for *of* read *o'er*.
ib. l. 14 for *while* read *whilst*.
- p. [307](#) l. 132 for *Comes* read *Come*.
- p. [313](#) l. 6 for *Churches* read *Church's*.
ib. l. 12 for *knew* read *know*.
ib. l. 14 for *Oh!* read *Ah!*
- p. [327](#) l. 528 for *staid* read *stay'd*.
- p. [328](#) l. 12 for *xxvii.* read *xxviii.*
- p. [329](#) l. 6 for *leader* read *captain*.
ib. l. 8 for *beer: all* read *beer ... all*.
ib. ib. for *I* read *and I*.
ib. ll. 10, 11 for *and they shall all worship me as* read *and worship me*.
- p. [336](#) l. 7 for *Manilius* read *Plaut. Trucul.*
- p. [340](#) l. 114 for *professions* read *professions'*.
- p. [347](#) instead of ll. 4, 5 read as in text:

*Finirent multi letho mala; credula
vitam
Spes alit, et melius cras fore
semper ait.*

- p. [364](#) l. 6 for *Catull*, lib. 3 read (*Dionys.*) *Cato De Moribus* III. 7.
ib. l. 7 for *fatiscat* read *fatiscit*.
 p. [374](#) l. 14 for *Et* read *Sed*.
ib. for *juncta* read *multa*.
 p. [407](#) l. 7 for *pool* read *pond*.
ib. l. 9 is followed in Shakspeare by the line:

'Of wisdom, gravity, profound
 conceit.'

- p. [417](#) l. 5 for *quia* read *quam*.
ib. l. 12 for *tibi* read *cui*.
ib. l. 15 for *blessing* read *blessings*.
 p. [422](#) l. 147 for *reverend* read *reverent*.
 p. [428](#) l. 114 for *blissing* read *blessing*.
 p. [431](#) l. 5 six lines follow after 'Burning Lamp.'
ib. for *wast* read *wert*.
ib. l. 7 five lines follow after *this fire*.
ib. 'An everlasting bonfire light!' follows after 'perpetual triumph.'
ib. l. 8 for *in a* read *with thee in the*.
 p. [439](#) l. 4 for *who* read *that*.
ib. l. 5 for *in time* read *in the time*.
 p. [451](#) l. 71 for *birth* read *berth*.
 p. [480](#) l. 4 for *Coepis* read *Coepisti*.
ib. for *desines* read *desinis*.
 p. [485](#) l. 166 for *then* read *than*.
 p. [502](#) l. 7 for *my* read *our*.
 p. [512](#) l. 24 six lines follow after *at taw*.
 p. [519](#) l. 250 for *illude* read *elude*.
 p. [524](#) l. 452 for *Quixotte!* read *Quixote!*

The (mis)quotation from Ovid in p. 5 cannot be identified; the lines quoted on p. 284 as 'Pope's Homer's Iliad, bk. vi. line 45' are not to be found in that work; and the stanza attributed on p. 294 to Percy is not traceable to the *Reliques*.

VARIANTS.

[POEMS.](#) Dedication and Preface. Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

Dedication:

- p. [88](#), l. 2. Henry-Richard.
- p. [89](#), l. 5. judgement.
 - l. 10. have taught.

Preface:

- p. [90](#), l. 11. enquiry.
 - l. 27. judgement.
- p. [91](#), l. 23. among.
 - l. 32. as Mr Boswell (since Lord Auchinleck) has told.
- p. [92](#), l. 7. suspense.
- p. [93](#), l. 2, my friends.
 - l. 5. judgement.
 - l. 9. blameable.
- p. [94](#), l. 13. such opinion.
 - l. 18. Charles-James.
 - l. 28. criticizing.
 - l. 36. judgement.
- p. [95](#), l. 12. judgement.
 - l. 15. Lope de Vega.
 - l. 22. an high degree.
 - l. 26. Lope de Vega.
- p. [96](#), l. 20. judgement.
 - l. 26. in a beneficed clergyman.
- p. [97](#), l. 23. Baptisms.
 - l. 31. enquiry.
- p. [98](#), l. 25. judgement.

- l. 26. intitled.
p. [99](#), l. 8. judgement.
l. 14. or the exultation.

THE LIBRARY. Variants in edition of 1781 (first edition).

- l. 16. *for* wo: woe.
l. 22. prevail.
l. 28. her old.
instead of ll. 51-54:

Come then, and entering view this
spacious scene,
This sacred dome, this noble
magazine;

- l. 57. asswage.
instead of ll. 63-178:

In this selection, which the human
mind
With care has made; for Glory has
design'd,
All should be perfect; or at least
appear
From falshood, vanity, and passion
clear:
But man's best efforts taste of man,
and show
The poor and troubled source from
whence they flow;
His very triumphs his defeats must
speak,
And ev'n his wisdom serves to
prove him weak.
Fashion, though Folly's child, and
guide of fools,
Rules e'en the wisest, and in
Learning rules;

From courts and crowds to
 Wisdom's seat she goes,
 And reigns triumphant o'er her
 mother's foes:
 Yon Folios, once the darlings of the
 mode,
 Now lie neglected like the birth-
 day ode;
 There Learning, stuff'd with
 maxims trite though sage,
 Makes Indigestion yawn at every
 page;
 Chain'd like Prometheus, lo! the
 mighty train
 Brave Time's fell tooth, and live
 and die again;
 And now the scorn of men and
 now the pride,
 The sires respect them, and the
 sons deride.

l. 183. every note and every comment.

l. 197. is.

l. 200. your judges are your rivals.

instead of ll. 201-322:

But ne'er, }
 discourag'd, }
 fair attempts
 lay by,
 For Reason views them
 with approving eye,
 And Candour yields what
 cavillers deny.
 She sees the struggles of the soul to
 steer
 Through clouds and darkness,
 which surround us here,

And, though the long research has
ne'er prevail'd,
Applauds the trial and forgets it
fail'd.

followed by ll. 105—140 of the text; then continuing:

Wits, Bards and Idlers fill a tatter'd
row;
And the vile Vulgar lie disdain'd
below.

Amid these works, on which the
eager eye
Delights to fix, or glides reluctant
by
Where all combin'd their decent
pomp display,
Where shall we first our early
offering pay?

To thee Philosophy! to thee, the
light,
The guide of mortals through their
mental night,
By whom the world in all its views
is shown,
Our guide through Nature's works,
and in our own;
Who place in order }
Being's }
wondrous
chain,
Save where those puzzling,
stubborn links remain,
By art divine involv'd,
which man can ne'er
explain.

These are thy volumes; and in
these we look,
As abstracts drawn from Nature's
larger book;
Here first describ'd the humble
glebe appears,
Unconscious of the gaudy robe it
wears;
All that the earth's profound
recesses hide,
And all that roll beneath the raging
tide;
The sullen gem that yet disdains to
shine,
And all the ductile matter of the
mine.
Next to the vegetable tribes they
lead,
Whose fruitful beds o'er every
balmy mead
Teem with new life, and hills, and
vales, and groves,
Feed the still flame, and nurse the
silent loves;
Which, when the Spring calls forth
their genial power
Swell with the seed, and flourish in
the flower:
There, with the husband-slaves, in
royal pride,
Queens, like the Amazons of old,
reside;
There, like the Turk, the lordly
husband lives,
And joy to all the gay seraglio
gives;

There, in the secret chambers,
 veil'd from sight,
A bashful tribe in hidden flames
 delight;
There, in the open day, and gaily
 deck'd,
The bolder brides their distant
 lords expect;
Who with the wings of love
 instinctive rise,
And on prolific winds each ardent
 bridegroom flies.
Next are that tribe whom life and
 sense inform,
The torpid beetle, and the
 shrinking worm;
And insects, proud to spread their
 brilliant wing,
To catch the fostering sunbeams of
 the spring;
That feather'd race, which late
 from winter fled,
To dream an half-existence with
 the dead;
Who now, returning from their six
 months' sleep,
Dip their black pinions in the
 slumbering deep;
Where, feeling life from stronger
 beams of day,
The scaly myriads of the ocean
 play.
Then led by Art through Nature's
 maze, we trace
The sullen people of the savage
 race;

And see a favourite tribe mankind
attend,
And in the fawning follower find
the friend.

l. 346. virtues seek.

l. 390. subtle.

l. 408. a song.

l. 410. did ne'er

l. 422. Abridgements.

l. 431. cries.

instead of l. 432:

Ere laws arose, ere tyrants bade
them rise;

l. 435. no tumults.

instead of ll. 441-2:

Bound by no tyes but those by
nature made,
Virtue was law, and gifts prevented
trade.

l. 444. chearless.

instead of l. 454:

Taught by some conquering friends
who came as foes.

l. 477. Primæval.

After l. 478:

Now turn from these, to view yon
ampler space,
There rests a sacred, grave and
solemn race;
There the devout an awful station
keep,
Vigils advise and yet dispose to
sleep;

There might they }
long in }
lasting peace
abide

But controversial authors
lie beside,
Who friend from friend and
sire from son divide:
Endless disputes around the world
they cause
Creating now, and now controuling
laws.

followed by ll. 223-266 of the text, with the ensuing variations:
ll. 237-244:

Calvin grows gentle in this silent
coast,
Nor finds a single heretic to roast:
Here, their fierce rage subdu'd, and
lost their pride
The Pope and Luther slumber side
by side:

l. 245. whom the Church's.

l. 248. Crumbs.

ll. 249-256 *omitted*.

instead of l. 257:

And let them lie—for lo! yon
gaudy frames.

l. 259. dread.

l. 260. sparks of Grace.

l. 265. prophane, or impiously.

l. 537. What tho' neglect has shed.

l. 550. dæmons.

l. 555. strait.

l. 578. tipling.

l. 595. fancy'd.

THE VILLAGE. Variants in edition of 1783 (first edition).

Book I.

Synopsis of contents omitted.

l. 5. forms.

instead of ll. 7-8:

Fled are those times, if e'er such
times were seen,
When rustic poets prais'd their
native green;

l. 18. echo's.

l. 31. one chief cause.

instead of ll. 33-35:

They ask no thought, require no
deep design,
But swell the song and liquefy the
line;
The gentle lover takes the rural
strain.

l. 40. gazes.

l. 59. sooth.

l. 76. And the wild tare clings round.

instead of ll. 99-100:

And foil'd beneath the young
Ulysses fell;
When peals of praise the merry
mischief tell?

l. 107. Or, yielding part (when equal knaves contest).

l. 108. for the rest.

l. 118. their's.

after l. 143:

Like him to make the plenteous
harvest grow,

And yet not share the plenty they
bestow;

l. 153. as luxury.

instead of ll. 166-7:

Or will you urge their homely,
plenteous fare,
Healthy and plain and still the poor
man's share?

instead of l. 171:

As you who envy would disdain to
touch.

l. 183. its own.

l. 189. straitest.

l. 197. And urge the efforts.

l. 204. rouz'd.

l. 219. Slow in their gifts, but.

l. 223. woe.

l. 265. is all.

l. 271. Nor wipes.

l. 273. Nor promise.

l. 295. mutely hastens to the grave.

instead of ll. 312-13:

Sure in his shot his game he
seldom mist,
And seldom fail'd to win his game
at whist;

l. 325. oh! Death.

l. 327. farmer gets.

THE VILLAGE.

Book II.

Synopsis of contents omitted.

l. 30. began.

l. 52. the Lord's.

l. 55. Hear too.

instead of ll. 59-62:

How their maids languish, while
their men run loose,
And leave them scarce a damsel to
seduce.

instead of l. 68:

One cup, and that just serves to
make them foes;

l. 70. And batter'd faces end.

l. 85. faltering.

l. 102. you reckon great.

instead of ll. 111-112:

Who gave up pleasures you could
never share,
For pain which you are seldom
doom'd to bear,

instead of ll. 161-2:

But Rutland's virtues shall his
griefs restrain,
And join to heal the bosom where
they reign.

l. 165. Hush the loud grief.

l. 168. can please.

l. 172. not valu'd.

l. 176. terror.

instead of l. 177:

But 'tis the spirit that is mounting
high.

l. 178. a native.

l. 193. nearer woes.

after l. 197:

Victims victorious, who with him
shall stand
In Fame's fair book the guardians
of the land;
l. 201. streams go murmuring by.
l. 204. strong stream.

THE NEWSPAPER. Variants in edition of 1785 (first edition).

l. 37. Yet you in pity check.
l. 38. and still vouchsafe to write.
instead of ll. 39-40:

(While your choice works on quiet
shelves remain,
Or grace the windows of the trade
in vain;
Where ev'n their fair and comely
sculptures fail,
Engrav'd by Grignion, and design'd
by Wale)—

instead of ll. 47-48:

But lend your aid to make my
prowess known,
And puff my labours as ye puff
your own.

l. 51. or what the time they fly.
instead of ll. 57-60:

Gray evening comes, and comes
not evening gray
With all the trifling tidings of the
day?

instead of ll. 71-72:

Yet soon each reptile tribe is lost
but these,

In the first brushing of the wintry
breeze;

l. 73. These still remain.

after l. 78:

(The Oglio now appears, a rival
name,
Of bolder manners, tho' of younger
fame);

l. 83. lye.

l. 85. holy day.

instead of l. 92:

Tomorrow Woodfall, and the world
below.

l. 104. the weak man's brain.

after l. 126:

Soon as the chiefs, whom once
they choose, lie low,
Their praise too slackens, and their
aid moves slow;
Not so, when leagu'd with rising
powers, their rage
Then wounds th' unwary foe, and
burns along the page.

l. 132. nor leaves the winter one.

l. 134. Fly in successive troops this fluttering race.

after l. 136:

Or are there those, who ne'er their
friends forsook,
Lur'd by no promise, by no danger
shook?
Then bolder bribes the venal aid
procure,
And golden letters make the
faithless sure:

For those who deal in flattery or
abuse,
Will sell them when they can the
most produce.

l. 155. Justice, Rector and Attorney.

l. 160. tythe.

instead of ll. 163-4:

Here comes the neighbouring
Squire, with gracious air,
To stamp opinions, and to take the
chair;

l. 172. plagues.

l. 175. Brook's and St Albin's.

l. 178. owes.

instead of ll. 190-192:

"Strive but for power, and parley
but for place;"
Yet hopes, good man! "that all may
still be well,"
And thanks the stars that he's a
vote to sell.

after l. 192:

While thus he reads or raves,
around him wait
A rustic band and join in each
debate;
Partake his manly spirit, and
delight
To praise or blame, to judge of
wrong or right;
Measures to mend, and ministers to
make,
Till all go madding for their
country's sake.

l. 193. th' all-teeming Press.

l. 194. These pois'nous.

instead of ll. 211-12:

Studious we toil, correct, amend,
retouch,
Take much away, yet mostly leave
too much;

l. 230. deny'd.

l. 253. chearful.

l. 260. And slighting theirs, make comments of their own.

l. 266. monies.

instead of ll. 267-8:

While the sly widow, and the
coxcomb sleek,
Dive deep for scandal through a
hint oblique.

instead of ll. 273-4:

Hence on that morn no welcome
post appears,
That luckless mind a sullen aspect
wears;

l. 279. Such restless passion.

l. 280. Worse than an itch for Music or the Muse.

l. 284. Has neither chance for cure, nor intervals of rest.

after l. 284:

Such powers have things so vile,
and they can boast
That those peruse them who
despise them most.

l. 285. Thus sung—say Muse.

l. 294. Or coin fresh tales.

l. 300. No British widow turns Italian bride.

l. 304. peers give place, and own her fair.

instead of ll. 309-312:

Such tales as these with joy the
many read,
And paragraphs on paragraphs
succeed;
Then add the common themes that
never cease
The tide-like Stocks, their ebb and
their increase;

instead of l. 336:

And nameless murder'd in the face
of day.

l. 337. Here, first in rank, the Stage.

l. 344. From self, and.

l. 346. try'd.

l. 373. gray.

instead of ll. 379-80:

Such are their puffs, and would
they all were such,
Then should the verse no poet's
laurel touch;

l. 386. friseurs.

l. 416. sacred labours.

l. 428. On the scroll'd bar-board, view'd too long before.

l. 429. tipling.

l. 438. For these no more shall live, than they shall die.

instead of ll. 449-50:

Nameless you this way print your
idle rhymes,
A thousand view them, you a
thousand times:

l. 462. Leave wealth, indulge not these but nobler fires.

Note 1. SPLEEN, a poem.

The following footnotes appear in the first edition of The Newspaper, but were not reprinted:

l. 1. The greatest part of this Poem was written immediately after the dissolution of the late parliament.

l. 68. The Ephemera, or May-fly, is an insect remarked by naturalists for the very short time it lives, after assuming its last and more perfect form.

l. 78. [See Variant.] The OGLIO, a Sunday paper, advertised about October last.

THE PARISH REGISTER. Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

Part I.

Instead of ll. 43-50:

Above the mantel bound with
 ribband blue,
The Swain's emblazon'd Arms
 demand our view.
In meadow *Vert*, there feeds in
 Gules a cow,
Beneath an *Argent* share and *Sable*
 plough;
While for a crest, an *Azure* arm
 sustains
In *Or* a wheatsheaf, rich with
 bristling grains.

l. 53. when tried.

l. 54. who prov'd misfortunes.

l. 61. that England fed.

l. 66. That nations dreaded and that Nelson beat.

instead of ll. 67-8:

And here will soon that other fleet
 be shown,
That Nelson made the ocean's and
 our own.

l. 85. by famous Heads made out.

l. 86. That teach the simple reader where to doubt.

- l. 87. That made him stop.
l. 88. And where he wonder'd then.
l. 112. Laid.

instead of ll. 127-8:

These hear the parent Swain,
 reclin'd at ease
With half his listening offspring on
 his knees.

- l. 140. The tall *Leek*, tapering with his rushy stem.
l. 177. who knew not sex.
l. 193. gutters flow.
l. 197. woe.
l. 248. drink and play.
l. 270. Glories unsought, the Fathers.
l. 309. an haughty soul.
l. 310. controul.
l. 314. seldom shed.
l. 339. What then was left, these Lovers to requite?
l. 368. Higler's.
l. 369. antient.

instead of ll. 371-2:

Day after day were past in grief
 and pain,
Week after week, nor came the
 Youth again;

instead of ll. 417-18:

Few were their Acres,—but they,
 well content,
Were on each pay-day, ready with
 their rent;

instead of ll. 453-60:

'Far other thoughts, your
 Reverence, caus'd the ill,

'Twas pure good-nature, not a
wanton will;

They urg'd me, paid }
me, beg'd }
me to
comply,

Not hard of heart, or slow
to yield am I,

But prone to grant as
melting charity.

For wanton wishes, let the frail-
ones smart,

But all my failing is a tender heart.'

l. 470. Gerrard.

instead of ll. 471-2:

Seven have I nam'd, and but six
years have past
By him and Judith since I bound
them fast.

l. 477. he would no more increase.

l. 481. humbled.

l. 521. pedlar's.

l. 539. woe with woe.

l. 540. "Ah! Humphrey! Humphrey!"

l. 558. said Humphrey.

l. 559. an husband's.

l. 569. antient.

instead of ll. 582-3:

To prove these arrows of the giants'
hand,
Are not for man to stay or to
command.

instead of l. 604:

Of news or nothing, she by looks
compel.

l. 628. *Artimisia*.
l. 631. *Senecio*.
l. 649. *turged Anthers*.
instead of l. 650:

"But haste and bear them to their
 spouse away;
In a like bed you'll see that spouse
 reclin'd,
(Oh! haste and bear them, they like
 love are blind,)

l. 652. make the marriage sure.
l. 663. to life's great duty, Love.
l. 676. some notice they will claim.
instead of ll. 678-9:

The straitest furrow lifts the
 ploughman's heart,
Or skill allow'd firm in the bruiser's
 art.

l. 700. For he who lent a name to babe unknown.
l. 702. they ask'd the name of all.
l. 713. controul.
l. 743. that seem'd.
l. 744. that nothing meant.
l. 748. steelly.
l. 751. still more sure about the world.
l. 784. Keeps looking on the ground.
l. 785. These looks and sighs.
l. 803. transcendant.
l. 811. Bishoprick.
l. 826. Passions.
l. 833. Spencer; Spencer's.
The note to l. 833 is omitted in the first edition.

Part II.

Instead of ll. 5-6:

If Poor, Delay shall for that Want
prepare,
That, on the hasty, brings a World
of Care;

instead of l. 17:

Yet thee too long, let not thy Fears
detain

l. 19. tied.

l. 26. Banns.

instead of ll. 34-60.

Fie, Nathan! fie! to let a sprightly
Jade
Leer on thy Bed, then ask thee how
'twas made
And lingering walk around at Head
and Feet,
To see thy nightly Comforts all
complete;
Then waiting seek—not what she
said she sought,
And bid a Penny for her Master's
Thought;—
(A Thought she knew, and thou
could'st not send hence,
Well as thou lov'dst them, for ten
thousand Pence!)

And thus with some bold Hint she
would retire,
That wak'd the idle Wish and stirr'd
the slumbering Fire;
Didst thou believe }
thy Passion }
all so laid
That thou might'st trifle
with thy wanton Maid,

And feel amus'd, and yet not feel
afraid?
The dryest Faggot, Nathan, once
was green,
And laid on Embers, still some Sap
is seen;
Oaks, bald like thee above, that
cease to grow,
Feel yet the Warmth of Spring and
Bud below;
More senseless thou than Faggot
on the Fire
For thou could'st feel and yet
would'st not retire;
Less provident than }
dying Trees, }
—for they
Some vital Strength, some
living Fire display,
But none that tend to wear
the Life itself away.
Ev'n now I see thee to the Altar
come;
Downcast thou wert and conscious
of thy Doom:
I see thee glancing on that Shape
aside,
With blended Looks of Jealousy
and Pride;
But growing Fear has long the
Pride supprest,
And but one Tyrant rankles in thy
Breast;
Now of her Love, a second Pledge
appears,
And Doubts on Doubts arise, and
Fears on Fears;

Yet Fear defy, and be of Courage
stout,
Another Pledge will banish every
Doubt;
Thine Age advancing as thy
Powers retire,
Will make thee sure—What more
would'st thou require?

l. 68. antient.

l. 96. Drew Oil, drew Essence.

l. 100. Mrs.

l. 269. And hid the Snare, prepar'd to catch the Maid.

l. 290. Scrolls.

instead of ll. 301-308:

Is it that strong and sturdy in the
Field
They scorn the Arms of idle Men
to wield
Or give that Hand to guide the
Goosequill Tip,
That rules a Team, and brandishes
a whip?
The Lions they, whom conscious
Power forbid,—
To play the Ape and "dandle with
the Kid."

l. 313. For Bridget Dawdle.

l. 317. To Roger Pluck.

l. 321. In all his Dealings, Hodge was just and true.

l. 340. Bridget's.

l. 341. Roger.

l. 351. Bridget.

l. 353. Roger's.

l. 355. Roger's *bis*.

instead of ll. 372-375:

So two dried Sticks, all fled the
vital juice,
When rubb'd and chaf'd, their
latent Heat produce;
All in one part unite the cheering
Rays,
And kindling burn with momentary
Blaze.

l. 380. when touch'd with Galvin's Wire.

instead of ll. 400-1:

No more she plays, no more
attempts to fit
Her Steps responsive to the
squeaking Kit,

l. 419. in room apart.

l. 424. And Wives like these assert and prove their own;

l. 430 (*note*). Spencer.

l. 437. Nor sought their Bliss, at *Cupid's* wild Commands,

l. 444. was her Reuben's Care;

instead of ll. 461-66:

Nor these alone, (though favour'd
more) are blest;
In time, the Rash, in time, the
Wretched rest;
They first-sad years of Want and
Anguish know,
Their Joys come seldom, and their
Pains pass slow;

instead of ll. 473-4:

When Life's Afflictions long with
dread endur'd,
By Time are lessen'd, or by
Caution cur'd;

l. 477. And calm in Cares, with Patience, Man and Wife,

l. 490. Quite.

instead of ll. 491-2:

For me, (he thinks,) shall soon this
Deed be done,
A few steps forward, and my Race
is run;

l. 499. He gives his Friend a tear, and heaves himself a sigh.

l. 516. Plowman's.

l. 521. spare, for Rapture to enjoy?

instead of ll. 565-7:

Who caus'd the Anguish they
disdain'd to heal,
Have at some time, the Power of
Virtue known,
And felt another's good promote
their own:

l. 568. the youth.

l. 569. Who took the Maid, with innocence and truth;

l. 572. its vigour keep.

l. 583. When Beauty all decays.

Part III.

l. 33. that sad submission.

l. 48. as a Sinner's Right.

l. 49. God is good.

l. 50. And, none have liv'd, as Wisdom wills they should.

l. 54. To think about beginning to repent.

l. 65. That feels the useful Pain, Repentance brings.

l. 66. Dejection's Sorrows.

l. 67. And then, the Hope, that Heaven these Grievs approve.

l. 68. And lastly Joy that springs.

l. 75. Collet.

instead of ll. 151-2:

Like that industrious Kind, no
thoughts of Sex
No cares of Love, could her chaste
Soul perplex.

l. 159. welcome at her Board to share.

After l. 172: As Bridget churn'd the Butter, for her Hand.

l. 173. (Geese, Hens, and Turkeys following where she went.)

l. 185. as the more.

l. 186. She grasp'd with greater force.

l. 212. To bear a Grandchild.

l. 219. check the passions.

l. 220. Youth's Disappointments, the Regrets of Age.

instead of ll. 225-31:

Blest is the Nurseling never taught
to sing,
But thrust untimely from its
Mother's Wing;
Or the grown Warbler, who, with
grateful Voice,
Sings its own Joy and makes the
Grove rejoice;
Because, ere yet he charm'd th'
attentive Ear.

l. 278. aweful.

l. 283. woe's.

l. 297. Studds.

l. 329. Catharine's.

l. 345. And held the Golden Watch, the Ruby-Rings.

l. 357. the Lady's.

l. 381. On Pride that governs, Pleasure that will grow.

l. 394. Bawbles.

l. 412. Catharine.

l. 428. the Joy.

l. 431. that wounds.

l. 432. Who miss one Comfort that.

l. 434. He felt with many.

l. 436. an old Neighbour.

l. 443. he knew.

l. 444. More skilful none, and skill'd like him, but few.

instead of 458-60:

By the new Light, to the new Way
direct;—

"Mine now are Faith and Hope," he
said; "Adieu!

I fear to lose them, in a way so
new."

instead of ll. 467-8:

His honest Fame he yet retain'd; no
more,

His wife was buried, and his
Children poor;

l. 473. And just, as kind.

l. 474. And then for Comforts.

l. 477. with him to live.

l. 478. Who, while he feeds me, is as loath to give.

l. 480. guages.

l. 485. to mourn my Lot is vain.

l. 486. Mine it is not to choose but to sustain.

l. 495. awful.

l. 499. that suppliant Look.

l. 500. Nor that pure Faith, that gave it Force are there.

l. 510. Intic'd.

l. 565. An House.

l. 573. And thus he rose, but tried.

instead of ll. 594-6:

And all was Terror, till all Hope
was gone;

Was silent Terror, where that Hope
grew weak,

Look'd on the Sick, and was
asham'd to speak.

- l. 601. So sure.
- l. 654. Glib.
- l. 664. Glib.
- l. 670. With Luck and Leah.
- l. 675. "Nay, but," he said "and dare you.
- l. 700. Judgement.
- l. 715. Woe.
- l. 825. Ailes.
- l. 848. sly Dissenters.
- l. 863. An whoreson Cough.
- l. 882. Gypsies.
- l. 891. Aile.
- l. 921. antient.
- l. 966. while Parents them and us forsake.

THE BIRTH OF FLATTERY. Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

- l. 1. Spencer.
- l. 15. Siren.
- l. 21. An hireling.
- l. 50. Dissentions.
- l. 52. Say what Success has one Projection crown'd?
- l. 60. Ingulph'st.
- l. 65. worthless Arts.
- l. 111. nuptual.
- l. 125. repay'd.
- l. 191. antient.
- l. 213. controul.
- l. 304. *Gorze*.
- l. 317. Tenniers.
- l. 333. Mein.
- l. 344. that well their Worth she knew.
- l. 347. While all Disgrace attend.

SIR EUSTACE GREY. Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

- l. 23. Will sometimes point.
- l. 24. And will with.

- l. 26. Will veil.
 - l. 37. Well! I am calm.
 - l. 38. woe.
 - l. 58. an.
 - l. 171. Dæmons.
 - l. 234. Travellers.
 - Note 3, l. 5. Intended to cast ridicule on any religious persuasion.
 - l. 8. enthusiastical.
- The notes appear as footnotes in the first edition.*

THE HALL OF JUSTICE. Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

Part I.

- l. 11. forbad.
- l. 36. woe.
- l. 41. on Want and Error.

WOMAN! Variants in edition of 1807 (first edition).

- l. 1. Africk's.
- l. 4. Dæmons.

THE BOROUGH. Variants in the edition of 1810 (first edition).

Preface.

- p. **266**, l. 9. may fairly be.
- l. 24. values.
- p. **268**, l. 16. connections.
- p. **269**, l. 12. an hope.
- p. **271**, l. 5, enquiries.
- p. **273**, l. 13, enquiry.
- ib.* l. 28. controul.
- p. **274**, l. 35. attornies.
- p. **275**, l. 2. license.
- ib.* l. 39. set down.
- p. **276**, l. 7. give us more favourable view.
- p. **277**, l. 33. an hundred.

p. [278](#), l. 2. an happier.

ib. l. 31. immoveable.

p. [279](#), l. 14. *after* insane,: and why the visions of his distempered brain should be of so horrible a nature.

p. [282](#), l. 7. mottos.

Letter 1.

l. 85. wreathes.

l. 153. an House.

l. 156. tipling.

l. 175. stoney Beech.

l. 195. o'ershrowd.

l. 290. rimpling.

Letter 2.

Synopsis, l. 2. Columns and Aysles;

l. 8. Grief in the survivor.

l. 29. Yet Gothic all.

l. 34. aisle.

l. 40. grey.

l. 57. greys.

l. 62. grey.

l. 76. The stoney Tower as grey.

l. 114. Woe.

l. 127. teiz'd.

Letter 3.

l. 46. inlists.

l. 62. antient.

l. 105. charardes.

l. 127. antient.

l. 132. aisle ... aisle.

l. 137. woe.

instead of ll. 158-159:

Mamma approv'd a safe contented
guest
And Miss a Friend to back a small
request;
instead of ll. 202-205:

Oh! had he learn'd to make the Wig
he wears,
To throw the Shuttle or command
the Sheers,
Or the strong Boar-skin for the
Saddle shap'd,
What pangs, what terrors had the
Man escap'd.

l. 214. woeful.

Letter 4.

Synopsis, l. 3. Swedenbugeans.

ll. 5, 9. Armenian.

l. 12. extatic.

l. 21. doat, extacies.

l. 70. tye.

l. 75. Dioclecian.

l. 120. antient.

l. 129. antient.

l. 168. Swedenborgeans.

l. 184. Phaëtons.

l. 191. chastizing.

l. 205. rev'rendly.

l. 230. bye-word.

l. 255. antient.

instead of ll. 258-259:

True *Independants*: while they
Calvin hate,
They heed as little what *Socinians*
state;

They judge *Arminians Antinomians*
stray
Nor *England's Church*, nor Church
on Earth obey;

- l. 260. But for themselves.
- l. 264. inlists.
- l. 267. Westley.
- l. 299. an helping hand.
- l. 338. ingulph'd.
- l. 389. antient, Westley.
- l. 419. naught.
- l. 477. stoney.
- l. 487. stoney-cold.
- l. 500. awful.
- l. 503. woe.

Letter 5.

- l. 92. for then he's most.
- l. 113. burrs.
- instead of* ll. 167-170:

In fact the Fisher was amaz'd; as
soon
Could he have judg'd Gold issued
from the Moon;
But being taught, he griev'd with
ail his heart,
For lack of knowledge in this
precious art;

Letter 6.

- l. 52. Socilitor.
- l. 64. the far-resounding.
- l. 75. buz.
- l. 108. controul.
- l. 114. Whose Sons aspiring, for Professions call.

- l. 292. dosing.
- l. 295. if he try.
- l. 298. strait.
- l. 306. doat.
- l. 335. He'd balked.

Letter 7.

Synopsis, l. 6. Empiricks.

l. 8. Empirick.

instead of ll. 1-4:

From Law to Physic stepping at
our ease,
We find a way to finish—by
degrees;
Forgive the quibble, and in graver
style,
We'll sing of those with whom we
seldom smile.

l. 15. an hope.

l. 19. Physician.

instead of l. 59:

So Merit suffers, while a Fortune's
made.

l. 64. the licenc'd Tribe.

l. 79. Coblers.

l. 80. Lyars.

l. 96. their Patents.

l. 111. Schirrus.

l. 124. Empirick's.

l. 147. fewel.

l. 156. intreats.

l. 257. controul.

l. 262. bar'd

l. 268. Ev'n. some who'd known him.

l. 271. neither reason.

Letter 8.

Synopsis, l. 5. *After* 'The Weaver an Entomologist, etc.
insert 'Hunting Butterflies,' etc.

- l. 18. an high.
- l. 27. expence.
- l. 30. Th' estimate that's made.
- l. 216. controul

Letter 9.

- l. 17. an Hall.
- l. 27. Sheers.
- l. 64. Where.
- l. 152. Expence.
- l. 154. favouring Gale.
- l. 176. this Envy.
- l. 197. on the Waters float.
- l. 198. Note.
- l. 216. Shores to Shores.

Letter 10.

Synopsis, l. 5. Petulences.

- l. 121. an happier few.
- l. 123. not fretful.
- l. 129. antient.

instead of ll. 165-6:

Against their Nature they might
show their Skill
With small Success, who're Maids
against their will.

- l. 167. bashful muse.
- l. 253, 258. Aye.
- l. 293. Gulph.
- l. 353. gregareous.
- l. 382. tye.

l. 385. Himself to strengthen, or himself to shun;

Letter 11.

l. 55. Ribbands.

l. 78. the work of Treason done.

instead of ll. 79-80:

Have, like the *Guillotine*, the royal
Neck
Parted in twain—the Figure is a
Wreck;

l. 102. antient.

l. 136. Styes.

l. 143. Basons.

l. 185. antient.

l. 286. Controul.

l. 287. an Home.

Letter 12.

Synopsis, l. 6. An Heroine;

l. 8. Frederic.

l. 21. an House.

l. 54. an Hero's.

l. 65. Havock.

l. 75. Woe.

l. 87. Wane.

l. 94. in the appointed Course.

l. 105. pityful.

l. 136. Woe.

l. 148. Woe.

l. 185. teiz'd.

l. 195. Taylor's.

l. 202. Frederic.

instead of ll. 205-6:

It was not quite within the
Merchant's line.

To think of College, but the Boy
would shine.

l. 207. he'd prosper, none could doubt.

l. 214. Frederic.

l. 222. Frederic.

l. 236. authoriz'd:

between ll. 266-7:

Vice, dreadful habit! when assum'd
so long,

Becomes at length inveterately
strong;

As more indulg'd it gains the
Strength we lose,

Maintains its Conquests and
extends its Views;

Till the whole Soul submitting to
its Chains,

It takes possession, and for ever
reigns.

l. 282. an Home.

l. 298. an Home.

l. 330. an Hoy.

l. 332. Frederic.

l. 339. Enquiries.

l. 341. Frederic.

l. 347. Enquiry.

l. 356. an happier.

l. 369. Woe.

Letter 13.

Instead of ll. 5-6:

He wore his Coat till every Thread
was bare,

And fed his Body with the meanest
Fare;

l. 13. Crumbs.

l. 25. favorite.

instead of ll. 27-28:

Haunts have been trac'd to which
he nightly went,
And serious Sums in private
Pleasures spent;

l. 78. Controul.

l. 107. controul.

l. 121. Detracter.

l. 135. Enquiry.

instead of l. 173:

Small is his private Room: you'd
find him there.

l. 188. an herd.

instead of ll. 191-2:

You'd meet Sir Denys in a morning
Ride,
And be convinced he'd not a spark
of Pride;

l. 202. Equipt.

l. 203. an Horse.

l. 207. An handsome Youth *Sir Denys*; and an Horse.

l. 214. Aye.

l. 226. cloath'd.

l. 244. controul'd.

l. 275. try'd.

l. 296. t' asswage.

Letter 14.

Synopsis, l. 6. Connections.

l. 17. Enquiry.

l. 31. Expences.
l. 49. try'd.
l. 58. antient.
l. 120. this final Hoard.
instead of l. 138:

Those whom he'd daily shaken by
the hand.

l. 145. Billedoux.
l. 148. an useful.
instead of l. 165:

He'll even read to learn the Ill
they've done.

l. 169. he'll dispose the Mind.
l. 212. antient.

Letter 15.

l. 19. and Poems.
l. 93. an Heart so fond, an Hand so priz'd;
l. 108. straiter.
l. 152. try'd.
l. 216. antient.

Letter 16.

Synopsis, l. 11. Dolly.
l. 86. Vallies.
l. 90. forebore.
l. 127. 'twould not believe its Eyes.
l. 128. 'Twould sadly glide.
l. 132. an huge.
l. 133. an huge.
l. 156. Breakfasts.
l. 159. teiz'd.
l. 183. railing.
l. 209. She held him babish and his Captives blind.

instead of ll. 211-213:

Her Sexe's Pattern, without
Thoughts of Sex;
Our timid Girls and Lovers half
afraid,
All shunn'd the Speeches of the
frank old maid.

l. 230. antient.

Letter 17.

l. 7. Woe.
l. 17. all have.
l. 41. inclose.
l. 48. has never heard.
l. 78. Woe.
l. 113. bruize.
l. 138. an House.
l. 208. Tyes.
l. 248. place in view.
l. 261. well-dry'd.
l. 277. do the work.

Letter 18.

Synopsis, l. 8. Bye-Ways.
l. 12. antient.
l. 24. antient.
l. 94. antient.
l. 130. Woe.
l. 199. try'd.
l. 218. 'till he's run his Race.
l. 222. antient.
instead of l. 264:

Which that low Paling, form'd of
Wreck, surround;

- l. 270. relicks.
- l. 318. an Handmaid.
- l. 327. Virtue's.
- l. 332. an Humourist.
- l. 336. an Home.
- l. 365. antient.
- l. 369. contain.
- l. 389. fry'd.

Notes. *These appear in the first edition as footnotes.*

Letter 19.

Instead of ll. 18-19:

This book-taught Man, with ready
mind receiv'd
More than Church commanded or
believ'd;

- l. 64. their very Look's a charm.
- l. 94. try'd.
- l. 110. Abash'd.
- l. 131. an hearing.
- l. 196. Aisle.
- l. 259. cry'd.
- l. 269. *not in inverted commas.*
- l. 299. enquir'd.

Letter 20.

Synopsis, l. 6. An Husband.

- l. 7. The Men's.
- l. 34. *Darnly-Cottages.*
- l. 59. Chateux.
- l. 97. an Hound.
- l. 101. Woe.
- l. 112. Woe.
- l. 135. teiz'd.
- l. 182. an Hovel's.

l. 196. affrighten'd.
instead of ll. 262-3:

I would all Memory of his Fate
were fled
He was our second Child, our
darling *Ned*;

l. 269. Slight.

l. 283. Tyger.

l. 299. might be proud.

Notes. *These appear in the first edition as footnotes.*

Note 1. l. 1. Southerwood.

l. 2. *Artimisia*.

Note 2. l. 2. tenor.

l. 6. teasing.

l. 10. teased.

Letter 21.

l. 51. aukward.

l. 86. antient.

l. 110. thine Heart.

l. 122. (thou had'st them).

l. 183. laid.

l. 184. blest the dying Maid.

l. 211. Pedlar's.

l. 214. Entitled.

l. 218. stedfast.

l. 231. lead.

instead of l. 263:

Oh! please your Rev'rence,
rev'rendly I said.

l. 289. woe.

Note. *This does not appear in the first edition.*

Letter 22.

Synopsis, l. 6. insipient.
l. 30. an happy Time.
l. 54. controul.
l. 69. enquir'd.
l. 165. an helping Hand.
l. 228. Dæmons.
l. 259. could'nt.
l. 361. Dæmons.

Letter 23.

Synopsis, l. 6. an Highwayman.
l. 78. succeed.
l. 89. The Folly diverse.
l. 102. an Home.
l. 105. try'd.
l. 165. enquiries.
l. 184. Woe.
l. 219. Controul.
l. 308. brouzes.

Letter 24.

l. 27. an heavy Load.
l. 104. Strife on both sides.
l. 129. an heavy Eye.
l. 188. All Hardship.
l. 250. illude the Burdens.
instead of l. 276:

Of Money wasted! when no taste
remain.

l. 290. controuls.
l. 310. Dependants.
l. 334. bear.
l. 335. slily.
l. 339, footnote, *not in first edition*.
l. 380. savory.

l. 387. an high degree.

END OF VOL. I.

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Transcriber's Note:

Regarding the set of lines beginning with

"When shall I rest—O! let me,
Night, [besiege]

440

Thy drowsy Ear with wailing,
but be thou
[Tenacious] of my Guilt;

due to a page break it could not be said from the layout whether a new stanza began before; however, as the last line before that line ends in an em-dash, and since that usually indicates the end of a stanza, the line quoted above was treated as the beginning of a new stanza.

The header "POEMS" which is followed by a dedication, is not in the original Table of Contents, but from the content of the dedication it is clear that all following poems until The Borough are covered by this dedication, and are therefore sections to this part.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK GEORGE
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